

Predicting the Past

Predicting the Past

Counterfactual History from Napoleon
to the Present

VOLUME 2

By

Gavriel D. Rosenfeld



DE GRUYTER
OLDENBOURG

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Introduction

Following the American and French revolutions, counterfactual history began to evolve in new ways. Volume 2 of *Predicting the Past* picks up the story in its opening chapter, “From Napoleon to Bismarck: Nationalistic Counterfactuals in the 19th Century.” This chapter examines how the forces of nationalism changed how Europeans speculated about the era’s major events. As nations such as France, Britain, and Germany were busy forging their national identities, historians began to craft master narratives for their respective national pasts. In doing so, the greatest historians of the age—François Guizot and Jules Michelet in France; Thomas Macaulay and Henry Thomas Buckle in Britain; and Leopold von Ranke and Heinrich von Treitschke in Germany—argued that history inevitably worked out for the best by counterfactually depicting how it might have turned out worse. French historians valorized the principle of liberty by showing how their country could have remained mired in authoritarianism. British historians validated parliamentary rule by showing how their island home might have remained wedded to absolutist monarchy. And German historians celebrated national unity by imagining their *Vaterland* remaining hampered by division.

Chapter 2, “Determinism and Its Discontents: Controversy over Counterfactuals, 1815–1914,” analyzes how counterfactual history gradually migrated from the realm of academic scholarship into the western cultural mainstream. During this period, writers, philosophers, and historians for the first time recognized the existence of historical speculation as an independent phenomenon by contrasting it with, and seeing it as an antidote to, deterministic thinking. While deterministic thinkers, such as Thomas Carlyle, G.W.F. Hegel, Karl Marx, and Friedrich Engels, saw little point in speculating about the past, anti-deterministic theorists, such as Isaac Disraeli, Jacob Burckhardt, Friedrich Nietzsche, and Max Weber, justified doing so in new ways. Away from the ivory tower, western writers began to track the proliferation of what came to be known as “might-have-beens” in contemporary works of journalism, fiction, and poetry. In so doing, they introduced counterfactual thinking to a mass audience and sparked the first public debate about its merits and drawbacks.

Chapter 3, “Counterfactuals and the Civil War: Sectional Speculation in the United States, 1861–1914,” examines how national division boosted the use of “what ifs” in American life. In the years leading up to the war, and in the half-century following its conclusion, politicians, journalists, clergymen, and historians in the North and South bitterly debated whether the Civil War was an “irrepressible conflict” or one that could have been avoided. Whether tracing

the war's origins to the constitutional debates of the 1780s or the Southern attack on Fort Sumter in 1861, supporters of the Union and the Confederacy, such as Abraham Lincoln, Stephen Douglas, Charles Sumner, Frederick Douglass, William Lloyd Garrison, Jefferson Davis, and Alexander Stephens, used "what ifs" to make sense of the events that led to sectional conflict. Both sides notably imagined counterfactual nightmares and fantasies about the Confederates winning the war, a prospect that unrepentant Confederates later made central to the "Lost Cause" myth. In the process, counterfactuals became increasingly present in American culture.

Chapter 4, "What Ifs' and World War I: Trauma and Speculation in the Interwar Era," analyzes how the First World War further stimulated the use of counterfactuals. Between 1914 and the early 1930s, monarchs, diplomats, journalists, and historians in Europe and the United States speculated about the war's complex origins and traumatic consequences. Whether hailing from the Triple Entente or the Central Powers, major figures like David Lloyd George, Raymond Poincaré, Kaiser Wilhelm II, Theobald von Bethmann-Hollweg, Tsar Nicholas II, Sergey Sazonov, Franz Conrad von Hötzendorf, and Leopold Graf Berchtold used "what ifs" to ascertain who was to blame for the war and determine whether it was avoidable. Predictably, they accused their enemies of failing to prevent the conflict and depicted their own behavior as unavoidable. The frequent use of counterfactuals to debate guilt for the war boosted their popularity in western popular culture and led a range of commentators, including J.B. Bury, Sidney Low, and John Buchan, to become increasingly self-reflexive about the merits and drawbacks of historical speculation. Many of them contended that the rupture caused by the Great War encouraged people to wonder "what if" by highlighting the role of chance in human affairs.

Chapter 5, "Ideological Counterfactuals: Communist, Nazi, and Liberal 'What Ifs,' 1914–1945," examines how the rise of extremist political ideologies shaped historical speculation in the years between World War I and World War II. During this period, Soviet leaders, such as Vladimir Lenin and Joseph Stalin, as well as Nazi leaders, such as Adolf Hitler and Joseph Goebbels, used deterministic counterfactuals to validate their respective worldviews. On multiple occasions, they argued that if they had not acted in ruthless fashion to seize power, history would have taken a nightmarish turn. By contrast, liberal historians, such as Allan Nevins, Charles Oman, Raymond Aron, Marc Bloch, Bertrand Russell, Bernard Berenson, and Sidney Hook, used "what ifs" to undermine deterministic claims to certainty by emphasizing the role of contingency in historical events. From their perspective, counterfactual history was a liberal antidote to interwar totalitarianism.

Chapter 6, "Cultural Counterfactuals (I): The Rise of Alternate History, 1815–1945," discusses how "what ifs" began to find expression in works of

literature. Alternate history was born in mid-nineteenth century France, when the writers Louis-Napoléon Geoffroy-Château, Joseph Méry, and Charles Renouvier published a series of novels about the legacy of Napoleon Bonaparte. Several decades later, British and American writers, such as G.M. Trevelyan, Edward Everett Hale, Edward Page Mitchell, Castello Holford, F. P. Williams, and Charles Felton Pidgin, began to dominate the genre of alternate history, using “what ifs” to comment on topics ranging from geopolitics to social reform. After World War I, alternate histories were produced by an increasingly diverse array of European writers, such as Gaston Homsy, Jacques Rigaut, Kurt Tucholsky, Arthur Conan Doyle, and J.C. Squire, but they were all linked by the fantasy of avoiding World War I. In the period leading up to the outbreak of World War II, finally, alternate histories declined in number, but those that appeared—by writers such as L. Sprague de Camp, Nat Schachner, and Alfred Bester—expressed looming anxieties about fascism. On balance, alternate history between the years 1815 and 1945 evolved into a distinct literary genre but remained largely a curiosity.

Chapter 7, “Cold War What Ifs: The East-West Conflict and the New Counterfactuals, 1945–1989,” explains how the Cold War shaped how Americans and Britons wondered “what if?” During this period, Anglo-American historians divided into competing orthodox and revisionist camps and used counterfactuals to shore up their respective arguments. The former, composed of scholars like Louis J. Halle, John Snell, Herbert Feis, and Arthur Schlesinger, Jr., argued that the Cold War was inevitable, while the latter, comprised of scholars like Harry Elmer Barnes, William Henry Chamberlin, Denna F. Fleming, and Gar Alperovitz, insisted it was avoidable. The use of counterfactuals in this debate once again led historians to reflect on the utility of wondering “what if?” During the 1950s, scholars such as G. M. Trevelyan, Herbert Butterfield, Mary Collins Swabey, Isaiah Berlin, Arnold Toynbee, Edward Hallett Carr, and Hugh R. Trevor-Roper debated the relationship between counterfactualism and determinism. A decade later, historians such as Alfred H. Conrad, John R. Meyer, Robert Fogel, Stanley Engerman, Fritz Redlich, and Eugene Genovese debated the pros and cons of “cliometric” counterfactuals. These debates made the new concept of “counterfactual history” the preferred signifier for historical speculation.

Chapter 8, “Cultural Counterfactuals (II): The Breakthrough of Alternate History, 1945–1989,” examines why the quantity of alternate histories significantly increased in western culture during the Cold War. Especially in the English-speaking world, but also in other countries, cultural counterfactuals appeared in the form of novels, short stories, plays, films, radio programs, television shows, and comic books. Some of the genre’s classic works appeared during this period, such as Ward Moore’s *Bring the Jubilee* (1953), about the

South winning the Civil War; Philip K. Dick's *The Man in the High Castle* (1962), about Nazi Germany triumphing in World War II; and Kingsley Amis's *The Alteration* (1976), about England remaining Catholic in the early sixteenth century. These texts and many others focused on a range of topics, but they tended to concentrate on World War II, the Civil War, and the American Revolution. In so doing, the narratives revealed how wondering "what if?" about the past reflected shifts in historical memory. Finally, the growing prominence of cultural counterfactuals stimulated a larger discussion about how literary "what ifs" related to other literary genres, such as science fiction. By the end of this period, critics had embraced the new concept of "alternate history."

Chapter 9, "Into the Mainstream: Canonizing Counterfactuals, 1989-Present," describes the unprecedented explosion of counterfactuals in western life since the end of the Cold War. During this period, the production of analytical and cultural counterfactuals surged to new heights, reaching millions of readers and viewers worldwide. Academic historians published scores of counterfactual anthologies, such as Niall Ferguson's popular volume *Virtual History* (1997) and Robert Cowley's collection *What If?* (1999). For the first time, academic historians published monographs entirely devoted to historical speculation, such as Richard Ned Lebow's *Archduke Franz Ferdinand Lives!* (2014) and Jeffrey Gurock's *The Holocaust Averted: An Alternate History of American Jewry* (2015). Numerous alternate histories also appeared during this period, including bestselling novels such as Robert Harris' *Fatherland* (1992) and streaming television series such as HBO's *Watchmen* (2019). The growing popularity of counterfactual history, in turn, led growing numbers of scholars to analyze its origins in the form of journal articles, academic conferences, and even manifestoes. All these trends helped canonize counterfactual history as a legitimate enterprise and move it from the margins to the mainstream of western life.

The conclusion of *Predicting the Past* sums up the book's larger argument and forecasts possible future trends. Building on the book's survey of three thousand years of "what ifs," the conclusion presents a general theory of counterfactualism that seeks to explain why people in the western world have speculated about the past. It outlines the varied factors that have consistently prompted counterfactual thought over time and identifies a "dialectic of counterfactualism" that explains why wondering "what if" continues to generate controversy. The conclusion goes on to examine whether historical speculation is largely a western phenomenon or is just as common in the non-western world. Finally, it hazards some predictions about how counterfactual history may evolve in the future.

From Napoleon to Bismarck: Nationalistic Counterfactuals in the 19th Century

What would have been the consequences for Europe if Napoleon [III] had triumphed [in the Franco-Prussian War] and Germany ... had been returned to its ... weakened condition of fragmentation? [Such a victory] would have benefited ... [France's militarists] and ... the absolutist-clerical faction, which felt threatened by ... liberal [forces]... and sought to restore [the country's]... inner glory through a foreign victory over a Protestant power.¹ (Heinrich von Sybel 1874)

With the dawn of the nineteenth century, counterfactual thinking was increasingly shaped by the forces of nationalism. The eruption of the Napoleonic Wars (1800–1815) and the depredations of the *Grande Armée* across Europe sparked the awakening of national consciousness among the peoples that experienced French invasion and occupation. After Napoleon's defeat, the return of conservative rule during the Era of Restoration (1815–48) sought to stifle nationalist passions, but they continued to simmer before exploding once more during the revolutions of 1848. Although the defeat of these revolutions marked a setback for some aspiring nations, others, most notably Germany, were able to forge unified nation-states in the decades that followed. Nationalism did not only influence the unfolding of European events, however, but shaped how Europeans speculated about them. As was shown by German historian Heinrich von Sybel's vision of Prussia losing its war against France in 1870, nationalist feeling led certain Germans to express gratitude about the present by imagining nightmares about the past.

Sybel's comment was especially significant for highlighting the important role of nineteenth-century historians in employing counterfactual reasoning. The era of nationalism was also the time when the modern historical profession came into being. As nations were busy determining their social composition, territorial borders, and political systems, they were forging distinct national identities. The process of identity formation was led by a wide range of cultural and intellectual figures, but historians played an important role in creating evocative stories that chronicled the origins, struggles, and successes of individual nations. Building upon the historical scholarship of the late Enlightenment, nineteenth-century historians worked assiduously to establish

the intellectual foundations of the modern historical profession, refining its approach to archival research, source analysis, and narrative representation.

As they were embracing these new practices, historians in different countries were developing special areas of focus. France, Great Britain, and Germany led the way. In each of these countries, major historians gained renown for generating master narratives about the national past. The narratives varied from country to country, but they all reflected broader intellectual trends. For one thing, the narratives were empirically minded, deeply researched, and highly detailed in orientation, in keeping with the historical profession's newly accepted standards. They were also deterministic in nature, drawing on one of the era's dominant intellectual trends to present the nation's historical development as preordained. They were also often teleological, depicting a specific goal or mission as the ultimate destination of the nation's history. Finally, they often embraced a secular version of theodical and providential thinking, portraying history's course—and all its attendant hardship—as working out for the best. In the process, the national narratives shared the era's deep faith in progress.

All these traits were visible in the histories produced in France, Britain, and Germany. The narratives of all three nations focused on the themes of nation building, state formation, and national identity. But they diverged in explaining their countries' respective paths to success. French historians argued that France had to suffer through the experience of revolutionary unrest and Napoleonic dictatorship to gain freedom. British historians argued that England had to endure centuries of civil strife between the nobility and monarchy to establish parliamentary rule. And German historians insisted that Germany had to overcome centuries of division in the Holy Roman Empire to achieve unity.

In producing these narratives, French, British, and German historians frequently used counterfactuals. Like scholars in earlier centuries, they did so to explain and judge the past. But their willingness to wonder "what if" was especially important given the growing professionalization of historical scholarship. Earlier writers, thinkers, and intellectuals could be excused for employing counterfactual reasoning in their work because the historical profession had not yet established "scientific" ground rules for analysis and interpretation. Nineteenth-century historians, by contrast, had less excuse for doing so, given their field's newfound methodological rigor. Significantly, they did so anyway. The greatest European historians of the era—Michelet in France, Macaulay in Britain, and Ranke in Germany—all wondered "what if?" on a regular basis. Their use of speculative reasoning should finally put to rest the canard that "real" historians only examine what "actually" happened in the past. The fact

that these historians used counterfactuals despite being deterministically minded should also put to rest the misconception that “what if” thinking has thrived only since the waning of deterministic modes of thought in western intellectual life.² In fact, nineteenth-century historians often used “what ifs” to bolster their deterministic narratives. In all these ways, modern historical scholarship relied upon, and promoted the use of, counterfactual thought in western intellectual life.

France

French counterfactuals reflected the turbulent course of nineteenth-century French history. Between the years 1800 and 1870, France experienced tremendous political upheaval as its citizens fought to determine their nation's form of government. In the early years of the French Revolution, the proponents of liberty initially triumphed over the supporters of authority. But with Napoleon Bonaparte's rise to power in 1799 and his eventual coronation as Emperor in 1804, France experienced the return of dictatorship. This setback for liberalism continued for another decade and a half after the Bourbon Restoration of 1814. But before long, French liberals once again made progress towards achieving their political goals by launching the Revolution of 1830—which brought about the reign of the “Bourgeois King” Louis Philippe—and the Revolution of 1848, which toppled the monarchy and reestablished republican rule. Unfortunately, the cause of liberalism experienced yet another crushing setback when the gains of the Revolution of 1848 were negated by the dictatorship of Napoleon III between the years 1852 and 1870. Ultimately, the dream of a fully republican system of government was only achieved after France's defeat by German forces in the Franco-Prussian War of 1870 and the creation of the Third Republic.

Throughout the nineteenth century, French historians vigorously debated how to assess these tumultuous events. Conservatives and liberals disagreed profoundly about the legacy of 1789 and what it revealed about the relative merits of authority and liberty. Conservatives argued that by challenging traditional authority, the revolutionary supporters of liberty had caused a calamity. Only by returning to the national traditions of monarchy, clergy, and nobility, they argued, could peace and tranquility be restored. By contrast, liberals insisted that by overthrowing traditional authority, the French Revolution had dramatically advanced the spread of liberty. Although they recognized that Napoleon's dictatorship represented a temporary defeat, they retained the teleological belief that French history was a story of progress that was destined

to expand liberty so long as the legacy of 1789 was safeguarded. Indeed, they believed that spreading liberty was France's national mission.

In advancing their arguments, conservatives and liberals both used “what ifs.” Conservatives employed a wide range of counterfactuals—from the providential to the polemical—to show why history had to occur as it did, to examine whether it could have been better, and to contemplate how it could have been worse. Whatever type of counterfactual they used, conservatives wondered “what if?” to justify restoring traditional forms of religious and political authority. Predictably, liberals took a different approach. While they also used counterfactuals to show how history could have been better or worse, they did so to foster the spread of liberty. The debate between conservatives and liberals about the legacy of 1789 both reflected and promoted the gradual emergence of counterfactual thought in nineteenth-century France. But the most important contribution was offered by Napoleon Bonaparte himself. By using countless “what ifs” in his multi-volume memoir *The Memorial of St. Helena* (1823), Napoleon brought historical speculation more fully into the French cultural mainstream.

The Revolution's Opponents: Conservatives and Traditional Authority

One of the most important conservatives to demand a return to traditional authority was the Catholic philosopher Joseph de Maistre (Figure 1.1). In his *Considerations on France*, written in the years 1796–97, de Maistre advanced the theodical argument that the revolution, for all its horrors, had been divinely ordained to punish and purify the French nation. De Maistre's point of departure was the Thermidorian Reaction of 1794, when the Jacobin architects of revolutionary terror—most notably Robespierre—were consumed by the same violence they had unleashed against their enemies. For de Maistre, this ironic development revealed that the “rascals” who led the revolution were merely its “simple instruments” and could not hinder its “overwhelming force.”³ As he put it, “men do not lead the revolution, it is the Revolution that uses men.”⁴ To emphasize this deterministic position, de Maistre counterfactually declared that “the first condition of an ordained revolution is that whatever could have prevented it does not exist.”⁵ Indeed, he speculated that if the revolutionaries had possessed any “prior design” to unleash the revolution, “it would not have succeeded” as they were never in control of events. The reason for this inevitable failure, de Maistre argued, was that the revolutionaries were up against the formidable forces of “Providence.” Declaring that “never [before] has the Divinity shown itself so clearly in any human event,” he

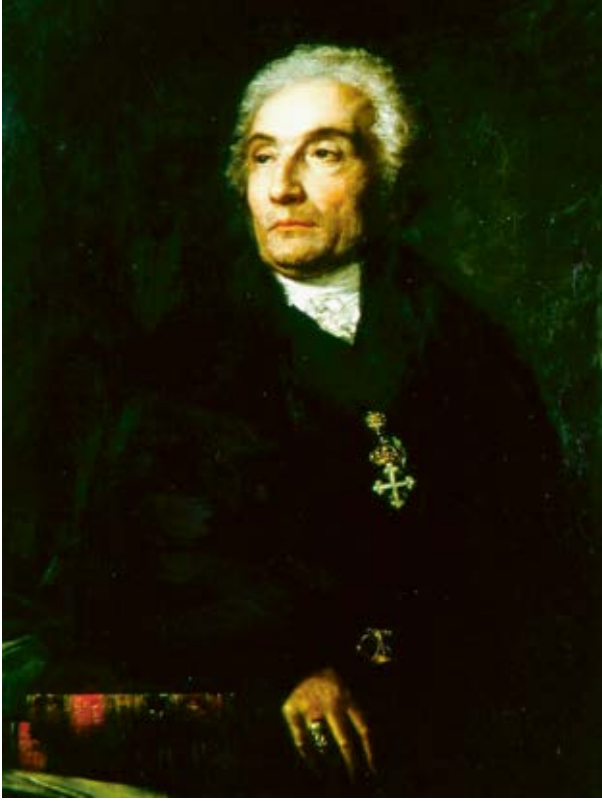


FIGURE 1.1 Joseph de Maistre used providential counterfactuals to argue that the terror of the French Revolution spared France the nightmare of a conservative counter-revolution, which would have perpetuated national division. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

explained that God had used the “vilest instruments” to punish France “for the sake of [its] regeneration.”⁶ France deserved punishment for several reasons: not only had the country been “dishonoured by more than a hundred thousand murders,” it had strayed from its sacred “mission” of serving “at the head of the religious system.”⁷ Thanks to these failures, de Maistre concluded, God was using “terrible means” to bring France “back to her mission” of leading a “moral revolution ... [in defense of]... the religious spirit.”⁸

De Maistre further employed silver lining and providential counterfactuals to demonstrate that the revolution’s violence was a precondition for national recovery. It was all for the best, he argued, that the Jacobins ended up killing each other during the Terror. For the alternative method of ending their

rule—a conservative counter-revolution—would have made things worse. “If force alone had ... restored the king to the throne,” de Maistre speculated, “there would have been no way of rendering justice” to the revolution’s victims. Since the “judges would ... have belonged to the injured class,” their verdicts “would have had an air of vengeance,” and to avoid this impression, the judges would have avoided a sweeping purge of the revolutionaries. The result, de Maistre feared, would have been an unsatisfactory form of “partial justice”: the “guiltiest would be [punished]... and all the rest would obtain pardon.”⁹ Even worse, from de Maistre’s perspective, was the likelihood that a violent counter-revolution, “far from curing the people, would confirm them in their errors and they would never forgive the power that snatched away their myths.” Finally, de Maistre speculated that a conservative rebellion, by dividing the nation, would have hastened “the conquest of France” by outside forces, “annihilated her influence,” and sparked “three centuries of massacres.”¹⁰

Fortunately, he explained, “Providence did not want” the country to suffer this fate, and so God pursued a “great purification” through the unlikely means of the Jacobins. Employing a deterministic counterfactual, de Maistre asserted that “once the revolutionary movement was established, only Jacobinism could have saved France and the monarchy.”¹¹ Only the “infernal genius of Robespierre,” by instilling a fanatical will to fight in the nation’s armed forces, could have protected the “integrity of France” from the armies of “conspiring Europe.” Finally, de Maistre argued that the “monsters ... of the revolution” ensured that the King would “reascend his throne” with his reputation intact. For by perpetrating unprecedented “horrors” against the nation’s enemies—horrors that the more “humane” King never would have perpetrated—the revolutionaries worked to the “advantage of the French monarchy.”¹²

De Maistre’s optimism about the Jacobins’ fall proved fleeting, however, for the rise of Napoleon in 1799 gave conservatives new reason to wish history had turned out otherwise. One of the main figures to articulate this pessimism was the Catholic writer François-René de Chateaubriand (Figure 1.2). In several texts, most notably *Portrait of Bonaparte* (1806), the writer used a series of polemical counterfactuals to condemn Napoleon’s disastrous impact on France. Calling him the “grand administrator ... [of] evil,” Chateaubriand declared that Napoleon had “done more injury to the human race, in the short space of ten years, than all the tyrants of Rome together,” adding that if “France [had] been a little while longer under Bonaparte, she would have become a cavern of robbers.”¹³ Chateaubriand also accused Napoleon of fatally mismanaging France’s war effort. In attempting to determine why “France ... [had] been invaded on every side” by hostile forces, the writer speculated that “if Bonaparte had wished to deliver us, without defence, to the allied powers ..., could he have



FIGURE 1.2 François-René Count de Chateaubriand used counterfactuals to endorse Christianity.
(Source: Wikimedia Commons)

acted otherwise?”¹⁴ Chateaubriand also sought to attribute Napoleon’s blood-thirsty militarism and his responsibility for “many massacres” to his identity as an “abominable ... foreigner,” speculating that he “would never have been so prodigal of French blood, if he had had one drop of it in his veins.”¹⁵

In view of the era’s upheaval, conservatives called for asserting authority over liberty. For Chateaubriand, liberty had been corrupted by the French Revolution’s violence. “[When] I saw the first head carried on a pike,” he recalled in his *Memoirs*, “[I realized that]... murder can never appear either [as] an object or ... proof of liberty.” This experience proved pivotal, for as he counterfactually mused, “the Revolution would have gained a supporter in me had it not been commenced by crimes.”¹⁶ Napoleon’s dictatorship further convinced Chateaubriand that the only thing that could restore the liberty that had

been stolen by “the most deceitful tyrant” was the restoration of the Bourbons, whom he praised with the counterfactual claim that “antiquity ... would not have failed to call divine a race, which ... reckoned in the space of nine centuries forty-three monarchs, among whom we do not find one single tyrant.”¹⁷ Chateaubriand further asserted that true liberty could only be restored with the aid of religion. Declaring that “the excesses of liberty ... lead to despotism,” he employed a missed opportunity counterfactual to argue that “liberty, which might have saved the world, will not work, because it has cut itself off from religion.”¹⁸ Nevertheless, Chateaubriand retained his faith, declaring that because “Christianity is perfect,” it was destined to “rise triumphant from the dreadful trial by which it has just been purified.”¹⁹

To further justify a return to religious authority, conservatives used counterfactuals to praise Christianity. In *The Genius of Christianity* (1802), Chateaubriand celebrated the “beauty and grandeur” of the Christian faith by listing its many contributions over the centuries to western life, from founding hospitals to establishing universities. In Chapter XIII, however, he adopted a more unconventional method by creating a medium form counterfactual that explored the question, “what would the present state of society be if Christianity had not appeared in the world?” In this account, Chateaubriand made clear that history would have been much worse. Pointing to the “wickedness” of the Roman Empire, he noted that only Christianity protected the citizenry from barbarian invasion. As he explained, Christianity provided people with far more religious “zeal ... [and] ardor” than polytheism, asking, “what priest of Jupiter would have gone forth to arrest Attila in his way? What pagan pontiff would have persuaded an Alaric to withdraw his troops from Rome?” Were it not for Christian intervention, he declared, “the barbarians ... would have destroyed all before them ... We should all be Turkish slaves, or something still worse.”²⁰ Not only had Christianity defended the west from foreign invasion, but it had also protected the western world’s intellectual heritage. Defending monks from the longstanding charge of being “indolent,” Chateaubriand said that “but for them, the chain of letters and the arts would have been irreparably broken.”²¹ “But for Christianity,” he concluded, “the wreck of society would have been complete,” adding “it is impossible to calculate how many ages would have been necessary for mankind to emerge from the ... gross barbarism in which they would have been engulfed.”²²

Around two decades later, de Maistre echoed many of Chateaubriand’s claims. In his 1819 book *The Pope*, de Maistre supported Chateaubriand’s effort to promote clerical authority by using “what ifs” to show how much worse history would have been without the papacy. To illustrate how the

Popes preserved morality during periods of barbarism, for example, de Maistre used a close call counterfactual to argue that “if, in the youth of the northern nations, the Popes had not had the means of alarming the passions of sovereigns, the princes ... would have ended by establishing ... divorce ... and perhaps even polygamy.” Moving forward in time, he noted that “[if] the unsubdued princes of the Middle Ages had been allowed to do as they pleased in this respect, the morals of the Pagan world would soon have re-appeared.”²³ Looking to foreign relations, de Maistre speculated that “the ascendancy of Islam would ... have been established [over Europe], if we had not been saved ... by the Popes, and by the Crusades of which they were the authors.”²⁴ He further hypothesized that “if the Popes had possessed the same authority over the eastern empire as over the west,” they “would they have expelled the Saracens [and]... Turks ... [and prevented]... the evils which these peoples ... inflicted on us.”²⁵

De Maistre added that greater clerical power would have improved the course of French history. As he explained in his *Letters on the Spanish Inquisition* (1815), France should have followed the precedent set by early modern Spain and ruthlessly extirpated heresy by force. Noting that Spain had avoided religious war by suppressing the “blasphemous texts of Luther,” de Maistre said that it was wrong to “inculcate Spain for an institution [i.e., the inquisition] which would have ... prevented such indescribable calamities had it been adopted by those countries that became the theaters of bloodshed.”²⁶ As he declared, “the inquisition would have certainly prevented the French Revolution.”²⁷ Given these missed opportunities, de Maistre advocated the creation of a universal Christian republic defined by restored clerical authority.²⁸ As he fantasized, “who knows what would have happened if ... theocracy, human policy, and science ... had remained in a state of undisturbed equilibrium?”²⁹ Not only could it have prevented France from suffering “terrible calamities,” it could have enabled the nation to extend its power. If the Papacy had acquired control of the east during the Middle Ages, de Maistre hypothesized, “the French people ... would [today] bear sway at Constantinople and in the Holy City ... the French language ... would be spoken in Palestine.”³⁰ For conservatives, in short, “what ifs” from the past could help safeguard France’s future.

The Revolution’s Heirs: Liberals and the March of Liberty

By contrast, French liberals believed the revolutionary era confirmed the value of liberty. In the decades after 1815, they embraced the teleological belief that the progressive spread of liberty was the defining feature of French history.³¹ In a wide range of studies published during the half-century after Napoleon’s fall,

they historicized the origins of liberty within, and outside of, France. Unlike their conservative opponents, however, they argued that religious authority had impeded liberty, while the French Revolution—and, to a degree, even the rule of Napoleon—had promoted it.

One of the main figures to advance this argument was the historian, statesman, and later Prime Minister (1847–48) François Guizot. Like many liberals, Guizot believed that the spread of freedom was inevitable, noting in 1852 that the “plan of Providence” had consistently steered French history ... onward to the union of monarchy and liberty.”³² Several decades earlier, in his *General History of Civilisation in Europe* (1828), Guizot historicized France’s embrace of liberty by chronicling its erratic evolution over the course of European history. To emphasize how freedom had been hindered in certain eras and promoted in others, Guizot frequently used counterfactuals. On the one hand, he regretted how medieval Christianity had inhibited the spread of liberty because of the religion’s tendency “to ally with power,” wistfully musing that “if religions had ... not given way to [this]... deceitful tendency, they would have discovered that their province was to strengthen liberty, in order morally to control it.”³³ Guizot also bemoaned the fact that the Italian Renaissance had failed to advance liberty, fantasizing that if only Italy’s “small republics” had “passed ... through a despotic centralization” process, such as France experienced, they “would have formed ... into one nation, and rendered [the country]... independent of the stranger.”³⁴ On the other hand, Guizot praised certain historical events for helping to spread liberty. Pointing to the Protestant Reformation, he speculated that even if the Papacy “had suddenly fallen into agreement with” Luther in the effort to “preserve [its]... position ... [as]... the government of the human mind ..., the religious revolution [would not] have ... stopped in its course ... [but]... would have continued [to] demand ... reform ... [and] liberty.”³⁵ Guizot also credited England with boosting the cause of freedom in the Glorious Revolution of 1688, writing that even “if William III had not ... come with his Hollanders to put an end to the quarrel between James II and the English people,... the whole of England ... was aroused at that epoch against James, and ... the Revolution of 1688 would have been effected under one form or another.”³⁶

As other scholars went on to show, however, pre-revolutionary France tragically decided to reject the English model and embraced authority. In his *History of the French Revolution* (1823–27), the historian and later statesman, Adolphe Thiers, wrote that France had gained renown in the seventeenth century thanks the rule of Louis XIV. But while the King had “rendered France powerful in Europe,” he “enslaved it at home.” Although French culture had thrived under Louis XIV’s rule—and although “Racine, Boileau, and

Molière ... produced masterpieces of ... genius”—it was not worth the loss of freedom. Employing a deterministic counterfactual, Thiers argued that “without [Louis XIV]..., Corneille, Pascal, [and] La Fontaine ... would not the less have adorned France.”³⁷ Moreover, history would have been better, since “reason would have had freer organs, and genius, emancipated from an absorbing contemplation of the grand monarch, would have risen to ... more useful, conceptions.”³⁸

Historian Jules Michelet took a similar position in his *Historical View of the French Revolution* (1847) by blaming centuries of clerical rule for stifling French liberty (Figure 1.3). Arguing that “for nearly five hundred years” conservative church doctrine had “caused every impediment to progress,” Michelet asserted that “Rabelais, Shakespeare, and Molière ... would have been far [greater geniuses]... had they not been condemned to the labor of shaking the old sacred block which they found in their path.”³⁹ Still, Michelet believed that authority had inevitably, if paradoxically, paved the way for liberty. In his *Introduction to World History* (1831), he used a silver lining counterfactual to express gratitude that medieval French Kings had subordinated the priests, nobles, and towns to their rule, speculating that “if the priest had ... ruled alone,... the feudal state would have given way to the sacerdotal demagoguery,” adding that “if the freedom of the towns had prevailed,... France, carpeted with republics, would never have become a nation.”⁴⁰ Worse still, the country would have been unable to bring liberty to the whole world through the French Revolution.

Like Michelet, many liberal scholars described the events of 1789 as more or less inevitable. Yet they emphasized that the spread of liberty was rocky and marked by missed opportunities for it to have been smoother. This was especially true of liberals who believed that France could have evolved into a stable constitutional monarchy after 1789 instead of descending into a radical republic. In his book *The Formation and Progress of the Tiers État, Or Third Estate in France* (1853), historian Augustin Thierry argued that the cause of liberty had enjoyed steady progress “from the twelfth to the eighteenth [centuries]” until the Third Estate’s growing “distrust” of the Crown in the years 1789–91 “prepared a fatal divorce between [them at precisely]... the point at which a last step ... would naturally have ... founded political liberty by the establishment of a new constitution.”⁴¹ Thierry’s regret that history did not follow its prescribed course was shared by the writer and statesman Alphonse de Lamartine, who in his *History of the Girondists* (1847) speculated that

if each of the parties ... had taken their virtue instead of their impulses as the rule of their actions, all these disasters which eventually crushed them, would have been saved to them and to their country. If the king had been firm and sagacious,



FIGURE 1.3 The liberal historian, Jules Michelet, condemned clerical rule in France for stifling liberty, arguing that without it, the country's "spirit of independence ... would not have been smothered." (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

if the clergy had been free from a longing for things temporal, and if the aristocracy had been good; if the people had been moderate,... the Revolution would have progressed, majestic and calm as a heavenly thought, through France, and thence through Europe."⁴²

Despite these missed opportunities, Lamartine nevertheless believed the revolution's progress was inevitable, arguing that the shortcomings of human beings were ultimately less decisive than "the will of the event itself," whose core idea was "divine" and unstoppable.⁴³ The historian François Mignet echoed this deterministic perspective in his *History of the French Revolution from 1789 to 1814* (1824), arguing that events had to happen as they did because human beings are unable to do what they later realize they should have done

to prevent them. As he wrote, "when a reform has become necessary and the moment for accomplishing it has arrived, nothing can prevent it ... Happy were it for men, could they then come to an understanding [of this]... But the annals of nations have not as yet presented any instance of such prudent sacrifice; those who should have made them have refused to do so."⁴⁴ So irresistible was the power of the events that produced [the revolution]," he noted, that "by no possibility could the face of things been otherwise."⁴⁵

Liberal historians not only believed that the revolution was inevitable but that it was crucial for the advance of freedom. Unlike conservatives, they excused the revolution's violence as a necessary means to an end. Arguing that "the Revolution would have perished if it had not turned aggressive," Michelet praised the Jacobins for taking "the offensive" and rejecting foreign criticism of their violent rule.⁴⁶ Noting how the National Assembly in 1789 was in a very "difficult position ... [between] the old royalty [and]... the royalty of the mob," he replied to British critics of the revolution by exclaiming, "What would you have done? Tell us, you ... sages of European aristocracy ... Sitting at your ease on the dead bodies of Ireland ..., have not your revolutions of interest cost more blood than our revolutions of ideas?"⁴⁷ Condemning British hypocrisy, Michelet declared: "England would have died, had she not found, from century to century, an exterior diversion for her interior evil: in the sixteenth and seventeenth, North America and the spoliation of Spain; in the eighteenth, the spoliation of France and the conquest of India."⁴⁸ Michelet even suggested that the revolution's violence should have gone further in eliminating the Old Regime. In describing the storming of the Bastille, he criticized the tentativeness of "the citizen class [which] trembled in the presence of the Revolution," noting that it "ought not to have ... recoiled in alarm from the ocean it had roused from its slumber,... [but] ought to have plunged into its bosom. Then the illusion of dread would have disappeared."⁴⁹

Michelet's colleague, the historian Edgar Quinet, took a similar position by wishing the French Revolution had purged Catholicism more thoroughly from French life. Convinced that the revolutionaries of 1789 had failed to note that Catholicism was "incompatible with liberty," Quinet argued that "if [they] had clearly seen [this]," they "might have eliminated that religion ... and opened up [a]... new era [by]... overturn[ing] the edifice of all tyranny."⁵⁰ Unfortunately, the Jacobins under Robespierre avoided a ruthless purge and merely tried to replace Catholicism with the cult of reason.⁵¹ Given that that the former "rested upon the mass of the nation," while the latter was restricted to a "tiny minority," Quinet said that it "would have been necessary" for Robespierre to "reconcile" the two religions with one another by somehow making it clear to the masses "that Catholicism had been a preparation for the worship of

the Supreme Being ... and was the crowning achievement of Catholicism.”⁵² Unfortunately, because Robespierre failed to see that “Catholicism could only have been vanquished by another form of Christianity,” the revolution missed the opportunity to “erode the old religion.”⁵³ As a result, the cause of liberty was fated to suffer further setbacks in the nineteenth century.

Napoleon Bonaparte: Liberty’s Foe or Friend?

Liberal historians also examined how Napoleon Bonaparte shaped the unfolding of liberty in France (Figure 1.4). Unlike their critical view of Catholicism, however, they were divided on the emperor’s historical legacy. Early commentators saw Napoleon’s rule as detrimental to the cause of liberty, but later ones came to view him more positively. This shift mirrored the evolution of France’s political system, which changed from a conservative to a more liberal monarchy between the years 1814 and 1830, and which enabled French liberals to view Napoleon with increasing admiration.⁵⁴ Liberal counterfactuals varied accordingly, with fantasy, nightmare, and stasis scenarios all coexisting with one another.

Among the early critics of Napoleon’s rule, the most vocal was Madame de Staël. In her *Considerations on the Principal Events of the French Revolution* (1818), she identified many missed opportunities to have prevented Napoleon’s rise to power. If only the oligarchic Directory “had formed a constitution” between 1794 and 1799, she noted, it could have stopped Napoleon and “been the light of the world” by helping “liberty ... be[come] triumphant.”⁵⁵ De Staël also blamed the French people for Napoleon’s long grip on power, saying “a great nation would not have borne [his]... despotism, if military glory had not incessantly animated ... the public mind.”⁵⁶ De Staël also used close call counterfactuals to voice relief that Napoleon’s role was not even worse. She praised England for standing up to Napoleon’s aggression, saying that without “the ascendancy of England,... there would not have remained ... a single corner of the earth in which a sufferer could have escaped from his tyranny.”⁵⁷ She also shuddered at the ramifications of continued Napoleonic military victories in Eastern Europe, writing that “if Bonaparte had succeeded in his expedition against Russia, there would not have been a single corner of Continental ground where one would have been sheltered from his power.”⁵⁸ Had he continued to triumph, she concluded, “[people] would have sought in vain to discover the intentions of Providence in human affairs.”⁵⁹

Napoleon’s fall, however, did not restore liberty in France but facilitated the country’s return to monarchy. While de Staël was grateful that the British halted Napoleon militarily, she lamented that they restored the Bourbons to power without ensuring basic liberties.⁶⁰ Directing her anger at a British audience, she



FIGURE 1.4 French liberals after 1815 differed in their assessment of Napoleon Bonaparte, initially fantasizing about ways that his dictatorial rule could have been prevented, but later defending it as indispensable for the spread of liberty. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

employed a substitution counterfactual and noted that if Louis XIV's armies had occupied England after the restoration of King Charles II in 1660, they "would have re-established the Catholic worship and suppressed parliaments ... Europe would have heard of nothing but the murder of Charles I, [and]... the excesses of the Puritans."⁶¹ In offering this nightmare scenario, de Staël accused the British of hypocritically refusing to support liberty in France despite their own historical record of doing so at home. As she noted, "if on the day after the death of Charles I, an Englishman ... had implored Heaven that there might never again be freedom in England,... [and] if so unthinking a prayer had been heard, England would not at this day serve as an example to the world."⁶² Invoking that legacy, de Staël urged the French to remember that they were a "chosen people" who understood that their "honour was freedom."⁶³

In contrast to de Staël, who wrote during the years of the Bourbon Restoration, liberal historians writing after France's July Revolution of 1830 described Napoleon's rule as necessary for advancing liberty. In his *History of the Consulate and the Empire of France Under Napoleon* (1837), Adolphe Thiers used deterministic counterfactuals to depict Napoleon's dictatorship as unavoidable (Figure 1.5). Noting that France's post-Jacobin governing body, the Directory, was so weak that any ordinary individual—even someone with far “less glory than [Napoleon]”—might have sufficed ... to seize the government,” Thiers justified Napoleon's coup on the eighteenth of Brumaire, saying “France ... might have perished” without the creation of one-man rule.⁶⁴ As he put it, “I love the Revolution because it is the regeneration of my country; but had not Napoleon saved it, it would have been ruined.”⁶⁵ Convinced that liberty was being providentially driven by the “spirit of the time,” Thiers confidently asserted that despite Napoleon's authoritarianism, his imperial constitution preserved enough freedom that it “might one day have become a representative monarchy.”⁶⁶ As a longtime supporter of constitutional monarchy who became Prime Minister to King Louis Philippe after the latter took power in the liberal revolution of 1830, Thiers confidently believed history was destined to unfold as it did. As he concluded, “our Constitution of 1830... would probably not have produced results sensibly different” from those that Napoleon's government would have produced had it survived.⁶⁷

Thiers amplified his stance by using aggrandization counterfactuals to praise Napoleon.⁶⁸ Noting that the “essential feature of [Napoleon's]... career” was the “absence of restraint,” Thiers argued that “[if] skill in politics depend[ed] solely on ... intelligence,... Napoleon would have surpassed the greatest statesmen that ever lived.” Thiers further praised Napoleon as a commander, arguing that “had not Hannibal existed, he would have been without an equal.”⁶⁹ Finally, Thiers patriotically praised the French people for contributing to Napoleon's greatness, saying “He was by his genius fitted for France, and France for him. What they have done together could not have been accomplished by the French army without him, nor by him without the French army.”⁷⁰

Despite this praise, other historians faulted Napoleon for missing opportunities to be a more successful ruler. Madame de Staël blamed his exaggerated sense of ambition, declaring that “had Bonaparte been satisfied with acting the proud part of a great general ... he would have soared in all the height of his genius ... But when he entertained the design of becoming an upstart king ... he exposed himself ... to ... mockery.”⁷¹ De Staël further claimed that Napoleon had erred in forcibly exporting French values abroad through military force, saying that if he had instituted “constitutional liberty [in] France,” his rule “would have acted gradually, but with certainty, on the rest of Europe.”



FIGURE 1.5 In his *History of the Consulate and the Empire of France Under Napoleon* (1837), Adolphe Thiers justified Napoleon's coup on the 18th of Brumaire, saying that without the creation of one-man rule, "France ... might have perished." (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

In the process, Napoleon "might have rendered France happy and free" and a "new impulse would have animated the civilized world."⁷² De Staël, however, doubted that Napoleon could have been anything but ambitious. Employing a leopard spot counterfactual, she observed that "it has often been said that [Napoleon] would have kept his place, if he had been moderate." "But ... from the moment that his soul [saw]... no grandeur except in despotism, it was ... impossible for him to do without continual wars."⁷³

Other liberal historians, finally, wished Napoleon had avoided the mistakes that ultimately led to his downfall. His biggest error, according to Thiers, was refusing to invade England in August of 1805 and instead deciding to launch a continental campaign. Thiers was unsure whether Napoleon "[would] have ... attained his object ... [if he] had been transported across to Dover" by his Navy,

but believed it unlikely “that [England]... would venture to hold out against the soldiers of Napoleon,” concluding that “[once] Napoleon [arrived] in London, England would have treated [for peace].”⁷⁴ Because this event never came to pass, however, Napoleon made the catastrophic decision to invade Russia. According to Mignet, “the emperor ought to have seen that this war [in the East] could not terminate as the others had done” and that “cold and famine” would determine his fate.⁷⁵ Finally, Thiers regretted that Napoleon made a final bid for power after escaping imprisonment at Elba, returning to France, and toppling the Bourbons from power. As Thiers wrote,

it would have been a hundred times better that the Bourbons had not been expelled,... as then Napoleon would not have counted in his life the fatal day of Waterloo,... nor would France have been plundered ... by ... foreigners. ... To have avoided such sad results, Napoleon should have remained at Elba [and been content to]... record ... his ... heroic actions.⁷⁶

In the end, however, Napoleon could not curb his ambition. As Thiers concluded, “If only control of ambition had shared that throne with genius,... France might have been guaranteed a sufficient measure of freedom.”⁷⁷

The Emperor’s “What Ifs”

Historians were not alone in speculating about the dramatic events of the Napoleonic era but were joined by Napoleon himself. After being exiled to the remote West African island of St. Helena in 1815, Napoleon had lots of time to reflect on how his life might have been different (Figure 1.6). His reflections became public knowledge when his memoirs, *The Memorial of St. Helena*, were published in 1823. Recorded and transcribed by the French aristocrat Emmanuel-Auguste-Dieudonné Comte de Las Cases, who stayed with Napoleon at his island prison for an entire year, the memoirs included hundreds of “what ifs.”⁷⁸ Some involved close calls, while others involved missed opportunities. Most reflected Napoleon’s belief that historical events were largely determined by chance. Predictably, Napoleon’s “what ifs” were far more subjective than the more measured counterfactuals of French historians. They mostly reflected his desire to rehabilitate his reputation in the wake of his ignominious fall from power. A good many of them, moreover, were highly fanciful and revealed that the former Emperor still suffered from delusions of grandeur.

Napoleon frequently used close call counterfactuals to wonder how his career might have unfolded differently. Were it not for chance events, he repeatedly noted, he never would have risen to greatness. For example,



FIGURE 1.6 As he reflected on his tumultuous career in his memoirs, Napoleon offered hundreds of counterfactual claims, ultimately concluding that historical events were largely determined by chance. (Source: "Napoleon's Exile on Saint Helena," by Franz Josef Sandman (1820). Wikimedia Commons)

Napoleon cited his father's early death before the age of forty and employed a fast-forward counterfactual to surmise that "if ... [he] had survived some time longer, his father would have been appointed deputy from the Corsican nobility to the Constituent Assembly." The result, Napoleon imagined, was that "I should have followed my father's footsteps and ... my career would have been ... lost." Napoleon also mused that "if I had been older at the time of the [French] Revolution, I should ... have been appointed deputy ... [and] should have shut myself out from the military service." "Thus again," he speculated, "my career would have been changed." Napoleon also pointed to the importance of his humble origins, saying "had my family been ... more distinguished, my rank of nobility ... would have ... proscribed me [and]... I could never have obtained confidence ... [to] command ... an army," let alone "arrive ... at the head of the Government."⁷⁹ These and other examples led Napoleon to exclaim with wonder: "on what trivial circumstances does human fate depend!"⁸⁰

While he expressed relief about averting close calls, Napoleon also voiced regret about missed opportunities. Most involved military events and geopolitical decisions. He speculated that he could have defeated the British in

Egypt in 1798, for example, if his trusted General, Jean-Baptiste Kléber, had not been assassinated by a Syrian rebel and replaced by the inferior commander Jean-François Menou.⁸¹ He could have kept the colony of St. Domingue (present-day Haiti) by depriving the rebels of their leaders.⁸² And he could have triumphed over Austria and Spain—not to mention won the Battle of Waterloo—had other circumstances been different.⁸³ Most of all, Napoleon regretted not triumphing over England and Russia. Recalling that he had prepared 200,000 troops for an attack on the British Isles in 1805, he speculated that “in four days I should have ... entered the English capital” and mused “if ... I had [only] invaded Ireland” first, “what would England have been today?” In mulling over how his Russian campaign would have turned out “if Moscow had not been burnt,” Napoleon insisted that he would have quartered his troops in the city through the winter until “the first appearance of fine weather.” Then, he declared, “I should have marched against the enemy [and]... beaten them; I should have been master of their empire.” Here, again, chance decreed otherwise. Lamenting that “my success depended upon a mere trifle,” Napoleon pointed to the role played by “snow and the winter” in his defeat, concluding, “The problems of Providence are insoluble!”⁸⁴

Napoleon also used medium form, additive effect counterfactuals to depict how French history would have been improved had he realized his goals. Had he “returned victorious and triumphant” from Moscow, he declared, “Paris would have become the capital of the Christian world.” Building on his Concordat with Pope Pius VII in the year 1801, Napoleon imagined that he would have continued to strip the Pope of his “temporal power” and keep him “near my person,” while “exalt[ing him]... beyond measure.”⁸⁵ In this manner, he fantasized, “I should have governed the religious as well as the political world ..., [just] as Constantine and Charlemagne had done.”⁸⁶ Napoleon further agreed with the claim that “if Heaven had allowed [him]... to reign sixty years, as it had Louis XIV, he would have left many grand monuments.” Comparing himself to Archimedes, Napoleon declared, “I should have done as much, wherever I could have found a point of support for my energy, my perseverance, and my budgets.” “Ancient Paris would have been sought for in vain; not a trace of it would have been left, and I should have changed the face of France,” making it “the envy of nations!”⁸⁷

French power would have been further boosted by other geopolitical achievements. Upon defeating and occupying England, Napoleon imagined he would have been greeted “not as a conqueror but as a liberator” and would have arranged a rapprochement between Britain and France.⁸⁸ He predicted that after promising to ensure “the prosperity of the English people,... the two nations, which had been such determined enemies, would have thenceforward

composed only one people.”⁸⁹ He would have then gone on to unite tens of millions of divided Europeans “into one nation” governed by a common “European system,” including “a European code, a European court of appeal,... money of the same value,... the same weights, the same measures, [and] the same laws.” Once he had made Europe “a common country,” Napoleon continued, it would finally be at peace, for he “would have proclaimed the immutability of boundaries” and mandated that “all future wars [be] purely *defensive*.” As he wistfully concluded, “How many ills that are now endured, and how many that are yet to be experienced, would not unhappy Europe have escaped!”⁹⁰

Napoleon fantasized about other parts of the globe beyond Europe. As far back as 1798–99, when he undertook his famous campaign in Egypt, Napoleon believed that seizing the territory from Britain and turning it into a French colony “would have ruined the British in America, in the Mediterranean, and even on the banks of the Ganges.” In pursuing this goal, however, Napoleon once again fell short. After clashing with Ottoman and British forces in 1798, he led 13,000 soldiers through Ottoman-held Palestine in early 1799, conquering Jaffa and aiming for Syria. But at the pivotal Battle of Acre between March and May of 1799, he was again defeated by chance (Figure 1.7). Alluding to the failure of French ships to push through British naval defenses and deliver needed supplies to Acre, he declared that “the most trivial circumstances ... [often] lead to the greatest events. The weakness of the captain of a frigate, who stood out to sea instead of forcing a passage into the harbour ... prevented the face of the world from being changed.” If only he could have conquered Acre, Napoleon mused,

the French army would have flown to Damascus and ... in a twinkling it would have been on the Euphrates;... nations were ... being shaken ... Who can calculate what ... might have been? I should have reached ... the Indies [and]... changed the face of the world.⁹¹

In the end, Napoleon’s grandest plans remained unrealized, but in his memoir’s conclusion, he used “what ifs” to cement his legacy. He briefly wondered whether he “ought to have died at Moscow, because at that time, his military glory had experienced no reverse and his political career was unexampled in the history of the world.”⁹² He also hypothesized that if he had “returned victorious from Moscow” and then “withdrawn myself mysteriously from the world,... it would have been said that I had been carried up to heaven, to take my place among the gods.”⁹³ Beyond entertaining these fantasies, Napoleon also considered nightmares. In wondering whether he should have held onto power as a tyrant after Waterloo and rallied the French people to defend the



FIGURE 1.7 Recalling how chance events kept him from triumphing at the Battle of Acre in 1799, Napoleon lamented how “the most trivial circumstances ... prevented the face of the world from being changed.” (Source: Thomas_Sutherland, “Defence of the Breach at St. Jean d’Acre May 8, 1799” (1815). Wikimedia Commons)

nation against an Allied incursion, Napoleon ultimately decided against it, saying it would have produced “scenes of horror” that would have “drowned my memory in the deluge of blood” and led him to be “viewed ... as a second Nero.”⁹⁴ In the end, Napoleon simply wished he could have passed on his legacy to his heir, the Prince Imperial (and future Napoleon II). After his son’s “constitutional reign commenced,” Napoleon imagined, “my leisure ... would have been devoted ... to visiting ... every corner of the empire ... and doing good ... by every means.” “These,” he exclaimed, “were among my reveries!!!”⁹⁵

Great Britain

While historians and other writers in France were divided about their recent past, their counterparts in Great Britain were more unified. The history of nineteenth-century Britain was much more stable than that of France. In the decades following Napoleon’s defeat at Waterloo, the British ruling elite pursued a policy of political reform, abolishing “rotten boroughs” and extending

the suffrage to eligible Britons. Thanks to the Reform Bill of 1832 and the abolition of the Corn Laws in 1846, Britain avoided the revolutionary upheaval experienced in much of Europe during the 1830s and 1840s. Great Britain's simultaneous acquisition of a global empire and its achievements in science, technology, and culture further confirmed the country's advancement and justified its population's growing faith in progress.

English historians expressed this optimism in a master narrative known as the "Whig interpretation of history."⁹⁶ Starting in the early nineteenth century, the country's leading historians began to portray British history as a linear story of progress.⁹⁷ Like their French counterparts, they viewed their nation's past from a teleological perspective defined by the inevitable unfolding of liberty, democracy, and prosperity. The Whig historians were determinists, who believed that their country's success had to happen as it did.⁹⁸ They were nationalists, who believed that England's historical record of accomplishment was second to none.⁹⁹ And they were presentists, who sought the roots of their country's contemporary success in the distant past. In numerous studies, they showed how, during the four centuries between the issuing of the Magna Carta in 1215 and the eruption of the Glorious Revolution in 1688, England's "ancient constitution," with its longstanding respect for civil liberty and the rule of law, evolved into a unique political system where the parliament and crown shared power.¹⁰⁰

The Whig historians advanced their view of the nation's past with abundant counterfactuals. Despite their deterministic mindset, they were more than willing to wonder "what if?" As committed presentists who wanted their work to serve a didactic agenda, they recognized that counterfactual reasoning would bolster the persuasiveness of their narratives.¹⁰¹ Whig historians were especially fond of employing close call counterfactuals. Given their gratitude for how history unfolded, they tended to explore gripping nightmare scenarios about how it might have turned out worse. By showing how England avoided succumbing to tyranny and embraced popular sovereignty, they made the case that real history had turned out for the best. In so doing, "what if" thinking became associated with national success and British historians developed a penchant for engaging in counterfactual thought.

Deferring Despotism: The Middle Ages

Whig historians traced the country's rise to dominance back to the Norman Conquest. Prior to William the Conqueror's arrival in 1066, E.A. Freeman noted in 1876, "feudal notions" were fragmenting the country and weakening England's sense of "national unity," but this dangerous trend was halted by the imposition of Norman rule. "Had there never been a time of foreign tyranny,"

he wrote, “we might have seen ... our native Kings growing into despots” and the “old rights” and freedoms “might have died out step by step, as they did in so many of the kindred lands.” Instead, by forcing the English to fight for their liberty, the Normans taught them to cherish it.¹⁰² Freeman also praised William the Conqueror for teaching England “to become a continental power,” speculating “had the Norman Conquest never happened,... we should have held a place in Europe ... [like] that which has been held by our kinsmen of the Scandinavian North,... cut off from the general course of European politics.” By contrast, Thomas Babington Macaulay stressed that, in the short term, the events of 1066 threatened England’s very existence (Figure 1.8). Noting how for a century after the Battle of Hastings, the French Kings of England, the Plantagenets, were busy consolidating their island possession into their powerful Kingdom, he noted that if they had

succeeded in uniting all France under their government, England would never have had an independent existence. Her princes, her lords, her prelates, would have been men differing in race and language from the artisans and the tillers of the earth. ... The noble language of Milton and Burke would have remained a rustic dialect ... [and] been contemptuously abandoned to the use of boors. No man of English extraction would have risen to eminence, except by becoming in speech and habits a Frenchman.

Fortunately, however, this never came to pass. Paradoxically enough, Macaulay explained, “England ... escape[d] from such calamities [thanks] to an event which her historians have generally represented as disastrous.”¹⁰³

That event was the failure of King John (r. 1199–1216) and his successors to impose absolutist rule on the country. Starting in the fateful year 1215 and lasting for around three centuries, England was consumed by a power struggle between its monarchs and its nobles. Following the death of his brother Richard the Lionheart in 1199, King John pursued a series of ill-advised policies that lost him possession of Normandy and sparked a noble rebellion known as the First Barons’ War (1215–1217). Its primary result was the proclamation of the Magna Carta in 1215, which limited royal power by enabling the nobles to give counsel to the King. According to Macaulay, England benefited from John’s ineptitude, for “had John inherited the great qualities of his father ... the House of Plantagenet must have risen to unrivalled ascendancy in Europe.”¹⁰⁴ Thankfully, the nobles’ pursuit of the “common benefit” ended up thwarting “the tyranny of a bad king” and helped fuse Normans and Englishmen into a single people.¹⁰⁵ Building on Macaulay’s claim, William Stubbs explained how England averted another brush with tyranny during the Second Barons’



FIGURE 1.8 In his *History of England*, Thomas Babington Macaulay contemplated the nightmare scenario that if the French Plantagenets had consolidated their rule in the 12th century, “England would never have had an independent existence.” (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

War (1262–65), when noble resistance to King Henry III prevented him from “creat[ing]... a lasting despotism.”¹⁰⁶ Stubbs drew a similar conclusion about the reign of Richard II (1377–99), who was deposed in the rebellion of 1399 after trying to impose his will on the nobles, writing that “if Richard had overcome them, England might have ... sunk like France into that gulf from which only revolution could deliver her.”¹⁰⁷ In the end, these medieval clashes confirmed the Whig historians’ theodical belief that while England’s “evil kings” were a “momentary curse,” they were a “lasting blessing.” As Freeman put it, “Had Richard and John and Henry been ... like [the beloved 13th century French monarch] Saint Lewis,... the ... people of England ... would never have seen the mightiest triumph of her freedom.”¹⁰⁸

Before they could fully realize their freedom, however, the English people had to endure further warfare, which further hampered their political development. During the Hundred Years War (1337–1453), England attempted to establish a continental empire and, in fact, registered famous victories, such as the triumph of Henry V (r. 1413–22) over French forces at Agincourt in 1415. But as Macaulay argued, the effort was not inspired by “enlightened policy” and thankfully failed; after all, he explained, England “now occupies in the history of mankind a place far more glorious than if she had ... acquired by the sword an ascendancy similar to that which formerly belonged to the Roman republic.”¹⁰⁹ The same was true during Wars of the Roses (1455–85), when the House of Lancaster (led by the weak King Henry VI) and House of York (led by the powerful Edward IV) fought each other to a stalemate, thereby preserving the country’s constitution from the absolutist threat. It was a close call, however, for as Stubbs noted, “if Henry VI and Edward IV had changed places [or]... if it had fallen to the strong unscrupulous masculine Yorkist to work the machinery of a waning constitutional life and to the weak incompetent Lancastrian to maintain the doctrine, or to anticipate the first impulses, of personal absolutism,” things would have been different.¹¹⁰

Redeeming Despotism: The Rule of Henry VIII

Absolutism became a dangerous new threat under Henry VIII (1509–47), but even his tyranny proved but a temporary impediment to liberty. While Whig historians acknowledged the despotic aspects of the King’s rule, they justified his actions as benefiting England’s long-term national interests. In chronicling the dramatic events surrounding Henry’s divorce from Catherine of Aragon and marriage to Anne Boleyn in 1533 and his ensuing break with the Papacy one year later, British scholars made clear that Henry VIII had committed many “arbitrary act[s],” murdering his enemies, sacking monasteries, and subverting the independence of parliament. At the same time, however, scholars such as Stubbs counterfactually justified them, declaring that it was “by these means [that Henry VIII]... carried the nation over a crisis in which it might have suffered worse evils.”¹¹¹

Whig historians largely validated the King’s fateful decision to break with Rome. J.A. Froude said that the King did not ask for a battle with Pope Clement VII and argued that his actions were solely caused by the lack of a male heir, speculating that “if his sons had lived to grow up around his throne, there is no reason to believe that the peace of his married life would have been interrupted.”¹¹² Froude and other Whig historians further justified Henry VIII’s autocratic policies, such as his Act of Supremacy (1534), which demanded



FIGURE 1.9 Henry Hallam justified King Henry VIII's seizure of Church property, saying that without it, the English clergy "would ... have retained their allegiance to Rome." (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

loyalty oaths, and his seizure of Church property, especially monasteries, around the same time. This measure was crucial, for as Henry Hallam speculated, "it is certain that a large majority of [the English clergy]... would ... have retained their allegiance to Rome" were it not for the fact that Henry had "broke[n their] power ... and humbled their spirit" (Figure 1.9).¹¹³ Hallam praised Henry's ensuing decision to give church lands to the nobles and thereby secure their loyalty as "providential," since it worked to the "advantage to our civil constitution [by] strengthening ... the territorial aristocracy," who would otherwise have found it hard in later years to "withstand the enormous prerogative of the crown."¹¹⁴ Moreover, England itself benefited, for as James Mackintosh noted, without the parliament's "concurrence," the "immense revolutions ... in property [and]... religion" that took place under Henry VIII "never could have been effected."¹¹⁵

In the end, Whig historians assessed Henry VIII by using temporal counterfactuals to distinguish between the early and later decades of his rule. Mackintosh used a rewind counterfactual to argue that "had Henry the Eighth died in the

twentieth year of his reign, his name might have come down to us as that of a festive and martial prince,” since the “applause” he received for his “gaiety and enterprise” would have overshadowed the misrule of his latter years.¹¹⁶ Froude made a similar argument, saying “if Henry VIII had died previous to the first agitation of the divorce, his loss would have been deplored as one of the heaviest misfortunes which had ever befallen the country.”¹¹⁷ By contrast, Macaulay used a fast forward counterfactual to defend Henry VIII’s rule, noting that his despotism was destined to be short-lived and arguing that “had his life been prolonged, he would have found it difficult to maintain a position assailed with equal fury by all who were zealous either for the new or for the old opinions.”¹¹⁸ In fact, the reigns of Henry VIII’s successors confirmed that his autocratic rule was temporary: the efforts of Queen Mary I (r. 1553–58) to centralize power were undermined by the widespread resistance to her divisive re-Catholicization campaign, while Queen Elizabeth I (r. 1558–1603), despite seldom convening Parliament after 1588, skillfully avoided any confrontation with the institution over key constitutional principles.

Defeating Despotism in the Seventeenth Century

The pivotal event for England’s embrace of parliamentary rule took place in the seventeenth century. Between 1603 and 1640, the Stuart Kings, James I (r. 1603–25) and Charles I (r. 1625–49), posed a threat to parliament by trying to govern as absolutists. Here, again, Whig historians saw blessings coming out of curses, for as Macaulay explained, though England’s status in the world suffered during James I’s reign, it was “little to be regretted,” for if his “administration had been able and splendid, it would probably have been fatal to our country.” If James “had ... been ... like Gustavus Adolphus, a valiant, active, and politic ruler,” he noted, “the English Parliament would soon have been nothing more than a name.”¹¹⁹ Macaulay identified another close call during the first year of the English Civil War in 1642, noting that if Charles I had possessed “a sagacious and powerful mind,” his army could have capitalized on its early military victories and “marched in triumph to Whitehall,” thereby ending parliamentary rule.¹²⁰ Although the execution of Charles I in 1649 ostensibly ended the threat of absolutism, it soon resurfaced in the form of the Lord Protector, Oliver Cromwell, whom the House of Commons, according to Macaulay, “would gladly have made ... King” (Figure 1.10).¹²¹ As Henry Hallam noted, if Cromwell had been tempted, “he would have transmitted the sceptre to his descendants with the acquiescence and tacit approbation of the kingdom.”¹²² Had this come to pass, Cromwell would have been firmly in power and no “insurrection ... could have overthrown a possession ... that belonged



FIGURE 1.10 Whig historians used close call counterfactuals to express relief that Oliver Cromwell was never able to establish a new form of absolutism in mid-17th century England. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

to his name.¹²³ But as Hallam explained, Cromwell “did not live long enough” to realize the potential of any system “which he might have devised.”¹²⁴ And so absolutism failed to advance.

It also failed to advance after the restoration of King Charles II in 1660. Commenting on the possibility that the King’s return from Holland might have sparked new domestic turmoil, Macaulay expressed relief that the complex negotiations surrounding the restoration’s terms were resolved quickly, noting “had the statesmen ... held long debates on the principles of government ... the coalition on which the public safety depended would have been dissolved,... and the ... friends of liberty might ... have regretted, under a rule worse than that of the worst Stuart, the golden opportunity which had been suffered to escape.”¹²⁵ Macaulay added that it was equally fortunate that Charles II took power in a country where “the name of a standing army was long held in abhorrence,” noting that otherwise, “there would have been little hope indeed for the

liberties of England.”¹²⁶ Nevertheless, despite avoiding these perils, Charles II’s devout Catholic beliefs and desire to forge closer relations with France posed a serious threat to England, for as Hallam noted, such a possibility “would have reunited a great kingdom to the catholic religion,... turned a powerful neighbour into a dependent pensioner,” and enabled France to “realize ... supremacy ... over Europe.”¹²⁷

Close calls also surrounded the reign of Charles II’s successor, James II. Pointing to the King’s fateful decision to revoke anti-Catholic legislation in his Declarations of Indulgence in 1687, Hallam speculated that James II “would [not] have failed” to achieve absolutist rule “had he not given alarm to his high-church parliament by a premature manifestation of his design to fill the civil and military employments with the professors of his own mode of faith.”¹²⁸ Mackintosh added that while the repeal of anti-Catholic laws “would have [given England]... the blessings of religious liberty,” its failure to “protect the endowments of the Protestant clergy” would have eventually helped the crown “establish the Catholic religion ... and ... abolish toleration.”¹²⁹ Ultimately, Macaulay asserted, the Protestants knew that if James II achieved his goals, “not one post in the government ... would have been bestowed upon any Protestant ... [and in] twenty years, every military man from a general to a drummer ... would have been a Catholic.”¹³⁰

For Whig historians, the events that brought about James II’s demise in the Glorious Revolution were both fortunate and inevitable. Noting that the King had a chance to rally the British population behind him after parliament invited William of Orange’s Dutch forces to expel him, Mackintosh speculated that if James II had “manifested the requisite ... resolution, to ... inspire the faithful, his army would, doubtless, have fought and conquered” (Figure 1.11). “But to do this,” Mackintosh added with a leopard spot counterfactual, James “must have changed his nature and become another man.”¹³¹ His defeat was more or less inevitable. Noting that James II was an “absurd” figure governed by “folly,” Macaulay declared that “we do not believe that [the King]... could have succeeded” in pursuing his absolutist agenda, concluding it was inevitable that “the nation would have achieved its deliverance.”¹³² That said, Macaulay expressed relief that the country had avoided a potential nightmare, noting that if James had been able to advance his Catholic agenda, the result would have been “a most bloody and destructive contest” that “would have shaken the whole fabric of society.”¹³³

Fortunately, when William III became England’s new King, he willingly subordinated himself to the power of parliament. Thanks to the insistence of the Whig party, the Parliament voted in 1689 to approve the Declaration of Rights and Bill of Rights, which limited the executive branch’s power relative to that



FIGURE 1.11 Whig historians agreed that King James II would have needed an entirely different personality to have withstood the powerful forces that overthrew him in the Glorious Revolution.
(Source: Wikimedia Commons)

of the legislative. Employing a deterministic counterfactual, Hallam argued that “no other remedy could have been found, according to the temper and prejudices of those times ... than ... to [break] the line of succession” and invite the House of Orange to assume the throne.¹³⁴ At the same time, Hallam noted, “it would have been ... preposterous [not] to ... assert ... those rights and liberties, which the very indeterminate nature of the king’s prerogative at common law ... must continually place in jeopardy.” Offering another close call counterfactual, Hallam explained that while “the House of Lords ... would have conferred the crown on William and Mary [and left]... the redress of grievances to future arrangement,” the Whigs “addressed the root of the nation’s grievances” by convincing the new King that “he was raised to the throne for the sake of the [very]... liberties” that James II had violated and thereby safeguarded parliamentary rule.¹³⁵

By the end of the seventeenth century, England, according to the Whig historians, had permanently enshrined liberty in its political system. To be sure, subsequent events in the eighteenth century prompted counterfactual nightmares and fantasies. If the English and Scottish Union of 1707 had not have preserved the independence of the Presbyterian Church, Britain's unity would have been hindered.¹³⁶ If the Jacobite Rebellion of 1745 had succeeded, England might have turned Catholic. If King George III had defeated the American Revolution, he might have curtailed the liberties of the British people.¹³⁷ These and other questions, however, played a relatively minor role in the Whig historians' master narrative. From their perspective, the Glorious Revolution confirmed that British history was a linear story of progress.

Germany

Like their French and English counterparts, German historians in the nineteenth century also used counterfactuals, but they focused less on political liberty than national unity. Having lived for a millennium in the decentralized Holy Roman Empire, Germans never enjoyed political cohesiveness in any modern sense. But in response to the traumatic experience of French invasion in the early 1800s, they began to see themselves as a common people (*Volk*) that deserved a polity for their Fatherland (*Vaterland*). Between the years 1848 and 1870, the influential state of Prussia, under the leadership of King Wilhelm I (r. 1861–1888) and his chancellor, Otto von Bismarck (1815–98), employed a variety of strategies to bring a new unified Germany into existence. War was the most effective, and following a series of military conflicts with Denmark (1864), Austria (1866), and France (1870), a united Germany was established in 1871.

Nineteenth-century German historians devoted much of their work to situating these and other important events in the larger sweep of German history. Beginning with the Middle Ages, they examined the fluctuating fortunes of the Holy Roman Empire before turning their attention to the eruption of the Reformation, the rise of Prussia, and the post-Napoleonic push for national unity. In covering these topics, German historians drew on an impressive tradition of historical scholarship dating back to the Enlightenment. They did not do so consistently, however. German historians not only lacked a unifying master narrative but embraced different methodologies and philosophies.¹³⁸

Nineteenth-century German historians were divided into two main camps. The first was associated with the historicist approach of Leopold von Ranke and his colleagues, Wilhelm Giesebrecht, Julius Ficker, and Karl Hampe



FIGURE 1.12 AND 1.13 Although Leopold von Ranke and Gustav Droysen represented two different camps of German historians—the Historicists and the Prussian School—both used counterfactuals to narrate the German people's journey from division to unity. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

(Figure 1.12). The second was the Prussian School of Historians led by Gustav Droysen, Heinrich von Sybel, and Heinrich von Treitschke (Figure 1.13). Both groups were nationalistically minded and focused much of their scholarship on Germany's meandering path of development from the fragmented Holy Roman Empire to the unified Second Empire. Both groups differed, however, in their philosophical and methodological orientation. They differed, first of all, on the question of presentism. Ranke and his colleagues rejected the tendency to project contemporary values onto the past and to see it as the inevitable precursor to the present; instead, they assessed the past according to its own ethical standards and sought to “objectively” understand how it “really was.”¹³⁹ By contrast, the Prussian historians believed that the historian's job was not just to understand the past but to judge it. Writing in an era of intensifying nationalism, they believed that grasping the shortcomings of the German past would promote present-day nation building. The two camps also differed on the question of determinism. While Ranke and his colleagues rejected the teleological belief that history proceeded in a progressive direction toward a specific goal, the Prussian historians saw German history inevitably proceeding

toward the creation of the Second Empire thanks to the decisive agency of the Prussian state.¹⁴⁰

These differing approaches shaped how the two camps employed counterfactuals. The historicists' distrust of presentism led them to use judgmental counterfactuals less frequently than the Prussians. Believing that "a strict presentation of the facts ... is the highest law," Ranke and his colleagues largely stuck to the existing historical record in their work.¹⁴¹ By contrast, the Prussians' nationalistic sentiments led them to second-guess the course of history more frequently. As a result, they had a fondness for missed opportunity counterfactuals. Writing in a period when Germany had not yet, or had just recently, achieved national unification, the Prussian historians explored the reasons why it was so late in coming. At the same time, both camps paradoxically employed deterministic counterfactuals. Although Ranke believed that history did not proceed in any specific direction and should be understood on its own terms, his fear of being viewed as a relativist led him to embrace the idealist notion that all eras were "equally close to God." Even though he shied away from teleological views, therefore, Ranke embraced the theodical belief that the past was the product of God's will and was thus unalterable.¹⁴² By contrast, the Prussian historians' determinism was influenced by a different source, namely Hegel's belief that history was driven by the dialectical competition between Idea and Spirit and had culminated in the form of the Prussian state.¹⁴³ Like the historicists, the Prussian historians also saw the course of German history as steered by unalterable forces. Both groups thus gravitated to deterministic and providential counterfactuals in explaining the German past.

The Middle Ages

During the nineteenth century, German historians devoted considerable attention to the thousand-year existence of the Holy Roman Empire. The two major camps differed substantially in their conclusions. Among the historicists, Wilhelm Giesebrecht and Julius Ficker sought to understand the Empire on its own terms, according to the needs of the Middle Ages, and generally lauded it for serving the needs of the German people.¹⁴⁴ By contrast, members of the Prussian School, such as Heinrich von Sybel, took a more presentist perspective and accused the Empire of preventing Germany from achieving national unity earlier in history. This scholarly debate coursed throughout the nineteenth century, but it reached an apex in the years 1859–62, just as the states of the Germanic Confederation were beginning to actively reconsider its future form. In debating the medieval past, the historicists and Prussians were debating contemporary politics, with the former taking a pro-Habsburg,

grossdeutsch position and the latter taking a pro-Prussian, *kleindeutsch* stance. The counterfactuals used by both camps directly served their historiographical and political positions. In examining medieval German history, the historicists argued that without the Holy Roman Empire, German history would have been worse, while the Prussians insisted that it would have been better.

Members of the historicist school used “what ifs” to examine the distant origins of German unity. Employing a missed opportunity counterfactual, Giesebrecht pointed to the powerful Empire of the Goths on the Black Sea at the time of Roman Emperor Aurelian (r. 270–275 CE) and hypothesized that “if the[ir]... strength ... had remained undivided and unfragmented, how different would the history of the German people ... have been!” (Figure 1.14).¹⁴⁵ After discussing how the Goths were later displaced by another Germanic tribe, the Franks, Giesebrecht underscored the event’s importance for German unity by saying “the Empire of the Franks would have ... soon collapsed had a people from the Germanic part of the Empire ... not come at the right moment and saved [it by] taking control ... [namely, the] Carolingians.”¹⁴⁶ Ficker, meanwhile, praised the Frankish ruler, Charles Martel, for unifying the Frankish tribes and defeating Muslim troops at the Battle of Tours in 732, thereby preserving German unity, noting that “if the Germanic world had persisted ... in its tendency to create independent tribal empires,” the “first clashes between [them and Islamic armies]... would have led to the swift defeat of the Germanic empire.”¹⁴⁷

By the time Charlemagne united Frankish lands in the Holy Roman Empire, the new German polity repeatedly proved critical for protecting Germany from external threats. Pointing to the danger of French aggression, Ficker praised the Empire’s rulers for expanding into Italy and Burgundy, saying “If the Germans had complacently remained distant from Italy and Burgundy and [largely shunned] imperial power ... instead of our rulers [being in charge], the Capetians [would have] worn the crowns of Italy and Burgundy.”¹⁴⁸ A “Germany that could not assert itself against the French monarchy,” moreover, would hardly “have been in a position to defend [itself]” from “Slavic ... and Hungarian attack.”¹⁴⁹ Ficker further emphasized the Empire’s defensive importance by showing how it refused to behave as an expansionist power. Employing an aggrandization counterfactual, he pointed to the powerful Emperor Heinrich III (r. 1046–1056) and noted that while “there was no comparable ... force [in medieval Europe] that could have prevented [him]... from pursuing limitless conquest,” he never made “a serious attempt to put an end to [France’s] independence.”¹⁵⁰

Beyond protecting Germany, the Holy Roman Empire defended Western civilization. Pointing to the threat posed by the Byzantine Empire, which



FIGURE 1.14 Wilhelm Giesebrecht used “what ifs” to chart the waxing and waning of German unity in the Middle Ages. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

sought to seize control of the Holy Roman Empire at various junctures during the Middle Ages, Ficker speculated, “who can imagine the consequences if the Bishop of Rome had been reduced to a Byzantine subject ... and forced to serve the Eastern Emperor’s ends?”¹⁵¹ Without the Empire’s suppression of rivalries between noble factions in Rome, moreover, the Papacy would have been “a tool of the Roman nobility” and would not “have been in a position” to lead the Crusades.¹⁵² These benefits, according to Ficker, explain the Papacy’s receptivity to external German support. At the same time, however, the Papacy was loath to grant the Germans too much power for fear of jeopardizing its own “clerical independence.” The result, Ficker noted, was constant but productive tension between secular and religious forces, without

which “western culture and civic freedom would not have developed as positively they did.”¹⁵³

This tension, according to the historicists, marked the subsequent evolution of the Holy Roman Empire. In discussing how Otto the Great re-forged the Empire on an explicitly German basis in the year 962, Giesebrecht praised the Emperor for subordinating the self-interested nobility and clergy to his rule and working for the benefit of the people, saying “how else could the incipient sense of common belonging among the Germans have developed ... but through the kind of monarchy that Otto established among the German tribes?”¹⁵⁴ At the same time, Otto’s claim of the Italian crown in 961 and the desire of his Ottonian, Salian, and Hohenstaufen successors to expand into Italy adversely shaped German identity by sabotaging German unity.¹⁵⁵ Noting “it would have been good if Otto and the Germans had ... departed from such a painful path,” Giesebrecht and his historicist colleagues identified multiple missed opportunities for the Germans to unify.¹⁵⁶ Giesebrecht, for example, fantasized that Emperor Conrad II (r. 1027–1039) could have created “a strong hereditary monarchy ... in Germany” had he subordinated the German nobles to his rule, while Ficker speculated that if Henry VI (r. 1191–97) had not died after acquiring Sicily, he could have realized his “solid prospects of increasing royal power.”¹⁵⁷ Yet while these unfortunate developments marred the development of the Empire, the historicists denied they discredited it. Insisting the Empire “perfectly synthesized the desire for universal and national monarchy,” Ficker used a deterministic counterfactual to argue “it would be hard to imagine a more ideal spatial configuration,” concluding “no part of the empire could have been dispensed with without threatening the survival of the whole.”¹⁵⁸

By contrast, the Prussian School historian Heinrich von Sybel believed the Empire was irreparably flawed (Figure 1.15). It was laughable, he believed, for Ficker to argue that the Empire’s problems stemmed from ill-advised foreign policy adventures in Italy—“as if the [Empire]... would still exist today if only the annexation of the Kingdoms of Sicily had never happened!”¹⁵⁹ The Empire, Sybel argued, was never as important as Ficker claimed. Rejecting the latter’s claim that the Empire helped defend against Islam, Sybel pointed out that the Franks defeated the Muslims before establishing the Empire, using a deterministic counterfactual to note that in the year 800, “there was no state in the world that could have challenged the superiority of the Franks.”¹⁶⁰ Sybel further attacked the Empire’s expansion into Italy under Charlemagne—saying “the Carolingians should have pursued a more modest war policy”—and instead hailed the achievements of Duke of Saxony, Heinrich I (876–936), whose success in uniting the five German stem duchies into a unified Kingdom created “Europe’s most powerful state.”¹⁶¹ Indeed, Sybel speculated that “[if]

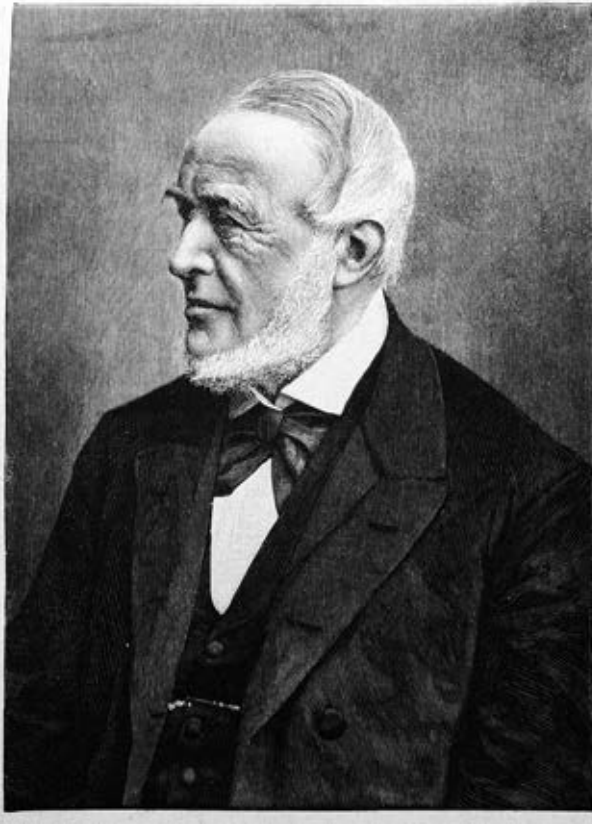


FIGURE 1.15 Heinrich von Sybel lamented missed opportunities in the Middle Ages for the Germans to have forged greater unity. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

the progress that began under Heinrich [had]... continued ... [and] royal officials [had]... been subordinated to ducal authority,” then “the creation of a north German/Saxon power could have [taken place].”¹⁶² Unfortunately, Sybel argued, later Emperors squandered this opportunity by becoming embroiled in needless squabbles with the Church in Italy, such as the Investiture controversy of 1073 between Emperor Henry IV (r. 1084–1105) and Pope Gregory VII (r. 1073–1085), declaring that “the German King ... could have avoided a fight with the papacy, just as easily as the French or English king[s],” who remained satisfied merely with having the Pope as an ally, rather than a dependent. In the end, though, the Emperor never could have done such a thing, for as

Sybel noted with a deterministic counterfactual, “the Holy Roman Emperor of the German Nation could not avoid [trying to control the Pope]... unless he wanted to relinquish the essence ... of his office.” “For this reason,” he declared, “the clash that ruined German monarchy and German unity was inevitable.”¹⁶³

Sybel concluded his response to Ficker by using close call counterfactuals to show how the Empire might have inflicted even more damage to Germany than it already did. In discussing Charlemagne’s pursuit of political “centralization” and cultural “uniformity,” Sybel said there was no reason to “complain that it did not come to pass,” since if his vision had become a reality, “the freedom of all individuality would have been suffocated and ... there would have been no place for national development.”¹⁶⁴ Sybel made an equally bleak prediction about the rule of Frederick II, saying that “if [he]... had triumphed, his rule would have been everything—Sicilian, Italian, Saracen—except for German.”¹⁶⁵ Worst of all, foreign distractions might have led to the abolition of German identity altogether. In discussing the administration of Otto III (996–1002), Sybel noted that the Emperor so totally neglected German affairs in the interest “of reviving the Roman Empire” that “if he had not died at an early age,... he would have done everything in his power to remove the “raw’ [*rohe*] German character from the face of the earth.”¹⁶⁶ Given all these criticisms, Sybel was confident that German history would have been better served without the existence of the Holy Roman Empire altogether.

The Reformation

German historians also used “what ifs” to examine how the Protestant Reformation affected the country’s disunity. Here, the historicists and Prussian historians largely agreed: while there were many missed opportunities in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, the course of history was largely inevitable.

German historians believed the Reformation could have been avoided if the Reich’s emperors had pursued a more national and less dynastic agenda. While various opportunities had been missed in the Middle Ages, the most important took place two years after the eruption of the Reformation, when the Emperors Maximilian I (r. 1508–1519) and Charles V (r. 1519–1556) failed to endorse the German people’s desire to break with the Roman Catholic establishment.¹⁶⁷ Had they followed the wishes of the people and “completely thrown off of [the Pope’s] authority,” Sybel noted, “the most important step towards national unity and ... political independence ... would have been taken.”¹⁶⁸ Taking a similar position was the historicist scholar Leopold von Ranke who, after noting that Luther’s rebellion had sparked an “intense desire of the nation

to consolidate itself into a certain unity,” criticized Maximilian’s weakness, declaring that “had there been at this moment a powerful emperor, he might have ... been able to revive the ancient opposition to the papacy and to inspire his people with a new life founded upon religious ideas.”¹⁶⁹ Ranke added that if Charles V had supported concurrent proposals for imperial reform, such as a new, empire-wide, tax and custom union, he would have shaped “the future fate of Germany” and “awakened a universal feeling of the unity of the empire.”¹⁷⁰

Yet, while Ranke and other historians advanced such missed opportunity counterfactuals, they qualified their effect by deterministically showing how they were destined to fail. While Ranke speculated that the Elector of Saxony and supporter of Luther, Frederick (r. 1486–1525), might have promoted “the destiny of Germany” had he become Emperor instead of Charles V, the historian noted that Frederick’s lack of “ambition” and “cautious” nature prevented him from pursuing a nomination.¹⁷¹ Ranke also speculated that while Luther could have united the nation at the Diet of Worms in 1519 had he merely “attack[ed] the abuses of the curia” and not boldly assailed the entire “government of Pope Leo X,” it was impossible for him to moderate his message, because his “mind ... would have been broken had it been fettered by any consideration not purely religious.”¹⁷² Gustav Droysen also saw compromise as impossible. Noting that Luther could “do no different” than pursue his vision of religious reform, the historian asserted that Charles V could also “do no different” in opposing Luther because of his imperial and religious “obligations,” which the electors “should have realized” when they elevated him to the throne in 1519. In the end, all the parties “had to accept things the way they were.” “Luther’s work,” Droysen concluded, “was not the kind of new beginning that could have suddenly made everything around it gentle [and]... peaceful.”¹⁷³ History had to occur as it did.

Prussian historians also used counterfactuals to criticize how the Habsburgs impeded German unity during the Wars of Religion. In condemning how Charles V continued to pursue his “universal religious pretensions” by trying to eradicate Protestantism from Germany after the first Schmalkaldic War in 1547, Sybel noted that “a genuine German king would have harnessed the domestic forces belonging to his confession and secured the Fatherland for his church,” just as other nations’ rulers did during the period.¹⁷⁴ Heinrich von Treitschke, meanwhile, extended Sybel’s critique of the Habsburgs into the era of the Thirty Years War.¹⁷⁵ In discussing Emperor Ferdinand II’s Edict of Restitution in 1629, which re-Catholicized lands in Protestant Germany for the Habsburgs, Treitschke noted that if “these measures [had] been carried out [permanently],... Protestantism would have been completely annihilated” and the German people’s “freedom of spirit” would have been

destroyed.¹⁷⁶ Sybel summed up this sentiment with a polemical counterfactual, condemning the “exploitation [of Germany] for Austria’s special interests” and asserting that no “[other] foreign rule would have subjected us to [a]... worse [fate].”¹⁷⁷ All these claims, by showing the detrimental impact of the Habsburgs on German history, served the Prussian historians’ present-day anti-Habsburg agenda.

The Rise of Prussia

While the historicists and Prussian school historians both wished medieval and early modern German history had unfolded differently, they were more upbeat in discussing the history of Prussia. While the latter were more deterministic and presentist in orientation, both used “what ifs” to express regret that Prussia had not unified Germany sooner and relief that the state finally achieved its goals in the nineteenth century.¹⁷⁸

In chronicling Prussia’s rise to prominence, German historians mostly focused on Frederick the Great. Some focused on close calls that nearly prevented Prussia’s mid-eighteenth century ascent. In Volume III of his *Memoirs of the House of Brandenburg*, Ranke used a medium form counterfactual to imagine how history, on the eve of the War of the Austrian Succession in 1740, would have unfolded “had ... Frederick II not existed,” noting that in response to the inevitable “war [that] would have broken out concerning the Austrian succession,” France “would have seized the occasion ... [to make] herself ... the predominant power of Europe” and probably succeeded, given Austria’s weakness and the absence of a Prussian deterrent. “The situation of Germany,” he lamented “would ... have been ... miserable.”¹⁷⁹ Droysen agreed, noting that without Prussian intervention, Germany “would have become a puppet of ... England or a dependency of ... France.”¹⁸⁰

Yet despite Prussia’s victory in the War of the Austrian Succession, the state missed later opportunities to sideline Austria and forge a unified Germany. In discussing how Frederick the Great engineered the rise of his ally, the Bavarian Elector, Charles, to the position of Holy Roman Emperor in 1742, Treitschke wrote that “if things had gone as Frederick hoped, the separation from Austria would have been accomplished then.” But Prussia was not strong enough to push through further “imperial reform.”¹⁸¹ Treitschke explained that Frederick missed another opportunity to increase the power of Germany when he failed to gain Bavarian support for secularizing the empire’s ecclesiastical territories, noting that if the plan had succeeded, Germany could have “become a confederation of temporal princes under the dominant influence of Prussia” and moved closer to unity.¹⁸²

In examining Prussian history in the years following Frederick's death in 1786, Prussian historians used other "what ifs" to lament the slow pace of German unification. In describing Napoleon's invasion of the Holy Roman Empire in 1800, Treitschke described how France subjected the German lands to "terrible things" by reducing the number of states in the Empire and then replacing it entirely with the Confederation of the Rhine in 1806, but he used a silver lining counterfactual to show how it proved to be "a benefit politically, for it ... accomplished what ... should long ago have been done," namely abolish "all the dirty little states of the Roman Church, which existed to give fat livings to the Catholic nobility" (Figure 1.16).¹⁸³ Napoleon thus paradoxically helped the cause of German unity. It was also fortunate that Austria failed to defeat French forces at the Battle of Wagram in 1809. Given how the Habsburg Emperor, Francis II (r. 1792–1806), "feared the ... national idea which was so active in Germany," Treitschke insisted that a potential "Austrian defeat of Napoleon "could have brought no salvation for our Fatherland. For in that case ... the foreign domination of the Habsburgs would have replaced that of Napoleon."¹⁸⁴

Yet while Prussia avoided these nightmares, it also missed opportunities to advance the cause of German unity. Sybel noted how, in the Revolution of 1848, Prussia's King, Frederick William IV (r. 1840–1861), could have extended "Prussian influence in South and Middle Germany" and "paved the way "for the conversion of the German Confederation into a German Empire!"¹⁸⁵ But he failed to provide leadership by immediately convening a parliament.¹⁸⁶ At the same time, Sybel made clear that the King faced deterministic headwinds. In explaining his rejection of the liberal constitution on April 21, 1849, Sybel declared that Frederick William IV could not have accepted a constitution that "would have involved the humiliating of the German Kings by cooperation with the revolutionary populace." Moreover, accepting the constitution "would have ... led to a great war against Austria and Russia; for Austria would never have yielded meekly the foremost position in Germany, and Russia would surely have supported her." "Perhaps a Frederick the Great might have undertaken this task and have succeeded in it," Sybel speculated, "but the present King ... was not another Frederick."¹⁸⁷

Thankfully, by the 1860s, Prussia had a leader—Otto von Bismarck—who was finally able to realize the state's destiny of unifying Germany. In discussing Bismarck's role in engineering Prussia's pivotal victory over Austria in 1866, Sybel used an aggrandization counterfactual to praise the Prussian Chancellor for his subsequent modesty, noting that "with such a combination of military and political triumphs, how many of the great conquerors of the ancient or modern times would have resisted the temptation to break in pieces ... all



FIGURE 1.16 Heinrich von Treitschke used silver lining counterfactuals to praise Napoleon for abolishing hindrances to German unity that should have been eliminated generations earlier. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

constitutional restraints” and strive for “boundless power?”¹⁸⁸ Instead, like George Washington after 1783, Bismarck abided by constitutional norms for the sake of “healthy unity.” Sybel further praised the Prussian King, Wilhelm I, writing that “today there is ... gratitude for the work of [the] King ..., without which the founding of the German Empire would have been a shadowy dream.”¹⁸⁹ Treitschke, meanwhile, praised both Bismarck and the Prussian monarch with a deterministic counterfactual, arguing that “Prussian policy up to 1866 could only have been carried out by a great king and ... minister, never by a republic.”¹⁹⁰

The Prussian historians also used “what ifs” to justify the subsequent course of German unification. Treitschke expressed his relief that national unity was forged through war instead of a “popular rising” by pointing out that the

latter event would have entailed German Protestants fighting against German Catholics, who, as the “defeated party,” would have gone on to “cherish ... a silent hostility towards the victors” and complicated the course of unification. Thanks to the fact that Prussia won the war and imposed “mild terms” on Austria, however, the erstwhile enemies were filled “with so much mutual esteem ... that within four years, they were fighting side by side against France as true comrades.”¹⁹¹ The ensuing Franco-Prussian War in 1870 was a byproduct of this new sense of German nationalism, which was so strong, according to Treitschke, that “No German Government could have withstood the national cry [to fight the French].”¹⁹² Yet, while Treitschke credited structural forces for facilitating German unification, he also acknowledged Bismarck’s individual agency. Citing the famous Ems telegram affair of July 1870, Treitschke described how Bismarck shrewdly made the French Ambassador to Prussia, Count Vincent Benedetti, seem especially hostile to King Wilhelm I by demanding that the Prussian monarch refrain from proposing another Hohenzollern candidate for the vacant throne of Spain, noting, “If Bismarck had not drawn up so cleverly the telegram on the Benedetti affair, the King would have yielded” and Germany would not have been able to go to war.¹⁹³

Finally, Otto von Bismarck himself echoed the claims of the Prussian historians in his own writings (Figure 1.17). In his posthumously published *Memoirs* (1898), the German chancellor resembled Napoleon Bonaparte by including dozens of counterfactuals in his recollections.¹⁹⁴ Yet while Napoleon’s counterfactuals expressed regret about history’s unrealized possibilities, Bismarck expressed relief that history worked out as it did. Most of Bismarck’s “what ifs” pertained to his decisions to secure German unification in the years 1864–1871. In discussing his role in forging the North German Confederation in 1867, for example, Bismarck noted that he consistently used more carrots than sticks to persuade other German states to embrace unity. Explaining that “acts of violence against German fellow-countrymen ... would for generations afterwards have been a hindrance in the way of reconciliation,” Bismarck cited his decision to respect Bavaria’s territorial integrity by refusing to annex the Palatinate, writing that doing so would have led the state to seek “revenge against us in a junction with Austria.”¹⁹⁵ Bismarck also used “what ifs” to explain his role in the war with France by justifying his use of the Ems Telegram to mobilize the German people’s “national sense of honour ... to go to war,” speculating that “if we did not act according to the demands of this feeling, we should lose ... the entire impetus towards our national development won in 1866,” since the “German national feeling south of the Main [that had been] aroused by our military successes in 1866... would have ... grow[n] cold again.”¹⁹⁶ Finally,



FIGURE 1.17 Many of the counterfactuals that Otto von Bismarck offered in his memoirs expressed relief that German history worked out as it did.
(Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Bismarck used counterfactuals to echo Thomas Carlyle's belief in the importance of great men in history. Recalling that when he became King Wilhelm's advisor in 1862, the Prussian monarch was demoralized by the weakness of the Prussian army, Bismarck speculated that "if I had not taken over [the]... direction [of Prussian policy at that time]," Wilhelm "would have abdicated ... and the policy which laid the foundations of the glory of the army" with the victories of 1864–71 "would never have come into being."¹⁹⁷ Because he acted decisively, however, Bismarck avoided disaster and helped Germany realize its destiny.

Conclusion

The rise of nationalism profoundly shaped the evolution of counterfactuals in nineteenth-century Europe. In countless historical monographs, French, British, and German historians regularly used “what ifs” to explain and judge their nations’ pasts. They did so in different ways and for different reasons, however. British historians were the most ebullient in speculating, possibly because their master narrative about the nation’s past—the “Whig Theory” of history—was such an optimistic and widely-held one. Rooted in the confident belief that British history was a success story, British historians could enjoy concocting close calls about historical nightmares knowing they never happened. French and German historians also speculated a great deal about the past, but they did so just as much to express regret as relief. Living in more politically divided societies that disagreed about the reasons for recent national setbacks—whether the failure to advance liberty or forge unity—scholars in France and Germany were less able to take pleasure in doing so. While scholars in all three nations shared the era’s belief in progress, British historians were the most inclined to situate their speculative claims within deterministic and theodical philosophies of history. Because French and German scholars were more aware of the contingencies of historical events, they were more prepared to acknowledge the importance of chance. Significantly, this scholarly debate soon penetrated European intellectual and cultural life more broadly.

Determinism and its Discontents: Controversy over Counterfactuals, 1815–1914

We shall enlarge our conception of ... human events ... by ... contemplating, for a moment,... *events which have not happened*.¹⁹⁸ (Isaac Disraeli 1824)

Would-have-beens are mostly a vanity. ... [The] World's History could never ... be what it would, or might, or should [have been] by any manner of potentiality, but simply and altogether what it *is*.¹⁹⁹ (Thomas Carlyle 1837)

As counterfactual reasoning became more common in nineteenth-century Europe, it left the realm of academic scholarship and migrated into the western cultural mainstream. Counterfactuals increasingly appeared not only in works of history but in journalistic essays, religious sermons, poems, and even commercial advertisements. As Europeans increasingly wondered “what if,” they became increasingly self-aware about doing so. As was shown by the competing views of Isaac Disraeli and Thomas Carlyle, they gradually began to debate whether counterfactuals expanded or inhibited historical understanding.

The eruption of this debate, and its intensification in the years before World War I, was promoted by a new skeptical mindset that emerged after the second half of the nineteenth century. During this period, the optimistic faith in determinism that once prevailed across the western world was increasingly challenged by the pessimistic recognition that chance played an equally important role in human affairs. As western society underwent the disruptive process of modernization, it experienced a series of cultural crises—of faith, liberalism, positivism, and historicism—that, in certain circles, produced an epistemological shift away from rational objectivity towards skeptical relativism.²⁰⁰

All these developments shaped the evolution of counterfactuals. While the influence of determinism had limited the kinds of “what ifs” used by historians and other writers before the mid-nineteenth century, growing doubts about the inevitability of history and new interest in the role of chance in the ensuing period inspired people to contemplate ways that history might have been different. Although the two groups of scholars—the determinists and anti-determinists—did not engage each other directly, their differing attitudes towards counterfactuals gave rise to a de-facto debate about their epistemological utility. This debate was not confined to the world of scholarship, moreover,

but spilled into mass culture. In journalism, poetry, and literature, western society became increasingly divided on the question of counterfactual speculation.

The First Counterfactualist: Isaac Disraeli

The first person to fully recognize the existence of counterfactual history as an independent phenomenon was the British writer Isaac Disraeli (Figure 2.1). In his pioneering 1824 essay “Of a History of Events Which Have Not Happened,” Disraeli called attention to the presence of “what ifs” in the work of contemporary historians.²⁰¹ Published in his extremely popular, multi-edition anthology *Curiosities of Literature*, Disraeli’s essay was mostly devoted to aggregating examples of counterfactual speculation. Like earlier writers, he noted that historians as far back as antiquity had “amused themselves” by exploring “event[s] which did not happen,” citing Livy’s famous hypothesis about Alexander the Great squaring off against Rome’s mighty legions and alluding to Edward Gibbon’s contemplation of a Muslim victory over the Franks in 732.²⁰²

Mostly, though, Disraeli cited the presence of “what ifs” in the work of recent British scholars—including Robert Southey, William Roscoe, Malcolm Laing, and John Whitaker—while adding a few of his own.²⁰³ While Disraeli speculated about a range of topics, most involved close calls and missed opportunities in British history. Disraeli reflected, for instance, on how Luther might have recanted at the Diet of Worms in 1521 if his passions had not been roused by a condescending Cardinal, hypothesizing that without Luther, “the Reformation ... had possibly never freed England from the papal thralldom.”²⁰⁴ Disraeli also contemplated the nightmare that might have ensued in 1588 if the Spanish King, Philip II, had not “failed to support [the Duke of Alba] in finishing what he had begun,” speculating that “had the armada of Spain safely landed ... in England ... we might now be going to Mass!”²⁰⁵ Disraeli also noted that if King Charles I’s spiritual autobiography, the *Eikon Basilike* (1649), had been published “one week sooner” than it actually was, “it might have preserved the king” by improving “popular feeling” towards him and preventing his execution.²⁰⁶

In embracing these and other counterfactuals, Disraeli explicitly challenged deterministic portrayals of history. He did so partly for political reasons. At the time he was writing, Britain’s Whig interpretation of history had not yet fully appeared, but its telltale features were already present in the writings of Joseph Priestley, whose triumphalistic view of English history Disraeli rejected for its retroactive determinism.²⁰⁷ As he put it, “So ductile is history in the hands of man! And so peculiarly does it bend to the force of success and warp



FIGURE 2.1 Isaac Disraeli's pioneering essay, "Of a History of Events Which Have Not Happened" (1824), was notable for identifying counterfactual history as an independent phenomenon. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

with the warmth of prosperity!"²⁰⁸ It was partly to puncture the Whigs' smug view of the British past that Disraeli cited close calls and missed opportunities in English history. Disraeli also criticized determinism for religious reasons. He was especially opposed to providential views of history, complaining that when people cited divine intervention to explain why "the events which at first were adverse to their own cause ... finally terminate[d] in their favour," they were falling victim to "human error" or, worse still, "intolerant prejudice."²⁰⁹ Disraeli's view that the belief in Providence was a "custom [that] has long prevailed among fanatics" probably reflected his conflicted sense of Jewish identity. As the descendant of Portuguese Jews who had fled religious persecution—and as someone who was personally alienated from organized religion—Disraeli expressed his distaste for religious intolerance by seeking refuge in secular culture, especially history and literature.²¹⁰

Disraeli's embrace of counterfactuals ultimately represented a way to rebel against necessity and make people recognize that things did not have to happen the way they did. Emphasizing the importance of "accident and [individual] character," Disraeli concluded his essay by programmatically declaring: "we shall enlarge our conception of ... human events ... by ... contemplating, for a moment, *on certain events which have not happened!*"²¹¹ In making this momentous declaration, Disraeli revealed how scholars were becoming increasingly aware that counterfactual history was an independent branch of historical thought.

Despite its pioneering insights, Disraeli's essay was ahead of its time. Although many writers would later cite his role in providing counterfactual history with theoretical grounding, his essay received little attention when it was originally published. One reason for this neglect was the same phenomenon that animated Disraeli's endorsement of counterfactualism in the first place—the dominance of deterministic thinking in European intellectual life.

The Determinists: Promoting Necessity, Avoiding Alternatives

During the first half of the nineteenth century, the prominence of deterministic thinking limited the spread of counterfactual speculation. Deterministic thought assumed different forms: idealist, materialist, and positivist. But whatever its incarnation, the belief that human existence had to proceed in a certain direction restricted the willingness of people to wonder "what if?" Some determinists, such as Thomas Carlyle and Victor Cousin, scorned counterfactual thinking explicitly. Others, such as Karl Marx and Herbert Spencer, seldom used it, and when they did, employed it in a deterministic framework.

The British writer and historian Thomas Carlyle was the most outspoken opponent of "what ifs." In his famous book *The French Revolution* (1837), Carlyle memorably declared that "*would-have-beens* are mostly a vanity" (Figure 2.2).²¹² While this dismissive remark suggests that Carlyle regarded counterfactual reasoning as a hubristic mode of thought, it also had deeper significance relating to questions of historical causality. The immediate context for Carlyle's remark was his discussion of the French Revolution's tragic course during the fateful year 1791—especially the pivotal role played by the moderate revolutionary, Count Mirabeau. Long beloved by the French masses for his fiery oratory, Mirabeau in 1790 secretly entered into an agreement with King Louis XVI to help the monarch remain in power; one year later, Mirabeau sought to facilitate the King's flight from Paris without losing the support of

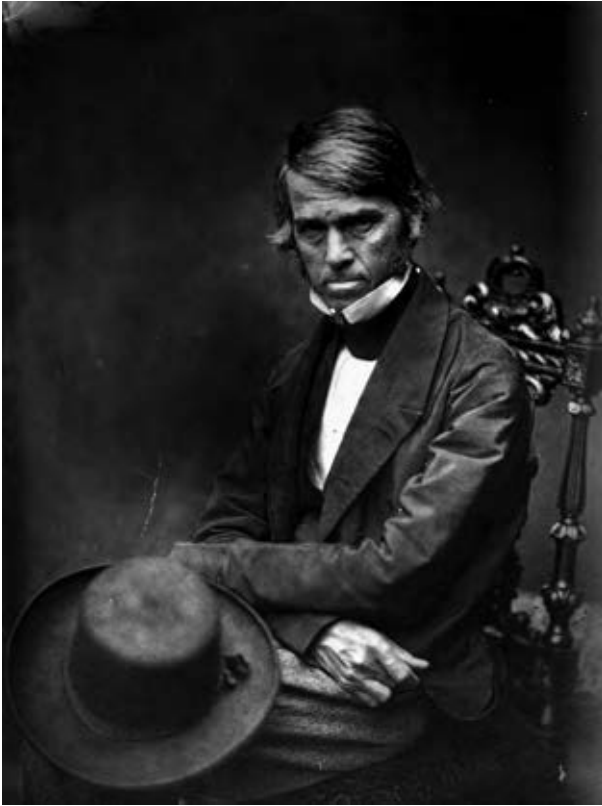


FIGURE 2.2 In his book, *The French Revolution* (1837), Thomas Carlyle critically asserted that “*would-have-beens* are mostly a vanity.” (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

the National Assembly.²¹³ Unfortunately, Mirabeau died of heart trouble on April 2, 1791, before he could fully solidify his plans for the King, and when the royal family belatedly fled Paris several months later, they were famously caught in Varennes, with devastating effects for the monarchy’s reputation. Carlyle used these events as an opportunity for counterfactual speculation, writing: “suppose Mirabeau, with whom Royalty takes deep counsel,... [had] got his arrangements [for the King’s return] *completed*?” In all probability, Carlyle continued, Mirabeau would have been embroiled with “Jacobinism ... in [a] Hercules-and-Typhon duel.”

Yet, instead of further developing his hypothesis, Carlyle confessed it was “vain [to] guess” since it is “unknown what is to be.”²¹⁴ While he was willing to speculate that “had Mirabeau lived, the History of France and of the World

had been different,” he quickly added that “Mirabeau could not live another year, any more than he could live another thousand years.”²¹⁵ In the end, it was not meant to be. Declaring “It matters not to peremptory Fate,” Carlyle concluded that “the most important of men cannot stay, adding [“if”] the World’s History depend[s] on an hour, that hour is not to be given.”²¹⁶ For this reason, he declared, “*would-have-beens* are mostly a vanity.”

In concluding on this somber note, Carlyle revealed his larger philosophy of history. Today, Carlyle is often viewed as an opponent of determinism thanks to his famous “great man” theory of history, according to which men of unique talent and charisma shape historical events.²¹⁷ Carlyle certainly saw himself in this way, presenting his theory as challenging the mindset that “denies the existence ... of great men” and reduces them to figures merely “call[ed] forth” by “the times.”²¹⁸ Insisting that the concept of “the times” was a reified abstraction that denied the all-important principle of free will, Carlyle believed “the times” could not generate meaningful change in and of themselves, explaining that while “[the] Times *call* loudly enough for their great man ... [they do] not find him when they called!”²¹⁹ The role of the individual was thus paramount.

Yet in explaining why great men were often absent from history, Carlyle ironically fell back on a deterministic answer. As he noted, the reason why “[the great man] was not there [when called]” was because “Providence ... had not sent him.”²²⁰ This answer revealed that while Carlyle rejected a secular version of deterministic thinking (“the times”), he embraced a religious version of determinist thought (divine Providence). A spiritually-minded adherent of Romanticism, Carlyle hailed from a strict Calvinist background and believed that God played a providential role in history by making great men available at key historical moments.²²¹ Employing a Promethean metaphor, Carlyle observed that the world prior to the arrival of great men was little more than “dry mouldering sticks” incapable of generating fire. Only when great men came onto the scene—like “lightning out of Heaven”—would their heroic deeds “kindle” nature’s sticks and advance history’s course.²²² Notably enough, Carlyle drove home this point with a counterfactual claim—namely, that “In all epochs of the world’s history we shall find the Great Man to have been ... the lightning, without which the fuel never would have burnt.”²²³ As long as Providence made a great man available, all would be well.

Carlyle thus believed the French Revolution was destined to end tragically because the men who were needed by the times could not be found. Mirabeau was one of those vital men—“a living son of Nature”—but France’s problem was that “[everything] depended on that one man!”²²⁴ As matters turned out, Mirabeau’s death shifted the course of events by placing the focus on a second

man who could not see the needs of the times. That man, King Louis XVI, was a man of tentative character who resisted fleeing Paris until it was too late and then allowed history's verdict to be sealed by surrendering at Varennes. A more forceful King, Carlyle mused, might have resisted, and "the whole course of French history [would have been] different!"²²⁵ "Alas, it was not *in* the poor phlegmatic man [to do so]. Had it been in him, French history had never come under this Varennes Archway to decide itself."²²⁶ Because the King was not a great man of history, in short, the events of the revolution unfolded as they had to—toward Jacobin terror and Napoleonic dictatorship. Because history had to unfold along its providential axis, it was a "vanity" to wonder "what if?" In the end, Carlyle only used counterfactuals to prove their irrelevance.

The French philosopher and historian Victor Cousin was equally skeptical about the utility of counterfactuals (Figure 2.3). Like Carlyle, he expressed skepticism about "what ifs" in the process of reflecting on the relationship between great men and their times. In his *Course of the History of Modern Philosophy* (1847), Cousin noted that "the philosophy of history in regard to great men is ... to judge them by what they have done, not by what they have wished to do."²²⁷ Speculating about missed opportunities and close calls was thus irrelevant. There was no sense, he argued, in wondering about "the most beautiful plans, which could not have failed to result in good, had it not been for this or that reason." As he put it, "all that does not resolve itself into fact is counted for nothing by humanity."²²⁸ That which happened was "that which should have happened."²²⁹ In articulating these views, Cousin revealed himself to be more openly deterministic than Carlyle.²³⁰ While he also believed in Providence—writing that "history is nothing less than ... divine action"—he went further by asserting that "great men" merely channeled the "spirit of the times" in which they lived, like "servant[s]" who promoted "the ideas which are dominant."²³¹

In expressing these beliefs, Cousin revealed the influence of the German Idealist philosopher G.W.F. Hegel.²³² In his *Philosophy of History* (1837), Hegel argued that history had a providentially decreed directionality, asserting that historical events were part of a rational process, one in which the "world spirit" (*Weltgeist*) gradually became aware of its own existence and embarked upon the task of self-realization over time. This view of history was both teleological and theodical. Believing that all historical events were driven by the dialectical struggle between competing ideas, Hegel asserted that the struggle advanced a central goal—the expansion of freedom—and was marked by inevitable clashes, whether between the universal and the particular or the collective and the individual. Thanks to the "cunning of reason," however, the clash of



FIGURE 2.3 Victor Cousin doubted the utility of counterfactuals, arguing that people should be “judge[d]... by what they have done, not by what they have wished to do.” (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

ideas was resolved for the benefit of all humanity by giving rise to the institution that both embodied and protected freedom, the modern state. This worldview shaped how Hegel understood the relationship between great individuals and the needs (or spirit) of the times. Writing that “great historical men [are those]... whose own particular aims involve ... the will of the World-Spirit,” Hegel argued that while their bold deeds “appear ... [to emanate] from themselves,” they were unconsciously unfolding a “general Idea,” one that “the time [held]... ripe for development.”²³³ “World-historical men,” he noted, were thus the “clear-sighted ones” who recognized what needed to be done in order for the era to realize its destiny.²³⁴ Individuals were thus steered by deeper forces.

Given these views, Hegel largely avoided counterfactuals.²³⁵ *The Philosophy of History* contained hardly any “what ifs.” The exception that proved the rule was a geographical counterfactual that asserted the influence of a deeper force—landscape—on human history. Referring to how the American frontier had served as a safety valve by enabling internal migration and reducing social tensions, Hegel applied the dynamic to Europe and observed: “Had the woods of Germany been in existence, the French Revolution would not have occurred.”²³⁶ Like Carlyle, Hegel used counterfactuals merely to confirm the deterministic realities that governed human existence.

The same was true of two other thinkers influenced by Hegel—Karl Marx and Friedrich Engels. Given their embrace of dialectical materialism and the attendant belief that class conflict was the motor of all history, it was predictable that the two men largely avoided counterfactuals. Hardly any appeared in Marx’s key works, including *The Communist Manifesto*, *The German Ideology*, and *Political Economy*. The major exception was a comment he made in his *18th Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte* (1852). In addressing the vexing question of why “the Parisian proletariat [did] not rise in revolt” against Louis Napoleon’s coup d’état of December 2, 1851, Marx used a close call counterfactual to explain that “any earnest uprising of the proletariat would have ... revived the bourgeoisie ..., brought on its reconciliation with the army, and ... ensured a second June rout of the workingmen.”²³⁷ By floating this nightmarish “what if,” Marx neutralized any potential regret about the working class’s absent revolt and staved off any doubts about dialectical materialism’s predictive value.²³⁸ For his part, Friedrich Engels also used scattered counterfactuals to illustrate the power of determinism (Figure 2.4). In 1894, he rejected Carlyle’s claim that great men were needed to light the kindling structurally produced by a given era, saying that if “the so-called great man” were “eliminate[d]... a substitute [is]... sure to be found.” Insisting that if Napoleon Bonaparte had not “been the military dictator ... [during] the exhausting wars of the French Republics ... another would have filled his place,” Engels concluded that throughout the course of history, “whenever a man was necessary, he has always been found: Caesar, Augustus, [and] Cromwell.”²³⁹ Engels thus confirmed the value of structure over agency.

Another major thinker who shaped the determinist ethos of the nineteenth century was the French social scientist August Comte. More than any of his contemporaries, Comte believed that the methods of the natural sciences could be mobilized to understand the world of human beings, whether in the past or the present. In his work *The Course of Positive Philosophy* (1830–42), Comte argued that human development (at least in Europe) unfolded according to a three-stage pattern in which people transcended theological and metaphysical



FIGURE 2.4 Friedrich Engels rarely employed counterfactuals, but when he did, he used them to confirm the value of structure over agency as a historical force. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

modes of thought before arriving at what he called a “positivist” stage, where they finally grasped how mental life followed natural laws. Comte scorned narrative history, claiming that the proper focus of historical study was neither the deeds of great individuals nor specific nations but general patterns “without [the] names of men ... [or] peoples.”²⁴⁰ Small wonder that counterfactuals rarely appeared in Comte’s writings. Once again, certain exceptions proved the rule. In his book, *A General View of Positivism* (1865), Comte sought to identify the laws guiding the development of scientific and poetic genius and asserted that the latter could only emerge where the former “had already been fixed” in the form of “first principles.” Claiming that “in history we find periods of

esthetic growth succeeding periods of great philosophical change, but never co-existing,” Comte speculated that

if we look at instances of great minds who were never able to find their proper sphere, we see at once that had they risen at some other time, they might have cultivated either poetry or philosophy, as the case might be, with equal success. Diderot would no doubt have been a great poet in a time more favourable to art; and Goethe, under different political influences, might have been an eminent philosopher.²⁴¹

Convinced that great men were subordinated to forces that shaped their milieus, Comte only used “what ifs” to reveal why the world had to be as it was.

Comte’s thinking, in turn, influenced the English historian Henry Thomas Buckle.²⁴² Rejecting all providential views of the past, Buckle sought to establish a “science of history” that identified the natural laws governing human existence.²⁴³ Like other determinists, Buckle mostly used “what ifs” to confirm why things had to be the way they were. His belief that landscape and climate were among the more important structural determinants of human life, for example, prompted him to follow in Hegel’s path and use geographical counterfactuals. In his *History of Civilization in England* (1858), Buckle supported his claim that precise combinations of “heat and moisture” were preconditions for civilization by pointing to the United States and hypothesizing that “if the sandy plains of California ... had been irrigated by the rivers of the [American] east ... the result ... would have been that exuberance of soil ... by which every early civilization was preceded.”²⁴⁴ Buckle also used temporal counterfactuals to support his claim that historical change could only arrive at preordained moments. In writing about England’s repeal of the Corn Laws in 1846, he praised the work of the Anti-Corn Law League but noted that its members “could ... only slightly hasten what the progress of knowledge rendered inevitable,” writing that “if they had lived a century earlier, they would have been altogether powerless, because the age would not have been ripe for their labours.”²⁴⁵ These examples reflected Buckle’s belief that structure outweighed agency in shaping historical events.²⁴⁶

The wide-ranging British scholar Herbert Spencer took a similar view. Spencer’s embrace of determinism was visible in many areas—especially in his views on evolution—but his 1877 book *The Study of Sociology* employed a sociological version to debunk the belief that great men shaped the course of history. In seeking to prove that man “is powerless in the absence of ... co-existing ... social arrangements,” Spencer used a variety of deterministic

counterfactuals.²⁴⁷ Pointing to William Shakespeare, Spencer declared: “what dramas could he have written without the multitudinous traditions of civilized life ... [and] without the language which a hundred generations had developed?” Speaking of the Scottish inventor James Watt, Spencer declared “Suppose [he lived]... in a tribe ignorant of iron ... what chance would there have been of the steam-engine?” These and other “what ifs” illustrated Spencer’s claim that “the great-man theory [all too often]... leaves out of sight ... the number and the quality of his followers.”²⁴⁸

Yet while the work of these positivist thinkers supports the contention that determinism inhibits counterfactual thought, the case of John Stuart Mill provides evidence to the contrary (Figure 2.5). Mill was an empirically minded determinist who believed that scientific laws guided the behavior of human beings. At the same time, he was a committed individualist who insisted that human beings had the freedom to impact the world according to “the laws of nature of the individual man.”²⁴⁹ Mill thus rejected the belief that structurally determined economic and social forces were paramount in guiding historical events. Like Carlyle, Mill supported the “great man” theory of history, arguing that “the volitions of exceptional persons ... [are] indispensable links in the chain of causation.”²⁵⁰ But Mill abandoned Carlyle’s belief in divine Providence and embraced a perspective that was wholly secular.²⁵¹ Rather than viewing counterfactuals as a “vanity,” he understood their utility.

Mill embraced “what ifs” to support his commitment to individual freedom. In his book *A System of Logic Ratiocinative and Inductive Part II* (1843), Mill explained the significance of “great men” by showing what would have transpired in their absence. It was wrong for determinists to claim that “because any one great man might have had his place supplied by other great men ... all great men could have been dispensed with.”²⁵² For example, it made little sense to speculate that “If Columbus ... had never lived, America would still have been discovered ... a few years later” or “if Newton had never lived, some other person would have discovered the law of gravitation.”²⁵³ While Mill conceded that “these things [eventually] would have been done,” he argued that they would not have taken place until “someone had again been found with the qualities of Columbus or Newton.” Moreover, some individuals were irreplaceable. As he put it, “had there been no Socrates, no Plato, and no Aristotle, there would have been no philosophy for the next two thousand years;... if there had been no Christ, and no St. Paul, there would have been no Christianity.”²⁵⁴ In using these and other counterfactuals to underscore the importance of individual agency in history, Mill became one of the first social scientists to see the value of “what ifs” and employ them in his analytical work.²⁵⁵

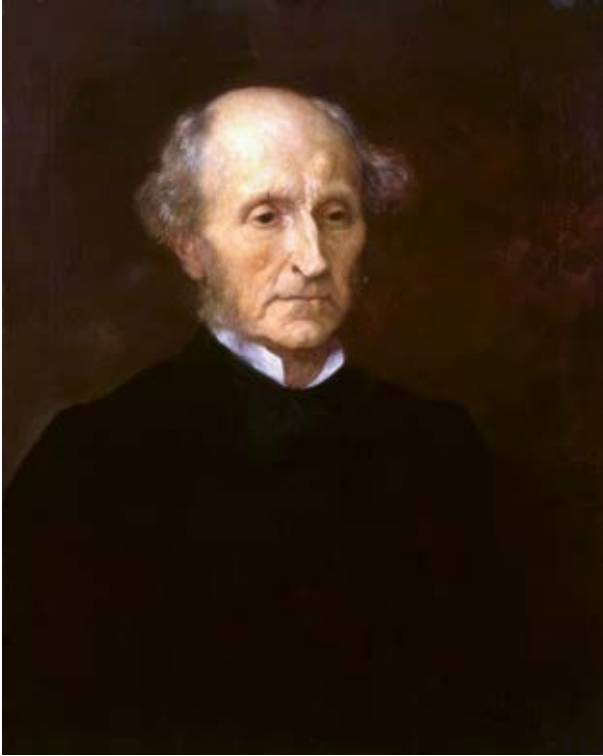


FIGURE 2.5 To emphasize his belief in the significance of great men in history, John Stuart Mill used “what ifs” to show what would have transpired in their absence. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

The Revival of Counterfactualism: Burckhardt, Nietzsche, and Weber

While the case of Mill reveals that deterministic thinkers had the capacity to explore counterfactuals, most of the thinkers who used them were hostile to determinism. Significantly, the number of such thinkers increased after the middle of the century, when Europeans turned away from determinism, along with the providential, teleological, and theodical attitudes associated with it. During this period, European thinkers showed an increasing appreciation of chance and entertained the belief that history could have easily turned out differently. This development reflected an intellectual shift from epistemological confidence to epistemological doubt.

The decline of determinism was fueled by a variety of factors. The social and cultural upheaval caused by the Industrial Revolution after the middle of the nineteenth century accelerated the secularization of European life and undermined the traditional belief in divine Providence. Around the same time, Charles Darwin's Theory of Evolution—and its belief that chance mutations determined which species lived or died—challenged the theodical faith in God's benevolence and the teleological idea that evolution led to progress.²⁵⁶ In the world of politics, liberal optimism about the inevitable spread of democracy faded thanks to the failed revolutions of 1848, the rise of the socialist movement, and the late nineteenth-century "crisis of liberalism." Added to these trends was the intellectual revolt against positivism and its assertion that human beings were governed less by natural laws than subjective, irrational forces.

In the field of history, these developments found their counterpart in the "crisis of historicism." By asserting that all knowledge was filtered through consciousness, historians increasingly recognized that historical representation could not avoid being subjective and presentist in nature. Historians thus confronted the worrisome possibility that historical truth was unattainable and ultimately relative. This crisis not only challenged historians' epistemological confidence but changed their narrative style. As Hayden White has argued, early and mid-nineteenth century historiography had been composed in a "heroic" mode and employed the tropes of romance or comedy, both of which reflected the era's self-confident belief in progress.²⁵⁷ With the crisis of historicism, however, historians began to write in a more "ironic" mode. Newly pessimistic about the possibility of determining truth and increasingly skeptical about the efficacy of historical study, they embraced the idea that history's course was ultimately ironic—that the best laid plans of human beings, accompanied by the loftiest of expectations, were all too often crushed by reality. This ironic mindset sought to make sense of the inexplicable in a secular age. What earlier, religiously-minded eras understood in terms of theodicy—as a product of divine will—secular Europeans now understood as irony.

This intellectual rupture encouraged "what if" thinking in several ways. By eroding the causal power of deterministic forces—whether religious or scientific—the new skeptical mindset eroded the teleological belief that history had to proceed in a particular direction and opened new opportunities for imagining alternate paths of historical development. The new mindset was especially important for deemphasizing the causal role of impersonal, structural forces and elevating the role of individual agency and chance. This development allowed historians to reassert the familiar, though somewhat dormant, belief that small causes could have major consequences. The attendant crisis

of historicism, by making historians more conscious of relativism, liberated them from rigid empiricism and encouraged them to engage in historical speculation. So did the narrative shift to irony. By exposing the frequent contradiction between the intentions of historical actors and the results of their actions (a condition known as “situational irony”), the new mindset encouraged the counterfactual tendency to explore the causal role of accidents and other contingent events. Moreover, the fact that ironic modes of narration tend to be self-aware and self-negating (a trait known as “verbal irony”) meant that historians were no longer obliged merely to show how the past “really was” through fact-based mimesis. Instead, they could explore history’s constructedness and self-reflexively highlight their own authorial departure from traditional modes of narration. They could move from the cult of the fact to the counterfactual.

Before long, historians took note of these changes and began to self-consciously embrace counterfactuals in their work. In the half-century between 1850 and 1900, major thinkers began to explore “what ifs.” Three figures from the German speaking world were especially prominent: Jacob Burckhardt, Friedrich Nietzsche, and Max Weber. Not only did they speculate with greater frequency than earlier, more deterministic, thinkers, they did so in more systematic fashion.

Jacob Burckhardt

Jacob Burckhardt’s penchant for counterfactual thinking reflected his anomalous status among nineteenth-century historians (Figure 2.6). Although he was celebrated around the turn of the century as one of the era’s most important scholars, he had ceased publishing already in 1860 and was, in many ways, ahead of his time.²⁵⁸ Whereas most mid-century historians were deterministically minded and believed in progress, Burckhardt was influenced by the bleak philosophy of Arthur Schopenhauer and rejected all teleological philosophies of history.²⁵⁹ Unlike most of his peers, Burckhardt also viewed history not as a science but an art.²⁶⁰ Although he studied with Leopold von Ranke and Gustav Droysen in Berlin in the early 1840s, he rejected their faith in objectivity and realized that historians cited facts selectively in their narratives, often according to arbitrary and subjective criteria.²⁶¹ Burckhardt, as a result, fully embraced presentism. That said, he rejected its Whiggish incarnation in favor of a version that was more critical and pessimistic. One reason for this was Burckhardt’s skepticism towards liberalism. While most historians in Germany, England, and France held liberal or republican beliefs, Burckhardt was a conservative elitist. Having grown up in a patrician family in Basel, Switzerland, he was shocked by the violence that accompanied the

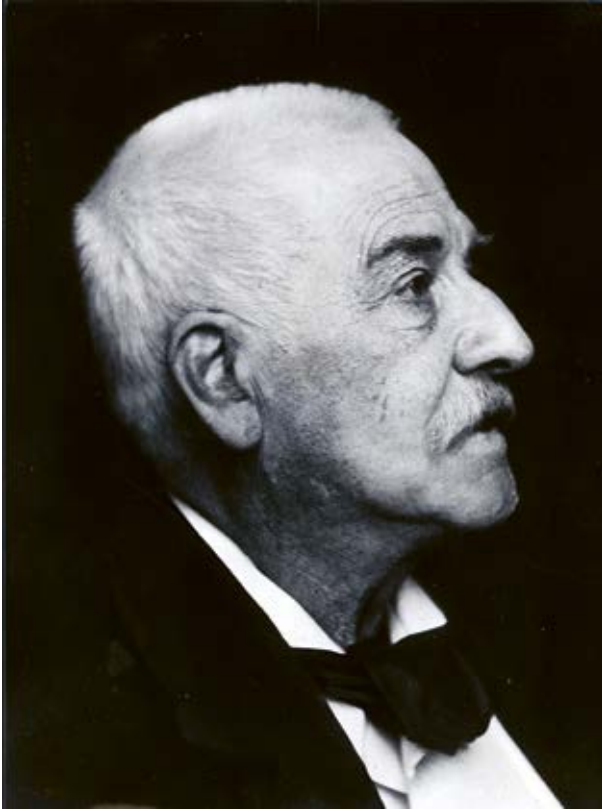


FIGURE 2.6 Jacob Burckhardt used counterfactuals to criticize determinism, cast doubt on progress, emphasize the importance of great men, and highlight the ironies of history. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

toppling of the city's oligarchy in the Revolution of 1848 and lacked his colleagues' faith in the capacity of the masses for rational political behavior.²⁶² At the same time, Burckhardt also rejected nationalism. Having been disillusioned by its effects on Germany after the country's victory over France in 1871, he focused his ensuing work less on the history of nation states than the achievements of western culture.²⁶³

Burckhardt's paramount interest was human freedom.²⁶⁴ Like Carlyle, he believed in the importance of great men.²⁶⁵ But he was more secular in orientation and deemphasized the role of Providence.²⁶⁶ As a result, Burckhardt appreciated the role of chance in history.²⁶⁷ There were no general laws, no moral lessons, that emerged from historical study.²⁶⁸ Expressing the era's embrace of irony, Burckhardt believed that the point of history was that there

was no point.²⁶⁹ With so much left to chance, Burckhardt embraced the belief that everything in history might have been different.

Burckhardt employed a great number of counterfactuals in his scholarly work. Some appeared in his classic study *The Civilization of the Renaissance in Italy* (1860), but the great majority appeared in his university lectures on European history from antiquity to the modern era, which he delivered between the years 1865 and 1885, and which were later published in two anthologies: *Judgments on History and Historians* (originally published in German as *Historische Fragmente* in 1929) and its companion volume, *Force and Freedom* (originally published in German as *Weltgeschichtliche Betrachtungen* in 1905). Several reasons explain Burckhardt's growing willingness to wonder "what if" over the course of his scholarly career. First, counterfactuals were less in vogue when he was working on his Renaissance volume than in the subsequent decades when he delivered his university lectures. Second, since his lectures were far more sweeping in scope than his empirically grounded monographs, they permitted a greater range of interpretative judgements and counterfactual reflections. Burckhardt used many kinds of "what ifs" in his work: short form and medium form, analytical and literary, declarative and interrogative. Although he never developed a systematic method for employing counterfactual scenarios, he applied them to a range of themes.

Burckhardt frequently used "what ifs" to question the notion of progress. He illustrated his pessimism about modernity by praising medieval Europeans for their lack of "national wars [and] mass industry," writing that "if [they]... had mined hard coal" and "exploited the earth's surface as we are doing, we would perhaps not be around at all."²⁷⁰ Burckhardt nevertheless viewed the Renaissance as an important advance beyond the Middle Ages, arguing that if the "elegiac" people who yearned for a return to the medieval world "could pass but one hour in [that world],... they would gasp to be back in modern air."²⁷¹ While Burckhardt was grateful for the benefits of the Renaissance, he regretted they had been curtailed by the Reformation. In seeking to understand why Italy had produced "no Shakespeare," he blamed the onset of Spanish rule over sixteenth-century Italy, lamenting that "had not the Counter-Reformation and the rule of foreigners intervened," Italian drama might have ascended to greatness.²⁷² Burckhardt regretted that the notorious Renaissance *condottiero* and cardinal Cesare Borgia had not secularized Italy more dramatically. Drawing on Niccolò Machiavelli's sixteenth-century counterfactual speculations in *The Prince* about Borgia's missed opportunity to conquer and unify Italy's warring states in the early 1500s, Burckhardt speculated that Borgia's ability to eliminate his rivals "could have secularized the States of the Church" and might have "ended in

the ruin of the Papacy" if "he had not ... been laid upon a sickbed" when his father, Pope Alexander VI, died in 1506.²⁷³

Burckhardt also used "what ifs" to illustrate the importance of great men in history. In discussing the role of key individuals in the Reformation, for instance, he wondered "what [its]... course ... [would] have been without Luther," hypothesizing that "without the pig-headedness ... of this one man, everything [in European religious life] might have gone back to status quo."²⁷⁴ Burckhardt made a similar case for notable individuals in the Wars of Religion. He questioned the belief that, during the Thirty Years War, "German Protestantism [was]... saved only by the appearance of the Swedes" under the command of Gustavus Adolphus, by exploring what would have happened "without this horrible remedy."²⁷⁵ His answer was that Protestantism would have survived anyway, for the renegade commander of Catholic forces, Albrecht von Wallenstein, "would have ... asserted his command over North Germany" but ignored "the Edict of Restitution ... because of his army's indifference to creed."²⁷⁶ Finally, like Thomas Carlyle, Burckhardt explored the role of Louis XVI at Varennes, speculating that "If he had ... furnished an example of defiance of death, he would have found a great many more defenders," concluding that "if there had been even a little of Henry IV in him ... [and], if he had mounted a horse, he could have turned the blow planned against him to his advantage."²⁷⁷

Burckhardt also speculated to reveal the ironies of history. He often used silver lining counterfactuals to show how destructive conflicts often had beneficial consequences. Burckhardt praised the ancient Romans' persecution of Christians, for instance, saying that they served as a "uniting force" and speculating that "without the last persecutions under Decius, Valerian, and others, [the church]... would have split into ... sects and paganism would then probably have overpowered them."²⁷⁸ He also showed how Britain's loss in the American Revolution proved beneficial, writing that if "the Americans [had] initially ... been defeated ... the whole political and economic life of England would have had to be oriented toward the permanent suppression of America ... and England would have become a ... military state."²⁷⁹ Burckhardt also revealed how victories could actually be defeats, arguing that the Jacobins achieved the opposite of what they wanted by executing Louis XVI, speculating that "a Louis XVI roaming about abroad would have been a hundred times less dangerous than the beheaded Louis with the martyrdom of his family."²⁸⁰ In all these ways, Burckhardt exposed the ironic fact that historical outcomes often ran counter to people's intentions.

For this reason, Burckhardt opposed the presentist tendency to draw moral lessons from history. In his essay "On Fortune and Misfortune in History" (1871),

he used counterfactuals to show how “historical judgments of good and evil” were inherently subjective and, as a result, important to avoid.²⁸¹ There was no point in calling certain historical eras “happy” and other ones “unhappy,” he noted, since categorizing events as either one or the other was impossible outside of one’s moral values, political principles, and cultural ideals.²⁸² This was especially true since the passage of time often turned unhappy events into their opposite. Burckhardt cautiously illustrated this ironic “law of compensation” with multiple counterfactuals.²⁸³ He pointed out that, although the rule of the fourteenth-century Mongol warlord Timur was “devastating” for Asia, “without him,” the Turkish forces of “[the Ottoman Sultan] Bazajet and the [Bohemian] Hussites ... [would have] hurl[ed]... themselves simultaneously at Germany and Italy.”²⁸⁴ Similarly, although the loss of countless “relics of history” had been painful, Burckhardt said that, “if in the fifteenth century, vast numbers of well-preserved Greek sculptures had been discovered, Leonardo, Raphael, [and] Titian ... would not have done their work ... in their own way.” Understanding history’s ironies, according to Burckhardt, was preferable to making claims about “good and evil fortune.”²⁸⁵

Most ironic of all, however, was the fact that Burckhardt often stopped short of exploring the full potential of his counterfactual scenarios. He usually kept his imagination within limits and explicitly spoke out against fashioning additive effect counterfactuals. He said it was “beyond all speculation,” for instance, to imagine how the world would have developed “without Islam.”²⁸⁶ He insisted that “it is impossible to judge how desirable [a] delay [in the Reformation] may have been.”²⁸⁷ He argued that “We do not know what might have happened without the helpful storm in the Channel” when Spain’s Armada attacked England.²⁸⁸ And he declared that “It is impossible to say how things would have gone [in the French Revolution] without the guillotine.”²⁸⁹

Despite this hesitancy, however, Burckhardt nevertheless produced medium form, additive effect counterfactuals on certain occasions. In writing about the rule of King Richard III in England, for instance, Burckhardt wrote an extended literary monologue in which the King explained how much worse things would have been for England if he had not murdered his enemies (Figure 2.7). Declaring it was a “necessity for me to seize the crown and [order]... the disappearance of my nephews,” Richard III justified his actions in Burckhardt’s narrative by saying “[imagine] how things would be without me? The so-called friends of my brother and my sister-in-law’s relatives would now be giving battle to one another in the name of Edward V and in the end there wouldn’t be anyone left who was ... qualified to hold aloft the banner of England.”²⁹⁰ Burckhardt also produced several medium form counterfactuals about Oliver Cromwell’s role in the English Civil War—one of which imagined his absence



FIGURE 2.7 One of Jacob Burckhardt's more notable counterfactuals was an extended literary monologue that imagined King Richard III declaring how much worse things would have been for England if he had not murdered his enemies. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

from history and the other depicting him living longer.²⁹¹ Burckhardt, in short, displayed more than his share of inconsistency in employing counterfactuals, giving them free rein despite having reservations about their limitations.

Friedrich Nietzsche

Burckhardt had a major impact on the counterfactual thinking of a second major figure in the latter part of the nineteenth century, Friedrich Nietzsche (Figure 2.8). Like Burckhardt, Nietzsche was influenced by the writings of

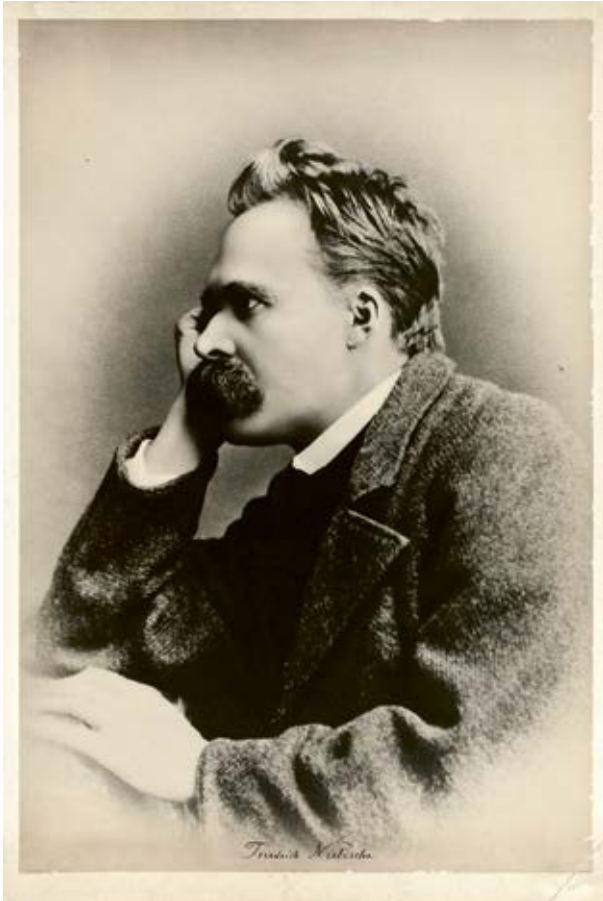


FIGURE 2.8 Friedrich Nietzsche used counterfactuals to criticize Christianity (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Arthur Schopenhauer and firmly rejected deterministic, teleological, and theological views of the past. Whether Hegel's theory of the rational World Spirit, the Prussian Historians' view of the state, or the Christian belief in Divine Providence, these views, according to Nietzsche, endorsed a false view of progress that lulled people into complacency. Nietzsche also believed that contemporary historical writing, especially in Germany, had become stale due to its increasingly scientific and scholarly orientation. In his essay "On the Use and Abuse of History for Life" (1873), he sought to replace "monumental" and "antiquarian" models of history" with a more "critical" mode of historical writing informed by artistic considerations. By employing "ingenious," defamiliarizing methods of representation, Nietzsche believed that history could be remythologized, regain its creative

potential, and be made relevant once more for present-day life.²⁹² To a notable degree, he sought to achieve this goal with the aid of counterfactuals. Nietzsche used many kinds of “what ifs” in his philosophical writings, but they all served two larger purposes: to show that history was shaped by the will of great men and to analyze key turning points in the history of western civilization.

Nietzsche first endorsed counterfactuals in his 1874 essay “We Philologists,” which was posthumously published in his collection of essays *Untimely Meditations*.²⁹³ In this essay, he criticized European historians for being overly triumphalistic in depicting the history of classical antiquity and sparing it any “critical consideration.”²⁹⁴ The main exception, Nietzsche suggested, was Jacob Burckhardt, who refused to be “humbled” by the era’s “stupid theories.” Nietzsche’s reference to the Swiss historian was significant, for immediately after complementing him, Nietzsche explicitly praised counterfactuals, declaring: “the question ‘what would have been the consequence if so and so had not happened?’... is the cardinal question, which makes everything ironical.”²⁹⁵ The placement and phrasing of this sentence leaves little doubt that Nietzsche was influenced by Burckhardt’s frequent use of “what ifs.” There is also little doubt that Nietzsche endorsed counterfactuals to challenge the optimistic tenor of his era’s prevailing historical worldview. By showing how history might have been different, and by exposing certain ironies about the past, Nietzsche hoped to advance his reformist cultural agenda.

Nietzsche commonly used counterfactuals in his campaign against Christianity. While he famously derided Christianity in his writings, Nietzsche admired Jesus as one of history’s great men, noting that his “glad tidings” about the need for people to live an egalitarian, simple life, at one with God, represented a momentous message for all humanity.²⁹⁶ As Nietzsche went on to argue, however, Jesus’s “decadent” followers prevented him from realizing the full potential of his “will to power” and kept him from producing a more life-affirming religion.²⁹⁷ In his book *Thus Spoke Zarathustra*, Nietzsche used a fast-forward counterfactual to comment on the timing of Jesus’s death, writing

Verily, too early died that Hebrew whom the preachers of slow death honour: and to many hath it proved a calamity that he died too early. As yet had he known only ... the melancholy of the Hebrews, together with the hatred of the good and just ...

Had he but remained in the wilderness, and far from the good and just! Then, perhaps, would he have learned to live, and love the earth—and laughter also!

Believe it, my brethren! He died too early; he himself would have disavowed his doctrine had he attained to my age! Noble enough was he to disavow!

But he was still immature ...²⁹⁸

If only Jesus had lived longer, Nietzsche fantasized, Christianity never would have taken the form it did.

In explaining why Christianity betrayed the ideals of Jesus, Nietzsche blamed another key individual, Paul of Tarsus. Because of the latter's obsession with sin and injection of "resentment" into Christianity, Paul proved to be a "dysangelist," a "genius for hatred," who corrupted Jesus's evangelical message and undermined the Roman Empire's reigning movement of Epicureanism, which held that life should be lived in pursuit of simple, modest pleasures.²⁹⁹ Noting that Epicurus "opposed ... 'Christianity[']... emphasis on "guilt, punishment and immortality," Nietzsche speculated that "Epicurus would have won" the battle of ideas at the time, since "every mind of any account in the Roman Empire was an Epicurean."³⁰⁰ But it was not meant to be—for, as Nietzsche explained, "then Paul appeared."³⁰¹ It was he who transvalued all European values and redirected them towards concepts that Nietzsche abhorred—for instance, the concepts of the afterlife and immortality, which he believed drained European culture of its natural, affirmative power and denied them the possibility of enjoying happiness on earth. Had only Epicureanism survived, Nietzsche mused, Christianity's adverse impact on European life would have been avoided.

Nietzsche also believed Europeans had missed opportunities to limit Christianity during the Italian Renaissance. Convinced that the Renaissance was "the last great age" because its leading proponents embraced a secular mindset and sought to "revalue" and replace "Christian *values* ... [with] *countervales*," Nietzsche argued in *Twilight of the Idols* (1889) that the famed artist Michelangelo best expressed this secular mindset, certainly more so than his overtly religious contemporary, Raphael.³⁰² Yet as Michelangelo aged, Nietzsche wrote, the artist unfortunately surrendered to the "eternally feminine dimension of Christianity" and failed to realize his potential. "On the basis of his ideals," Nietzsche hypothesized, Michelangelo "should have destroyed Christianity, but was not enough of a ... philosopher to do so."³⁰³

Nietzsche also used "what ifs" to discuss the Renaissance ruler Cesare Borgia (Figure 2.9). Viewing Borgia as a "kind of superman" who embodied the martial, heroic, and pagan virtues that existed in the Roman Empire before Christianity, Nietzsche viewed him as an antidote to his own "weak age" and its "tender" men.³⁰⁴ To emphasize this point, Nietzsche used a Rip van Winkle counterfactual to complain that "we moderns, with our thickly padded humanity, which at all costs wants to avoid bumping into a stone, would have provided Cesare Borgia's contemporaries with a comedy at which they could have laughed themselves to death."³⁰⁵ So tough and "ruthless" was Borgia that Nietzsche believed he could have overcome and perhaps even destroyed



FIGURE 2.9 Friedrich Nietzsche fantasized that Christianity could have been destroyed if Cesare Borgia had become Pope. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Christianity. In *The Antichrist* (1895), Nietzsche imagined how Borgia might have pursued this goal, hypothesizing: “I see a spectacle so rich in significance ... that it should arouse all the gods on Olympus to laughter—*Caesar Borgia as pope!*... Am I understood?... Well then, *that* would have been the sort of triumph that *I* alone am longing for today ... [for] by it, Christianity would have been *swept away!*”³⁰⁶

Unfortunately, Nietzsche noted, one last notable individual came onto the scene and prevented this from happening—Martin Luther. When “Luther came to Rome ... and raised a rebellion against the Renaissance,” Nietzsche explained in the *Antichrist*, he helped revive Christianity by establishing “the uncleanest variety ... that exists ... Protestantism.”³⁰⁷ In so doing, Luther smothered the Renaissance’s progressive features with the “backward German spirit.”³⁰⁸ Missed opportunities surrounded this tragic turn. Noting that Luther benefited from “an extraordinary constellation of politics,” in which German

princes protected him from the reach of the Emperor, Nietzsche speculated that “without this curious counter-play of intentions, Luther would have been burnt like [the Bohemian preacher, Jan] Huss.”³⁰⁹ Had this happened, Nietzsche fantasized, “the morning sun of enlightenment would probably have risen somewhat earlier, and with a splendour more beauteous than we can now imagine.”³¹⁰ The failure to realize this fantasy had terrible consequences for European culture by “delay[ing] for two or three centuries the complete awakening and mastery of the sciences,” thereby importing into the modern world the intolerant and fanatical Protestant belief that absolute truth can be asserted through pure conviction.³¹¹ “If all those who thought so highly of their convictions ... had only devoted half of their energy to examining their right to adhere to this or that conviction,” Nietzsche lamented, “how peaceable would the history of mankind now appear!”³¹²

Max Weber

Like Burckhardt and Nietzsche, Max Weber also employed counterfactuals in his work (Figure 2.10). He, too, opposed determinism, rejected progress, and believed that history was shaped by presentist concerns. Weber was deeply affected by the turn of the century “crisis of historicism,” yet like other German scholars at the time, he responded not by surrendering to subjectivity but by devising new methods of preserving the ideal of objectivity.³¹³ Just as he created the concept of an “ideal type” as an “analytical construct” (*Gedankenbild*) to make sense of reality, he invited scholars to embrace counterfactuals—or what he called “objective possibility”—as a method of understanding causality.³¹⁴ In several essays around the year 1900, especially “The Logic of the Cultural Sciences,” Weber contributed to a broader methodological debate (*Methodenstreit*) in Germany about the epistemological differences between the natural sciences and the humanities, along with the role of thought experiments in the quest for truth.³¹⁵ Crucially, Weber did not merely see a role for counterfactuals in this debate; he was the first scholar to present a rationale and method for employing them.

Weber’s embrace of counterfactuals was partly a response to what he saw as their improper use by the historian Eduard Meyer (Figure 2.11). A well-known German scholar of antiquity, Meyer opposed deterministic tendencies in modern historical scholarship and believed that chance, free will, and individual motivation drove historical events.³¹⁶ In advancing this view, Meyer often employed “what ifs.” In his multi-volume *History of Antiquity* (1884–1902), for example, he endorsed the view that the Greeks’ victories over the Persians in the Battles of Marathon and Salamis were crucial for the “evolution of world history,” speculating that “if the Persians had won ... they would have imposed



FIGURE 2.10 AND 2.11 Max Weber embraced counterfactual reasoning partly as a response to what he saw as its improper use by the historian, Eduard Meyer. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

a theocratic kind of rule on the Greeks ... and Greek thought would have been ... permanently blocked from soaring to the highest regions of human ... activity.”³¹⁷ Meyer also used “what ifs” to support Carlyle’s “great man” theory of history. In his book *Theory and Method of History* (1902), Meyer noted that “individuals who were historically significant for their acts of will” were sufficiently influential that “if another man had stood in their place, the course of history would have taken a different form.”³¹⁸ To emphasize the “historical importance of resolution of will,” Meyer noted how Hannibal, Frederick the Great, and Bismarck all made key decisions in the second Punic War, Seven Years War, and Austro-Prussian War of 1866, speculating that “they all could have decided differently, and other figures would have decided differently in their place; the result would have been that history’s course would have been different.”³¹⁹ Yet, Meyer stopped short of fully embracing counterfactual speculation, noting that the related question of whether the “wars would not have occurred” was a “an unanswerable and superfluous question.”³²⁰ Indeed, he added in another context that counterfactual “speculation ... did not belong in history.”³²¹

In response, Weber criticized Meyer for his inconsistent use of counterfactuals and sought to determine their proper place in social science research. Referring to Meyer’s dismissal of “what ifs” in his *Theory and Method of History*,

Weber declared that “the problem [of] what might have happened ... is by no means an ‘idle’ one” but had tremendous bearing on the “causal significance” that scholars assigned to an “individual decision in the context of the totality of infinitely numerous ‘factors.’”³²² “If history is to be raised above ... a mere chronicle of notable events and personalities,” he declared, “it has no alternative but to pose such questions.” Weber’s mode of examining this question was to examine the motivations that any “acting person weighs insofar as he acts rationally” in a given historical situation, and to “retrospectively carry out the same calculation which [that person]... could have performed [differently].” In so doing, he argued, the historian “is able to consider ... which consequences were to be anticipated had another decision been taken.”³²³

Weber pursued this goal by embracing the concept of “objective possibility.” As he argued, historians sought to understand “historical causality” with an eye not just towards how a specific cause produced a specific effect but how the effect had “‘important’ consequences for world history.”³²⁴ Weber argued that determining this matter required “a series of *abstractions*” involving counterfactual reasoning. As he explained, “the ... decisive [abstraction]... occurs when we *conceive* of one or a few of the actual causal components as modified in a certain direction and then ask ourselves whether under the conditions which have thus been changed, the same effect ... or some other effect ‘would be expected.’” Such reasoning involved competing “possibilities.” Weber addressed Meyer’s example of the Battle of Marathon and said that its significance rested in the possibility of two very different “possibilities”—one leading to “the development of a theocratic-religious culture,” the other leading to “the triumph of the free Hellenic circle of ideas.” For Weber, historians used such possibilities all the time to assign significance to events. As a result, they need not “ask ... to be forgiven their use ... of [such]... [an] anti-deterministic category” but should openly embrace the reality that “judgments of possibility” are indispensable for producing knowledge of any “value.”³²⁵ Weber rejected the claim that “judgments of possibility regarding what ‘would’ have happened ... cannot be arrived at” without falling victim to “subjective arbitrariness,” saying that historians could use their imagination to arrive at valid judgments of possibility by following certain “empirical rules” rooted in “nomological knowledge,” or what he called the “laws of events.”³²⁶ In order to assess the significance of “Bismarck’s ‘decision’” to go to war in 1866, for example, a historian could remove it as a cause and then see how “the other remaining determinants would ... have” shaped events.³²⁷ The result, Weber said, could be safely designated as “cases of ‘adequate’ causation.”³²⁸

Weber did not view “what ifs” as a free for all. He felt most secure crafting subtractive cause counterfactuals, writing that it was undeniable that “if a

single historical fact is conceived as absent from or modified in a complex of historical conditions, it *would* condition a course of historical events [that]... would be different in certain ... respects.”³²⁹ By contrast, he rejected additive effect counterfactuals, writing that “the attempt to construct in a positive way what ‘would’ have happened can ... lead to grotesque results.”³³⁰ In this regard, Weber more closely resembled Burckhardt than Nietzsche. Nevertheless, he was, by far and away, the most advanced thinker to identify the importance of “what ifs” for determining the workings of causality.

Counterfactualism in Western Culture: New Definitions, New Debates

At the same time that counterfactuals were gaining prominence in western thought, they were also finding a place in western culture. Especially in print culture—journalism, poetry, and literature—speculating about the past became an increasingly common and self-conscious activity. The new prominence of counterfactual thought was revealed by its acquisition of a proper name. In the years after 1850, Anglo-American writers employed a variety of terms for counterfactual history, including “hypothetical histories,” “imaginary histories,” and “historical ‘ifs.’”³³¹ The most popular, however, was “might-have-beens.” While the subjunctive phrase, “might have been,” along with the related phrase, “would have been,” had long been conjoined with specific verbs in English to describe hypothetical actions, neither phrase was used as a compound noun until the 1800s.³³² The most influential use of the term was Thomas Carlyle’s reference to the “vanity” of “would-have-beens” in his book *The French Revolution* (1837).³³³ Thanks to Carlyle’s literary reputation and wide readership in the English speaking world, the term “might-have-beens (or the un-hyphenated, italicized alternative, “*might have beens*”) began appearing after the 1860s and spread quickly. This development was not viewed with unanimity, however, as the rise of counterfactuals sparked debate in the Anglo-American world between enthusiastic supporters and fierce critics.

The Supporters

In 1864, the English writer Francis Jacox helped launch the debate on “what ifs” by publishing a noteworthy article entitled, “Historical Might, Could, Should, or Would Have Beens.”³³⁴ The essay was the first since Isaac Disraeli’s pioneering article forty years earlier to aggregate recent instances of counterfactual speculation and highlight the phenomenon as a noteworthy trend. In the article, Jacox conceded that most people viewed “what ifs” as “futile and

frivolous.”³³⁵ But he defended counterfactuals as inherently appealing, asking “what writer ... [can help] but ... pause ... in his narrative of actual events ... on what might have been, had but things taken another turn?”³³⁶ Especially as it gave rise to “illimitable potentialities,” he noted, historical speculation was “one of the most interesting ... of all branches of human inquiry.”³³⁷ Jacox noted that “what ifs” not only had a long lineage but were becoming increasingly popular, pointing to the pioneering writings of Lord Bolingbroke and Disraeli and praising Thomas Macaulay for his willingness to “indulge ... in speculative surmise.”³³⁸ While Jacox praised British scholars for using counterfactuals, he noted that “the French are at least as fond as any other people of speculating in historical might-have-beens,” with figures like Chateaubriand, Michelet, and Lamartine being the most notable.³³⁹ Most of Jacox’s essay was a descriptive survey of counterfactual claims found in the work of recent British and French writers, but he concluded his analysis on a polemical note by exposing the hypocrisy of writers who used “what ifs” while simultaneously condemning them. Jacox especially criticized Carlyle for branding counterfactuals a “vanity,” while frequently employing them himself, noting that “when *he* is in the mood, the contingencies of the subjunctive are not without interest to him.”³⁴⁰

Several years after the appearance of Jacox’s essay, the British writer John Timbs also commented on the popularity of “what if” thinking (Figure 2.12). In an essay entitled “The ‘Ifs’ of History” that appeared in his 1869 anthology *Historic Ninepins: A Book of Curiosities*, Timbs declared that the question “what would have happened” if “something happened which didn’t happen?” was “now very much in fashion.”³⁴¹ Like Jacox, Timbs did not try to explain the new trend but merely aggregated instances of it in the works of European thinkers from the past (Pascal and Disraeli) and present (John Stuart Mill). But Timbs hinted at one possible reason why “what ifs” were in fashion. In the preface to *Historic Ninepins*, he linked his anthology to a new spirit that was marking historical thought in Europe—one in which historians were “reversing the settled verdict of past centuries” by producing popular revisionist studies, such as Joseph Octave Delepierre’s *Historical Difficulties and Contested Events* (1868) and Timbs’s own study, *Popular Errors Explained and Illustrated* (1858).³⁴² Timbs implied in “The ‘Ifs’ of History” that counterfactuals could contribute to this larger revisionist effort by showing how historical events were guided not merely by deterministic, but contingent, forces, writing that “even the strictest believer in universal causation may admit that ... the most trivial circumstances may be of cardinal importance” in guiding the course of history.³⁴³ Timbs made this point explicitly in a second essay, entitled “Great Events From Little Causes,” which used “what ifs” to highlight the importance of chance in history—for example, the possibility that “Martin Luther might have been a lawyer had his ... companion escaped the thunder-storm at Erfurt.”³⁴⁴ Timbs



FIGURE 2.12 In his 1869 essay, “The ‘Ifs’ of History,” John Timbs noted that “what ifs” were “very much in fashion.” (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

made this claim and others in the spirit of Disraeli and Mill—as useful epistemological tools for determining the truth of history. Although he acknowledged counterfactuals could be flawed, he believed they could help establish historical truth if they were empirically grounded.³⁴⁵

Another writer who boosted attention to counterfactuals was the Irish historian William Edward Hartpole Lecky.³⁴⁶ In his celebrated study *A History of England in the Eighteenth Century* (1878), Lecky revisited many of the counterfactuals floated by early Whig historians about the Glorious Revolution but changed their deterministic framing to foreground “the importance of accident in history.” Indeed, Lecky developed this idea into a larger historical philosophy, noting that there were many examples where “a slight change in the disposition of circumstances, or in the action of individuals, would have altered the whole course of history.” Citing many moments when history might have been different—for instance, “if ... the invasion of Xerxes had succeeded,... If Mahomet had been killed in one of the first skirmishes of his career, [or if]

Charles Martel been defeated at the battle of Poitiers”—Lecky’s essay received lots of attention in the British press.³⁴⁷ In an 1879 review article, entitled “Events that Never Happened,” one writer praised Lecky for doing what Disraeli had done a generation earlier in calling attention to “the subject of *If*.”³⁴⁸ Other reviewers praised Lecky for “tracing up great events to accidents” and confirming “there is an immeasurable amount of a charm about a good ‘if.’”³⁴⁹

The trendspotting essays of Jacox, Timbs, and Lecky helped the British public recognize the utility of counterfactuals. As early as the 1860s, British commentators rediscovered Disraeli’s pioneering essay from 1823, with one writer underscoring the “significance ... [of] that little phrase—‘What might have been!’” and noting that the number of possible “might have beens” could not be contained “under a [single] volume.”³⁵⁰ Other British writers around the same time realized that counterfactual history was an increasingly international phenomenon, with one observer in 1859 writing that “‘Frenchmen are skillful in writing ... the history of events which have not happened.’”³⁵¹

In the decades that followed, comments in the Anglo-American press continued to confirm the popularity of counterfactuals. In 1870, an American literary critic wrote that “there are never wanting persons, who ... are always conjuring up what would have been if things had happened differently. If Charles I had not lost his head, if Napoleon had beaten at Waterloo, if Booth’s pistol had missed fire [and so forth].”³⁵² Other commentators praised “what ifs” for highlighting the role of accident in history. In 1879, a British journal asserted that in the realms of “scientific discovery and mechanical invention,” accident plays a major role, declaring that “If [Thomas]... Edison had not pricked his finger while experimenting on the telephone” he would not have seen how “the little spot of blood [was]... affected by the ... vibrating diaphragm” and might not “have invented the phonograph.”³⁵³ In 1892, a Belfast newspaper invoked Pascal’s quote about Cleopatra’s nose and cited cases of “the unforeseen advantages produced by accidents”—for example, surmising that if the French diplomat Maurice de Talleyrand-Périgord had not suffered a fall that rendered him “lame for life,” he would not have “turn[ed]... his attention to books and [become]... one of the leading diplomatists of the day.”³⁵⁴

By the turn of the century, counterfactuals were being applied to specialized subjects and used in new genres of creative expression.³⁵⁵ One of the more notable was satire. In 1908, the well-known British humorists Charles Larcom Graves and Edward Verrall Lucas published a book entitled *If—A Nightmare in the Conditional Mood* (1908), which featured dozens of illustrations by the well-known British artist George Morrow.³⁵⁶ Composed of comical news stories and fake advertisements, the vignettes included several counterfactual premises—for example, cartoons like “If Columbus had Never Seen an Egg” and a series of one-line “Unthinkables,” including “If the Ark had sunk.”³⁵⁷ A



FIGURE 2.13 By 1914, popular journals were publishing cartoons about “Historical Ifs.”
(Source: Wikimedia Commons)

second volume published by the same authors that same year, entitled *Hustled History: Or, As It Might Have Been*, also featured scattered counterfactual comments—for instance, a news article about the violin skills of the Roman emperor, Nero, which concluded that “if he had devoted himself entirely to the instrument instead of ... politics,... he might have become a formidable rival to [the famed British violinist] Vivien Chartres.”³⁵⁸ Finally, counterfactual cartoons appeared in other publications of the time, like the journal *Popular Electricity and Mechanics*, which ran a cartoon entitled “Historical Ifs,” that mocked contemporary fashion trends by musing that “If Helen of Troy had Worn 1914 [clothing] styles, there wouldn’t have been any Trojan War” (Figure 2.13).³⁵⁹

During this period, observers praised “what ifs” for being emotionally satisfying and intellectually respectable. In 1883, a British writer observed that “there is nothing more calculated to relieve the tedium of historical narrative than to speculate upon what would have been the current of events if things, which to us seem to have taken place by chance, had not taken place at all.”³⁶⁰ In 1891, another British writer lent counterfactuals prestige by associating them with serious thinkers, writing “the part which accident plays in ... history is a favorite branch of speculation with those philosophers who have a fancy for the ... ‘might-have-beens’ of the world.”³⁶¹ Similar comments appeared in later years as well. One British writer in 1912 declared that “the most mature students of history are struck by the accidental ... character of their subject” upon encountering “a fact ... which had it happened otherwise must have changed the entire course of events.”³⁶² That same year, an American journalist referred to the “academic inquiry into the ‘might-have-beens’ of history,” while another referred to the “philosophical consideration of the ‘what-might-have-beens’ of history.”³⁶³

The Critics

The newfound popularity of counterfactuals was not shared by all, however. In the years after 1850, many commentators in the Anglo-American media employed various arguments to attack “what ifs.” On New Years’ Day of 1876, a British newspaper declared that “speculations as to what might have been are almost as idle as speculations as to what may be.”³⁶⁴ Two decades later in 1897, an American newspaper bluntly declared that “discuss[ing]... ‘might-have-beens’ is a waste of time.”³⁶⁵ In 1907, the *Jewish Exponent* agreed, declaring “It is not, as a rule, profitable, even in a cultural sense, to speculate on the ‘might-have-beens’ of history.”³⁶⁶ That same year, a newspaper in Macon, Georgia, used poetic verse to dismiss counterfactuals, opining “Ain’t no use o’ mopin’... ‘bout the ‘things that might have been’... A-figgerin’ on the ‘might-have-beens,’ you’ve got no way to know,... [since] what the seemin’ might-have-beens might not have been at all.”³⁶⁷ Finally, in 1911, a writer for *The Nation* declared that “few things ... are more futile than to talk of the ‘might-have-beens’ of history.”³⁶⁸

Some critics attacked counterfactuals as emotionally debilitating. On New Year’s Day of 1868, an Ohio newspaper admonished people not to waste time wondering “what if” about the past year, declaring “as the years flow past us still, let not their sad faces thrill in us a remembrance ill [of]... graves of might-have-beens.”³⁶⁹ A writer in the *Washington Post* took a similar approach in a 1897 article, insisting that wondering about “might-have-beens” should be resisted, lest it “weaken” people and keep them from accepting that “the

thing is done.”³⁷⁰ The notion that history’s verdict was sealed informed other complaints about counterfactuals. Writing about U.S. intervention in the Philippines, a writer in the *New York Times* in 1900 observed that “you can’t turn the millwheel with the water that has passed.”³⁷¹ In 1907, an Edinburgh newspaper compared “the ‘might-have-beens’ of history” to “wasteland outside the margin of cultivation,” concluding “What is done is done.”³⁷²

Other commentators argued that counterfactuals lay beyond the realm of genuine historical study. In 1867, a British writer curious about how English history would have evolved had Oliver Cromwell not died early referred to the “folly ... [of] making calculations about events that never happened and ... contingencies which never arose.”³⁷³ An American writer in 1873 refuted revisionist claims about the New Testament’s authorship by asserting that “the ‘might have beens’ of the world are not the proper matters of historic inquiry.”³⁷⁴ In 1888, on the eve of the 100th anniversary of the French Revolution, a British writer rejected a conservative claim that political change could have been achieved without revolution by saying “it is unworthy [of] the merest tyro in history to give attention to ... might-have-beens.”³⁷⁵ In 1897, meanwhile, another writer reflecting on the possibility of war between Britain and Russia twenty years earlier in 1877 complained that counterfactuals were unverifiable, insisting that “the would-have-beens of history are most uncertain matters of debate; and if you insist upon it, my would-have-been and your would-have-been must consent to make a drawn game of it.”³⁷⁶

Many critics objected to counterfactuals on theological grounds. Anglo-American Protestants often invoked divine providence to reject claims that things might have been different. Noting how people mourning the loss of loved ones often dwelled on the “*might have beens*” surrounding their deaths, Henry Ward Beecher in 1869 said such thinking was “not Christian” as it led men to be “selfish” in their “suffering.”³⁷⁷ A few years later, a British author used Biblical exegesis to conclude that people whose lives were cut short “shall find their full development in [God’s]... kingdom. ... For Christ has redeemed the ‘might-have-beens’ of his servants.”³⁷⁸ Among the many theological commentaries on “what ifs,” the most notable was British nonconformist minister E. Paxton Hood’s 1883 essay, “The King’s Sceptre” (Figure 2.14).³⁷⁹ Citing Disraeli, Carlyle, and Jacox, Hood expressed the era’s fondness for trendspotting in arguing that “almost all of our great historians ... have [explored]... what might possibly have been.”³⁸⁰ Hood did so from a position of anxiety, however. Concerned that the belief in secular causality and chance was undermining religious faith, he bemoaned the fact that the word “If ... has been magnified into amazing importance,” noting that it was merely a “mirage” that ignored



FIGURE 2.14 In his 1883 essay, "The King's Sceptre," the English minister, E. Paxton Hood, feared that "what ifs" were undermining religious faith. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

"the divine ordaining of Providence in the history of human affairs." For Hood, Disraeli was mistaken that the alteration of events "would have been advantageously different," noting instead that "the great march of ages would have held on by other routes to the destined end." Fittingly, Hood's conclusion endorsed

the Whig interpretation of history and asserted that the “unbroken succession” that marked Britain’s political evolution refuted the idea that “accident has been the great mover ... of human affairs” and confirmed God’s will.³⁸¹

Other observers criticized counterfactuals by exposing their analytical shortcomings. Writing in 1862, the British writer Shirley Gerard called the word, “if,” a “musquito of a word [that]... stings us most unmercifully,” adding that “the ... subjunctive” tense was marked by “bitter misery” and cautioning that anyone who fixated on “what *might have been*” was destined for unhappiness.³⁸² Half a century later, an American writer for *The Detroit News* criticized “might-have-beens” as “deceptive ... ghost[s],” urging people to remember that “all the ‘Have-Beens’... might have been ‘*Might-Have-Beens*, too. ... and would be taunting us today just as the other ‘*Might-Have-Beens* like to do.”³⁸³

The negative reputation of “might-have-beens,” finally, was visible American advertisements. In 1896, an American company claimed its “blood and nerve remedy” could cure anxieties related to wondering “what if?,” declaring that “If you have ... exhausted your nerve force [by]... thinking [about]... ‘what might have been,’... you can be restored to health” with “Dr. Greene’s Nervura,” which will “quiet [your]... nerves” and ensure that “you will have no [more] occasion to mourn ‘it might have been.’”³⁸⁴ In 1906, a Toronto brokerage firm tried to sell shares in a range of Canadian gold mines by reassuring customers that “you are the architect of your own fortune—only the ‘might-have-beens’... prate dolefully about the LUCK in others.”³⁸⁵ In 1911, the Jacob Weil life insurance company marketed its policies by telling customers that purchasing life insurance was akin to buying “a vacuum cleaner to sweep out all those mental “*Might Have Beens*.”³⁸⁶

While the debate over “what ifs” revealed that ordinary Britons and Americans were becoming increasingly aware of counterfactual speculation, it is unclear whether a similar awareness emerged in other western nations. No comparable word to the compound noun “might-have-been” seems to have emerged elsewhere in Europe. In France, some writers borrowed the term “*uchronia*” from Charles Renouvier’s alternate history novel *Uchronie* from 1857 (discussed in chapter 6 of this volume) and used it as a synonym for a counterfactual. Yet while the word *uchronia* appeared in scattered essays in the 1880s and was listed in a French dictionary in 1890, the word never entered mainstream French usage to the same degree that “might-have-been” did in the English-speaking world.³⁸⁷ In Germany, there was no equivalent term at all. In fact, when German writers invoked the concept of counterfactuals, they often cited Carlyle and used the English phrase “might-have-been” instead of devising a German variant.³⁸⁸ The equivalent German phrase “*was geschehen sein möchte*” was rarely used in the country and never evolved into a compound

noun.³⁸⁹ Although further research on other countries and languages is needed, it appears that counterfactual thought in the late nineteenth century was an especially Anglo-American phenomenon.

Conclusion

In the decades between the middle of the nineteenth century and the eruption of World War I, historians, philosophers, and other scholars increasingly used counterfactuals to question many of the western world's prevailing beliefs. Criticizing the era's faith in positivism, determinism, and progress, western thinkers advanced the skeptical belief that human affairs were governed by sheer chance instead of ascertainable laws. The growing interest in counterfactual history also spilled into western culture. Especially in the Anglo-American world, "what ifs" attained sufficient attention in the public sphere to gain counterfactual reasoning recognition as an independent form of historical thought. The new vogue for "might-have-beens," however, met with a divided response. While some people welcomed the rejection of determinism as liberating, others found it unsettling. As other debates would reveal, this polarization reflected deeper conflicts in western society.

Counterfactuals and the Civil War: Sectional Speculation in the United States, 1861–1914

But for slavery, there would have been no war.³⁹⁰ (James Redpath 1874)

If there had been no Republican party, there would have been no war.³⁹¹
(Benjamin Harvey Hill 1891)

The eruption of the American Civil War played a major role in stimulating nineteenth-century counterfactual thought. As the western world's deadliest military conflict in the years between 1815 and 1914, the war sparked tremendous debate in the U.S. among historians, journalists, and politicians. In seeking to explain the conflict's origins and consequences, supporters of the Union and the Confederacy advanced competing arguments that reflected deep divisions of section, party, and race. These differences shaped not only how both groups portrayed what happened in the war but how it might have unfolded differently. Here, too, Americans took diametrically opposed positions. As was illustrated by the comments of New York journalist and abolitionist James Redpath and the U.S. Senator from Georgia James Harvey Hill, Northerners used "what ifs" to explain the war as the result of slavery, while Southerners blamed it on the decision of the North's dominant political party to infringe on the principle of states' rights.

The competing views of Redpath and Hill were typical of American historical writing about the Civil War in the half-century between 1861 and 1914. During this period, Americans produced an immense literature about the conflict. In the first several decades after the war, most histories in the North and South were produced by amateur historians, often by people who had participated directly in the conflict as political leaders, military men, and ordinary citizens.³⁹² Writing in an era when their memories of the war were still bitter, they injected their texts with deep partisan fervor. After the 1890s, by contrast, most histories were produced by professional historians who were wedded to the newly established ideal of scholarly objectivity. Writing at a time of heightened nationalism and expressing the era's desire for sectional reconciliation, they sought to replace partisanship with consensus and create a unified national narrative. In contrast to Europe, however, where nationalistically minded historians succeeded in crafting master narratives for their respective

nations, historians in the United States were unable to do so because of persisting sectional divisions.³⁹³

These divisions were visible in the ways that supporters of the Union and the Confederacy used “what ifs” to explain and judge the events of the Civil War. Both sides employed causal counterfactuals to determine whether the war was the result of structural or contingent factors and whether it was inevitable or avoidable.³⁹⁴ Both sides used judgmental counterfactuals to explore the war’s many missed opportunities and close calls, producing fantasies and nightmares about how history might have been different. Despite these commonalities, both sides were unable to agree on the recent past. In fact, their disagreement explained why they used so many counterfactuals in the first place. Given their inability to convince one another empirically about their views, both sides embraced “what ifs” as rhetorical trump cards to defeat their opponents. The strategy ultimately failed, but by embracing “what ifs” so fervently, Americans in the North and South dramatically boosted the prominence of counterfactual history in the United States. In so doing, they kept pace with their European counterparts in recognizing the virtues of historical speculation.

The Civil War’s Long-Term Origins: 1776–1815

In examining the Civil War’s origins, supporters of the Union and the Confederacy looked back to the nation’s founding and examined how slavery and states’ rights were reflected in the American constitution. Northerners mostly used missed opportunity counterfactuals to show how the constitution might have limited slavery, while southerners mostly used deterministic counterfactuals to argue that, without the acceptance of slavery, the Union never would have come into existence at all.

Northern Views

Northerners believed the nation’s founders missed key opportunities to limit slavery. Some observers cited the failure to pass Thomas Jefferson’s original draft of the Land Ordinance of 1784, one clause of which sought to prohibit slavery in all the western territories north and south of the Ohio River (including Kentucky, Alabama, Mississippi, and Tennessee) by the year 1800. Noting how the measure was narrowly defeated due to the absence of a delegate from New Jersey, who was nursing a cold, the famed abolitionist Horace Greeley in 1864 wrote that the “deplorable ... accident ... prevented the adoption ... of

a proposition which would have confined Slavery in our country within the limits of the then existing States, and precluded all reasonable probability of subsequent ... strife touching its extension" (Figure 3.1).³⁹⁵ A decade earlier, the anti-slavery Ohio Senator Salmon P. Chase declared that if the measure had passed, "the question of slavery ... would have been settled ... forever" and the new territory "would have been covered with the impenetrable aegis of freedom."³⁹⁶ These and other scholars lamented how, due to chance, "a lean minority ... gained a victory that should have fallen to the other side."³⁹⁷

Northerners also regretted how chance undermined efforts to legally limit the slave trade. Noting that the "majority of the framers of the Constitution ... were adverse to Slavery," Greeley saw golden opportunities for the early U.S., speculating that "[if] the majority [could] have made such a Constitution as they would have preferred, Slavery would have found no lodgment in it."³⁹⁸ Greeley believed the corner had been turned when Congress formally abolished the slave trade on January 1, 1808, noting that "this was the period from which ... slavery in our country should have ... gone steadily ... to its ultimate ... extinction."³⁹⁹ Indeed, slavery would have disappeared for good, according to the abolitionist Archibald Henry Grimké, "had other ... causes not intervened to produce adverse social and political conditions" that ended up solidifying the institution.⁴⁰⁰ The most important of these causes was Eli Whitney's invention of the cotton gin in 1793. As the historian Edward Channing speculated in 1901, "If the cotton gin had never been invented,... slavery would have been peaceably abolished in the South in the first quarter of the nineteenth century."⁴⁰¹ But for that "mechanical improvement," the historian John William Draper noted in 1868, "the two sections of the country would have been found in accordance on [the issue of slavery]... at the present day."⁴⁰²

Because slavery ended up remaining legal in the new nation, some Northern abolitionists wished that the Union had never come into existence at all. Noting that "a partnership between right and wrong is wholly wrong," William Lloyd Garrison in 1852 declared, "Better that the American Union had never been formed, than that it should have been obtained at such a frightful cost!"⁴⁰³ Garrison's colleague Theodore Parker made a similar point in 1863, noting that when South Carolina and Georgia originally "threatened to withdraw from the Union, if [their insistence on preserving slavery was]... not sufficiently respected in the new Constitution," it "would have been better" if "the other States had said, 'You may go, soon as you like, for hitherto you have been only a curse to us.'"⁴⁰⁴

Still other Northerners sought solace in the failure to ban slavery by insisting that things might have been worse. Using a silver lining counterfactual, the radical Republican politician Henry Wilson expressed relief that Jefferson's



FIGURE 3.1 In 1864, the northern abolitionist, Horace Greeley, lamented the failure to pass the Land Ordinance of 1784, saying it might have limited the spread of slavery. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

1784 Ordinance ended up being defeated, noting that because it only banned slavery in the western territories after 1800, its approval would have sparked “a more powerful and persistent effort” by “emigrants from the South” to bring their slaves to the new territories before that date and “might have imperiled [the freedom there].”⁴⁰⁵ “If slavery had been allowed to get a foothold in the territory for sixteen years,” the scholar and later president of the American Historical Association William Frederick Poole added in 1876, “it could not have been abolished at the end of that period.”⁴⁰⁶ The failure to pass Jefferson’s measure, and the ensuing passage of the Northwest Ordinance of 1787 (which prohibited slavery north of the Ohio River, despite permitting it in the South), was thus all for the best, since without these decisions, historian Daniel Wait Howe noted, states like “Indiana and Illinois ... would have established slavery.”⁴⁰⁷ This turn of events, others observed, might have later proved fatal in the later Civil War. Writing that “the Northwestern States put more than a

million soldiers into the Union armies,” Poole wrote that “if ... the institution ... of [slavery]... had been allowed to gain a foothold in these States, can anyone doubt what would have been the result of the war and the fate of this Union?”⁴⁰⁸

Southern Views

Compared to the diverging arguments put forth by Northerners, Southerners and their Northern sympathizers were more unanimous in assessing the long-term factors behind the Civil War. While most Northerners wished that the constitutional order had somehow been different, most Southerners said it had to be as it was.

Many writers speculated that the U.S. Constitution never would have been approved had it not given individual states the right to embrace slavery. Pointing to Article X in the Bill of Rights, which relegated to the states all powers not explicitly assigned to the Federal Government, the Virginia theologian and writer Robert Lewis Dabney argued that state sovereignty endorsed “slaveholding ... as lawful,” a principle “without which the Southern States would never have accepted the Union.”⁴⁰⁹ In 1836, the South Carolina Congressman William Drayton put it even more explicitly, noting that “the South would never have sanctioned a constitution which gave to the general government any power ... to legislate on the slave question.”⁴¹⁰ The Mississippi Senator and later President of the Confederacy, Jefferson Davis, meanwhile, used a similar argument to demand Northern compliance with the Fugitive Slave Act, saying in 1860 that “without [its] adoption,... the Union could not have been formed.”⁴¹¹

Southerners and supporters of states’ rights further deterministically argued that the constitution could not have been dramatically different, since the framers had never intended to give Black people equality. Rejecting the abolitionist claim that the constitution’s references to freedom and equality should be applied to Black people, Dabney hypothesized that “[if] the men who framed it had intended to refer to African slavery, they would have completely stultified themselves. For the majority of them ... continued to hold Africans in bondage.”⁴¹² The Illinois Democratic Senator Stephen Douglas agreed, telling Abraham Lincoln in an 1858 debate that if the founding fathers “had understood ... [the] Declaration [of Independence] as including the negro ... they would have ... restored the negro to that equality which [Mr. Lincoln]... thinks the Almighty intended they should occupy with the white man.”⁴¹³ The Confederate officer Albert Taylor Bledsoe meanwhile, used a Rip Van Winkle counterfactual to argue that “If [Thomas]... Jefferson had lived till the present day,... he would have ... [supported]... slavery” (Figure 3.2).⁴¹⁴

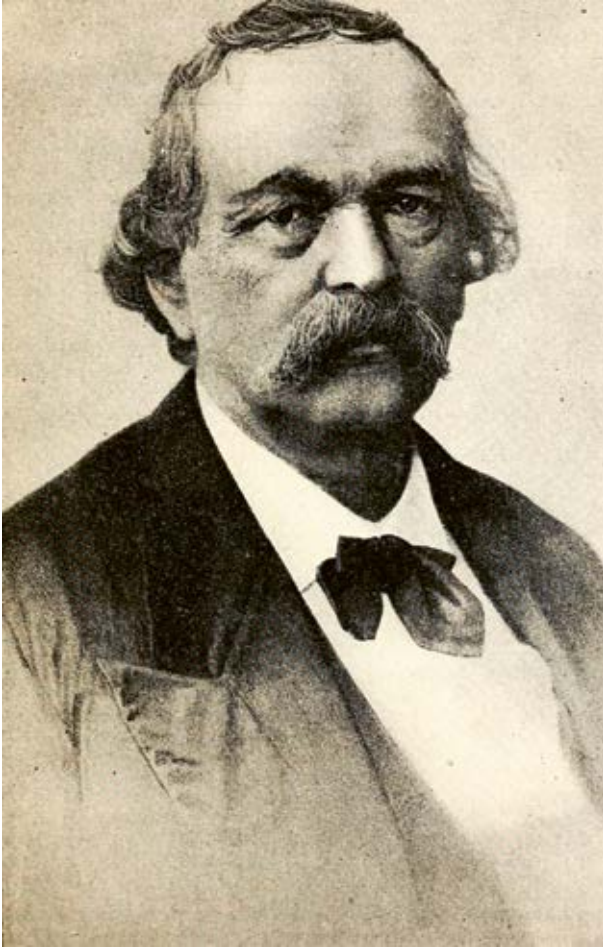


FIGURE 3.2 Writing in 1866, the Confederate officer, Albert Taylor Bledsoe, speculated that if Thomas Jefferson were alive, “he would have ...[supported]... slavery.” (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

While some Southerners defended the constitution as it was, others wished it had accommodated their needs more thoroughly. The Georgia Congressman and later Vice President of the Confederacy Alexander Stephens regretted the South's acceptance of the 3/5ths clause in the Constitution (which gave the South Congressional representation by partially, rather than fully, counting its slave population), saying “but for it, the Southern States would have had six more members than they had under the first census.”⁴¹⁵ South Carolina Senator John Calhoun meanwhile, speculated that “if the South had ... not been excluded by the ordinance of 1787... from the region lying between the

Ohio and the Mississippi rivers ... it would have divided the emigration with the North and ... would have at least equaled [it] in population, [thereby]... preserv[ing] the equilibrium between the two sections that existed at the commencement of the Government.”⁴¹⁶ The problem was that the Constitution had not kept pace with the country’s westward expansion. Employing a geographical counterfactual, the pro-slavery Ohio Senator Clement Vallandigham said that if “the country [had retained]... the limits which it ... had [in 1787],” the constitution “would have ... been perfect, enduring for ages,” but the founders, he noted, could not “have foreseen ... the amazing rapidity with which new ... States [sprang]... up.”⁴¹⁷ Sharing this sentiment, Bledsoe speculated that “if [the founders]... could only have witnessed the gigantic ... faction of 1861, they would have pronounced their own ‘grand experiment’ a disastrous failure,” adding that if James Madison were still alive, “he would have seen that the Union ... no longer deserved to exist.”⁴¹⁸

Some Southerners channeled their regret about the U.S.’s constitutional evolution into counterfactual fantasies. Several wished that New Englanders had acted on the plan—which was discussed at the Hartford Convention of 1814–1815—to secede from the Union. As the Tennessee writer Elizabeth Avery Meriwether (writing under the pseudonym of George Edmonds) argued in 1904, if such a secession had taken place, “no gulf would have been dug between the Southern and Northern States, no gulf filled with the blood and bones of slaughtered men.” “The Northern people,” she noted, “might not have aided ... the Republican party in committing the awful crime of ... [forcing the South]... back into a Union she detested.” More importantly, New England’s secession would have established the principle that “the Union Government had ... no ... right to coerce seceding States.”⁴¹⁹

By contrast, other Southerners defended the U.S. Constitution’s endorsement of slavery with counterfactual nightmares. Some hypothesized that if slavery had been abolished early in history, the American Revolution would never have happened. Declaring that “African slavery [was]... a potent influence in forming the character of the Southern gentleman,” Dabney noted that “without [his]... high spirit, independence, and chivalry, America would never have won her freedom from British rule.”⁴²⁰ Envisioning a different nightmare, the Tennessee politician James Williams noted that “[if] slavery had been abolished,” the “white race would have revolted,” sparking “perpetual conflict between the two races” and forcing the white community “to seek shelter and protection under ... a despotism,” thereby destroying the “infant republic.”⁴²¹ Finally, the pro-slavery Massachusetts lawyer and writer George Lunt noted that because Northern prosperity relied on slavery, its abolition would have prevented Northern manufacturing from becoming “the competitor of Europe

in the markets of the world” and “might have thrown back [American]... progress for ... many years, if the republic ... could have survived at all.”⁴²²

The Civil War’s Medium-Term Origins: 1820–1854

Northern and Southern writers also used “what ifs” to explain how the Civil War grew out of worsening sectional tensions in the first half of the nineteenth century. As the United States expanded westward and acquired new territory through war and conquest, it faced the question of whether the newly admitted states would permit or prohibit slave labor. In describing how radical abolitionists in the North and ardent secessionists in the South clashed over the issue, Northern and Southern writers used counterfactuals to debate whether the war was avoidable or inevitable.

Avoiding the War: Northern Views

Northerners employed missed opportunity counterfactuals to assign responsibility for the war. They blamed their Southern opponents, as well as themselves, for failing to de-escalate sectional tensions and prevent the eruption of military conflict.

Northerners contended that without the South’s adherence to slavery, there would have been no war. As President Abraham Lincoln told a delegation of Black freedmen in 1862, “without the institution of Slavery ... the War could not have an existence.”⁴²³ Many others took the same position, with the one-time New York congressman and later newspaper editor Horace Greeley adding in 1864 that “if Slavery had been content to remain where the Constitution placed it,... the Free States and the Slave States of this Union could have lived together in a perpetual bond of fraternity.”⁴²⁴ Still others, such as historian James Ford Rhodes, rejected Southern arguments that their rebellion was about states’ rights by saying “the doctrine ... would not have been carried in 1861 to the point of secession, had it not been for the purpose of [defending]... slavery.”⁴²⁵

Northern abolitionists, however, insisted that Northerners could have prevented the war had they simply not tolerated slavery. Pointing to the support for slavery in the Northwest Territory in the early nineteenth century, Greeley observed that “prior to 1818–20, a majority of the white settlers ... in that Territory would have voted in favor of the introduction of slaves,” while the abolitionist Theodore Parker said, “I know ... men [in Boston].... who would have been glad if slavery had been continued here.”⁴²⁶ Edward Channing, meanwhile, wrote that “if slavery had been profitable over a larger area of the

United States, that institution might have become so firmly established that it could not have been overturned.”⁴²⁷ In one of the most searing indictments of Northern complicity, the abolitionist Wendell Phillips (Figure 3.3) indicted the North for slavery’s persistence, declaring in 1836,

But for the fear of Northern bayonets, pledged for the master’s protection, the slaves would long since have wrung a peaceful emancipation from the fears of their oppressors. ...

But for the countenance of the Northern Church, the Southern conscience would have long since awakened to its guilt ...

But for the weight of Northern influence, Louisiana had never been bought, and then there never would have been a domestic slave trade.

Employing a Rip van Winkle counterfactual, Phillips concluded, “if the old men of 1776 could ... see the ruin they have wrought, they would curse us as bastards if we did not ... do our utmost ... to blot from history the memory of this ... crime.”⁴²⁸

Northerners also speculated that the war might have been prevented had they not compromised with the South in the effort to preserve the Union. Some regretted the Missouri Compromise of 1820, which, by allowing slavery in the new state (despite banning it north of the latitude of 36° 30’), sparked Northern fears of slavery’s future expansion into the territories of the Louisiana Purchase. Employing a predictive counterfactual, the New York Senator William Seward in 1854 said that if Americans could have foreseen in 1820 how the country would later be “carving up ... the [west]... between Freedom and Slavery,... Missouri ... would have stood outside of the Union until even this portentous day.”⁴²⁹ James Ford Rhodes, agreed, writing: “Had ... Missouri [not].... been admitted as a slave State, the moral and political force of so much free territory would have confined slavery below the latitude of 36° 30’, and the well-founded hopes of the framers of the Constitution might have been realized.”⁴³⁰ The Ohio Congressman and abolitionist James M. Ashley said that “[if] the ... Missouri compromise would never have been made,... the nation [would have] been delivered from the rule of the slave power.”⁴³¹

Northerners also regretted the Compromise of 1850, which admitted California into the Union as a free state, but weakened the Missouri Compromise by implicitly admitting the possibility of slavery in Utah and New Mexico. Northerners fantasized that the decree would not have been passed if President Zachary Taylor—an opponent of the plan—had not suddenly died of gastroenteritis on July 9, 1850, with Channing declaring that “Had he lived a few months longer, California would probably have been admitted without



FIGURE 3.3 The northern abolitionist, Wendell Phillips, used counterfactuals to indict northern complicity in slavery. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

any compromise.”⁴³² By contrast, the conservative Democratic Senator and supporter of states’ rights Stephen Douglas fantasized that if Taylor had lost the 1848 election to the Democratic nominee (and supporter of states’ rights), Lewis Cass, California would have been admitted more “quietly” into the Union,... [and] we would have heard not a word of southern rights and northern aggressions, much less the harsh and discordant sounds of disunion.”⁴³³

Northerners also expressed regrets about the Kansas-Nebraska Act of 1854, which, by letting the two territories’ populations decide the status of slavery, negated the Missouri Compromise and sparked violent clashes between pro-slavery and anti-slavery settlers known as “Bleeding Kansas.”⁴³⁴ Blaming President Franklin Pierce, who endorsed the act, the anti-slavery Ohio Congressman John Sherman said that if Pierce’s Democratic party

“had been content with the Compromise of 1850... and had faithfully observed the pledges in its platform, there would have been no Civil War.”⁴³⁵ Historian Charles Eugene Hamlin fantasized that if Supreme Court Justice Levi Woodbury had become the Democratic nominee for president instead of Franklin Pierce, and if Woodbury had ultimately attained the office, his “firmness, honesty, and loyalty would have been unconquerable obstacles to the conspirators who broke down the Missouri Compromise.”⁴³⁶ The Massachusetts Congressman Robert Charles Winthrop, meanwhile, argued that if the Missouri Compromise’s author, Kentucky Senator Henry Clay, had not died in 1852, and instead “had survived in health and strength to take part in the controversies of that day,” then the Compromise “never would have been repealed” by the Kansas-Nebraska Act.⁴³⁷

Avoiding the War: Southern Views

Southerners and slavery apologists also employed missed opportunity counterfactuals to assign blame for the war. Most accused their Union opponents—but some criticized themselves—for failing to prevent the conflict.

Some said Northerners could have taken a milder stance on slavery. George Lunt rejected the Northern claim that “the war could not have taken place except for the passions excited by opposition to negro slavery,” noting that the claim made “it appear that the country would have remained at peace had it not been for the ambitious instigators of rebellion at the South.” For Lunt, this speculative argument allowed Northerners to obscure the fact that they “would have consented to allow slavery to remain undisturbed in the South, but for the agitation of the question in that part of the country where it existed.” As he pointed out, most Northerners accepted the existence of slavery, insisting that “a war professedly for abolition could hardly have enlisted a dozen regiments in the North.”⁴³⁸ For that reason, he concluded, “the civil war ... was actually begun by the North ... upon merely political, and not upon moral ... considerations.”⁴³⁹

Other Southerners and slavery apologists used counterfactuals to defend the merits of slave labor. The South Carolina writer and politician William Drayton defended the morality of slavery, arguing that “the spirit of our country would long since have reformed such an evil had it been an evil,” adding that if there were a “more profitable” method of “cultivating the South,” it “would have been heretofore adopted.”⁴⁴⁰ James Williams took a similar position, noting that if early nineteenth-century British plans to employ Black freedmen as wage laborers “had been successful in achieving their purpose, slavery in America

might ... have abolished itself, because of its unprofitableness.”⁴⁴¹ “But,” as he pointed out, “the African would not work without a master” and the plan failed.⁴⁴² Multiple writers, finally, cited the claim of the Northern pro-slavery politician Mordecai Manuel Noah, who in 1835 declared that “the greatness of our country ... would have been a dead letter without the aid of slave labor,” explaining that without it, the “South would have been a ... morass of ... overgrown forests” and never produced the valuable “commodities of cotton, tobacco, [and] rice.”⁴⁴³

Other commentators insisted that if only Northern abolitionists had left the South alone, slavery would have died out by itself. Blaming abolitionists for inciting sectional violence at the time of the Kansas-Nebraska Act, Jefferson Davis said the slogan “No extension of slavery!” was counterproductive in light of how slavery was reaching the end of its lifespan, explaining that “as white laborers ... flowed into the country ... negro labor would have inevitably become a tax to those who held it, and their emancipation would have followed that condition, as it has in all the Northern States.”⁴⁴⁴ Slaveholders in Virginia, meanwhile, argued that “had not the abolitionist agitation” contributed to slave revolts, such as the one led by Nat Turner in 1831, local anti-slavery sentiment “would have resulted in the gradual emancipation of slaves in that state.”⁴⁴⁵ As the Virginia writer John A. Buchanan put it in 1909, “but for [abolitionist]... agitation,... there would have been a gradual emancipation of slaves ... without the shedding of a drop of blood, and in a manner which would have redounded to the interest of both races.”⁴⁴⁶

Some self-critical Southerners said the war might have been avoided if the South had been smarter in addressing the issue of slavery. Robert Lewis Dabney argued that pro-slavery advocates could have exposed the hypocrisy of Northerners for upholding the constitutional structure that permitted slavery, noting that the former could have made the latter admit that “[the] Constitution and Government ... ought not to have been prostituted to the extension of a great moral wrong.” But Southerners failed to expose this hypocrisy effectively. As he complained, “once the slavery agitation became inevitable,” then “the ethical question ... should have been made the great question by us. The halls of Congress should have rung with the arguments, the newspaper press should have teemed with them. But little was done to purpose in this discussion ... and ... they were practically unheard.”⁴⁴⁷ Other Southerners claimed that their fellow citizens should have been more willing to compromise with the North on such legislation as the Clayton Compromise of 1848, which sought to enlist the Supreme Court in deciding the legality of slavery in newly acquired western territories. Condemning the fact that the proposal

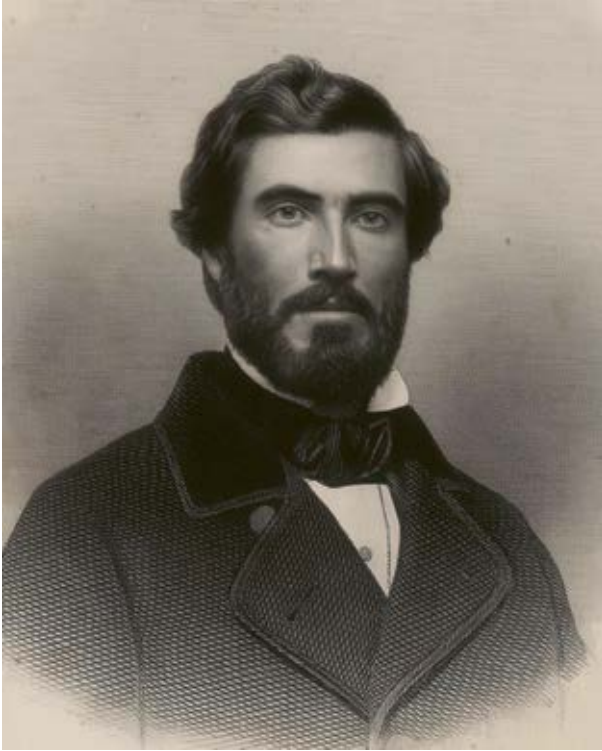


FIGURE 3.4 The southern anti-slavery activist, Hinton Rowan Helper, lamented missed opportunities for the South to abolish slavery earlier in history. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

was scuttled by Alexander Stephens, who feared negative court rulings, the Mississippi Senator and one-time Unionist Henry S. Foote wrote in 1866 that if “this bill ... [had] become ... law, sectional agitation would have been ... suppressed ... and the painful scenes through which we have been lately passing ... might have been happily avoided.”⁴⁴⁸

By far and away, the most self-critical Southerner was the North Carolina writer and anti-slavery activist Hinton Rowan Helper (Figure 3.4). In his 1857 book *The Impending Crisis*, he offered a variety of missed opportunity counterfactuals to argue that the South could have prospered and avoided sectional conflict had it abolished slavery earlier in history. Lamenting the South’s economic stagnation relative to the North’s prosperity, Helper blamed slavery, claiming that “if the State [of Virginia] had emancipated her slaves at the time of the adoption of the Constitution ... the last census would no doubt have reported her wealth ... at a sum exceeding a thousand millions of dollars”

instead of “being worth only \$392,000,000.”⁴⁴⁹ Helper insisted that Virginia’s fate was true of the entire South. “Had the Southern States ... abolished slavery at the same time [as] the North,... there would have been ... a larger, wealthier, wiser, and more powerful population, south of Mason and Dixon’s line, than there now is north of it.”⁴⁵⁰ Conversely, had the North not abolished slavery, he declared, “New York would never have risen above the dishonorable level of Virginia [and]... Massachusetts would have continued [as]... the contemptible coequal of South Carolina.”⁴⁵¹ Had there only been no slavery, he concluded:

how much richer, better, greater, would the South have been to-day? How much larger and more intelligent would have been our population ... How much ... larger would be the number of our churches, theatres, [and] schools, ...[?] How ... vastly more reputable would we be abroad, how infinitely more ... happy would we be at home?⁴⁵²

Helper’s book predictably sparked outrage in the South, where it was banned. But Northern writers found it instructive. As Edward Channing speculated, “had [Southerners]... been able to read ... the arguments set forth in [Helper’s]... book, slavery would have been doomed to destruction.”⁴⁵³

The Inevitability of War: Northern and Southern Views

While many Americans saw the war as avoidable, others believed it was inevitable due to the South’s need to spread slavery. Writing in 1892, the famed Black abolitionist Frederick Douglass depicted slavery as inherently expansionistic, writing that the anti-slavery activists “could have done very little without the aid rendered them unwittingly by the aggressive character of slavery itself, [which as a]... system [could] never rest in obscurity ... [and] was noisiest when it should have been most silent and unobtrusive” (Figure 3.5).⁴⁵⁴ As a result, sectional conflict over slavery was inevitable. In 1864, Greeley invoked the famous claim of Massachusetts Senator Charles Sumner that the Civil War was an “irrepressible conflict” in calling the war the “unavoidable result of antagonisms imbedded in the very nature of our heterogeneous institutions ... which might have been ... postponed but could by no means have been prevented.”⁴⁵⁵

Northerners argued that the Southern drive to spread slavery was so fierce that, if the North had not agreed to so many compromises, the Civil War would have erupted earlier in history. Commentators pointed to many such moments, but they focused especially on the Compromise of 1850.⁴⁵⁶ Many debated whether the compromise would have been approved had President Zachary

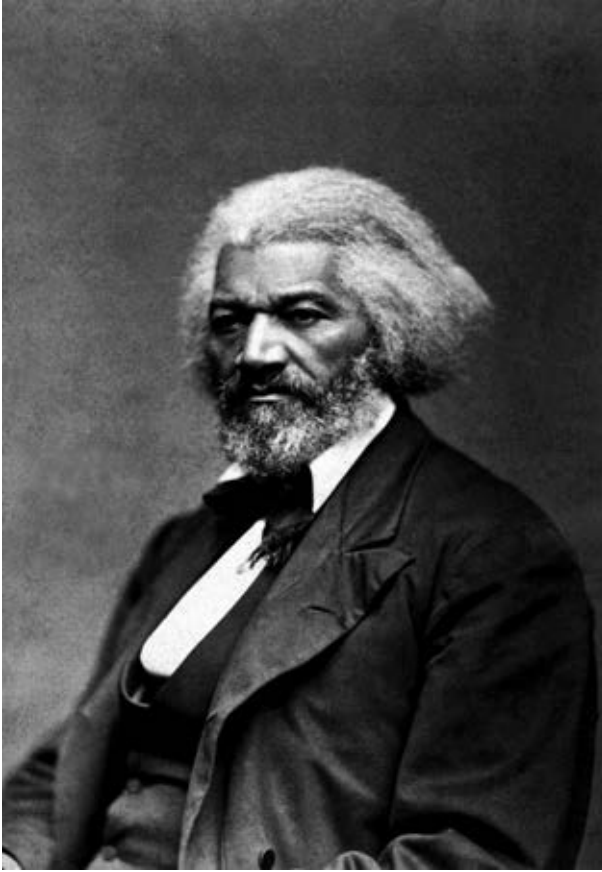


FIGURE 3.5 Frederick Douglass used deterministic counterfactuals to emphasize the aggressive character of slavery. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Taylor had not died unexpectedly in July of 1850. Pointing out that Taylor was a fierce Unionist, despite being a slaveholder, the Massachusetts lawyer Thornton Kirkland Lothrop claimed that the compromise “would probably have failed to pass in any form,” while Whig politician Thurlow Weed concluded that failure “might have precipitated the rebellion” a decade earlier.⁴⁵⁷ Northerners also debated what the outcome of an earlier war would have been. The statesman and anti-slavery activist Carl Schurz argued that since Southerners realized that “slavery could not be saved within the Union, and that every compromise putting off the decisive crisis only made its final doom all the more certain,” the “slave-holding states would have been more able to hold their own in 1820 than in 1850, and more in 1850 than they proved to be in 1861.”⁴⁵⁸ By contrast,

historian Joseph M. Rogers cited President Taylor's claim that if the South ever seceded, "he would lead an army of Southern troops and put down the secession," adding that there was "no ... doubt ... he would have ... succeeded had he lived."⁴⁵⁹ Lothrop, however, insisted the consequence of such a victory would have proved temporary, arguing that "while the offenders would have been quickly reduced to obedience,... slavery would have been untouched, and the whole battle would have remained to be fought out at a later day."⁴⁶⁰ The war could be postponed, but not avoided.

For their part, Southerners saw the Civil War as inevitable but attributed it to Northern Sectionalism. Jefferson Davis stated it plainly in 1881, when he said that the Civil War "was not the consequence of ... slavery, [but]... the offspring of ... political ambition," noting that the "sectional hostility" that sparked the war "would have manifested itself just as certainly if ... there had not been a negro in America."⁴⁶¹ Much of that hostility, Southerners argued, was due to economic greed. As a Confederate officer opined at a Tennessee veterans' reunion in 1900, "If the South had been allowed to go in peace, as she desired to do, the North would have lost her richest taxing district,... and this would have ... pauperize[d]... the great manufacturing industries of the North ... hence her war of subjugation."⁴⁶² Albert Taylor Bledsoe agreed, claiming that the North's desire for "absolute dominion and control" was an unavoidable function of its imperial ambitions, declaring that "if the North, with a majority in both branches of Congress, had not oppressed the South, it would have been unlike every other unchecked power in the history of the world."⁴⁶³ Endorsing the view that sectionalism—not slavery—made war inevitable, Clement Vallandigham used a fast forward counterfactual to reject the idea that "if slavery had never existed ... we would have had no sectional controversies," arguing that the "civil war might have happened fifty, perhaps a hundred years later."⁴⁶⁴

The Civil War's Short-Term Origins: 1859–1861

Northerners and Southerners devoted special attention to the short-term events that sparked the Civil War. Between 1859 and 1861, John Brown's famous raid on Harpers Ferry, the election of Abraham Lincoln as President of the United States, the secession of South Carolina, and the last-ditch attempt to salvage the Union with the Crittenden Compromise prompted Americans to imagine a wide range of "what ifs". Expressing nightmares and fantasies, these counterfactuals reflected ongoing disagreement about whether the war was avoidable or not.

John Brown's Raid on Harpers Ferry

On October 16, 1859, a group of twenty-two radical abolitionists led by John Brown raided the U.S. Arsenal in Harpers Ferry, West Virginia, hoping to spark a slave rebellion and destroy slavery once and for all in the United States (Figure 3.6). The risky mission failed due to a variety of mistakes, especially Brown's decision to take hostages and hunker down in the Armory's fire house, which led to his eventual capture by Virginia militia forces and execution for the crime of treason. But the event sharpened Northern disgust with slavery and worsened sectional tensions. In using "what ifs" to explain and judge the event, Brown's supporters and opponents profoundly disagreed about how history might have been different.

Brown's supporters argued that his raid could easily have succeeded. In 1860, the abolitionist minister Edwin M. Wheelock noted that "If Brown had not ... lingered in the captured town till beset by the Federal bayonets, he would now have been lodged in the mountains or swamps, while every corner of the State would have flamed with revolt."⁴⁶⁵ Historian Henry William Elson took a similar position, arguing that if Brown "had ... avoided the Federal army, he might have overrun the heaving, rocking soil of the fifteen States, breaking every slave chain in his way."⁴⁶⁶ In 1859, Wendell Phillips declared that if Brown "had not stayed at Harpers Ferry" but had fled to higher elevation with "two thousand Charlestown people,... the mountains would have ... heaved with insurrection!"⁴⁶⁷ For his part, Brown himself could not explain why he did not flee into the mountains, but he used a providential counterfactual to explain why "I did not hold fast to my own plans." Employing a Biblical analogy, he speculated that "If Samson had remained true to his resolve not to tell Delilah wherein his great strength lay, he probably never would have pulled down the house," concluding that "God's plan was [for me] beyond a doubt much better, otherwise I should have held to my own."⁴⁶⁸

Brown's supporters insisted that without his failed raid, history would have turned out worse. Some argued that abolishing slavery would have been more difficult. As James Ford Rhodes put it, "who can say that the proclamation of emancipation would have met as hearty a response, that Northern patriots would have fought with as much zeal, and the people sustained Lincoln in the war for the abolition of slavery as faithfully, had not John Brown suffered martyrdom in the same cause on Virginia soil?"⁴⁶⁹ The abolitionist Franklin Benjamin Sanborn doubted there was "any method ... that could have [abolished slavery]... quicker than Brown's," arguing that "but for Brown's career, it might have been sixty years before we reached that result."⁴⁷⁰ The abolitionist writer Frank Preston Stearns, meanwhile, praised Brown's willingness



FIGURE 3.6 Both the opponents and supporters of slavery used “what ifs” to judge John Brown’s ill-fated raid on Harpers Ferry in 1859. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

to become a martyr with a silver lining counterfactual, writing that “his failure ... achieved much greater results than its most complete success could have done,” adding that Brown himself believed he was “worth infinitely more on the gallows than ... anywhere else.”⁴⁷¹

Some observers used “what ifs” to justify Brown’s actions. Responding to Brown’s use of violence to liberate enslaved persons, the abolitionist minister George B. Cheever used a substitution counterfactual, observing “that if the color had been white, and the victims of oppression your relatives, neighbors, or neighbors’ descendants, you would have made no question of the virtue,

righteousness, and nobleness of John Brown's attempt."⁴⁷² The abolitionist minister Fales Henry Newhall made a similar point with a trading places counterfactual, arguing that "had John Brown done precisely the same act to save the white man from the tyranny of the black man, successful or unsuccessful, the deed would have been sung and celebrated as heroic."⁴⁷³ Black commentators also hailed Brown. In an 1883 commemorative ceremony for Brown in Kansas, the orator O.H. Langston noted, "had there been no John Brown,... who will say that the black race would have been manumitted?"⁴⁷⁴

By contrast, more skeptical commentators insisted that Brown's raid had no chance of success. Stearns wrote that "the Harper's Ferry attack was not a success from a military point of view, or even from that of guerrilla warfare," adding that it was "difficult to understand how it could have been otherwise than unsuccessful."⁴⁷⁵ Referring to Brown's goal of spreading emancipation nationwide, Stearns noted that "Heaven itself could not have brought this about, unless it had sent the angel of judgment to cast down into the dust the whole white population from Florida to Maine."⁴⁷⁶

For these skeptics, history would have turned out better without the raid. Some argued if Brown had not launched his attack, slavery would have disappeared on its own. Noting that "a majority of the people of Virginia ... were at heart opposed to slavery," the Virginia writer John S. Wise argued that if the people of the South had remained "uninterrupted by madmen like Brown, they would have accomplished, in good time, the emancipation of the slaves[s] without the awful fratricidal scenes which he precipitated."⁴⁷⁷ President James Buchanan also criticized Brown's raid, arguing that "if left to the wise ordinances of a superintending Providence, which never acts rashly, [slavery]... would have been gradually extinguished in our country, peacefully and without bloodshed."⁴⁷⁸

Others criticized Brown by pointing to the nightmares that might have ensued had his attack succeeded. Pointing out that "the white population of the Southern States alone ... outnumbers the colored race in the ratio of two to one," the Massachusetts Senator and slavery apologist Edward Everett noted that there would have been "scenes of fire and sword, of lust and murder, of rapine and desolation" that would have ended in "the extermination of the [colored race]..., after scenes of woe for which language is too faint."⁴⁷⁹ The abolitionist writer Frank Preston Stearns agreed, noting that "upon recovering from the stupefaction of the first alarm, the white population of the South would have risen as one man to force the slaves back into the yoke, and the North, with the exception of a handful of the most radical Abolitionists, would have helped the South with all its might." No matter how noble Brown's intentions were, "the blacks would have been crushed like tinder."⁴⁸⁰ The

abolitionist minister Thomas Wentworth Higginson, meanwhile, speculated that while insurrection was an understandable response of enslaved persons, a successful revolt led by Brown “would ... have divided the Northern sentiment; and a large part of our army would have joined with the Southern army to hunt them down.”⁴⁸¹

The Election of Abraham Lincoln

After the raid on Harpers Ferry, the election of Abraham Lincoln as President in 1860 further stoked sectional tensions (Figure 3.7). Throughout the South, but especially in South Carolina, political leaders spoke openly of seceding from the Union were Lincoln elected. This rhetoric alarmed many Northerners and helped Lincoln win 180 electoral votes from seventeen of the U.S.’s thirty-three states. That said, Lincoln only received a plurality of the vote, benefiting from the presence of three pro-slavery candidates, Stephen Douglas, Vice President John Breckinridge, and Tennessee Senator John Bell, who split the anti-Lincoln vote between them.

In seeking to explain Lincoln’s triumph, some writers imagined how it might have been avoided. In 1860, John Sherman blamed Lincoln’s predecessor, James Buchanan, for the poor showing of Democratic presidential candidate, Stephen Douglas, attributing it to the party’s split over the former’s endorsement of the Kansas-Nebraska Act in 1854, arguing that “if Buchanan had ... admitt[ed]... Kansas as a free state,... the Democratic party would have retained its power” and avoided “the consequent election of Lincoln.”⁴⁸² Henry William Elson agreed, noting that the Democratic Party “might have survived the odium of the Kansas-Nebraska Law ... had it not been for [the] quarrel ... within its own household [between Buchanan and Douglas].”⁴⁸³ Daniel Wait Howe also blamed Buchanan for Douglas’s defeat, writing “If [the latter]... had been loyally supported by the Buchanan Administration,... he would probably have been elected over Lincoln.”⁴⁸⁴ Pointing out that “in the North alone over a million votes had been cast for Douglas,” Howe claimed that if “the Democrats who voted for Breckinridge and Douglas [had] been united on either, Lincoln would not have carried all the Northern States.”⁴⁸⁵

Others blamed Southerners for missing opportunities to neutralize Lincoln by restraining their secessionist rhetoric. As Greeley noted, “it was evident that harmony at Charleston would have rendered the election of a Democratic President morally certain. But, after the disruption there, things were bravely altered.”⁴⁸⁶ Elson blamed Northerners for not recognizing the intensification of secessionist rhetoric in South Carolina, writing that “had the North fully realized the gravity of the situation, the election of Lincoln would have been

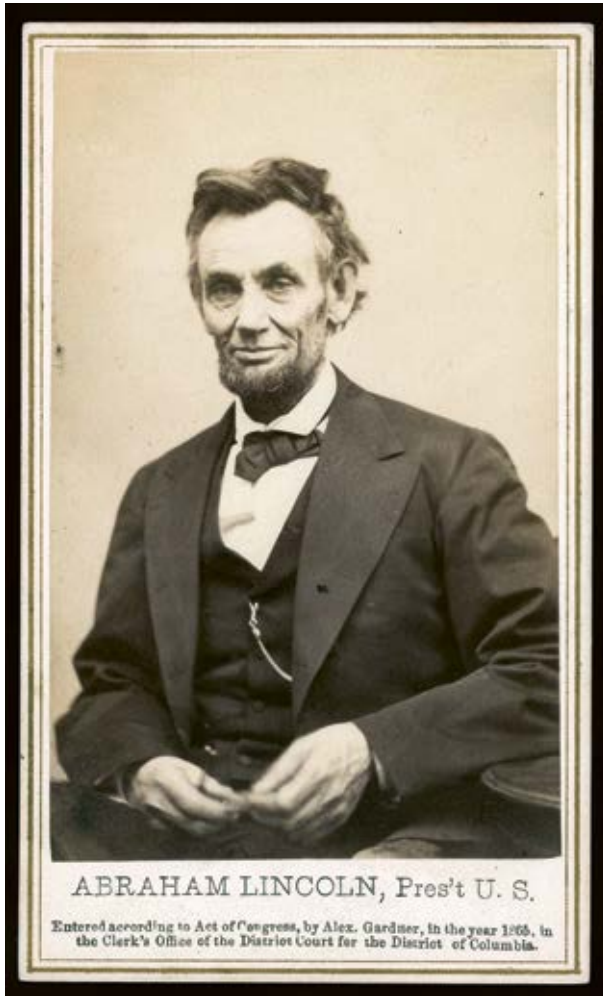


FIGURE 3.7 The election of Abraham Lincoln as president in 1860 prompted some Americans to wonder how his rise to power might have been avoided. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

doubtful.”⁴⁸⁷ After Lincoln won the presidency with a mere plurality of the vote, Wilson noted that if the slave-holders “[had merely] been content therewith,” they “might ... have remained in practical possession of the government,” possibly “for generations.”⁴⁸⁸

Regardless of whether Lincoln won or lost the election of 1860, Northern observers believed that secession was inevitable. According to Daniel Wait Howe, had Douglas or someone else won the election, “neither could have

reconciled the advocates and the opponents of the extension of slavery.”⁴⁸⁹ Although conceding that “the election of Douglas might, for a time, have prolonged the Union,” Howe noted that “it would also have given slavery a new lease of life, and as long as slavery continued it would have been a disturbing factor in politics and a menace to peace.” Because “it was impossible ... for the country to endure permanently half free and half slave,” he concluded, “there was but one way in which the slavery question could be finally settled and that was by ... battle.”⁴⁹⁰

The Secession of South Carolina

On December 20, 1860, citing the threat of anti-slavery agitation to the “equal rights of the States,” South Carolina formally seceded from the United States of America. President Buchanan denied South Carolina’s right to secede, but dithered about how to enforce his will, being torn between Southern cabinet members, who urged compromise with the secessionists, and Northern advisers, who supported using force to preserve the Union (Figure 3.8). While some of the latter urged Buchanan to send reinforcements to vulnerable Federal forts in the South, especially Fort Moultrie and Fort Sumter in Charleston, Buchanan refused to do so, for fear of riling up the secessionists. As a result, some of his Northern cabinet members promptly resigned. Less than a week after South Carolina’s secession, Southern anger was inflamed when Federal troops, led by Major Robert Anderson, unilaterally shifted forces from the indefensible Fort Moultrie to Fort Sumter, leading some of Buchanan’s Southern cabinet ministers to resign. By February 1, 1861, six additional states in the Deep South had seceded from the union and sent delegates to Montgomery, Alabama, where they approved a provisional constitution of the new Confederate States of America on February 8. In assessing these events, commentators used “what ifs” to determine whether secession was inevitable or avoidable, and whether Buchanan might have defused it without going to war.

Northerners blamed Southern leaders for failing to deescalate the crisis. Pointing to the fact that most Southern whites owned no slaves, Ulysses S. Grant speculated that the former would have sided “with the North” if they had “been capable of seeing [their true interests]” and if elite slaveowners had responded to the crisis with “a ... calm expression of opinion” instead of with “threats.”⁴⁹¹ Greeley agreed, arguing that “had time been afforded for consideration, and both sides been generally heard, a free and fair vote would have shown an immense majority, even in the Slave States, against Secession.”⁴⁹² Unfortunately, Southern elites banged the drums of war.

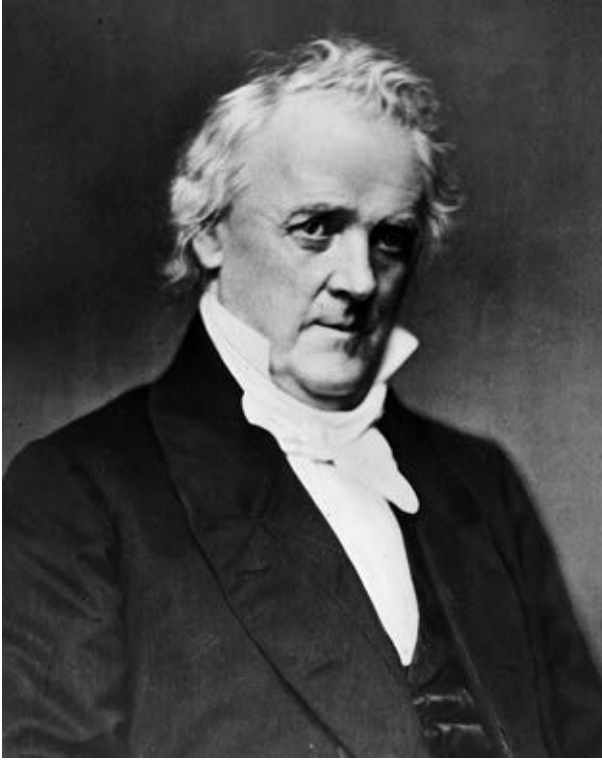


FIGURE 3.8 After South Carolina seceded from the Union in December of 1860, many Americans tried to assess whether President James Buchanan might have prevented it. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Northerners also claimed President Buchanan could have ended the crisis peacefully without resorting to arms. Criticizing the President for ignoring General Winfield Scott's call to send one thousand soldiers to reinforce the Federal Forts in Charleston, James Ford Rhodes hypothesized that sending troops "might have met with the approval of a considerable minority in the border States ... and. ... surely would have caused a thrill of patriotism at the North that could not have failed to unite it almost to a man"; more importantly, he added, it might have "caused the remainder of the Southern States to delay their movements."⁴⁹³ Buchanan's dithering was critical, since many Southerners were wary of secession. As the Maryland writer and naval officer, French Ensor Chadwick, put it, "Had Mr. Buchanan ... held firm,... matters would have had another course," for "resist[ing] the sending of troops [to the]... forts would have been unqualified treason, and for this no one in the

South was prepared.”⁴⁹⁴ Many commentators used substitution counterfactuals to echo Daniel Wait Howe’s claim that if only Buchanan had possessed the same “will” shown by President Andrew Jackson when he neutralized South Carolina’s threat to secede from the Union during the Nullification Crisis of 1832, Buchanan “could have changed the history of the revolt against the Union.”⁴⁹⁵ Even if the war “had begun under his presidency,” James Ford Rhodes noted, had Buchanan prioritized the national interest, “he would have had a united North at his back ... and when he retired,... [he would have enjoyed] the approval of a grateful people.”⁴⁹⁶

For his part, Buchanan used “what ifs” to defend his actions. In his memoirs, he argued that he had lacked sufficient troops to wield against the South and claimed that “to have attempted to distribute ... five companies in the eight forts of the cotton States. ... would have been a confession of weakness. ... [and] could have had no effect in preventing secession, but must have done much to provoke it.”⁴⁹⁷ In early December of 1860, he explained, South Carolina was alone in making secessionist threats, adding that if “a feeble force of United States troops” had been sent to Fort Moultrie and “blood been shed,” then “the other cotton States, from their well-known affinities, would have rushed to the support of South Carolina.”⁴⁹⁸ “It would have precipitated a civil war with the cotton States without the slightest preparation on the part of Congress, and would at once have destroyed the then prevailing hopes of compromise.”⁴⁹⁹ Buchanan further deflected blame from himself onto Southerners by accusing them of mishandling the crisis, saying, “they ought ... to have foreseen ... that if their secession should end in civil war, whatever might be the event, slavery would receive a blow from which it could never recover!”⁵⁰⁰

Southerners, meanwhile, identified missed opportunities to resolve the secession crisis peacefully or prevent it in the first place. Blaming the North, writer J.A. Richardson noted that “if the seceding South had been left unmolested to pursue her own courses, the years would have been comparatively few before a reconciliation ... and a new Union [would have resulted].”⁵⁰¹ Alexander Stephens, by contrast, was more critical. While he later became the Vice President of the Confederacy, he initially opposed Southern secession and defended the historical benefits of Union, declaring in 1860 that without it, “we [would not]... have made the same advancement ... [in] material wealth and prosperity.”⁵⁰² Still others said that the South had failed to adequately defend the principle of states’ rights at the nation’s founding, with Virginia Colonel W. H. Stewart arguing that “when South Carolina gave [Forts] Moultrie and Sumter to the general government, they planted a death germ of State sovereignty,” adding “had these forts been manned by Virginians and Carolinians, the Southern cross would be flying from their ramparts to-day.”⁵⁰³

While many Americans believed opportunities had been missed to avert, or peacefully resolve, the secession crisis, others saw it as unavoidable. Northerners said that South Carolina could not help but secede because of its commitment to slavery. James Ford Rhodes put it bluntly when he wrote that “if the negro had never been brought to America and enslaved, South Carolina would not have seceded.”⁵⁰⁴ John Sherman made a similar point in refuting the claims of South Carolinians that they were leaving the Union due to the election of Abraham Lincoln, writing that the state’s “pretense for secession would not have been concurred in by any of the states north of South Carolina, but for the previous agitation of slavery, which had welded nearly all the slaveholding states into a compact confederacy.”⁵⁰⁵ Rhodes concluded that while more Northern flexibility “might have led ... to a compromise ... [that] prevent[ed] the secession of any State but South Carolina ..., those of us who hold to the idea of the irrepressible conflict can see in the success of such a project no more than the delay of a war that was inevitable.”⁵⁰⁶

Southerners and slavery apologists, meanwhile, saw secession as inevitable because of Northern oppression. Recalling his prophecy that “the success of a sectional anti-slavery party would be the beginning of disunion,” Vallandigham argued that the Northern “disease” of abolitionism had sparked the Southern secession, writing “no display of ... force ... could have arrested it, even at the outset.”⁵⁰⁷ Another writer, while discussing the prominent role played by the Alabama Senator and ardent secessionist William Yancey in the birth of the Confederacy, insisted that “secession would have come sooner or later [even if]... Yancey [had] never been born.”⁵⁰⁸

A Last Chance for Peace? The Crittenden Compromise

As the crisis over South Carolina’s secession was deepening, a bipartisan committee of Congressmen led by Kentucky Congressman John J. Crittenden desperately tried to devise a compromise that could reduce the threat of war (Figure 3.9). The resulting proposal was known as the Crittenden Compromise and proposed a constitutional amendment extending the Missouri Compromise’s ban on slavery north of 36° 30’ to the Pacific Ocean along with a decree that Congress had no power to interfere with slavery south of that line. In the period between December 18 and February 27, 1861, multiple meetings were held in the effort to forge an agreement, including a peace conference in Washington, D.C. that was attended by representatives of Northern states and Southern border states that had not yet decided about secession. Due to the resistance of Northern and Southern leaders, however, the meetings came to naught. Less than two months later, the North and South were at war.

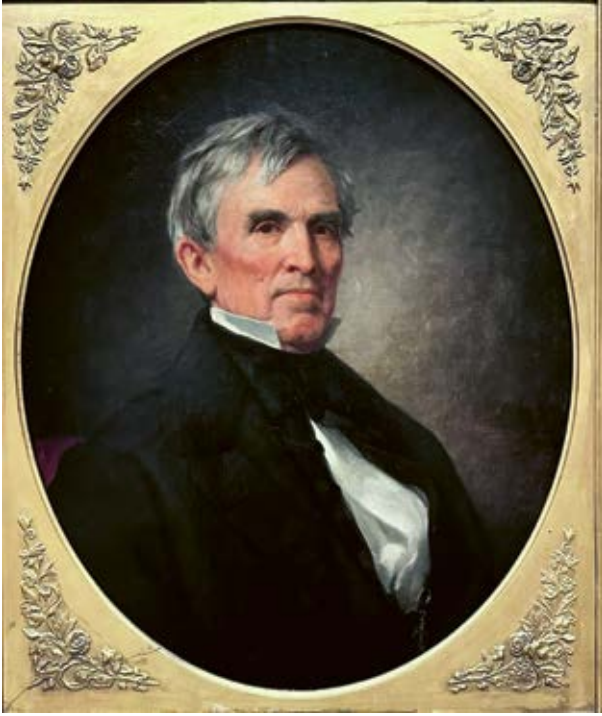


FIGURE 3.9 Americans debated whether the last-ditch proposal of the Kentucky Congressman, John J. Crittenden, to limit slavery to specific parts of the U.S. could have prevented the Civil War. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Many observers debated whether the failure to pass the compromise was avoidable or inevitable. Focusing on Southern responsibility, Greeley said the South's leaders could have "establish[ed] the Crittenden Compromise by their own proper strength, had they not been in haste to secede, from fear that concessions would be offered [and]... their pretexts for disruption would ... be obviated."⁵⁰⁹ Similarly, Rhodes blamed the South's insistence on a constitutional amendment, arguing that "if the ... compromise had been put forward as an ordinary congressional enactment,... Lincoln would have accepted every article of it except the one that proposed the settlement of the territorial question."⁵¹⁰ Others, by contrast, blamed the North, with the states' rights advocate Vallandigham saying the absence of "a single Republican vote" supporting the compromise explained why it failed to "avert ... civil war and maintain ... the Union."⁵¹¹ Still other commentators described the Crittenden Compromise as destined to fail. In explaining why Northern Republicans

declined to compromise, The Tennessee political scientist John W. Burgess insisted that it “would have been ... political and moral suicide” for the party, while Daniel Wait Howe added that even if “the peace propositions ... proposed by Senator Crittenden ... had been passed by both the Senate and House, they would never have been ratified in the North.”⁵¹²

Americans also disagreed about whether the Crittenden Compromise could have prevented the Civil War. Those who sympathized with the South fantasized that it would have. In 1862, Vallandigham argued that “if the ‘Crittenden propositions’... had been adopted, secession would have perished,” while George Lunt noted that the Compromise “would have checked the progress of the rebellion and ... saved the Union.”⁵¹³ By contrast, others said the Compromise could not have saved the union. Declaring that “even with the Crittenden Compromise, the old friction would have remained,” French Ensor Chadwick insisted that “the situation of slavery would not have been bettered; the slaves themselves would have been aroused to greater efforts to freedom by the abolitionists, who would have redoubled their efforts,... [and the South’s] feeling of isolation ... would have grown greater.”⁵¹⁴ Howe, meanwhile, said it was “certain” that the approval of the Crittenden Compromise “would not have tempted South Carolina back into the Union” and it was “doubtful” that its approval “would have induced any one of the seceding cotton States to return.”⁵¹⁵

Finally, many Northerners speculated that if the Crittenden Compromise had been approved, history would have turned out worse. Elson said the Compromise would have “made slavery perpetual in the United States” and “would have struck a blow at modern progress from which the country could not have recovered in a hundred years.”⁵¹⁶ Charles Eugene Hamlin said if the Compromise had been approved, it “would have encouraged the slaveholders to grab more land from Mexico, seize Cuba, and perhaps land in South America.”⁵¹⁷ Had the “slave power ... continued to rule,” Frederick Douglass observed, “the North would have become utterly demoralized; the hands on the dial-plate of American civilization would have been reversed, and the slave would have been dragging his hateful chains to-day wherever the American flag floats to the breeze.”⁵¹⁸ Accepting the Compromise, Burgess bleakly concluded, “would have turned back the clock of the world’s civilization an entire century” and “arrest[ed] the plans of Providence in the evolution of the world’s history.”⁵¹⁹

The Civil War: 1861–65

While there was no official declaration of war between the North and South, hostilities commenced when Southern forces bombarded Fort Sumter on April 12–13, 1861 (Figure 3.10). This event happened just over one month after



FIGURE 3.10 Once Southern troops fired on Union forces stationed at Fort Sumter, Americans wondered how military hostilities might have been avoided. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Abraham Lincoln's inauguration and confronted the new president with an unprecedented crisis. Lincoln's administration was initially uncertain about how to respond to the Southern rebellion given the lack of clarity about whether secession was legal.⁵²⁰ But after he decided to resupply the beleaguered Federal troops at Fort Sumter, and after South Carolina responded by attacking the Fort, hostilities escalated into a full-blown, four-year war. By 1865, the United States had lost more than 700,000 men. Small wonder that the origins of the Civil War generated unprecedented counterfactual speculation.

Critics said Lincoln could have responded more moderately to the stand-off at Fort Sumter. Employing a medium form counterfactual, Alexander Stephens argued that Lincoln "ought to have withdrawn [Federal]... troops" and organized "a Convention of all the States, with a view to a readjustment of their relations." "If the Seceded States had responded to that call," Stephens hypothesized, they "would have returned to their positions ... and the whole Federal machinery ... would have been restored." Alternatively, "[if] the Seceded States had not responded to the call," then "the ... irreconcilable difference between the States" would have led to "peaceful separation." "There would have been no war," Stephens concluded, "nor any of those outrages upon public liberty ... which have brought so much reproach upon our Institutions of Self-government throughout the world."⁵²¹ Other southerners agreed. Jefferson Davis mused that if Northerners "[had] tried the experiment of separation,...

there might have arisen ... a reconstructed fraternal Union such as our fathers designed.”⁵²² The Virginia writer Herbert H. Farmer similarly asked, “is it not probable that, if we had separated peaceably, both sections would have prospered?”⁵²³

Some Northern commentators agreed that the North should have let the South secede. Writing in 1902, the New York politician, writer, and pacifist Ernest Howard Crosby fantasized that “if the South had been allowed to secede peacefully” history would have been markedly better.⁵²⁴ Arguing that “the Confederacy would have suffered from its new commercial isolation ... and ... the States of the Confederation would have quarreled,” Crosby speculated that the Southern states “would not have remained long intact,” because with the North’s abolition of the fugitive slave law, “a general exodus of slaves would have begun, and ere long the border States would ... have ceased to be slave States.” “With slavery extinct,” he continued, “the reason for their separation from the North would have ceased, and their commercial interests would have demanded reunion with the United States.”⁵²⁵ The ensuing Union, moreover, would have been more stable than the original one, since “the Southerners would have felt that they had consented to [slavery’s] demise, and they would have accepted the new order with that attitude of acquiescence which is necessary to the success of any social experiment.”⁵²⁶

Other Northerners, by contrast, said Lincoln had to go to war. Horace Greeley supported Lincoln’s hardline response to the Southern attack on Fort Sumter, speculating that “had a similar course been pursued five months ago [under President Buchanan], the last would have been heard of Secession before now. Not the firing of a gun would have been needed.”⁵²⁷ Some critics went further and wished that the North had been even firmer with the South. As Wendell Phillips put it in December of 1861, “if, a year ago,... Jefferson Davis and ... the rest had been hung for traitors at Washington, and a couple of frigates anchored at Charleston, another couple in Savannah, and half a dozen in New Orleans, with orders to shell those cities on the first note of resistance, there never would have been this outbreak.”⁵²⁸ In the long run, John William Draper concluded, if Lincoln had not used force to oppose secession, the Confederacy “would have renewed the African trade,” pursued “territorial expansion,” and eventually become “a military empire founded on Force.”⁵²⁹

The Counterfactual Battlefield: From Bull Run to Gettysburg

Like all military conflicts, the Civil War sparked an enormous amount of counterfactual speculation. Contemporaries as well as later scholars used innumerable “what ifs” in recounting the many battles of the years 1861–1865.

One of the most frequently discussed was the Battle of Bull Run. Also known as the First Battle of Manassas, the clash took place in Northern Virginia on July 21, 1861, and was the first major confrontation of the Civil War. In describing how Southern troops outmaneuvered Union forces and came dangerously close to capturing Washington, D.C. before retreating to Virginia, Northern and Southern critics identified many missed opportunities and close calls. The Union General and writer John A. Logan blamed his fellow General Robert Patterson for disobeying orders and failing to prevent Southern Generals Joseph E. Johnston and P.G.T. Beauregard from linking their forces during the battle, saying “but for this disobedience,... Bull Run would doubtless have been a great victory to the Union Arms ... and the War, which afterward lasted four years, might have been over in as many months.”⁵³⁰ Other commentators, by contrast, saw missed opportunities for a decisive Southern victory. Echoing other Northern commentators, James Ford Rhodes said that if “Beauregard’s army ... had ... made a dash upon Washington, [it would] have probably taken [the city],” while Lincoln’s advisers John G. Nicolay and John Hay concluded that “the seizure of Washington ... would have been a fatal blow to the Union cause.”⁵³¹

Another clash that prompted “what ifs” was the Battle of Antietam. Fought in Maryland on September 17, 1862, it was crucial for giving the North a much-needed triumph at a time when Lincoln was struggling to maintain the Northern population’s commitment to the war following repeated Southern victories under Generals Robert E. Lee and Stonewall Jackson. One reason why Union forces were able to win at Antietam was due to an accident of history that took place on September 9, 1862—the chance discovery by a Union Private, Barton W. Mitchell, of Robert E. Lee’s military plans (known as Order 191) for Southern forces in the region. This “lost order” enabled the normally cautious Union General George B. McClellan to aggressively move Union troops to intercept Confederate forces and prompt the Battle of Antietam on Northern terms, thereby ending the South’s string of victories. It was a tragic missed opportunity for the South. As the pro-Confederate journalist Edward A. Pollard put it, “a little piece of paper” became “the most sorrowful accident of the late war” and denied “the Confederates a victory that might have ultimately decided the immense issue of Southern independence.”⁵³² Antietam also had counterfactual consequences for the North. Prior to the victory, Northern calls for peace were intensifying in the absence of convincing military triumphs. As Rhodes noted, “a signal Confederate victory in Maryland might have caused the Northern voters at the approaching fall elections to declare for the peace that Jefferson Davis would offer them from the head of Lee’s victorious army.”⁵³³



FIGURE 3.11 The pivotal Battle of Gettysburg (1863) sparked much counterfactual speculation about how it might have had a different outcome. (Source: “The Battle of Gettysburg,” by Thure de Thulstrup (ca. 1887). Wikimedia Commons)

The Battle of Gettysburg also generated lots of speculation (Figure 3.11). Long viewed as the turning point of the war, the battle raged between July 1 and July 3, 1863, and featured several pivotal clashes that prompted close calls and missed opportunities. Northern commentators, for instance, questioned General George G. Meade’s defensive strategy against Robert E. Lee’s aggressive stance at Cemetery Ridge and wondered whether he should have mounted a counterattack after the failure of Pickett’s Charge.⁵³⁴ Had Meade done so, according to critics, “the Confederate army might have been destroyed” and the war ended a year sooner.⁵³⁵ Southerners also identified missed opportunities to win the battle. Robert E. Lee himself bewailed the death of Stonewall Jackson, who perished in a friendly fire accident following the Battle of Chancellorsville in May of 1863, noting “Had I Stonewall Jackson at Gettysburg, I would have won a great victory.”⁵³⁶ Touching on a more radical possibility contemplated late in the war, the Confederate colonel William Calvin Oates speculated that “if at Gettysburg Lee had had 50,000 Negro troops under white officers, he would have walked over Meade’s army ... and peace would have been made.”⁵³⁷

As events transpired, the South never recovered from the defeat at Gettysburg. For the next two years, Union troops steadily wore down their Southern opponents, capturing Atlanta on September 3, 1864, under General William Tecumseh Sherman, and eventually making it all the way to Georgia's Atlantic coast. Following Lincoln's reelection triumph over the Democratic nominee General George McClellan later that fall, it was merely a matter of time before General Robert E. Lee surrendered to General Ulysses S. Grant at Appomattox Court House on April 9, 1865.

The Emancipation Proclamation

One of the most important results of the North's military successes was President Lincoln's announcement of the Emancipation Proclamation on January 1, 1863. From the beginning of the war, Lincoln had been ambivalent about freeing the enslaved population of the South, being aware that Northern opinion was split on the issue between radical abolitionists and pro-slavery Unionists. For this reason, Nicolay and Hay argued, Lincoln "never would have [issued the Emancipation Proclamation]... if he had not been compelled by necessity to do it to maintain the Union."⁵³⁸ Once the president recognized that emancipating the slaves would have positive psychological and military benefits to the Northern cause, however, he just had to wait for the right moment to present the decree as a show of strength, not desperation. The victory at Antietam provided exactly that moment. As Rhodes put it, "without [the]... victory [at Antietam,] the Emancipation Proclamation ... might never have been issued!"⁵³⁹

Later writers used "what ifs" to hail Lincoln's proclamation. Praising the president for realizing he could not end slavery without having the "cooperation of his loyal fellow-countrymen," Frederick Douglass speculated that "had [Lincoln]... put the abolition of slavery before the salvation of the Union, he would have inevitably driven from him a powerful class of the American people and rendered resistance to rebellion impossible."⁵⁴⁰ John Burgess agreed that Lincoln's policy "was the only [one] upon which he could hope to unite the North and divide the South," noting that "a pronounced anti-slavery policy ... would have produced the directly opposite effect."⁵⁴¹ Lincoln's wisdom was further borne out by reports of Northerners criticizing the proclamation with counterfactual laments that "they never would have joined the army had they known that they were to be used for the freeing of slaves."⁵⁴²

Northern writers further debated whether Lincoln should have issued the proclamation earlier. Speaking in favor of that prospect was the historian

John C. Abbott, who in the fall of 1861 argued that “an earnest proclamation [freeing the slaves]... would have spread ... from plantation to plantation, like electric fire” and, before long, “the slaveholders would have been compelled to remain at home to watch their negroes,... [while] in a fortnight, 50,000 lusty arms would have been in the patriot camp.”⁵⁴³ By contrast, Nicolay and Hay argued that “If the President had adopted the policy when it was first urged upon him by impulsive enthusiasts, it would have brought his Administration to political wreck, as was ... indicated by the ... election reverses of 1862.”⁵⁴⁴

Other Northern commentators voiced the nightmare that emancipation might not have come to pass at all. Abbott speculated that if the war had ended earlier—for example, if Union forces had seized the Confederate Capital of Richmond in 1861—“some compromise would have been effected which would have preserved slavery, the ... cause of all our troubles.”⁵⁴⁵ Similarly, Greeley, aware of the growing demands by Northerners for peace in 1862, declared that “had a popular election been held at any time during the year following the Fourth of July, 1862,... a majority would have voted for Peace [and]... against Emancipation.”⁵⁴⁶ The pro-Southern historian William Archibald Dunning agreed, speculating that “had hostilities terminated before the whole South was occupied by the armies of the United States, there would have been no legal basis for a claim to freedom on the part of the slaves in the unoccupied regions.”⁵⁴⁷

The North's Triumph: Close Calls for the Union

In explaining the North's triumph in the war, many commentators used close-call counterfactuals to explore a nightmare that never came to pass. Some underscored Lincoln's importance to the Union victory by imagining his absence from history. Referring to the violent rhetoric emanating from Southern sources after Lincoln's election in 1860, as well as his ensuing decision to journey to the White House under secret cover, Ulysses S. Grant said that “there is little doubt that he would have been assassinated if he had attempted to travel openly throughout his journey.”⁵⁴⁸ Frederick Douglass, meanwhile, worried that Lincoln might have lost the 1864 election to General George McClellan, who was running as a Democrat on a platform of sectional reconciliation, writing that such a defeat “would have been a fatal calamity,” as

it would have prevented the abolition of slavery, which would have continued to “rend the country again ... [in the near] future.”⁵⁴⁹ Speaking more broadly, Rhodes concluded that the Union victory “could not have been accomplished without great political capacity at the head of the Northern government and a sturdy support of Lincoln by the Northern people.”⁵⁵⁰

Supporters of the Union also imagined close calls involving Black soldiers serving in the Union cause. A Black Union officer, Martin R. Delany, declared in 1865 that “if it was not for the black men, this war never would have been brought to a close with success to the union.”⁵⁵¹ Around the same time, a Black periodical noted that were it not “for two hundred thousand muskets which the negro added to the army of the union the Federal Congress might not have been able to sit today.”⁵⁵² For their part, Black soldiers used counterfactuals to appreciate their experience. In his book *Army Life in a Black Regiment* (1870), Thomas Wentworth Higginson quoted a former slave-turned-soldier named Thomas Long who said, “If we hadn’t become sojers, all might have gone back as it was before; our freedom might have slipped through de two houses of Congress and President Linkum’s four years might have passed by and notin’ been done for us.”⁵⁵³

Northerners also imagined nightmare scenarios in which they lost the war. While historians and other writers floated many such possibilities in the years after 1865, the most concise summation of them appeared in a 1909 speech at Gettysburg National Cemetery by President William Howard Taft’s Secretary of War Jacob McGavoc Dickinson (Figure 3.12).⁵⁵⁴ Although a Southern Democrat from Mississippi, Dickinson advanced a nationalist message of sectional reconciliation, declaring that “few thinkers ... in the North [today]... question the patriotism of those in the South” and “[few Southerners believe] it would have been better if it had succeeded in establishing an independent government.”⁵⁵⁵ Pointing to “the tremendous evils to all the States which would ... have followed upon the establishment of the Southern Confederacy,” Dickinson declared that if the South had won, “there would have been hate and rivalry between the north and the south as intense as that [today] between France and Germany.”⁵⁵⁶ Northern press coverage of the speech endorsed the sense that a Southern victory would have produced a catastrophe. While *The New York Tribune* said it would have created “two rival nations with antagonistic interests,” *The Washington Evening Star* said it would have produced “a new peril to the whole North American continent.”⁵⁵⁷



FIGURE 3.12 In a 1909 speech at Gettysburg National Cemetery, the U.S. Secretary of War, Jacob McGavock Dickinson, floated the nightmare scenario of the South winning the Civil War. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Counterfactuals and the “Lost Cause”: Fantasies of a Confederate Victory

By contrast, Southerners fantasized about how they could have won the Civil War. In so doing, they revealed the importance of “what ifs” to the “Lost Cause” myth. Coined by Edward A. Pollard in his 1866 book *The Lost Cause*, the term was originally meant to justify the Confederacy’s rebellion.⁵⁵⁸ To the extent that the narrative cast any accusations, it blamed the Confederacy’s leaders, especially Davis, for the war and exonerated the South’s population, casting them as virtuous people betrayed by the elites. It also advanced a benign

view of slavery. These ideas reflected the anger felt by white Southerners in the early Reconstruction period about Northern occupation and Black emancipation. After President Rutherford B. Hayes withdrew Union soldiers from the South in 1877, however, the restoration of white hegemony, the recovery of the South's economy, and the fading of Confederate veterans' war memories produced a kinder view of the Confederacy's leaders, who, together with ordinary soldiers, were glorified in monuments, holidays, and speeches. In this increasingly nostalgic period, Southern historians began to pursue reconciliation with the North and declared their loyalty to nation over section.⁵⁵⁹ At the same time, however, ordinary Southerners defended the Lost Cause just as fervently as ever.⁵⁶⁰

During the period 1865–1914, counterfactuals buttressed the Lost Cause narrative. They were abundantly visible in early postbellum works of history, but after 1900, they became more explicitly thematized in such texts as “Suppose the South Had Succeeded” (1909), “Another View of What Might Have Been” (1909), and *The War Between the Union and the Confederacy and its Lost Opportunities* (1905).⁵⁶¹ “What ifs” also frequently appeared in journals, such as the *Southern Historical Society Papers* (founded in 1876) and *Confederate Veteran* (founded in 1893), both of which included innumerable first-person accounts by former soldiers exploring missed opportunities and close calls in pivotal battles.⁵⁶² All of these works explored how the course of history might have turned out differently for the South.

Some writers used counterfactuals to explain the Confederacy's military defeat. Noting that Southern troops were hopelessly outnumbered by the presence of immigrant and Black soldiers in the Union Army's ranks, the Virginia Colonel W.H. Stewart declared in 1910 that if “Europe [had] made her hireling hordes ... cultivate the earth for honest bread [in Europe]” instead of exporting them to the U.S. where they “swelled the ranks of [the Union's] invasion,” then “a Confederate soldier would be President of the Confederate States at this hour.”⁵⁶³ Another Confederate veteran, James W. Boyd, argued in 1903 that “If the United States had not enlisted a single white American citizen, its armies would [still] have outnumbered the total enlistment of the Confederate army by 80,017 men.”⁵⁶⁴ Southern bitterness in defeat was also visible in Stewart's claim that the Confederacy's loss was due to deserters, writing that if “the deserters from our ranks [had] stood true to the flag, our spirit nation would now be the proudest republic on the face of the globe.”⁵⁶⁵

Other Southern critics used “what ifs” to blame the defeat on Jefferson Davis (Figure 3.13). Citing an array of military miscalculations—for instance, removing General Joseph E. Johnston from his post in the summer of 1864 as Northern troops were moving against Atlanta—Edward A. Pollard asserted that Davis

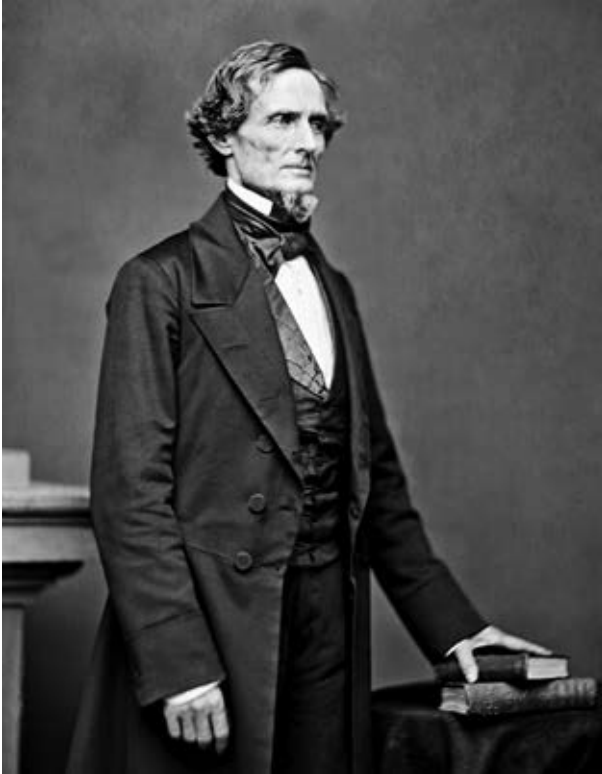


FIGURE 3.13 Southern critics used “what ifs” to blame Jefferson Davis for the Confederacy’s defeat in the Civil War. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

“might have continued a distinguished man in a lesser cause, [but]... ended his career in unequalled ... degradation.”⁵⁶⁶ John Burgess agreed, noting that while Davis originally “stood head and shoulders above all the others” who were candidates for President of the Confederacy, his stature paradoxically fated him to be the leader of a doomed state, speculating that “Davis might have done better, if only he had not done so well.”⁵⁶⁷ By focusing their ire on Davis, Southerners exonerated the larger population for the Confederacy’s defeat. Arguing that Southerners were “the better men,” Pollard insisted that “the Confederates, with an abler Government and more resolute spirit, might have accomplished their independence.”⁵⁶⁸ Pollard went so far as to fantasize that if Davis had been overthrown and replaced with Robert E. Lee, the legendary general “could have commanded public confidence [and] reanimate[ed]... the war.”⁵⁶⁹

Southerners further used counterfactuals to relativize the evils of slavery. Writing in 1901, the Confederate Army chaplain James Battle Averitt argued

that if the enslaved people of the South had not been treated well, "the several hundreds of thousands of dusky forms of African laborers, at the close of the first decade of this century would not have grown into the millions which we all know were found south of the Susquehanna in 1865."⁵⁷⁰ The Southern writer Hunter McGuire made a similar point, noting that if slavery had been so bad, no amount of Southern troops "could have stayed the flood of [slave-led] rapine and arson and pillage that would have started with the first gun of the Civil War," before noting that no such violence erupted.⁵⁷¹ James Williams, meanwhile, restated the old religious claim that "but for [their]... enslavement" and conversion to Christianity, Black Africans would have remained "heathens [and been] consigned ... to the horrors of eternal publishment."⁵⁷²

Southerners also fantasized that they would have abolished slavery themselves. Pointing to the military potential of enslaved persons and the North's enlistment of "one hundred thousand" Black soldiers during the war, the former Confederate Army colonel William Calvin Oates claimed that the South's "enlistment of negroes" at the same time "would have spared the lives of many white men" and "enhanced ... the probability of early recognition of the Confederacy by European Governments."⁵⁷³ Whether such a measure would have found popular approval, however, was open to debate. The Mississippi cavalry officer Frank A. Montgomery noted that when the idea was floated in 1864 and 1865, it was too late and "would [not] have met the approbation of the great mass of the southern people, even if it would have assured independence."⁵⁷⁴ Oates argued, however, that "had ... a leader ... [like] Davis appealed to the people, they would have sanctioned it, for they were then in a frame of mind to do anything to win ... independence ... [and] would have said 'Let slavery go.'"⁵⁷⁵ The "failure of the Confederate Congress to realize the vast importance of timely action," Oates concluded, was "one of the [South's] greatest missed opportunities" to win the war.⁵⁷⁶

Other Southerners argued that if the South had won the war, the Confederacy would have abolished slavery in later years. Writing in 1909, a Louisiana writer, Watkins Leigh, noted that "the institution of slavery, mild, benignant, and fraternal ... was already doomed, and would have fallen in a few years," since "a ... growing ... minority in the South itself would have compelled emancipation ... whether or not the War of Secession had ever been fought."⁵⁷⁷ Had "a plan of gradual emancipation" been pursued "instead of the one now in operation," Henry Foote explained, it "would have been far better for all concerned," as it would have avoided "the great shock to the planting operations of the South."⁵⁷⁸ The Tennessee Reverend James R. Winch, meanwhile, wrote that if "emancipation would have taken place in the natural course of events," Southerners "would have to-day a class

of servants unequaled in the world, knowing their position and respectful to their masters.”⁵⁷⁹

Broadly speaking, Southerners rejected the Northern belief that a Confederate victory would have been a nightmare.⁵⁸⁰ Many responded angrily to Secretary of War Dickinson’s 1909 speech in Gettysburg by offering their own “what ifs.” Watkins Leigh rejected the idea that a Southern victory “would ... have been an unleavened evil,” arguing that “many of the ... problems which threaten the life of our civilization ... [would have been avoided],” declaring that “the Fourteenth and Fifteenth Amendments would never have been written,” “the awful nightmare of reconstruction would never have been suffered,” and “the delusion of a social and political equality ... would have been [prevented].”⁵⁸¹ A Virginia veterans group protested Dickinson’s speech by saying “had the close of the war separated our fortunes for a time from those of the Northern States, we should probably be no less happy and no less prosperous,” since “[we] would have ... given to the world ... a constitution which was a model chart with a homogeneous population, knit together by common sufferings and glories.”⁵⁸² Southern newspapers, meanwhile, protested the speech by using reversionary counterfactuals to argue that, after a Confederate victory, “mutual commercial interests would have [eventually brought]... the governments ... back together.”⁵⁸³ In the end, while some Southerners embraced Northern views in the spirit of national reconciliation, the self-appointed guardians of the Lost Cause consistently enforced the traditional Southern narrative.⁵⁸⁴ History “might have been better,” *The Southern Historical Society* concluded in 1900, insisting that “if the South had been successful in the war,... the country ... would have benefited.”⁵⁸⁵

The Rise of Counterfactual Self-Awareness

The more that Americans wondered “what if?” about the Civil War, the more they became self-reflexive about doing so. Some commentators signaled this new awareness by adding disclaimers to their hypotheses. After speculating that “slavery would have been utterly abolished” if Northerners “had responded to [pro-slavery] sentiment ... thirty years ago as they responded to the tidings of the attack upon Fort Sumter,” William Lloyd Garrison added the cautionary observation: “it is in vain to talk about what might have been.”⁵⁸⁶ Edward A. Pollard said something similar when he wondered “whether, on the hypotheses of certain events, the Secessionists [of South Carolina] might have been ... overruled” in December of 1860, before noting that it was “a question we are not permitted to discuss.”⁵⁸⁷ Others questioned whether “what ifs” were worth

the effort—for instance, Charles Eugene Hamlin, who, in writing about the abrogation of the Missouri Compromise said that it was “easy to look back over the printed pages of history ... and wonder,” before adding that doing so “may not be worthwhile.”⁵⁸⁸ Finally, in hypothesizing whether the passing of the Crittenden Compromise might have prevented the war, French Ensor Chadwick noted that the question was “a subject for limitless ... argument, with futility as an end.”⁵⁸⁹

Yet despite recognizing the shortcomings of counterfactuals, Americans also recognized their analytical and moral utility. In assessing President Buchanan's response to the South Carolina secession crisis, James Ford Rhodes explained that “compar[ing]... what he did with what he ought to have done” allowed one to conclude that “[he] made the most miserable failure.”⁵⁹⁰ In discussing the failure of the Compromise of 1850 and its role in sparking the war, the political scientist Jesse Macy wrote that for people to learn “more perfect rules for moral conduct,” it was crucial to examine not just “that which has been [in history]” but to study “what might have been.”⁵⁹¹ Finally, in debating with the Georgia politician Robert Toombs on the eve of secession about how the South might have developed outside of the Union, Alexander Stephens declared that “we can only put the fact against speculation and conjecture.”⁵⁹²

Commentators on the war especially recognized the importance of counterfactual analysis for military history. In an 1896 essay, entitled “What Might Have Been,” a veteran of the Gettysburg campaign, William J. Hardy, commented on the battle's centrality in American consciousness by noting “the volume of ifs” that surrounded the battle, arguing that they revealed how “military critic[s]” embraced “speculations as to what might have happened in different dispensations.”⁵⁹³ Similarly, the New York politician and journalist J. T. Headley remarked that “there are always supposed events after a [military] defeat, which, had they occurred, would have made it a victory.”⁵⁹⁴

Other commentators recognized that “what ifs” were underpinned by different emotions. James Ford Rhodes perceptively observed that it was “regret for the war which characterizes the present speculation [about]... whether it might not have been avoided.”⁵⁹⁵ Edward A. Pollard made a similar point in discussing Jefferson Davis's removal of General Joseph E. Johnston in 1864, noting that “in history, we are often grieved ... at the narrow chances on which are determined the most important events,” adding “we say to ourselves, if such and such things had not been so,... a great disaster might have been averted, or a good cause might have been saved.”⁵⁹⁶ By contrast, another writer highlighted the significance of relief, using the fiftieth anniversary of the Battle of Gettysburg in 1913 to emphasize the “thrill of dread ... [evoked by] how very near we [in the North] came to crushing defeat,” before concluding that the

"Ifs of history" were redeemed by the divine mission of "God ... to lead North and South through fire and blood ... to save ... the world."⁵⁹⁷ Finally, Watkins Leigh exposed the subjectivity of counterfactual speculation, noting it was mere "fancy" for "any man to say what would have been the policy of the South in the event of her success," concluding that "one man's speculations [are]... of no more value than another's."

American writers further displayed their growing awareness of counterfactual history by using it analogically and intertextually. In discussing the defeat of Union troops at the Battle of Chickamauga in Georgia on September 20, 1863, Daniel Wait Howe speculated that the "result would undoubtedly have been vastly different had it not been for the disaster [that Union forces suffered] on Sunday [September 20th]," when they were overrun by Confederate forces, adding, "but for this, possibly 'Flodden had been Bannockburn.'"⁵⁹⁸ A direct quotation from Sir Walter Scott's famous poem *Marmion* (1808), this remark alluded to the longstanding Scottish fantasy that their historic defeat at the hands of the English at the Battle of Flodden in 1513 could have, in actuality, turned out like the Scots' famous victory over the English at Bannockburn in 1314. Howe's use of the phrase in the context of the Civil War expressed the recognition that counterfactuals had a long history in western thought. Another example was offered by James Ford Rhodes, who, in assessing the role of William Lloyd Garrison's abolitionist journal *The Liberator*, in sparking the Civil War, quoted Napoleon's remark, "If Rousseau had never lived ... there would have been no French Revolution" to ask whether "if Garrison had not lived, the Republicans would not have succeeded in 1860" (Figure 3.14).⁵⁹⁹

American writers did not merely show awareness of counterfactuals but signaled their presence in their texts. Some prefaced their counterfactual remarks with extra-diegetic comments that called attention to their constructed nature. In 1866, George Lunt wrote, "Let us imagine, for a moment, the condition of the country, as it would have been, if the slaves had been made free upon the adoption of the Constitution," before going on to paint a nightmarish portrait of how American history would have been worse.⁶⁰⁰ Similarly, in a 1904 speech at a commemorative dinner celebrating Abraham Lincoln, the New York Republican Congressman Jacob Sloat Fassett declared, "imagine, if you can, what would have been the result if ... the Constitution had not been strong enough to prevent dissolution of the Union ... [and] that if instead of having one nation today this continent would have contained ... the dis-United States of America."⁶⁰¹

Finally, the growing acceptance of counterfactuals was illustrated by their use as didactic tools in school textbooks. One of the "suggestive questions and



FIGURE 3.14 Writing in 1906, the historian, James Ford Rhodes, sought to explain the origins of the Civil War by citing a counterfactual observation by Napoleon Bonaparte about the origins of the French Revolution. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

topics” in Edward Channing’s book *A Student’s History of the United States* (1902) was the counterfactual question, “precisely what would have been the effect of the Wilmot Proviso had it been passed?” Another book, Arthur Dayton Cromwell’s *Students’ Outline for the History of the United States* (1903), asked students to consider the question “what bad results would have followed if we had let the South go?”⁶⁰² Finally, *A History of the United States for Schools* by John Fiske (1894) asked the question “what ... made compromises on slavery ... desirable?... What might have happened if these compromises had not been made?”⁶⁰³

Conclusion

The eruption of the Civil War played a notable role in anchoring counterfactual thinking in American culture. Although Americans in the late eighteenth and early nineteenth century had speculated considerably about the course of the American Revolution, they had experienced few subsequent events of the same magnitude and thus had little reason to wonder “what if” to the same degree in the half-century that followed. The events of 1861–65, however, changed this radically. The secession of the South, the splitting of the nation into two warring sections, and the eventual defeat of Confederacy constituted a traumatic historical legacy that later Americans struggled to come to terms with. In the years between 1861 and 1914, American historians, politicians, and other writers used counterfactuals to explain, judge, and remember the Civil War. They typically did so for partisan purposes, with supporters of the Union and Confederacy seeking to convince the other side that their cause had been just. In the end, neither side succeeded in persuading the other, for the unverifiability of their “what ifs” prevented the forging of consensus. This divisiveness ultimately proved to be representative of counterfactual thought more broadly, as would be shown by the controversy generated by the eruption of World War I.

“What Ifs” and World War I: Trauma and Speculation in the Interwar Era

The outbreak of the World War ... was [not]... the inevitable outcome of the European system of ... alliances ... [but grew out of] the specific personalities and policies of 1914. ... This can be proved ... by reflecting as to what would have been the outcome of the crisis after the murder of the Archduke [Francis Ferdinand] if [István] Tisza had been in control of Austrian policy, [Joseph] Caillaux in charge of matters in France, [Vladimir] Kokovtsov, Foreign Minister of Russia in the place of [Sergey] Sazonov, and ... Earl Loreburn in the shoes of Sir Edward Grey. Under such circumstances it is utterly inconceivable that war could have resulted.⁶⁰⁴ (Harry Elmer Barnes 1928)

The eruption of World War I further boosted counterfactual thinking throughout the western world. Not long after the conflict began in the summer of 1914, millions of people in Europe and North America bitterly debated who was most to blame: the Central Powers (Austria-Hungary and Germany) or the Triple Entente (Russia, France, and Great Britain). The debate has since gone on for more than a century, but it was never as intense as it was in the first two decades after the war's eruption. From 1914 until the early 1930s, commentators from all the warring nations—including monarchs, prime ministers, diplomats, generals, journalists, and historians—published memoirs, polemics, and monographs examining the war's origins and consequences. In so doing, they frequently employed counterfactuals. As was seen in the claim of the American historian Harry Elmer Barnes, scholars sought to determine whether the war was inevitable or avoidable.

In the same way that scholars in the United States used counterfactuals to debate the origins of the Civil War, commentators from the nations of the Triple Entente and Central Powers used “what ifs” because empirical methods were unable to resolve the bitter divisions caused by the conflict. European and American writers used counterfactuals to rhetorically bolster their respective positions. Mobilizing them offensively as well as defensively, they used “what ifs” to explain the war's long-term and short-term origins. They examined the roles of nationalism, militarism, and imperialism; they explored the assassination of the Archduke Francis Ferdinand; and they investigated the great powers' diverging responses to the ensuing “July crisis”—including Serbia's

intransigence, Austria-Hungary's warmongering, Germany's incitement, Russia's mobilization, France's passivity, and Great Britain's indecisiveness.

Whatever aspects of the war they addressed, all parties used counterfactuals to explain and judge. In addressing issues of causality and morality, most participants in the debate used missed opportunity counterfactuals to show how the war was avoidable and deterministic counterfactuals to show how it was inevitable. In doing so, they sought to assign responsibility for the war's eruption. Commentators analyzed the war's origins in several ways. Those who were nationalistically minded partisans used "what ifs" to blame their enemies for missing opportunities to avoid war. Many of these same commentators simultaneously used deterministic counterfactuals to exonerate their own nations by showing how they could not have acted differently. Other observers, by contrast, were less nationalistic in orientation and used "what ifs" self-critically to show how their own side had missed opportunities to preserve peace and instead went to war. All the participants in the broader debate, finally, grounded their "what ifs" in fantasy and nightmare scenarios: they showed how history would have been better if the war had been avoided and how it might have been worse if their nations had not fought as they did. In so doing, all sides expressed regret and relief for how history ultimately transpired.

The frequent use of "what ifs" to debate the origins of World War I boosted the popularity of counterfactuals in western culture and helped it gain a further hold in the mass media. As this trend intensified, some commentators showed a growing willingness to be self-reflexive about the merits and drawbacks of counterfactual speculation. Indeed, some linked the eagerness to wonder "what if" to the war experience, arguing that the traumatic rupture caused by the Great War—and the feelings of regret that it spawned—had sensitized people to the role of chance in human affairs. Between 1914 and the early 1930s, in short, commentators did not just use counterfactuals to examine the war; they were prompted by the war to examine the nature of counterfactuals.

Debating the War's Origins

Historical studies on the origins of World War I appeared in several phases between the years 1914 and 1930. During the war itself, all the great powers published "color books" containing documents related to the conflict: the Serbian *Blue Book*, Austrian *Red Book*, German *White Book*, Russian *Orange Book*, French *Yellow Book*, and English *Blue Book*. All these texts advanced a message of national innocence and enemy guilt. This tendentious trend also defined many early postwar memoirs and works of historiography. Especially

after the Treaty of Versailles declared Germany and Austria-Hungary responsible for the damage caused by the war, representatives of the Entente nations and Central powers took starkly opposing views on the question of war guilt. By the 1920s, however, most nations witnessed the emergence of "revisionist" trends that were defined by a willingness to upend early orthodox views and distribute blame for the conflict more widely. This trend was especially prominent among liberal and pacifist critics in the United States, France, and Britain, while in Germany it was mostly embraced by the socialist left.⁶⁰⁵ All these texts, regardless of their orientation, employed abundant counterfactuals. While they varied according to their authors' national backgrounds and political viewpoints, the texts used "what ifs" consistently, employing missed opportunity counterfactuals to depict the war as avoidable and deterministic counterfactuals to prove it was inevitable.

The Bosnian Crisis

Most historians after 1914 agreed that the killing of Austrian Archduke Francis Ferdinand by the young Serbian nationalist Gavrilo Princip in Sarajevo on June 28, 1914, sparked the eruption of the Great War (Figure 4.1). They also agreed that his killing was fueled by Serbian nationalism and hatred of Austria-Hungary for impeding the formation of a Greater Serbia. Historians disagreed, however, on whether the Archduke's murder was avoidable or inevitable and whether the war could have been averted had he lived.

In the wake of the Archduke's assassination, both contemporaries and later scholars debated whether his death could have been avoided. Most commentators recognized that the killing was the result of contingent events involving the band of assassins associated with the Serbian terrorist organization known as the Black Hand. Some made clear that Princip was only able to shoot the Archduke and his wife because of unforeseen mistakes made by the assassins during the royal couple's visit to Sarajevo. After one of the plotters, Nedjelko Čabrinović, failed to kill Francis Ferdinand and his wife by throwing a bomb at their motorcade as it headed to the city's town hall (the bomb bounced off the car's roof and exploded nearby), a second attack proved successful over an hour later when the Archduke's driver, while taking the royal couple to visit the wounded victims of the first attack at a nearby hospital, took a wrong turn on a Sarajevo side street. When "the car stopped and backed up," the American historian Bernadotte Schmitt explained, "Printsip, who was standing on the sidewalk, shot both the Archduke and the Duchess—which ... he would not have been able to do but for the unfortunate error."⁶⁰⁶ For the British

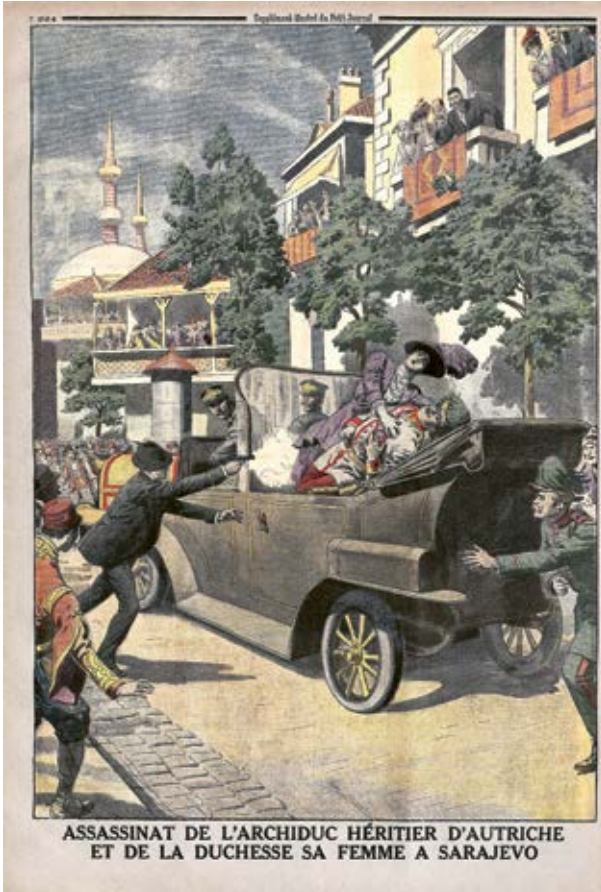


FIGURE 4.1 Following the killing of Austrian Archduke, Francis Ferdinand, by the Serbian nationalist, Gavrilo Princip, in Sarajevo on June 28, 1914, Europeans debated whether the murder was avoidable or inevitable. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

historian Robert William Seton-Watson, the episode underscored the crucial role “played by the element of blind chance,” noting “had the Archduke’s car not been driven by a chauffeur ignorant of the town,... the Archduke would ... have escaped.”⁶⁰⁷

Other scholars said the killing of Francis Ferdinand might not have happened if the Serbian government had acted in timely fashion to prevent it. According to the Italian historian Luigi Albertini, Serbian Prime Minister Nikola Pašić had become aware of the assassination plot earlier in 1914 and had told the Serbian Minister in Vienna, Jovan Jovanović, to inform

Austro-Hungarian officials, but the information was never conveyed. This failure led Albertini to speculate that "if the Serbian Minister had informed [Austrian Foreign Minister, Leopold] Berchtold of what awaited the Archduke at Sarajevo, Francis Ferdinand in all probability would either not have gone there or would have been better guarded than he actually was, so that events would have taken another course."⁶⁰⁸ While other scholars questioned this premise, the American historian Sidney Fay said there was no denying that the Serbian premier "failed to give Austria any warning ... which might have averted the fatal crime" (Figure 4.2).⁶⁰⁹

By contrast, other observers argued that Francis Ferdinand's death was inevitable. The American journalist Isaac Don Levine attributed the Archduke's killing to the clash between Slavic and German nationalism, declaring that "only by the self-negation of one party could a collision have been averted"—a possibility "that would have been a negation of the very soul ... of modern nationalism."⁶¹⁰ Once the Archduke arrived in Sarajevo, Luigi Albertini argued, the intensity of Serbian nationalism made Francis Ferdinand into such a "symbol of the tyranny" that "any other man in his place would have met with the same fate."⁶¹¹ As Sidney Fay noted, there were so many assassins sent to Sarajevo that the Archduke's death was assured, declaring that "if [he]... had escaped Princip's bullet as he did Chabrinovitch's bomb, so many others were prepared to slay him that he could scarcely have left Sarajevo alive."⁶¹² Seton-Watson added that if the Archduke had somehow made it out of Sarajevo, he "would ... have fallen to one of the ... large number of other youths" in Dalmatia and Croatia who "were sworn to [make an] attempt [on] his life."⁶¹³

Contemporaries also debated whether war would have erupted had Francis Ferdinand not been assassinated. Many speculated that the Archduke's plan to reform the Austro-Hungarian state by giving the South Slavs equality with Germans and Hungarians might have stabilized the monarchy for years to come. The German writer Hermann Lutz noted that "the tragedy of the Central Powers was that the one man who would have had ... the capacity to guide the development of the Monarchy into safe paths fell prematurely by the hand of an assassin."⁶¹⁴ The British writer Edith Sellers speculated that had the Archduke lived, he "could have held together the diverse races over whom he would have ruled ... [and] put a rein on [the]... ambitions of [the Pan-Slavs]."⁶¹⁵ Most importantly, because Francis Ferdinand sought to avoid a military conflict with Serbia, Sidney Fay argued, had he lived, "there would have been neither an Austro-Serbian War, nor a World War, in the summer of 1914." Affirming the importance of chance in human affairs, Fay concluded: "the murder of the Archduke ignited material which would not otherwise have taken fire as it did, or perhaps not at all."⁶¹⁶



FIGURE 4.2 The American historian, Sidney Fay, partly blamed the Serbian government for failing to provide Austria-Hungary with a warning that might have prevented the assassination of the Archduke. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Other observers doubted that Francis Ferdinand's survival would have prevented the war's eruption. Fay himself conceded that the Archduke's reform plan could never have calmed the nationalist passions brewing in the Empire, arguing it "would have certainly provoked bitter opposition from Germans and Magyars."⁶¹⁷ Seton-Watson agreed, declaring "murder or no murder, the seething pot would have continued to boil until Austria-Hungary could evolve a policy compatible with Yugoslav interests, or alternatively, until the Yugoslavs of the Dual Monarchy could shake off her yoke."⁶¹⁸ The Austro-Hungarian diplomat Ottokar Czernin insisted that no reform plan could have fixed the Habsburg monarchy, which "was already so rotten that it could not have stood any great innovations, and if not the war, then probably the revolution, would have shattered it."⁶¹⁹ Finally, the German writer Maximilian Harden noted that

Francis Ferdinand's death was ultimately irrelevant given Austria's desire to attack Serbia, noting that "the murder of the heir to the throne ... offered the welcome pretext ... [for] war, [which] would have been fought without it."⁶²⁰

Could Austria-Hungary Have Prevented the War?

Whether or not Austria-Hungary was, in fact, hell-bent on war was one of the major questions examined by historians after 1914. Critics and supporters of Austria-Hungary argued back and forth about the country's decision to attack Serbia. Critics accused the Austro-Hungarian government of missing opportunities to settle its grievances with the Serbs peacefully—either by issuing a more reasonable ultimatum after the Archduke's murder, accepting Serbia's ensuing response, accepting outside arbitration of the dispute, negotiating with Russia, or listening to last-minute German efforts at mediation. In response, Austria-Hungary's supporters employed deterministic counterfactuals to show that if the country had not gone to war with Serbia, it would have neglected its core security interests and been doomed.

Austria-Hungary's critics and defenders first debated the merits and drawbacks of the country's July 23 ultimatum to Serbia. This strongly worded ultimatum included a series of sweeping demands and required a reply within forty-eight hours. Sidney Fay conceded that the demands might have been "justified" if they "had been honestly calculated merely to exact punishment for ... the Sarajevo assassination" but concluded that because they were "deliberately framed with the expectation that they would be rejected," the ultimatum had to be "condemned ... as one of the main causes of the World War."⁶²¹ An American journal similarly commented in 1917 that "if Austria had not coupled her unreasonable ultimatum upon Serbia with a still more unreasonable time limit," then "the war would almost certainly have been prevented."⁶²²

By contrast, Austria-Hungary's defenders rejected the claim that the country's ultimatum contributed to the war. Many cited possible nightmares if Austria-Hungary had not issued the strong ultimatum. Count Berchtold noted that "if we had continued to suffer Servian agitation in our country, our existence as a State ... [and] a Great Power ... would have suffered," while Austro-Hungarian General and Chief of the General Staff Franz Conrad von Hötzendorf said that if "[we] had once again yielded after Serbia's violent attack, it would have [emboldened]... South Slavic, Czech, and pro-Russian groups ... [and] shaken the state's structure" (Figure 4.3).⁶²³ For this reason, Austrian leaders fantasized that punishing the Serbs would have solved the Empire's problems. If Serbia had been punished, Conrad mused, "a disruptive



FIGURE 4.3 The Austro-Hungarian Chief of the General Staff, Franz Conrad von Hötzendorff, insisted that if Austria had not responded forcefully to Serbia after the Archduke's murder, the Habsburg monarchy's very existence would have been endangered. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

force that constantly threatened peace would have been eliminated ... and all other powers would have been granted the blessing of peace.”⁶²⁴ Austria's German allies felt the same way, with members of the General Staff declaring that “the whole of Europe would have breathed freely if its mischief-maker had been suitably chastised, and peace and order thus restored in the Balkans.”⁶²⁵ If anything, the German policy analyst Alfred von Wegerer wrote, Austria should have “made the time-limit [of its ultimatum]... shorter and had sent [it]... to Belgrade a few days earlier,” because in response, “the Serbian Government very likely would have yielded unconditionally” and Vienna would have gained that diplomatic victory which she desired.”⁶²⁶

Other observers noted that Serbia's reply to the ultimatum on July 25 might have been more accommodating. Although the Serbian government accepted nearly all of Austria-Hungary's demands and said it was open to abiding by a "decision of the International Tribunal of the Hague ... or ... Great Powers," Conrad found this response unsatisfactory and noted that "if Serbia had 'unconditionally accepted' Austria Hungary's ultimatum, then 'the war would have been avoided.'⁶²⁷ Count Berchtold similarly defended the ultimatum on July 23, saying that "Serbia could have avoided the severity of our serious demarche ... by taking the measures for instituting an inquiry ... against the Servians who took part in the ... murderous plot."⁶²⁸

Others denied that the Serbian response to the ultimatum was responsible for the war. In seeking to defend Serbia, Russia's Foreign Minister Sergey Sazonov wrote that Serbia's "acceptance in full ... would have been equivalent to a voluntary abdication of [its]... national independence."⁶²⁹ Taking a very different approach, the American writer James M. Beck used a substitution counterfactual to elicit sympathy for Serbia, saying that Austria's ultimatum was just as improper as a hypothetical ultimatum Germany would have given to France if "an Alsatian citizen of German nationality ... had assassinated the [German] Crown Prince," declaring "every fair-minded man would say ... that such an ultimatum would be an unprecedented outrage upon the fine proprieties of civilized life."⁶³⁰ Still others defended the Serbs by saying that no amount of accommodation would have satisfied the Austrians. Declaring that Austria "wanted war ... at any cost," the German diplomat Wilhelm Mühlön argued that "Serbia could have ... accepted all the propositions of the note and Austria-Hungary would ... not have declared herself appeased."⁶³¹ The Italian Prime Minister, Antonio Salandra, agreed, noting that "if Serbia had ... accepted the ... note in its entirety,... [it] would not have persuaded Austria to cease hostilities."⁶³²

Austria-Hungary's critics added that the Empire could have accepted Serbia's reply to the ultimatum and moved to arbitration. Bernadotte Schmitt wrote that "If Austria-Hungary had been willing to negotiate on the basis of the Serbian reply, she could have demanded the rigid execution of the promises made, and, in default of Serbian performance, her diplomatic position would have been unassailable."⁶³³ Had this happened, British historian J.W. Headlam argued, "the punishment [that]... might have been ... inflicted upon Serbia ... would have been accepted ... by the people [as representing]... the united voice of Europe."⁶³⁴ Yet, as Schmitt noted, Austria-Hungary "had not expected so great a surrender on the part of Serbia" because it "was determined not to accept a diplomatic solution," and so the result was war.⁶³⁵ "When one recalls

the infinite treasure of property and life, which would thus have been saved ... had ... Austria accepted this reasonable and pacific course," James Beck concluded, "one can only exclaim,... 'oh, the pity of it!'"⁶³⁶

Austria-Hungary's supporters, in turn, dismissed the possibility of arbitration as pointless. Defending the Habsburg government's rejection of the option, American writer Robert L. Owen asked whether the "Russian, French, or English government [would] have accepted ... any [such demand]?"⁶³⁷ The British MP and pacifist E.D. Morel sought to generate sympathy for Austria-Hungary by asking his fellow Britons to imagine how they would feel if "the Prince of Wales had been murdered in the streets of an Indian town close to the Afghan border and ... the Indian Government [was] convinced ... that Afghan agents had inspired the crime," declaring that "the British Government [would not] have gone to a Conference under such circumstances."⁶³⁸ Similarly, Harry Elmer Barnes wrote that "[if] Theodore Roosevelt and his wife had been shot at El Paso, Texas, in December, 1900, by a full-blood Mexican citizen of the United States,... [and] the Mexican authorities offered no apologies and made no efforts to run down the conspirators," the United States [would] hardly "have submitted to a Brazilian demand for ... arbitration."⁶³⁹

In response to such claims, critics of the Habsburgs said they still could have avoided war by negotiating more sincerely with the Entente powers. Noting that Russian Foreign Minister Sazonov was willing to pressure Serbia into making concessions to avoid war, Albertini wrote that the Habsburgs "should have talked the matter over with St. Petersburg ... and [secured]... the repression of the anti-Austrian movement [with]... the support of the other Powers."⁶⁴⁰ The French historian Pierre Renouvin, meanwhile, alluded to British Foreign Minister Sir Edward Grey's proposal that Austria-Hungary be permitted a symbolic victory by being permitted to have its armed forces temporarily occupy Belgrade, arguing that "if Austria ... had agreed ... to limit her military activity to the occupation of Belgrade, an understanding [with Russia] might well have been reached."⁶⁴¹ Austria-Hungary's biggest mistake, according to critics, was rejecting German efforts at mediation. Noting that German Chancellor Theobald von Bethmann-Hollweg had asked Austria's Foreign Minister Berchtold to consider a peaceful resolution of the conflict in late July, Sidney Fay argued that Austrian resistance made the German effort moot, noting even "if [Bethmann-Hollweg] had ... spoken in stronger terms [to the Austrians], it would not have prevented the Austrian declaration of war on Serbia" because Berchtold had already decided on this step in order "to cut the ground from any attempt at intervention."⁶⁴²

Could Germany Have Prevented the War?

Western observers also debated whether Germany could have prevented the war. Critics, both foreign and domestic, accused the German government of missing opportunities to preserve Europe's peace by failing to restrain Austria, negotiate with Russia, accept mediation from Britain, and respect the neutrality of Belgium. Germany's defenders, by contrast, employed deterministic counterfactuals to argue that if the country had not acted as it did, its national interests would have been seriously endangered.

Germany's critics indicted the country for not keeping Austria-Hungary from declaring war on Serbia. During the July crisis of 1914, Russia's Foreign Minister, Sazonov argued that "Austria would not have acted so aggressively without the consent of Germany."⁶⁴³ In the early 1920s, the German writer Hermann Kantorowicz agreed, writing that if Germany had not endorsed Austria's "violent solution in July 1914," then "the war would not have erupted."⁶⁴⁴ Around the same time, the French pacifist Georges Demartial wrote: "Surely there would have been no war in August 1914 if Germany had deterred Austria from any military action against Serbia."⁶⁴⁵ Some commentators claimed the Kaiser's government never should have given Austria-Hungary the infamous "blank check" in early July 1914 supporting a Habsburg attack on Serbia even in the event of a Russian mobilization. Writing in 1928, France's President Raymond Poincaré asserted that "if only [Germany]... had not egged [Austria]... on" during the crisis, more moderate leaders like "Franz Joseph and [Hungarian Prime Minister] István Tisza would have had a fair chance of easing things a little" and preventing war.⁶⁴⁶ Other commentators said that the Germans should have remained neutral when Austria-Hungary clashed with Serbia. Had this happened, the German pacifist writer Richard Grelling noted, "the war would have been ... localised between Russia and Austria, and neither France nor England would have been drawn into the struggle."⁶⁴⁷

Many critics blamed Chancellor Bethmann-Hollweg and Kaiser Wilhelm II for failing to restrain Austria (Figure 4.4). According to Grelling, merely "a nod" from Bethmann-Hollweg "would have been enough to restrain Austria."⁶⁴⁸ Sazonov agreed, writing that "the Berlin Cabinet ... could have prevented the whole ... crisis ... [but refrained from exerting any]... influence on their ally."⁶⁴⁹ Others highlighted Kaiser Wilhelm II's failure to intervene in the crisis. Regretting the fact that the Kaiser "did not send a single cablegram in the interests of peace to his illustrious ally, the Emperor Francis Joseph," James Beck crafted a medium form, additive effect counterfactual in which the Kaiser did contact his counterpart with a telegram that read:

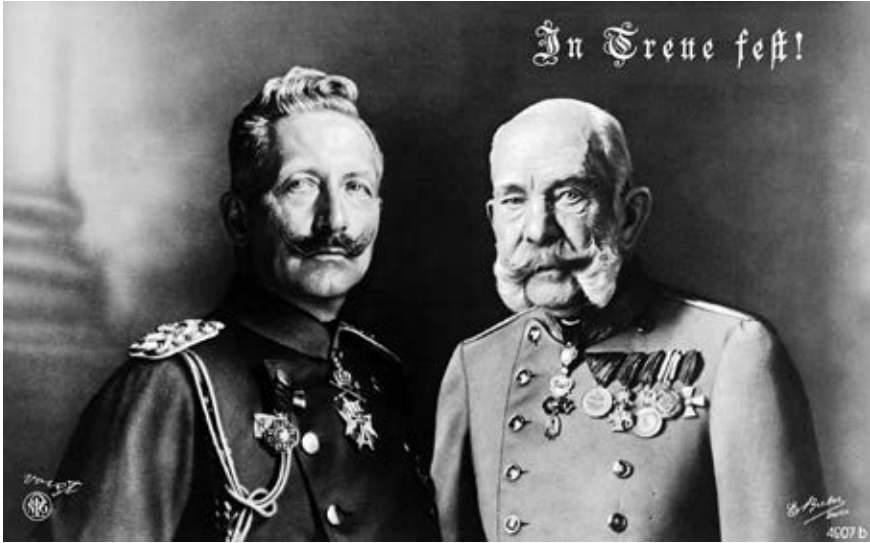


FIGURE 4.4 Many observers faulted Kaiser Wilhelm II for failing to restrain his fellow monarch, Emperor Franz Joseph I, from attacking Serbia. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

I agree with you that the Servian reply is not satisfactory [and]... shall ... support with the full power of the German sword the cause of Austria. ... [But] I shall be gratified if you can agree that ... time shall be granted ... to Russia, England, and France ... [to] determine ... whether it is not possible to preserve peace without sacrificing in any respect the legitimate demands of Austria, which have my full sympathy.

Speculating that “the Austrian Emperor, himself a noble-minded and peace-loving monarch [would probably not have] refused this reasonable request,” Beck regretted that the German Kaiser never reached out, concluding “a little ... forbearance for the rights of other States and the youth of Europe need not have perished. Again, ‘the pity of it.’”⁶⁵⁰

By contrast, Germany’s defenders said the country had no choice but to support Austria. Bethmann-Hollweg noted that “any idea of breaking up the alliance would have been madness, seeing that the Entente group was now so firmly consolidated that there could be no prospect of any sudden change there.”⁶⁵¹ German General Helmuth von Moltke agreed, saying “the German people would have shown no understanding for such a felony,” adding that it ultimately “would have backfired, since the English-French encirclement policy would have continued ... and in a few years we would have faced the

same war, this time without, or even possibly against, Austria."⁶⁵² In this event, Sidney Fay noted, "the internal dissolution of Austria would have been accelerated," the country's "prestige in the Balkans would have completely dried up," and before long, "Russia, with her growing population and ambitions, would have ... control[ed]... Constantinople and the Straits."⁶⁵³ More nightmarish still, Bethmann-Hollweg concluded, "If Austria had fallen, the Slav world would have secured the success of centuries. ... [and eventually] determined the day ... on which Germany should cease to exist as a Great Power" (Figure 4.5).⁶⁵⁴

Critics also said Germany could have better managed tensions with Russia. After Austria-Hungary declared war on Serbia, Russia ordered a partial mobilization of its army on July 25 and a general mobilization on July 30. In response, Germany issued an ultimatum to Russia to demobilize or face a declaration of war. When the demand went unheeded, Germany declared war on August 1. Many critics blamed Germany for missing opportunities to avoid this turn of events. The head of the German Navy, Admiral Alfred von Tirpitz, faulted the German government, saying "we ought to have [used]... the advantage that we were militarily on the defensive with regard to Russia, by leaving the declaration of war to the Russians."⁶⁵⁵ The German Ambassador to Britain, Count Karl Max Lichnowsky, declared "we ought to have sent to St. Petersburg a representative who ... [could] have convinced Russia that we wished neither to control the Straits nor to strangle Serbia."⁶⁵⁶ James Beck, meanwhile, blamed Kaiser Wilhelm II for failing to respond to last-minute overtures from Tsar Nicholas II, saying "Had the Kaiser been as pacific [as the Tsar] and ... been inspired by the same enlightened spirit in the interests of peace ... it would have been possible to prevent the shedding of blood."⁶⁵⁷

Germany's supporters replied by noting that if the country had not mobilized its army and declared war on Russia, its position would have been dramatically weakened. The authors of the German *White Book* emphasized the threat posed by Russia and asserted "that if the [German]... Government had neglected to meet this danger, it would have endangered the safety and even the existence of Germany."⁶⁵⁸ The famed sociologist Max Weber agreed, noting that "Germany could have avoided the war with Russia only temporarily and only on the condition of giving up all lands of West Slavs and its own independence to Petersburg and Moscow's absolute rule."⁶⁵⁹ Helmuth von Moltke explained that when "Russia mobilized its army, we too were obliged to mobilize, for if we had not done so, Russia would have been able to invade our defenseless land at any time and prevent us from completing any subsequent mobilization."⁶⁶⁰ Because Russia was determined to fight Germany eventually one way or another, waiting until later would only have put Germany at



FIGURE 4.5 German Chancellor Theobald von Bethmann-Hollweg feared that if Austria fell, Germany would have collapsed as a great power. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

a disadvantage. According to the American writer Fredrick Bausman, by 1916, Russia's "strategic railways and ... heavy artillery would ... have been complete" and the country would have been "an antagonist which Germany might have been unable to withstand at all."⁶⁶¹ Had Germany not responded to Russian mobilization, Alfred von Wegerer noted, "the Russian army would doubtless have got to Berlin," occupied the city, and brought about "an immediate collapse."⁶⁶² If Russia had gone on to win the war, Bausman bleakly concluded, "all Scandinavia," all the "Baltic Provinces," and all of "Central Europe" would have been "annexed to that dark empire," which "would have extended an absolute

autocracy to the Rhine" and soon "have flung their drunken challenges to France and England."⁶⁶³

Critics also said Germany could have dealt more skillfully with England. One missed opportunity took place in late July 1914, when Germany rejected Sir Edward Grey's invitation to a conference of ambassadors with Britain, France, and Italy to arbitrate Austria-Hungary's grievances with Serbia and Russia. Had Germany participated, Richard Grelling noted, "the four Powers ... would have been successful in arriving at a solution, and ... frustrated the war."⁶⁶⁴ The German diplomat, Count Karl Max Lichnowsky, agreed, writing that the "acceptance of the British proposal would have brought about a relaxation of the tension and ... improved our relations with England."⁶⁶⁵ James Beck also blamed Germany for not fully endorsing Grey's July 25 message to Austria requesting "more time" to organize the conference, insisting that "Austria would [not] have ignored its ally's request ... if it had ever been made."⁶⁶⁶

Germany's defenders, however, rejected the possibility of British mediation. Dismissing Grey's invitation to the ambassador's conference, the French writer Alfred Fabre-Luce declared that for Germany "to have accepted would have involved a considerable sacrifice on their part," especially since, of the four powers to be convened, the Triple Entente had two closely-allied powers (Britain and France), while the third, Italy, was not really that close to Germany, so that "consequently Grey's procedure would have led to Austria being condemned by three votes to one."⁶⁶⁷ Other observers said Germany never could have trusted British in the first place. Declaring "it was inevitable that England was going to rise up against Germany," Helmuth von Moltke argued that the Kaiser "would have been more likely to come to an agreement ... with France or Russia than a reliable neutrality pact with England."⁶⁶⁸

Critics blamed Germany for missing one last opportunity to preserve peace on August 3, 1914, when it declared war on France and invaded the country through neutral Belgium. Condemning the move as both cowardly and risky, Wilhelm Mühlton argued that "a direct and honorable attack launched against the French eastern frontier would have been safer than the movement across Belgium."⁶⁶⁹ The British Prime Minister during the war's second half, David Lloyd George, also regretted the invasion, writing that "had Germany respected the integrity of Belgium ... there would have been plenty of time for passions to exhaust their force and for the sanguine expectations of military enthusiasm to evaporate."⁶⁷⁰ James Beck, finally, condemned the invasion by employing a substitution counterfactual and asking American to imagine a scenario in which "Germany ... require[ed]... the United States to permit it to land an army in New York" and that the Germans thereafter "arrest[ed] its Mayor,

and check[ed] the first attempt of its outraged inhabitants to defend the city by demolishing the Cathedral, the Metropolitan Art Gallery, the City Hall,... and shooting down remorselessly large numbers of citizens, because a few non-combatants had not accepted the invasion with due humility." "Although Germany had not entered into any treaty to respect the territory of the United States," he concluded, "no one would seriously contend that Germany would be justified in such an invasion."⁶⁷¹

In response, Germans defended their country's actions as unavoidable. Not long after the beginning of hostilities, a multi-authored document, entitled *Truth About Germany*, insisted that "Germany would have exposed itself to the danger of a military defeat if it had ... respected the neutrality of Belgium after it had been announced that strong French detachments stood ready to march through that country against the advancing German army."⁶⁷² Bethmann-Hollweg cited Germany's unenviable dilemma about having to fight a two-front war, saying "we had no choice but to declare war on France ... [and make] ourselves appear as the aggressor," adding "I do not think that we could have avoided being forced into this position."⁶⁷³ Helmuth von Moltke refuted the claim that the invasion of Belgium brought Britain into the war, saying it was "inevitable" that Britain was going to war against Germany.⁶⁷⁴ Going even further, the authors of *Truth About Germany* deflected German guilt by saying "England in [Germany's]... place would have swallowed [Belgium] up ... long ago."⁶⁷⁵

In explaining Germany's plunge into war, commentators pointed to a combination of military aggressiveness and diplomatic cowardice. If "Moltke's will to war had not been in the ascendant" in the last days of July, Luigi Albertini noted, "diplomatic efforts for peace "might have borne different fruits."⁶⁷⁶ This would have been likely, he added, if "Bethmann had not let himself be overruled by Moltke [and] had insisted with Berchtold ... that Austria should content herself with the Anglo-German proposals,... the peace of the world might have been saved."⁶⁷⁷ For his part, Bethmann-Hollweg defended himself by saying "it would have been too heavy a ... responsibility for a civilian authority to have thwarted a military plan that had been elaborated in every detail and declared to be essential."⁶⁷⁸ Other commentators attacked the Kaiser for failing to pursue peace. Tirpitz criticized Wilhelm II for leaving on a sudden vacation cruise to Norway in the middle of July while tensions were building, writing that "if the Emperor had remained in Berlin ... [he] would probably have found ways ... of evading ... war."⁶⁷⁹ Sir Edward Grey agreed, writing that "in the critical moment after the Serbian reply," the Kaiser "withheld his influence, when it might have been decisive for peace."⁶⁸⁰ Raymond Poincaré made a similar point about the Kaiser's mobilization decision on July 31 against

Russia., writing that "Germany could always have mobilized her army without declaring war and ... thus have retained her advantage over Russia and yet not wrecked all chances of peace."⁶⁸¹

Supporters of the Germany, by contrast, said the Army had no choice but to declare war on Russia and France. Had Germany not done so, Alfred von Wegerer argued, "the result would have been a vain waiting on Germany's part for the beginning of hostilities, and the loss of the opportunity to play her trump card, namely the speedy offensive against France through Belgium."⁶⁸² Employing a substitution counterfactual to defend Germany's declaration of war, Frederick Bausman asked Americans to sympathize with Germany's fear of being caught between Russia and France by having them imagine the "state of panic" they would have felt "if there were in Mexico a population of one hundred and fifty millions, possessing [an]... army of three million men," while the "Government at Washington" continued to "permit ... the continuation of so bold a menace."⁶⁸³ Germany's defenders also used aggrandization counterfactuals to refute the claim that the country was a warmongering bully. Had Germany's desire been to 'subjugate' Europe," Morel argued, "she would have struck at France and ... Russia when her superior armament ensured her the certainty of ... success on several occasions within the past twenty years."⁶⁸⁴ The authors of *Truth about Germany* similarly insisted that the country had actually shown tremendous restraint while the Triple Entente was taking shape against it, insisting that "a warlike, militant nation would not long have endured such conditions, but would have compelled a [preventive] war and carried it through swiftly."⁶⁸⁵ The fact that such an attack never materialized proved Germany's innocence.

Finally, European leftists wondered whether the German working class could have prevented the war. Many critics condemned the decision of Germany's Social Democratic Party (SPD) to join the Kaiser's "truce" (*Burgfrieden*) of August 4 and approve war credits to support his military campaign. In June of 1919, the moderate Social Democratic politician Eduard Bernstein sadly wrote that "if we could have seen what was going to happen [in the conflict], we would have had reason to have said 'no,'" adding that that if the party had done so, "millions of people would not have been killed."⁶⁸⁶ Russian communists were even more critical of the Social Democrats' failure to prevent the war. Already in the late summer of 1914, Vladimir Lenin said that the SPD "should not have joined the chauvinist camp" and should instead have "unmasked its vileness," while a year later, Leon Trotsky wrote if European Marxists "[had] foreseen" the "danger to Europe" posed by nationalism and warn[ed] the people against the rulers,... how great would now have been the authority of international socialism to the masses ...!"⁶⁸⁷

By contrast, the Independent Social Democratic politician Karl Kautsky took a less self-critical position and exonerated the German masses for not preventing the conflict. In his book *The Guilt of William Hohenzollern* (1920), Kautsky speculated that if “German Social Democracy [had] known that the Austrian Ultimatum had not taken the German Government by surprise ... and that Germany was not the peaceable third party endeavouring to intervene between the ally and her opponents but the fellow-conspirator of Austria, then our Party ... would have turned as sharply against the German Government.” Had this happened, he speculated, the Kaiser “would have had either to forgo war or to begin it by locking up every leader of the Social Democracy.” “The great masses of the non-proletarian working classes,” he continued, “would also have joined [the workers] and ... the German Government could not possibly have launched a great war.” In the end, “the ruling system would ... have been doomed,” the “prestige ... of the German people ... would have been infinitely enhanced,” and “Social Democracy ... [w]ould have saved the peace of the world.”⁶⁸⁸ Tragically, however, these events remained pure fantasy.

Could Russia Have Prevented the War?

Commentators also charged Russia with missing opportunities to avoid war. Many argued that the country failed to force Serbia to appease Austria-Hungary and failed to reassure Germany about Russia’s intentions by provocatively mobilizing its army. The critics who advanced these claims mostly hailed from outside of Russia. By contrast, the country’s defenders included Russians, mostly from conservative backgrounds, who used deterministic counterfactuals and nightmare scenarios to explain why the country could not avoid mobilizing its armed forces against Austria-Hungary.

Many critics blamed the Tsarist government for Serbia’s refusal to accept Austria-Hungary’s ultimatum of July 23, 1914. Harry Elmer Barnes argued that Russia should never have supported Serbia in the first place,” noting that “in ... light of her incitement of Serbia against Austria ... Russia would have had slight justification for intervention” on Serbia’s behalf, “even if Austria had planned to annihilate [it]... in 1914.”⁶⁸⁹ Bethmann-Hollweg insisted that “a word from St. Petersburg would have sufficed to induce the Serbs to guarantee such satisfaction as would have contented Austria and would have brought about a *modus vivendi*.”⁶⁹⁰ Luigi Albertini made a similar point, asserting that “if Russia had not ... advised against acceptance, the Serbian Government would have given in,” adding that “without ... [Russia’s] aid,

Serbia would have found herself forced to swallow the Austrian ultimatum whole."⁶⁹¹ As a result, he concluded, "Austria would have won the war ... without firing a shot."⁶⁹²

Unfortunately, others noted, Russia had no intention of allowing this outcome to happen. As Bernadotte Schmitt said of outside efforts to negotiate the Austrian-Serbian conflict, "no diplomacy, however skillful, could have [overcome]... the determination of Russia not to permit the crushing of that small state."⁶⁹³ The British political scientist G. Lowes Dickinson also focused on Russia's eagerness to fight, arguing that while none of the European great powers wanted war, they all "would ... have entered when Russia did," adding that if the country had not sparked the conflict in 1914, "[it]... would ... have started it a year or two later."⁶⁹⁴

Other commentators attacked the Russian government for ordering its armed forces to begin partial mobilization against Austria-Hungary on July 25, 1914. Within a week, this action precipitated a German declaration of war against Russia. The American historian Albert Bushnell Hart wrote that "Emperor William would have held his hand for a few days if Russian mobilization had not seemed to him a warlike act directed at Germany."⁶⁹⁵ Luigi Albertini insisted that Sazonov was unaware that Germany viewed mobilization as a threat, writing, "had [he]... known that for Germany any mobilization was equivalent to war, there is no doubt that he would have shaped his course differently."⁶⁹⁶ Expressing regret for this oversight, Albertini noted that "if the [Russian government] had not proclaimed partial mobilization, the General Staffs at St. Petersburg, Paris, Berlin, and Vienna would never have been able to thrust themselves into the foreground and some peaceful solution of the conflict would have been found."⁶⁹⁷ Describing Germany's ongoing efforts in late July to keep Austria from attacking Serbia, Harry Elmer Barnes wrote, "no one can say that they would not have succeeded if Russia had refrained from mobilization."⁶⁹⁸ Even the Serbs saw Russia as to blame, with the Chargé d'affaires at Berlin Lyuba Yovanovitch noting in early August of 1914 that "If Russia ... had not ordered the mobilisation of her whole forces, there would have been no war, for ... Austria-Hungary would have probably been satisfied with the occupation of Belgrade."⁶⁹⁹

Critics of Russia focused especially on Tsar Nicholas II's failure to resist the aggressive demands of the hardline militarists in his government and army. There was little doubt, according to the U.S. Senator Robert L. Owen, that "Nicholas could have stopped the mobilization" but did not (Figure 4.6).⁷⁰⁰ The reason, Kaiser Wilhelm II noted in his memoirs, was due to the machinations of Foreign Minister Sazonov (Figure 4.7). After Nicholas II responded to the Kaiser's peace telegram of July 30 by ordering the Chief of the General



FIGURE 4.6 AND 4.7 Many commentators insisted that Tsar Nicholas II and his Foreign Minister, Sergey Sazonov, could have kept Russian forces from mobilizing after the murder of the Archduke. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Staff General Nikolai Januskevitch to call off mobilization, Sazonov told the latter to ignore the order as “nonsense,” prompting the Kaiser to remark that “stop[ping] the [Russian] war machine ... would have been possible and peace might have been preserved if Sazonov had not frustrated his wish.”⁷⁰¹ Finally, Frederick Bausman confirmed the Russian Army’s desire for battle by insisting that “had this war not occurred in 1914, it would have occurred within two years more from the determined policy of the Russian court.”⁷⁰²

Russia’s defenders predictably justified the country’s conduct with deterministic counterfactuals that underscored the war’s necessity. Sazonov explained that military requirements prevented Russia from yielding to Germany’s demobilization demand on July 31, writing that “it would have been impossible, on technical grounds, to comply with this request,” adding that “our demobilization ... would have introduced ... disorder into our military organization [that]... our enemies would have immediately taken advantage of.”⁷⁰³ Luigi Albertini agreed, noting that “Russian prospects in [the war]... would

have been injured by partial mobilization, which would have upset the one existing plan for general mobilization."⁷⁰⁴ Pierre Renouvin also judged Russia generously, noting that while the country's "partial mobilization represented an escalation," it could not have been "otherwise," given Austria's rejection of "all efforts at conciliation."⁷⁰⁵

Others imagined the nightmares that might have ensued if Russia had not mobilized its forces. Some focused on the broader geopolitical ramifications of Russia not rallying behind Serbia. Renouvin speculated that "had [Austria succeeded in]... reducing Serbia to the level of a vassal state,... Russia's position in the Balkans would have been greatly weakened and her prestige in Europe would have received an overwhelming blow."⁷⁰⁶ Sazonov similarly defended Russia's support for Serbia by saying that "any other solution ... would assuredly have upset the European balance of power by securing the hegemony of Germany."⁷⁰⁷ J.W. Headlam, meanwhile, argued that "[if] Russia had ... [not] give[n]... help to Serbia ... there would ... have been ... a prolonged and bitter guerrilla war,... [after which] Serbia would ... have come under Austrian occupation ... [and eventually]... ceased to exist."⁷⁰⁸ Had the Central Powers gone on to win the war, Sazonov feared, "Russia would have lost the shores of the Baltic [along with]... her Black Sea provinces [and in the process]... would have been cut off from the sea altogether and become once more of the same size as Muscovia in the seventeenth century."⁷⁰⁹ This outcome, Sazonov bleakly concluded, "would have been the death-warrant of Russia."⁷¹⁰

Could France Have Prevented the War?

France was also accused of missing opportunities to keep Europe from descending into conflict. Compared to the other great powers, France played a less prominent role in the July crisis but was still involved in key events. President Raymond Poincaré ordered French troops to mobilize on August 1 after Germany declared war on Russia; two days later, Germany declared war on France and sent its troops through neutral Belgium on their way to the French frontier. Already during, but especially after, the war, critics on the socialist left said that the liberal Poincaré government could have avoided war had it restrained Russia by not replacing key peace-minded diplomats with war-mongering substitutes. They also speculated that if the Radical-Socialist party had been in power (and if the party's leaders Joseph Caillaux and Jean Jaurès had remained in office) in the summer of 1914, France could have remained at peace. By contrast, France's defenders, both nationalists at home

and supporters abroad, used deterministic counterfactuals to argue that, if the country had not decided as it did, its core interests would have been threatened.

Many critics accused France of failing to restrain Russian aggression in the Balkans. As Austria and Serbia became embroiled in tensions following the assassination of Francis Ferdinand, France, according to the pacifist writer Georges Demartial, “could have said of the ‘Austro-Serbian conflict ... what an American recently said of the Germano-Silesian conflict,” namely, “that [he]... was as indifferent to it as the Trojan War.”⁷¹¹ Luigi Albertini agreed, noting that “France ... was in a position to have exercised friendly restraint and proffered counsels of prudence [to Russia] which might have averted the catastrophe.”⁷¹² Frederick Bausman, meanwhile, fantasized that “[if] the French Government had notified Russia that ... France would not join her [in defending Serbia],” it was unlikely “that Russia would even have mobilized.” “Had France taken this position,” he asserted, “there could have been no general European War.”⁷¹³

One reason France failed to do so was because Poincaré’s government deliberately removed pacifist diplomats from key positions in the period leading up to the war (Figure 4.8). In a controversial 1921 essay, the pro-Habsburg French ambassador to Austria-Hungary, Philippe Crozier, claimed that “his policy might have maintained peace” had he not been asked to step down in 1912, while a year later, the French journal *L’Éclair* speculated that “the war of 1914–1918 might have been avoided if Crozier’s efforts had been supported.”⁷¹⁴ Not long thereafter, the same journal sparked further controversy when its pro-German editor, Ernest Judet, attacked Poincaré for replacing the pro-peace French ambassador to Russia, Georges Louis, who was quoted in the essay claiming that “if [he] ... had remained Ambassador to Petersburg, ... we wouldn’t have had the war.”⁷¹⁵ Partly because of the situation with diplomatic personnel, critics focused on the responsibility of President Poincaré for failing to restrain Russia. According to Sidney Fay, “If ... Poincaré had ... said unmistakably to Russia: ‘Do not order general mobilization for the present while diplomatic negotiations are going on’... war might still have been avoided [as] Russian general mobilization had not yet been ordered.”⁷¹⁶ Bausman added that “a single telegram from the French Government to the Russian would have prevented this war [and]... saved civilization from ... catastrophe.”⁷¹⁷

Other critics said that France could have chosen to abandon Russia as an ally. After the war, French pacifists accused President Poincaré of deceiving the French people by claiming the country was at war due to Germany’s August 3 declaration, rather than the fact that France in 1912 had secretly promised to support Russia in any future conflict with Austria. In his famous 1926 pamphlet “Fourteen Questions,” the journalist René Gerin accused Poincaré of knowing that his “promises to Russia probably would not have been approved if they



FIGURE 4.8 Many commentators alleged that French Prime Minister, Raymond Poincaré, could have done more to reduce tensions with Germany on the eve of war. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

had been presented to parliament” in 1912 and charged the president of “paving the way to 1914” in the form of a “preventive rather than a defensive war.”⁷¹⁸ Georges Demartial fantasized that if only truly democratic oversight “had been in force in ... France,” then “the French government would not have been allowed to [pursue]... secret military conventions” and “the war would not have taken place.”⁷¹⁹ Demartial pointed to the existence of escape clauses in France’s treaty with Russia and argued that “if in 1914 the French Government had not wished war, it could have profited by this door, which the Russian Government had left open, to get out [of the conflict].”⁷²⁰

The French government’s failure to restrain Russia, critics concluded, proved that France was a warmongering nation. Using a rebuttal counterfactual,

Frederick Bausman argued that if France had really wanted peace, “she would have left an indelible record of remonstrances and caution to her unscrupulous ally,” but none were visible in the French *Yellow Book*.⁷²¹ Switching to a deterministic counterfactual, Bausman accused Poincaré of knowing all along that “even if Germany had let France alone, his country would have attacked Germany on behalf of Russia.”⁷²² Georges Demartial also believed Poincaré yearned for battle, saying

the German declaration of war against France was not ... the cause of France's entry into the war ... [but rather] the consequence of it. If Germany had remained on the defensive [against France], it would have been the French Government which would have had to declare war upon Germany, because ... the French Government could not long have remained a spectator in a Germano-Russian war.⁷²³

Indeed, Demartial said in 1927 that France was “the main obstacle to a true peace” and asserted that if the country were not “out of breath, money and blood, [it] would have already started [to make plans for war] again.”⁷²⁴

By contrast, the supporters of France argued that the country's abandonment of Russia would have led to a catastrophe. Poincaré rejected Gerin's claim that France had pursued a “preventive war” due to its commitments to Russia, insisting that “if Germany had not declared war against us, we would not have declared war against it, but would have been obliged to discuss the matter in parliament.”⁷²⁵ At the same time, Poincaré insisted on Russia's importance, arguing that France “could not have disavowed the Russian alliance since that ... would have made us isolated in European affairs.”⁷²⁶ Taking a similar position, Bernadotte Schmitt said it was unlikely that “France could have abandoned Russia without destroying the alliance,” adding that “if France had declined to march with Russia, the peace of Europe probably would have been preserved. But it would have been a peace tolerable only to Austria-Hungary and Germany.”⁷²⁷ As J.W. Headlam explained, “the next time [that France]... was in difficulties she would have appealed in vain to Russia for support and have been confronted without allies by the whole strength of Germany and Austria.” The result would have been a new European order defined by “the hegemony of one single State” and France would soon have fallen “into submission to the preponderance of Germany.”⁷²⁸

French commentators also wondered whether the war could have been prevented had the Socialists been in power. Several months before the war's eruption, France's Radical Party appeared poised to form a government based on its impressive showing in the parliamentary elections of April and May of 1914. Unfortunately, French leftists experienced a double blow when two of

their most important leaders, Finance Minister Joseph Caillaux and Socialist Party head, Jean Jaurès, respectively lost their political positions through scandal and assassination in March and July of 1914.⁷²⁹ Because both men were foreign policy doves who preferred a policy of rapprochement with the Central Powers (best seen in Caillaux's appeasement of Germany during the 1911 Morocco crisis), their departure from the historical stage sparked numerous counterfactuals.

One of the most notable was the possibility that if Caillaux had been Prime Minister, France would not have entered the war. In 1924, the American writer Naboth Hedin declared that if Caillaux "would have again become premier" there would have been "a change in the European situation," but without him, "the war was on."⁷³⁰ Harry Elmer Barnes made a similar point on several occasions, writing that "if the French had adopted in 1914 a policy comparable to [the mild one]... taken by Caillaux in the ... Morocco crisis, there would have been no World War," adding that "had Caillaux remained in power, there is little probability that [Russia]... could have brought France around to a war-like policy by 1914."⁷³¹ For his part, Caillaux said that if he had "remain[ed] in power," he would have "prevent[ed] 'the great war ... by the exercise of the same policy [used in Morocco],'" explaining "that in 1914, the situation was child's play compared to that of 1911."⁷³²

By contrast, more conservative commentators rejected the idea that a Caillaux government would have improved the course of history. In 1925, the anti-German writer André Chéradame used a long nightmare scenario to attack Caillaux's pro-German reputation, saying if he had been premier in July of 1914, France would have remained neutral and

[Germany] would have obtained what she wanted without having to fight for it ..., [while]... the Slavs of Austria-Hungary and the Balkans would have been practically reduced to bondage. Russia [and]... France ... would have vanished as great powers and,... become vassals of Germany. The latter would then have found itself the master of Europe and the Pan-German Plan would have been achieved.⁷³³

The conservative journalist Léon Daudet similarly dismissed Caillaux's belief that "the war might have been avoided if [France]... had consented to a friendly ... understanding with Germany after the Agadir incident," insisting that "the Hun is insatiable."⁷³⁴ The American writer, Laurence Lyon, agreed, writing that Caillaux's policy of pursuing a "settlement of all outstanding differences with Germany ... would have been ... fatal to his ... country."⁷³⁵ Worse still, according to the anti-Socialist American writer Severance Johnson, when



FIGURE 4.9 Many French observers insisted that World War I might have been averted if the French socialist leader and pacifist, Jean Jaurès, had not been assassinated by a violent French nationalist on July 31st, 1914. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

the “Huns began marching on Paris,” Caillaux would have allowed Paris to “fall ... into the hands of the commune.”⁷³⁶

Other writers imagined that if Jean Jaurès had survived, France might have avoided war (Figure 4.9). Many commentators speculated that Jaurès would have exposed France’s alliance with Russia as a mistake. The French pacifist Fernand Gouttenoire de Toury noted that if Jaurès had lived, he “would have continued ... to assert that Republican France had nothing to do with the struggle between Austrian and Russian imperialisms.”⁷³⁷ One American commentator agreed, writing that Jaurès “was one of the few clearsighted leaders who [saw that the Russian alliance]... would prove a great calamity,” adding

that "had the French but listened to Jaurès ... there would have been no war at all."⁷³⁸ Demartial, meanwhile, declared that Jaurès had been the only member of parliament "who could have compelled a hearing" about the secret decision of Poincaré government to support Russia but had "disappeared a few days before."⁷³⁹ Finally, Gouttenoire de Toury believed that Jaurès would have seen through "the trickery and lies of the government," resisted the push to war, and "spared humanity a good part of its misfortunes!"⁷⁴⁰ Unfortunately, Jaurès' death denied the socialist movement a broader chance to bring peace to the world. As the British writer Margaret Pease concluded, "Jaurès was the leader who might have shown the way through the dark mazes in which we are now wandering ... [into] the new day."⁷⁴¹ But it was not meant to be.

Could Great Britain Have Prevented the War?

Britain was also blamed for failing to prevent the Great War. During the late days of the July crisis, Sir Edward Grey tried to organize a conference of ambassadors to resolve the dispute between Austria, Serbia, and Russia but failed to gain the support of the Central Powers. One week later, the British government vacillated in responding to Germany's declaration of war against Russia and France because the terms of the Triple Entente did not require Britain to go to war in the event one of its partners was attacked. While the ensuing invasion of Belgium ultimately forced the government to declare war, in the weeks leading up this decision, Britain's ambiguous stance in the crisis caused widespread confusion. All these realities led commentators to lament various missed opportunities to avoid war. They included the possibility that Britain could have better explained its official position in 1914; warned its allies that it might stay neutral; and alerted its enemies that it might fight. According to these observers, if Britain had done any of these things, history would have turned out much better. By contrast, defenders of British policy used deterministic counterfactuals to show that these actions would have made it worse.

Certain critics said that England could have been less ambiguous about its stance on the Balkan crisis. Arguing that Britain's "vacillation ... made France and Russia feel that they could count on England's support, while it made Germany and Austria equally certain that England would remain neutral," Harry Elmer Barnes explained that the country's stance was "as dangerous ... as ... if she had come out for intervention on the side of France and Russia from the beginning."⁷⁴² Hermann Lutz agreed, writing that if "Great Britain ... [had] clearly stated her position, world peace would have been saved."⁷⁴³ The British government minister, Robert Reid, the 1st Earl Loreburn, agreed that if Britain's

leaders “had explained their position “unequivocally,” they “might have exercised enormous pressure on either side” and been able to “keep the peace.”⁷⁴⁴

Britain also could have alerted Russia and France that it would deny them support unless they helped diminish tensions. Sidney Fay wrote that “if Sir Edward Grey had ... warned France and Russia ... that if they became involved in war, England would remain neutral,... Russia would have hesitated with her mobilizations, and France would probably have exerted a restraining influence at St. Petersburg.”⁷⁴⁵ Bethmann-Hollweg agreed, noting that “the Cabinet in London could have made the war impossible if it had ... declared ... that Great Britain would not allow a Continental war to develop from the Austro-Serbian conflict.”⁷⁴⁶ Lutz concurred, writing “Had Britain ... brought similar pressure to bear on St. Petersburg, peace would have been preserved.”⁷⁴⁷ The Earl Loreburn created a medium form, hybrid counterfactual in which he imagined that “our own Cabinet [could]... have said to the French Government at the outset [that]... unless you can restrain Russia from mobilizing till we agree that the necessity for doing so is come, we will not join you in arms” (Figure 4.10). “If we had taken up that attitude,” he declared, “Russia would ... have ... delay[ed]... in mobilizing ... on 31st [of] July, and that ... would have given the short time that was needed to settle the whole controversy between Austria and Russia.”⁷⁴⁸

Britain also could have warned Germany and Austria that it might side with France and Russia in the conflict. The Earl Loreburn argued that “if Germany had thought for a moment that Great Britain would go in with France and Russia, she would never have undertaken the enterprise,” while the Conservative politician and later Prime Minister Bonar Law went even further and claimed that “the war would never have occurred [at all].”⁷⁴⁹ The Russian diplomat and former Foreign Minister Alexander Izvolsky similarly speculated that “if England had at once declared her solidarity with Russia and France ... Germany and Austria would have hesitated,” while his colleague Sergey Sazonov said that if “the British Government [had] sided with Russia and France,... the hour of reckoning between the two hostile camps ... would have been postponed for years, if not for ever.”⁷⁵⁰ Among Germans, Wilhelm Mühlton speculated that if Grey had been able to “state his position more definitely in advance ... [then] Germany and Austria-Hungary would have abandoned their warlike attitude,” while the shipping baron Albert Ballin said that “for the sake of Germany, probably Austria might have been more ready to compromise.”⁷⁵¹ Perhaps the most notable “what if” was penned by the Earl Loreburn, who crafted another medium form, hybrid counterfactual that imagined the British government appealing to Austria in a fictional communiqué. While sympathetically noting that the Austrian government had “strong grievances against Serbia” that were “entitled to redress,” the document made



FIGURE 4.10 In 1919, the Earl Loreburn used a medium form, hybrid counterfactual to fantasize about the British government restraining France from seeking war. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

clear that "war with Russia ... will bring France in and will bring us in, for we are tied to France in honour." "Suppose that had been said," Loreburn concluded, "it seems very difficult to believe that [Austria]... would have paid no need to a really well-meant warning."⁷⁵²

By contrast, other commentators insisted that a more decisive British stance would have made things even worse. The British Prime Minister at the outset of the war Herbert Asquith said that "no serious proof has been adduced to show that a menacing ... attitude on the part of Great Britain would have caused Germany and Austria-Hungary to abandon their line of action."⁷⁵³ In fact,

some observers said that a more militant stand would have made things worse by creating domestic divisions within England. As Winston Churchill put it,

if Sir Edward Grey had sent the kind of ultimatum suggested, the Cabinet would have broken up. ... Nothing less than the deeds of Germany would have converted the British nation to war. To act in advance of those deeds would have led to an exposure of division worse than the guarded attitude which we maintained, which brought our country into the war united.⁷⁵⁴

J.W. Headlam agreed, writing that “[if] the country ... [had] been ... half-hearted,” it “could not have thrown its full strength into the war ... and inevitable disaster would have resulted.”⁷⁵⁵ Sir Edward Grey himself confirmed these thoughts, writing that a pledge to defend France would “have divided the Cabinet” as well as the country, “with one section ... committed to helping France and another section ... opposed to ... war.”⁷⁵⁶

Critics of a tougher British stance feared that it could have radicalized Germany. Grey said that “an early intimation that we should join France and Russia ... would have led to an outburst of German propaganda and to the cry that British hostility had ... made war inevitable by stiffening the backs of France and Russia.”⁷⁵⁷ Bernadotte Schmitt agreed, writing that “a clear-cut declaration of solidarity with France and Russia would have ... rous[ed]... the German Government to instant action.”⁷⁵⁸ Even if a strong declaration had “postponed the war over the Austro-Serbian crisis for some months,” Sidney Fay noted, “it would have so increased the Anglo-German embitterment that some other occasion would probably have soon set Europe on fire.”⁷⁵⁹ By then, Headlam noted, Britain’s defenses “would have been weakened, for the criticisms directed against the Entente with France and Russia would have gained in strength” and Germany would have eventually launched an “attack ... at a time when we were not prepared to meet it.”⁷⁶⁰

Debate also erupted over the possibility that the ambassadors’ conference organized by Grey in late July 1914 could have prevented war. Winston Churchill wrote that the “mere acceptance of the principle of a conference by the Central Powers would have instantly relieved the tension” and helped the great powers “escap[e]... the terrible net which was drawing in upon us all hour by hour.”⁷⁶¹ Sidney Fay agreed, writing that “war could have been avoided in 1914 if a Conference of the Powers could have met and discussed the Austro-Serbian quarrel.”⁷⁶² More skeptical observers, by contrast, believed such a conference would have been a failure. Alfred von Wegerer noted that such a conference “might have ... deferred,” but “would not have ... settled,” the tensions between the two alliances. As he explained, the late date of the

conference's proposal meant that it "would have had to cope with the problem of a Serbia completely mobilized, an Austria partially mobilized, and a Russia in a state of preliminary mobilization." "With eastern and southeastern Europe bristling with bayonets," he concluded, "war would have broken out spontaneously as a result of some border incident."⁷⁶³

Scholars also discussed whether the war could have been prevented if Britain had been able to protect Belgium from German attack. If Britain had said it "would remain neutral if Germany did not invade Belgium," Harry Elmer Barnes argued, "Germany would have been happy" to respect Belgian neutrality.⁷⁶⁴ Alternatively, Barnes proposed that "if England had given a sharp preliminary warning that she would intervene in the event of the invasion of Belgium, Germany would have changed her plans."⁷⁶⁵ Other commentators, by contrast, saw these possibilities as destined to fail. Bernadotte Schmitt said that, given the British population's support for Belgium, Britain could have avoided defending the country "only by denying at once her obligation, her honor and her interest."⁷⁶⁶ Even Barnes conceded that, in all likelihood, "England was bound to enter the war whether Belgium had been invaded or not."⁷⁶⁷

Other commentators declared that if Britain had not gone to war over Belgium, it would have faced untold nightmares. The British journalist Henry Wickham Steed said that "had Germany respected the pledge to Belgium, the British Government might have hesitated to make war until the German fleet threatened the coast of France—and then it might have been too late to save either France or England."⁷⁶⁸ The American historian William Stearns Davis said that "if Belgium had been left intact, England would not have entered the war during its opening stages ... [but] after a little, the pressure of her more intelligent classes would have compelled her to go into a contest which, if Germany had won promptly, would have left England in ruinous isolation facing aggrandized Teutonia."⁷⁶⁹ As the American historian Herbert Baxter Adams concluded, the invasion of Belgium was "most fortunate," for had it not offered "British Cabinet ... popular ... support in declaring war upon Germany ... the nation might have awakened too late to the fact that the triumph of Germany in Europe would menace her national existence."⁷⁷⁰

Of all the nightmares imagined by Britons, the most notable was the extended counterfactual produced by Sir Edward Grey in his memoirs (Figure 4.11). Spanning six continuous pages, the passage offered many reasons why it was fortunate that Britain intervened in the conflict. Responding to the claim of pacifists that "we could have kept out of the war," Grey noted, "Let us [ask]... What would have happened?" As he went on to show, it would have been a nightmare. "Paris would have been taken. ... Huge defeats of Russian armies would have followed. ... [and] Germany would have been supreme on the



FIGURE 4.11 In his memoirs, the British Secretary of State for Foreign Affairs, Sir Edward Grey, offered an extended nightmare scenario of what might have happened had Britain not intervened in World War I. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Continent.” More concerning still, “Britain would have been ... isolated [and]... had no friend in the world.” Worse still, “France and Russia would not have loved Germany after the war, but ... would have been ready to join with her ... in a policy directed against Britain, who had stood aside while they suffered.” As a result, “Germany would have wielded the whole diplomatic strength of the Continent.” “When the German Fleet was ready,” Grey warned, “war would have been forced on us, and we should have been found dispirited ... before [it even]... began.” “Anyone [who believes]... this picture is remote from probability,” Grey concluded ... [should imagine] what German militarism ... would have meant for us after a war from which Germany had emerged supreme.” As he declared, “if we had not gone into the war in 1914, we should have had later ... to undergo suffering at least as great, and we should have perished ignobly.”⁷⁷¹

By contrast, other observers fantasized that Britain would have been better served by staying out of the war and allowing Germany to win it. Harry Elmer

Barnes explicitly addressed Grey's claims, objecting that there was "no proof ... that things would have actually turned out as Grey predicts if England had not gone into the War." "Instead of ... an ultimate war to the death between England and Germany," Barnes argued, "the result would much more likely have been German gratitude and an Anglo-German Entente which would have dominated the Eastern Hemisphere." British non-intervention might have actually made history worse, Barnes added, saying it might have brought about "a decisive and early Entente victory ... [which] would have strengthened ... Russian autocracy, given Russia the Straits, and increased the Russian menace to the British Empire in the Near East."⁷⁷² Taking a similar position, the pro-German American writer H.L. Mencken noted in 1931 that, since the war created new threats for postwar Britain in the form of Germany, which remained a "dangerous rival," and for the United States, which sought to "challenge England's control of the world's markets," Britain would have done better by having fought the "war on the German side." Had it done so, "the Germans would be grateful for the help," the French "would be ... unable to menace the peace of Europe," and "there would be no Bolshevik [communist] nuisance." Better yet, he speculated, the "United States would still [have been]... a docile British colony, as it was in 1914."⁷⁷³ Unfortunately for Britain, however, none of this came to pass.

Counterfactual Self-Reflexiveness

Commentators not only wondered "what if?" about the origins of World War I but expressed a growing self-awareness in doing so. Some called attention to the link between regret and "what ifs." In his memoirs, Sir Edward Grey confessed that

after the outbreak of war, I sometimes lay awake asking myself again and again whether the war could have been prevented by anything that I could have done in the preceding years ... About four o'clock in the morning ... when spirits are depressed,... I would try one hypothesis after another, considering what hope there would have been in any of them.⁷⁷⁴

Other observers articulated their regrets in more literary fashion. In his book *The Evidence in the Case* (1914), James Beck quoted a line from William Shakespeare's tragic play *Othello*, where the title character tells the scheming Iago that he plans on killing his beloved wife, Desdemona, for allegedly carrying on an adulterous affair, exclaiming: "But yet the pity of it, Iago! O Iago, the pity of it." Beck used this quote counterfactually several times in his book,

writing in one instance that “when one recalls the infinite treasure of property and life, which would ... have been saved the world ... had Germany and Austria accepted [a]... reasonable and pacific course, one can only exclaim, “oh, the pity of it!”⁷⁷⁵ Sidney Fay was also aware of the link between counterfactual thinking and tragedy, writing of Francis Ferdinand that “it was the tragic fate of Austria that the only man who might have had the power and ability to develop Austria along sound lines became the innocent victim of the crime which was the occasion of the World War.”⁷⁷⁶

Commentators further signaled their regrets about the war by stressing its contingent origins. In discussing different scenarios that might have prevented the conflict, the Earl Loreburn used a variety of metaphors to signify the role of chance, invoking the “cards of Providence,” the “arrows in the quiver of Fate,” and the “gifts in Pandora’s box” to describe how the course of history might have been improved if only different historical figures had been present on the historical stage. Lamenting how “wiser Ministers in the various countries concerned ... would have guided the world towards peace,” he exclaimed that

we might have had ... some Minister in Germany who would not ... bow the knee to the General Staff, someone in Russia who would have allowed another forty-eight hours before mobilizing, someone in France like Jaurès who would have told Russia ... that France would not help her if she mobilized prematurely. Any one of these contingencies would have made all the difference next time if only there could have been a next time.⁷⁷⁷

Other observers affirmed the importance of individual agency in the war’s origins. Arguing that that “the world was exceptionally unfortunate in the quality of its counsellors in this terrible emergency,” David Lloyd George speculated that “had there been a Bismarck in Germany, a Palmerston or a Disraeli in Britain, a Roosevelt in America, or a Clemenceau in authority in Paris, the catastrophe ... would ... have been averted” (Figure 4.12).⁷⁷⁸

Some writers justified these kinds of arguments by stressing the virtues of counterfactual reasoning. In discussing whether the last-minute diplomatic negotiations on August 1 between Germany and Russia might have prevented the war, Luigi Albertini wrote:

this is a point which has escaped the notice of historians, who tend to confine themselves to what actually happened without considering what might logically have happened. But responsibility for acts that have been committed is not to be measured only on a basis of the consequences that actually followed from them. Account must also be taken of the consequences they might potentially have had.⁷⁷⁹

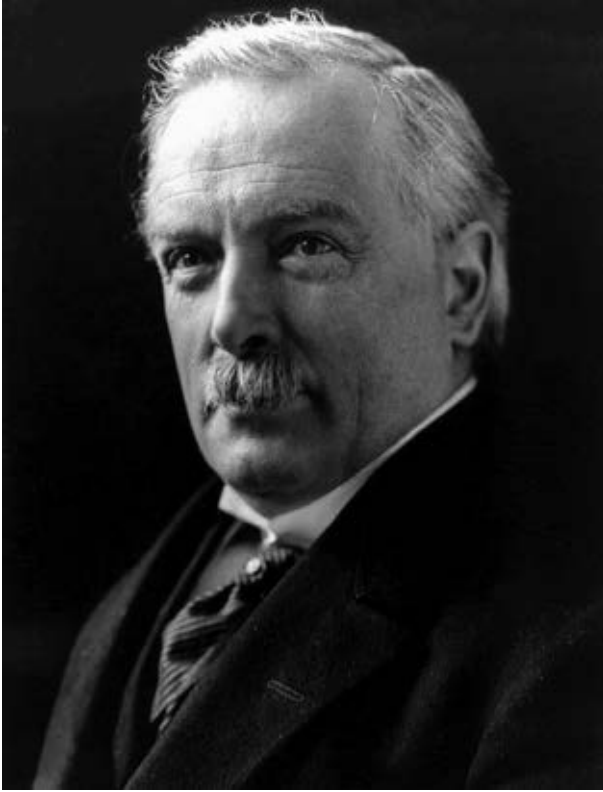


FIGURE 4.12 David Lloyd George believed that war could have been avoided if other, more responsible, statesmen had been in power. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Alfred Fabre-Luce made a similar observation, noting that “in tracing the path that led to ... war,” it was important “to discover the crossroads where a choice could have been made between several paths and to determine [the extent to which]... each nation ... was restricted in regard the alternatives open to it, and the reasons for the choice made. Then, and only then,... shall we [see] history[’s]... real meaning.”⁷⁸⁰ Sidney Fay, finally, penetrated to the heart of how counterfactuals could answer causal questions when he asserted that “a European War broke out” because “in each country political and military leaders did certain things, which led to ... declarations of war, or failed to do certain things which might have prevented them.”⁷⁸¹

Other observers, by contrast, rejected counterfactuals as pointless. Like writers in earlier eras, these skeptics were often the same people who, on other occasions, used “what ifs” for their own purposes. The German writer Richard Grelling used “what ifs” to highlight Germany’s failure to prevent the war but

denied Bethmann-Hollweg the right to use the same method, declaring that the German chancellor's tendency to use "many 'ifs'" to shift guilt for the war from Germany onto England was improper, because "what England ... would have done if this or that had happened or had not happened, is a mere supposition, which is not amenable to serious discussion."⁷⁸² Similarly, the Earl Loreburn frequently used historical speculation in his writing but also proclaimed that "[a] discussion of what would or might have happened under conditions which never arose would ... be unprofitable."⁷⁸³ Sir Edward Grey also routinely speculated about missed opportunities, but in reflecting on whether Britain should have given an earlier pledge of support to France and Russia, he declared that "it is hardly worthwhile to consider whether, if it had been possible [it]... would have prevented war."⁷⁸⁴ Finally Harry Elmer Barnes sought to disprove Grey's "catalogue of the calamities which would have come to England if she had not entered the War on the side of France and Russia" by comparing it to "the disasters which actually accompanied England's participation in the conflict," concluding that the latter were "much more impressive" than the overly "hypothetical" former.⁷⁸⁵

Still other commentators, while recognizing the flaws of counterfactual speculation, nevertheless endorsed their value. In blaming Britain's failure to warn Germany about its possible intervention in the war, Sergey Sazonov conceded that while it was "impossible to prove that a thing which did not happen would have had such and such consequences," there was nevertheless a "strong presumption in favour of the view [that a British warning would have been effective]."⁷⁸⁶ In discussing the failure of Serbia's government to warn Francis Ferdinand about the plot against his life, Luigi Albertini declared that "we are ... here in the realm of induction, not of proof," before admitting that it was important "to examine the question more closely" because if he had been warned, "events would have taken another course."⁷⁸⁷ In exploring whether an earlier death for Emperor Franz Joseph I might have affected the outbreak of the war, Austrian historian Theodor von Sossnosky described such hypotheses as "fruitless speculations after the event," before adding that "they may well be correct."⁷⁸⁸

Finally, writers embraced new stylistic gestures to present their counterfactual observations. Many writers not only employed medium form counterfactuals but framed them with extra-diegetic comments. These comments often took the form of prefatory clauses that were used in multiple texts. One of the most popular was the phrase "let us suppose," as when James Beck in his book *The Evidence in the Case* wrote: "Let us suppose that ... France had been given forty-eight hours to comply with [an ultimatum that included] conditions

which were obviously fatal to ... its prestige as a great Power."⁷⁸⁹ Another common phrase was "let us think," as in Frederick Bausman's statement "Let us think what would have happened to Europe if Russia had won this war."⁷⁹⁰ Finally, on some occasions, authors such as the Earl Lorne produced hybrid counterfactuals by interrupting their otherwise analytical texts with imaginary speeches delivered by figures like Sir Edward Grey and Kaiser Wilhelm II. All these stylistic choices revealed the willingness of writers to call attention to the speculative dimensions of their narratives.

Debating Cleopatra's Nose: "What Ifs" in Interwar Culture

This self-reflexiveness reflected a growing awareness among Britons and Americans about the existence of counterfactual history. In the years between 1914 and the early 1930s, Britons and Americans renewed their turn of the century debate about the merits and drawbacks of wondering "what if."⁷⁹¹ The trauma and anxiety caused by the war played an important role in convincing more and more people that chance, accident, and contingency played a pivotal role in history. This acceptance of uncertainty was epitomized by the surging popularity of the phrase "Cleopatra's nose" after 1914.⁷⁹²

One of the earliest and most prominent uses of the phrase appeared in the British historian John Bagnell Bury's essay "Cleopatra's Nose" (1916) (Figure 4.13). In it, Bury embraced Jacob Burckhardt's anti-deterministic belief that the absence of key individuals from history would have radically altered its course, arguing that "the course of history ... [is] marked at every stage by contingencies."⁷⁹³ Bury, however, did not surrender to the tyranny of contingency but sought to explain it with the aid of rational methods. An avowed positivist who believed that history was "a science, no less and no more," Bury strove to rationally elucidate the role of chance in history.⁷⁹⁴ In this effort, he first offered a sophisticated definition of contingency, describing it as "the valuable collision of two or more independent chains of causes." He further refined his definition by distinguishing between causes that were "pure" and "mixed."⁷⁹⁵ Notably enough, Bury illustrated the difference between these kinds of causes with a famous counterfactual, speculating that

If Napoleon at an early stage in his career had been killed by a meteorite, that would have been the purest of pure contingencies ... But [if]... Napoleon had been killed by the hand of an assassin who detested his policy,... [t]his would not be a pure contingency. For the assassin was interested in Napoleon's death,

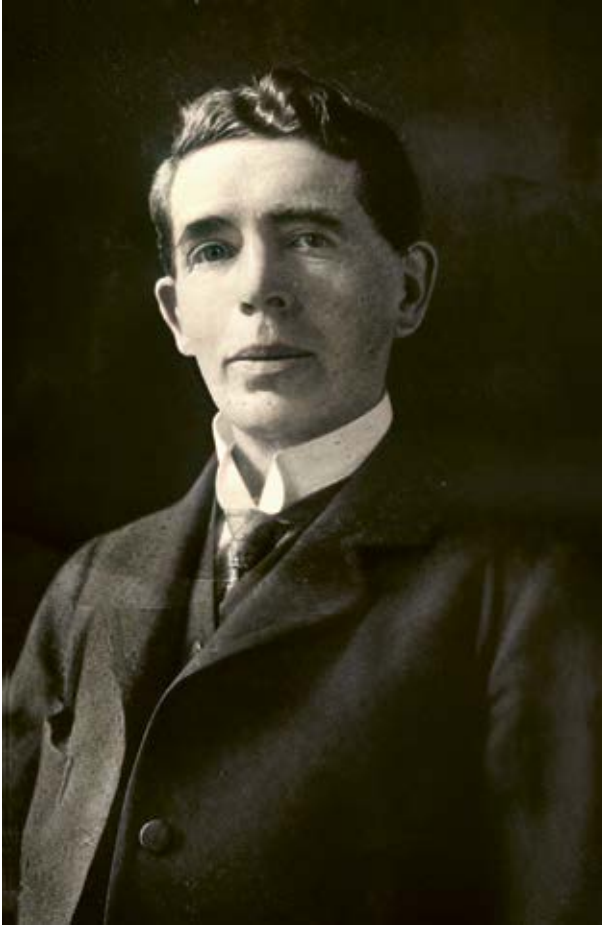


FIGURE 4.13 John Bagnell Bury's essay, "Cleopatra's Nose" (1916) attested to the importance of individuals in history. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

and the causal sequence which led him to commit the act would have been connected with the causal sequence which rendered the great man's death historically important.⁷⁹⁶

Bury's essay was far more optimistic than other wartime invocations of Cleopatra's nose. Indeed, he concluded his essay by predicting that, in the future, "contingences will become less important in human evolution," since "the growth of democra[cy]" would make "the destinies of societies ... moulded less by single individuals."⁷⁹⁷ Only later did Bury recognize that he was swimming against the cultural tide. Shortly before his death in 1926, he confessed

that he increasingly saw history as a partisan, subjective enterprise, rather than one with scientific pretensions.⁷⁹⁸ His essay thus represented a holdover from the more optimistic prewar world.

By contrast, another essay published the same year by the British journalist and historian Sidney Low, entitled "The New Orientation of History," offered a more pessimistic perspective. For Low, the traumas caused by the war required a radical shift in the writing of history. Noting that historians before 1914 embraced the "scientific" belief that history could be understood as "a rational process" that flowed towards "moral ... perfection," Low said that after the war, history had to accommodate "the sudden and appalling change which has come upon the whole world ... since the summer of 1914."⁷⁹⁹ Two years into the war, he declared, historians needed to recognize the role played by "chance" and abandon their discomfort with "Pascal's cynical remark that the history of the world would have been different if Cleopatra's nose had been longer." Conceding that the remark might be "frivolous," Low noted that the "truth ... is often disgracefully frivolous." To top off his claim, Low employed a long list of counterfactuals, writing, "what a different world-story our textbooks would have to tell if a careless nurse had allowed Julius Caesar to die of whooping-cough in his cradle, if Alexander the Great had not 'done himself' too well when he dined at Babylon,... [and] if a fair wind had blown down the [English] Channel in the last week of July, 1588." Such "chastening impressions," he concluded, were confirmed by the war and reminded people "that a slightly different integration of ... factors would have saved humanity from a catastrophe which will be felt for centuries."⁸⁰⁰

Low's belief that World War I was sensitizing people to chance was notably echoed in the Anglo-American press. In 1915, an Oklahoma newspaper bluntly opined that "the war is fast developing more 'ifs' to add to the others that have influenced history for all time," adding that the word "if" was "the biggest little word in the vocabulary," so much so, that "it should be decorated with a ... medal ... [and] honored for [its] 'pernicious omnipresence.'"⁸⁰¹ One year later, a writer in *The Hartford Courant* declared that it was "easy to suggest 'ifs' that would have saved humanity from the catastrophe of the present war," since they showed how "the course of things might possibly have been more peaceably ordered." At the same time, the writer sought to maintain faith that things would work out and asserted that people should "be thankful that Cleopatra's nose was not longer, for in that case we know not what would have ensued."⁸⁰² In 1923, a British writer in *The Times* of London noted that the interest in "Historical 'Ifs'" was stimulated by "the late war [when] there were moments when everything seemed to depend on one small event."⁸⁰³

A more sardonic view of Cleopatra's nose, by contrast, was expressed by the American poet and World War I veteran Leonard Van Noppen in his 1918 poem "Circumstance." Published in his collection entitled, *The Challenge*, the poem read:

Had Cleopatra's nose—you know the rest,
 So take the scent and follow: Had the Kaiser
 Been born less arrogant, and therefore wiser,
 He never had—Alas! this is not jest—
 Trained his moustache, till it so well expressed
 His swelling ego that each idolizer,
 Of course, must imitate the pompous Kaiser
 And so began to boast and puff his chest.

And hence the war. That ego-centric horde
 Could never rest till it had won the world.
 For forty years, they strutted, clanked the sword
 And threatened; then their empire madly hurled
 Against the breast of Belgium. So the point
 Of one moustache put Europe out of joint.⁸⁰⁴

The poem's message was as notable as it was clear. The poem not only assumed public familiarity with Pascal's aphorism (by telling readers "you know the rest") but explained the war as the result of a seemingly chance occurrence—namely, the form of the Kaiser's moustache. Unlike Cleopatra's nose, which was a manifestation of beauty, however, Kaiser Wilhelm II's moustache was an emanation of German arrogance and symbolized the country's war guilt.

Other critics in the 1920s made similar points. In 1922, the American writer Brander Matthews published an essay entitled "On the Length of Cleopatra's Nose" that affirmed the role of accidents in history, while also stressing the importance of "predisposing conditions."⁸⁰⁵ While he agreed with Pascal's observations about Mark Antony and Octavian, Matthews noted that "if we look a little ... deeper we are likely to conclude that Antony's fatal weakness was in himself," adding that "if he had never laid eyes on Cleopatra, the ultimate result might well have been the same."⁸⁰⁶ Several years later, in 1925, the British journalist and writer Alfred George Gardiner published a similar essay entitled "The Jests of Chance" that invoked Pascal's aphorism to show how "accidents play havoc with the affairs of men." Unlike Mathews, Gardiner focused more on the tragic nature of "[our] inexplicable world" and used counterfactuals to do so—for example, lamenting how "there would have



FIGURE 4.14 The Scottish historian, John Buchan, invoked the idea of “Cleopatra’s Nose” in his book *The Casual and the Causal in History* (1929). (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

been no European war in 1914” if Germany’s refined Ambassador to Britain Baron Marschall von Bieberstein had not died shortly after being appointed in 1912.⁸⁰⁷ For Gardiner, the “importance of chance” was all powerful—in the case of the war, tragically so.

The most significant contribution to the interwar discussion of Cleopatra’s nose was a short book published in 1929 by the Scottish historian and later Governor General of Canada John Buchan, entitled *The Casual and the Causal in History* (Figure 11.14).⁸⁰⁸ In it, Buchan rejected J.B. Bury’s attempt to study history with “formulas” drawn from the “natural sciences” and followed Sidney Low’s example by appreciating “the irrational and the inexplicable” in history.⁸⁰⁹ At the same time, however, Buchan joined both Bury and Low in emphasizing the importance of counterfactuals for understanding the

past, arguing that “everywhere ... we find those sparks which fire the powder mines,... in the absence of which, the powder might ... never have exploded at all.” Invoking the phrase “what would have happened to the world had Cleopatra’s nose been a little shorter?”, Buchan examined a variety of ways in which history would have turned out differently—noting, for example, that if British troops had only continued their attack on the Dardanelles despite losing several sweepers to Turkish mines on March 18, 1915, they could have seized Constantinople and helped the Allies win the Great War by 1916.⁸¹⁰ This missed opportunity, for Buchan, confirmed that “the world is bigger and more intricate than we thought.”

The idea of Cleopatra’s nose also found expression in popular culture. In literature, the concept provided the title for scattered novels and short stories, such as T.B. Marle’s novel *Cleopatra’s Nose* (1937), where it described the role of a “motor accident in Buda-Pest changing the whole course of a man’s life.”⁸¹¹ The concept was also used in American advertisements for bank loans, bathroom fixtures, and men’s hats (Figure 4.15).⁸¹² Finally, the concept was used as a source of entertainment. John Buchan, Brander Matthews, and other writers proposed that speculating about the past in the spirit of “Cleopatra’s Nose” was the perfect subject for a “parlor game” that people in “academic circles” could play by the “fireside” in the winter.⁸¹³

Besides using the phrase “Cleopatra’s nose,” journalists, poets, and other writers after 1914 employed new words employing the word “if.” Following the publication of the British writer F.J.C. Hearnshaw’s book of self-authored counterfactuals, *The ‘Ifs’ of History* (1929), the phrase “the ‘ifs’ of history” was increasingly used to announce public lectures by historians, journalists, and clergymen on counterfactual themes.⁸¹⁴ Indeed, as writers started reflecting on the importance of the word “if” in history, the American writer Bruce Barton noted in 1928 that “if—if—if—in every ... period of history that little word appears.”⁸¹⁵ Finally, in English language usage, the word “if” inspired the creation of various neologisms, most notably “iffing” (the act of historical speculation) and “iffers” (the people who speculated), with one sports journalist even taking the pen-name, “Iffy.”⁸¹⁶

Regardless of the terms that were used to describe them, counterfactuals continued to have critics. Writing in 1936, historian R.G. Collingwood criticized J.B. Bury’s essay “Cleopatra’s Nose” for endorsing the role of contingency in historical events, saying the question of “history ... would have been different” was posed “in despair of genuine explanation.”⁸¹⁷ The British philosopher Michael Oakeshott, meanwhile, noted that while counterfactual questions might be “entertaining,” they were “an extravagance of the imagination” and constituted an “abandon[ment of] ... history.” “The



FIGURE 4.15 The idea of "Cleopatra's Nose" was often used in American advertisements, for example, this one for bank loans in 1919.

question in history," he concluded, "is never ... what might have taken place, but solely what ... did take place."⁸¹⁸ Anglo-American journalists also criticized counterfactuals. One American writer in 1922 declared that speculating about "what might have happened" in the spirit of "Cleopatra's nose" was "a waste of time."⁸¹⁹ The co-editors of *The American Mercury*, H. L. Mencken and George Jean Nathan, crankily argued in 1925 that "Cleopatra's nose changed the history of the world no more than a defective sinus frequently changes the history of men's attitudes toward the world."⁸²⁰ Other critics continued the prewar criticism of "might-have-beens," with one writer in 1919 insisting that speculation had "little value in life" as it made people full of "regret."⁸²¹ Another in 1925 said people who wondered "what if" were a "pathetic sort of folk" who

were “full of self-pity.”⁸²² Still another critic complained that there were “whole flocks of ... terrible iffers floating about” complaining about “things that ... didn’t happen.”⁸²³ As one commentator summed it up: “Idle Iffing is a worthless business.”⁸²⁴

Conclusion

World War I was not just a foundational event in the history of the twentieth century but also in the development of counterfactual history as a mode of historical analysis and cultural expression. The occurrence of the former, in fact, played a major role in the growing prominence of the latter. While major historical points of divergence have always spurred “what ifs,” the Great War’s role in doing so was especially powerful. The war erupted precisely at the time that counterfactual thinking was becoming increasingly common in western culture. The spread of “what ifs” since the late nineteenth century meant that people throughout Europe and North America were becoming accustomed to viewing the world not just in terms of what actually happened but in terms of how things might have happened. Although the populations of the major powers that fought in the war gravitated to different counterfactuals during the interwar period, they displayed a common tendency to think in speculative, and not just factual, terms. This trend would continue—albeit in more ideological fashion—in the years that followed.

Ideological Counterfactuals: Communist, Nazi, and Liberal “What Ifs,” 1914–1945

[The question of whether] Soviet power could ... maintain its position in the international system of economic relations [after 1917]... could be decided only by war. ... We said to the capitalists,... [‘We] shall give you a thrashing. ...’ We could not act otherwise. Any other way would have meant ... complete surrender.⁸²⁵ (Vladimir Lenin October 29, 1921)

Soldiers of the Eastern Front! Filled with grave concern for the ... future of our Volk, I decided on June 22 to ... forestall ... the rulers in the Kremlin [from]... destroy[ing] not only Germany, but also Europe. ... Lord have mercy ... if this barbaric enemy had been able to get his tens of thousands of tanks to move before we could. All of Europe would have been lost.⁸²⁶ (Adolf Hitler October 2, 1941)

The Treaty of Brest-Litovsk was a milestone in modern history ... Without the ‘breathing spell’ [provided by the treaty] the Bolsheviks might ... have perished at the hands of the advancing Germans [and]... the world might ... have never witnessed ... the Third International ... The potential ‘ifs’... do not cease there ... [For] if there had been no Comintern, would not ... National Socialism have been deprived of [its]... primary *raison d’être*?⁸²⁷ (John Wheeler-Bennett 1939)

Between the eruption of World War I and the conclusion of World War II, the breakthrough of new political ideologies dramatically shaped how people in the western world wondered “what if?” The rise of communism and Nazism posed serious challenges to the principle of liberal democracy and radically reshaped the western political landscape. As Europe became polarized between the extreme left and the radical right—and as the United States became increasingly drawn into European affairs—historians, politicians, and other commentators began to use counterfactuals in new ways. As the quotations above demonstrate, however, they did so in very different fashion. Communists and Nazis deterministically used “what ifs” to justify their respective ideological worldviews. By contrast, liberals rejected ideological certainty and used “what ifs” to lament the failure to halt the very movements responsible for the interwar era’s polarization.

These diverging trends reflected the different philosophies of history that underpinned communism, Nazism, and liberalism. Because the supporters of the first two movements embraced philosophies of history that leaned in a deterministic direction, they tended to speculate within strict ideological parameters. Believing that history had to unfold according to specific laws, communists and Nazis used counterfactuals to reinforce the certainty of their worldviews. Liberal thinkers veered in the opposite direction. Although they, too, had once embraced deterministic ideas—most notably, a belief in the inevitability of progress—their disillusionment in the face of interwar events convinced them that history was driven by contingency and prompted them to wonder “what if?”

Communist Counterfactuals: 1917–1945

Between the years 1917 and 1945, communists in war-torn Russia (and after 1922, the Soviet Union) used “what ifs” to interpret the meaning of the Bolshevik Revolution. They did so only in a limited sense, however. In surveying the recent historical record, communist leaders and thinkers employed a deterministic philosophy of history—inherited from Karl Marx, Friedrich Engels, and the Russian theorist, Georgi Plekhanov—known as “historical materialism.”⁸²⁸ Described as “the Soviet equivalent of the Whig interpretation of history,” this paradigm teleologically viewed Soviet history as the culmination of deep-seated, socio-economic forces that were guided by historical laws.⁸²⁹ The paradigm directly shaped how the Soviet Union’s two most powerful leaders, Vladimir Lenin and Joseph Stalin, speculated about the past. Both men, along with other Soviet officials, used counterfactuals to validate communist doctrine and defend their policies from domestic and foreign criticism. While these uses were predictable, Lenin’s and Stalin’s “what ifs” were surprising in one regard. Although historical materialism deemphasized the role of individual agency and chance in historical events, Lenin—and to an even greater degree, Stalin—used “what ifs” to emphasize their own individual prominence as agents of change. Both leaders used close call counterfactuals to highlight how, but for their wise guidance, the history of Russia and the nascent Soviet Union would have turned out worse. Not all communists wondered “what if?” in this fashion, however. Bolshevik leaders who fell from grace, such as Leon Trotsky, focused on missed opportunities and fantasized about ways that history might have been better.

Dogmatic Counterfactuals: Lenin, Stalin, and Bukharin

During the summer of 1917, several months before the November revolution, Lenin fantasized that the Bolsheviks could have launched a successful revolt earlier that spring (Figure 5.1). During the “April Crisis,” mass discontent towards the Russian Provisional Government’s continuation of what the Bolsheviks called an “imperialist war” led moderates in the party, then dominant in the Petrograd Soviet, to call for joining the government in the effort to control it. Lenin condemned the prospect of cooperation as treasonous, however, and used missed opportunity counterfactuals to attack the party’s moderates. “If the Mensheviks and Socialist-Revolutionaries had not been betraying the revolution and supporting the counter-revolutionary Cadets,” he argued in July of 1917, power would have [already] been in the hands of the [Petrograd Soviet’s] Executive Committee since early May.”⁸³⁰ If only this had happened, Lenin went on argue, the Petrograd Soviet could have used its power to “establish ... a state monopoly over ... the press,... enlighten the peasants, and ... disband ... the Duma.”⁸³¹ The Soviet could have further dispelled “the illusion of ... compromise with the bourgeoisie” and ended the war, thereby “sav[ing]... the lives of the half million Russian soldiers, who ... perished in ... ‘rivers of blood.’”⁸³² In short, if the “Soviets [had]... taken over state power in full,... then ... our revolution [would] have become a truly popular and truly democratic revolution.”⁸³³

After the triumph of the October revolution several months later, however, Lenin used deterministic counterfactuals to validate how the course of events turned out. His first goal was to confirm his ideological belief that Russia could only experience a true proletarian revolution if the Bolshevik party inspired the masses to recognize their historical mission as agents of class conflict. In arguing that the historical events of 1917 had proven his theory correct, Lenin in 1919 rejected the counterfactual lament then being expressed by moderate socialists—“If only socialism had come into being peacefully”—by noting that “the little word ‘if’ [in the phrase] makes all the difference.” Because of the necessities of “class struggle,” he insisted, there could “be no peaceful evolution towards socialism.”⁸³⁴

For Lenin, the revolution had unfolded according to his ideological expectations. He declared that the party had correctly recognized the historical necessity of establishing the “dictatorship of the proletariat” already before 1917, speculating that “If we had made any concessions to petty-bourgeois illusions ... we would have ruined the whole cause of the proletarian revolution in Russia.”⁸³⁵ Lenin identified 1918 as the year when “the real proletarian

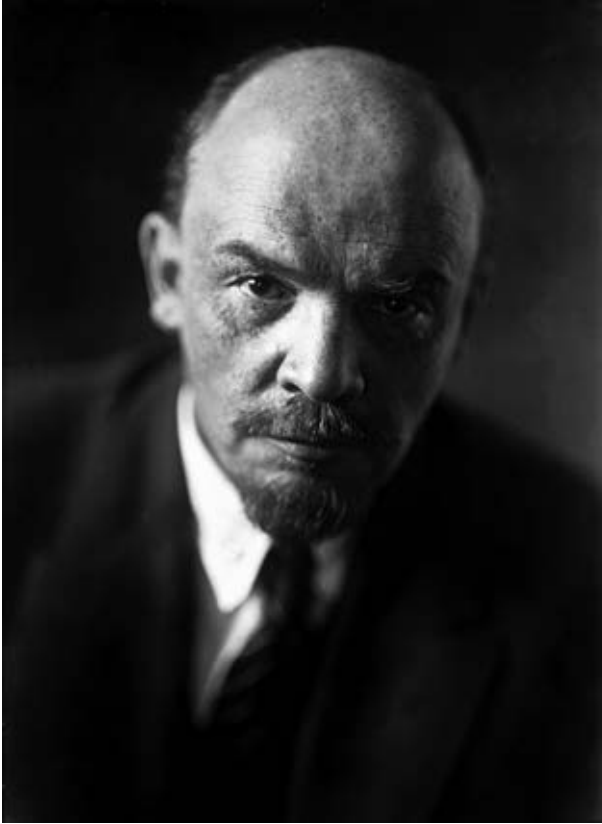


FIGURE 5.1 Vladimir Lenin often used counterfactuals to emphasize his prominence as an agent of great historical change. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

revolution [erupted]... in the rural districts,” noting that “only the proletariat could have created the solid force which the disunited and scattered peasantry are following and which has withstood all onslaughts by the exploiters.”⁸³⁶ In 1918, he further speculated that “if the Bolshevik proletariat in the ... large industrial centres had not been able to rally the village poor ... against the rich peasants, this would ... have proved that Russia was “unripe” for socialist revolution.”⁸³⁷ Lenin added that this requisite social alliance was further supported by the millions of European workers who revolted against their governments in 1918, asking whether “our proletariat [in Russia would] have had the moral strength [to persevere]... if it had not relied on the sympathy of the workers of the advanced countries?”⁸³⁸

Lenin also used “what ifs” to justify the Bolshevik regime’s actions in the Russian Civil War. After the Bolsheviks dissolved the newly established Constituent Assembly in January of 1918, the party’s disparate opponents—liberals and conservatives alike—formed a “White” opposition that, after receiving promises of military support from the western Entente powers, launched an attack on Bolshevik-controlled territory that ended up dragging on for four bloody years. The Reds, as they came to be known, emerged victorious, and in December of 1922, the Bolsheviks officially proclaimed the birth of the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR). Looking back on those events, Lenin employed counterfactuals to validate the decisions that led to victory. In 1918, he defended his dismantling of the Constituent Assembly by saying that preserving it would have been “tantamount to saying that the fight against the bourgeoisie should not have been fought to a finish ... and that the proletariat should have made peace with them.”⁸³⁹ With the onset of civil war, he noted, the revolution was in such danger that “had the Entente countries ... been able to fling even a tenth part of their armies against us with any success,... [then] Soviet Russia would have been doomed.”⁸⁴⁰ Lenin partly used such close call counterfactuals to underscore the miracle of the Bolsheviks’ success. Noting that the enemy “had an army of millions ... to which we could not oppose even the semblance of ... an army of any strength,” he observed that “all they had to do was to employ a few hundred thousand soldiers ... and the Entente would have crushed us.”⁸⁴¹

Lenin used similar arguments to justify his use of terror after 1917. In discussing the Red Army’s use of violence against White forces, Lenin declared that “If we had attempted to influence [them]... by any means other than terror, we would not have held out for even two months and we would have been fools.”⁸⁴² In discussing his decision under “war communism” to impose punitive economic policies on the “privileged class[es], he wrote that “when it is a case of freeing millions of working people from exploitation, a government that did not make other classes bear the burden would not be a socialist government but a traitor government.”⁸⁴³ Lenin also justified seizing grain from the peasants, saying “But for that, we would not have beaten the landowners and capitalists in a ruined small-peasant country.”⁸⁴⁴ Lenin also used missed opportunity counterfactuals to blame the Bolsheviks’ opponents for the revolution’s violent turn, saying had they “not offered such savage ... resistance ... [and] joined in an alliance with the world bourgeoisie, the revolution would have assumed more peaceful forms.”⁸⁴⁵ Yet, because “the mighty powers of the world flung their hordes against us,” Lenin added, “[they] forced [us] to use terror,” without which “we could not have lasted two days.”⁸⁴⁶ All these examples underscored Lenin’s wisdom as the revolution’s indispensable leader.



FIGURE 5.2 Joseph Stalin used “what ifs” to underscore his indispensability to the success of the Bolshevik experiment in socialism. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

After Lenin’s death in 1924, his successor, Joseph Stalin, also used “what ifs” to solidify his rule (Figure 5.2). Stalin partly did this by endorsing Lenin’s counterfactual claims about the revolutionary events of 1917–21. Stalin sycophantically praised Lenin’s “brilliant ... leadership of the revolution,” arguing that if he had not timed the party’s power grab perfectly and “launched the insurrection on ... November 6,” then “the whole course of the revolution would have been ... different [and]... the enemy would have been able to take the initiative.”⁸⁴⁷ Stalin also agreed that “had it not been for [the]... assistance of [western] European workers [in 1918],... the proletarian dictatorship in Russia would have been in a tight corner” and “[been] torn to pieces long ago.”⁸⁴⁸

In addition to honoring Lenin’s individual importance for the revolution, Stalin also honored his own indispensability. He often used counterfactuals

to justify his policy decisions after 1927, especially his pursuit of "Socialism in One Country." During his power struggle with Leon Trotsky in 1926, Stalin warned that anyone who opposed "building socialism" in Russia was making the heretical claim that "we should not have taken power in October 1917."⁸⁴⁹ A few years later, Stalin defended his regime's "collective farm ... movement" and campaign against wealthy peasants (*kulaks*) by declaring, "without the offensive against the capitalist elements in the rural districts,... we would not have had the decisive success achieved this year in ... grain collections."⁸⁵⁰ In 1933, Stalin defended the achievements of his forcible industrialization program by saying without it, "we would not have [our]... big iron and steel industry ... and ... would be unarmed while ... surrounded by capitalist countries," adding that the USSR would have become "a target for military attacks by foreign enemies."⁸⁵¹ In 1938, Stalin also justified his purges of internal "enemies," saying that if they "had not been vanquished ... it would have been impossible to achieve the victory of the proletarian revolution ... and to build up Socialism."⁸⁵²

Like Lenin and Stalin, Nikolai Bukharin also employed "what ifs" to defend the revolution's course. Unlike them, he did so with a greater degree of self-reflexivity. In his 1925 book, *Historical Materialism*, Bukharin made his deterministic orientation abundantly clear by rejecting the role of "accident in history" and affirming the principle of "historical necessity." To illustrate his philosophy, he frequently used deterministic counterfactuals. In discussing the origins of World War I, for example, he declared that even without "the murder of the Austrian Archduke," the "war [still] would have come ..., for the 'crux of the matter' was not [the]... slaying, but ... the sharpening of the competition between the imperialist powers, growing fiercer day by day with the evolution of capitalist society."⁸⁵³ Bukharin further illustrated his belief that "*all* events [are]... the result of causal necessity" by showing how, without "the so called 'Liberation of the Serfs' in Russia in 1861, ... Russian capitalism could not have developed."⁸⁵⁴ These and other examples revealed that Bukharin used "what ifs" only to the degree they illustrated "the historical necessity of socialism."⁸⁵⁵

Just as communist ideology limited how Soviet leaders used counterfactual thought, it sometimes prompted them to reject it altogether. In dismissing Trotsky's objection to the Bolshevik party's landslide win at the 1927 CPSU Congress, for example, Stalin derisively declared that "our oppositionists thundered that ... if 'ifs' and 'ans' were pots and pans they, the oppositionists, would certainly have had 99 per cent on their side. But since 'ifs' and 'ans' are not pots and pans, it turns out that the opposition has not even one per cent."⁸⁵⁶ A few years earlier, politburo member, Gregori Zinoviev, dismissed counterfactual thinking in similar terms, attacking Trotsky's claim that the

February revolution of 1917 “could have been different” had it not taken place in the fortuitous context of an “imperialist war” by saying, “it has apparently never occurred to [Trotsky]... that ‘if ifs and ands were pots and pans’ [and] if there had never been an imperialist war ... there probably never would have been a revolution of 1917.”⁸⁵⁷ These skeptical comments further confirmed the tendency of Soviet leaders to view history as driven by necessity.

Historical Pessimism: Trotsky and the Role of Accident

Not all communists shared this belief, however, as was shown by the renegade views of Leon Trotsky (Figure 5.3). Ousted from the Bolshevik Party in 1927, Trotsky used “what ifs” in his subsequent writings to attack Stalin for betraying the Bolshevik Revolution. Trotsky especially criticized Stalin for abandoning the principle of “permanent revolution,” arguing that during the civil war, “the Soviet power could not have held out for twelve months without the direct help of the international ... proletariat.”⁸⁵⁸ From Trotsky’s vantage point, Stalin’s policy of “Socialism in one country” had unfortunately injected an antirevolutionary form of statism—a bureaucratic “Thermidor”—into the Soviet system that adversely affected the USSR.⁸⁵⁹ As he hypothesized in his autobiography, *My Life*, “But for this blind ... policy of ... bureaucracy ..., the position of the working masses in the twelfth year of the dictatorship would be infinitely more favorable, the military defense much stronger,... and the Communist International would be standing upon a higher level.”⁸⁶⁰ Trotsky also declared that Stalin’s forced collectivization program “should have assumed a more reasonable tempo,” noting that “the bureaucracy could have regulated the process without carrying the nation to the edge of disaster.”⁸⁶¹

Trotsky’s anger about Stalin’s rule led him to wonder how things might have developed had Lenin not died. While conceding it was “impossible ... to reply with mathematical precision” about “how ... the struggle [would] have developed had Lenin been alive,” Trotsky insisted that “Lenin would have been the implacable enemy of the greedy conservative bureaucracy and of Stalin’s policy,” noting that Lenin’s “testament ... recommend[ed]... that Stalin be removed [as]... general secretary.”⁸⁶² Trotsky wished he had helped Lenin neutralize the threat of Stalin, writing that “joint action against the Central Committee at the beginning of 1923 would ... have brought us victory ... against the Stalin bureaucracy.”⁸⁶³ But, as he went on to observe, chance intervened. When Lenin was convalescing from his first stroke in the fall of 1923, Trotsky caught a bad case of influenza while out duck hunting and ended up “stay[ing] in bed [for the] rest of the autumn and winter.” As a result, he missed the pivotal



FIGURE 5.3 Leon Trotsky's fury about Stalin's rise to power led him to wonder how things might have developed had Lenin not died. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

intra-party "discussion of "Trotskyism"" that ended up leading to his marginalization after Lenin's death in January of 1924.

Notably enough, the counterfactual implications of this episode challenged Trotsky's faith in determinism. As was shown by his famous comment that "one can foresee a revolution or a war, but it is impossible to foresee the consequences of an autumn shooting-trip for wild ducks," Trotsky struggled to comprehend the contingencies that drove the events of the 1920s.⁸⁶⁴ He had difficulty reconciling the power of chance with his deterministic faith in the inevitability of proletarian revolution. Despite believing that he, together with a healthy Lenin, might have halted Stalin's rise, Trotsky knew that he faced serious structural headwinds. Indeed, he later agreed with the 1927 claim of Lenin's

wife, Nadezhda Krupskaya, “that if [Lenin] had been alive he would probably have been doing time in a Stalin prison,” commenting “the thing that matters is not Stalin, but the [bureaucratizing] forces that he expresses without even realizing it.”⁸⁶⁵ Trotsky tried to keep his doubts at bay with silver lining counterfactuals. Rejecting the notion that “Stalin’s victory was inevitable,” he took solace in the achievements of the Trotskyite “Opposition,” noting that “without the bureaucracy’s fear of the Opposition, the course of Stalin ... toward the kulak ... would have ended up in the revival of capitalism.”⁸⁶⁶ In the end, however, Trotsky admitted that accident played a major role in historical events, concluding that “the entire historical process is a refraction of historical law through the accidental.”⁸⁶⁷ This conclusion revealed how Trotsky adjusted his deterministic inclinations to fit the reality of his setbacks. In so doing, he was the exception that proved the rule about communism’s determinist outlook.

Nazi Counterfactuals: 1918–1945

Like communist counterfactuals, Nazi “what ifs” were informed by a deterministic worldview. Yet, while the former expressed the principles of historical materialism, the latter reflected the worldview of National Socialism. As conceived by its chief ideologue, Adolf Hitler, National Socialism was deterministic, teleological, and providential (Figure 5.4). Hitler saw history as driven by the Social Darwinist belief that ruthless struggle between racially superior and inferior beings—most notably, Aryans and Jews—was the engine of human history. He believed that this struggle was historically responsible for driving human development towards ever higher levels of achievement. And he believed he was chosen by a secular version of providence to ensure that the German people realized its intended racial destiny. That said, Hitler’s determinism was not absolute. As was true of Lenin and Stalin, Hitler’s authoritarianism led him to acknowledge that individual leadership—especially his own—could impact broader historical forces.

Hitler often used counterfactuals to support his ideological mission. During the movement phase of the Nazi party in the years 1920 to 1933, he used causal and missed opportunity counterfactuals to attack the Weimar order. After rising to power in 1933, and then for the next twelve years until the Nazi regime’s collapse in 1945, Hitler used deterministic counterfactuals to depict his actions as consonant with historical necessity and close call counterfactuals to stress the importance of his leadership in Nazism’s success. Apart from Hitler, other Nazis also used counterfactuals, mostly to express loyalty to his regime. A tiny minority, however, used “what ifs” to express dissent.



FIGURE 5.4 Adolf Hitler used counterfactuals to underscore the inevitability of Nazism's emergence and success. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Critiquing the Legacy of 1918

Hitler's worldview was directly shaped by the traumatic legacy of 1918. Germany's loss of World War I, the collapse of the Hohenzollern monarchy, and the eruption of leftwing revolutions in November 1918 prompted the demobilized war veteran and aspiring politician to wonder "what if" in many ways.

Hitler used causal counterfactuals to blame Germany's military defeat on the country's old imperial elite. Focusing on missed opportunities related to the Kaiserreich's foreign policy, Hitler insisted Germany should have allied with England instead of Austria in 1914, declaring in *Mein Kampf* (1925) that "no sacrifice should have been too great for winning England's willingness. We should

have renounced ... sea power and spared English industry our competition.”⁸⁶⁸ If Germany had joined with England “against Russia” and abandoned “a feeble global policy” overseas for “a determined European policy of territorial acquisition on the continent,” he noted, “there would never have been any ‘World War,’” and Germany “would have [been blessed with] a ... mighty future.”⁸⁶⁹

Hitler also alleged that Germany could have won the war had it not been for the German left. Writing in *Mein Kampf*, he argued that “if ... the German [labor] unions ... in matters of national defense ... had avowed their Germanism with the same fanaticism” as they pursued their class interests, then “the War would not have been lost.”⁸⁷⁰ He also blamed the postwar revolutionary government for signing the Treaty of Versailles, arguing in 1932 that the hated treaty “would never have come about had not the Center, the Social Democrats, and the Democrats ... undermined, destroyed, and betrayed the old Reich.”⁸⁷¹ Instead of signing the Treaty, Hitler said in 1924 that the leftist government should have resisted it, arguing that “if ... [President Friedrich] Ebert ... [and Reich Minister President Philipp] Scheidemann ... had called on the German People to take up the fight for freedom,... the Republic would still be intact, and none of us would raise a hand against it.”⁸⁷²

Furious about this alleged subversion, Hitler conceived murderous fantasies that might have prevented it. “The leaders of the whole movement should at once have been put behind bars [and] brought to trial,” he argued in *Mein Kampf*, adding that “all the implements of military power should have been ruthlessly used for the extermination of this pestilence.”⁸⁷³ He singled out left-wing Jews for particular punishment, declaring: “If at the beginning ... [of] the War twelve or fifteen thousand of these Hebrew corrupters ... had been held under poison gas,... the sacrifice of millions at the front would not have been in vain.” Indeed, he noted, “twelve thousand scoundrels eliminated in time might have saved the lives of a million real Germans, valuable for the future.”⁸⁷⁴

Yet, Hitler ultimately saw redemptive significance in the bleak years of the Weimar Republic. Employing a silver lining counterfactual, he noted in *Mein Kampf* that “it must almost be considered ... good fortune that [Germany’s]... period of creeping sickness was suddenly cut short by so terrible a catastrophe, for otherwise the nation would have gone to the dogs more slowly.”⁸⁷⁵ Hitler further saw providential forces at work in the Nazis’ failed Beer Hall Putsch of November 9, 1923, writing that “[the] failure proved ... to be of greater benefit than we may realize to this day.”⁸⁷⁶ For while he was eventually jailed for treason, Hitler explained that “without my imprisonment, *Mein Kampf* would not have been written” and he would not have “acquired that fearless faith ... which nothing could shake thereafter.”⁸⁷⁷ Hitler emphasized this point in 1943, noting

that his setback “actually helped National Socialist ideology ... spread like wild-fire ... and convey[ed] the essence of Jewry to so many million men, as we ourselves would never have been able to do under normal circumstances.”⁸⁷⁸ As he concluded, “without a November 9, 1923,... there would not be a strong German Reich today.”⁸⁷⁹

Justifying the Legacy of 1933

The creation of the Nazi dictatorship in 1933 provided further material for counterfactual self-justification. Hitler repeatedly validated the radical methods used by the Nazis to seize power as essential for avoiding a communist putsch. In defending the Reichstag Fire Decree of February 27 and the Enabling Act of March 23, 1933, Hitler noted that “the burning of the Reichstag [was]... only a taste of what Europe would have to expect from a triumph of [communism],” adding that “only by means of its immediate action was the Government able to ward off a development which would have shaken all of Europe had it proceeded to its disastrous end” (Figure 5.5).⁸⁸⁰ Hitler reiterated similar points in 1936, when he noted that “[a] Red revolt and the collapse of the German Reich [in 1933] would have dealt the European order ... a blow having consequences which ... are virtually beyond the grasp of most European statesmen.”⁸⁸¹ And on January 30, 1944, he noted that that “without the National Socialist revolution,... there would be no factor today that could oppose the Bolshevik colossus.”⁸⁸²

Hitler also speculated in justifying his crushing of the paramilitary *Sturmabteilung* (SA), led by Ernst Röhm, on the “Night of the Long Knives” on June 30, 1934. Here again, he noted that his bloody purge—which killed around 200 people—averted worse calamities. “From May onwards,” he noted, “there could no longer be any doubt that Chief of Staff Röhm was involved in ambitious plans which, had they become reality, could have resulted only in the most violent disruptions.”⁸⁸³ For this reason, he explained in 1934, “lightning action had been required to rule out the danger that many thousands of human lives would have been destroyed.”⁸⁸⁴ “It is hard to even fathom,” Hitler declared, “what would have become of Germany in the event that this sect had been victorious.”⁸⁸⁵

Hitler also used “what ifs” to legitimize his aggressive foreign policy after the mid-1930s. In discussing his decision to remilitarize the Rhineland in 1936, Hitler recalled that when he threatened France with “send[ing] six extra divisions into the Rhineland,” he actually “only had four brigades,” adding, “what would have happened on the 13th of March 1936, if anybody other



FIGURE 5.5 Hitler claimed that without the Reichstag Fire Decrees, Germany would have faced the nightmare of a “red revolt.” (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

than myself had been at the head of the Reich! Anyone you care to mention would have lost his nerve.”⁸⁸⁶ It was a close call, Hitler continued, for “had the French ... marched into the Rhineland, we would have been forced to withdraw, greatly losing face, since our armed forces back then did not possess sufficient strength.”⁸⁸⁷ Hitler used an aggrandization counterfactual to boast about his bloodless annexation of Austria in 1938, noting that “had I not complied with the wishes of the Austrian Volk and its new National Socialist Government,... our intervention would subsequently have been necessary in any case” and potentially caused “endless ... suffering.”⁸⁸⁸ On the eve of Germany’s planned invasion of the Sudetenland in September of 1938, finally, Hitler declared that “any further leniency” toward the Czechs “would have been construed as a most fatal weakness, adding “I would not have had the right to appear in the annals of German history had I nonchalantly abandoned ... ten million [ethnic Germans] to their fate” instead of being the “Führer of this Volk.”⁸⁸⁹

Hitler reserved most of his speculative energy for defending the Nazi invasion of the Soviet Union on June 22, 1941. Between the fall of 1941 and early 1945, Hitler validated the launching of Operation Barbarossa over a dozen times with medium form counterfactuals. In early October, 1941, he amplified how “immensely great the danger had been” by saying that the Soviet threat “could have become a second Mongolian invasion by a new Genghis Khan,” adding in December that “had this wave of more than twenty thousand [Soviet] tanks [and] hundreds of divisions ... started to move across the Reich, then Europe would have been lost.”⁸⁹⁰ Hitler also emphasized the unified nature of the anti-Bolshevik crusade, noting in 1941 that “had Finland not been immediately determined to take up arms,... had not Slovaks, Hungarians, and Romanians also taken on the defense of this European world,... had not Italy, Spain, and Croatia sent their divisions, then the resistance of the European front would not have developed.”⁸⁹¹ In 1943, Hitler added that “had the German Wehrmacht not raised its shield before Europe at the last minute on June 22, 1941,” then the Soviets would have been able to “pursue ... the goal of attacking Europe,... destroying its culture, and, above all, exterminating the European in order to win slaves for work in the Siberian tundra.”⁸⁹²

Hitler's nightmare scenarios reflected his Social Darwinist philosophy of history. Believing that history was the outgrowth of racial struggle, he justified the Nazi crusade against Bolshevism by pointing to looming demographic trends. As he argued in 1941 with a predictive counterfactual, “If this war had not taken place, the Reich would scarcely have increased its population during the next ten years, but the Russian population would have grown vigorously.”⁸⁹³ One year later, he made a similar point in declaring that “the more we see of conditions in Russia, the more thankful we must be that we struck in time. In another ten years there would have sprung up in Russia a mass of industrial centres, inaccessible to attack, which would have produced armaments on an inexhaustible scale, while the rest of Europe would have degenerated into a defenceless plaything of Soviet policy.”⁸⁹⁴ “If Stalin had been given another ten or fifteen years,” Hitler added in 1942, “Russia would have become the mightiest State in the world, and two or three centuries would have been required to bring about a change.”⁸⁹⁵

One reason Hitler used “what ifs” to justify Operation Barbarossa was because of the setbacks it experienced after 1941. In private conversations recorded in his *Table Talk*, Hitler often lamented Germany's present-day difficulties in the Soviet Union by invoking missed opportunities from earlier eras in German history. On several occasions, he regretted that medieval German rulers had tried to colonize Eastern European Slavs instead of Italy, declaring “But for the particularism of the German princes, we'd have succeeded in Germanising the

whole of Northern Italy,” adding that if “expansion to the West had been pursued logically, we’d have a great Germanic empire stretching from Denmark to the Loire.”⁸⁹⁶ If he “had been an emperor of the Holy Empire,” Hitler made clear, he would not have been “tempted by the conquest of the East ... [where] Winter ... lasts ... all the year round.”

Hitler’s wartime travails also prompted him to go further back in time and wish that Christianity had never shaped German history. Echoing Nietzsche from half a century earlier, Hitler declared in 1941 that “without Christianity, the Roman Empire, under Germanic influence, would have developed in the direction of world-domination” and defeated “the onrush of the Huns” from the east, thus sparing the Nazis their present-day military difficulties.⁸⁹⁷ Germany would have also avoided the internal divisions caused by the Protestant Reformation. Arguing that “we were already a great empire when the English were only beginning to build up their maritime power,” Hitler said, “If we hadn’t been such fools as to tear each other to pieces in order to find out whether we should consume God in the forms of bread and wine ... or of bread only, England would never have been able to have her say concerning the balance of power on the Continent.”⁸⁹⁸ Hitler even fantasized that German history would have turned out better if the Germans had originally been Muslim instead of Christian. Drawing on Edward Gibbon’s famous counterfactual, Hitler speculated that “Had Charles Martel not been victorious at Poitiers,... then we should in all probability have been converted to Mohammedanism, that cult which glorifies heroism and ... the bold warrior ... Then the Germanic races would have conquered the world. Christianity alone prevented them from doing so.”⁸⁹⁹

Despite his critique of Christianity, Hitler was ironically indebted to the religion for his providential view of history. Hitler believed he had been chosen by providence to lead Germany to greatness and frequently used providential counterfactuals to justify his political agenda. Hitler credited providence with his survival of the Great War, noting that he “might have perished like millions of my comrades” but had a mission to fulfill.⁹⁰⁰ In 1941, he speculated that “If somebody else had one day been found to accomplish the work to which I’ve devoted myself, I would never have entered on the path of politics. I’d have chosen the arts or philosophy.”⁹⁰¹ But, as no other candidate was available, he was selected by fate to serve Germany’s needs. Convinced that “Providence does not show mercy to the weak” and “only recognizes the right to live for the ... strong,” Hitler justified his aggressive actions as necessary for Germany’s survival.⁹⁰² Viewing himself as a latter day Bismarck, Hitler noted that “only a German from the South” such as himself “could have brought about [the]... second unification” of Germany under Nazism.”⁹⁰³ As he declared in 1938, “I

would have sinned against Providence's calling, if I had become a traitor to this endeavor to return my homeland and my German Volk of the Ostmark to the Reich."⁹⁰⁴ Hitler extended this belief to the war against the Soviet Union in 1943, asking Germans to imagine "what might have become of Germany and Europe, had Providence not effected the transfer of power to National Socialism ... on January 30, 1933?"⁹⁰⁵

Near the end war's end, however, the prospect of military defeat eroded Hitler's faith in providence and led him to use counterfactuals to blame others for Germany's woes. When he learned about the involvement of Army leaders in the July 20, 1944, plot against his life, for example, Hitler exclaimed: "Now I know why all my great plans in Russia had to fail in recent years. It was all treason! But for those traitors, we would have won long ago."⁹⁰⁶ Until the bitter end, in short, Hitler used "what ifs" to shield himself from the reality of history.

Other leading Nazis used counterfactuals in similar ideological fashion. Many did so to display their loyalty to Hitler and the larger Nazi cause. Reich Propaganda Minister Joseph Goebbels, for instance, frequently mimicked Hitler's counterfactual claims, noting in March of 1933, "if we had not come to power, everything would have ended in a terrible catastrophe."⁹⁰⁷ Other Nazi writers used *sine qua non* counterfactuals to highlight Hitler's centrality to the Nazi movement. In 1933, for instance, the Nazi historian Werner Haverbeck wrote that "without ... Hitler's struggle and the efforts of the Brown army ... Germany would have forever sunk into chaos."⁹⁰⁸

Nazi officials also used counterfactuals to justify the regime's most heinous crimes. In his notorious October 4, 1943 speech to the SS in Posen, Heinrich Himmler explained that it was necessary to undertake the grueling task of "exterminating the Jewish people" to avoid a repeat of their alleged treason during World War I, speculating that "we know how difficult things would be, if today in every city during the bomb attacks, the burdens of war and privations, we still had Jews as secret saboteurs, agitators and instigators. We would probably be at the same stage as 16/17, if the Jews still resided in the body of the German people."⁹⁰⁹ In March of 1944, Hans Frank, the Nazi chief of the Polish General Government, made a similar claim, declaring: "if there were still one and a half to two million Jews there ... we would have had so much sabotage ... that we would not have been able to save ourselves."⁹¹⁰ Admiral Karl Doentz agreed, noting in 1944 that "if the Führer had not united us under National Socialism" Germany would have been "beset with the spreading poison of Jewry" and "succumbed under the burden of ... war."⁹¹¹ In making these claims, Nazi officials channeled Hitler's own preemptive logic. For as the Nazi leader told the conservative politician, Hermann Rauschning, in 1940 about

the Germany's plan to displace Slavs from Eastern Europe: "we are merely doing unto others as they would have done to us."⁹¹²

Between Ambivalence and Critique: Nazi Reflections on Counterfactuals

Like Bolshevik leaders in Russia, Hitler and other Nazis rarely reflected on the merits and drawbacks of counterfactual thinking. On one of the few occasions when he did, however, Hitler dismissed its value. In discussing a "mistake" made by Benito Mussolini during the failed coup of Austrian Nazis in 1934, Hitler concluded that "the criteria by which a politician should be judged are ... the actual services he has rendered to his country," not "juggling with possible hypotheses," declaring that "in politics, the use of that little word 'if' must be avoided." To explain the irrelevance of "ifs," Hitler paradoxically cited a variety of counterfactuals. "It is ... perfectly true," he noted, "to say that had the Romans been defeated by the Huns on the Gatalaunian Fields the growth of western culture would have been impossible." But the claim, he continued, was ultimately "of no importance." It was equally misguided to wonder "where [we Germans] should ... be to-day IF the Czechs had had a little imagination, or IF the Poles had been realists and had gone about their affairs with a little more honesty?" In the end, Hitler argued, such speculative questions ran up against the deterministic essence of separate peoples. As he noted, "it is precisely the fact that the Pole is a dreamer and the Czech is an out-and-out realist which has enabled us swiftly and successfully to establish the new order in the territories formerly known as Czechoslovakia and Poland."⁹¹³ These rare comments, uttered at a time when the German war effort in the east was stagnating, reflected Hitler's reluctance to admit that his deterministic worldview was being threatened by chance.

Like Hitler, most Nazi historians seldom reflected on counterfactuals, but when they did, they expressed the German historical profession's embrace of Nazi ideology. In 1935, for example, the head of the Nazi Teachers League and Gauleiter of Bavaria, Eastern March, Hans Schemm, explicitly called on Germans to appreciate Hitler's importance by imagining his absence. "If we want to appreciate the achievements of our Führer," Schemm wrote, "we should not measure the positive construction efforts of the past two years, but should ask the question, what would things be like today, if Adolf Hitler had never existed [*nicht gekommen wäre*]?"⁹¹⁴ Arguing that most Germans "forget too quickly," Schemm reminded them of the many nightmares they were spared by Hitler's rise to power, recalling that in 1933, "National Socialism was in a race with Bolshevism" and insisting that "if Bolshevism had gotten a head

start, then Germany today would be a pile of rubble.”⁹¹⁵ These “what ifs” echoed Hitler’s tendency to justify all his decisions as the leader of the Nazi regime.

Other Nazi writers built upon this tendency in more theoretical fashion by using counterfactuals to discuss the relationship between agency and structure in historical events. In his 1933 book, *Reichskanzler Adolf Hitler*, the Propaganda Ministry official, Johann von Leers, examined how the two forces had shaped the Nazis’ rise to power (Figure 5.6). Given his commitment to Hitler’s idea of the “leader principle” (*Führerprinzip*), von Leers privileged the role of the individual in historical events. At the same time, he embraced the Nazi view that Hitler channeled the will of the Volk and thereby emphasized the significance of structural realities. To disentangle the two factors, von Leers used “what ifs.” Notably enough, he prefaced his technique by posing the explicitly counterfactual question of “whether the National Socialist movement would have emerged without Hitler?” In answering it, von Leers on the one hand adopted what he called a “Hegelian method” and credited the emergence of a “völkisch sense of community” for serving as the “antithesis” that reacted against the original “thesis of liberal individualism” and creating the proper political context for Hitler’s emergence already prior to 1918.⁹¹⁶ Yet, this precondition was not sufficient by itself, for, as he explained, the sense of community among Germans was “for all intents and purposes, finished” by the end of World War I. At that point, von Leers argued, there was the need “for a statesman to emerge and provide spiritual clarity to the fermenting desires”—and it was “Adolf Hitler’s deed” to be able to give that “feeling ... organization.”⁹¹⁷ Von Leers’s conclusion was simple: “National Socialism is unthinkable without Hitler.”⁹¹⁸

Some Nazi writers, finally, used counterfactuals for more critical purposes. Like Leon Trotsky in the USSR, the renegade Nazi Otto Strasser wondered “what if” to express regret about being politically sidelined—in his case, for criticizing Hitler’s abandonment of the Nazi party’s original “socialist” principles in 1932–33. Despondent that Hitler’s conservative turn “blocked the path that would have led to German socialism,” Strasser speculated that a true “National-Socialist Revolution in Germany might have been the path leading to the consolidation of European peace.”⁹¹⁹ None of it was destined to happen, however. Having witnessed the triumph of “reaction” over “revolution,” Strasser feared that all his efforts “had been for nothing” and went so far as contemplate a kind of time-travel solution in which “it would be possible ... to reset the present day back to July 31, 1914, and dispense with the future” altogether.⁹²⁰

Another Nazi who used counterfactuals to critique the regime was Hermann Rauschning. A one-time party member who later became a conservative nationalist, Rauschning after 1939 accused Hitler of missing many opportunities for peace, saying that if he had kept to his original policy of pursuing “bilateral



FIGURE 5.6 Nazi Propaganda Ministry official, Johann von Leers, wondered whether Nazism would have arisen without Adolf Hitler. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

pacts with her neighbors,” then “it would have brought Germany assured and lasting successes.”⁹²¹ Rauschnig further criticized the Nazi government by expressing his preference for a military dictatorship, noting in 1940 that “military action against the Nazi regime” in the late 1930s “would have brought back into activity the political forces that had been paralyzed by the existing totalitarian tyranny ... [and] led irresistibly to a new state of constitutionalism.”⁹²² Like Strasser, however, Rauschnig ended up being disappointed.

Finally, the German writer Peter Purzelbaum also used counterfactuals to critique the Nazi regime. In his 1942 mass market anthology, *Was Wäre Wenn?* (*What If?*), Purzelbaum devoted twenty counterfactual essays to illustrating

the “holy majesty of chance.”⁹²³ While many of the essays focused on events in German military history—for example, the role of the Prussian army in the Napoleonic wars—others addressed famous European episodes like the Spanish Armada’s invasion of England in 1588 and Louis XVI’s flight to Varennes in 1791. Purzelbaum’s motives in exploring “what ifs” are unknown. The pen-name of the Prussian nobleman and former German military officer, Karl Alexander Prusz von Zglinitzki (1884–1957), Purzelbaum was a well-known writer of military adventure tales and a German nationalist.⁹²⁴ In his book’s introduction, Purzelbaum wrote that he merely sought to “entertain ... the reader,” but he may have also sought to advance a subversive political agenda.⁹²⁵ Given the fact that *Was Wäre Wenn?* appeared in 1942 when the German offensive on the Eastern front had stalled, his volume’s focus on “coincidence, miracle,... [and] accident” may have been meant to challenge the Nazi regime’s claim that victory was inevitable.⁹²⁶ The absence of explicitly pro-Nazi themes in the book—and the presence of several philosemitic references—also suggests that the volume might have been an example of anti-Nazi *Resistenz*.⁹²⁷ Whatever its intentions, *Was Wäre Wenn* once more revealed the political flexibility of counterfactual thinking.

Liberal Counterfactuals: 1918–1945

Unlike communists and Nazis, the supporters of liberal democracy were less self-confident in wondering “what if?” in the years 1918–1945. Whether they were classical liberals, social democrats, or moderate conservatives, the beleaguered supporters of democratic norms speculated about the past in urgent fashion. Especially in the United States and Great Britain, liberal writers desperately wondered how the era’s left-wing and right-wing threats could have been avoided. Especially after ideological tensions exploded into military conflict in 1939, liberal writers increasingly reflected on how counterfactuals could foster historical understanding.

Preventing Bolshevism

Liberal writers actively speculated about the Bolshevik Revolution. Some examined how it might have been prevented. Others focused on how it could have been defeated. Still others contemplated how its effects could have been mitigated.

Certain commentators argued that the revolution might have been prevented if the Russian monarchy had been reformed prior to 1914. The American

anti-Bolshevik writer Arkady Joseph Sack, for instance, saw missed opportunities in the Revolution of 1905, arguing that “if the program of the First Duma had been carried out, Russia would have become a constitutional monarchy of the English type, with very progressive social legislation.”⁹²⁸ Other commentators believed that Tsar Nicholas II could have reformed the Russian political system in 1914. The British journalist E. H. Wilcox argued that the granting of “wide liberties and radical constitutional reforms ... at that moment” might “have increased ... enthusiasm [for]... winning the War,” boosted “the popularity of the monarch,” and helped “the Empire’s political institutions [develop] along democratic lines.”⁹²⁹ Unfortunately, as the moderate socialist leader of Russia’s Provisional Government, Alexander Kerensky, noted in 1917, the Russian monarchy failed to appeal to the patriotism of the masses and “deliberately threw away this only chance, which, had it been taken advantage of, would have saved Russia from dissolution and ruin.”⁹³⁰

Kerensky’s ensuing rule also came in for counterfactual second-guessing (Figure 5.7). Criticizing his decision in March of 1917 to replace the Duma with a new, but unelected, Provisional Government as “the first deadly blow at national unity,” the American Jesuit writer Edmund A. Walsh noted in 1928 that “If Mr. Kerensky had fathomed ... the ... anarchic tendencies of his own people, he would [not] have ... divided the country hopelessly.”⁹³¹ The American sociologist Edward A. Ross meanwhile criticized Kerensky for suppressing General Lavr Kornilov’s right-wing coup against the Provisional government in July of 1917, writing in 1921 that if Kerensky had not “restrained the reactionary generals from ... crush[ing] the soviets,... the proletarian revolution might have been prevented.”⁹³² Writing in 1921, the British writer and Labor politician Morgan Philips Price criticized Kerensky for waiting until November 1917 to announce elections to the new Constituent Assembly, noting that “if the Constituent Assembly had been proclaimed earlier in the year, it would have acquired sufficient prestige” to have kept “the Soviets [from becoming]... the sole directing force in the Revolution.”⁹³³ Because Kerensky’s missteps benefited the Bolsheviks, the American Congressman William H. King lamented in 1924 that “If Kerensky ... had possessed more ... audacity and ... a little more ... cruelty,... his government would have been saved and the Bolsheviks would have failed in the successful coup which they executed.”⁹³⁴

In discussing the Bolsheviks’ actual seizure of power, many commentators explored the pivotal role of Vladimir Lenin. The conservative American historian William Henry Chamberlin wrote that “without [Lenin’s]... driving, extremist leadership, it is ... conceivable that the explosive mood of the masses would have evaporated in a series of disconnected, local outbursts.”⁹³⁵ Lenin had impeccable timing in launching his October revolt, for as the moderate



FIGURE 5.7 Liberal commentators criticized the moderate socialist leader of Russia's Provisional Government, Alexander Kerensky, for missing opportunities to stabilize the country on the eve of revolution. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Russian socialist N. N. Sukhanov asserted, “By the time Lenin declared himself to the masses,... the primitive instincts had been neutralized that would have swept Lenin away, and perhaps the Soviet into the bargain, if he had ‘pushed in’ before with his radical, naked harangues.”⁹³⁶ Chamberlin agreed, noting that “if the Bolsheviks had not struck for power ... when they did, their opportunity would have passed,” since “the meeting of the Constituent Assembly, in which the Bolsheviks ... could not have gained a majority, would have been a barrier against a violent coup.”⁹³⁷

By contrast, others saw the revolution—and Lenin’s role in it—as a product of deeper forces. Commenting on the famed “sealed train” journey of Lenin and his Bolshevik colleagues from Germany to Russia in April of 1917,

the American sociologist Edward A. Ross noted that “If the train ... had fallen through a bridge on its way and all had perished, events in Russia would have taken much the same course,” since “the peasants would have seized the estates and the soldiers would have quit fighting ... [just] like a flow of molten lava that no human force can ... turn aside.”⁹³⁸ Even Chamberlin saw Lenin as the product of circumstances—namely, the chaos produced by the First World War—speculating that “had there been no such conflict, it is most unlikely that ... Lenin,... would have found [himself] in control of the destin[y of his]... nation.”⁹³⁹ Kerensky, meanwhile, saw Lenin as a puppet of Germany, arguing that “had Lenin not had the backing of the entire material and technical power of the German propaganda machine and espionage service, he never would have succeeded in destroying Russia.”⁹⁴⁰

Other commentators argued that after its eruption, the Bolshevik Revolution might have been defeated or been switched onto a more moderate track. Chamberlin highlighted how the Bolsheviks benefited from Germany’s military setbacks in the summer of 1918 after concluding the Treaty of Brest-Litovsk, saying “had Germany emerged from the World War victorious,... it might well have gone hard with the Bolshevik Revolution.”⁹⁴¹ The British historian John Wheeler-Bennett agreed, writing that without the treaty, “the world might ... have never witnessed the vast experimentation of the victorious Soviet Power.”⁹⁴² Sir Edward Grey said that the Bolshevik government could have been weakened if the Allies had “declare[d] a policy of non-interference” after the armistice, noting “if that ... had been pursued,... Russia would ... have ... progress[ed] through a stage of revolution to ... evolution.”⁹⁴³ Chamberlin added that “if there had been ... no foreign intervention,” Soviet leaders would have brought “some kind of order out of the economic chaos into which the country had fallen” and this recognition “would have given a ... much more moderate turn to the ... Revolution.”⁹⁴⁴

In expressing regret about the Bolshevik Revolution, liberal commentators often speculated self-reflexively. Some highlight the role of accident in history. Pointing to how the Romanov dynasty’s political authority had been weakened by the trust placed by Tsarina Alexandra in the ability of the quack monk, Grigori Rasputin, to cure the health problems of her son and heir to the throne, Alexi, Edmund A. Walsh declared that if the boy “[had] not been a chronic haemophilic [and his mother had]... not been an abnormal hypochondriac,... Russia might have been spared the scourges that came upon her, and the world might not have known the challenge of Bolshevism.” Walsh went on to note how the Russian case echoed other instances when “relatively petty factors [determined]... the destiny of states and peoples,” noting “Had Anne Boleyn been less comely, Henry VIII might never have repudiated Katherine

of Aragon [and] there might have been no Spanish Armada, no schism, nor religious wars in England.”⁹⁴⁵

By contrast, other commentators dismissed the value of counterfactual speculation. The American journalist and Soviet sympathizer Albert Rhys Williams struck a determinist note and defended the Bolshevik Revolution by rejecting the claims of “wise men [who]... point out that [its]... results might have been obtained in a better way,” saying that “the Reformation, the Independence of America, [and] the Abolition of Slavery might have been achieved in a more gracious, less violent manner. But history did not move that way. And only the foolish quarrel with history.”⁹⁴⁶ Alexander Kerensky also resisted the appeal of wondering “what if,” dismissing the attempt of people in the face of “immense upheaval” to “prove that everything would have happened differently if so and so had acted thus and not otherwise,” insisting “it is easy to prophesy after the event!”⁹⁴⁷ Finally, in describing the Bolsheviks’ storming of the Winter Palace in 1917, the moderate Russian socialist writer Boris Shumansky refused to speculate about “[what] would have saved Russia from herself,” declaring that “it is not for me to pass judgment as to what might have been,” explaining that “it is not my purpose to judge. I am an historian.”⁹⁴⁸

Preventing Nazism

Liberal writers also fantasized about preventing the emergence of Nazism. Among the various scenarios they explored, one of the most divisive involved the Treaty of Versailles (Figure 5.8).⁹⁴⁹ Many British and American observers claimed that a milder treaty might have kept the Nazis from seizing control of Germany. In 1933, the British historian and Germanophile G. P. Gooch reacted to Hitler’s rise to power by declaring that “if we had made a moderate peace in 1919... things would never have developed like this.”⁹⁵⁰ That same year, the British journalist William Harbutt Dawson argued that “intelligent foresight might have prevented” the drafting of a treaty that stoked “national ... desperation” and played “into the hands of the extremist ... Nazi movement.”⁹⁵¹ Similar claims were expressed in the American press. In October of 1933, an Iowa newspaper declared that “without the Treaty of Versailles ... Hitler’s rise to power would have been impossible,” while letters to the editor in subsequent years repeated the claim of an angry *Chicago Tribune* reader in 1939 that “if there had been no Versailles treaty, there would have been no chance of Germany having a Hitler.”⁹⁵² Many similar claims were voiced by Anglo-American commentators before and after the eruption of World War II—especially among those seeking a separate peace with the Nazis—while closer to the war’s conclusion, they were advanced by people debating what kind of peace to impose on Nazi Germany.⁹⁵³



FIGURE 5.8 Liberal commentators vigorously debated how the Treaty of Versailles could have done a better job of preventing the rise of Nazism. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

By contrast, other critics rejected the claim that the Treaty of Versailles had been too harsh. Some justified the Treaty's severity by employing trading places counterfactuals. In 1939, Utah Senator William King said "the oppressive acts of Hitler" made clear "what kind of peace treaty Germany would have imposed on the allied nations if she had won the world war," concluding that "the Treaty of Versailles [was] moderate by comparison."⁹⁵⁴ Around the same time, British commentators agreed that the Treaty's terms were "mild and merciful" compared to what Britain would have suffered "if [Germany]... had been victorious."⁹⁵⁵ Other observers argued that the Treaty of Versailles should have been even tougher on the Germans. In 1935, a Canadian newspaper argued that "the Allies should have marched to Berlin, completing Germany's extinction," a point echoed several years later by the Austrian Jewish emigré scholar and American diplomat Egon Ranshofen-Wertheimer, who said that "if ... the Allies had occupied Berlin," then the Germans' "defeat ... [w]ould have been made more clear."⁹⁵⁶ As a Tennessee newspaper noted in 1938, if the "harsh Treaty" had been imposed to the letter, then "Germany would now be ... disarmed" and unable to "cause nightmares to Democracy."⁹⁵⁷

Still other scholars exonerated the Treaty of Versailles with the help of deterministic counterfactuals. Some embraced the "Luther to Hitler" view of

German history and argued that, even without the Treaty, the country would have gone down the path of authoritarianism.⁹⁵⁸ Rejecting the claim that “democracy would not have perished if the Treaty had not imposed an impossible reparations burden [on Germany],” the British writer and Labor official Harold Butler said that the war’s ruinous impact on Germany’s economy meant that the country would “have passed through a period of dire distress” anyway, and that rightwing extremists, “deprived of the reparations slogan,” would have seized upon other grievances and never “admitted that [their]... ruin was caused by their ... military failures.”⁹⁵⁹ Taking a more essentialist position was the British historian Rohan D’O. Butler, whose book, *The Roots of National Socialism* (1941), speculated that “the Nazis could never have won the devotion of the German folk by imposing a regimen wholly alien to the German outlook.”⁹⁶⁰ Somewhat less fatalistic, but still downcast, was the American scholar, James Thomson Shotwell, whose study, *What Germany Forgot* (1940), acknowledged the persistence of Germany’s “pre-war militarism” into the 1920s but exonerated the Treaty of Versailles by saying “all might ... have been overcome [but for]... the great depression.”⁹⁶¹ Similar claims appeared in the American press, with a Honolulu newspaper in 1940 declaring that “Germany probably ... would have ... followed the same devastating military course without the Treaty of Versailles.”⁹⁶²

Some commentators self-reflexively recognized that the Treaty of Versailles was what *The New York Daily News* in 1939 called “[one] of those big historical ‘ifs’” and questioned the value of historical speculation.⁹⁶³ In responding to the query of the American Secretary of State Sumner Welles, whether “the last war ... would have occurred” if the U.S. had joined the League of Nations, a British newspaper in 1942 said that “the ‘ifs’ of history have long been a fruitful source of speculation, though the conclusions to which they lead are bound to be barren, since no one can determine what effects on subsequent events would have been caused by one central fact taking a different direction.”⁹⁶⁴ Around the same time, an Ohio newspaper flirted with the idea that “if ... a peace of justice had been accomplished at Versailles, there ... never [would have] been an Adolf Hitler to ... darken the map of Europe,” before concluding that “the ‘Ifs’ of History” are excusable only in the laggard hours of idle speculation.⁹⁶⁵ Other observers who commented on what “might have prevented” the rise of the Nazis pessimistically declared that “the ifs of history ... are mere academic exercises.”⁹⁶⁶ Finally, the Austrian exile philosopher Aurel Kolnai rejected speculating about the rise of Nazism for moral reasons, writing that “a thing so evil ... cannot be attributed to this or that ‘mistake,’” insisting “we have no right to assume that ‘had it not been for ...’ all would have been well.”⁹⁶⁷

Theorizing “What Ifs”

Despite such skeptical comments, liberal historians in Western Europe and the United States were prompted by the interwar era’s ideological extremism to reflect on counterfactuals. While some historians critiqued them, many more endorsed them.

The most famous critic of counterfactuals was the Italian historian Benedetto Croce (Figure 5.9). In his 1937 essay, “History as the History of Liberty,” Croce rejected certain kinds of “what ifs” as detrimental to good historical writing.⁹⁶⁸ It was impermissible, he explained, for a historian to take two facts in a narrative, deem one “accidental,” and then “mentally eliminate” the latter “in order to espy how the first would have developed along its own lines if it had not been disturbed by the second.”⁹⁶⁹ In making this assertion, Croce essentially rejected Max Weber’s concept of “objective possibility.” As Croce famously put it, counterfactual reasoning was a “wearisome” activity, a “game” that “all of us in moments of ... idleness indulge in,” but which “had no rightful place” in history.⁹⁷⁰

Croce’s hostility to counterfactuals reflected his belief that they had affinities with fascist historiography. According to the historian, counterfactual reasoning represented a “rebellious assault” by rightwing forces against the Enlightenment idea of “historical necessity.” Croce was aware that this assault dated back to the nineteenth century but feared it was intensifying in the 1930s.⁹⁷¹ For Croce, historical necessity had to be defended from the wave of “logical absurdity” coming from rightwing historical texts that violated the rational foundations of traditional historiography. Pointing to the “mass of literature” that was appearing “at the present time in Germany,” Croce argued that fascist histories embraced an irrational, essentializing approach to “transient” subjects, such as nations and races. These histories, Croce wrote, analyzed such “stupid” notions as an “‘Aryan’ [or] ‘Semitic’ scent” and essentialized the qualities of historic individuals, such as Martin Luther or Dante Alighieri, into “absurdities” like “Lutherhood” or “Dantehood.”⁹⁷² For Croce, the production of “‘nationalist’ or ‘racial’ histories” were “monstrous” works of pseudo-scholarship. To defend against this worrisome trend, it was important to embrace rational concepts like necessity. It was thus important to reject counterfactuals.

By contrast, other scholars viewed historical necessity as a totalitarian concept that could be combatted with “what ifs.” In his book *The Gateway to History* (1938), the American historian Allan Nevins argued that “tyrannical authorit[ies]” in Germany and Italy had fostered the rise of “dogmatists who exaggerate the domain of the scientific in history.”⁹⁷³ “Russian Communists,”



FIGURE 5.9 The liberal Italian historian, Benedetto Croce, feared that counterfactuals had affinities with fascist historiography. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

he added, had also “gone to ... extremes in their treatment of history” by “making human thought and action ... by-products of economic processes.”⁹⁷⁴ Nevins objected to both views, arguing that they “underrate[d]... the powerful role which fortune or accident plays in history,” whether “a sudden illness; a change in weather; [or] the loss of a document.” As Nevins explained, “it is easy to conceive that Philip of Macedon might have left behind him a son as weak as Oliver Cromwell left in his son Richard. Had he done so, had there been no Alexander the Great, history would have recorded no Macedonian conquest of Asia Minor and Persia, no establishment of Greek kingdoms,... [and] no clearance of the way for the Roman Empire.”⁹⁷⁵ In short, “the course of all ancient and medieval history would have been profoundly different.” While Nevins conceded that “scientific history is constantly advancing,” he believed that

counterfactual scenarios revealed the importance of “chance and ... personality” in history.⁹⁷⁶

The English military historian Charles Oman also emphasized the importance of contingency in history (Figure 5.10). In the preface to his study, *On the Writing of History* (1939), Oman rejected the idea that history was “a logical, orderly development from cause to inevitable results,” saying instead that it was “full of ‘might-have-beens,’ [that]... deserve as much attention as the actual ... course of events.”⁹⁷⁷ Throughout his volume, Oman used counterfactuals to illustrate the importance of individuals and accidents in history. Using a series of vignettes to illustrate how “cataclysmic personalit[ies],” such as Mohammed, Alexander the Great, and William the Conqueror uniquely shaped historical events, Oman rejected the deterministic claim that “if [they]... had not lived, some other [figure]... must have arisen” to fulfill their tasks, noting that if “Alexander’s ... incapable half-brother, Philip” had ruled instead of him ... a thousand years of history ... might have taken a completely different aspect.”⁹⁷⁸ In discussing how counterfactuals could highlight the importance of accidents, Oman focused on the realm of warfare and pointed to a number of “great ‘Ifs’” involving Charles Martel and Napoleon Bonaparte to show how “many military events ... might well have gone otherwise [and]... turned European history into strange channels.”⁹⁷⁹ For Oman, recognizing that historical events “might have happened otherwise” was essential for averting the perils of determinism. Noting that “no word is so dangerous as the word inevitable,” he concluded that anyone who used it or any other “abstract general term” was a “propagandist.”⁹⁸⁰

Like Nevins, Oman advanced this argument with an eye towards the Nazis. For him, Nazi Germany was the worst example of a country that had produced “fake history” by embracing the “pseudo-historic legend ... that the Germans are a pure Nordic race.”⁹⁸¹ It was telling, then, that one of Oman’s most powerful counterfactuals implicitly fantasized about preventing the rise of German nationalism. In discussing the achievements of Otto von Bismarck, Oman pointed out that the Prussian chancellor was “helped by ... chance, which blessed him with a venerable head of state who survived long enough to allow [the newly unified Germany] to take root,” adding that “if [Kaiser] William I had died at threescore years and ten, instead of living to be ninety-one, Bismarck would have found himself confronted quite early on in his Chancellorship with a Liberal-minded monarch [Frederick III] who disliked him and all his ways.” Imagine the results,” Oman concluded, “if Frederick had succeeded to the Prussian throne in 1867.” “Bismarck would not have had ... [the] power ... to create the Reich.”⁹⁸² Subsequent German and European history would have been much happier.

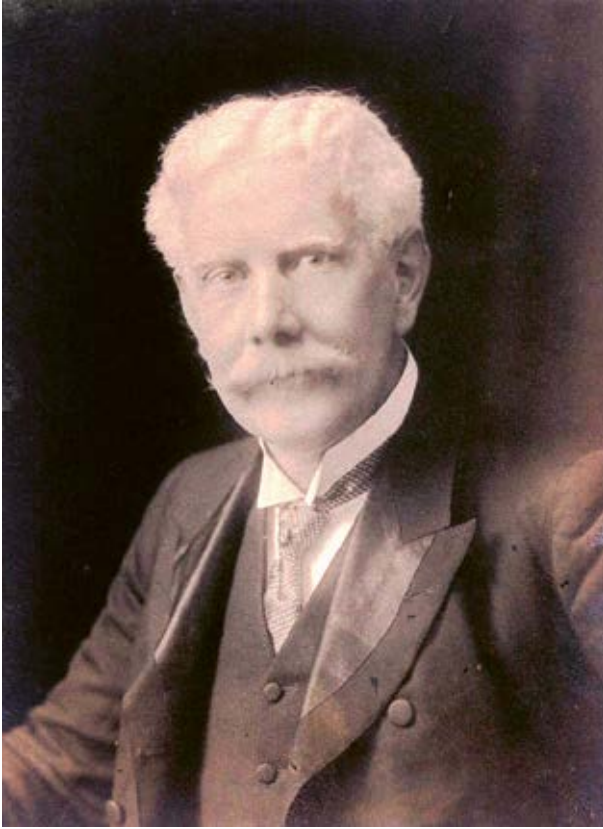


FIGURE 5.10 The English military historian, Charles Oman, argued that history is “full of ‘might-have-beens.’” (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Like Nevins and Oman, the French sociologist Raymond Aron also embraced counterfactual thought (Figure 5.11). In his 1938 book, *Introduction to the Philosophy of History: An Essay on the Limits of Historical Objectivity*, Aron systematically used “what ifs” to determine whether a “universally valid science of history was possible.”⁹⁸³ In pursuing this goal, Aron diverged from Croce and endorsed Max Weber’s idea of “objective possibility.”⁹⁸⁴ Declaring that “the cause of a phenomenon” could be affirmed by imagining “what would have happened” if an antecedent “disappeared,” Aron embraced what he called “unreal constructions” to explore “retrospective probabilities.”⁹⁸⁵ Citing examples from the Persian Wars of the 5th Century BCE, the Austro-Prussian War of 1866, and World War I, he insisted that “every historian, to explain what did happen, asks himself what might have happened.”⁹⁸⁶ Like Weber, Aron agreed



FIGURE 5.11 The French sociologist, Raymond Aron, agreed with Max Weber that counterfactuals, used carefully, could bolster historical understanding. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

that in pursuing this speculative version of “ideal history,” limits needed to be placed on the imagination. While it was acceptable to use subtractive cause counterfactuals, it was impermissible to embrace additive effect counterfactuals. Aron explained that “when the scholar asks ... whether by causing a fact to vary he gets ... another event,” the scholar usually remained “satisfied with showing that ‘something would have been different’ [and]... would not ... say more.”⁹⁸⁷ Yet, if the scholar speculated further, Aron noted, problems could arise. It would “surpass the power of our intelligence,” he insisted, to show how history would have been different “if the French had lost the Battle of the Marne” or if “America had not intervened [in the Great War in 1917].”⁹⁸⁸ While a scholar could flirt with “probability,” there was no chance of certainty. For

this reason, Aron explicitly distinguished his counterfactual method of determining causality from the less legitimate method of “writing a Uchronia (a history reshaped as it might have been).”⁹⁸⁹ Despite these limitations, Aron fully endorsed counterfactuals, concluding “the historian will no[t]... be refused the right to wonder what might have been.”⁹⁹⁰

In making his case, Aron had both scholarly and political goals in mind. He endorsed counterfactuals partly to resolve the longstanding debate about the role of chance and determinism in historical events. Notably, he bucked the tendency of French positivists to privilege the latter over the former, affirming that “accident plays a special part in history.”⁹⁹¹ Yet, Aron did not go as far as Nevins and Oman in embracing chance, asserting there was “no general solution” to the problem of explaining how contingent events and structural forces shaped historical change, saying “each [specific] case” had to be evaluated on its own terms.⁹⁹² Still, Aron remained wary of determinism because of its links to political extremism. A fierce opponent of totalitarianism, he understood that Nazism and Communism had eroded liberalism’s deterministic faith in progress and replaced it with an ideologically fanatical version of determinism.⁹⁹³ Wondering “what would have been,” by contrast, offered a means of “escaping the retrospective illusion of fatality” and the “counterfeit enslavement [of] necessity.”⁹⁹⁴ Convinced that history had “no prime mover” or “set terminus,” Aron argued that true liberals—those who “believe ... in freedom”—would reject determinism since they understood that “things might have been otherwise.”⁹⁹⁵ “In our day of blind beliefs,” Aron concluded, individuals should “emphasize the uncertainty of opinions rather than the absoluteness of commitments” and embrace the notion that “no humanity is possible without tolerance.”⁹⁹⁶ “What ifs” were thus important to use in historical analysis to ensure interpretive pluralism.

Like Aron, the French Jewish historian Marc Bloch also explored the utility of counterfactuals (Figure 5.12). In several essays written in 1941 and posthumously published in his classic book *The Historian’s Craft*, Bloch cautiously endorsed “what ifs” in the effort to better understand “causal relationship as a tool of historical knowledge.” Like Nevins, Oman, and Aron, Bloch sought to determine the role of accident in historical events.⁹⁹⁷ In a famous example that appeared in a chapter entitled “Historical Causation,” Bloch imagined “a man ... walking along a mountain path” and, upon tripping, “falling off a precipice.” Bloch explained that many “determining elements” were involved in the “accident.” But he stressed—in agreement with Aron and in direct contrast to Croce—how their relative importance could be distinguished with the help of subtractive cause counterfactuals. One could imagine, for instance, that if “the evolution of the earth [had] been otherwise” and not given rise to the



FIGURE 5.12 The French Jewish historian, Marc Bloch, used counterfactuals to better understand historical causality. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

“geological changes” that produced the mountain path in the first place, “the fall would not have happened.” Yet, while counterfactual reasoning proved these claims to be true, they were mostly important for highlighting the accident’s most proximate cause—“the misstep,” which was “the antecedent which could have been most easily avoided.”⁹⁹⁸ Based on this example, Bloch advised historians to accept “a graduated classification of causes” in analyzing historical events instead of pursuing “the fetish of [the] single cause.”⁹⁹⁹

In adopting this position, Bloch also rejected totalitarianism. In explaining why he refused to reduce human behavior to “rational” causes—for example, “economic ... self-interest”—he said that “the oppressive moral atmosphere in which we are currently plunged” could hardly have erupted from “the rational part of our minds” and was likely rooted in deeper “psychological facts.”¹⁰⁰⁰ Unfortunately, Bloch was unable to further develop his thoughts on the

relationship between politics and historiography due to the Nazi occupation of France, which he fought against as a member of the French resistance until being executed by the Gestapo in 1944. As Bloch's friend, the eminent historian Lucien Febvre, noted in the introduction to *The Historian's Craft*, Bloch had planned to devote part of a final chapter to "the idea of chance," which might have included reflections on counterfactuals.¹⁰⁰¹ Support for this claim was suggested in the third chapter of *The Historian's Craft*, entitled "Historical Criticism," in which Bloch explicitly asked whether historians could legitimately assess the "probability of a past event," for instance, the "probability ... that Adolf Hitler, the soldier of 1914, would escape French bullets?"¹⁰⁰² Bloch's choice of this example was significant as it entailed a fantasy scenario that would have spared him later suffering. It is unclear, however, whether he would have embraced counterfactuals to the same degree as his colleagues. While he conceded that "we are not forbidden to amuse ourselves with such questions," he ultimately dismissed them as "a metaphysical game."¹⁰⁰³

Several years later, the English philosopher Bertrand Russell employed several counterfactuals in his book *How to Read and Understand History* (1943). Like other liberal scholars, Russell was also influenced by the era's political turmoil. Arguing that "there has been in recent times a dangerous tendency, not unconnected with totalitarianism, to think only in terms of whole communities, and to ignore the contributions of individuals," Russell insisted that "the main course of great events may sometimes depend upon the actions of an individual."¹⁰⁰⁴ Russell used various "what ifs" to illustrate this point, claiming for instance that "the Russian Revolution would have been very different without Lenin."¹⁰⁰⁵ This example, Russell argued, showed not only how "a comparatively small force may decide" which of two "opposing forces in ... momentary equilibrium" will ultimately "be victorious" but revealed why scholars should not try and "turn history into a science."¹⁰⁰⁶ Given that the existence of "incalculable forces" impeded the identification of causal laws, Russell concluded that anyone who sought to "make up philosophies of history" could be dismissed as "inventors of mythologies."¹⁰⁰⁷

The expatriate American art historian Bernard Berenson also viewed "what ifs" as an antidote to the era's ideological upheaval (Figure 5.13). In January of 1943, while living in Fascist Italy, Berenson (who was a Jewish convert to Episcopalianism) reflected on the precarious reality of daily life during the war. In his wartime diaries, *Rumor and Reflection*, he noted that the "contradictory rumors" spawned by contemporary events sensitized him to the role of "unpredictable ... accidents" and convinced him to abandon "the doctrine [of]... historical inevitability" as a "dangerous dogma."¹⁰⁰⁸ Berenson illustrated this belief by including many counterfactual reflections in his diary entries—in



FIGURE 5.13 The American art historian, Bernard Berenson, viewed “what ifs” as an antidote to the interwar era’s ideological extremism. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

particular, on the links between the ancient past and the fascist present. This was best illustrated by Berenson’s extended claim that if the anti-Christian Roman Emperor, Julian, had “ruled ... for thirty [years]” instead of “a bare three,” Europe would have avoided the early twentieth century plague of ideological extremism.¹⁰⁰⁹ Like Nietzsche, Berenson was a critic of Christianity, calling it “totalitarian,” and wrote that the rise of a “Julian” form of religious observance in the Roman Empire “would have prevented the monopoly which led the church to actuate a totalitarian authoritarianism the likes of which the world had never known before or since, till our own day in Russia and Germany.”¹⁰¹⁰

Berenson explicitly praised the heuristic value of counterfactuals and said that he “could write volumes on this subject ... if [only] I were twenty-nine

instead of seventy-nine." To illustrate the potential of what he believed was still a "fallow field of history," Berenson outlined a number of counterfactual scenarios worth exploring, included the possibility that

If Akhenaton had reigned half as long as Ramses II,... he might have freed Egypt from the strangling grip of the Theban priesthood ... and anticipated by a thousand years the best that Jerusalem and Athens were going to teach. If Philip of Macedon had not been assassinated, he would have turned his arms westward to Hellenize perhaps the whole of Europe penetratingly, instead of leaving the task to be half done by Romans ... There was no historical necessity for any of these misfortunes and failures, nor for hundreds of others. But for Mussolini and his peculiar temperament, Italy ... would not have engaged in this war and be suffering her present humiliation and distress. If Hitler's mind had not been possessed by infantile stories about the Jews, he would not have made their extirpation one of the most urgent, if not the foremost, of his tasks.¹⁰¹¹

The importance of such speculative questions ultimately led Berenson to conclude that "we must stop thinking and writing about human history as if it were geology or astronomy." "On the contrary," he concluded, history was "crossed ... by the unforeseeable."¹⁰¹²

Of all the scholars who explored counterfactuals during the interwar era, the most significant was the left-wing American Jewish writer Sidney Hook (Figure 5.14). In his 1943 study, *The Hero in History*, Hook offered the most systematic analysis of how "what ifs" fostered historical understanding. Like many historians before him, Hook used counterfactuals to determine the relative importance of individual agency and structural determinants in historical events. In doing so, he, too, embraced the former over the latter due to his concerns about the totalitarian tendencies of his era.¹⁰¹³ At a time in history "where so few can ... decide so much," he wrote, it was crucial to examine "the historical significance of outstanding individuals."¹⁰¹⁴ While Hook explained that this "cult of the hero" was a byproduct of contemporary "crisis," he traced it back to the larger nineteenth century debate sparked by Thomas Carlyle about whether "great men" or impersonal forces drove historical events. Hook went on to survey the ways in which nineteenth and twentieth century figures, from Hegel to Trotsky, used counterfactuals to explain historical causality. In so doing, he concluded that "the whole answer to our inquiry depends upon the legitimacy of our asking and answering ... what would have happened if this event had not happened or that man had not lived or this alternative had not been taken."¹⁰¹⁵



FIGURE 5.14 The left-wing American Jewish writer, Sidney Hook, used counterfactuals to determine the relative importance of individual agency and structural forces in historical events. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Throughout his study, but especially in a chapter entitled, “If in History,” Hook examined a plethora of counterfactuals—from the Persian Wars to the rise of Nazism—to arrive at a series of notable theoretical insights. He argued, to begin with, that for historical individuals to qualify as “great,” one had to disprove the objection of critics that “if the individuals had not lived ..., their work ... would have been done by others.”¹⁰¹⁶ The proponents of individual agency would have to show that “if the great man had not existed, the course of events ... would ... have taken a different turn.”¹⁰¹⁷ To illustrate his point, Hook insisted on the greatness of President Franklin D. Roosevelt by arguing that “if, by some chance, [the conservative Texas Congressman and later Vice President] John Nance Garner

had been President" instead of Roosevelt in the early 1930s, the latter's New Deal programs would not "have been adopted" and their absence "would have resulted in a tremendous growth of indigenous Fascist sentiments ... out of which a Huey Long could have made great political capital."¹⁰¹⁸

Yet while Hook believed this example proved that "contingent events in history are tremendously important," he cautioned that "not all events are contingent" and that many occurred within strict limitations of time and place. While "alternatives in history ... might have redetermined the course of events in the past," Hook wrote, it was not the case that "all alternatives are possible," only those that are "grounded [in] ... laws of social behavior."¹⁰¹⁹ No matter how pivotal FDR's left-leaning policies were during the years of the Great Depression, Hook argued, "in 1929, Roosevelt would have been as helpless as Hoover."¹⁰²⁰ Timing—or what Hook called "the receptivities of the moment"—was everything.¹⁰²¹ Finally, Hook did not regard all counterfactuals as equal. While he endorsed those that were "scientifically credible," he rejected "imaginative reconstructions" that extended the time frame "indefinitely forward"—from "a few years ... [to] a hundred years"—so that "the mind staggers under the cumulative weight of the unforeseen."¹⁰²² Hook thus echoed the reservations of Weber, Aron, and many others about additive effect counterfactuals.

In the end, Hook hoped that counterfactuals could counteract totalitarianism and promote democracy. While his analysis cited examples from many centuries of history, his frequent invocation of Nazism and Communism revealed his concerns about the present day. Hook's historical reflections mirrored his political commitments. As a former Trotskyite-turned-liberal, he rejected the gloomy, deterministic claim that "the drift toward totalitarian political controls" was "a natural consequence of ... our economy and ... an inescapable consequence of total war."¹⁰²³ Instead, he argued that people retained the freedom to "determin[e] ... who the state shall be."¹⁰²⁴ For this reason, it was crucial to remember that "history ... present[s] a daily confrontation of alternatives in which we forge part of our own destiny." By making sure that the individual is "free to make his own decisions" and not surrender them "to an event-making man," society could ensure that the emerging "collectivist society" would develop in a democratic direction.¹⁰²⁵ Wondering "what if" about both the past and future was thus critical to liberal democratic practice.

Conclusion

In the period between the two World Wars, counterfactual history was shaped by competing political trends. On the one hand, the rise of communism in the

Soviet Union and Nazism in Germany led people in both countries to speculate within strict deterministic parameters. Committed as they were to ideologically rigid philosophies of history, communists and Nazis had difficulty imagining anything apart from the success of their respective movements. While they used close call counterfactuals to express relief that history worked out as it did, communists and Nazis had no doubt that it was destined to do so. Liberals, by contrast, were driven by their despair about the era's totalitarian tendencies to see history as shaped by chance. Having lost their faith in progress, they saw history not as a realm of transcendent meaning but random accident. As a result, they became increasingly prone to meditate self-reflexively about the ways in which counterfactual speculation could help make sense of the world. As would be shown by the literary work of many fiction writers, moreover, they were hardly alone.

Cultural Counterfactuals: The Rise of Alternate History, 1815–1945

The Saint Napoléon Cathedral, decorated with all the riches of the earth, sparkled with gold and precious stones. ...

People from the four corners of the earth [were in attendance] in their national costumes,... [including] generals, magistrates, [and] sovereign princes. ...

The Emperor stood and walked down the few steps ... toward the Pope.

Then His Holiness ... anointed the forehead of Napoléon with holy oil. Taking from the altar a newly designed crown formed of six golden laurel leaves, representing each of the continents of the earth, he presented it to the monarch saying:

'God consecrates you, through my hand, Universal Monarch of the World. May His name be adored and yours glorified!'¹⁰²⁶ (Louis-Napoléon Geoffroy-Château 1836)

Europeans and Americans speculated about the past not only in works of history but literature. In the years between 1815 and 1945, European and American writers increasingly channeled counterfactual thinking into literary form, producing works of fiction that eventually developed into a literary genre known as alternate history. The first acknowledged example of alternate history appeared in 1836, when the French writer, Louis-Napoléon Geoffroy-Château, published his pioneering novel *Napoleon and the Conquest of the World, 1812–1832*. In imagining how Napoleon Bonaparte might have become the ruler of planet Earth, Geoffroy-Château was merely the first of several French writers in the mid-nineteen century to publish alternate histories about Napoleon's legacy.

The wave of speculative fiction inaugurated by Geoffroy-Château was soon followed by others. Between the 1880s and 1914, a spate of counterfactual novels and short stories appeared in the United States and Britain on a range of topics inspired by contemporary domestic and foreign policy concerns. Not long thereafter, between 1918 and the early 1930s, a third wave of alternate histories appeared, one in which Anglo-American writers wondered "what if?" about the legacy of World War I. In the years prior to the outbreak of World War II in 1939, the production of alternate histories slowed, but those that appeared expressed the era's growing fears about fascism. By 1945, in short,

alternate history had emerged as a notable, if still nascent, manifestation of the western counterfactual tradition.

The Origins of Alternate History

Alternate history is a genre of literature with many distinctive features. The first is the recent vintage of its name. As is discussed in Chapter 8 of this volume, alternate history has only been viewed as an independent literary genre since the 1990s. Prior to that point, it was regarded as a subgenre of science fiction and described with such terms as *uchronia*, *parahistory*, *allotopia*, and *alternate world fiction*.¹⁰²⁷ Alternate history is typically viewed as a form of historical fiction. But it is distinct in important ways. While the latter depicts fictional characters acting in real historical settings and experiencing real historical events alongside real historical figures, the former places its characters in settings where the course of historical events is dramatically altered.¹⁰²⁸ Alternate histories change both the causes and consequences of the known historical record to something “other” and alien. They promote an estranging rather than mimetic relationship to history.¹⁰²⁹

In making this ontological leap, alternate histories share traits with, but are ultimately distinct from, other genres of historical fiction. One such genre is known as “secret history.” Dating back to antiquity, secret histories claim to expose the “hidden” realities of historical events but do not change the historical record.¹⁰³⁰ They can either uncover the “true” origins of events that actually happened (for example, Greg Iles’ 1993 novel *Spandau Phoenix*, which reveals the “real” reason why Rudolf Hess mysteriously flew to England in 1941) or they can expose the existence of events that almost, but ultimately never, happened (for example, Jack Higgins’s 1975 novel *The Eagle Has Landed*, which portrays the Nazis attempting, but ultimately failing, to kill Winston Churchill in World War II).

Alternate histories also share traits with, but are ultimately distinct from, future histories. Whereas the former changes how events transpire in the past, the latter does so for events in the future. Works of utopian and dystopian fiction are the best-known examples of this literary genre, whether H. G. Wells’s *The Time Machine* (1895) or George Orwell’s *1984* (1948), the plots of which unfold in the distant, or near, future relative to the text’s publication date. Future histories can also take the form of time travel and parallel world tales, which are typically set in a future that the narrative’s protagonist has created by travelling back in time and altering historical events. Due to their fantastical elements, future histories have often been classified as works of science fiction

instead of alternate history. Yet future histories can easily cross over into alternate histories (and vice versa). Tales that feature a point of divergence in the past but explore its consequences at a point in time after the tale's publication date can, in certain instances, be seen as alternate histories. Keith Roberts's novel *Pavane* (1966) pivots on a sixteenth-century point of divergence (the assassination of Queen Elizabeth), but its main plot takes place in the year 1968—a point close in time to the novel's appearance. By contrast, tales that unfold in the distant future relative to their publication date, for example Frank Herbert's *Dune* series (1955–85)—which takes place 20,000 years in the future—are often classified as science fiction. In short, alternate history has semi-flexible boundaries and can include hybrid works that lie on the genre's margins.

Prior to the nineteenth century, alternate history did not really exist. Although scattered works have vied for inclusion in the genre, they remain marginal. The oldest contender is the fourteenth century French epic *Perceforest*. Yet while the tale imagined Alexander the Great traveling from India to the British Isles and installing two local brothers as kings in England and Scotland, it is best regarded a secret history, since it does not so much change the past as reveal its "hidden" origins.¹⁰³¹ The same can be said of the Valencian writer Joanot Martorell's late fifteenth-century chivalric novel *Tirant lo Blanch*, which despite depicting its title character saving Constantinople from the "the Grand Turk" and later being proclaimed "Caesar of the Greek Empire" does not set its action in a clear time frame (it could just as plausibly take place in the future as the past), and is thus hard to classify as a bona fide alternate history.¹⁰³² The British writer Samuel Gott's 1648 romance novel *Nova Solyma (New Jerusalem)* also depicts a religious fantasy—one in which "a sudden flash of divine light" leads the "Jewish race" to convert to Christianity and retake Jerusalem from the Muslims—but since the novel's temporal setting is only hazily defined (it takes place in the "fiftieth year" after the Jews' restoration to their land), the novel is best regarded as a future history.¹⁰³³ Finally, the French writer Alain Renais Lesage's 1732 novel *The Adventures of Sir Robert Chevalier, Called the Pirate Captain Beauchene (Les aventurs de Monsieur Robert Chevalier dit de Beauchene, capitaine de flibustiers)* featured a dual nesting doll and trading places counterfactual in which Native Americans "discover" Europe. But since the novel's narrative was mostly comprised of a non-fictional memoir written by a real historical figure (Chevalier) that was later embellished by the editor (Lesage), *The Adventures of Sir Robert Chevalier* is best seen as an "embryonic" rather than a fully-fledged, work of alternate history.¹⁰³⁴

Beginning in the nineteenth century, however, new cultural trends enabled alternate history to realize its potential as an independent literary genre. The

emergence of romanticism in the early nineteenth century fostered a growing fascination with history and conditioned Europeans to embrace works of culture that were rooted in the past.¹⁰³⁵ So did the ensuing movement of historicism, whose supporters believed that works of creative expression should be based upon historical precedents. Both movements profoundly influenced all branches of European culture, but they especially shaped the field that provided the main home for alternate history—literature. European literature experienced explosive growth during the nineteenth century, seeing the unprecedented publication of novels, short stories, and other works of fiction. Fueled by new methods of mass production and the emergence of a mass reading public, literature provided a critical medium for artists to create, and readers to explore, fictional worlds. Among the different genres of fiction that emerged in the nineteenth century, historical fiction was especially popular. Writers such as Sir Walter Scott in England, Victor Hugo in France, and James Fenimore Cooper in the United States, among countless others, penned tales that satisfied the desire of readers to lose themselves in bygone eras. Equally important was the later emergence of utopian fiction and science fiction, both of which allowed historical fiction to transcend its traditionally realistic orientation and explore more fantastic scenarios. As writers such as William Morris and Jules Verne began to speculate about alternate futures, it was not long before other writers began to speculate about alternate pasts.¹⁰³⁶

The Rise of Alternate History in France

National trends also promoted the rise of alternate history. Important works of alternate history were published in most major countries in Western Europe and North America between 1850 and 1945. But these texts did not appear at the same time or the same rate in all places. Some nations wondered “what if?” more often than others.

The country that gave birth to alternate history was France.¹⁰³⁷ This distinction was hardly coincidental. Because counterfactual thought is sparked by major historical turning points, it thrives in countries that stand at the center of epochal events. Between 1789 and 1815, France drove European events more than any other country. The upheaval caused by the French Revolution and the Napoleonic Wars stimulated French writers to engage in extensive literary reflection and historical speculation. The country’s longstanding literary tradition—dating back to the seventeenth-century plays of Molière—and its embrace of romanticism in the early 1800s also created a fertile environment for counterfactual fiction. Yet the most immediate factor for the emergence of

alternate history in France was the publication of Napoleon Bonaparte's memoirs in 1823 (see chapter 1 of this volume). By including countless counterfactual reflections, Napoleon's narrative provided a model for historical speculation that inspired the first writers of alternate history.

Between the 1830s and 1850s, a small but notable wave of longform alternate histories appeared with the publication of three important texts: Louis-Napoléon Geoffroy-Château's 1836 novel *Napoleon and the Conquest of the World, 1812–1832*, Joseph Méry's 1854 novel *History that Never Happened* (*Histoire de ce qui n'est pas arrivé*), and Charles Renouvier's 1857 novel *Uchronia: Utopia in History* (*Uchronie: l'Utopie dans l'histoire*). These texts shared a variety of notable traits. Temporally, they were published within a relatively short period of time. Substantively, they shared a focus on the legacy of Napoleon Bonaparte. Functionally, they reimagined the past to critique the present. Indeed, between the years 1836 and 1857, French writers held something of a counterfactual referendum on Napoleon's legacy.

Geoffroy-Château's novel presented a clear fantasy scenario of Napoleon Bonaparte achieving global hegemony (Figure 6.1).¹⁰³⁸ The tale's point of divergence is the Emperor's decision, after the burning of Moscow in 1812, not to return to France but to "march on!" to "the one capital of Russia" still standing in the country—St. Petersburg—and winter there with his troops before fighting anew in the spring.¹⁰³⁹ Napoleon's armies thereafter defeat Britain and go on to conquer the rest of the known world, "subduing the whole of Asia" along with the Americas.¹⁰⁴⁰ In the wake of his military victory, Napoleon launches a massive campaign of religious transformation, becoming a de facto messiah and converting all the world's Jews, Muslims, and Protestants to Catholicism. Having subjugated the entire globe, Napoleon proceeds to impose "unity" on its population. He makes French the world's universal language, standardizes laws, regularizes weights and measures, pursues scientific experiments (especially with electricity), develops new medicines, invents innovative forms of transportation (trains, steamships, and balloons), maps the entire earth (including the North Pole), pursues dramatic engineering projects (re-routing rivers and leveling mountains), and even controls the weather. By 1828, Napoleon attains near-divine status and asks to be referred to as "the almighty."¹⁰⁴¹

Scholars have long interpreted *Napoleon and the Conquest of the World* as a right-wing endorsement of Napoleonic absolutism, with some going so far as to call it "political pornography."¹⁰⁴² In fact, the novel explicitly endorsed Napoleon's use of brutal methods in pursuing world conquest. In a chapter describing the defeat of the Muslim world, for example, Geoffroy-Château breezily depicted French troops brutally destroying the Muslim world's main holy sites, putting Jerusalem's El-Aqsa Mosque "to the torch," and setting fire



FIGURE 6.1 Louis-Napoléon Geoffroy-Château's 1836 novel, *Napoleon and the Conquest of the World*, fantasized that Napoleon Bonaparte conquered Russia and later attained global hegemony. (Source: Alamy)

to the city of Medina, where “the conflagration ... last[s]... for a month.” In so doing, the French army deals a “deathblow to Islam,... the only force in the world capable of opposing ... Napoleon.”¹⁰⁴³ Written not long after French troops had used similar violence to conquer Algeria, such passages displayed Geoffroy-Château's imperialist sentiments.

In so doing, *Napoleon and the Conquest of the World* also expressed the author's discontent with the French present. Geoffroy-Château (1803–58) was an avowed Bonapartist, a man whose politics were partly shaped by his personal identity as an adoptive son of Napoleon (the legal status given the children of officers who died while in the general's service).¹⁰⁴⁴ At the time he wrote the novel, Geoffroy-Château was also an extremely frustrated man. Living in the

post-Napoleonic era of King Louis Philippe, who had taken power in the July Revolution of 1830 with middle class support, Geoffroy-Château never got to rise to prominence through his Napoleonic connections. His inability to transcend the limitations of his era explained his desire to undo its existence. As he wrote in the novel's original preface:

How many have sighed after interrupted dreams, begging heaven to finish them?...

What if Napoleon Bonaparte had not been [defeated]... but instead, conquered the world?... Would that not ... bring tears of joy ... to ... those who would wish to read such a story?¹⁰⁴⁵

Yet while Geoffroy-Château's preface criticized post-Napoleonic France, his novel also criticized Napoleon.¹⁰⁴⁶ In fantasizing about the emperor's conquest of the world in alternate history, Geoffroy-Château implicitly indicted his failure to do so in real history.¹⁰⁴⁷

In the final analysis, *Napoleon and the Conquest of the World* was most significant for its literary, not its political, dimensions. According to Catherine Gallagher, Geoffroy-Château did something pioneering by inventing a diegetic narrator and placing him inside the narrative as a means of lending verisimilitude to the novel's alternate history.¹⁰⁴⁸ Geoffroy-Château also introduced an early example of a nesting-doll counterfactual, having the narrator criticize the publication of a "fictional history" written by "an anonymous author" in Napoleon's own alternate world that portrays the emperor failing to conquer Russia and ending his life in disgrace.¹⁰⁴⁹ Thanks to these and other innovations, *Napoleon and the Conquest of the World* is justifiably viewed as the western world's first alternate history novel.

Notably enough, it was not alone. Just over a decade later, Joseph Méry's novella, *History that Never Happened*, offered a similar fantasy (Figure 6.2). Like Geoffroy-Château, Méry portrayed Napoleon triumphing in a battle that he lost in real history: the Battle of Acre (1799). In the text, the historical point of divergence arrives courtesy of a French officer, who bravely escapes Turkish imprisonment and relays information to French forces that Acre's famed citadel, together with its "accursed tower," is about to collapse thanks to consistent French bombardment. As a result, Napoleon decides to launch a final attack, which brings down the tower "like a chess-piece" and prevents French forces from having to retreat.¹⁰⁵⁰ Having acquired the "key to the Orient," Napoleon and 20,000 troops proceed to Jerusalem and, from there, push through Damascus and Mesopotamia, following Alexander the Great's path to India.¹⁰⁵¹ When Napoleon's troops finally arrive in the fabled city of



FIGURE 6.2 Joseph Méry's novella, *History that Never Happened*, fantasized that Napoleon conquered the world. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Mysore, their reputation as a “beloved” people of culture leads Indian troops to surrender without a fight.¹⁰⁵² In a triumph of French imperialism, Méry’s narrator reports: “all of the Bengal peninsula has been captured by France ... The peaceful army of the arts, the companion of conquering France, will ... make its triumphant entrance into all those dead cities, once so great in the arts ... [and] give [them]... back [their]... civilization.”¹⁰⁵³ As the tale winds down, Napoleon plans to invade Japan and foster “the renaissance of the primal world,” but before moving forward, he underscores the Battle of Acre’s pivotal significance, reminding readers that he understood all along that “the fate of the world [rests]... in that tower.”¹⁰⁵⁴

Like Geoffroy-Château, Méry (1798–1866) was a supporter of Napoleon’s legacy, a critic of King Louis Philippe’s regime, and a supporter of French

imperialism. A well-known writer during the Era of Restoration, Méry used the novella's preface to express his "sad[ness]... by the check at ... Acre" and resulting "loss of India," remarking that "one consoles one's self with dreams" and concluding that "the lies of one's nights often compensate us for the verities of our days."¹⁰⁵⁵ These sentiments make it likely that Méry wrote his tale during the reign of Louis Philippe and only published it after the latter's abdication in 1848. Of course, Méry had extra incentive to do so in 1854, for by then, Napoleon III had completed his violent *coup d'état* of December 2, 1851, and created a political climate conducive to Emperor-worship. What may have been inspired as a criticism of constitutional monarchy thus became an endorsement of imperial authority.

Conversely, Charles Renouvier's alternate history novel *Uchronia* (1857) attacked the rule of Napoleon III (Figure 6.3). Set in Ancient Rome, the novel's point of divergence is the agreement of Emperor Marcus Aurelius (r. 161–180 C. E.) and his General, Avidius Cassius, to pursue a course of internal political reform by returning the Empire to Republican rule. Instead of following his Stoicist philosophical inclinations, which incline him to accept the present in its current form, Marcus Aurelius heeds Cassius's admonition to return Rome to its tradition of civic mindedness and liberty. The two men proceed to purge Rome of Christianity, which they view as an authoritarian faith, and require all citizens to swear allegiance to the state. Those who refuse must leave the Empire for the east. By asserting the state's power over religion, the rehabilitated Roman Republic becomes a model of secular, liberal rule and thrives in the centuries that follow. Despite incursions from eastern barbarians, the Republic evolves into a stable, peaceful, and prosperous state. By the end of the novel, which is set during the reign of Charlemagne, the tradition of liberty has become cemented.¹⁰⁵⁶

In crafting his narrative, Renouvier created a counterfactual fantasy that indicted the authoritarian government of Napoleon III. A radical supporter of the 1848 Revolution and a fierce opponent of the Catholic church, Renouvier was furious when French troops were sent to Rome to crush the anti-Papal revolution that erupted in the city.¹⁰⁵⁷ Small wonder that his novel featured a secular Europe, where Christianity's adverse impact on European political life has been negated. Like the historian, Edgar Quinet, Renouvier believed history would have been much better without the Catholic Church. *Uchronia's* radical political stance was echoed by its innovative literary structure. Like Geoffroy-Château, Renouvier included a diegetic narrator in the form of a nameless editor, who in the novel's preface explains that the narrative of *Uchronia* was originally written by an early seventeenth-century Dominican monk in the Netherlands, who was condemned by the Inquisition for his



FIGURE 6.3 Charles Renouvier's influential alternate history novel, *Uchronia* (1857) allegorically attacked the rule of Emperor Napoleon III. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

heretical views and who barely succeeded in smuggling out his text with the aid of a confidant. According to the editor, the monk hoped that life would improve in the future, because the “centuries ... follow[ing] the extinction of Christian faith” will be ones in which “thought will soar above time.”¹⁰⁵⁸

Uchronia also had a philosophical agenda. Although Renouvier is best known today for his fiction, he was also a renowned philosopher who used his novel to critique deterministic thinking. In fact, *Uchronia* was originally published in 1857 in serial form in a French philosophy journal.¹⁰⁵⁹ At that point in time, deterministic thought was still very much in vogue in Europe, whether in its Hegelian, Marxist, or Christian forms. Renouvier, however, opposed the idea that history had to unfold in a certain direction. He was especially skeptical about August Comte's faith in progress, believing it forestalled the possibility of ethical critique.¹⁰⁶⁰ Renouvier expressed this belief through the voice of

his novel's fictional editor. In explaining why the seventeenth-century monk's "utopia of past times" had remained unknown until the present, the editor noted that the utopia was unsuited to earlier eras, especially the eighteenth century, when "speculation ...[was] weak and people "appli[ed]... reason to all things."¹⁰⁶¹ The editor went on to complain that present-day philosophy also "tended to affirm universal necessity" and led historians to mistakenly provide "justification" for "current facts" by seeing those facts as "inscribed in the past."¹⁰⁶² The editor further attacked historians for having theodical tendencies, accusing them of viewing "everything evil as good" and regarding "crime [as having]... indispensable utility."¹⁰⁶³ To counteract these trends, the editor proposed that the seventeenth-century *Uchronia* "might not be a complete anachronism," because learning how to imagine alternate pasts could help people appreciate the importance of "human freedom" in historical change.¹⁰⁶⁴ In having his fictional editor make these claims, Renouvier suggested that embracing contingency would foster an appreciation of free will and moral judgment. By showing how things could have been different, people could be inspired to critique the status quo.

When it first appeared in 1857, Renouvier's narrative failed to resonate with readers, but two decades later, in 1876, new developments led to *Uchronia*'s re-publication as a stand-alone novel. The rise of a new intellectual mood that doubted determinism and was curious about contingency boosted public interest in Renouvier's philosophical agenda. Political developments also helped the novel's popularity. France's defeat by German forces in the Franco-Prussian War, together with the upheaval of the Paris Commune and the creation of the Third Republic in 1870–71, further eroded whatever optimism remained in French society from the reign of Napoleon III.¹⁰⁶⁵ This new climate of skepticism brought new attention to *Uchronia*. Reviews of the novel were especially numerous in France, with commentators hailing it as an "ingenious," "learned," and "daring" attempt "to remake history by hypothesis."¹⁰⁶⁶ British readers were also complimentary, hailing it as "original" and "profound," with one reviewer perceptively noting that, while counterfactuals had previously been advanced by Gibbon and Disraeli, Renouvier was the "first writer who has seriously worked out this form of imagination."¹⁰⁶⁷ German reviewers also took note of the book, though they were less sure what to make of it, calling *Uchronia* "a strange book" and likening it to "a witty joke."¹⁰⁶⁸ These slight differences notwithstanding, many reviews agreed that *Uchronia* represented a "rejection of historical ... determinism" and an endorsement of "free will."¹⁰⁶⁹ This line of argumentation underscored the book's newfound relevance and confirmed France's status as the country most engaged with alternate history.

Anglo-American Alternate Histories: 1850–1914

Yet, in the years between the republication of *Uchronia* and the First World War, Anglo-American writers gradually replaced French writers as the most productive creators of alternate history. Whether producing novels, short stories, or edited anthologies, British and American writers began to lend greater coherence to alternate history as an independent literary genre.

This achievement was partly fostered by longstanding British and American literary trends. Since the works of Chaucer and Shakespeare, Britain had been home to a robust literary tradition that was deeply steeped in history. By the nineteenth century, that tradition helped writers, such as Sir Walter Scott, Charles Dickens, and William Makepeace Thackeray, develop the modern genre of historical fiction.¹⁰⁷⁰ This precondition for the rise of alternate history was bolstered by the role of British writers in producing secret histories. As was seen in such novels as Sophia Lee's *The Recess* (1785) and Benjamin Disraeli's novel *The Wondrous Tale of Alroy* (1833), secret histories paved the way for alternate histories by giving writers new imaginative leeway in playing with the facticity of the past.¹⁰⁷¹ So did the subsequent emergence of utopian fiction and science fiction. Dating back to the early modern texts of Thomas More and Francis Bacon, both genres promoted the rise of "future histories," which later became a nineteenth and twentieth-century British specialty, thanks to the works of H. G. Wells, Aldous Huxley, and George Orwell. By way of comparison, American literature had a shorter and less distinguished history, but it was also shaped by many of the same nineteenth-century trends that fostered literary counterfactuals in Britain. The romantic works of Ralph Waldo Emerson and Walt Whitman, the historical fiction of Mark Twain and James Fenimore Cooper, the utopian fiction of Edward Bellamy and Charlotte Perkins Gilman, and the science fiction of Edward Page Mitchell all prepared American writers to embrace alternate history like their British counterparts.

The Literary Vogue for "Might-Have-Beens"

The clearest sign that British and American writers were primed to explore alternate history was the growing presence of counterfactual themes in nineteenth-century Anglo-American poetry and literature. At the same time that historians and journalists were explicitly employing the phrase "might-have-beens" in historical monographs and journalistic essays (see chapter 2 of this volume), poets and writers were doing the same in lyric verse, novels, and short stories.

"Might-have-beens" were everywhere in mid to late nineteenth-century Anglo-American poetry.¹⁰⁷² Alfred Lord Tennyson wrote his famous poem, "In Memoriam A. H. H." (1850), to honor his friend and fellow poet Arthur Henry Hallam, who died at the young age of twenty-two, referring to Hallam's unrealized possibilities with the lines, "The world which credits what is done, Is cold to all that might have been."¹⁰⁷³ Taking a slightly different approach was the American poet John Greenleaf Whittier, whose depiction of an unrealized romance between a respected judge and a beautiful maid in his poem "Maud Muller" (1856) received enormous attention for its evocative (and subsequently much-quoted) declaration: "For of all sad words of tongue or pen, The saddest are these: 'It might have been!'" (Figure 6.4).¹⁰⁷⁴ Unrealized possibilities also informed the English poet Dante Gabriel Rossetti's sonnet "The House of Life" (1881), which included the lines: "Look in my face: my name is 'Might-have-been,'" and the English poet W. E. Henley's poem "To James McNeill Whistler" (1898), which featured the lines, "O Death! O Change! O Time! Of these poor Might-Have-Beens!"¹⁰⁷⁵ Still other poets incorporated the phrase into the titles of their poems, such as British writer Mary Wyatt Candler's "Might-Have-Beens and Yet-May-Be's" (1877) and the English writer Ellice Hopkins' "The World of Might Have Beens" (1883).¹⁰⁷⁶

"Might-have-beens" were also explored in works of Anglo-American literature. In Charles Dickens's famous novel *David Copperfield* (1850), the title character entertains regrets about having married his immature wife, Dora, and reflects to himself "sometimes, the speculation came into my thoughts, What might have happened ... if Dora and I had never known each other?" adding "it would have been better for me if my wife could have ... shared the many thoughts in which I had no partner; and that this might have been; I knew."¹⁰⁷⁷ Similarly, in Thomas Hardy's novel *A Pair of Blue Eyes* (1873), the narrative's female protagonist, Elfride Swancourt, chats with one of her love interests, Henry Knight, about whether he would still fancy her if she had ever been kissed, to which he replies, "let us confine our attention to ourselves, not go thinking of might have beens."¹⁰⁷⁸ Eliza Tabor Stevenson's novel *St. Olave's* (1863) portrays one its protagonists, Janet Bruce, being aware that "the great might have beens ... wear ... robes of mystery all through life," but simultaneously depicts her as displaying "wisdom" for "think[ing] of her '*might have beens*'" only "rarely."¹⁰⁷⁹ Finally, in the English writer James Payn's novel *Not Wooed, But Won* (1871), the protagonist Mabel Denham regrets marrying a wealthy man, Mr. Winthorp, whom she does not love, and having to remember "not to vex herself with idle might-have-beens" involving the man she truly loved, Richard Thornton.¹⁰⁸⁰

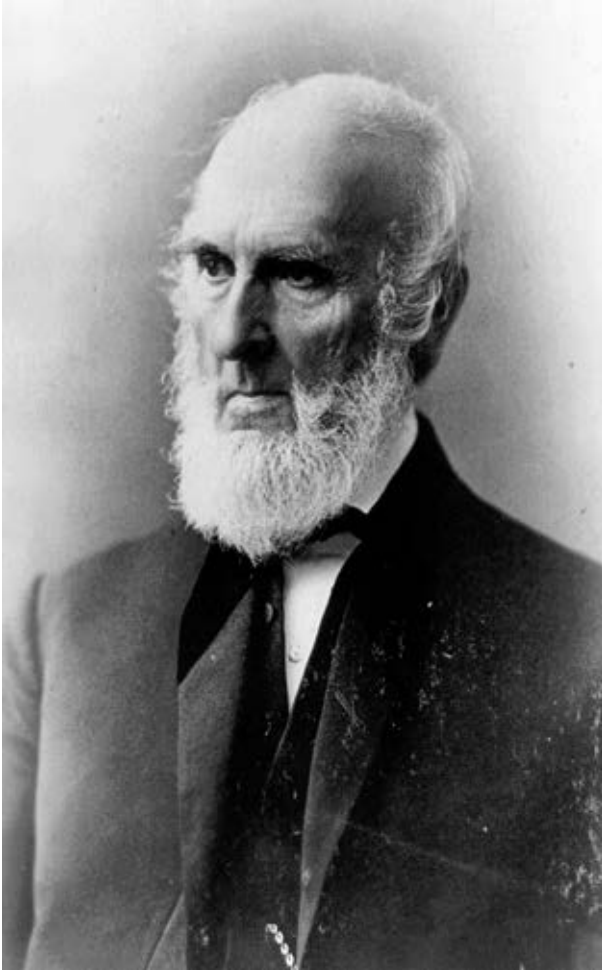


FIGURE 6.4 In his poem, “Maud Muller” (1856), the American poet, John Greenleaf Whittier, wrote the evocative (and subsequently much-quoted) declaration: “For of all sad words of tongue or pen, the saddest are these: ‘It might have been!’” (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

The ubiquity of “might-have-beens” in poetry and literature reflected deeper literary and emotional patterns in nineteenth-century Anglo-American life. They especially displayed the lasting influence of the sentimental, Romantic, and Victorian literary traditions.¹⁰⁸¹ Long committed to exploring the broad spectrum of human emotions, these traditions—epitomized by the wistful,

nostalgic verse of the New England “Fireside Poets” surrounding Whittier—were especially inclined to probe feelings of regret for missed opportunities.¹⁰⁸² Whether exploring premature deaths, unconsummated loves, or other unachieved goals, “might-have-beens” were routinely employed in poetry and literature to dramatize the ups and downs of interpersonal relationships.¹⁰⁸³ The prominent use of counterfactuals especially by female writers reflected the latent frustration felt by nineteenth-century women about confining social convention—whether marriage expectations or job restrictions—that kept them from living emotionally fulfilling lives.¹⁰⁸⁴

Certain commentators at the time confirmed the emotional appeal of poetic and literary counterfactuals. Writing in 1862, the English novelist Joseph Hatton described the wistfulness felt by people when they erred “in selecting a particular route when several other roads lay open,” exclaiming “Oh, these ifs and might have beens!”¹⁰⁸⁵ Around a decade later in 1871, the American writer Cornelia Strykor, writing under the pseudonym Ailenroc, discussed the topic of “mismatching” in *David Copperfield* and explained the reason why so many women often cried out, “oh! it might have been,” was due to the many husbands who “falter ... in [their]... allegiance.”¹⁰⁸⁶ At the turn of the century, Mark Twain reflected on the difficulties of aging while looking back on “the dreams of ... youth” and “the ruins of these might-have-beens,” proclaiming that sympathy should be given to the “pain” caused by “the dreamer’s valuation of ... thing[s] lost.”¹⁰⁸⁷ Finally, a critic writing in *The Glasgow Herald* explained why “poetry ... is prolific in might-have-beens” by noting that “our sweetest songs are those that tell of saddest thought.”¹⁰⁸⁸

Anglo-American Alternate Histories

The willingness of poets and novelists to explore “might-have-beens” helps explain why other writers found their way to alternate history. In the last three decades of the long nineteenth century, a total of nine counterfactual texts appeared in Britain and the U.S.—three in the former and six in the latter.¹⁰⁸⁹ The British texts included George Tomkyns Chesney’s novella *The Battle of Dorking: Reminiscences of a Volunteer* (1871), Edmund Lawrence’s novel *It May Happen Yet: A Tale of Bonaparte’s Invasion of England* (1899), and G. M. Trevelyan’s essay “If Napoleon Had Won the Battle of Waterloo” (1907). The American narratives included Edward Everett Hale’s short story “Hands Off” (1881), Edward Page Mitchell’s short story “The Clock that Ran Backward” (1881), Castello Holford’s novel *Aristopia: A Romance History of the New World* (1895), Frank P. Williams’ novel *Hallie Marshall: A True Daughter of the South*



FIGURE 6.5 G. M. Trevelyan's essay, "If Napoleon Had Won the Battle of Waterloo" (1907) won a contest sponsored by the *Westminster Gazette* for the best "probable history." (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

(1902), Charles Felton Pidgin's novel *The Climax, Or, What Might Have Been* (1902), and Joseph Edgar Chamberlin's anthology of analytical essays *The Ifs of History* (1907).

Yet while the number of texts suggests that alternate history was becoming an independent literary genre, it still lacked a clear sense of identity. In truth, some of the texts lay on the genre's margins. Chesney's *The Battle of Dorking*, which depicted Britain being attacked at an unspecified point in history by an unnamed European nation (a thinly-veiled Germany), was just as much a future history as an alternate history.¹⁰⁹⁰ Lawrence's *It May Happen Yet*, which detailed a failed Napoleonic invasion of England in 1805, was actually a secret history that left the course of history essentially unaltered.¹⁰⁹¹ And the plot of Williams' *Hallie Marshall*, which imagined the South winning the Civil War, is

merely dreamed by the novel's slumbering protagonist. The practitioners of alternate history, furthermore, did not recognize that they were working in an emerging genre.¹⁰⁹² In describing how his novel *Aristopia* depicted an alternative founding of the United States in the seventeenth century, Holford contrasted his text with many utopian novels then in circulation, writing that while "books giving us a history of the future ... are much in vogue,... books giving a history of the past as it might have been ... I know not one."¹⁰⁹³ On the other hand, the wave of texts before 1914 showed that the genre of alternate history was on the upswing. The fact that Trevelyan's essay was written in response to a contest sponsored by the *Westminster Gazette* in the spring of 1907 promising "a prize of fifty pounds" for the best essay describing "the situation that would have been brought about IF NAPOLEON HAD WON THE BATTLE OF WATERLOO" revealed a growing awareness of the genre (Figure 6.5).¹⁰⁹⁴

British Narratives

British narratives were few in number but their clustering in the years 1871–1907 reflected contemporary events. Throughout most of the nineteenth century, Britain was the world's leading imperial power, a status that found historiographical validation in the upbeat Whig interpretation of history. By the last third of the century, however, the country's self-confidence was challenged by new uncertainties. Germany's defeat of France in the Franco-Prussian War of 1870, the intensification of European competition for colonies in Africa, and growing domestic criticism of imperialism posed new challenges for Britain's standing on the world stage. If scholars are correct that that these geopolitical concerns stimulated the emergence of science fiction in the late nineteenth century, it stands to reason they also sparked alternate histories.¹⁰⁹⁵

Notably enough, the era's three alternate histories all featured nightmare scenarios. Chesney's *The Battle of Dorking* built upon an existing tradition of "invasion-scare narratives" by depicting Britain being invaded by Germanic attackers and falling from the ranks of the great powers.¹⁰⁹⁶ Lawrence's *It May Happen Yet* portrayed the Napoleonic invasion of 1805 causing widespread death and destruction in Britain before British troops force the French to withdraw back across the English Channel. Trevelyan's essay depicted Napoleon's victory at the Battle of Waterloo producing a reactionary shift in British politics under the leadership of the conservative Tory, Viscount Castlereagh, and the suppression of liberal efforts at domestic political reform.

In depicting nightmarish pasts, the three tales expressed concerns about the present. On the one hand, by focusing on how British history almost turned out worse, the texts expressed gratitude that events transpired as they did. Yet

the texts also expressed the desire not to take the present for granted. The opening lament of Chesney's narrator that England had been "willfully blind" to the era's growing threats and had naively believed the country's "prosperity [was]... sent us by Providence" reflected the author's desire to challenge the complacency bred by Whiggish thought.¹⁰⁹⁷ The fact that Chesney was a British Army Captain who lobbied the government to modernize the country's antiquated military helps explain his novella's political agenda, which was perfectly embodied in its narrator's counterfactual conclusion that "a little ... foresight might have averted the disaster."¹⁰⁹⁸ Lawrence's *It May Happen Yet* also promoted a presentist message of military readiness, interjecting midway through the novel that the failure to prevent the Napoleonic invasion of 1805 underscored the need to shore up British rule in Egypt (which had become an important possession in 1882) and build new fortifications around London to defend it against a possible future attack.¹⁰⁹⁹ Geopolitical concerns, finally, also may have shaped Trevelyan's tale. As a fervent Liberal and opponent of imperialism, he may have sought to critique Britain's role in the Boer War (1899–1902) and its adverse effect on the country's political order.¹¹⁰⁰

American Narratives

American alternate histories were more varied in focus but also expressed shared concerns, especially a commitment to social reform. In the years leading up to the turn of the century, the United States was being convulsed by the economic, social, and political effects of the second industrial revolution, witnessing the rise of income inequality, labor unrest, and progressive political activism. In response, there emerged a wave of religiously-inspired and secular-oriented reform movements that addressed the issues of housing, labor, education, suffrage, and temperance in the effort to achieve progressive change. Just as these movements shaped the genres of American utopian literature and science fiction, they also encouraged the appearance of alternate histories.¹¹⁰¹

The first text to appear in the United States was Edward Everett Hale's short story "Hands Off" (Figure 6.6).¹¹⁰² Originally published in *Harper's Magazine* in 1881, the story features an unnamed, otherworldly narrator who describes being tempted to alter the course of human history by rescuing the biblical figure of Joseph from being sold into Egyptian slavery. Early in the tale, however, God himself interrupts the narrator and tells him to keep his "hands off" of history by showing him how his decision would adversely affect it. Using a parallel world inhabited by simulacra of the Bible's "real" historical figures, God shows the narrator how his rescue of Joseph makes history worse. Because Joseph is

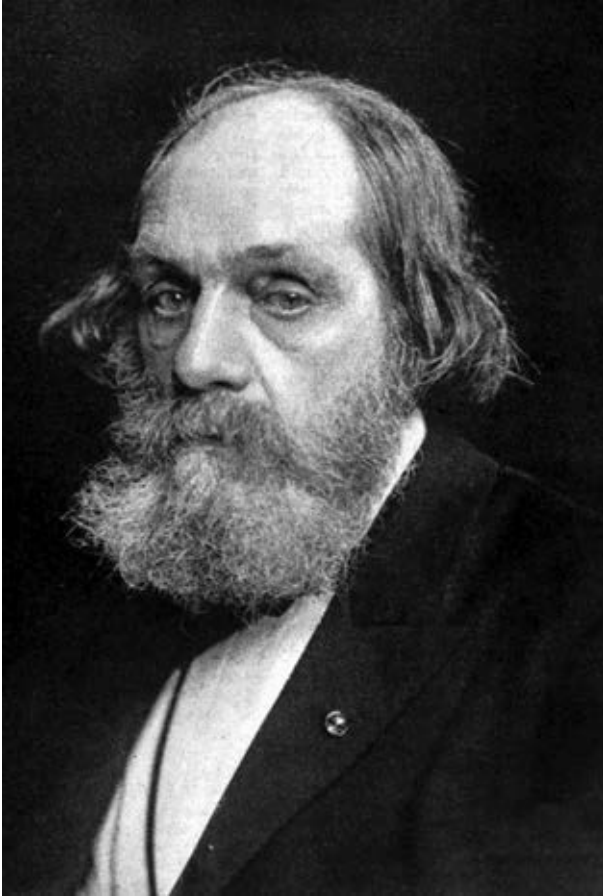


FIGURE 6.6 Edward Everett Hale's short story, "Hands Off" (1881), imagined the nightmarish consequences of Joseph not being sold by his brothers into Egyptian slavery. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

never sold into slavery in Egypt, he cannot prevent the arrival of famine there and his family thus never leaves Canaan. As a result, Joseph never becomes Pharaoh's adviser, the Jews never fall into slavery, the Exodus never takes place, and there is no Kingdom of Israel. Instead, Canaan conquers Egypt and Greece, the worship of Moloch sweeps across the planet, and civilization comes to an end in a cataclysm of "lust, brutality, cruelty ... agony, [and]... horror."¹⁰³

In presenting this nightmare scenario, Hale had a mixture of religious and personal motives. A well-known Boston-based writer and Unitarian minister, Hale (1822–1909) partly used his narrative to advance a theodical philosophy of history typical of American Protestantism. This was made clear in the story's

final paragraphs, where the narrator, horrified by the consequences of his actions, is reassured by God that Joseph was divinely destined to go to Egypt to change the world for the better. When the narrator declares in the story's last line, "From what I call evil, he [i.e. God] educes good," the narrator reveals that divine providence makes an ostensible evil—Joseph's enslavement—bring forth a greater good: the creation of Israel and the coming of Christianity.¹¹⁰⁴ Hale's story also had personal significance to him. A liberal-minded social reformer who supported abolitionism, pacifism, and "Christian Reform," Hale wrote "Hands Off" as he was undergoing a mid-life crisis in which he revisited "the indecisions of his youth ... and the choices of the past," especially regarding alternate career possibilities.¹¹⁰⁵ At a time when Hale had difficulty juggling his multiple careers as a minister, writer, and social reformer, his story's conclusion that everything works out for the best may have provided him with much-needed emotional consolation.

That same year, Edward Page Mitchell published a short story, entitled "The Clock that Ran Backward" (Figure 6.7).¹¹⁰⁶ Considered the first backward time travel story, the tale was also the first to have counterfactual implications. Set in the present-day United States, it features a young, unnamed protagonist who inherits an old—and, as he eventually realizes, magical—grandfather clock from his recently deceased great-aunt. Because her will provides money for him and his cousin, Harry, to study abroad, the two young men travel to the University of Leiden in the Netherlands, bringing the clock with them. Once he arrives, the protagonist proceeds to study metaphysics with an eccentric Hegelian professor of "speculative philosophy" by the name of Van Stopp.¹¹⁰⁷ One day, while the two are walking through Leiden, the Professor tells the protagonist about how, during the Dutch rebellion against Spain in 1574, Catholic forces besieged the Protestant city but failed to conquer it thanks to a lone defender who prevented its walls from being breached. Had the city fallen, the professor speculates, Spanish "tyranny ... would have been reestablished. The birth of religious liberty and self-government by the people would have been postponed ... [And] there [might not]... have been a republic of the United States of America."¹¹⁰⁸

Some months later, the professor visits the protagonist at his apartment, where he sees his clock and, after a long conversation, suddenly winds the clock's hands backwards. Without warning, the protagonist and his cousin Harry are transported back in time to the siege of Leiden, where they encounter a scene of "conflagration" and soon run into Professor Van Stopp, who has heroically spent the night singlehandedly defending the breached walls from the invader, thereby "sav[ing]... Holland."¹¹⁰⁹ Three days later, the protagonist accountably finds himself back in the present, sitting in the professor's class

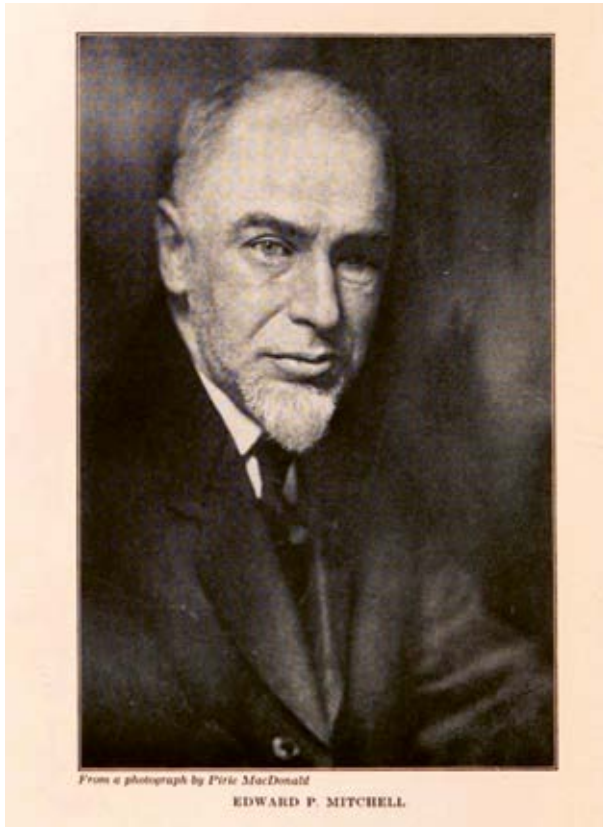


FIGURE 6.7 Edward Page Mitchell's short story, "The Clock that Ran Backward" (1881), was one of the first to combine alternate history with time travel.

and hearing him quizzically declare: "We hear much ... of the influence of the sixteenth century upon the nineteenth. No philosopher, as far as I am aware, has studied the influence of the nineteenth century upon the sixteenth."¹¹⁰ With this unsettling reversal of cause and effect, the story ends with the protagonist sitting in his apartment with "the silent clock."¹¹¹

In crafting his tale, Mitchell had a mixture of motives. Although best known during his lifetime for being the editor-in-chief of a major daily newspaper, *The New York Sun*, Mitchell was also a pioneering writer in the genres of science fiction and fantasy.¹¹² His embrace of the human imagination partly reflected the late nineteenth-century's rebellion against determinism. When the protagonist fails to answer Professor Van Stopp's question why time "should not ... retrace its course" and reverse the path of "progress," the latter tells the former, "Your

intelligence has no wings. You follow in the trail of [Auguste] Comte [sic] and his slimy brood of creepers and crawlers.”¹¹¹³ Mitchell’s close friendship with Edward Everett Hale also suggests that “The Clock that Ran Backward” may have been driven by religious motives.¹¹¹⁴ Even though it differed from Hale’s by valorizing, rather than discouraging, human intervention in history, the story endorsed a Protestant view of historical destiny. After all, it is thanks to Mitchell’s Protestant hero, Professor van Stopp, that the Protestant Dutch repel the rapacious Catholic Habsburgs and ensure that the United States is established on a Protestant foundation.

A less religious agenda influenced Castello Holford’s novel *Aristopia* (1895) (Figure 6.8).¹¹¹⁵ Set in the seventeenth century, the novel presented a fantasy in which an early English settler in the Jamestown colony by the name of Ralph Morton discovers a massive reserve of gold in the Virginia wilds and uses it to set history on a different course. After securing several large nuggets early in the novel, he sails back to England and parlays his profits into financing subsequent trips to Virginia, where he buys land and resolves to found a “new commonwealth better than the world had ever seen before.”¹¹¹⁶ In order to create his utopian state far from English supervision, Morton settles the land west of the Appalachian mountains and eventually establishes six states in the Midwest, all of which are distinct from the British-ruled American colonies on the East Coast. The states, which include “Alleghany,” “Columbia,” and “Elenwah,” are linked to the Atlantic Ocean thanks to a port city named “Mortonia,” near the Potomac River. In this expansive region, Morton welcomes oppressed immigrants (though he prioritizes Europeans), bans slavery (though he excludes non-whites), and embraces a stable currency resting on the gold standard. The novel culminates when Aristopian forces join the colonial rebellion at Lexington in 1775, declare their independence from England, and help defeat the British colonial occupiers. In short order, the Aristopians join the Atlantic colonies and Canada to form a pan-American state that stretches to the Rio Grande, thereby fulfilling the dream of creating “a government of the people, by the people, and for the people.”¹¹¹⁷

Aristopia reflected Holford’s discontent with Gilded Age inequality in the United States. A Wisconsin-born writer and newspaper owner, Holford explained in the text’s introduction that he set his fantasy of a better America in an alternate past to condemn “violent contrasts of wealth ... and poverty” in his own era.¹¹¹⁸ Notably enough, Holford recognized that his fantasy was part of an emerging, if still unnamed, literary genre based on historical speculation. Indeed, he explicitly rejected John Greenleaf Whittier’s claim in his poem, “Maud Muller,” that among the “saddest” words in the English language were “might have been.” Instead, he insisted that “it is a solace ... in the misery



FIGURE 6.8 Castello Holford's novel, *Aristopia* (1895), reflected discontent with Gilded Age inequality in the United States. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

that is, to contemplate the happiness that might have been." As he explained, "studying the opportunities we have lost may teach us to grasp the opportunities which are to come."¹¹¹⁹

Like Holford's *Aristopia*, Frank Purdy Williams' novel, *Hallie Marshall*, also used fantasy to advance social critique (Figure 6.9).¹¹²⁰ Set in New England, the novel details the unlikely adventure of a successful mill owner named Ralph, who falls asleep one night and awakens to find himself in a world where the South has won the Civil War and preserved the institution of slavery. As he struggles to understand life in the victorious Confederacy, he is aided by a beautiful Southern belle named Hallie Marshall, who uses her feminine wiles to show Ralph that all is good in the "Southland." In contrast to the "bleak inhospitable North," as Hallie calls it, the South's "lavish earth and ... generous sun ... make man's labor light."¹¹²¹ When a disoriented Ralph objects that

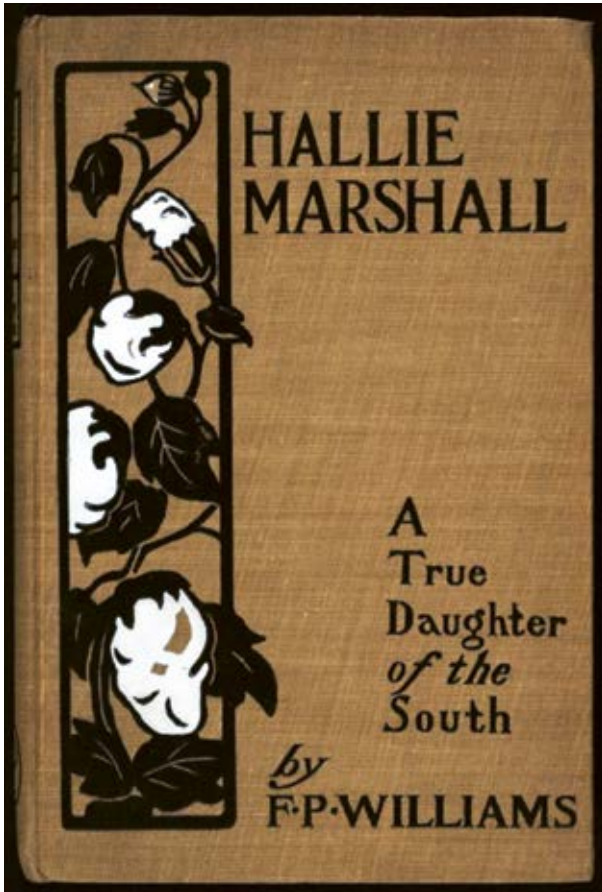


FIGURE 6.9 Frank Purdy Williams' novel, *Hallie Marshal* (1905), romanticized the South's system of chattel slavery to attack the wage slavery of the industrial north. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

the Southland relies on slavery, Hallie's father, "the Colonel," points out that Southern slavery is a benevolent, paternalistic institution in which "the rights of the negroes are protected."¹¹²² By way of comparison, the Colonel explains that Northern laborers are "stripped of the means of independence" and often "starve" if they lose their job.¹¹²³ As it unfolds, the novel's main point becomes obvious when the Colonel remarks that "there are thousands in your northern cities who would be glad ... to exchange places with our slaves in the South."¹¹²⁴ Ralph struggles for the remainder of the story's to process the Colonel's words, but before he can do so, he is awakened from his slumber by his wife and cannot determine whether his whole experience "was ... a dream" or "actual."¹¹²⁵

At first glance, *Hallie Marshall* appears to be a straightforward apology for slavery.¹¹²⁶ Yet, as Renee de Groot has argued, Williams did not write his novel to defend southern slavery but to condemn northern industry.¹¹²⁷ Williams was a social reformer and a supporter of the economic philosophy known as “Georgism,” a movement founded by the American economist Henry George, who responded to the growing inequality in late nineteenth-century America by seeking a third way between capitalism and socialism through reforms including public land ownership and a “Single Tax.” Williams made his Georgist views clear by depicting Ralph facing down a rebellion from his strike-prone workers and dreading the prospect of Socialism, while admiring the South’s agrarian prosperity.¹¹²⁸ From a present-day perspective, *Hallie Marshall*’s soft stance on slavery distracts from its larger agenda. But Williams’ portrayal of a prosperous South, where slaves are “well fed” and guaranteed a basic subsistence, expressed his polemical (if undeniably relativizing) desire to condemn Northern wage slavery by making it appear worse than Southern chattel slavery.

The final novel of the era, Charles Felton Pidgin’s *The Climax, Or, What Might Have Been*, also expressed a fantasy scenario—the possibility that Aaron Burr might have led the United States to superpower status earlier in history (Figure 6.10).¹¹²⁹ Instead of gaining permanent notoriety for killing Alexander Hamilton in a duel, Burr is instead elected Governor of New York in 1804, after which he becomes a U.S. Army General and, after 1808, a three-term President of the United States. In these different roles, Burr conquers wide parts of Central America, the Caribbean, and Canada and turns America into an imperial power long before it becomes one in real history. Burr further enhances the United States’s status by building the Panama Canal, which facilitates American trade, and sponsoring a massive program of “great public works.”¹¹³⁰ For good measure, he also solves the vexing “moral question” of slavery through abolition and the planned resettlement of slaves in Cuba and Jamaica.¹¹³¹ In short, Pidgin’s Burr resembled Geoffroy-Château’s Napoleon Bonaparte, a national hero of unprecedented achievements.

Pidgin’s motives were mostly literary and only partly political. A longtime Massachusetts state government clerk, Pidgin was also a bestselling writer who made a career popularizing Burr, writing three novels about him.¹¹³² Notably enough, in *The Climax*’s preface, he described the novel as a fantasy and, like Holford, rejected John Greenleaf Whittier’s famous line about the saddest words being “might have been,” declaring that many readers would wish that the words were “true” about Burr.¹¹³³ Pidgin’s love of Burr has unclear origins, but by depicting him improving American history, he expressed his discontent with American life in 1900. Indeed, Pidgin’s support for social reform

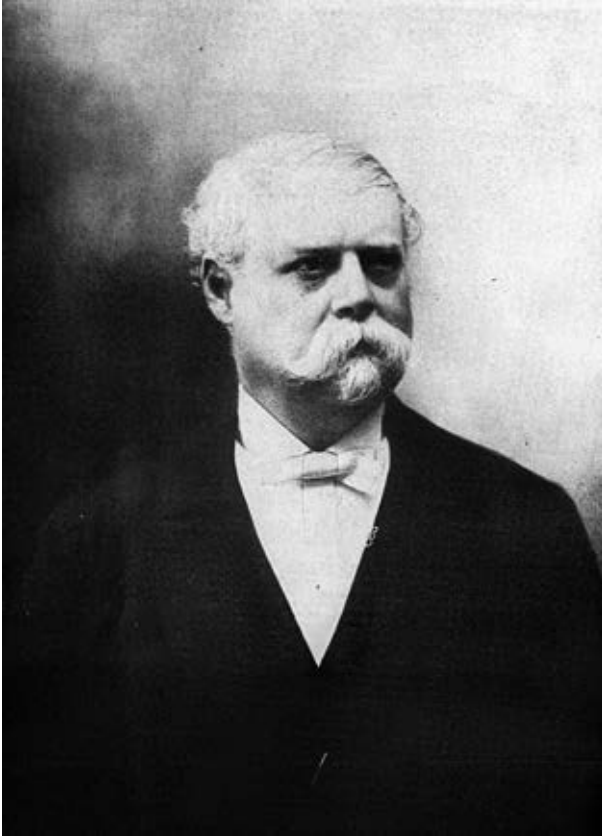


FIGURE 6.10 Charles Felton Pidgin's novel, *The Climax, Or, What Might Have Been* (1902), fantasized that Aaron Burr might have led the United States to superpower status earlier in history. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

efforts—especially the campaign against alcohol abuse—suggests that he had presentist motives for reimagining the past.¹¹³⁴

By contrast, Joseph Edgar Chamberlin's collection of essays *The Ifs of History* (1907) offered a more triumphalistic depiction of American history.¹¹³⁵ Composed of twenty-one chapters, the volume covered a range of topics involving European and American history from antiquity up through the early twentieth century. Yet while they were diverse in orientation, the essays were linked by an upbeat message. Of the volume's twenty-one narratives, sixteen were nightmare scenarios, all of which showed how American history might have turned out worse than it did in reality. Chapter 2, for example, speculated

that if the armies of Charles Martel had not beaten back the Muslim threat, “oriental contemplativeness” would have taken root in western thought and “the mellifluous [chant]..., ‘There is no god but God,’ would echo now where the shouts ...[of] Wall Street speculators reverberate.”¹¹³⁶ Similarly, chapter 4 speculated that if Christopher Columbus had heeded, rather than ignored, the advice of his navigator, Martin Alonzo Pinzón, the explorer would have landed on the North American mainland and enabled Spain to turn what later became the U.S. into “the heritage of another race.”¹¹³⁷ Other chapters speculated that “If the Boy George Washington Had Become a British Midshipman,” “If Alexander Hamilton Had Not Written About the Hurricane,” and “If Gilbert Livingston Had Not Voted New York into the Union,” the United States never would have been created.

In filling his volume with these and other nightmare scenarios, Chamberlin expressed his contentment with turn-of-the-century American life. A well-regarded writer and newspaper editor, Chamberlin was known for writing light-hearted essays for a popular audience. *The Ifs of History* adhered to this literary profile, crafting patriotic tales for readers in a period of American expansion. At the same time, Chamberlin sought to advance a serious intellectual agenda, noting in the volume’s introduction that his essays sought to resolve the longstanding tension between determinism and contingency. “Whether or not we believe that events are consciously ordered before their occurrence,” he wrote, “we are compelled to admit the importance of Contingency in human affairs.”¹¹³⁸ Chamberlin leveled this charge at theological as well as secular forms of determinism, noting that their supporters—whether “the believer in special providences” or “the evolutionists”—had to concede the importance of “trivial circumstances” in shaping events.¹¹³⁹ In doing so, Chamberlin echoed the position of Isaac Disraeli, who said the same thing nearly a century earlier.

The response to British and American alternate histories was mixed. Most reviewers saw the texts as unusual works of literature. *The Ifs of History*, for example, was described as “thoroughly unique,” while *Aristopia* was called “perfectly original.”¹¹⁴⁰ At the same time, reviewers disagreed about how to classify the texts. *The Climax* was described as a “pseudo-historical novel,” an exercise in “remade time,” and a “burlesque” that “distort[ed]... well-known historical facts.”¹¹⁴¹ *The Battle of Dorking* was called an “imaginary history,” a work of “prospective imagination,” and a “jeu d’esprit.”¹¹⁴² Finally, *It May Happen Yet* was described as “an artificial fancy” that explored “history ... not ... in the far off ... future”—as was true of the era’s utopian novels—“but [in]... a past as it might have been.”¹¹⁴³

Despite their puzzlement, reviewers welcomed the new alternate histories. *The Battle of Dorking* was a huge commercial success, selling nearly 100,000

copies after its publication as a stand-alone novella, and generated a national debate about Britain's war readiness.¹¹⁴⁴ *It May Happen Yet* had a smaller readership but was described as "happily conceived" and praised for its literary "workmanship."¹¹⁴⁵ Trevelyan's essay won first prize in the *Westminster Gazette's* essay contest and was later included in his well-regarded anthology, *Clio, A Muse, and Other Essays* (1913).¹¹⁴⁶ Other works of alternate history were praised for their social reform agendas. *Hallie Marshall* was commended for its "strong presentation of ... labor troubles."¹¹⁴⁷ *Aristopia* was hailed for exposing "the hideous corrupting farce of democracy ... in this country."¹¹⁴⁸ And *The Ifs of History* was complemented for "making history come alive."¹¹⁴⁹

Other commentators, however, strongly criticized the narratives. One critic called *Hallie Marshall* a "queer tale," whose "purpose" was "hard to understand."¹¹⁵⁰ Another said that reading *Aristopia* "[would]... not benefit anyone."¹¹⁵¹ An especially sarcastic critic of *It May Happen Yet* quoted the words of John Greenleaf Whittier and quipped that the book's narrative was among "the dullest words of tongue or pen."¹¹⁵² *The Climax*, finally, received the most criticism, not only for its poor literary quality but—notably enough—for distorting the historical record.¹¹⁵³ One reviewer accused Pidgin of turning "fact topsy-turvy" to express his "own prejudiced opinions," while another said that while Pidgin may have "founded a new school of fiction," there would likely be "no pupils [in it]."¹¹⁵⁴ As one critic skeptically concluded: "what is the use of considering what might have been? We could write thousands of [such] tales ... But we don't."¹¹⁵⁵

Alternate History Between the Wars

The third wave of alternate histories appeared after World War I. Between 1914 and the early 1930s, the publication of new narratives confirmed that alternate history was a continuing, if still niche, phenomenon. Alternate histories appeared in a variety of countries, mostly as short stories, though there were scattered anthologies and novels as well. The narratives covered a wide range of topics: The Irish writer Charlotte Elizabeth McManus's novel *The Professor in Erin* (1918) was a time travel fantasy about Ireland gaining its independence from England after winning (instead of losing) the Battle of Kinsale in 1601–02.¹¹⁵⁶ The Polish writer Antoni Slonimski's 1924 novel *Torpeda czasu* (*The Time Torpedo*) depicted a time traveler trying to halt the rise of modern nationalism by preventing Napoleon's rise to power.¹¹⁵⁷ That same year, the American writer Webb Waldron's short story "If Lincoln Had Yielded" (1924) portrayed the sixteenth president allowing the Confederacy to secede peacefully from

the Union.¹¹⁵⁸ In 1926, finally, the British historian Charles Petrie published a short story, "If: A Jacobite Fantasy," which imagined the Stuarts being restored to the British throne in 1745.¹¹⁵⁹ These texts were all well-crafted, imaginative tales, but they largely existed in isolation.

The one exception to this trend was a cluster of texts focusing on the Great War. Produced by British, French, and German writers, these texts assumed the form of nightmares as well as fantasies, and expressed diverse emotions about the war's outcome, ranging from *schadenfreude* to chagrin.

The tendency of Britons to wonder "what if?" about the Great War surfaced during the war itself. This tendency was first displayed by the British reaction to a German future history. In 1915, the German writer, Paul Georg Münch, published a best-selling novel, entitled *Hindenburgs Einmarch in London*, which depicted the German army conquering England.¹¹⁶⁰ After being published in English in 1916 as *Hindenburg's March into London*, the novel generated angry responses, some of which featured counterfactual reflections.¹¹⁶¹ In the afterword to the English edition, the editor, L. G. Redmond-Howard, sardonically thanked the Germans for their decision to wage war, speculating that "nothing but a European conflagration could have roused England from a comatose state [to protect]... mankind" from the German threat, which "another twenty years of peace would have consolidated" into one of existential proportions.¹¹⁶² Fortunately for the British, he continued, Germany's wartime behavior discredited the Reich in the eyes of the world and hastened its decline as a threat. Redmond-Howard emphasized this point by drafting a medium form, nesting doll counterfactual that imagined a future German historian, resembling Sir Edward Gibbon, writing a massive study called *The Decline and Fall of the Teutonic Empire* that analyzed the reasons for Germany's decline. Redmond-Howard portrayed the fictional German historian lamenting that if only Germany had refrained from war, the country "would have held the world within the palm of her hand" thanks to her growing economic power and would have secured a "complete world victory for the Fatherland."¹¹⁶³ Yet since Germany ultimately squandered the advantages that "might have [allowed it to] take ... the place of England as [a] pioneer of civilization," Redmond-Howard concluded that Britain should thank the Kaiser as the man "who saved England."¹¹⁶⁴

Three years later, in 1919, the Canadian writer and humorist Stephen Leacock published a satirical novel, *The Hohenzollerns in America*, that also expressed Anglophone resentments towards Germany (Figure 6.11). Written in the form of diary entries by a fictional Princess Frederica of Hohenzollern, the novel imagined how the Prussian royal family would have fared had they been forced to leave Germany after its military defeat in 1918 like "an immigrant family

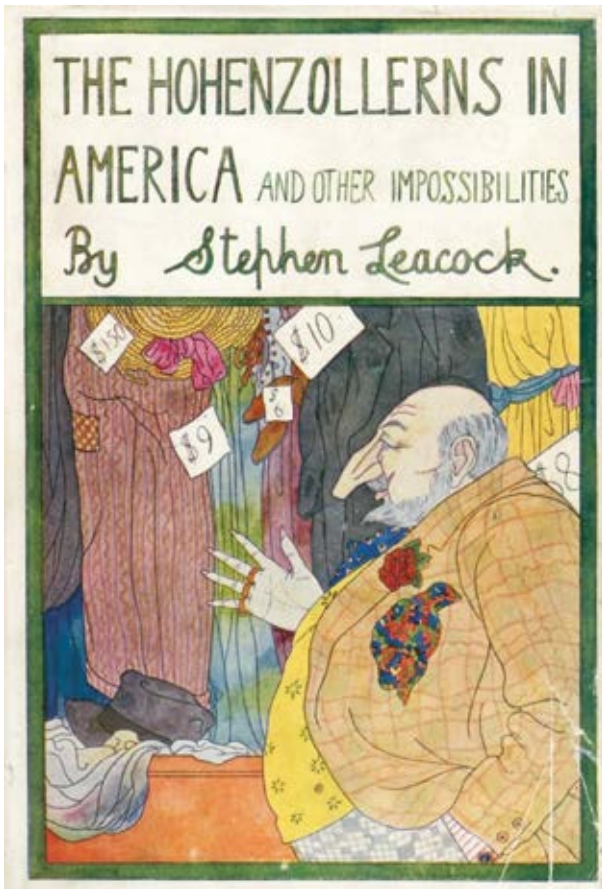


FIGURE 6.11 The Canadian writer, Stephen Leacock's novel, *The Hohenzollerns in America* (1919), expressed Anglophone resentments towards Germany after World War I. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

departing for America.” As Leacock explained in the preface, the novel sought to counterfactually punish the Hohenzollern family for their role in the war by presenting sketches of what their life would have been like without political power. One of the most notable entries was a nesting doll counterfactual, entitled “If Germany Had Won,” in which Princess Frederica fantasizes about how an American newspaper would have covered the activities of the royal family in “(Imperial) New York City” had the Germans conquered the United States. The details are uniformly comic: in one scene, German leaders stiffly attend cultural events, such as musicals on “Upper (Imperial) Broadway,” where they order audience members to “spontaneously ... break into cheers”;

in another scene, they order “the business men of New York” to march “in procession from the Battery to the Bronx” to be inspected by the Governor General.¹¹⁶⁵ On the surface, the entries documented what, for an Anglophone audience, would be the nightmare of a living in a German-ruled world. But the entries actually articulated an Anglo-American fantasy. The fact that the ex-princess prefaces her counterfactual musings by explaining that they help her forget the “extremes of liberty” that define her reality as a refugee living in “North American civilization” reveals that her wistful speculation is a method of coping her present-day suffering.¹¹⁶⁶ Her misery reflected Leacock’s desire to subject the Hohenzollern family to a fictional form of justice for their wartime crimes.

In 1921, a more nightmarish exploration of the Great War’s legacy appeared with French writer Gaston Homsy’s novel *Si les Allemands Avaient Gagné la Guerre ... (If Germany Had Won the War ...)*.¹¹⁶⁷ Partly a future history set in 1924, the novel depicted Germany conquering all of Europe “in the manner of a Xerxes” and achieving a degree of geopolitical hegemony undreamed by “a Roman Emperor ... or a Charles V.”¹¹⁶⁸ The consequences of this event for France are especially grim. After German forces occupy Paris, they crush French intellectual life, pillage its economy, and enforce a ruthless policy of “germanization.” The Germans fail to extinguish France’s will to fight, however, and a resistance movement, fueled by an underground press, arises to challenge German rule. Unfortunately, it comes to naught. As the novel concludes, the Germans remain firmly in control. In the final scene, a Prussian military man and a Bavarian professor are conversing in a German café on the Place de la Opéra when the latter wonders what would have happened “if the French had won [the war],” to which the former replies: “Don’t worry! We would have got away with it. All these people, you see, are naïve ... dreamers ... who never would have been able to take advantage of their victory if they had won.”¹¹⁶⁹ In arriving at this bleak conclusion, Homsy hoped to convince the French people not to forget the lessons of the recent war. In the novel’s preface, the writer honored the soldiers “who died for the noblest of causes,” noting that he wanted to remind those French citizens who were complaining “about the miseries of the present hour ... how much worse those miseries would have been if the Germans had won the war.”¹¹⁷⁰ This nationalistic message may have reflected Homsey’s foreign ancestry as an Egyptian Coptic Christian, whose ancestors had emigrated to France after collaborating with Napoleonic forces during the occupation of Egypt (1797–1801). Indeed, his explicit assertion at the end of his preface that he wished to “affirm my faith in the destin[y]... of the country” confirmed that his alternate history was meant as a gesture of patriotism.¹¹⁷¹

Two years later, in 1922, the French writer Jacques Rigaut offered a more unconventional reaction to the disappointments of the Great War in his short story, "A Brilliant Subject." Taking the form of a found document—a short, one-page abstract for a potential novel addressed to the famed French writer, André Breton—the abstract focused on the adventures of "a sentimental young man" named Palentête, who uses an egg-shaped time machine to go back in time to find "a lost mistress." Unfortunately, Palentête repeatedly runs into earlier versions of himself seeking the same woman and the resulting competition between the different Palentêtes leads one of them to "threaten to commit suicide," whereupon the other returns to the time machine to prevent his (their) death. In despair, the original Palentête embarks on a path of counterfactual nihilism in which he tries to alter the course of history. He first "traverse[s]... the province of Judea for six months," where he "discovers a child, Jesus of Nazareth asleep under an olive tree [and]... injects cyanide of potash into his veins." Shifting over to Egypt, Palentête "watches for a girl" and "one day, when he sees her alone,... pounces on her and ... mutilates her nose. This little girl was called Cleopatra." Finally, Palentête travels to South America where he helps the "red men" discover "steam and electricity" and is "honored as a deity." By virtue of these actions, Palentête drives himself to despair, and he decides to spread "the dogma of compulsory suicide" around the world. He eventually ends up dying in his time machine, a long white beard draped over his chest. In concluding on this bleak note, Rigaut expressed his own personal and artistic despair. A committed Dadaist, he embodied the movement's well-known embrace of absurdity as a nihilistic response to the upheaval of the war years. Indeed, Rigaut famously practiced what he preached, predicting his own suicide at age twenty and then carrying it out in real life on November 5, 1929, at the age of thirty.¹¹⁷² Rigaut's embrace of alternate history was a mere dalliance in an otherwise varied career. But his embrace of the genre suited the bleak mood of the early post-war era.

Around the same time, the leftwing German writer Kurt Tucholsky also speculated about the legacy of World War I. In the early years after the war, Tucholsky produced a series of essays, entitled "What If ..." (*Was wäre, wenn ...*), that presented nightmare scenarios relating to the country's deposed Kaiser, Wilhelm II. In one essay from 1919, Tucholsky speculated that "if the war had turned out happily" for Germany, the Kaiser would have stepped down, and "the crown prince [Wilhelm III] would have ascended to the throne." This would have been a nightmare, according to Tucholsky, for despite being a non-entity, the new Kaiser would have been lustily "cheered" by the German people, who would have thereby displayed their antidemocratic orientation.¹¹⁷³ Tucholsky's

second essay appeared in 1923 and imagined how the German people would have responded if Kaiser Wilhelm II had died. By depicting ordinary Germans praising the departed Kaiser as someone who acted “out of love for his people,” and by showing them jailing communists for refusing to attend his funeral procession, Tucholsky displayed his pessimistic belief that Germany’s political system was determined more by the German people’s obedience to authority than the character of any individual ruler.

The 1920s also saw the publication of more conventional counterfactual narratives in the realm of military history. In 1929, the English writer, Arthur Conan Doyle, published a short story, entitled “The Death Voyage,” that featured Kaiser Wilhelm II deciding in the last days of the war to become a martyr by launching a suicidal naval assault from Kiel against the Royal Navy (Figure 6.12).¹¹⁷⁴ The story depicted extended scenes of naval combat—an “Armageddon of the sea”—between the German and British fleets, but it ended on a patriotic note with “ship after ship in the German line” going “up in smoke” and the Emperor himself going “up into the air” as his vessel is hit by a British artillery barrage. Doyle’s story was ultimately a stasis counterfactual, as the course of history remains the same. But by enabling the British Navy to destroy the German fleet, the story enabled English readers to live out the fantasy of added vengeance against the enemy.

A second work of alternate military history appeared one year later, when the British writer Bernard Newman published a novel entitled *The Cavalry Goes Through* (1930). The novel was an extended exploration of military strategy and focused on the exploits of a brilliant officer named Henry Duncan, who devises innovative methods to help British forces win the Battle of Verdun and thereby defeat the Germans in 1917.¹¹⁷⁵ Like Doyle’s tale, *The Cavalry Goes Through* was also a fantasy, though it was more self-critical. By showing Britain ending the war one year before it did in reality, the novel criticized the country’s actual conduct in the conflict. Newman’s experience in World War I as a staff sergeant, together with his later government service in the Ministry of Works, explain his novel’s patriotic desire to offer critical feedback on how England might have performed better in the Great War.¹¹⁷⁶

The interwar era’s most important work of alternate history was J.C. Squire’s anthology of essays, *If It Had Happened Otherwise* (1931).¹¹⁷⁷ While scholars have long viewed the volume as a classic because of the prominence of its contributors, they have overlooked the fact that nearly half of the essays directly or indirectly fantasized about preventing World War I. The most famous of them, Winston Churchill’s “If Lee had not Won the Battle of Gettysburg,” imagined that if the South had seceded from the Union in 1861, Britain would have eventually helped the two regions merge with the U.K. into a powerful



FIGURE 6.12 Arthur Conan Doyle's 1929 short story, "The Death Voyage," imagined Kaiser Wilhelm II deciding to die as a martyr in the last days of World War I. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

English-Speaking Association (the E.S.A.) that would have given the nations of Europe the necessary "breathing space" following the assassination of Francis Ferdinand to let the "danger of ... war pass ... away" (Figure 6.13).¹¹⁷⁸ Similarly, German writer Emil Ludwig's essay "If the Emperor Frederick Had Not Had Cancer" depicted the reform-minded German Kaiser, Friedrich III, surviving throat cancer and turning Germany into a constitutional monarchy that supports, rather than threatens, the liberal European order. French writer André Maurois's essay "If Louis XVI Had Had an Atom of Firmness" hypothesized that if France had refused to support the American Revolution in 1776, it could have avoided the revolution of 1789 and enabled the French monarchy to survive into the present without experiencing "the war of 1914–1918."¹¹⁷⁹ British writer Philip Guedalla's essay "If the Moors in Spain Had Won" also altered



FIGURE 6.13 Winston Churchill employed a nesting doll counterfactual in his 1931 short story, "If Lee had not Won the Battle of Gettysburg." (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

World War I by showing how the failure of King Ferdinand and Queen Isabella to conquer Granada in 1491 enables the Muslim-ruled state to develop into a European great power and, in the year 1915, join forces with Britain to defend "gallant little Belgium" from attack by an unnamed foreign power.¹¹⁸⁰ Finally, British writer Hilaire Belloc's essay "If Drouet's Cart Had Stuck" imagined King Louis XVI successfully escaping to Varennes in 1791 and completing a counter-revolutionary restoration of the French monarchy one year later, thereby preventing the rise of Napoleon, preserving the Holy Roman Empire, and ushering in a new "Golden Age ... of Christendom" free of continental war.¹¹⁸¹

The reception of interwar alternate histories was mixed. Newman's novel *The Cavalry Went Through* was the most uniformly praised in the Anglophone press, being hailed as a "most curious blend of fantasy and reality," a "glorious yarn," and a "fabulous story of the great war as it might have been."¹¹⁸² Other

texts received a more divided response. Leacock's book *The Hohenzollerns in America* was praised as "sanely humorous," with one reviewer saying he found it "amusing" to see "the Hohenzollerns" portrayed as "immigrants ... with their ... backs bowed down with trunks and boxes."¹¹⁸³ Other critics, however, said the book's satirical approach was "cheap and unworthy," given the seriousness of the recent war.¹¹⁸⁴ Homsy's novel *If Germany Had Won the War* was hailed by French reviewers as a "poignant" tale that would help the French "keenly appreciate ... having escaped German servitude," but English-speaking reviewers faulted the novel for its "meagre and uninteresting [plot]."¹¹⁸⁵ Squire's anthology *If It Had Happened Otherwise* also received a mixed response. While some reviewers hailed it as a "remarkable volume" that showed how "trifling matters ... become paramount in decreeing the fate of nations," more critical reviewers called it "a silly book" whose contributors were chosen for "their selling power rather than their historical qualifications," concluding that "speculating on what might have been ... is a futile game."¹¹⁸⁶

The Stalling of Alternate History: 1931–1945

In the years between the publication of Squire's volume and the eruption of World War II, alternate history's pace of development slowed. Only a few counterfactual novels appeared. In Britain, Elspeth Briggs's *The Rhyme for Porringer* (1939), imagined Queen Mary II surviving her husband, King William III, and restoring her father, the last Stuart King, James II, to the throne of England.¹¹⁸⁷ In France, Robert Aron's novel *Victoire à Waterloo* (1937) depicted Napoleon winning the Battle of Waterloo but, in a reversionary counterfactual, still being ousted from power and exiled to St. Helena.¹¹⁸⁸ Finally, the Swiss writer Léon Bopp's four-volume novel *Liaisons du monde* (1938–44) imagined France experiencing a violent, communist-led revolution in the 1930s.¹¹⁸⁹ These texts were relatively isolated, however, and lacked any thematic unity. They also displayed few new literary features.

Time Travel Tales

At the same time, however, alternate history was poised to move in new literary directions thanks to the rise of time travel stories and future histories. Prior to the 1930s, time travel stories, such as Mark Twain's novel *A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur's Court* (1889), remained mostly in the realm of secret history and refrained from altering the course of historical events. Yet, several tales published in the 1930s moved time travel fiction in the direction of

alternate history. The American writer Murray Leinster's short story "Sideways in Time" (1934) depicted an unspecified cataclysm enabling people from parallel universes to visit one another and experience alternate timelines where the course of history has been altered: in one, for example, the South wins the Civil War; in another, China colonizes the New World before Columbus.¹¹⁹⁰ The American writer L. Sprague de Camp did something similar in his short story "Wheels of If" (1940), which explored multiple universes, timelines, and points of divergence in a single narrative, including one where the American revolution fails and France wins the Napoleonic Wars. These two tales, which were among the era's most influential, differed from prior alternate histories by veering into the fantastic territory usually restricted to science fiction. They thereby created new narrative possibilities that shaped alternate history's later development.

Several of the era's time travel tales were significant for confronting the threat of fascism. The first was the short story "Ancestral Voices" by the American science fiction writer Nat Schachner. Published in *Astounding Stories* in 1933, the tale refined the idea of the "grandfather paradox"—the notion that a time traveler might prevent his own birth by somehow killing one of his ancestors.¹¹⁹¹ The tale was technically a future history, insofar as it was set in 1935, but it moved into alternate history territory by tweaking the course of historical events. In the tale, a scientist named Emmett Pennypacker uses a self-produced time machine to travel Rome as it is being sacked by the Huns in the year 452 C.E. While trying to protect a young woman from being assaulted, Pennypacker kills one of the "savage-looking barbarians," who turns out to be one of his ancestors. Having "interfered with the course of history," Pennypacker "unwittingly seal[s]... his own fate" and erases himself from history.¹¹⁹² He does not erase only his own existence, however, but that of more than "fifty thousand" other people on Earth—people "of every race and clime" from "savage Africa" to "blue-eyed northern Europe."¹¹⁹³ Among the famous people who vanish from the Earth because they have descended from the "barbaric" Huns, one is a fictional political autocrat, "Herr Hedwig, dictator of Mid-Europe," who is known for attacking "Jews and communists" and telling his countless "Blue Shirt" followers that they are a "pure race of Nordics" descended from the Gallic warlord "Vercingterox."

In showing the diversity of victims killed by Pennypacker's journey through time, Schachner critiqued the Nazi idea of racial purity and endorsed the idea of human equality.¹¹⁹⁴ Notably enough, two of the people who vanish from Earth are a pair of boxers from radically different ethnic backgrounds: the "Nordic heavyweight [boxing] champion ... Hans Schilling" and his "Hebraic challenger, Max Bernstein," both of whom disappear from the ring in the

middle of their title bout.¹¹⁹⁵ In light of Schachner's Jewish background, it was hardly surprising that he critiqued Nazi principles. By merging time travel with alternate history, he fantasized about removing Hitler from history and fostering the unity of humankind.

Another important narrative was L. Sprague De Camp's time travel novella *Lest Darkness Fall*. First published in the magazine *Unknown* in December of 1939 (and later expanded in 1941), the tale was notable for rejecting the grandfather paradox and endorsing the premise of multiple worlds.¹¹⁹⁶ Early in the story, the story's protagonist, an American archaeologist named Martin Padway, is touring the city of Rome and discussing time travel with his Italian host Professor Tancredi. In response to Padway's fearful observation that someone going back in time could "change all subsequent history," Tancredi compares time to a tree trunk and notes that when someone goes back in time, "the trunk continues to exist, but a new branch starts." "Otherwise," Tancredi warns, "we would all disappear."¹¹⁹⁷ Soon thereafter, Padway gets caught in a thunderstorm and a bolt of lightning mysteriously transports him back to ancient Rome during the reign of Emperor Justinian (6th century C.E.) just as the city is being convulsed by battles between rival Latin and Gothic warlords. As the story unfolds, Padway uses modern technology (especially the printing press and the telegraph) to survive in the war-torn empire. But his main achievement is to ward off the arrival of Dark Ages. Recognizing that he is living in "the twilight of classical western civilization," he uses his technical knowledge to return stability to Rome and ward off disaster. "History had been changed," the story concludes. "Darkness would not fall."¹¹⁹⁸

In writing his tale, De Camp hoped to warn against fascism. Published three months after the beginning of World War II, *Lest Darkness Fall* opens in Mussolini's Rome and communicated a clear sense of fascism's menace. In the first several pages, Padway is almost run over by motorcycle rider "in a Fascist uniform" and, in a discussion with Tancredi about the role of individuals in history, is told that a person's historical significance depends on whether or not they become a "king or a *duce*."¹¹⁹⁹ Despite these encounters, Padway initially ignores his political surroundings, admitting that he "had never ... paid more attention to current events than he had to."¹²⁰⁰ Once he is transported back in time, however, he can no longer be complacent about political matters if he hopes to survive the looming Dark Ages. Padway's ensuing use of modern technology to produce a happy ending was typically American. But De Camp may have sought to critique a different American tradition—isolationism—by didactically showing the importance of knowing the political context of one's place in history.

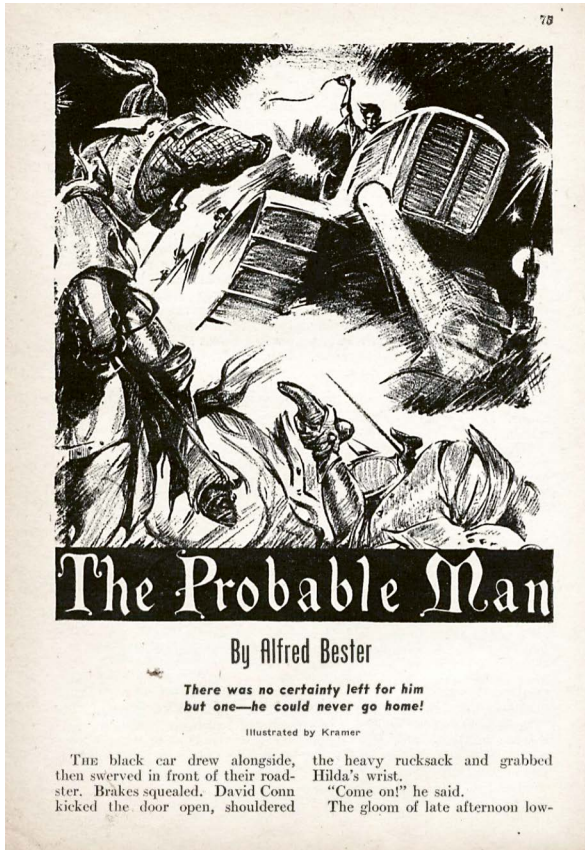


FIGURE 6.14 Alfred Bester's short story, "The Probable Man" (1941), called attention to the threat posed by Nazism.

The last notable narrative was American writer Alfred Bester's short story "The Probable Man" (Figure 6.14). Published in *Astounding Science Fiction* in July of 1941, the tale describes the time traveling adventure of an American journalist named David Conn, who journeys from the United States in the year 2941 back to the year 1941 to prevent the Nazis from kidnapping the daughter of the Dutch Prime Minister.¹²⁰¹ Conn accomplishes his mission early in the story when he kills his Nazi antagonists in a shootout, but after returning to his world in the thirtieth century, he finds it has been altered for the worse. After a violent encounter with mysterious soldiers, he learns that the U.S. has become a war zone between two groups: the surface-dwelling, German-descended "Swasts" and the underground-dwelling, American-descended "Readers." Confused,

Conn learns that his journey back to 1941 has altered the world of 2941, thereby illustrating the fact that—as a Reader named Rollins tells him—“the future can never affect the past without becoming part of the past and thus destroying itself.”¹²⁰² Eventually, Conn uses his technological knowledge to defeat the Swasts, rebuild his time machine, and travel back to 1941. At that point, however, he realizes that he is no longer the “real” Conn and merely a “probable” version of himself existing in an “alternative reality.”

In presenting this conclusion, Bester resembled De Camp and Schachner by calling attention to the threat posed by Nazism. Like De Camp’s protagonist, Padway, in *Lest Darkness Fall*, Conn is initially apolitical. Early in his mission, he asks himself, “what am I getting so excited about Nazis for?”, knowing full well that “democracy will survive” the Nazi threat of 1941 and “fascism [will] die ... out in 1970.”¹²⁰³ Yet, fighting the Nazis forces Conn to abandon his complacency and reconnect with his dormant Jewish heritage. Recognizing that “a thousand years ago [my]... name might have been Cohen,” he reminds himself that he “still hate[s] Nazis and their children’s children.”¹²⁰⁴ Bester’s Jewish identity makes it likely that he wrote “The Probable Man” in the hope that history would lead to Nazism’s defeat. Yet he was aware enough of American isolationism in 1941 not to place his faith merely in hope but to use his literary talents to galvanize popular support for the anti-Nazi cause.

Future Histories

Liberal fears of fascism were also expressed in future histories. Most of these tales expressed Anglo-American concerns about the Nazis winning World War II. In 1937, before the war even erupted, the English writer Katherine Burdekin—writing under the pseudonym Murray Constantine—published the novel, *Swastika Night* (1937), which depicted the British people living under an oppressive Nazi regime seven hundred years in the future. After the beginning of World War II, other narratives, such as Douglas Brown and Christopher Serpell’s 1940 novel *Loss of Eden*, H.V. Morton’s 1942 novel *I, James Blunt*, and Humphrey Jennings’ 1943 film *The Silent Village*, portrayed the Nazis invading, defeating, and occupying the British Isles with brutal savagery. After the tide of war turned in favor of the Allies in 1943, British future histories became more optimistic, with texts such as Anthony Armstrong and Bruce Graeme’s novel *When the Bells Rang* (1943) and Martin Hawkins’s novel *When Adolf Came* (1943), portraying a Nazi invasion ending with the swift defeat of the enemy.¹²⁰⁵

Similar narratives appeared in the United States. Nightmare scenarios were common, with Hendrik Willem van Loon’s novel *Invasion* (1940) and Fred Allhoff’s serialized novel *Lightning in the Night* (1940) depicting the Nazis

delivering destruction to the U.S. before being defeated by American resistance forces. A bleaker narrative was offered by Marion White's novel *If We Should Fail* (1942), which portrayed the Nazis perpetrating horrific atrocities against the American people.¹²⁰⁶ American writers also produced fantasies about defeating the Nazis. American science fiction writer Robert Heinlein's short story "Solution Unsatisfactory" (1941) imagined the U.S. staying out of World War II by using radioactive dust to destroy Berlin and force the collapse of the Nazi regime.¹²⁰⁷ Similarly, Alexander Blade's 1941 story "Dr. Loudon's Armageddon," depicted the Nazis losing World War II thanks to a Dutch physicist who sabotages their invention of a nuclear weapon.¹²⁰⁸ In all these tales, fears that might have been expressed in counterfactual pasts were instead explored in the future.

Conclusion

Between 1815 and 1945, alternate history emerged as an important expression of western counterfactual thought. In four waves, European and North American writers channeled fears and fantasies about the present into alternative depictions of the past. The leading figures in this development hailed from countries on the cusp of historical events. French writers pioneered the genre of alternate history in the wake of the turbulent Napoleonic era. But by the second half of the nineteenth century, they were eclipsed by writers from Britain and the U.S. The waves of alternate history generally received respectable, and in some cases, enthusiastic attention. Yet, on balance, the genre remained something of a curiosity. Despite the increasing pace of production and increasing prominence of its practitioners, alternate history remained a marginal literary phenomenon. After 1945, however, new forces helped propel it to greater visibility.

Cold War What Ifs: The East-West Conflict and the New Counterfactuals, 1945–1989

When the United States decided to reject its own Yalta policy following Roosevelt's death, it virtually went to war—albeit a “cold” one—like Don Quixote fighting his windmills. Washington, not Moscow, prevented a settlement which might have left Europe intact rather than divided into blocs and camps.”¹²⁰⁹ (Diana Shaver Clemens 1970)

The more one broods about the Cold War, the more irrelevant the assessment of blame seems. The Second World War had left ... two states—America and Soviet Russia—with ... opposite and antagonistic ideas ... No one should have been surprised at what ensued. The real surprise would have been if there had been no cold war.¹²¹⁰ (Arthur Schlesinger, Jr. 1986)

After the end of World War II, counterfactual thought continued to be influenced by the western world's dominant political worldviews. Yet, in contrast to the trilateral competition of the years 1918–1945 between Nazism, communism, and liberalism, the postwar era witnessed a bipolar confrontation between the latter two. The conflict between communists and liberals quickly came to be known as the Cold War and, for forty years, shaped not only global politics but historiography. The conflict also left a strong imprint on counterfactual thinking. In the Soviet Union, communist writers continued earlier traditions by using counterfactuals within narrow ideological parameters. In the Anglo-American world, by contrast, scholars used counterfactuals for more disputational purposes. As was shown by the competing views of the American historians Diana Shaver Clemens and Arthur Schlesinger, Jr., scholars energetically debated whether the Cold War could have been avoided or was inevitable.

Partly because of this debate, western historians were prompted, once again, to reflect on the nature of counterfactuals. Between 1945 and 1989, there were two major theoretical discussions of “what ifs.” The first erupted during the first decade-and-a-half of the postwar era, when an array of distinguished historians in Britain and the U.S. debated whether counterfactuals should be used to judge and explain the past. In doing so, they notably cited the threat of totalitarianism to justify historical speculation. The second debate lasted from

the early 1960s to the mid-1980s, when scholars discussed whether the new field of “cliometrics” provided empirical legitimacy for counterfactual thought. Thanks to these discussions, an important development took place by the end of the period: the newly coined concept of “counterfactual history” became the preferred term for both sides in the ongoing debate over wondering “what if?”

Communist Counterfactuals

After 1945, Soviet communists actively speculated about the recent past. During the first years after the war, communist commentators often employed deterministic counterfactuals to justify the domestic and foreign policy decisions made by Joseph Stalin in the years 1927–1953. After Stalin’s death in 1953 and the rise of Nikita Khrushchev in 1956, however, Soviet historians followed the new official policy of “destalinization” and examined whether the Soviet experiment could have taken a different turn.¹²¹¹

As the cold war was commencing, Soviet historians argued that the western allies could have prevented World War II by partnering sooner with the Soviets against Germany. In a famous 1948 publication, entitled *Falsifiers of History*, Soviet officials criticized Britain and France for failing to offer the USSR sufficient security assurances as part of a possible tripartite alliance in mid-1939, claiming that if Stalin had accepted it, “the USSR would have taken upon itself the brunt of the sacrifice in repulsing a possible Hitler aggression, while Britain and France would not bind themselves by any commitment to the Soviet Union.”¹²¹² This talking point remained a constant one in Soviet historiography after Stalin’s death. In 1969, the classic study *History of Soviet Foreign Policy* explained that “the Soviet government would have preferred collective security founded on cooperation between the USSR, Britain, and France against Nazi aggression,” but the Western powers declined to guarantee Soviet security.¹²¹³ Similarly, B.N. Ponomarev’s 1962 study *History of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union* declared that “Hitler would not have risked a war against a coalition of the U.S.S.R., Britain, France and the U.S.A., to which many other countries would have adhered.”¹²¹⁴

Soviet officials further used “what ifs” to justify Stalin’s signing of the Nazi-Soviet Non-Aggression Pact of 1939. Many argued that without it, the USSR might have lost the Second World War. One of the architects of the pact, Foreign Minister Vyacheslav Molotov, explained that the agreement was meant to buy extra time for the Soviet Union to defend itself against an expected German invasion, arguing that an “earlier” war “would have been very dangerous,” as the country was not yet fully prepared to fight.¹²¹⁵ As the *History of*

Soviet Foreign Policy explained, an earlier war “would have caught the USSR at a disadvantage, for it would have had to fight in isolation on two fronts—against Germany and against Japan.”¹²¹⁶ *Falsifiers of History* further explained this stance, insisting that “if, prior to Germany’s attack, the USSR had not created an ‘Eastern’ front far to the west of the old frontiers of the USSR,” then the Germans would have had an easier “advance into the interior of the USSR, hastening the fall of Kiev and the Ukraine, [and] leading to the capture of Moscow by the Germans.”¹²¹⁷ While Soviet historians were unwilling to admit they would have lost the war without the pact, they noted that “[the conflict] would have dragged on at least for two more years ... [and] ended ... not in 1945, but in 1947.”¹²¹⁸

The Soviets also claimed the war could have been won sooner had the Allies opened up a second front against the Nazis earlier in the conflict.¹²¹⁹ “Victory over the Nazi bloc,” the *History of Soviet Foreign Policy* noted, “could have been achieved much sooner and at much smaller cost if the USA and Britain had ... fulfilled their Allied duty and opened the second front not in 1944 but at an earlier stage of the war.”¹²²⁰ If the Allies had opened up a second front in early 1942, the *History* argued, Hitler would have not been able to shift 39 divisions from France to the eastern front “and the course of the war might have been more favourable.”¹²²¹ Indeed, as the Soviet news media noted in 1957, “millions of lives ... would have been preserved.”¹²²²

In addition to criticizing the Allies’ war effort, early postwar Soviet commentators validated the wartime decisions of the Soviet commander-in-chief, Joseph Stalin. Up through the end of his reign, Soviet officials and their western apologists used close call counterfactuals to argue that without Stalin’s brutal methods, the USSR would not have won the war.¹²²³ Stalin himself stressed the importance of his interwar economic policies in a February 1946 speech celebrating the Red Army’s wartime triumph over the Nazis, declaring that it “could [not] have been achieved ... without heavy industry [and]... the policy of collectivization.”¹²²⁴ Another of Stalin’s allies, Georgy Malenkov, justified Stalin’s purges in the late 1930s, noting that “if [they] had not been done in time,” then “we would have found ourselves ... under fire from the front and the rear, and we might have lost the war.”¹²²⁵

In praising Stalin for defeating the Nazis, Soviet historians implicitly altered the communist party’s official stance on the importance of structural forces and individual agency in historical events. Instead of emphasizing the former over the latter, the Russian scholar G.M. Gak wrote that notable individuals could transcend the limits of social forces, arguing “in the absence of the great man, [an]... event which will take place ultimately, takes place so belatedly that for a while, the historical development can follow a different course from the

course it would have followed had the event taken place in due time.”¹²²⁶ The historian M.D. Kammari went even further, asserting in 1952 that the Bolshevik Revolution “could not have taken place ... without the ... great leadership of Lenin and Stalin.”¹²²⁷

Stalin's death in 1953, however, emboldened Soviet critics to question Stalin's actions related to the war. In his “secret speech” of 1956, Nikita Khrushchev counterfactually argued that building socialism would have been easier without Stalin's purges, noting “our march forward toward socialism and toward the preparation of the country's defense would have been much more successful were it not for the tremendous loss in the cadres suffered [in the]... mass repressions in 1937–1938” (Figure 7.1).¹²²⁸ Khrushchev also condemned Stalin by invoking Lenin, saying “Had Leninist principles been observed,... we ... would not have had such a brutal violation of revolutionary legality and many thousands ... would not have fallen victim to ... terror.”¹²²⁹ Khrushchev went so far as to declare that “had Lenin lived, such ... extreme method[s] would not have been used against [communist party dissidents].”¹²³⁰ Khrushchev also challenged the view that Stalin's heroism won the war for the USSR, insisting “had our industry been mobilized properly ... to supply the Army with the necessary materiel, our wartime losses would have been ... smaller.”¹²³¹

This new official line was imported into subsequent Soviet histories. After 1956, Soviet texts once again decried the “cult of the individual” and reemphasized the catalytic role of “the People [as]... the Creators of History.”¹²³² In 1956, an official resolution of the Central Committee of the Communist Party declared that “without the support of the ... masses,... our country would not have been able to create a mighty socialist industry, ... bring about the collectivization of agriculture,... [and win] the Second World War, on whose outcome hung the fate of all mankind.”¹²³³ A few years later, B. N. Ponomaryov's *History of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union* (1962) condemned the “Stalin personality cult” and praised the importance of communist doctrine, saying that the CPSU “would not have been able to secure the historic gains of socialism in the U.S.S.R. if it had not been guided ... by the theory of Marxism-Leninism.”¹²³⁴ The *History of Soviet Foreign Policy*, finally, valorized the Army, noting that “[if] the Soviet Armed Forces [had] not defeated the Nazi aggressors ... [and protected]... the People's Democracies ... against ... U.S. and British imperialism in the years immediately after the war ..., the socialist system ... would not have triumphed and become consolidated in these countries.”¹²³⁵

Unlike the shifting attitude towards Stalin, Soviet views on the origins of the cold war remained consistent during the early postwar period. Because Soviet officials understood the East-West conflict in ideological terms as



FIGURE 7.1 In his “secret speech” of 1956, Nikita Khrushchev argued that building socialism would have been easier without Stalin’s purges. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

originating in “the imperialist tendencies of American monopolistic capital,” they mostly used deterministic counterfactuals in speculating about the cold war.¹²³⁶ In a 1946 speech, for instance, Stalin pointed to the inevitability of East-West conflict by citing the origins of World War II, speculating that while “the catastrophe of war could have been avoided if the ... periodic redistribution of raw materials and markets between the countries existed in accordance with their economic needs,” the fact remained that “this is impossible under the present capitalist development of world economy.”¹²³⁷ As a result, the Cold War was inevitable. For this reason, Soviet commentators in the years that followed rarely wondered whether the East-West showdown might have been prevented.

Liberal Counterfactuals

By contrast, liberal scholars in the English-speaking world, especially in the United States, debated the origins of the Cold War intensely. Erupting in 1945 and lasting well into the 1970s, the debate pitted two groups of scholars against one another: an orthodox camp known as the consensus historians and a dissenting camp known as the revisionists. While the former blamed the USSR for the cold war, the latter blamed the United States. This divergence of views reflected diverging political agendas. While the orthodox camp represented the centrist liberal establishment, the revisionists hailed from the isolationist right (in the 1950s) and the pacifist left (in the 1960s).¹²³⁸ In advancing their positions, both groups used numerous counterfactuals. The former regarded the Cold War as the inevitable outgrowth of Soviet expansionism and employed deterministic counterfactuals to portray the conflict as unavoidable. The latter, by contrast, replied that the U.S. could have easily averted a clash with the Soviets and gravitated to missed opportunity counterfactuals.

One of the first questions debated by the two groups was whether the Cold War could have been prevented if the United States and Great Britain had refrained from intervening in World War II. The revisionists insisted that the answer was yes. As the isolationist historian Harry Elmer Barnes declared in 1953, "had we not entered the Second World War, the Cold War ... would have been unthinkable."¹²³⁹ The anticommunist historian William Henry Chamberlin similarly argued that if "the western powers [had]... maintained a hands-off policy in eastern Europe" on the eve of World War II, "the two totalitarian regimes [Nazi Germany and the Soviet Union] might have been expected to shoot it out to their hearts' content" (Figure 7.2).¹²⁴⁰ The result would have been no cold war. As the anticommunist writer, Hanson Baldwin, explained, had the Allies gotten "the world's two great dictatorships to fight each other to a frazzle,... [it would] have aided in the establishment of a more stable peace ... [by placing] the democracies in supreme power in the world, instead of elevating one totalitarianism at the expense of another."¹²⁴¹

If anything, right-wing revisionists declared, Nazi totalitarianism would have been preferable to Soviet totalitarianism." Referring to the possibility of a US-Nazi alliance, Chamberlin declared that "We should have made peace with Germany and Japan when they were too weak to be a threat to us and still strong enough to be useful in a coalition against the Soviet Union."¹²⁴² Chamberlin sought to preempt objections that such an outcome would have elevated Nazi Germany as a threat to the U.S., writing that while it was "reasonable to assume that a victorious Nazi Germany would have been an uncomfortable neighbor,



FIGURE 7.2 The anticommunist historian, William Henry Chamberlin, claimed the U.S. and U.K. could have prevented the cold war if they had not intervened in World War II. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

just as a victorious Soviet Russia is today,... there is no proof that Hitler envisaged the American continent as part of his empire.”¹²⁴³ Barnes went even further, saying there was “little, if any, possibility of a Nazi triumph ... if we had remained aloof from the conflict,” adding that “the world situation since 1945 could not have been worse than it has been, even if Hitler had won the war.”¹²⁴⁴

By contrast, the consensus historians declared that America’s failure to intervene in the Second World War would have proved disastrous. Writing in 1950, the President of Brooklyn College, Harry D. Gideonse, rejected Chamberlin’s claim that the U.S. would have been better off had the Nazis defeated the USSR, insisting that Germany would not have been “less of a menace to the United States than Stalin is now.”¹²⁴⁵ Several years later, the British historian Arnold Toynbee said that without Allied intervention, “the Nazis would have

conquered the world," adding that while the war benefited the Soviet Union, a Nazi triumph "would have been worse than a Communist oppression for the Jews ... Asian, African, and Indian-American majority of the human race."¹²⁴⁶ This nightmare was supported by ordinary Americans in the form of newspaper columns and letters to the editor, with one Ohio writer declaring in 1951 that "if ... Hitler would have won [the war, he]... would now be more of a threat to our security than Stalin."¹²⁴⁷

Historians also discussed whether the Cold War might have been prevented if the western Allies had seized more of Eastern Europe during World War II. Addressing the possibility of an earlier second front, Hanson Baldwin wrote in 1950 that "[if] a large-scale Mediterranean invasion [had]... been mounted [before]... the ... attack in Normandy,... there was a real chance ... that a push [of Allied forces] from Belgrade up [to]... Poland would have beaten the Red Armies to northern Europe."¹²⁴⁸ William Henry Chamberlin agreed, noting that "a successful Anglo-American occupation of the Balkan countries would have tipped the political balance in this part of the world in favor of the West and against Russia."¹²⁴⁹ Leftwing revisionists also shared this stance. In 1961, Denna F. Fleming declared that an earlier second front "would have meant the saving of millions of Russian lives, a shortening of the war, and ... the [possibility of] the Russians [being]... pleased to strike hands with us in Poland," thereby preventing postwar tensions.¹²⁵⁰ Making a related argument, the hawkish wartime ambassador to the USSR William Bullitt wrote in 1948 that if President Truman had "ordered General Eisenhower to take ... as much ... of Germany, Czechoslovakia, and Austria as he could occupy" in the spring of 1945, "the Soviet government [might have begun]... to carry out its agreements with us."¹²⁵¹

Orthodox critics roundly rejected these claims. In his memoirs, Winston Churchill wrote that any "attempt to cross the Channel in 1943 would have led to a bloody defeat of the first magnitude, with measureless reactions upon the result of the war."¹²⁵² John Snell expanded upon this nightmare, noting that "If Allied troops had become bogged down in the Balkans,... the Red Army and Soviet political influence might have moved along the North European plain ... to the English Channel"¹²⁵³ The writer and FDR supporter John Gunther, meanwhile, dismissed the idea that Allied forces "could have taken Berlin," declaring in 1950 that "the line at which our troops stopped was determined ... by the generals themselves" in accordance with Allied agreements to divide "Germany into zones of occupation."¹²⁵⁴

Americans also debated whether the Cold War might have been prevented if Roosevelt had behaved differently towards Stalin at the Yalta Conference of February 1945. In June of 1951, the hawkish American General Patrick J. Hurley

noted that Roosevelt should have spoken “the only language the Communists understand, the language of power,” and reminded Stalin that ... the United States ... was in command of the greatest land, navy and air force ever assembled on earth,” adding “one quiet sentence ... in that language ... would have prevented the conquest of all the Balkan states, the conquest of Poland, and the conquest of China.”¹²⁵⁵ William Henry Chamberlin agreed that Roosevelt had been insufficiently tough with the Soviets, saying that “Stalin’s grip on Eastern Europe would have been very shaky and hard to maintain if the United States and Great Britain had flatly refused to recognize ... the puppet Communist regimes ... set up in areas overrun by the Red Army.”¹²⁵⁶

Roosevelt’s defenders replied that the setback of Yalta could not have been avoided. Writing in 1951, George Kennan declared that “the establishment of Soviet military power in Eastern Europe ... was not the result of [the Yalta]... talks [but]... of the military operations during the concluding phases of the war,” adding “there was nothing the Western democracies could have done to prevent the Russians from entering these areas except to get there first, and this they were not in a position to do.”¹²⁵⁷ The former U.S. Ambassador to the Soviet Union Averill Harriman agreed, noting that “if we hadn’t had the Yalta agreements, we would have been blamed for all the postwar tensions” between the west and the USSR.¹²⁵⁸ Finally, the international studies scholar Louis J. Halle noted that while Truman “[could] have postponed the demobilization of its armed forces until the international arrangements of the postwar world had been completed,” he “was quite without choice” since “from the moment the fighting ended, Washington was overwhelmed by the ... demand of the American people that the soldiers be returned to their homes.”¹²⁵⁹

Debate also swirled around the question of whether greater Allied attentiveness to Soviet economic and security concerns could have prevented the Cold War. Stressing the importance of satisfying the “spiritual and material needs of all men,” former Vice President Henry Wallace speculated in 1948 that the postwar adoption of “such a policy ... would have [helped]... to stop Russian imperialism” by inducing Russia to accept Marshall Plan aid, the refusal of which led the “cold war [to begin]... in earnest.”¹²⁶⁰ Writing two decades later, the leftwing revisionist Gar Alperovitz argued that “a U.S. reconstruction loan for Russia would have ... given U.S. diplomacy strong leverage in a variety of negotiations” with the Soviets after the war.¹²⁶¹ Alperovitz also addressed the U.S.’s failure to assuage Stalin’s security concerns, writing that “had [they] been met,... the USSR’s domination of Eastern Europe might have been much different from what it turned out to be.”¹²⁶² Denna Fleming, meanwhile, blamed Churchill’s “Iron Curtain” speech of 1946 for torpedoing the chances of the U.S.

and USSR agreeing on a twenty-five year disarmament treaty for Germany, saying "if ... any chance of ... accepting a ... guarantee had existed, it vanished with Churchill's speech, which put confidence only in superior armed force."¹²⁶³

Orthodox critics replied that greater American concern for Soviet needs would not have prevented the Cold War. Herbert Feis noted that "Soviet Communist ... aims ... were too firmly fixed to have been deflected by the receipt of a loan, except in secondary ways and in situations in which Russia was at a disadvantage."¹²⁶⁴ Arthur Schlesinger Jr. wrote in 1967 that "satisfying Moscow on any ... financial score ... would ... merely have reinforced both sides of the Kremlin debate [and not]... reversed deeper tendencies toward the deterioration of political relationships" (Figure 7.3).¹²⁶⁵ Indeed, other observers claimed that a softer approach to the USSR would have produced a disaster. Commenting in 1950 on the Berlin crisis of 1948, Secretary of State John Foster Dulles praised Democrats and Republicans for jointly standing up to Soviet aggression, arguing that "if conditions had been otherwise,... Berlin would have been lost,... and after that, the rest of the Continent would almost surely have been lost."¹²⁶⁶ In 1967, Louis J. Halle argued that "if the weight of the United States had not again been thrown into the balance ... against the Soviet Union," it was "unlikely that western Europe would have recovered and maintained its independence ... after 1945."¹²⁶⁷ Indeed, as the State Department journal *Issues* asked in 1969, "if the United States ... had disengaged itself militarily from Europe,... what now would be the situation in the Mediterranean? The Middle East? South Asia? Africa?"¹²⁶⁸

One of the biggest questions debated by orthodox and revisionist historians was whether the United States could have avoided the Cold War by adopting a different policy on atomic weaponry. After the U.S. attacked Hiroshima and Nagasaki on August 6 and 9, 1945, Americans and their western Allies frequently justified it with counterfactuals. In a famous *Life Magazine* essay from 1947, Secretary of War Henry L. Stimson argued that without the bomb, the war "[would have] continued, [and] additional fire raids of B-29s would have been more destructive of life and property than the very limited number of atomic raids which we could have executed in the same period."¹²⁶⁹ Given the importance of "saving ... lives," Stimson concluded that "no man ... holding in his hands a weapon ... for accomplishing this purpose ... could have failed to use it."¹²⁷⁰ Around the same time, one of Stimson's atomic bomb consultants, the physicist Karl T. Compton, argued that "If the Atomic Bomb Had Not Been Used," the alternative plan for defeating Japan—an American naval invasion—might have cost "perhaps millions ... of lives," as the Japanese "would have kept fighting" American forces with guerrilla warfare."¹²⁷¹ Other



FIGURE 7.3 The liberal historian, Arthur Schlesinger Jr., rejected the claim of revisionist scholars that the U.S. could have prevented the cold war by making more concessions to the USSR. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

commentators insisted that the U.S. atomic attacks prevented the Cold War from being worse. As Winston Churchill argued in 1949, “it is certain that Europe would have been Communized like Czechoslovakia,... but for the deterrent of the atomic bomb in the hands of the United States.”¹²⁷² Finally, in 1965, historian Gaddis Smith defended “the men who decided to drop the bomb” as people who “acted conscientiously ... insofar as they were able,” adding that critics should ask themselves whether they “would have acted otherwise in the circumstances?”¹²⁷³

By contrast, revisionist historians insisted that history would have turned out better if the U.S. had not dropped the bombs.¹²⁷⁴ Drawing on the 1947 U.S.

Strategic Bombing Survey's conclusion that "prior to December 31, 1945, Japan would have surrendered, even if the atomic bombs had not been dropped," the rightwing revisionist Hanson Baldwin argued in 1950 that "a far more definite warning could have been given" by American military leaders to the Japanese, adding that "a target objective in Japan with ... sparse population could ... have been found."¹²⁷⁵ Leftwing revisionists echoed these points in the 1960s.¹²⁷⁶ Denna F. Fleming argued that "if we had refrained from using [the bomb]..., all other peoples, including the Russians, would have been under a moral compulsion not to use it. This presumption ... would have [helped]... control the use of atomic energy" (Figure 7.4).¹²⁷⁷ Others said the U.S. could have reduced East-West tensions if it had shared nuclear technology with the Soviets. Historian Lloyd Gardner, for example, wrote that if Churchill and Roosevelt had invited "the Russians ... to join in the effort to produce an atomic bomb,... [it] might have helped sweep away the growing accumulation of mutual suspicion."¹²⁷⁸

Historians further debated whether the Cold War would have unfolded differently had President Roosevelt not died in February of 1945. Writing in 1946, the chairman of the British Labor Party Harold J. Laski argued that "had [FDR]... lived,... the distrust between the Anglo-Saxon powers and Soviet Russia would never have been permitted to assume its present and unnecessary proportions."¹²⁷⁹ Writing in 1950, John Gunther cited Roosevelt's belief in his powers of persuasion to speculate that "if [the president]... had lived ... he would have gone to Moscow [to meet with Stalin]" and "the whole world might be in a far happier state than it is."¹²⁸⁰ In 1961, Denna F. Fleming agreed that "if Roosevelt had been able to finish his fourth term in the White House there would have been no Cold War," since "[his] friendship would have been a powerful influence in Moscow."¹²⁸¹ Finally, Arthur Schlesinger Jr. also endorsed the view "no other American could hope to have the restraining impact on Stalin which Roosevelt might ... have had."¹²⁸²

By contrast, more skeptical commentators argued that Roosevelt's survival would not have improved U.S.-Soviet relations. Hardline leftwing revisionists argued that a single individual like the president could hardly have prevailed over deeper capitalist imperatives after 1945. According to William Appleman Williams, there was "little evidence that Roosevelt seriously entertained ... abandon[ing] the ... [United States' longstanding] open door [foreign policy] and ... even if he personally had been on the verge of trying to do so, few of his advisors and subordinates had either the intention or the power to effect such a change."¹²⁸³ Historian Gabriel Kolko also dismissed the claim that America's "policy toward the postwar world ... could so easily have been reversed had



FIGURE 7.4 The leftwing historian, Denna F. Fleming, wished the U.S. had refrained from dropping the atomic bomb on Hiroshima in World War II. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

better individuals been in charge of policy,” arguing that “there was no other recourse for the United States” but to pursue the anticommunist project of “counterrevolution,” given that “the consequence of inaction might have been the unchallenged triumph of the Left in numerous countries.”¹²⁸⁴ Finally, John Lewis Gaddis noted that because “Roosevelt ... had been deeply concerned before his death over ... Russian violations of the Yalta agreement,” it was “unlikely that ... had he lived [he] would have continued” his policy of “open-handedness” toward the Soviets.”¹²⁸⁵

Despite their disagreements, members of the orthodox and revisionist schools partly saw the Cold War as unavoidable. Pointing to the Soviet Union’s ideological worldview and geopolitical needs after 1945, George Kennan declared that “little ... could have [been] done to alter ... the political personality of the Bolshevik leadership or ... moderate [their]... violent preconceptions

against Western democracy.”¹²⁸⁶ Arthur Schlesinger, Jr. agreed, noting that because of Stalin’s belief that “America was ... driven by the logic of its [capitalist] system to ... destroy Soviet Russia,” there was “nothing the United States could have done in 1944–45 [that] would have abolished this mistrust, required and sanctified as it was by Marxist gospel.”¹²⁸⁷ Leftwing revisionists, meanwhile, argued that the Soviet Union’s legitimate geopolitical needs made it impossible for them to cooperate with American capitalism. Writing in 1971, historian Robert Tucker said it was “difficult to imagine” what kind of alternative policy the Russians “might ... have followed ... [in] the immediate post-war years ... that would have given them a degree of security ... comparable to that enjoyed by the United States” that “would not [also] have incurred American hostility.”¹²⁸⁸ In the end, he concluded, “it seems ... implausible to assume that conflict ... could have been avoided.”¹²⁸⁹

Counterfactual Self-Reflexiveness

The debate about whether the Cold War could have been prevented prompted historians to reflect on the role of “what ifs” in assessing the conflict. While some scholars criticized counterfactuals as unverifiable and useless, others appreciated their analytical and didactic value.

Scholars in the orthodox camp argued there was no use wondering “what if?” because the Cold War had to happen as it did. In commenting in 1970 on claims that Roosevelt should have been tougher with Stalin at Yalta, the American journalist C.L. Sulzberger declared that “ex post facto conjecture is fruitless.”¹²⁹⁰ Similarly, in discussing whether the U.S. could have avoided dropping the atomic bombs on Japan, Gaddis Smith said there was “little profit in lingering too long over ... might-have-beens.”¹²⁹¹ Historian Herbert Feis, meanwhile, declared that “learning the secrets of unacted history” was tantamount to “groping” in the historical record for conclusions that were easily “disputable.”¹²⁹² Orthodox scholars took this position to defend the decisions of U.S. policymakers after 1945. Arguing that there was greater willingness in the U.S. than the USSR for a *modus vivendi* after World War II, Arthur Schlesinger, Jr. asked, “why does anyone suppose that any conceivable American policy [towards the Soviets] would have succeeded?” adding that that because of the USSR’s totalitarian, anti-capitalist orientation, “the Soviet dictatorship ... simply could not have survived such a collaboration” with the United States and thus bore the prime responsibility for the East-West conflict.¹²⁹³ John Lewis Gaddis similarly argued that because Stalin was a dictator who—unlike FDR

or Truman—could “modify” his policies “whenever it suited him to do so” regardless of public opinion, it was “unjust” for historians “to suggest ways in which the United States might have avoided ... a postwar confrontation with the Soviet Union ... [that] were not viable alternatives at the time.”¹²⁹⁴

By contrast, revisionist historians praised counterfactual reasoning while challenging historiographical orthodoxy. In discussing unrealized policy proposals considered by U.S. policymakers vis-à-vis the Soviets in the mid-1940s, William Appleman Williams affirmed that “might-have-been proposition[s]” could “help clarify the reason [why certain events]... did not occur.”¹²⁹⁵ Gar Alperovitz similarly noted that while “no one ... can be certain of “what might have been,” counterfactuals helped “refute ... accepted myth[s]” about American policymaking by showing “that mistakes made by American officials just after the war may well have prevented ... compromise.”¹²⁹⁶ Arguing from a rightwing revisionist standpoint, the sociologist George A. Lundberg admitted that while “any discussion of alternate policies” could “only be surmised,” it was still ... possible ... to marshal logical evidence that will satisfy most men of the probability that an alternative policy would have been preferable.”¹²⁹⁷ In showing how different decisions made by the U.S. “might have spared the world the worst moments of the Cold War,” Lloyd Gardner said that American policymakers bore a greater “responsibility for the way [it]... developed” because in 1945 they had ... far more options to influence the course of events than the Soviet Union, whose situation in victory was worse in some ways than that of the defeated countries.”¹²⁹⁸

In the end, many historians saw the Cold War as marked by tragedy. Arthur Schlesinger, Jr. put it well when he invoked W.H. Auden’s distinction between “Greek tragedy” and “Christian tragedy,” noting that the distinction was between “‘the tragedy of necessity,’ where the feeling aroused in the spectator is, ‘What a pity it had to be this way,’ and ‘the tragedy of possibility,’ where the feeling aroused is, ‘What a pity it was this way when it might have been otherwise.’” According to Schlesinger, Greek tragedy best described the East-West conflict, for as he explained, “the Cold War could have been avoided only if the Soviet Union had not been possessed by convictions both of the infallibility of the communist word and of the inevitability of a communist world.”¹²⁹⁹ Louis J. Halle made a similar point in arguing for the inevitability of postwar Soviet expansion into Eastern Europe after 1945, employing a leopard spot counterfactual to conclude that “history is like a Shakespearean tragedy. Hamlet need not have suffered the fate that befell him—but only if he had not been Hamlet.”¹³⁰⁰

Debating Counterfactuals

At the same time American and British scholars were speculating about the origins of the Cold War, they debated the suitability of counterfactuals in historical study more broadly. While some scholars endorsed counterfactuals as an antidote to deterministic and antidemocratic modes of thought, others rejected “what ifs” as inimical to genuine historical scholarship.

Welcoming “What Ifs”

One of the first postwar scholars to speak out in favor of counterfactuals was the eminent British historian G. M. Trevelyan. In his *Autobiography* (1949), Trevelyan argued that “what ifs” could help scholars pursue the important postwar task of examining the “origins of evil.” Although he saw this task as one of the main “functions of history,” Trevelyan conceded that “the mixture of good and evil in historical events is difficult to disentangle.”¹³⁰¹ To illustrate the difficulty, Trevelyan applied a silver lining counterfactual to the Norman Conquest, explaining that while the indigenous English population undeniably experienced the “evils of ... subjection” after the arrival of William the Conqueror, had the events of 1066 never happened, “there never would have been the plays of Shakespeare.”¹³⁰² Trevelyan also noted that while scholars had long mourned “the fall of the Roman Empire in the west,” the fact that the Empire’s “luxury ... rested on ... slavery” made it impossible to fantasize that “[the Empire might] have survived.”¹³⁰³

Trevelyan used these examples to reveal the value of counterfactual reasoning. As he explained, “the difficulty of forming judgments about the past is that every historical approval or condemnation ... is based on the assumption that if things had gone differently, they would have been better—or worse.” That said, Trevelyan acknowledged that it was precisely “this ... [outcome that] we can never find out.” Echoing earlier skeptics, Trevelyan declared that “the endlessly attractive game of speculating on the might-have-beens of history can never take us far with ... safety. For if one thing had been different, everything would thenceforth have been different—and in what way we cannot tell.”¹³⁰⁴ Trevelyan did not dismiss counterfactual speculation out of hand, however. Befitting his own embrace of “what ifs,” which dated back to his prize-winning 1907 essay about Napoleon, he ultimately endorsed historical speculation, provided it was done with care. Declaring that “each of us [may] have his opinions [about how the past might have been different],” Trevelyan recommended that they should be held “with a modest diffidence.”¹³⁰⁵



FIGURE 7.5 Herbert Butterfield endorsed the use of “what ifs” to counteract the perils of determinism.
(Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Trevelyan's eminent colleague Herbert Butterfield came to similar conclusions around the same time (Figure 7.5). In an essay entitled “The Dangers of History” (1951), he lamented how recent “wars and revolutions” had led historians to insert their “prejudices into [their] reconstructions of the past” and turn history into “propaganda.”¹³⁰⁶ To counteract this “ossified” form of history, Butterfield said historians needed to remove its “crust of error” and make history “liquid” with the use of counterfactuals.¹³⁰⁷ Historians had to do so carefully, however, for all too often, they were driven by “wishful thinking” and considered “only one alternative”—the one that supported their “prejudices”—and ignored the fact that “there [were]... a great many [alternatives]” to consider.¹³⁰⁸ Pointing to tendentious postwar British assessments of World War II, Butterfield argued that while “every Tom, Dick, and Harry in England can [imagine how they]... could easily have thwarted Hitler ... because [they]...

would have done *the other thing*," they failed to understand that "in such a case, a man like Hitler would ... have done something different, too, at the next remove."¹³⁰⁹

A few years later, Butterfield reiterated the importance of alternatives in an essay entitled "The Role of the Individual in History" (1955).¹³¹⁰ Like Sidney Hook, Butterfield stressed the role of individual action and contingency in historical events in order to counteract the perils of determinism. Arguing that "all of us [can]... recall occasions when our doing a trifle more or a trifle less ... had a magnified effect which we should never have calculated," Butterfield asserted that "the over-all course of historical development is capable of being switched into one of a myriad of alternative courses in accordance with what men decide at every moment of their lives."¹³¹¹ Here again, Butterfield cited the case of World War II, noting that "our victory ... [was] achieved by so small a margin that we hold our breath at the memory of the hairbreadth escape."¹³¹² As he concluded, "World history would have taken [a]... vastly different turn if [Hitler]... had been victorious."¹³¹³

Around the same time, the American philosopher Marie Collins Swabey took a similar stance in her book *The Judgment of History* (1954).¹³¹⁴ In a chapter entitled "Predictions and Might Have Been," she criticized the present-day efforts of "scientific" historians to offer "predictive" claims about the future, whether from a methodologically deterministic or politically presentist perspective.¹³¹⁵ Attributing this tendentious trend to "the world growth of socialism and its success in employing theories of history as tools of political action," Swabey noted that this "revolutionary" climate made it difficult for liberals to preserve their ideal of "impartiality."¹³¹⁶ To give them a weapon against historiographical "certainty," Swabey cited the benefits of counterfactuals. There was no better way to challenge communism's "oracular" belief that "dialectical laws" determined historical events, she argued, than by "imagining away'... key figures or conditions" and demonstrating that "without them the actual historical outcome would not have occurred." For instance, "if Lenin had not lived ... there would have been no USSR"¹³¹⁷ Swabey thereby echoed Max Weber's embrace of subtractive cause counterfactuals for establishing the "causal weight" of different factors. Like Weber, Swabey also rejected additive effect counterfactuals, noting that "imaginary experiments which ask: *if what happened had not happened, how then would things be?* make a travesty of scientific prediction."¹³¹⁸ Yet while Swabey's endorsement of counterfactuals was qualified, she ultimately believed they could affirm "the truth of history" independent of "instrumental ... modes of manipulation."¹³¹⁹

Taking a similar position was the eminent philosopher Isaiah Berlin. In his book *Inevitability in History* (1957), Berlin expanded on the argument of



FIGURE 7.6 Isaiah Berlin believed counterfactuals offered a healthy corrective to the “Moloch” of “historical inevitability.” (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Bernard Berenson’s *Wartime and Reflection* by endorsing the “accidental view of history” as a healthy corrective to the “Moloch” of “historical inevitability” (Figure 7.6).¹³²⁰ Like Berenson, Berlin opposed the deterministic notion that history was guided by “impersonal ... forces,” such as “race, class, [and] culture,” partly because of World War II. An Eastern European Jew who had migrated to England in the early 1920s, Berlin had safely assimilated into British society but lost several close family members in the Nazi Holocaust.¹³²¹ Berlin thus opposed the deterministic insistence that “nothing can be otherwise than as it is,” arguing that such a belief negated “the notions of responsibility or guilt, of right and wrong.”¹³²² It was unacceptable, Berlin noted, to compare “Hitler” to a “flood ... [or] earthquake,” because such a fatalistic viewpoint denied that the Nazi dictator “could have acted otherwise” and failed to subject him to historical judgment.¹³²³ To counteract these perils, Berlin sought to restore choice

to historical analysis with the aid of counterfactuals. In order to arrive at “historical ... justice,” he proclaimed, scholars had to evaluate “what occurred [in the past]... in the context of what could have happened.”¹³²⁴ Only by recognizing “the reality of human choices” could there be valid “discussions ... about whether a given policy could or could not have been prevented and what view should therefore be taken of the acts ... of the actors.” Counterfactuals were thus essential for drawing conclusions about morality and causality in history. As Berlin wrote, “the very meaning” of [the word]... cause ... depends on the possibility of contrasting [it with its]... imaginary opposite.”¹³²⁵ The history of what happened could only be fully understood with an awareness of what had not.

The final, and perhaps most significant, scholar to praise the utility of counterfactuals in the early postwar period was the British historian Arnold Toynbee (Figure 7.7). Regarded after 1945 as one of the greatest living historians by virtue of his massive, twelve-volume text *A Study of History* (1934–1961), Toynbee lent newfound credibility to counterfactual reasoning in 1961 when he published a high-profile essay in *The New York Times Magazine*, entitled “Some Great Ifs of History.”¹³²⁶ In this essay, and throughout Volume 12 of *A Study of History*, which appeared the same year, Toynbee praised “what ifs” for counteracting the deterministic thrust of modern political movements.¹³²⁷ Like Isaiah Berlin, Toynbee vehemently opposed rightwing nationalism, especially its “Fascist ... and Nazi ... extremes,” and also rejected “the pretension of Communism to be a unique discovery of the truth about Reality.”¹³²⁸ Unlike his liberal contemporaries, however, Toynbee also indicted the broader western tradition. Citing a long list of “Western atrocities,” from “the Crusades” to the “French war of repression ... in Algeria,” Toynbee attacked “the pretensions of western civilization to be ... the only civilization truly worthy of the name.”¹³²⁹ He also blamed the west for sparking the Cold War and producing “the spirit that has led the United States and the Soviet Union [to]... risk ... committing genocide and making ... this planet uninhabitable.”¹³³⁰ In taking this position, Toynbee anticipated the postmodern attack on western “metanarratives,” but his critique came from the alienated Christian right, not the New Left.¹³³¹ Indeed, his solution to the west’s crisis—the metaphysical restoration of mankind’s spiritual and political “unity”—was highly idiosyncratic.¹³³²

That said, Toynbee resembled his liberal contemporaries by advancing his critique with counterfactuals. To challenge western pretensions to greatness, Toynbee followed in the tradition of Jacob Burckhardt and used “what ifs” to expose the ironies of western history. Throughout his *Study of History*, Toynbee recast counterfactual nightmares as fantasies. For instance, he rejected the time-honored belief that an Athenian defeat by the Persians in the 5th century BCE would have been a disaster for Greek and Western civilization, arguing



FIGURE 7.7 Arnold Toynbee followed in the tradition of Jacob Burckhardt by using “what ifs” to expose the ironies of western history. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

that “if unity ... had been imposed upon them by the Persians” it “would have spared the Hellenes ... four and half centuries of tribulation between ... Darius and ... Augustus.”¹³³³ Toynbee also speculated that if Alexander the Great “had ... not died young, he might have politically united the world,” adding that there would then be “no nuclear Sword of Damocles hanging over our heads [today].”¹³³⁴

In addition to using “what ifs” critically, Toynbee also used them affirmatively to illustrate the “interrelation of human events in all times and places.”¹³³⁵ Eager to show how recent events could have distant origins, Toynbee devoted part of his 1961 essay “Some Great Ifs of History” to examining how the western allies might have stopped Nazi Germany from launching World War II. After floating the possibility that this goal could have been achieved if the U.S. had

supported a firmer Anglo-French response to the German reoccupation of the Rhineland in 1936, Toynbee noted that for this to have occurred, the U.S. would have first had to join the League of Nations in 1919, which, in turn, would have required American leaders to not have feared “foreign entanglements” since George Washington became president in 1789. Like Marc Bloch, Toynbee sought to show that “what ifs” could identify different levels of causation, from the immediate to the distant. Yet, Toynbee was more explicit than Bloch in recommending the utility of counterfactuals, concluding: “If, if, if: the series of ‘if’s’ seems often to stretch away and away into the past. Yet if one perseveres in tracing the series backward, one usually comes ... to a choice that was genuinely open and was at the same time truly decisive in its effect on what happened after.” Like Berlin, Toynbee concluded that because of choice, “human freedom is a reality.”¹³³⁶

Critiquing Counterfactuals in the Early Postwar Era

Despite these important endorsements, opposition to “what ifs” persisted in Anglo-American culture after 1945. Journalists and scholars often expressed their reservations in the context of Cold War concerns. In discussing the Hungarian revolt of 1956 against the USSR, for example, the British-based Hungarian writer George Paloczi-Horvath wondered what would have happened “had Khrushchev ... [placed] Imre Nagy” in power instead of “the hated Ernő Gerő” following the removal of the hated dictator Mátyás Rákosi, before declaring “it is better to exclude ifs from a historical chronicle.”¹³³⁷ In a 1957 book discussing whether the Chinese communist party would have become powerful had it not assumed a strong anti-Japanese stance during World War II, historian Malcolm D. Kennedy asserted that the “*Ifs* of history” were “*futile and sterile*.”¹³³⁸ Finally, a 1964 *Life* Magazine editorial speculated whether Douglas MacArthur should have lobbied President Truman to escalate the conflict with the USSR in the Korean peninsula before concluding that “the question turns on the unresolvable ifs of history.”¹³³⁹

Among the many opponents of counterfactuals in the early postwar period, one of the best-known was the British historian Edward Hallett Carr (Figure 7.8). In his classic book *What Is History?* (1961), Carr categorically dismissed historical speculation with several observations that have since been cited by countless critics of counterfactual history. The most notable was Carr’s snide claim that “one can always play a parlour game with the might-have-beens of history.”¹³⁴⁰ In offering this opinion, Carr smeared historical speculation as an unserious activity for professional historians. Continuing his assault, Carr wrote that scholars who embraced the “might-have-been school of thought”



FIGURE 7.8 Edward Hallett Carr's book, *What Is History?* (1961), famously dismissed the use of "might-have-beens" as a "parlour-game." (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

were engaging in a practice that had "[nothing] to do with history."¹³⁴¹ The historian's true task, Carr asserted, was to embrace determinism and "discover ... the causes of historical events and the laws that govern them." The true task was to accept that "everything that happens has a cause and could not have happened differently unless something in the cause or causes had also been different."¹³⁴²

Carr accused several historians of undermining this belief. He criticized Isaiah Berlin's claim in his book *Historical Inevitability* that determinism robbed people of their free will. He also attacked J.B. Bury for stressing the importance of chance, contingency, and accident in history. Dismissing what he called the "Cleopatra's Nose" theory of history—a direct jab at Bury's 1916

essay by the same name—Carr wrote that accidents could not “enter into any rational interpretation of history” because they could not be factored into “the historian’s hierarchy of significant causes” and “[could thus] not be generalized.” As he declared, “it makes no sense as a general proposition to say that generals lose battles because they are infatuated with beautiful queens.”¹³⁴³ The “only proper way” for the historian to narrate events was to recognize that “what happened was bound to happen,” and to avoid discussing any “alternative possibility” that might question the event’s “inevitability.”¹³⁴⁴

Many scholars have cited Carr’s dismissal of historical speculation as authoritative, but few have situated it in the larger context of cold war politics.¹³⁴⁵ In many ways, Carr’s critique of free will and defense of determinism mirrored the postwar rivalry between western liberal democracy and Soviet communism. Notably enough, Carr wrote *What Is History?* not merely for methodological but also for political reasons. Although Carr was not a Marxist, his scholarship on Soviet history—especially his multi-volume study, *A History of Soviet Russia* (1950–1978)—was marked by a structural focus on economic issues and an apologetic tendency to see Stalin’s dictatorship as necessary for the USSR’s survival. For liberal critics, Carr’s non-judgmental perspective toward the violence of Soviet history made it appear morally suspect and pro-Soviet. Isaiah Berlin, for instance, attacked the first several volumes of Carr’s *History*, which focused on the Bolshevik Revolution, for apologetically describing the event as the result of “inexorable laws” of history that helped Russia progress into the modern era.¹³⁴⁶ Carr, in fact, displayed a strong teleological orientation in his work and believed that historians should judge events based on whether they advanced or delayed progress.¹³⁴⁷ “Success” was thus the chief objective. For this reason, Carr said that history should always be viewed as the “record of what people did, not of what they failed to do.”¹³⁴⁸

Carr’s critique of counterfactuals included important insights. He perceptively noted that historians throughout the ages had embraced the idea of chance and wondered “what if?” in times of crisis. Whether referring to Polybius, who was writing when “Greece had been reduced to a province ... of Rome,” Tacitus, who chronicled “the decay of his country,” or Bury, who worked “in a mood of uncertainty ... after 1914,” Carr noted that in eras of decline, historians emphasized “the contingent and unforeseen.”¹³⁴⁹ Based on these and other examples, Carr went on to posit the bold (if mistaken) hypothesis that counterfactual speculation “attaches itself almost exclusively to contemporary history.” To bolster this hypothesis, Carr pointed to a recent lecture held at Cambridge University, entitled “Was the Russian Revolution Inevitable?,” and observed that such hypothetical phrasing would never be attached to an older event and give rise to a title, such as “Were the Wars of the Roses

Inevitable?"¹³⁵⁰ The reason why the Bolshevik revolution inspired such a meta-historical question, Carr theorized, reflected its ability to evoke "emotion[s]" among people who had "suffered ... from the results of the Bolshevik victory ... and [who] desire to ... protest against it ... [by] letting their imagination run riot on all the more agreeable things that might have happened."¹³⁵¹

Having discerned this "hidden motive" behind "what ifs," Carr arrived at several additional conclusions. The first was that counterfactuals flourished in nations that were "riding in the trough, not on the crest, of historical events."¹³⁵² History's losers were more likely to wonder "what if?" than history's winners. Yet while Carr understood how historical speculation made emotional sense, he viewed it as a dead end. Not only was it "unhistorical," it was a "red her-ring" that diverted historians from their mission of "quietly ... explaining what did happen and why."¹³⁵³ Finally, Carr offered a third, and blatantly *ad hominem*, critique of counterfactuals, writing that those who saw "history [as] a chapter of accidents" suffered from "intellectual laziness" and "low intellectual vitality."¹³⁵⁴

Carr's book was reviewed widely in the Anglo-American press, but most critics overlooked his comments on counterfactuals.¹³⁵⁵ The major exception was a blistering review written in 1962 by the British historian Hugh Trevor-Roper that emphatically endorsed "what ifs" (Figure 7.9).¹³⁵⁶ According to Trevor-Roper, Carr was wrong that the only people who used counterfactuals were those who "want[ed] to undo history"—namely, its losers.¹³⁵⁷ Blinded by his deterministic belief that history was "inevitably a success-story," Carr failed to see the analytical utility of "might-have-beens." As Trevor-Roper pointed out, when historians sought to answer the question, "why?", they needed to "consider ... alternatives." "Whoever presumes to state the cause of an event," he declared, "is *ipso facto* stating what would not have happened in the absence of that cause."¹³⁵⁸ Trevor-Roper cited concrete examples from Carr's scholarship—as well as from his own—to illustrate the importance of contemplating what might have been. He accused Carr of deterministic hubris for arguing in his book *The Soviet Impact on the Western World* (1946) that "the overthrow of feudalism and the victory of bourgeois democracy in England and ... France *could never* ... have been achieved except by way of the Cromwellian and Jacobin dictatorships," insisting that this argument "exclude[d] all alternative explanations." Pointing to his own research, Trevor-Roper countered that "the overthrow of feudalism and the victory of bourgeois democracy could have been achieved in several other ways." As he put it, "an historian who skips over the alternative possibilities ... must seriously misjudge historical ... events."¹³⁵⁹

Trevor-Roper also advanced a political critique of Carr. Expressing liberal fears of rightwing and leftwing totalitarianism, Trevor-Roper said Carr's



FIGURE 7.9 Hugh Trevor-Roper criticized E. H. Carr for dismissing the use of counterfactuals, saying it was crucial for historians to consider “alternative possibilities” when they examined the past. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

deterministic claim that history should be a story of “success” had antidemocratic implications. As he argued:

Suppose that, in the 1930s, [Carr]... had written a history of Germany, ‘objective’... according to the [era’s]... standard ... and disregarding the might-have-beens of history. I have no doubt that it would have been ... acute in analysis ... [but] I wonder how ... it would have appeared to us now, when the Nazi success-story has ended in ... failure.

Trevor-Roper flagged a similar problem with Carr’s *History of Soviet Russia*, which by “identif[ying]... with the victorious cause,” ended up ignoring the

Bolshevik Revolution's "victims" and all the "might-have beens." Saying that "no historian since the crudest ages of clerical bigotry has treated evidence with such dogmatic ruthlessness," Trevor-Roper declared that historians "must study ... alternatives."¹³⁶⁰ Only those who studied "the critics ... [who] backed the wrong horse" and had their "voices ... silenced with contempt" could see the past see objectively.¹³⁶¹

Cliometric Counterfactuals and the New Economic History

The exchange between Carr and Trevor-Roper was not the only instance when postwar historians debated the merits of counterfactual history. Around the same time, a second debate erupted about economic history. This debate, however, unfolded with different terminology. Thanks to a new concept imported from the field of philosophy, the debate over "might-have-beens" evolved into a debate about "counterfactuals."

The concept of a "counterfactual" originally emerged in the field of analytic philosophy.¹³⁶² First coined in 1947 by the American philosopher Nelson Goodman, in an essay entitled "The Problem of Counterfactual Conditionals," the term was originally conceived as a method of tackling broader questions of logic and causality, especially the relationship between antecedents and consequents.¹³⁶³ Goodman devoted no attention in his essay to the relevance of counterfactuals for history, however, and in the decades that followed, most philosophers followed suit by applying counterfactuals only to matters of formal logic.¹³⁶⁴ One exception to this trend was provided by the philosopher Walter Fales who, in a 1951 essay on "historical facts," coined the concept of a "historical counterfactual." Yet, while Fales defended "'what if' and 'what-if-not' judgments" as "neither meaningless nor pointless," he did not develop his thoughts in any systematic fashion.¹³⁶⁵ The same was true of subsequent philosophical studies, such as David K. Lewis's book *Counterfactuals* (1973), which addressed questions of logic and skirted over questions of history.¹³⁶⁶

Over time, however, the term "counterfactual" migrated from philosophy into history. An important step in this process was the publication of the American philosopher Paul Weiss's book, *History: Written and Lived* (1962) (Figure 7.10).¹³⁶⁷ Published one year after Carr's *What Is History?*, Weiss's book took a more positive view of historical speculation. Unlike Goodman, Weiss was a continental philosopher oriented towards metaphysics, but he employed a very similar concept, "contrary-to-fact conditionals," throughout his study.¹³⁶⁸ Influenced by Pascal's concept of Cleopatra's Nose, and Arnold Toynbee's counterfactual reflections in *A Study of History*, Weiss agreed that "the historian often makes use of contrary-to-fact conditionals, remarking on

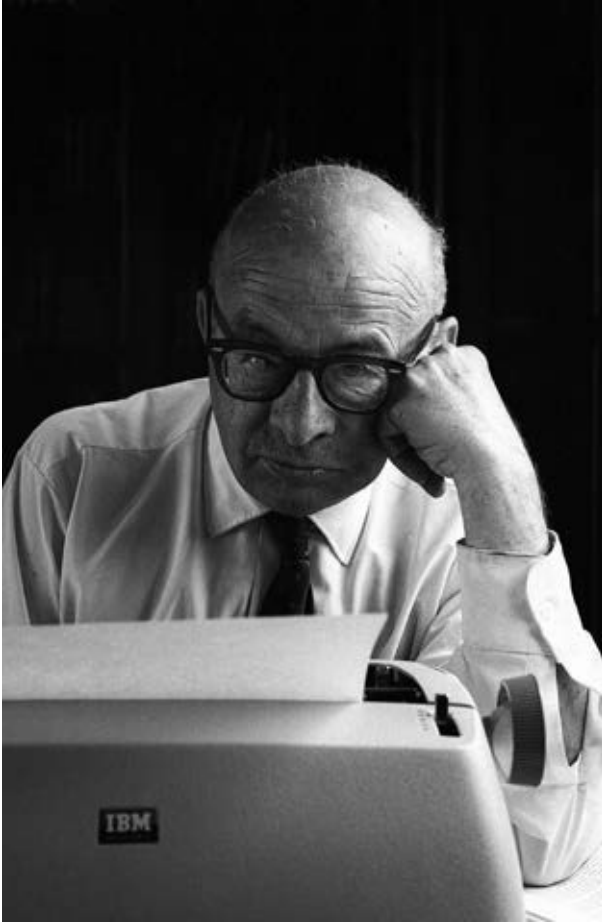


FIGURE 7.10 In his book, *History: Written and Lived* (1962), Paul Weiss embraced “contrary-to-fact conditionals” to better understand historical causality. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

what might have happened if causes, which did not occur, had operated.”¹³⁶⁹ In making this claim, Weiss sought to resolve larger questions of causality. Like Isaiah Berlin and other scholars in the 1950s, he opposed determinism and argued that a “sound motive for studying history cannot be a desire to know laws.”¹³⁷⁰ Weiss was also concerned with questions of historical judgment. Arguing that judging the past was a precondition for imagining an ideal future, Weiss used the term “contrary-to-fact conditionals” alongside another neologism, the “*ought-to-be*,” to describe “what might have been achieved” in

any historical era.¹³⁷¹ Because “there are no unrealizable historic possibilities,” Weiss argued, the “historic ought-to-be” could help determine whether “any part of the past ... is ... as good as it might have been” and thereby reveal history’s “blunders and successes.”¹³⁷²

Like Berlin, Weiss was a Jewish scholar whose views were shaped by the Holocaust. In explaining the importance of “constructing contrary-to-fact conditionals,” he tellingly explored counterfactual questions about the Nazi era, asking “[if] there [had] been ... no Nazi Germany” whether “there would have been no Israel,” and whether “Israel would nevertheless have come about ... as it did.”¹³⁷³ In the end, Weiss believed that all history was determined by a metaphysical telos, by an “absolute Ideal,” which he also defined—like Toynbee—as total human unity. Arguing that “men ... should not be broken up into factions but should ... live in peace,” he concluded that “Only by submitting to God can ... man acquire a true worth.”¹³⁷⁴

Following Weiss’s metaphysical meditation, counterfactuals found their main home in the field of economic history. Beginning in the late 1950s, “what if” reasoning was embraced by economic historians associated with the “New Economic History.”¹³⁷⁵ Influenced by Carl Hempel’s famous 1942 essay, “The Function of General Laws in History,” the new economic history was known for the methodological development known as “cliometrics,” which sought to apply “econometrics”—economic theory, mathematical methods, and computer technology—to the study of history. Highly quantitative in orientation, it pursued scientific objectivity to transform history into a social science. In this effort, counterfactual reasoning proved enormously helpful.

The first major studies to employ cliometric counterfactuals were produced by the American economists Alfred H. Conrad and John R. Meyer.¹³⁷⁶ In a 1957 article, entitled “Economic Theory, Statistical Inference, and Economic History,” they argued that statistical methods could test the validity of such unverifiable questions as “If the Civil War had not occurred, [would] the South ... have abolished Negro slavery in an orderly fashion within one generation [?]”¹³⁷⁷ Conrad and Meyer’s essay provided early methodological grounding for cliometric counterfactuals and paved the way for their next essay entitled “The Economics of Slavery in the Antebellum South” (1958).¹³⁷⁸ In it, they took up the question, first floated after the Civil War, whether “without external intervention, slavery would have toppled of its own weight.”¹³⁷⁹ Employing a range of statistical methods, Conrad and Meyer found that “slavery was profitable” and would therefore have persisted without the Civil War.¹³⁸⁰

In the 1960s, cliometric counterfactuals found further expression in the pioneering work of the American economic historian Robert Fogel (Figure 7.11). In his 1964 study *Railroads and American Economic Growth*, Fogel tested the



FIGURE 7.11 Robert Fogel used “cliometric” counterfactuals to examine how the United States’s economic growth in the 19th century would have unfolded without railroads. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

belief that railroads had been an “indispensable” factor for U.S. economic productivity by generating mathematical models that projected how the country’s growth would have unfolded without the railroads.¹³⁸¹ As he made clear in his introduction, counterfactual methods could be used to refute the nineteenth-century claim that “if ... railways had not been invented ... what we now style the Great West would be ... an ... unproductive wilderness.”¹³⁸² In challenging this pessimistic scenario, Fogel focused on agricultural transport costs in the year 1890 and projected how using canals instead of railroads to transport goods would have affected the nation’s overall prosperity. After

extensive number crunching, Fogel determined that there would have been little change, declaring that “the absence of the interregional railroad would have retarded the development of the economy by about three months” and amounted to less than “1 percent of gross national product.”¹³⁸³ Counterfactual reasoning thus suggested the importance of railroads was overstated.

A decade later, Fogel collaborated with the American historian Stanley Engerman in a second book, *Time on the Cross* (1974), that applied cliometric methods to the topic of slavery.¹³⁸⁴ Following in the tradition of Conrad and Meyer, they determined that slavery made Southern agriculture more productive than Northern agriculture, and counterfactually speculated that the population of enslaved persons in the U.S. was larger than it would have been had they been treated as badly as enslaved persons were in other countries.¹³⁸⁵ Beyond pointing to this “positive demographic experience,” Fogel and Engerman declared that the paternalistic treatment of enslaved persons by slaveowners may have “raise[d] profits by inducing labor to be more efficient than it would have been under a less benevolent management.”¹³⁸⁶ Because of these findings, Fogel and Engerman rejected the counterfactual claim of scholars “that slavery would have been extinguished ... in the absence of a Civil War because of the natural geographic limits to which the cotton culture was confined,” noting that the extension of cotton production to new lands meant that “the price of slaves would have risen” and slavery would have survived.¹³⁸⁷

Scholars during this period also used counterfactuals to examine the economic development of many other countries.¹³⁸⁸ In discussing Stalin’s brutal development policies in the Soviet Union during the 1930s, for example, economist Alec Nove’s 1964 book *Economic Rationality and Soviet Politics: Or Was Stalin Really Necessary?* declared that any “available alternatives” for Soviet communist leaders “could not have [been] chosen ... because they were Communists,” while historian Holland Hunter replied that “Bolshevik objectives might have been achieved without the Draconian methods that Stalin used.”¹³⁸⁹ Similarly, in debating how African nations might have developed in the absence of colonial rule, the Guyanese historian Walter Rodney’s book *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa* (1972) suggested that without “generalized slave trading across the whole belt of central Africa,” Africans could have prospered by “selling copper ... instead of captives,” while L.H. Gann and Peter Duignan’s book *Burden of Empire* (1967) claimed “home rule would ... have made [little]... difference” for Africa’s development, let alone reverse its “social and economic backwardness.”¹³⁹⁰

Between the mid-1960s and the end of the 1970s, the work of the New Economic Historians sparked prolonged debate about counterfactual reasoning.¹³⁹¹ In 1965, the Harvard economic historian Fritz Redlich targeted Fogel’s

use of counterfactuals by saying they were “neither verifiable nor falsifiable,” arguing that by investigating “what would have happened in the event that something else had happened which could not have happened,” Fogel “did not produce history, [but]... quasi history.”¹³⁹² Later critics focused on Fogel’s effort to assign empirical validity to what were essentially additive effect counterfactuals. In 1968, historian E.H. Hunt declared that the “attempt to measure what might have happened” was impossible, noting that since “no variable exists in a vacuum,” removing one from a causal sequence meant “the course of all the others might be affected.” For this reason, he concluded, counterfactual projections were based on “highly subjective guesswork.”¹³⁹³

Marxist-oriented scholars were especially critical of counterfactuals. In 1970, the American historian Eugene Genovese rejected Fogel’s claim that historians often employed “counterfactual conditional analysis” by saying, “No, they don’t—at least not while sober.”¹³⁹⁴ In 1974, the African-American historian John Blassingame criticized Fogel and Engerman’s *Time on the Cross* by calling the authors “practitioners of an anachronistic and thoroughly discredited form of historical inquiry known as the ‘counterfactual’ approach.”¹³⁹⁵ In his book *The Poverty of Theory* (1978), the English historian E.P. Thompson attacked “counterfactual fictions” as “unhistorical shit” (*Geschichtenscheissenschlopf*).¹³⁹⁶ Finally, the English historian Eric Hobsbawm rejected “the assumption that we can ... calculate how different the history of the world would have been if Cleopatra’s nose had been an inch longer,” proclaiming “History is what happened, not what might have happened” (Figure 7.12).¹³⁹⁷

The strongest critique of counterfactuals appeared in the liberal historian David Hackett Fischer’s book *Historians’ Fallacies: Toward a Logic of Historical Thought* (1970).¹³⁹⁸ Like Carr a decade earlier, and Croce in the 1930s, Fischer feared that the anti-determinist hostility to “scientific history” after 1945 reflected a wave of “historical relativism” with worrisome links to interwar totalitarianism.¹³⁹⁹ In the effort to combat these trends and establish a “logic of historical thought,” Fischer sought to debunk the many methodological “fallacies” that historians often fell victim to.¹⁴⁰⁰ Two in particular had relevance for “what ifs.” One was the “fallacy of metaphysical questions”—for example, “Was the [Civil] War inevitable?”—which, for Fischer, was one of many questions that had “distracted many generations of historians” into wasting time debating the relative importance of “determinism versus voluntarism.”¹⁴⁰¹ Another was the “fallacy of fictional questions,” such as: “Could Lincoln have succeeded where Johnson failed?”, which Fischer termed “an ancient form of error” that experienced a revival in the 1930s with the publication of Squire’s volume *If, or History Rewritten* (1931).¹⁴⁰² Both fallacies, according to Fischer, informed the efforts of the cliometric historian, who in trying to combine



FIGURE 7.12 In 1974, Eric Hobsbawm flatly asserted that “history is what happened, not what might have happened.” (Source: Alamy)

“counterfactual’... questions ... with techniques of empirical quantification,” had produced “results [that] are not merely false but absurd.” Fogel was especially guilty of such fallacies, Fischer argued, saying that his book *Railroads and Economic Growth* “might have been called *If, or History Derailed*,” for in it, “History is run off the rails in more senses than one.”¹⁴⁰³

In response, scholars defended the value of cliometric counterfactuals. Fogel himself argued in 1966 that he merely took a longstanding mode of analysis in economic history and made it explicit. Noting that “the old economic history abounds in disguised counterfactual assertions”—for example, in “essays which argue that slavery retarded the development of the South”—Fogel said

he was merely interested in “testing” the “counterfactual propositions” that were usually found “in traditional history.”¹⁴⁰⁴ Other scholars made similar arguments. Philosopher Jon Elster called Fogel’s *Railroads* book the “most ambitious attempt at wholesale counterfactualization ever undertaken by a serious historian.”¹⁴⁰⁵ Arguing more broadly, economist George G. S. Murphy said scholars could not ignore “the simple fact ... that we cannot judge any economic policy without counterfactuals.”¹⁴⁰⁶ Historian Alexander Gerschenkron said counterfactuals should be endorsed as long as they were used “with discretion and moderation.”¹⁴⁰⁷ Elsewhere, economist Douglas C. North wrote that “the counterfactual proposition is essential in historical inquiry.”¹⁴⁰⁸

As in earlier debates, no consensus emerged about the value of cliometric counterfactuals, and by the early 1980s, the debate died down. With the rise of postmodernism and the incipient “cultural turn” in western historiography, the scientific pretensions of cliometric counterfactuals rendered them passé. Indeed, in 1983, the appearance of a satirical essay by the American economist R. Preston McAfee, in the *American Economic Review*, suggested that counterfactuals had become ripe for parody. Entitled “American Economic Growth and the Voyage of Columbus,” the article spoofed the quantitative methods of the New Economic History by explaining how an innovative “Fractured Reconstructive Autoerotic Projection Package with Econometrization (FRAPPE)” could be mobilized to “compare America as it will be in the year 2000 to the way it would have been ... had Columbus fallen off the edge [of the earth].”¹⁴⁰⁹ After presenting several paragraphs of what would have happened “following Columbus’s demise”—including the “relocation of Australia to “the edge of the earth roughly 1,000 miles off Brittany”—McAfee used a stasis counterfactual to conclude: “whether or not Columbus discovered America, the United States would have been relatively unchanged. Thus, America is invincible to tinkering with history to a degree heretofore unsuspected.”¹⁴¹⁰

What’s in a Name? Mainstreaming the Concept of “Counterfactual History”

While McAfee’s parody suggested that cliometric counterfactuals had peaked by the early 1980s, counterfactual history was, in fact, gaining more mainstream acceptance. During this period, speculative reasoning moved beyond economic history into other areas of historical scholarship. Although older terms for historical speculation continued to circulate in popular and scholarly discourse, the term “counterfactual” gained new appeal among historians.

Prior to the 1980s, numerous phrases were used to describe the act of historical speculation. In a 1965 essay on the close calls of the Cuban Missile

Crisis, journalist Eric Sevareid referred to American's fascination with "the might-have-beens of history."¹⁴¹¹ During the 100th anniversary commemorations of the Civil War in the early 1960s, other writers referred to the "'ifs' of history" in discussing how certain battles might have easily turned out otherwise.¹⁴¹² In his introduction to a new edition of J. C. Squire's *If It Had Happened Otherwise* (1972), historian John Wheeler-Bennett embraced the phrase "imaginary history."¹⁴¹³ While these references had deep roots in western discourse, new phrases also appeared, including "iffy history," "hypothetical history," and "conditional history."¹⁴¹⁴ Some commentators, finally, began using "alternate history" to describe counterfactual novels and short stories. Yet while all these terms circulated alongside "counterfactual history," none gained dominance in mainstream parlance prior to the 1980s.

This terminological pluralism was reflected in one the era's most important statements on counterfactual history, Hugh R. Trevor-Roper's 1980 essay, "History and Imagination."¹⁴¹⁵ First delivered as valedictory address to mark his retirement from Oxford, Trevor-Roper used the essay to revisit his debate with Carr two decades earlier and defend the value of counterfactual history. Like other postwar liberals, Trevor-Roper cited the close calls of the Second World War—especially the possibility that "an accident ... could have put [Hitler]... in a position to conquer the world"—to attack Carr's demand that historians should narrate the past "as if what happened was ... bound to happen" and should avoid "might-have-beens" as a mere "parlour-game." Arguing that "at any given moment of history, there are real alternatives," Trevor-Roper insisted that "we must leave some room for the imagination," noting that without doing so, history would become "a dogmatic scheme." He punctuated his argument by delivering a memorable maxim to guide the work of future historians, declaring: "History is not merely what happened: it is what happened in the context of what might have happened."¹⁴¹⁶

A striking and highly ironic feature of Trevor-Roper's essay was his failure to employ the term "counterfactual history." Puzzling at first glance, this omission reflected the term's enduring associations with economic history.¹⁴¹⁷ Throughout the 1980s, many scholars continued to see the two fields as linked. In his 1981 book *The Past and the Present*, the English historian Lawrence Stone associated counterfactual history directly with the New Economic History, before concluding that the former did not having "much practical use [for]... historians."¹⁴¹⁸ As late as 1989, the historian D.C.M. Platt described "counterfactual history" as coterminous with "cliometrics."¹⁴¹⁹ Trevor-Roper's avoidance of the term may have reflected his reluctance to be pigeonholed in a small and controversial subfield of historical scholarship.

However, at the same time Trevor-Roper shunned the concept of “counterfactual history,” other historians were embracing it. Most did so to lend credibility to their own speculative claims. Even though cliometrics had been widely criticized, its quantitative character lent empirical heft to the practice of historical speculation. In a 1977 *Boston Globe* op-ed about how history might have been different if John F. Kennedy had not been assassinated, Arthur Schlesinger, Jr., justified his musings by saying that “avant-garde economic historians make much use of ‘counterfactual propositions.’”¹⁴²⁰ Other scholars made similar arguments in more extended fashion. In 1973, the American historian John Murrin’s essay “The French and Indian War, The American Revolution, and the Counterfactual Hypothesis” applied the cliometric method to a political rather than an economic question—whether “the Canada cession outweighed the Stamp Act ... as a cause of the Revolution”—by “systematically,” rather than “haphazardly,” exploring whether a French defeat of England in the war of 1757–63 might have prevented the eruption of the American Revolution.¹⁴²¹ In 1978, the American historian David Donald argued in his book *Liberty and Union* that to fully understand the Era of Reconstruction between 1865 and 1877, it helped to “invent ... a little counterfactual history” and explore “conceivable historical scenarios that were never acted out” after the Civil War, such as a harsher Northern occupation of the South.¹⁴²² In 1987, American historian James Axtell’s essay “Colonial America Without the Indians: Counterfactual Reflections” underscored the “indispensability [of Native Americans] for understanding America’s past” by subtracting them from U.S. history to imagine how the latter would have been different.¹⁴²³

European historians also explored counterfactual scenarios. In a 1976 essay examining Spain’s 1588 attack against Britain, entitled “If the Armada Had Landed,” Geoffrey Parker refuted E.H. Carr’s claim that “might-have-beens” were a “parlour game” by arguing that “a counterfactual ... is essential when the historian wishes to assess the feasibility of a ... policy, especially ...[where]... the balance between success and failure is precarious.”¹⁴²⁴ A few years later, the Italian historian Arnaldo Momigliano’s 1981 essay, “After Gibbon’s ‘Decline and Fall,’” examined how Sir Edward Gibbon’s *Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire* would have been received had it been published closer to the French than the American Revolution, declaring that “hypothetical history has once again become respectable, under the name of counterfactual history.”¹⁴²⁵ In his 1987 book, *The Fall of the Athenian Empire*, the ancient historian Donald Kagan explained his interest in examining “what might have happened ... or what is sometimes called ‘counterfactual history’” by citing the example of Thucydides, “who engage[d]... in this practice very frequently and more openly

than most.”¹⁴²⁶ Around the same time, historians in Germany and France began using the term “counterfactual” to speculate about various historical topics.¹⁴²⁷

Despite this growing acceptance, however, criticism persisted. In a 1978 review of Barrington Moore’s book *Injustice*, Eric Hobsbawm noted how the author failed to resolve much about the “obscure and confused debate on ‘counterfactual history.’”¹⁴²⁸ In 1981, a reviewer of historian Gunter Lewy’s book *America in Vietnam* said the study was marred by the “deplorably fashionable ... obsession with counter-factual history.”¹⁴²⁹ A 1977 article on Martin Luther King, Jr. admitted that it was “tempting to ask what [he]... would have been without the SCLC” but ultimately concluded that “counterfactuals lead to nothing.”¹⁴³⁰ Thanks to these and other criticisms, the term “counterfactual” acquired negative connotations. In 1979, a curmudgeonly journalist dismissed the term as an example of linguistic “bafflegab”—a new trend in which people used “nonsense words” as “armor against understanding”—and insisted that the phrase, “counterfactual propositions” was a euphemism for “lies.”¹⁴³¹ A few years later, a writer applied this claim to then-presidential candidate Ronald Reagan, calling the politician’s alleged lies on the campaign trail “counterfactual statements.”¹⁴³² These attacks revealed that counterfactuals remained controversial.

Conclusion

The Cold War boosted the prominence of counterfactual thinking in the English-speaking world. While postwar communists continued to speculate within ideological parameters, Anglo-American liberals freely debated whether the East-West rivalry might have been prevented. The answers that liberals proposed between the late 1940s and the 1980s oscillated between orthodox and revisionist perspectives but never produced a clear consensus. Partly for this reason, liberal historians became sensitized to the epistemological challenges of counterfactual reasoning and began to discuss how they could be mastered. In two separate debates between the early 1950s and late 1970s, historians discussed the merits and drawbacks of using “might-have-beens” and cliometric counterfactuals in historical research. Although no consensus emerged here either, the supporters of historical speculation steadily grew in number, so that by the year 1989, the nascent field of “counterfactual history” was poised to jump from the academic margins to the popular mainstream. Before counterfactual history came to the attention of a mass audience, however, it was preceded by the rise of its cousin, alternate history.

Cultural Counterfactuals (II): The Breakthrough of Alternate History, 1945–1989

Still feeling disappointed, [Wyndam-Matson].grabbed the book [and] glanced at it. *The Grasshopper Lies Heavy*. ...

‘One of those love stories,’ he said ... sullenly ...

‘No,’ [Rita]... said, ‘A story about war ...’

‘[Its]... theory is that ... Roosevelt isn’t assassinated in Miami; he ... is President until 1940... when Germany attacks England and France and Poland ...’

‘... After Roosevelt, Rexford Tugwell would have been President ... and would have continu[ed]... Roosevelt[’s] anti-Nazi policies. So Germany would have been afraid to come to Japan’s help in 1941. They would not have honored their treaty. Do you see?... Germany and Japan would have lost the war!’¹⁴³³ (*The Man in the High Castle* 1962)

Between 1945 and 1989, the prominence of alternate history surged in western culture. Especially in the English-speaking world, but also in other countries, cultural counterfactuals appeared in the form of novels, short stories, plays, films, radio programs, television shows, comic books, and even board games. This wave paralleled the embrace of analytical counterfactuals by historians and other scholars around the same time. Works of alternate history, however, differed in important ways. Unlike analytical counterfactuals, which were written in sober prose and intended mostly for academics, alternate histories employed elaborate plots, well-developed characters, and unusual framing devices to heighten their popular appeal. As was shown by Philip K. Dick’s use of a nesting doll counterfactual in his famous novel *The Man in the High Castle*, postwar alternate histories reached new levels of creativity in reimagining the past (Figure 8.1).

Alternate history’s unprecedented prominence reflected the new circumstances of the postwar world. Between the 1950s and 1970s, the explosion of economic prosperity, the expansion of popular culture, and the arrival of a transgressive postmodern attitude toward the past helped nurture the rise of alternate history. The new genre also effectively tapped into the fascination of western audiences with pivotal moments in the past. Particularly in the

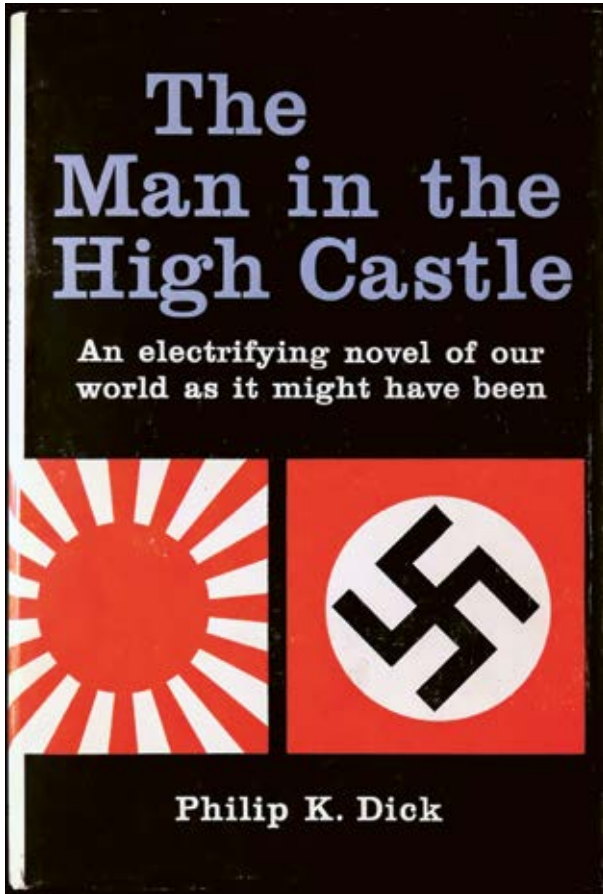


FIGURE 8.1 Published in 1962, Philip K. Dick's novel, *The Man in the High Castle*, helped establish alternate history as a legitimate literary genre after World War II. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Anglo-American world, three topics were especially popular: World War II, the Civil War, and the American Revolution. While alternate histories covered other topics as well, these three occupied a disproportionate share of the era's counterfactual imagination. The ways in which these events were reimagined, in turn, reflected their status in historical memory. As alternate histories became increasingly visible, finally, they stimulated new thinking about the genre itself. While commentators initially struggled to categorize the era's narratives, by the 1980s they agreed to define them with a new concept—"alternate history."

The Breakthrough of Alternate History

Between 1945 and 1989, more alternate histories appeared than ever before. The wave of works was the fifth since the inception of alternate history in the mid-nineteenth century and included many hundreds of narratives—far too many to be surveyed in their entirety. Taking note of the most important examples, however, helps explain alternate history's unprecedented growth after 1945.

Alternate history achieved its greatest prominence in literature. Among the classic novels that appeared in the early postwar decades were Ward Moore's *Bring the Jubilee* (1953), about the South winning the Civil War; Philip K. Dick's *The Man in the High Castle* (1962), about Nazi Germany triumphing in World War II, and Kingsley Amis's *The Alteration* (1976), about England remaining Catholic in the early sixteenth century. Certain alternate histories were especially innovative. Norman Spinrad's *The Iron Dream* (1972) was a (fake) novel within a (real) novel—the former a lurid science fiction tale, entitled *Lord of the Swastika*, by the German American writer, Adolf Hitler (Figure 8.2). Robert Sobel's book *For Want of a Nail* (1973) was an elaborately crafted, mock history textbook that explored the consequences of General Burgoyne's victory in the Battle of Saratoga in 1777.

Alternate histories also appeared in the form of short stories and long-form counterfactual essays. Some of the era's classic works appeared as standalone tales in science fiction magazines and edited anthologies, such as C.M. Kornbluth's short story "Two Dooms," about the Nazis winning the Second World War (1958), and Kim Stanley Robinson's "The Lucky Strike" (1984), about the United States not dropping the atomic bomb on Hiroshima in 1945.¹⁴³⁴ Other narratives appeared in popular mainstream publications, such as *Readers' Digest*, which published John Master's essay "The Day the South Could Have Won the Civil War" in 1960, and *The Saturday Evening Post*, which published C.S. Forester's serialized essay "If Hitler Had Invaded England" that same year.¹⁴³⁵ Alternate history narratives also appeared in edited anthologies. After the re-publication of J.C. Squire's 1931 volume *If It Had Happened Otherwise* in 1972, more than half-a-dozen edited volumes were published in the next decade-and-a-half.¹⁴³⁶ These volumes included well over one hundred total essays on an enormous range of topics—from Jesus not being crucified to the Watergate scandal never occurring.

Alternate histories also appeared in other media. In theater, Noel Coward's play *Peace in Our Time* (1948) imagined Britain being invaded by Nazi Germany, while Robert Wallace Russell's play *Washington Shall Hang* (1971) portrayed the

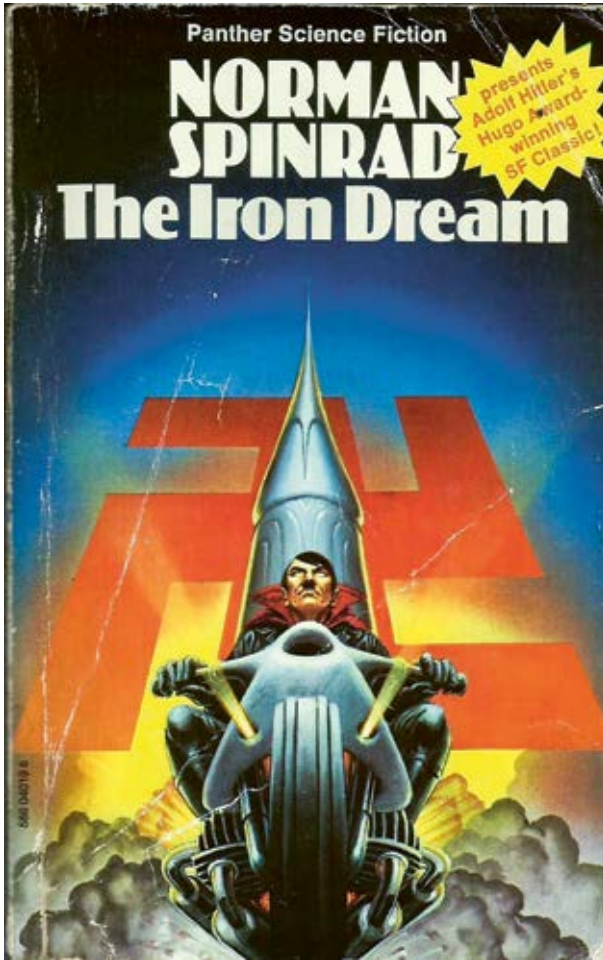


FIGURE 8.2 Norman Spinrad's *The Iron Dream* (1972) imagined Adolf Hitler moving to the United States and becoming a science fiction writer.

failure of the American Revolution. In film, the first ever cinematic works of alternate history appeared in Britain: Kevin Brownlow's and Andrew Mollo's film *It Happened Here* (1964), which chronicled the Nazi defeat and occupation of Great Britain, and Ralph Thomas's *Quest for Love* (1971), which examined the life of an ordinary British writer who finds himself in a parallel world where World War II never happened. In another milestone, NBC Radio in 1953 premiered the first ever alternate history radio show, *Stroke of Fate*, which aired thirteen episodes on such disparate topics as the relationship between Julius Caesar and Cleopatra, the Norman Conquest, and Alexander Hamilton's duel

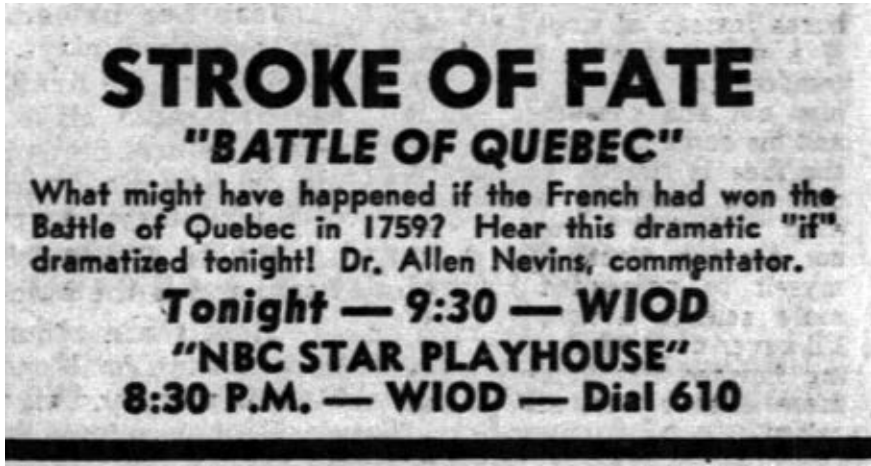


FIGURE 8.3 In 1953, alternate history hit the U.S. airwaves with NBC Radio's show, *Stroke of Fate*.

with Aaron Burr (Figure 8.3). Comic books also embraced alternate history narratives, focusing on topics like the Third Reich, the Civil War, and the Vietnam War, with certain titles, such as Alan Moore and Dave Gibbons' comic book series and later graphic novel *Watchmen* (1987), attaining classic status soon after their appearance. In the 1970s and into the 1980s, finally, alternate histories also appeared in the form of board games exploring alternative scenarios involving the Civil War and World War II.¹⁴³⁷

The most significant new medium for alternate history was television. Starting in the 1960s, several dramas depicted the Nazis winning World War II. In Britain, the ITV network aired Giles Cooper's play *The Other Man* in 1964, while the BBC dramatized Norman Longmate's book *If Britain Had Fallen* in 1972 and Philip Mackie's miniseries *An Englishman's Castle* in 1978.¹⁴³⁸ In the United States, the premise of the Nazis winning World War II found expression in episodes of popular television shows, such as *Star Trek* (1967) and *Saturday Night Live* (1979).¹⁴³⁹ Apart from these single-themed narratives, alternate history topics were also explored in two short-lived American television programs. In 1964, National Education Television debuted the television show, *Past Imperfect*, which ran eight episodes on "what ifs" involving such figures as Martin Luther, Napoleon Bonaparte, and Leon Trotsky.¹⁴⁴⁰ In 1982–83, NBC's time traveling show *Voyagers* depicted its protagonists traveling back in time to prevent potential changes to the historical record.¹⁴⁴¹

The era's alternate histories were not just abundant in number but were produced by prominent cultural figures. In Britain, Kingsley Amis and Noel

Coward were among the country's most famous fiction writers, while in the U.S., MacKinlay Kantor and William Shirer were both Pulitzer Prize-winning journalists. More notable still was the role of prominent scholars in producing alternate histories. The historian Arthur Schlesinger, Jr. and cultural critic Susan Sontag appeared on the television show *Past Imperfect*, while historians Allan Nevins and Gordon Craig were involved in the radio show *Stroke of Fate*.¹⁴⁴² Major historians also contributed essays to the era's half-dozen anthologies, including John Merriman, Robert Kagan, and Peter Gay. For the first time, moreover, alternate histories secured major corporate sponsorship, with NBC radio producing *Stroke of Fate* and the BBC producing *If Britain Had Fallen* and *An Englishman's Castle*.

The proliferation of alternate histories partly reflected the acceleration of what has been called the "Entertainment Revolution."¹⁴⁴³ Although rooted in older trends, this revolution transformed popular culture into an increasingly prominent "industry" in the years after 1945. Enabled by postwar economic prosperity, the expansion of leisure time, and the rise of new media—especially film and television—western consumers had greater access to works of popular culture than ever before. The surging profitability of popular culture led book publishers, television networks, film studios, and comic book companies to satisfy consumer demand by seeking out new sources of content. Science fiction and fantasy were among the most important genres, as was shown by the success of writers like Isaac Asimov, Ray Bradbury, and Robert Heinlein, along with blockbuster series such as *Star Trek*, *Dune*, and *Lord of the Rings*.¹⁴⁴⁴ As alternate history narratives were rooted in the same speculative orientation, they directly benefitted from this development. Not surprisingly, alternate history was originally classified as a subgenre of science fiction. Yet as it focused on the past instead of the future, alternate history gradually developed its own separate identity.

Alternate history was also promoted by the rise of postmodernism. By embracing the past from an ironic perspective, postmodernism dovetailed with the ironic tendencies that underpinned counterfactual thought.¹⁴⁴⁵ Postmodernism's tendency to blur the line between different branches of culture mirrored the way that alternate history blurred the line between fact and fiction.¹⁴⁴⁶ Postmodernism's valorization of "the other" and its attempt to resurrect suppressed voices paralleled alternate history's promotion of unconventional views of the past. Finally, postmodernism's promotion of subjective and relativistic varieties of historical consciousness encouraged a mind frame that fostered counterfactual speculation.¹⁴⁴⁷ By rejecting the quest for a single historical "truth," postmodernism stimulated new representations of the past that diverged from the accepted historical record.

The popularity of alternate histories also reflected their ability to channel historical memory. After 1945, people in Europe and North America were keenly aware of how the recent past had shaped the present. Having just gone through the Second World War, they were sensitized to the significance of historical events in their personal lives. With millions of people nurturing feelings of regret and relief, they gravitated to “what if?” narratives that were linked to such feelings. Alternate histories in the period 1945–1989 focused on a wide range of topics and varied from country to country. In Britain and the U.S., however, they were unusually concentrated on a specific set of topics that reflected broader trends in Anglo-American historical consciousness.

Nazis, Confederates, and Patriots

In the English-speaking world, most alternate histories focused on World War II, the American Civil War, and the American Revolution.¹⁴⁴⁸ Well over one hundred texts appeared on these topics in the years 1945 to 1989. In the early 1960s, the explosion of interest in Nazi Germany sparked counterfactual speculation in Britain and the U.S. about the Nazis winning World War II. Around the same time, the 100th anniversary of the Civil War, together with the ongoing Civil Rights movement, sparked speculation about the possible victory of the Confederacy. Finally, the arrival of the U.S. Bicentennial in 1976 prompted Americans to ruminate about the possible failure of the American Revolution.

Nazism Triumphant

In Britain and the United States, the possibility of the Nazis winning World War II was a popular nightmare.¹⁴⁴⁹ Over three dozen narratives explored this scenario between 1945 and 1989.¹⁴⁵⁰ They appeared in two phases and were notably different in character. Between 1945 and the early 1960s, accounts of a Nazi wartime victory were extremely dystopian, while the accounts appeared between the mid-1960s and early 1980s were much less frightening. This change corresponded to a shift in the narratives’ function. While they were initially intended to justify the western Allies’ decision to intervene in the war, they were later used to question it.

Early postwar alternate histories in Great Britain and the U.S. built upon, but subtly transformed, the agenda of wartime future histories. While the latter warned ordinary Britons and Americans about the horrors that awaited them if the enemy were not defeated, the former congratulated them for

ultimately prevailing. Early postwar alternate histories were relatively few in number; having won the war, Britons and Americans had little reason to fear the Germans and were eager to vindicate the recent past by confirming the belief that the decision to fight Nazi Germany in the pivotal years 1940–1941 constituted Britain’s “finest hour” and America’s “good war.” This desire intensified in the years 1959–61 when the eruption of neo-Nazi vandalism in West Germany, the capture and subsequent trial of fugitive SS officer Adolf Eichmann, and Cold War tensions over Berlin revived western interest in the Nazi era. By using alternate histories to imagine the dystopian consequences of the Germans invading, defeating, and occupying Great Britain and the U.S., British and American narratives in the early postwar years validated the present as the best of all possible worlds.

For the first decade and a half after World War II, British alternate histories consistently depicted a Nazi wartime victory as a nightmare. Noel Coward’s 1947 play *Peace in Our Time* portrayed the British people suffering tremendously under Nazi occupation—especially at the hands of the sadistic Gestapo official Albrecht Richter—before forming a resistance movement and expelling the enemy. John W. Wall’s harrowing 1952 novel *The Sound of His Horn* (published under Wall’s pen name, Sarban) also presented a dystopian portrait of Nazi-ruled world in which a British POW, Alan Querdillon, struggles to survive on the private forest reserve of a fiendish Nazi villain, Count Hans von Hackelnberg, who hunts human beings for sport. In 1960, the famed British novelist C.S. Forester published a serialized novella, “If Hitler Had Invaded England,” which portrayed the Germans brutally occupying Britain before eventually being overthrown by the British resistance. That same year, an anonymously published novel called *The Occupation* (most likely written by the historian Hugh Thomas) depicted a similar scenario with sadistic Nazi oppressors eventually being toppled by forces led by Field Marshal Bernard Montgomery. Finally, in 1961, British journalist Comer Clarke’s book *England Under Hitler* chillingly documented how Germany planned on using a “black-list” to arrest, imprison, and murder British citizens as part of their larger occupation policy (Figure 8.4). The authors of these works all hailed from varied backgrounds, but they shared the belief that Britain’s decision to fight the Nazis in 1940 had been correct.¹⁴⁵¹

Similarly, early postwar American alternate histories presented terrifying portraits of the Nazi-occupied U.S. to vindicate the country’s decision to intervene in World War II. C.M. Kornbluth’s short story “Two Dooms” (1958) depicted the failure of the U.S. to develop the atom bomb as leading to the nation’s brutal occupation by the Germans and Japanese.¹⁴⁵² One year later, to mark the twentieth anniversary of the start of World War II, the Polish-born

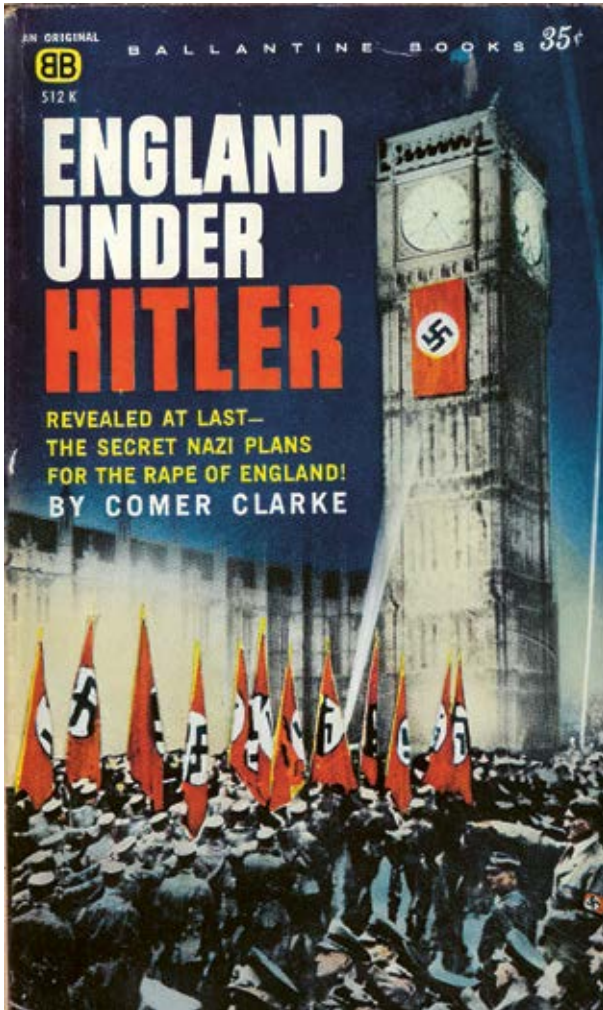


FIGURE 8.4 British journalist Comer Clarke's book, *England Under Hitler* (1961), depicted the nightmare of a German-ruled Britain.

American journalist Christine Hotchkiss published a nationally syndicated essay, "If Hitler Had Won!", which imagined how the U.S. might have been "brought to its knees" by the Germans.¹⁴⁵³ In November of 1961, to mark the twentieth anniversary of the U.S.'s entry into the war, William L. Shirer's *Look Magazine* essay, "If Hitler Had Won World War II," imagined the Germans and Japanese invading the U.S. and perpetrating an American Holocaust.¹⁴⁵⁴ One year later, Philip K. Dick's novel *The Man in the High Castle* depicted the U.S.

being defeated by the Axis due to the assassination of President Franklin D. Roosevelt and the decision of his successors to keep the U.S. neutral in the Second World War. This political lesson was echoed, finally, by the famous *Star Trek* episode “The City on the Edge of Forever” (1967), which portrayed the crew of the Enterprise going back in time to ensure the death of an American pacifist, whose goal of keeping the U.S. out of the war threatens to permit Germany to triumph in it.¹⁴⁵⁵ By showing how “perilously close” Hitler came to winning the war, as Hotchkiss put it, American alternate histories valorized the “Allied forces who fought to stop him.”¹⁴⁵⁶

The era’s alternate histories received a generally positive reception. In Britain, Noel Coward’s play was hailed as a “timely” vindication of the British “spirit”; Sarban’s novel was praised for its “power”; and Forester’s novella was welcomed as “highly plausible.” In the U.S., Dick’s *The Man in the High Castle* earned glowing reviews and received the prestigious Hugo award for best science fiction novel of 1962. Shirer’s essay, by contrast, sparked controversy in West Germany, where it was sharply attacked for allegedly stoking anti-German sentiment in the U.S.¹⁴⁵⁷ Although this was not Shirer’s intention, West Germans had good reason for such fears. In the early 1960s, high-profile news stories about the Nazi past raised frightening counterfactual possibilities. During the Eichmann trial in 1961, for instance, news reports publicized the likelihood that “if Hitler had won the war,” the Nazis would have murdered the Jews of Palestine.¹⁴⁵⁸ Around the same time, stories about surging antisemitism in the Federal Republic of Germany included cases of ordinary citizens declaring that “Hitler should have gassed all the Jews.”¹⁴⁵⁹ In the U.S., meanwhile, the rise of George Lincoln Rockwell’s American Nazi Party in 1958 and the extremist rhetoric of Barry Goldwater in the early 1960s prompted commentators to praise Shirer’s essay for highlighting the danger that “extremists on the right” posed to American democracy, with one Black journalist commending Shirer for revealing that “Negroes would have been treated brutally if Hitler had won World War II.”¹⁴⁶⁰

Between the mid-1960s and the late 1970s, however, alternate histories underwent a notable shift: instead of depicting heroic Britons and Americans battling evil Germans, they depicted the former collaborating with the latter. By embracing this self-critical view of what might have happened following a Nazi wartime victory, British and American writers respectively attacked the “finest hour” and “good war” narratives by suggesting their countries’ potential for embracing Nazism. This universalistic message reflected the dawning of a pessimistic mood in Britain and the United States. Britain’s fall from great power status, typified by the accelerating loss of overseas colonies after the 1950s and its economic stagnation in the 1970s, generated a downcast mood and a spirit

of self-reproach. In the United States, meanwhile, the traumas of the Vietnam War, the upheavals of the Civil Rights movement, the scandal of Watergate, the onset of economic recession, and the renewal of cold war fears transformed the function of alternate histories from self-congratulation to self-critique.

Self-critical alternate histories first appeared in Britain. In 1964, playwright Giles Cooper's television drama *The Other Man* featured Michael Caine as a collaborationist military officer named George Grant who, after overseeing a forced labor brigade in Nazi-ruled India, gets promoted to General in exchange for promoting Nazism to the occupied British people. That same year, Kevin Brownlow and Andrew Mollo's film *It Happened Here* depicted a female medic named Pauline collaborating with the Nazi occupiers—going so far as to euthanize Polish POWs—while simultaneously witnessing the brutality of the British anti-Nazi resistance (Figure 8.5). In 1978, playwright Philip Mackie's 1978 television miniseries *An Englishman's Castle* depicted a collaborationist television producer in Nazi-occupied England manipulating British public opinion to accept Nazism through a fictional television drama. Also in 1978, Len Deighton's bestselling novel *SS-GB* portrayed British police detectives simultaneously working with their German overlords while also trying to liberate the nation from Nazi occupation. Produced by left-leaning creators, these narratives compared counterfactual Britons and Nazis to express a declining belief in Britain's moral superiority.¹⁴⁶¹

In the United States, this self-critical tendency appeared in somewhat different form. Some narratives rejected the "good war" paradigm and argued that history would have turned out better if the United States had remained neutral in World War II. Conservative historian John Lukacs's 1978 essay "What if Hitler Had Won the Second World War?" implied that if the U.S. had stayed out of the conflict, the Nazis could have defeated the Soviet Union and thereby prevented the Cold War.¹⁴⁶² Similarly, the libertarian writer Brad Linaweaver's 1982 novel *Moon of Ice* endorsed isolationism by showing how the U.S.'s decision to remain neutral and allow the Nazis to win World War II improves the course of history.¹⁴⁶³ Notably, both tales imagined "pragmatic" Nazis like Albert Speer assuming control over Nazi Germany and steering Europe towards political unification. In advancing this fantasy, both writers expressed their conservative hostility to communism at a time when the U.S.-Soviet Union rivalry was intensifying.¹⁴⁶⁴ Convinced that communism was a greater threat than Nazism, they rewrote history to neutralize the threat posed by the former.

By contrast, other American narratives combined self-criticism with support for interventionism. Like British narratives in the 1960s and 1970s, they depicted Nazism as evil but portrayed Americans having their own fascist tendencies. Ward Moore's 1975 short story "A Class with Dr. Chang," showed



FIGURE 8.5 Kevin Brownlow and Andrew Mollo's film, *It Happened Here* (1964), pessimistically imagined the British population collaborating with the Nazis. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

how American neutrality in World War II enables a Nazi triumph, while also sparking a nationalist, anti-foreigner backlash among ordinary Americans.¹⁴⁶⁵ William Overgard's novel *The Divide* (1980) bleakly portrayed an isolationist U.S. not only losing World War II to the Germans but actively collaborating with them during the ensuing occupation. Finally, David Dvorkin's novel *Budspy* (1987) imagined the U.S. helping the Nazis win the war by abandoning the USSR as an ally but then sliding into steep decline under a series of anticommunist presidents, including Joseph McCarthy and Jesse Helms. The three narratives' critical depiction of the United States came from different wings of the political spectrum. Moore was a longtime leftist, whose unflattering portrait of American racism critiqued Vietnam-era American nationalism. Dvorkin also stood on the political left and indicted the Reagan administration for continuing the Cold War tradition of supporting authoritarian regimes in the name of anticommunism. By contrast, Overgard was a World War II veteran who critiqued America from a more libertarian perspective.¹⁴⁶⁶ These differences notwithstanding, the tales illustrated how a Nazi victory in World War II could be used for self-critical purposes.

The reception of these self-critical narratives was more mixed than the response to the triumphalistic texts of the early postwar era. While certain British reviewers hailed *The Other Man*, *It Happened Here*, *SS-GB*, and *An Englishman's Castle* as “brilliant” and “absorbing,” others attacked them for universalizing Nazism's evil and suggesting that “within us all exists ‘the other man.’”¹⁴⁶⁷ These criticisms reflected ongoing British resistance to the idea that their country might have fascist tendencies. American narratives, being somewhat less high-profile, received less attention and sparked less controversy, but they too received a mixed reception. While *Moon of Ice* and *Budspy* received positive reviews from major science fiction writers, such as Norman Spinrad and Robert Heinlein, they were also criticized for being heavy-handed in their political messages.¹⁴⁶⁸ As in Britain, Americans were reluctant to see fascist tendencies in their country and clung to the “good war” narrative.

The Victorious Confederacy

Americans speculated not only about the Nazis winning World War II but the South winning the Civil War. While alternate histories on this topic remained scattered before 1945, they surged in the years that followed.¹⁴⁶⁹ As with tales of a Nazi wartime triumph, narratives of the Confederacy defeating the Union took the form of both nightmares and fantasies, with the former generally prevailing over the latter.

The first major narrative was Ward Moore's novel *Bring the Jubilee* (Figure 8.6).¹⁴⁷⁰ Employing the premise that Southern forces win the Battle of Gettysburg, Moore used a trading places counterfactual to show the North and South switching historical fates. While the independent Confederate States of America (CSA) abolishes slavery and becomes a prosperous Empire, conquering Mexico, the North stagnates economically and becomes mired in poverty, racism, and revanchism. Moore did not permit the South to enjoy its victory permanently, however, for midway through the novel, he introduced a counterfactual twist by having the novel's protagonist, a disaffected Northerner named Hodge Backmacker, use a time machine to change the course of history by transporting himself back to the Battle of Gettysburg and ensuring—through pure chance—that the South loses the battle and the larger war. Yet, while this twist allows the North to triumph, all is not well with American history. At the novel's conclusion, Hodge is convinced that he has restored history to its “proper” course, believing that the South's defeat and the passing of the thirteenth, fourteenth, and fifteenth amendments have put American history on a path to historical justice. Yet, his ensuing reference to “rumors of a deal ... between Northern Republicans and southern Democrats” to make

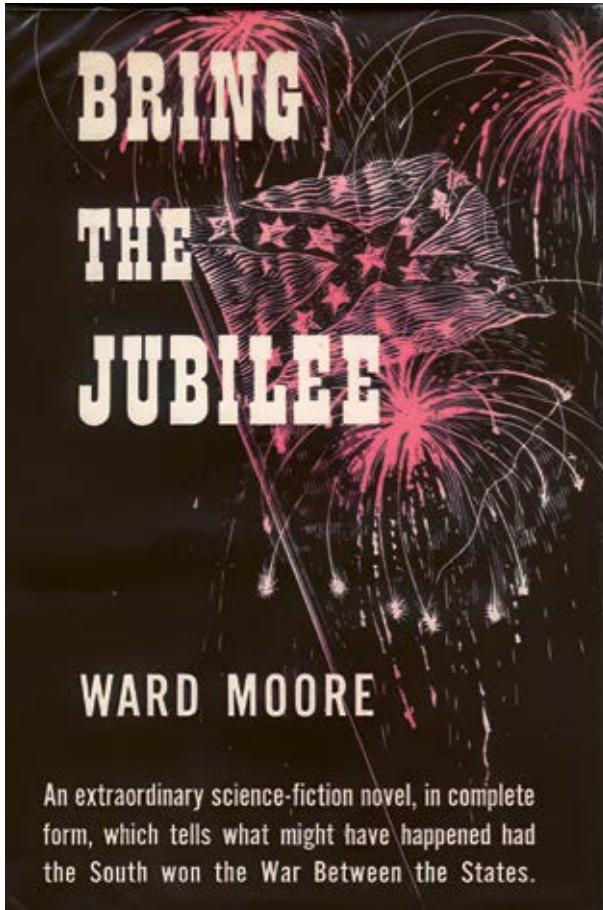


FIGURE 8.6 Ward Moore's novel, *Bring the Jubilee* (1953), imagined the South prospering and the North stagnating after a Confederate victory in the Civil War. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Rutherford B. Hayes President and halt Reconstruction reveals that, before long, Southern Blacks will be subjected to Jim Crow discrimination and history will follow its real disastrous course.

In presenting this conclusion, Moore expressed left-of-center political views. A northeastern Jew, union supporter, and anti-war pacifist, he used the novel to expose the U.S.'s failure to achieve its full democratic potential.¹⁴⁷¹ Indeed, as Mike Davis has argued, *Bring the Jubilee* was "the single most eloquent and intellectually powerful defense of the revolutionary meaning of the Union cause since Lincoln himself addressed fresh graves and future generations at

Gettysburg.”¹⁴⁷² Writing at a moment when the postwar civil rights movement was beginning to gather momentum, Moore exposed the missed opportunities of American history to generate support for progressive change.

Moore’s narrative was exceptional in the early postwar period, however. Not only was it the only one of its kind in the 1950s, but its reception revealed that its counterfactual perspective was out of step with prevailing attitudes. *Bring the Jubilee* was widely reviewed, with critics praising it as “evocative,” “clever,” and marked by “great artistry.”¹⁴⁷³ Most critics, however, overlooked the book’s political message, which went unmentioned in the several dozen reviews published at the time. Some Southern reviewers actually endorsed the novel: a Virginia journalist said the tale of a Southern victory “should warm the heart of every Southerner of the Old School,” while an Alabama reviewer praised Moore for being the first “to commit to paper” a fantasy of “many a dreaming Southerner.”¹⁴⁷⁴ These reviews suggest that *Bring the Jubilee* was not seen as a threat. Cold War concerns also played a role. Written at the height of the “Red Scare,” *Bring the Jubilee* appeared at a time when many Americans craved national unity in the face of the Soviet threat. There was thus little support for a counterfactual premise that would have stoked national division. As a Louisiana historian anxiously speculated in 1954, “had the south won, the nation would have been divided” and unable “to stop communism.”¹⁴⁷⁵

This desire for national unity directly shaped the next major narrative, MacKinlay Kantor’s *Look Magazine* essay, “If the South Had Won the Civil War” (Figure 8.7). Published in November of 1960 and later turned into a novel, Kantor’s tale differed from Moore’s by embracing the conservative fantasy of sectional reconciliation. The essay’s point of divergence takes place in May of 1863, when General Ulysses Grant dies after falling off his horse near Vicksburg; as a result, the South triumphs in the Battle of Gettysburg and eventually wins the war. The North and South thereafter develop in opposite directions. As in Moore’s tale, the North experiences a wave of anti-Black violence and loses Washington, D.C. to the Confederacy. The South, meanwhile, gains several new states (Kentucky and Maryland) and expands into the Caribbean, annexing Cuba in 1898. The Confederacy also frees its enslaved Black population in the “Liberation Act” of 1885. The unilateral nature of this decision is crucial, for as Confederate President James Longstreet speculates, “had we gone down in defeat” and been forced to free the slaves instead of doing so “in an act of self-determination,” then “a common hatred of the negro, which we do not now ... possess, would have been the inevitable result.”¹⁴⁷⁶ In the years that follow, the South pursues a reconciliationist program under the three-term administration of Confederate President Woodrow Wilson, and eventually finds common ground with the Union thanks to threats emanating from



FIGURE 8.7 MacKinlay Kantor's *Look Magazine* essay, "If the South Had Won the Civil War" (1960), optimistically portrayed the South unilaterally freeing its enslaved Black population.

Germany and the Soviet Union. As the story concludes, the North and South are slated to reunite in 1961 on the hundredth anniversary of the war's eruption.

In its motivations and reception, Kantor's essay echoed the era's Cold War climate. Unlike Moore, Kantor was a hawkish anticommunist who used his tale to confront the postwar Soviet threat.¹⁴⁷⁷ The fact that his essay portrayed the Confederacy annexing Cuba expressed the conservative fantasy of avoiding the Cold War anxieties caused by Fidel Castro's revolution of 1959. The response to Kantor's essay, meanwhile, revealed widespread support for its reconciliationist message. Hailed as "provocative," the essay received a flood of complementary letters to *Look Magazine* and was widely reviewed in the mass media.¹⁴⁷⁸ Former President Harry S Truman endorsed the essay's claim that a Confederate victory would have made the country more vulnerable to communism, noting that after a Southern triumph, Russia probably "would have kept Alaska,... taken all of Northwest Canada," and gained territory all the way

“eastward to the Mississippi River.”¹⁴⁷⁹ The support for Kantor’s essay among Southern reviewers further confirmed the era’s focus on American unity.¹⁴⁸⁰

Not long after the appearance of Kantor’s essay, however, depictions of a Confederate victory in the Civil War changed. The arrival of the war’s centennial in 1961 generated a flood of newspaper editorials, journal essays, and public lectures that speculated on how the conflict might have turned out differently. As writers wondered “what if?” about the past, they did so with an eye towards the newly volatile present.

In the late 1950s and early 1960s, the intensifying civil rights movement led writers to increasingly express regrets about the Civil War’s impact on American history. As the U.S. Supreme Court ruled in favor of desegregation measures in the years between *Brown v. the Board of Education* (1954) and the Civil Rights Act (1964), Southerners became increasingly vocal about wishing they had won the Civil War. In 1958, the segregationist U.S. Senator from North Carolina Sam Ervin confessed that he liked “to meditate on the great ifs of history,” noting that if the South had “beat the Yankees,” then the U.S. Supreme Court “wouldn’t have jurisdiction over us.”¹⁴⁸¹ In 1961, the segregationist U.S. Senator from South Carolina Ollie Johnson described himself as “an unreconstructed rebel who still wishes the South had won the war” because it would have made the U.S. “an even stronger nation.”¹⁴⁸² Other Southerners optimistically argued that “in an independent Confederacy,... the South would have drifted away from chattel slavery soon after 1860.”¹⁴⁸³

Certain northern writers shared the fantasy of the South becoming independent, believing it would have spared the North many of its present-day headaches over civil rights. In 1964, the syndicated columnist Sydney J. Harris argued that if Lincoln “had allowed the South to secede,... slavery would not have lasted,” and “a hundred years later ... we would not be resuming that fratricidal conflict.”¹⁴⁸⁴ In 1962, a Philadelphia newspaper declared that President John F. Kennedy “could be excused for dreaming of what-might-have-been,” for if he were only responsible for governing the “39 states above the Mason-Dixon Line,” he could avoid “the annual school integration melee in Dixie.”¹⁴⁸⁵ One 1960 editorial even proposed, “Let’s Reverse History and Let the South Go!”¹⁴⁸⁶ Some northerners resisted these gestures of despair. Commenting on the Southern resistance to Civil Rights legislation, one writer claimed that Southerners were “still acting as if the Confederacy had won [the war]” and said it was high time to “remind ... the bigots that the war is over.”¹⁴⁸⁷ Another writer drew attention to the nightmarish possibility that “If the Confederacy had won ... there would still be slaves in a land dedicated to freedom.”¹⁴⁸⁸

Despite the abundant speculation about the Civil War in the early 1960s, no longform alternate histories appeared until the end of the decade. Between the late 1960s and early 1980s, however, they appeared in greater number. The

texts appeared in two small waves and reflected the period's growing climate of crisis: the first appeared in the years 1968–1970 and reflected the domestic turmoil sparked by the assassination of Martin Luther King, Jr., the eruption of racial unrest in American cities, and the surge of white support for George Wallace and Richard Nixon; the second appeared in the early 1980s and expressed the malaise surrounding the latter years of President Jimmy Carter's administration, the intensifying Cold War with the USSR, and the election of President Ronald Reagan. Both sets of texts used the premise of a Confederate triumph in the Civil War to express the liberal fear that the U.S. was heading in a right-wing—perhaps even fascist—direction.

The first major text to express the new sense of crisis was Earl and Antonina Looker's novel *Revolt* (1968).¹⁴⁸⁹ As in Moore's and Kantor's novels, *Revolt's* point of divergence occurs with the Battle of Gettysburg, which the South wins thanks to the invention of a secret weapon—a “repeating rifle”—created by the novel's protagonist, the inventor and plantation owner Secundus Brook. After this victory brings about the collapse of Union forces, the Confederacy quickly wins the war and becomes one of “the great powers of the world.”¹⁴⁹⁰ The South's triumph proves short-lived, however. Unbeknownst to the Confederate leadership, Brook is a closeted abolitionist who fears for the South's future, aware that Blacks “will never be freed except by their own efforts at revolt.”¹⁴⁹¹ In the novel's violent climax, set in December of 1863, enslaved persons in the vicinity of Richmond attack the Confederate leadership at a dinner for the new President, J.E.B. Stuart, and brutally massacre all the guests, thereby sparking a larger rebellion. In the ensuing panic, the Southern leadership recognizes it has no choice but “to ask help from the only mortal source left ... *the government of the United States*.”¹⁴⁹² By the novel's conclusion, “Federal relief forces” have encircled Richmond and contained the Black rebels—the implication being that the Union will soon occupy Virginia and compel the remaining confederate states, fearful of further slave revolts, to “join the Union again.”¹⁴⁹³

It is unclear what motivated the Lookers to write their novel, but as southern liberals, they were likely concerned about the state of American race relations in the late 1960s and intended their novel to promote racial justice.¹⁴⁹⁴ Notably enough, the novel's narrator is a Southern physician, Horace Trevelyan, who gradually recognizes the evils of slavery and approves of Brook's efforts to destroy it. Throughout the novel, both men comment on the humanity of Black people, noting that they have “as great an ability to improve [themselves]... as do [whites].” The novel's main message, however, arguably appeared in a pivotal speech delivered by Brook near the novel's conclusion, when he says that Southerners need to live up to “the highest possible standards of our white civilization” and extend “tolerance, compassion, and mercy” to Blacks.¹⁴⁹⁵ This

comment, together with sympathetic references to Black “civil disobedience,” reflected the novel’s self-critical political message.

Two years later, Robert Stapp’s novel *A More Perfect Union* (1970) also explored the nightmare of a triumphant Confederacy (Figure 8.8).¹⁴⁹⁶ Set in 1981, more than a century after Abraham Lincoln allows the Confederacy to secede from the Union, the novel depicts the South’s turbulent political evolution from “constitutional democracy to semisocialism to neo-fascism,” before evolving into a totalitarian police state run by President Howie Ray Spearman of the National Resurgence Party in the 1960s.¹⁴⁹⁷ Domestically, Spearman classifies all people according to his party’s “Orderly Evolution” policy: Blacks are minimally educated, consigned to menial jobs, and segregated in scattered “cloisters,” while whites are classified between the levels of “Deserving” and “Deprived.”¹⁴⁹⁸ In foreign policy, Spearman pursues a policy of expansionism and threatens the North with its arsenal of nuclear missiles unless it surrenders part of California to give the Confederacy access to the Pacific Ocean. Against this backdrop, the plot of *A More Perfect Union* focuses on the effort of former army counter-insurgency officer Cordell Vance to carry out the plan of U.S. President Gordon Lander to assassinate President Spearman. Many scenes of cloak and dagger drama ensue, but in the end, Vance fulfills his mission, neutralizes the threat of war, and opens up the possibility of “re-establishing the bonds that once existed between [the North]... and the South.”¹⁴⁹⁹ *A More Perfect Union* thus tempered its nightmarish narrative with the potential of redemption.

Stapp’s motives in writing his novel are unknown. But as a Navy veteran who fought the Nazis in World War II and later worked in the deep South as a journalism professor, he clearly sensed the links between European fascism and Jim Crow segregation.¹⁵⁰⁰ By the time he was writing his novel in the late 1960s, he may have shared the growing critique leveled by left-of-center Americans who were distressed about racial unrest and the War in Vietnam that the Nixon administration was turning America into a “fascist” country.

Subsequent narratives made a similar point. Mark Nesbitt’s novel *If the South Won Gettysburg* (1980) imagined Confederate forces winning the Battle of Gettysburg, capturing Washington D.C., and forcing the Union to a negotiated surrender in 1863.¹⁵⁰¹ In exchange for the restoration of trade relations with the North, the South withdraws from Washington, D.C. and goes on to develop as an independent nation, expanding into Cuba and Latin America. Like Ward Moore, Nesbitt portrayed an embittered North scapegoating Blacks for their military defeat and lashing out with racist “riots ... for over ... a decade.”¹⁵⁰² By 1916–17, however, the North and South find themselves sharing common foreign policy interests and they both declare war against Germany.

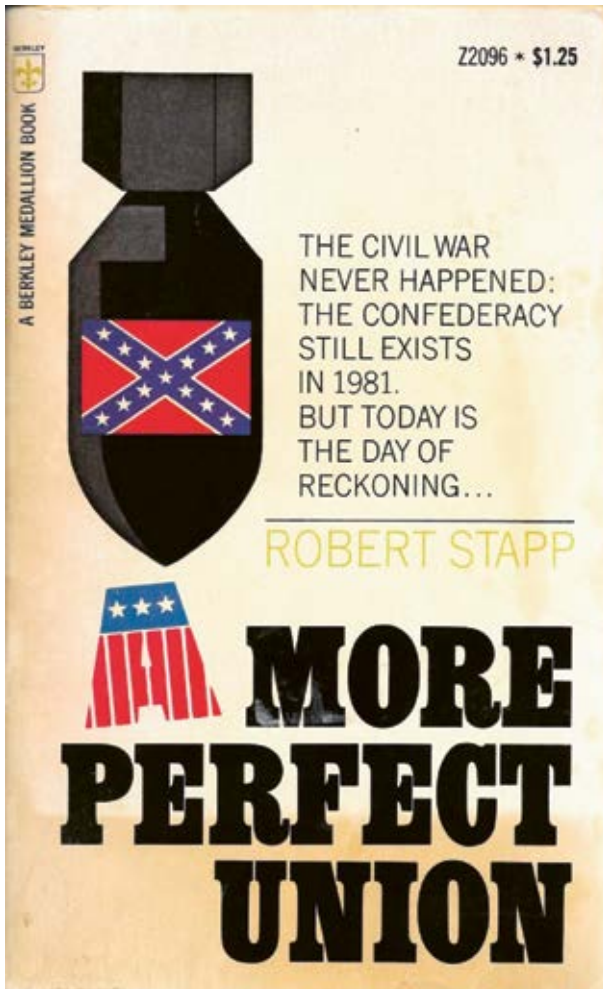


FIGURE 8.8 Robert Stapp's novel, *A More Perfect Union* (1970), depicted the nightmare of a triumphant Confederacy evolving into a totalitarian police state.

Unlike Kantor, however, Nesbitt concluded his novel in the 1930s by depicting the two countries remaining separate, with the North embracing big government policies during the Great Depression under FDR and the South preferring "self-reliance" and isolationism.

It is difficult to say what Nesbitt intended with this ambiguous ending. A former Gettysburg National Park tour guide and town resident, he wrote his book partly after being repeatedly asked by tourists how history would have been different "if the South had won."¹⁵⁰³ One possible hint about Nesbitt's

intentions, however, appeared at the novel's conclusion, when the narrator refers to a letter to the editor in the *Richmond Enquirer* by a Southerner named R.E.L. Beauchamps on the seventy-fifth anniversary of the Battle of Gettysburg in July of 1938. In the letter, Beauchamps declares how terrible it would have been "if the South had lost Gettysburg" and emphasizes the scenario's "ominous" potential by pointing to the plight of present-day Germans, who have desperately "grope[d for]... any leader, even a Hitler, to take them away from their past."¹⁵⁰⁴ By depicting Beauchamps' relief that the Confederate victory prevented the South from pursuing a revanchist path like Nazi Germany in alternate history, Nesbitt suggested an affinity between the South and fascism in real history. Nesbitt made this point explicit on the novel's final page, when the narrator reveals that Beauchamps has sent his letter to the editor from a plantation in Bogota, Columbia, where "resettled Confederates" have reestablished the old slave system.¹⁵⁰⁵ In presenting this creepy conclusion, Nesbitt may have been influenced by the many news stories about ex-Nazis living in South America. Whatever his precise motives, Nesbitt's liberal political leanings make it likely he wrote his novel for some of the same reasons Robert Stapp wrote *A More Perfect Union*.¹⁵⁰⁶

David C. Poyer's novel *The Shiloh Project* (1981) also portrayed the victorious South as fascist.¹⁵⁰⁷ Set in the early 1980s, the novel depicted the South's victory at Gettysburg as helping it win British military aid and ultimately defeat the North. As part of the resulting "Empire Alliance," the South goes on to develop a semi-egalitarian form of "Dixie Socialism" for whites, while imposing a brutal form of "conditional emancipation" for Blacks, marked by disenfranchisement, segregation, and lynchings. This severe persecution, however, is not enough for the right-wing, Klan-like "Kuklos League," which represents poor whites who hope to overthrow the aristocratic, sword-carrying planter class in charge of the CSA government in Richmond. Against this backdrop, *The Shiloh Project's* high-octane narrative focuses on the competing efforts of CSA intelligence forces and Black "terrorists" belonging to the "Railroad" resistance movement to steal a nuclear weapon being transported by ship from the North, while the Kuklos League exploits the crisis to topple the CSA government and launch a race war. The Kuklos League's agenda is clearly fascist. When the League's Colonel, Earl Sawyer, explains to the CSA official, Aubrey Lee Quidley IV, why the Richmond government needs to be toppled, he declares that it is too dominated by "English queers" and solicitous of "uppity ... nigras," concluding (in a variation of a famous Nazi phrase): "Now we goin' to be ... One party ... One leader. One flag, and one aim—the unshakable superiority of the white race."¹⁵⁰⁸ In the end, the apocalyptic scenario is averted when Quidley detonates the nuclear weapon far from any populated area, killing himself in a

gesture of semi-atonement for his family's Confederate heritage. Despite this heroic gesture, however, national division and racial oppression remain the status quo in North America.

As is true of the era's other authors, Poyer's motives in writing *The Shiloh Project* are difficult to determine. Like Earle Looker and Robert Stapp, he was a military veteran—having served for many years in the U.S. Navy—and only later became a successful writer. But as a self-proclaimed “FDR liberal,” who featured Nazi villains in some of his other literary works, he embraced the belief that a victorious Confederacy would have resembled a fascist state.¹⁵⁰⁹

Other tales around the same time made similar comparisons. Charles Harness's short story “Quarks at Appomattox” (1983) portrayed a neo-Nazi traveling back in time from the year 2065 to 1865 to help the Confederates win the Civil War, keep America divided, and help Germany avoid its twentieth-century defeats in the two World Wars.¹⁵¹⁰ In a less explicit, but still similar vein, Harry Harrison's 1983 novel *A Rebel in Time* depicted a Black Army veteran trying to prevent a racist American General from using a time machine to give the blueprints of a World War II-era, 9 mm Sten submachine gun to Confederate forces and help them win the Civil War.¹⁵¹¹ These tales also underscored how certain Americans perceived nineteenth-century history from a post-1945 historical perspective.

The response to these nightmare narratives was mixed. Stapp's novel was the most widely reviewed, being hailed as an “endlessly imaginative” and “extraordinary” story that provided significant “glimpses of ... [what] might-have-been”¹⁵¹² One reviewer even said that in light of “[today's] newspaper headlines,” Stapp's depiction of “American Fascism” in the victorious Confederacy was “chillingly convincing.”¹⁵¹³ The era's other works, by contrast, were less widely read. Although *The Shiloh Project* was called “provocative” and *Revolt* was described as “interesting,” the two novels, along with Nesbitt's book, were mostly regarded as curiosities.¹⁵¹⁴ The minimal attention suggests that, despite the increasing number of narratives depicting the South winning the Civil War in the 1970s and 1980s, the topic was of limited interest to American audiences. The relative novelty of alternate history as a genre during this period may have partly been responsible. But the scenario may also have been too politically controversial. The fact that *Revolt* failed to get a contract with an American publisher “because of the racial unrest at the time”—and had to be published in England—suggests that domestic sensitivities may have limited the willingness of people to contemplate the possibility of a Confederate victory in the Civil War.¹⁵¹⁵

Not all alternate histories about the South winning the Civil War were nightmares, however. Some narratives flirted with the possibility that a Confederate

victory might have had positive consequences, and some depicted it as an outright fantasy. Although few in number, these narratives softened the condemnatory tone of earlier works and reflected the conservative climate of the Reagan years.

One example of this trend was provided by the comic book *Captain Confederacy* (1986–87). Written by Will Shetterly and drawn by Vince Stone, the series is set in the present-day Confederate States of America and focuses on the dramatic life of a white southerner named Jeremy Gray, who plays a superhero called Captain Confederacy in a television show by the same name. Sponsored by the CSA state media, the show portrays Gray squaring off against various Black villains in the effort to defend white supremacy. Off screen, however, Gray is generally apolitical and maintains close friendships with his fellow Black actors, despite the fact they are denied citizenship in the CSA. Yet, when his Black co-star Aaron (who plays the villain, Blacksnake) is killed on the air for planning to expose the show as government-sponsored propaganda, Gray becomes a crusader against the Southern system. By the end of the series (and after many twists and turns) Captain Confederacy succeeds in convincing President Christine Roberta Lee to approve “full citizenship for Blacks and Indians and Mexicans.”¹⁵¹⁶ The counterfactual nightmare thus ends in a fantasy.

In offering this narrative, Shetterly offered something of a mixed political message. While he openly criticized anti-Black racism and condemned the premise of a victorious Confederacy by noting it might have “devised a “Final Solution to the Negro Problem,” he also speculated that the confederacy “might be a more enlightened nation [today] than the USA we live in.”¹⁵¹⁷ It is possible that Shetterly’s comment was motivated by the same self-critical impulses that inspired F.P. Williams to write *Hallie Marshall* in 1902. As a self-described “southern liberal,” Shetterly may have wanted to critique aspects of American life in the Reagan years by contrasting it unfavorably with life in a victorious Confederacy. At the same time, the upbeat ending of *Captain Confederacy* stood in stark contrast to the bleaker narratives from a decade earlier.¹⁵¹⁸

By contrast, the conservative writer Sheldon Vanauken’s 1984 essay “The World After the South Won” (1984) offered a more unapologetic view on the topic. Published in the neo-confederate journal *Southern Partisan*, the essay argued that a Southern victory would have dramatically improved the course of history.¹⁵¹⁹ Narrated by an unnamed Confederate writer chronicling the “War of Southern Independence,” the essay explained how British military support helps Confederate forces win the Battle of Gettysburg, capture Washington, D.C., and compel the Union to surrender. After joining the British Commonwealth, the Southern Prime Minister, Robert E. Lee (now Lord Arlington), abolishes slavery

in 1879 and approves a “benign program” to “slowly rais[e]... the Negro to the limits of his ability.”¹⁵²⁰ Even more dramatic is the independent Confederacy’s impact on world history. Thanks to Confederate support for the western Allies in 1914, Imperial Germany is defeated in the “One Year War of 1914–15,” thereby inaugurating a fifty-year period of “world peace.”¹⁵²¹ The narrator concludes his essay by expressing gratitude for how history turned out, speculating that “if England had remained neutral [in 1862], the United States ... might have conquered the South.”

In producing his alternate history, Vanauken displayed his reactionary political orientation. A paleoconservative who openly opposed the principles of equality and democracy, he fantasized that a Southern victory would have prevented the rise of “universal suffrage” and “the tyranny of the majority” both in the U.S. and Britain.¹⁵²² While Vanauken’s views were outside the popular American mainstream, his repetition of them in other writings during the decade, especially his 1989 book *The Glittering Illusion: English Sympathy for the Southern Confederacy*, revealed enduring nostalgia for the Confederacy.

This nostalgia was confirmed a few years later, when the famed country music star Hank Williams Jr. released the controversial song, “If the South Woulda Won” (Figure 8.9). Featured on his 1988 album *Wild Streak*, the song reiterated familiar features of the “Lost Cause” myth but updated them to suit present-day concerns. The opening line (and refrain) for the song was “If the South woulda won, we woulda had it made.” The reason, Williams explained, was because then

[The] Supreme Court [would be] down in Texas
 And we wouldn’t have no killers getting off free
 If they were proven guilty, then they would swing quickly
 Instead of writing books and smiling on TV ...
 I’d have all the cars made in the Carolinas
 And I’d ban all the ones made in China ...
 If the South woulda won, we’d a had it made ...
 Might even be better off.¹⁵²³

While some of the references in Williams’ song reflected late 1980s concerns about East Asian economic competition, it broadly endorsed the neo-confederate belief that an independent Confederacy would have improved the course of history. Given the song’s endorsement of lynching and its silence on slavery, “If the South Woulda Won” sparked immense controversy, especially after it won an award and was performed live on national television by Williams at the annual Country Music Awards. Liberal critics attacked the song

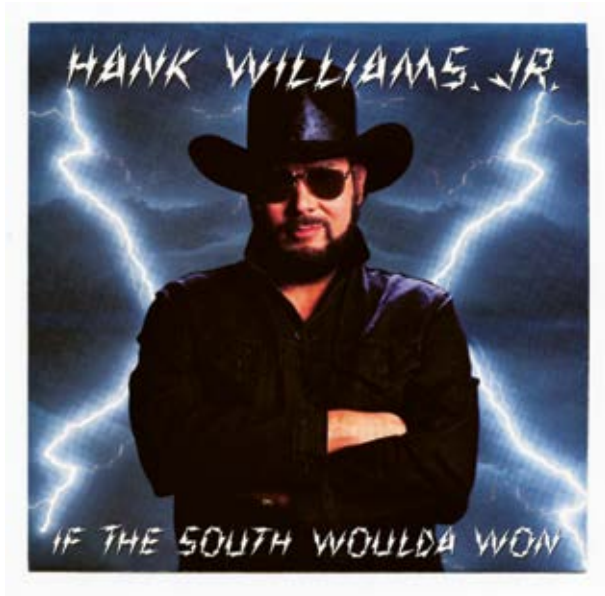


FIGURE 8.9 Hank Williams Jr.'s controversial song, "If the South Woulda Won" (1988) expressed discontent with the state of America in the late 1980s. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

as "disturbing," "racist," and as "redneck as a song can be," with many arguing that "if the south would have won, Black people would still be in slavery."¹⁵²⁴ In response, Williams and his defenders claimed the song was a "parody" and meant to be "tongue-in-cheek."¹⁵²⁵ But in light of Williams' well-known conservative views, it is hard to not to conclude that the song's counterfactual premise was meant in earnest.

Undoing the American Revolution

Besides reimagining the Civil War, American writers also explored counterfactual scenarios about the American Revolution, especially the possibility that it might have failed.¹⁵²⁶ While few alternate histories addressed the topic in the early years after 1945, they increased in the period leading up to the U.S. Bicentennial in 1976.¹⁵²⁷ After two centuries of the country's existence, writers wrestled with the Revolution's meaning and did so by speculating about how its failure might have shaped American history. Some asserted that the revolution's failure would have made history dramatically worse; others argued that it would have been better or essentially the same.

The first and most important nightmare scenario was advanced by historian Robert Sobel in his classic work *For Want of a Nail: If Burgoyne Had Won at Saratoga* (1973) (Figure 8.10).¹⁵²⁸ Sobel's narrative assumed the elaborate form of a fictional, four-hundred-page historical monograph replete with hundreds of fake footnotes and bibliographical references. Using General Burgoyne's victory in the Battle of Saratoga in 1777 as its point of divergence, the text chronicled two hundred years of American history up until the early 1970s. It is impossible to adequately survey the countless events re-imagined by Sobel, but their overall direction was clearly negative. Britain's defeat of the "North American Rebellion" prevents the United States from coming into existence and instead gives rise to two separate nations: the Confederation of North America (CNA), which is composed of British loyalists, and the new breakaway nation of Jefferson, which is founded in 1782 by exiled rebels in the area of present-day Texas. While the CNA makes its peace with Britain and becomes a successful industrial power, Jefferson becomes an expansionist nation, annexing Mexican territories all the way to the Pacific Ocean and renaming itself the United States of Mexico (USM) in 1819. Several decades later, tensions between the two nations lead to armed conflict, when the Rocky Mountain War (1845–53) erupts over mineral rights and causes several hundred thousand casualties. For the remainder of the century, the USM develops into a quasi-dictatorship that preserves slavery and develops an industrial economy dominated by a corporate behemoth, Kramer Associates, which assumes monopolistic hegemony over the USM's economy and eventually takes over the entire government.¹⁵²⁹ Several decades later, the USM destabilizes world affairs by allying with an aggressive Germany and unleashing the destructive "Global War of 1939–48," which results in over 200 million casualties and comes to be called the "worst tragedy in the history of the world."¹⁵³⁰ Worse still, after a left-wing USM administration nationalizes Kramer Associates' holdings and expels it from the country in 1944, the company becomes an independent global player and sparks a worldwide nuclear arms race after developing the first atomic bomb.¹⁵³¹ By the 1970s, a "War Without War" descends upon the globe, and the CNA and USM resemble two "scorpions in a bottle." "If one or the other lashes out," the text ominously concludes, "the world may be destroyed."¹⁵³²

While Sobel's motives in writing his text are difficult to determine, its function was to validate the real course of American history. A well-known business historian, syndicated columnist, and prolific author of popular histories on American capitalism, Sobel wrote *For Want of a Nail* as something of a lark; indeed, it was the only counterfactual text he published out of his roughly fifty published books.¹⁵³³ As was implied by the book's title, however (which draws on the famous medieval proverb about minor causes having

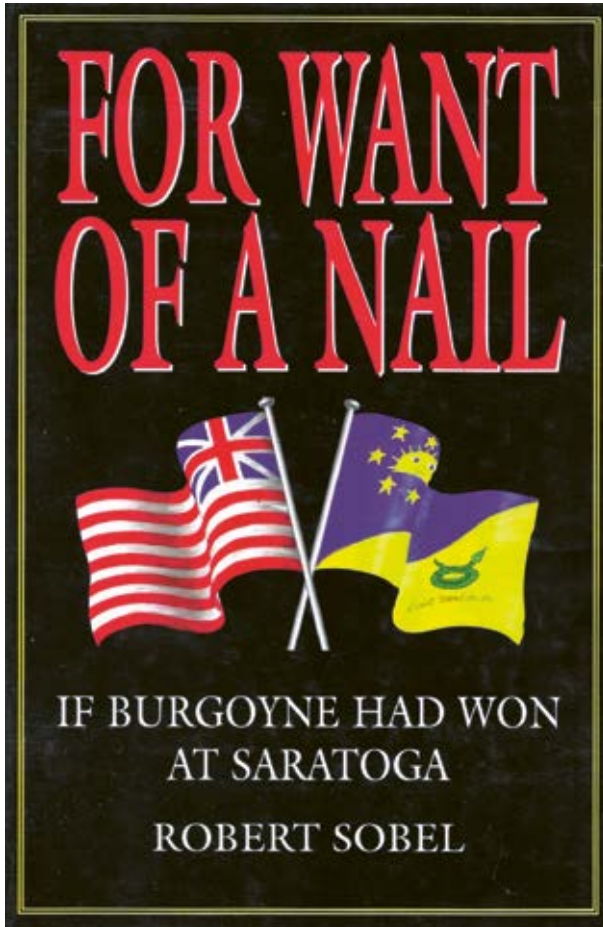


FIGURE 8.10 In Robert Sobel's book, *For Want of a Nail: If Burgoyne Had Won at Saratoga* (1973), Britain's defeat of the "North American Rebellion" in 1776 prevents the United States from coming into existence.

major consequences), Sobel believed the American Revolution's success was anything but inevitable. Its nightmarish depiction of history after the revolution's failure suggested that the historian was grateful the revolution happened as it did.

This reading is complicated, however, by the complex framing device used by Sobel for his narrative. *For Want of a Nail's* narrative is authored by an alternate "Robert Sobel," a man who is described in the book's preface and afterword as an Australian-born historian teaching at the University of Taiwan. It

is never made clear whether this alternate Sobel is the real Sobel's alter ego or his evil doppelgänger, but several hints point to the latter. In the book's afterword, we learn that "Robert Sobel" owes his university position in Taiwan to Kramer Associates, which has taken over the entire country.¹⁵³⁴ "Sobel" is thus exposed as a company shill and an unobjective analyst of modern history.¹⁵³⁵ This fact reveals the meaning of a key observation tucked into a footnote midway through the narrative in which "Sobel" counterfactually declares that "a rebel victory [in 1776] would have signaled the beginning of an age of anarchy, in which western civilization might have been crushed."¹⁵³⁶ Given "Sobel's" status as an unreliable narrator, we can infer that the real Sobel meant to convey the opposite—namely, the American Revolution was a positive event in history. The likelihood of this reading is further reinforced by the trajectory of Sobel's long publishing career. Having produced dozens of books on the positive impact of free market capitalism on American history, his depiction of a statist-oriented, corporate monopoly—Kramer Associates—adversely shaping world events can be seen as validating American history as it really occurred.¹⁵³⁷ Sobel's conservative political leanings further support this reading and suggest that his text endorsed the real course of historical events.¹⁵³⁸

Another notable nightmare appeared in Robert Wallace Russell's play, *Washington Shall Hang: A Drama of Lost Revolution* (1976) (Figure 8.11).¹⁵³⁹ The play's point of divergence takes place in 1781, when George Washington is captured, tried for treason, and sentenced to death by the British. The cause of this tragic turn of events is Benedict Arnold's ability to pull off his treasonous plot—hatched in 1780 with his wife Peggy Shippen and British Major John André—to capture Washington at West Point and surrender him to the British.¹⁵⁴⁰ Much of the play pivots on the drama of Washington's ensuing trial and does not depict the long-term consequences of the colonies' failure to break free from British rule. There is little doubt, however, that the consequences are dire. During the trial, it is revealed that other revolutionary leaders, such as John Adams, Thomas Jefferson, and John Hancock, have been "hanged, shot, [or] drowned in a barrel."¹⁵⁴¹ Moreover, Washington predicts that America is poised to "become another Ireland for the King's friends to pillage."¹⁵⁴² The play's British characters, such as Lieutenant Colonel Banastre Tarleton, mock Washington for his missed opportunities, noting that "had he succeeded,... [his] name ... would have been given to the rivers,... the cities, and the very mountaintops of this land"—before adding, "he has failed."¹⁵⁴³ Washington himself realizes that his defeat is the product of chance. When Peggy Shippen notes during the trial how she had once been locked in her attic by her father after a romantic dalliance, Washington retorts "had he left you locked in the attic, there might now be a United States of America."¹⁵⁴⁴ In the

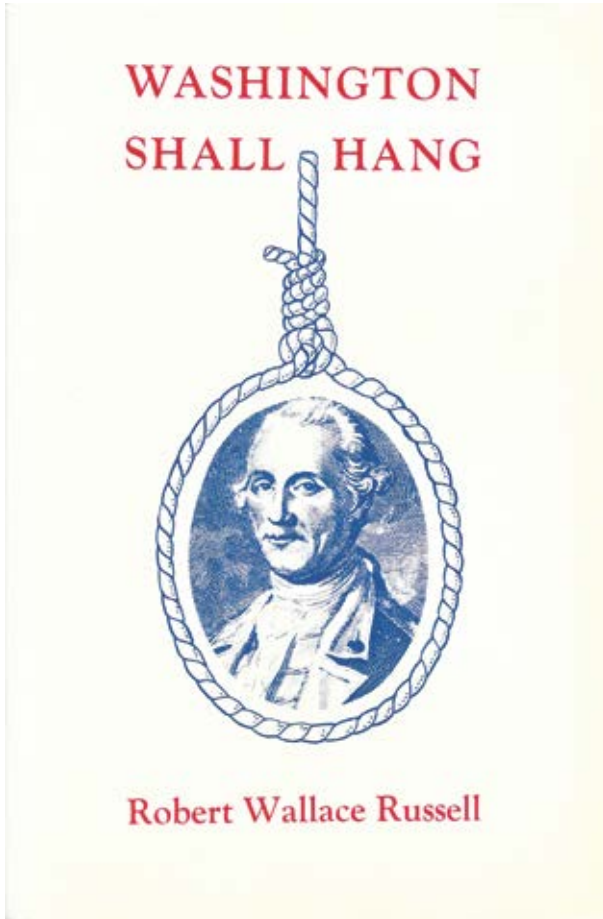


FIGURE 8.11 Robert Wallace Russell's play, *Washington Shall Hang* (1976), depicted the British capturing and executing George Washington while defeating the American Revolution.

end, though, Washington seeks redemptive meaning in his suffering, declaring that his "own loss of liberty" has helped him realize "what slavery means at last!"¹⁵⁴⁵ Washington goes to the gallows insisting that "everything happens for the best" and "we shall triumph over all our misfortunes."¹⁵⁴⁶

An accomplished Hollywood screenwriter and Broadway playwright, Russell seems to have conceived the idea for the play in the late 1960s and was quoted in 1971 saying it sought to examine "the mad ... ideals" at the heart of the American Republic.¹⁵⁴⁷ The play never appears to have been performed, however. Still, given Russell's personal history as an OSS officer in World War II, it

stands to reason that he shared his generation's broader patriotism and wrote the play to endorse American history as it transpired.

The final major alternate history was the American political scientist John P. Roche's 1976 essay in *TV Guide*, "And That's the Way It Was, July 4th, 1776."¹⁵⁴⁸ An example of a Connecticut Yankee counterfactual, the essay examined how the American Revolution would have been covered by broadcast journalists if television had existed in the eighteenth century. In the essay, an unnamed narrator describes how the coverage of key events by the Patriot Broadcasting Network (PBN) and Continental Broadcasting Network (CBN) would have ended up defeating the revolution. In a series of exposés, the networks reveal that colonial leaders have been conducting backroom negotiations with the widely-hated French to support the revolution (Ben Franklin claims the reports are "propaganda ... [meant] to divide the American people") and have been depriving colonial soldiers of "back pay," making them survive on "charity."¹⁵⁴⁹ The networks also criticize the colonial leadership's refusal to listen to the demands of an emergent "peace party" for "Negotiations Now" with the British. These revelations end up sapping popular support for the revolution (a PBN opinion poll reveals 39% of respondents believe "Congress has been too stubborn") and in 1780, Benedict Arnold reveals in a live TV interview that he is defecting to the British and calling for the reincorporation of the colonies into the Empire as the United American Provinces (UAP). As the essay concludes, the author reports that George Washington has retired to Mount Vernon "to write his memoirs," before signing off with the exclamation "God Save the Queen!"¹⁵⁵⁰

In offering this pessimistic account, Roche expressed his disaffection with the American media's coverage of political issues in the 1960s and 1970s. Beyond being an academic, Roche was also a syndicated journalist and adviser to President Lyndon Johnson. He also supported the U.S. war in Vietnam and believed that critical television coverage of the conflict was to blame for popular opposition to it.¹⁵⁵¹ By showing how negative media accounts of the American Revolution would have prevented it from succeeding in alternate history, he critiqued what he viewed as the media's undermining of America's national interests in the present.

The nightmares presented in these alternate histories echoed the beliefs of many Americans. In the period leading up to the Bicentennial, American journalists published numerous articles arguing that the revolution's success was hardly inevitable. Some pointed out the danger faced by the original signers of the Declaration of Independence, noting that "if [they had been] captured by the British, all would have been hanged for treason."¹⁵⁵² Others pointed to key battles that might have turned out otherwise. One writer noted

that if the American General, Henry Knox, had not succeeded in transporting heavy artillery from Fort Ticonderoga in New York to George Washington's troops in Boston in January of 1776, "America might have lost its fight for nationhood in its infancy."¹⁵⁵³ Another argued that if the Battle of Moore's Creek Bridge in North Carolina in February of 1776 had not prevented British ships from entering Cape Fear and cutting off weapons arriving from France, "the American Revolution might have been historically aborted into something like 'Washington's Rebellion.'"¹⁵⁵⁴ Finally, many commentators noted the critical importance of French support for the revolution, declaring it "might well have failed without the help of France" and adding, "we couldn't have done it by ourselves."¹⁵⁵⁵ All of these claims expressed relief that history turned out as it did.

Various observers recognized that wondering "what if?" about the revolution helped Americans psychologically cope with present-day anxieties. One writer said it provided consolation in a time of crisis, declaring that "as we recover from the wounds of Watergate and Vietnam," it was "soothing to go back to the days of Washington" and recall that "the American Revolution was a hard, bloody war we might well have lost."¹⁵⁵⁶ The historians Henry Steele Commager and Richard B. Morris added that in "a time of crisis like the present," it was appropriate to express gratitude for the revolution's "many glorious achievements," noting that "had the war been conducted by vengeful demagogues," it might have led to "a reign of terror."¹⁵⁵⁷ Finally, one journalist wrote that contemplating the revolution's failure would hopefully remind ordinary Americans "to count [their] blessings" about their many "great freedoms."¹⁵⁵⁸

By contrast, other commentators insisted that the American Revolution's failure would have improved the course of history. In March of 1975, a mysterious full-page advertisement paid for by a "Committee for Reunion with England" appeared in several American newspapers (Figure 8.12). Written by two young college graduates, John Ambrose and David Gambill, the advertisement used counterfactual reasoning to condemn the American Revolution as a "grievous mistake."¹⁵⁵⁹ Complaining that the Bicentennial was turning American history into "propaganda," they speculated that "every injustice could have been prevented if only those radical and hot-headed men had been patient enough to work within the system." Drawing on the fact that "SLAVERY WAS ABOLISHED IN THE BRITISH EMPIRE ... two score and sixteen years before the Emancipation Proclamation," the advertisement declared that "THERE WOULD HAVE BEEN NO CIVIL WAR, no Reconstruction Period, [and] no Ku Klux Klan" without the revolution, adding that "WORLD WARS I AND II WOULD HAVE NEVER OCCURRED" since "Germany would never have

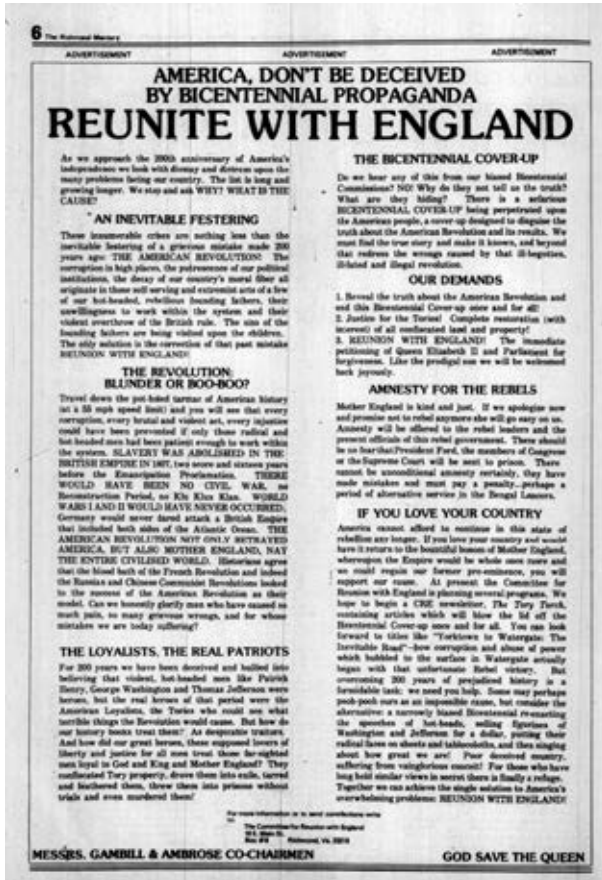


FIGURE 8.12 The short-lived "Committee for Reunion with England" (1976) argued that history would have turned out better if the British had suppressed the American Revolution.

dared attack a British Empire that included both sides of the Atlantic Ocean." The writers of the manifesto directly attacked present-day American woes, asserting that "the abuse of power which bubbled to the surface in Watergate actually began with that unfortunate Rebel victory." They further insisted that a "nefarious Bicentennial COVER-UP" was being "perpetrated upon the American people" to "disguise the truth about the American Revolution." The only way to make amends, they concluded, was for the U.S. to "petition ... Queen Elizabeth II ... for forgiveness" and restore confiscated Tory property.¹⁵⁶⁰

While the manifesto was a prank intended to counter what its authors called the "commercialization" of the Bicentennial, their arguments were echoed by

other writers.¹⁵⁶¹ Historians were especially eager to challenge the triumphalistic framing of the nation's 200th birthday celebration. Among the counterfactually oriented essays that appeared in this period, historian George P. Schmidt's article "But What Would Life Be Like if George III Had Won?" challenged the era's "star spangled platitudes" by noting that "if the fight for independence [had]... been lost," a "number of things would have turned out ... for the better." Under British rule, he noted, the country would have "turned into a parliamentary system" and avoided unrepresentative institutions like the Senate; economic growth would have been "more orderly"; slavery would have been abolished "a generation sooner ... without four years of bloody civil war"; and "both world wars just might have been avoided."¹⁵⁶² Historian Ralph Ladd offered similar reasons for rejecting the "Bicentennial hoopla," while historian John Beeson declared that exploring "what might have been" could prevent the Bicentennial from becoming a "jingoistic charade."¹⁵⁶³ Finally, a group of prominent Harvard historians, including David Donald, John Clive, and Harold Hanham, wrote that "in the midst of commemorating our fight for independence ... [we should] consider possible alternatives to revolution."¹⁵⁶⁴

The most prominent narrative that fantasized about the revolution's failure was L. Neil Smith's novel *The Probability Broach* (1980).¹⁵⁶⁵ A hybrid tale blending science fiction and alternate history, the novel portrayed the disorienting experiences of a Denver detective, Lieutenant Win Bear, who finds himself transported via a time machine (known as a "probability broach") from the U.S. of 1987 to a parallel "North American Confederation" (NAC) in the year 211 A. L. (*Anno Liberatis*). As he quickly learns, the confederation's origins date back to the year 1794, when the Pennsylvania Congressman and later Treasury Secretary, Albert Gallatin, decides to support (rather than oppose) the anti-tax revolt known as the Whiskey Rebellion and marches with thousands of rebels to Philadelphia, where they execute George Washington, revoke the Constitution, and replaced the Federal Government with a loose confederation of sovereign states. In the two centuries that follow, the NAC develops into an "anarchocapitalist" utopia, where individual freedom, small government, and abundant personal firearms produce technological innovation, health, and prosperity for all. Many salutary events ensue: Thomas Jefferson abolishes slavery in 44 A. L. (1820), there is no Civil War, and despite some lingering militarism from Prussia in Europe, neither World War occurs. Although Lieutenant Bear takes some time to get used to the new world, he gradually embraces its motto that "all you have to do is leave people alone."¹⁵⁶⁶ Indeed, after he helps defeat time traveling imperialists from the United States who seek to use the probability broach to conquer the NAC with nuclear weapons, Bear resolves to improve American history by using the time traveling mechanism to "drag the

United States ..., kicking and screaming, through two centuries of peace and freedom it managed to miss by letting Alexander Hamilton screw things up in 1789.”¹⁵⁶⁷ Given the novel’s frequent attacks on big government and valorization of individual freedom, it should not surprise that its author was a committed Libertarian, who hoped that by negating the Revolution’s impact on American history, he could improve the American present.¹⁵⁶⁸

Other writers, finally, imagined that the Revolution’s failure would not have changed the overall course of U.S. history. Some commentators at the time of the Bicentennial, for example, took the deterministic position that the Revolution never could have been defeated. Arguing that the British “never had a chance,” journalist Edgar Williams in 1975 rejected the claim that “if this British general had done this or this British admiral had done that, the British would have won the war,” concluding that “once the colonies had decided for independence ... no military force could reverse that course.”¹⁵⁶⁹ Other American writers endorsed the comment made by Britain’s Prince Philip on July 4, 1976, that there was no way that “the United States ... would have remained ... an enormous appendage to a small island.”¹⁵⁷⁰ The most in-depth commentary was journalist Gwynne Dyer’s alternate history essay “What Would America Be If George III Had Won in 1776?”, which asserted that “if King George’s redcoats had [won],” America would “not [have been] very different.” Arguing that “the arrival of full democracy would have [merely] been postponed,” Dyer said that because of ongoing “westward migration,” the North American continent “would have passed into the control of English-speaking America,” a “federal system would have arisen ... as it did in ... Canada [and] Australia,” and “the ‘great wave of European immigration in the later 1800s would have ... produced the same ethnic mix with or without rule from London.” Just as a “gentle drifting apart” gave “other former British dominions their independence,” America by the twentieth century would be “the great world power.”¹⁵⁷¹

The diverging ways in which American alternate histories imagined the failure of the American Revolution was mirrored by their mixed reception. The most widely reviewed narrative, Sobel’s *For Want of a Nail*, met with a highly divided response. Praised as a “visionary saga,” a “remarkable book,” and a “tour de force,” it was profiled in *Time Magazine* and eventually nominated for a Pulitzer Prize.¹⁵⁷² Other commentators, however, dismissed the book as a “completely pointless” work of fiction that left readers little alternative but to ask, “so what?”¹⁵⁷³ None of the era’s other narratives received the same degree of attention. Smith’s novel, *The Probability Broach*, received only scattered reviews, probably due to its niche marketing as a work of science fiction. Wallace’s play, *Washington Shall Hang*, met with little response when it was published in book form in 1976. By contrast, the advertisement run by

the Committee for Reuniting with England received lots of coverage in the American, and even British, media, but it was mostly viewed as a curiosity.¹⁵⁷⁴ The surging production of alternate histories, in short, was not echoed by a correspondingly prominent reception.

Other Alternate Histories

In addition to exploring World War II, the Civil War, and the American Revolution, writers in the U.S., Great Britain, and other European countries addressed many other topics. While fewer in number, they testified to the growing prominence of alternate history in western culture and revealed how writers reimagined the past to comment on the present.

American writers explored a wide range of historical events. They spanned everything from the life of Jesus, in works such as John Clagett's novel *A World Unknown* (1975), to the travels of Christopher Columbus, which Harry Turtledove examined in his short story "Report of the Special Committee on the Quality of Life" (1980).¹⁵⁷⁵ The most common topics, however, were twentieth-century events with present-day ramifications. They included the United States's nuclear attack against Hiroshima in 1945, which was the focus of Kim Stanley Robinson's short story "The Lucky Strike" (1984); the assassination of John F. Kennedy in 1963 and ensuing escalation of the U.S. War in Vietnam, which Otis L. Graham covered in his essay "The United States and Vietnam -- What If John F. Kennedy Had Lived?"; and Richard Nixon's Watergate scandal of 1974, which was the subject of Charles O. Jones's text "What If There Had Been a Nixon Presidency Without Watergate?" (1982).¹⁵⁷⁶ All these tales employed subtractive cause counterfactuals to undo real historical tragedies, thereby expressing American regrets about the crisis-ridden nature of American life between the mid-1960s and the 1980s.

In Britain, writers focused on a narrower range of topics, but one of the most significant was England remaining (or once more becoming) a Catholic state. Keith Roberts' novel *Pavane* (1968) and Kingsley Amis's novel *The Alteration* (1976) explored this topic from different perspectives (Figure 8.13). While the former imagined Queen Elizabeth I's assassination enabling the Spanish Armada to defeat England in 1588, the latter imagined Henry VIII never becoming King and severing England's ties with the Papacy. Both novels depicted these events as having mostly nightmarish consequences for twentieth-century England. Under the rule of a tyrannical Catholic theocracy, the country never develops the Protestant work ethic, fails to experience the Industrial Revolution, and remains stunted in science, technology, and culture.

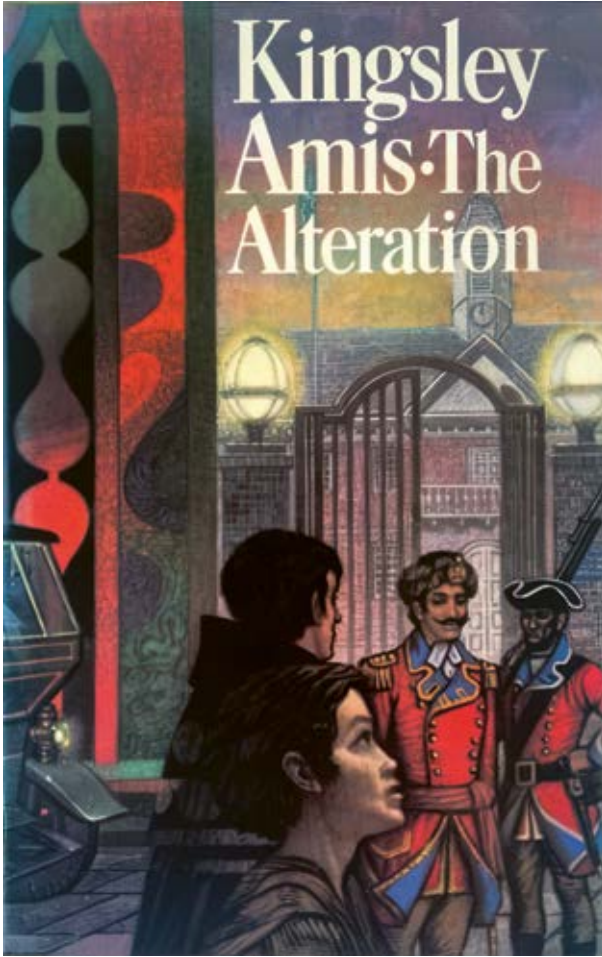


FIGURE 8.13 Kingsley Amis's 1976 novel, *The Alteration* (1976), imagined Henry VIII never becoming King and England evolving into a tyrannical Catholic theocracy.

At the same time, the novels depicted the inhabitants of England enjoying the serenity of a world enchanted by religious certainty. In presenting this complicated picture, Roberts and Amis explored the age-old conflict between progress and tradition.¹⁵⁷⁷ They also offered pessimistic commentaries on England's post-imperial decline.¹⁵⁷⁸

In the German-speaking world, alternate histories focused on a range of themes. A good number predictably portrayed the Nazis winning World War II. But unlike Anglo-American accounts, these narratives depicted a Nazi

triumph exclusively in dystopian terms. This was true of Austrian writer Otto Basil's 1966 novel *Wenn das der Führer wüsste* (*If Only the Führer Knew*), which portrayed Hitler's triumph swiftly leading to global nuclear war; German writer Helmut Heissenbüttel's 1978 short story "Wenn Adolf Hitler den Krieg nicht gewonnen hätte" ("If Adolf Hitler Had Not Won the War"), which depicted the victorious Reich establishing a computerized surveillance state; German writer Arno Lubos's 1980 novel *Schwiebus*, which showed the Reich turning on its most loyal supporters; and Ralph Giordano's 1989 book *Wenn Hitler den Krieg gewonnen hätte* (*If Hitler Had Won the War*), which documented the Nazis' plans for a racial empire in the event of military victory.¹⁵⁷⁹ Written by men who had personally lived through the horrors of the Nazi era, these nightmares simultaneously expressed regret for the regime's crimes and gratitude for the postwar world's relative stability.¹⁵⁸⁰

German writers explored other topics as well. Carl Amery published two alternate history novels: *Das Königsprojekt* (*The Royal Project*) (1974), which portrayed the Papacy using a time machine to Catholicize England and negate the Reformation, and *An den Feuern der Leyermark* (*At the Fires of Leyermark*) (1979), which imagined Bavaria employing American Civil War veterans to defeat the Prussian army in the war of 1866 and becoming an independent country (Figure 8.14).¹⁵⁸¹ Finally, Carl von Boeheim's novel, *Die Kaisersage: Utopia Austriaca* (*The Kaiser Legend*) (1960) depicted the Habsburg Crown Prince Rudolf's (fictional) younger brother, Franz Stefan, becoming Kaiser after the early death of Emperor Franz Joseph and thereby preventing the eruption of World War I.¹⁵⁸² While Amery wrote from the political left and Boeheim from the political right, both imagined German history avoiding the disasters of Nazism and World War II.¹⁵⁸³ They used fantasy to explore what other German writers imagined through nightmare.

Italian writers also dealt with World War II's legacy. In depicting Benito Mussolini earning acclaim from the Italian people for developing an atomic bomb and winning World War II, the right-wing writer Marco Ramperti's 1950 novel *Benito I., Imperatore* (*Emperor Benito I*) produced a fantasy meant to mock postwar Italian intellectuals who opportunistically transformed themselves from fascists into democrats after 1945.¹⁵⁸⁴ By contrast, the left-wing writer Lucio Ceva's 1973 novel *Asse Pigliatutto: Memorie 1937–1943 del nob. gen. Triora di Rondissone* (*The Axis Takes Everything*) explored a nightmare world in which Italy refrained from declaring war on the U.S. in 1941 and created a Fascist empire from Nice to the Persian Gulf, before ultimately being toppled by the anti-fascist resistance.¹⁵⁸⁵ A similar agenda inspired Vanni Ronsisvalle's 1980 novel *La grande Mummia* (*The Great Mummy*), which imagined Mussolini winning World War II and transforming half of the world into a fascist empire,

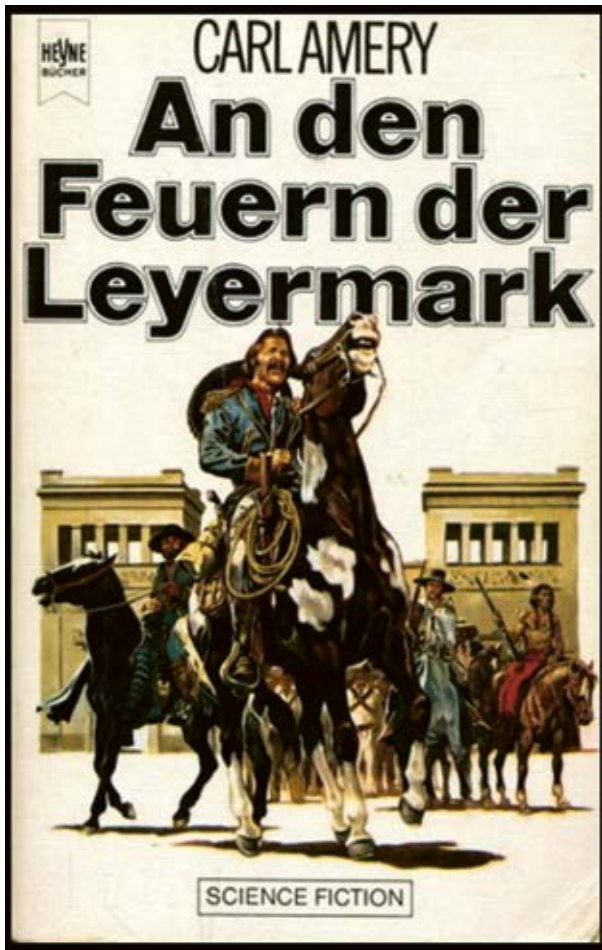


FIGURE 8.14 Carl Amery's novel, *An den Feuern der Leyermark* (*At the Fires of Leyermark*) (1979), imagined Bavaria becoming an independent country in 1866.

whose inhabitants worship his mummified corpse.¹⁵⁸⁶ Finally, Guido Morselli's 1975 novel *Contro-passato prossimo: Un'ipotesi retrospettiva* (*Past Conditional: A Retrospective Hypothesis*) fantasized that the Central Powers won World War I, established a socialist federation, and prevented the rise of Fascism.¹⁵⁸⁷

In France, alternate histories examined a wider range of topics. Unlike the case of the U.S., Britain, Germany, and Italy, France lacked a critical mass of narratives about the Second World War.¹⁵⁸⁸ Instead, most French narratives expressed concerns about postwar French political life. By imagining the Roman procurator, Pontius Pilate, pardoning Jesus, preventing the rise of

Christianity, and sparing the world centuries of religious violence, the literary critic and anti-fascist intellectual Roger Cailliois's 1961 novel *Pontius Pilate* sought to critique the French-Algerian War of the 1950s.¹⁵⁸⁹ Frederic Bon and Michel-Antoine Burnier's depiction of the May 1968 revolution achieving its goals in their 1968 novella *Si mai avait gagné* (*If May Had Succeeded*) expressed the writers' left-wing critique of the French communist party's role in the failed revolt.¹⁵⁹⁰ Finally, science fiction writer Jacques Boireau's 1976 short story "Les enfants d'Ibn Khaldoun" depicted Muslim forces defeating the Franks at the Battle of Tours in 714, thereby reversing the two peoples' subsequent historical development.¹⁵⁹¹

In Eastern Europe, Soviet limitations on free expression kept most writers from speculating about the past, but notable texts nevertheless appeared.¹⁵⁹² Two Hungarian narratives, László Gáspár's 1945 novel *Mi, I. Adolf* (*We, Adolf I.*) and Miklós Ajtay's 1950 novel *Si l'Allemagne avait vaincu* (*If Germany Had Won*), explored the nightmare of Nazi Germany winning World War II to express Hungarian discontent with the postwar world.¹⁵⁹³ The Polish exile writer Teodor Parnicki's 1970 novel *A Muse of Distant Journeys* (1970) fantasized about alternate forms of Polish statehood coming into being prior to 1918.¹⁵⁹⁴ Finally, the Russian dissident writer and later expatriate Vasily Aksyonov's 1979 novel *Ostrov Krym* (*The Island of Crimea*) reversed part of the Soviet Union's tragic twentieth-century history by depicting the Crimea remaining independent in the 1920s and evolving into a prosperous enclave free of Soviet control.¹⁵⁹⁵

What's in a Name? Inventing "Alternate History"

Although cultural counterfactuals proliferated after 1945, it took some time before they were called "alternate histories." Many of the era's most important texts, such as Ward Moore's *Bring the Jubilee*, Philip K. Dick's *The Man in the High Castle*, and Kingsley Amis's *The Alteration*, were originally categorized as works of science fiction.¹⁵⁹⁶ Since all three authors were already associated with the genre, the categorization made sense at the time. But reviewers had more difficulty categorizing alternate histories by other writers. Norman Longmate's 1972 book, *If Britain Had Fallen*, was originally called a "strange literary species" in a "no-man's land" between history and fiction.¹⁵⁹⁷ The same was true of Robert Sobel's *For Want of a Nail*, which prompted one reviewer to ask, "What sort of 'history' is this?"¹⁵⁹⁸ Given such confusion, most reviewers continued to link alternate history to science fiction well into the 1980s.¹⁵⁹⁹

Before the concept of "alternate history" could gain widespread acceptance, it had to displace the closely related concept of "alternative history." While the distinction between the two terms sounds trivial, it was anything but. In its

original incarnation, the idea of “alternative history” did not refer to “what if” narratives but “bottom-up” works of social history that gave expression to “other,” usually unheard, voices. In 1976, for example, the producers of the play “The Voice of the People” described it as “an alternative history of the United States,” while in 1986, Black groups protesting the centennial of the Statue of Liberty called for moving beyond “America’s white past” and forging “an alternative history for Americans.”¹⁶⁰⁰ As was seen by the inclusion of “an alternative history” in the subtitles and reviews of various books, the phrase became synonymous with revisionist history from below.¹⁶⁰¹

Observers after the late 1970s thus embraced a different, if linguistically related, term to describe counterfactual fiction—“alternate history.” Although some commentators continued to use the older term, alternate history came to be used with sufficient frequency to prompt critics to recognize its independent identity.¹⁶⁰² In 1988, one writer pointed to Keith Roberts’s *Pavane* and Philip K. Dick’s *The Man in the High Castle* as among the “many alternate histories” that have been around “for ... decades.”¹⁶⁰³ Around the same time, another writer declared that “alternate history novels are a subgenre unto themselves.”¹⁶⁰⁴

Finally, alternate history’s independent identity was confirmed by growing signs of intertextuality in the era’s narratives. The producers of alternate history were often influenced by other works and made explicit references to them in their texts. Philip K. Dick was partly inspired by Ward Moore’s *Bring the Jubilee* to write *The Man in the High Castle*.¹⁶⁰⁵ Dick’s novel, in turn, had an important impact on Kingsley Amis’s novel *The Alteration*, which was also influenced by Sarban’s *The Sound of His Horn* and Keith Roberts’ *Pavane*.¹⁶⁰⁶ Harry Harrison’s *Rebel in Time* depicted a key character possessing a copy of *The Alteration*.¹⁶⁰⁷ And MacKinlay Kantor’s “If The South Had Won the Civil War” influenced many of the alternate Civil War novels of the 1980s, especially David C. Poyer’s *The Shiloh Project*.¹⁶⁰⁸ These examples further contributed to alternate history’s emergence as an cohesive literary genre.

Conclusion

Between 1945 and 1989, alternate history became a bona fide cultural phenomenon across the western world. Alternate histories appeared in many different forms and developed into a popular genre of entertainment. Alternate histories were the most abundant in the United States and Great Britain, where an impressive number of narratives explored the topics of World War II, the American Civil War, and the American Revolution. These topics differed substantially from one another, but the way they were reimagined followed a

common pattern: while the narratives in the comparatively stable, early post-war decades (1945 to the mid-1960s) tended to be self-congratulatory, those of the ensuing crisis years (the mid-1960s to the 1980s) tended to be more self-critical. As domestic and foreign policy crises roiled Britain and the U.S., alternate histories expressed presentist concerns and altered prior patterns of counterfactual representation. The same tendency shaped the alternate histories that appeared other countries. Whether in Germany, France, Italy, or Eastern Europe, alternate histories were typically employed to express regret and relief about the postwar world. Finally, as in earlier eras, the proliferation of cultural counterfactuals produced a self-reflexive response from writers, scholars, and other critics, who sought to conceptualize the phenomenon. While they disagreed for a time, they ultimately settled on a new term, "alternate history." As the period after 1989 would prove, the newly christened cultural phenomenon had yet to achieve its full potential.

Into the Mainstream: Canonizing Counterfactuals, 1989–Present

[As we] think ... about [how] our past can help us talk about our future,... we wish to recommend ... counterfactual thinking ... It can be a parlour game, but it informs all historical thinking about causality and, therefore, responsibility. In an age of sustainability, counterfactual thinking ... is everyone's business.¹⁶⁰⁹
(Jo Guldi and David Armitage 2014)

In the years after 1989, counterfactual history attained unprecedented popularity throughout the western world. Analytical counterfactuals surged in a wave of books, essays, and op-eds. Cultural counterfactuals swelled in a flood of novels, films, and television programs. The wave of “what ifs” appeared in numerous countries and covered countless historical topics. From the English-speaking world to the lands of the former Soviet bloc, people speculated about old topics, such as the twentieth century’s world wars, and new topics, like the fall of communism and the crimes of imperialism. The number of counterfactual narratives was vast, significantly eclipsing that of earlier eras. Indeed, counterfactual history became a veritable industry, with publishers and studios competing for a share of the growing market. As the avalanche of historical speculation gathered momentum, it attracted the attention of scholars who sought to explain it in academic studies. In so doing, they helped to canonize counterfactual history as a legitimate enterprise and move it from the margins to the mainstream of western life. As historians Jo Guldi and David Armitage asserted in their *History Manifesto* of 2014, counterfactual history was increasingly regarded as an indispensable form of historical thought.

The canonization of counterfactual history did not take place without friction, however. As wondering “what if?” became more popular in western life, critics attacked it with an array of accusations. Some revived the claim that speculating about the past was a futile activity grounded in wishful thinking. Others went further and accused counterfactual history of harboring a conservative, if not right-wing, political agenda. As a result, counterfactual history became the source of renewed controversy. But it also assumed a more secure place in western life than ever before.

Historicizing the Surge

As in earlier eras, this willingness of people to wonder “what if?” was fueled by the rapid pace of change. In the years after 1989, various political, economic, social, and technological developments profoundly shaped western intellectual and cultural life. These developments swiftly eroded the bipolar stability of the Cold War world and prompted people to reassess the relationship between past and present.

The most important political development was the initial triumph, and subsequent crisis, of western liberalism. In the decade after 1989, liberalism reigned triumphant. The collapse of communism in Eastern Europe and the end of the Cold War produced an unprecedented wave of optimism marked by a belief in the “end of history” and the arrival of permanent liberal hegemony. Around the same time, the increasing willingness of nations to confront historical injustices during the worldwide “memory boom” confirmed the liberal faith that addressing “unmastered pasts” could advance the cause of historical progress.¹⁶¹⁰ After the turn of the millennium, however, western optimism took a major hit. In the United States, the domestic faith in liberalism experienced a blow with the bitterly contested election between George W. Bush and Al Gore in 2000. In the realm of foreign affairs, the Al Qaeda terrorist attacks of September 11, 2001, and the ensuing “War on Terror” shattered western confidence in the safety of the post-Cold War world. During the early 2000s, most westerners actively defended the liberal democratic order, but with the onset of the world financial crisis of 2007–08, their faith began to wane. The spreading of economic hardship in Europe and North America, together with the flight of Middle Eastern and North African migrants to Europe following the chaos unleashed by the Arab Spring in 2011, led rightwing populist movements to attack the liberal order. The ability of these movements to gain state power in Eastern Europe—and, after 2016, the United States—further added to this climate of crisis. The inability of liberal governments to respond effectively to climate change, the COVID-19 pandemic of 2020, and the Russian invasion of Ukraine in 2022 confronted the liberal order with further stress tests, the results of which remain unknown to this day.

Major intellectual and cultural developments further sharpened the sense of insecurity. Building on its origins in the 1970s and 80s, postmodernism continued to shape western culture in controversial ways. While left-of-center observers supported the postmodern critique of metanarratives for valorizing otherness, difference, and pluralism, conservative critics attacked postmodernism for undermining the belief in universal values, promoting the

relativistic rejection of objective truth, and sapping the west's self-confidence in its struggle against Islamist extremism. New scientific theories also contributed to the era's sense of uncertainty. The advent of chaos theory, complexity theory, and mathematical theories on risk and probability revealed how minor causes could have major consequences (the "butterfly effect") and, in so doing, exposed the vulnerability of the existing order.¹⁶¹¹ The sense of uncertainty was also amplified by the information revolution. Between the mid-1990s and the first decade of the twenty-first century, the emergence of laptop computers, digital cameras, and cellular phones converged with the spread of internet access to produce a world that was more interconnected than ever before. These developments injected a new sense of dynamism into western life, but they also spawned a sense of disorientation. After the advent of social media enabled people to bypass elite gatekeepers and democratize the production of information, people were able to cloister themselves in information bubbles where they could luxuriate in the customized reality of a "post-truth" world.¹⁶¹² In some cases, as with claims about the "stolen" 2020 presidential election in the U.S., people began to fabricate the very substance of history itself. Any shared truth that once existed—and all the certainties that it entailed—had now vanished.

All these trends fostered the growth of counterfactual history. As people lost their faith in ideological certainty, they lost their confidence in deterministic philosophies of history. They also became convinced that historical events were shaped less by structural forces than individual agency. They were reminded of this reality by the fact that powerful individuals on the world stage—whether autocratic leaders like Vladimir Putin and Donald Trump or tech titans like Mark Zuckerberg and Elon Musk—were able to shape events according to their idiosyncratic whims. As people were confronted with the capriciousness of historical change, they became more aware of how easily the past might have been different. The relevance of counterfactuals was also reinforced by the enduring influence of postmodernism. By rejecting objective truth and embracing irony over ideology, postmodernism encouraged the kind of skepticism that has long nurtured counterfactual thinking. Postmodernism was especially significant for sparking "alternative" forms of cultural expression that bolstered the status of alternate history. This quest for alternatives was further reinforced by the information revolution, which gave rise to a range of "alt" websites, newsgroups, and discussion boards, and by the rise of rightwing populism, which produced the Alt-Right in the U.S. and the Alternative for Germany (AfD) party in the Federal Republic of Germany. It even produced something of an epistemological revolution by producing the belief in "alternative facts."¹⁶¹³ All of these developments,

by encouraging people to seek alternatives to reigning political, intellectual, and cultural norms, promoted the tendency to imagine alternatives to the historical record.

A Flood of Counterfactuals

The willingness of people to wonder “what if?” found expression in both analytical and cultural counterfactuals. Whether in historical monographs or streaming internet television shows, counterfactuals spread like never before.

Analytical Counterfactuals

The popularity of analytical counterfactuals first manifested itself in a wave of edited anthologies. Inaugurated by Anglo-American military historians eager to mark the fiftieth anniversary of the end of World War II, the wave commenced with Peter Tsouras’s collection *Disaster at D-Day: The Germans Defeat the Allies, June 1944* (1994) and Kenneth Macksey’s volume *The Hitler Options: Alternate Decisions of World War II* (1995).¹⁶¹⁴ Around the same time, the American military historian Robert Cowley conceived the idea for an anthology of counterfactual essays for the journal *Military History Quarterly*, which was published in 1998, and later expanded into the best-selling mass market volume *What If?* (1999). Beyond military history, scholars discussed other topics, as was seen in Philip Tetlock and Aaron Belkin’s academic volume *Counterfactual Thought Experiments in World Politics* (1996) and Niall Ferguson’s pioneering, mass market anthology *Virtual History* (1997) (Figure 9.1). After the turn of the millennium, a flood of sequels and spin-offs appeared, including Cowley’s edited volumes *What If 2* (2001) and *What Ifs of American History* (2003), together with dozens of anthologies in the English-speaking world and other countries, including Australia, New Zealand, Ireland, Germany, France, Spain, Poland, Hungary, Finland, Serbia, Mexico, and Argentina.¹⁶¹⁵

After the year 2000, analytical counterfactuals also appeared in the form of individually authored monographs. The most significant were books entirely devoted to historical speculation. They included Roger Ransom’s *The Confederate States of America: What Might Have Been* (2005), Frank Harvey’s *Explaining the Iraq War: Counterfactual Theory, Logic, and Evidence* (2011), Peter J. Bowler’s *Darwin Deleted: Imagining a World Without Darwin* (2013), Richard Ned Lebow’s *Archduke Franz Ferdinand Lives!* (2014), Jeffrey Gurock’s *The Holocaust Averted: An Alternate History of American Jewry* (2015), and Jeff Greenfield’s two volumes, *Then Everything Changed: Stunning Alternate Histories of American Politics*,

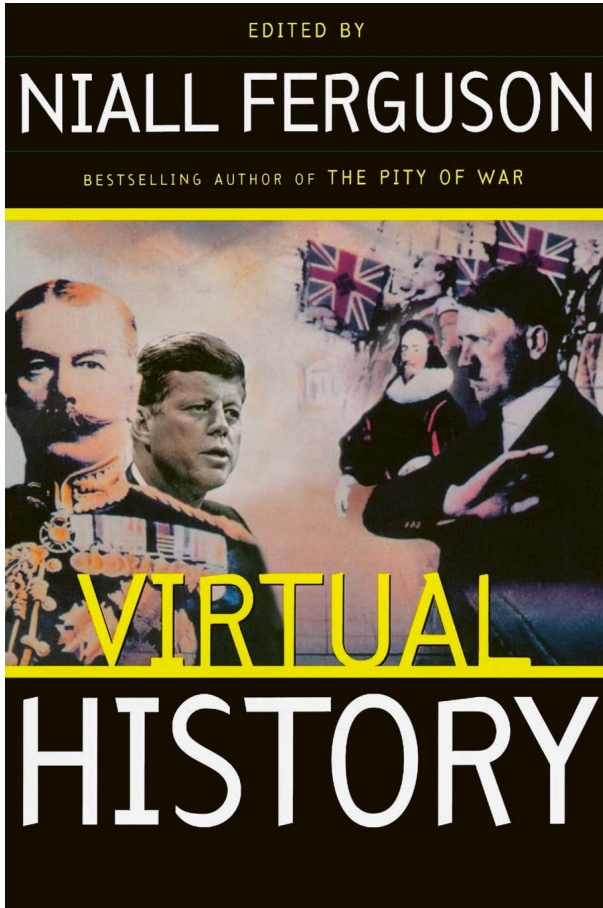


FIGURE 9.1 Niall Ferguson's anthology, *Virtual History* (1997) helped counterfactual history gain international attention.

JFK, RFK, Carter, Ford, Reagan (2011) and *If Kennedy Lived: The First and Second Terms of President John F. Kennedy: An Alternate History* (2013) (Figure 9.2). All these studies offered full-throated endorsements of counterfactual history as an essential method for pursuing historical understanding. In explaining why he explored how the world would have been different without Darwin's theory of natural selection, for example, Bowler wrote that "the counterfactualist argues for the contingency of history" and seeks "alternatives" to "probe the origins of the world we actually live in."¹⁶¹⁶

Other historians embraced "what ifs" by inserting medium form counterfactuals into their otherwise traditional narratives. In his book *Hitler's Thirty*

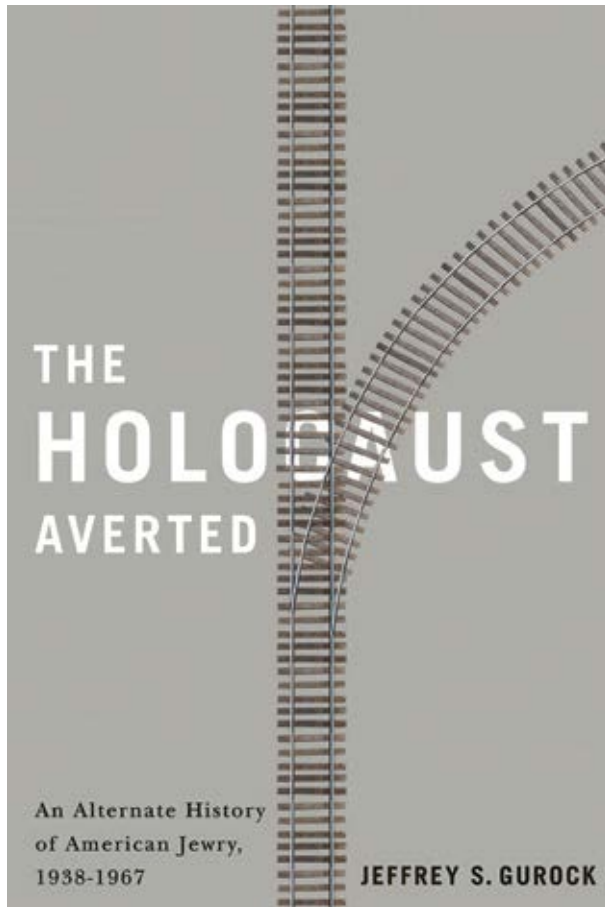


FIGURE 9.2 Jeffrey Gurock's book, *The Holocaust Averted* (2015), reflected the growing interest of academic historians in counterfactual history.

Days to Power (1997), Henry Turner dedicated his final chapter, “Determinacy, Contingency, and Responsibility,” to the ways in which Hitler could have been kept from becoming Chancellor in 1933 and how German history might have been different without him. Similarly, Anthony Pagden concluded his book *The Enlightenment: And Why It Still Matters* (2013) by examining what would have happened had the Enlightenment never occurred, while Steven Kotkin inserted a coda, “If Stalin Had Died,” at the end his of book *Stalin: Volume 1, Paradoxes of Power, 1878–1928* (2014).¹⁶¹⁷ In explaining their use of medium form counterfactuals, scholars explicitly endorsed “what if” thinking. In the prologue to his study *Jews for Sale? Nazi-Jewish Negotiations, 1933–1945* (2009), Yehuda Bauer

declared that he “consciously” departed “from accepted historical writing ... [by dealing] with might-have-beens,” while Walter Scheidel explained that his book *Escape From Rome: The Failure of Empire and the Road to Prosperity* (2019) made “explicit recourse to counterfactuals” since “we are all counterfactual historians.”¹⁶¹⁸

Analytical counterfactuals also proliferated in the mass media. Journalists increasingly included “what ifs” in their op-eds, as was seen in *New York Times* columnist Maureen Dowd’s essay “A Not So Wonderful Life” (2004), about how Donald Rumsfeld not being born would have affected the War in Iraq, and Bret Stephens’s essay “Imagining the Trump Presidency That Wasn’t” (2020), about how Donald Trump might have governed more as a moderate.¹⁶¹⁹ In 2014, National Public Radio (NPR) commemorated the 100th anniversary of World War I by asking its listeners “to help us imagine a counterfactual history of the last 100 years ... if the assassin in Sarajevo had missed.”¹⁶²⁰ In 2016, CNN launched a limited series called “Counterfactual Files,” which explored “what ifs” related to important historical events, such as the Cuban Missile Crisis and Watergate.¹⁶²¹ That same year in Britain, *The Guardian* sponsored a series of alternate history videos with Amazon, that included episodes like “What If Hitler Had Taken the World to War Sooner?”¹⁶²²

Cultural Counterfactuals

“What ifs” also proliferated in the form of cultural counterfactuals. Novels and short story collections led the way, with hundreds being published in the years after 1989. Most were conceived as traditional works of alternate history and marketed to the genre’s diehard fans. Some of the best-known works were written by the era’s most prolific writer, Harry Turtledove (Figure 9.3). Turtledove burst onto the national stage with his hit novel *Guns of the South* (1992) about the Confederacy winning the Civil War, and then published dozens of other alternate history novels between 1992 and 2025, including *The Two Georges* (about the failure of the American Revolution) and *In the Presence of Mine Enemies* (about the Nazis winning World War II). In the process, he became the public face of alternate history.¹⁶²³ Other writers achieved similar success, including Gregory Benford, who published four short story collections, including *Alternate Americas*, between 1989 and 1993; Mike Resnick, who published five anthologies, including *Alternate Presidents*, in the years 1992 to 1997; and Robert Conroy, who published ten novels between 1995 and 2015, including *1862* (about Britain supporting the Confederacy in the Civil War). Similar anthologies appeared in other countries, such as Great Britain and France, while many English language alternate histories appeared in foreign translation.¹⁶²⁴ All these volumes

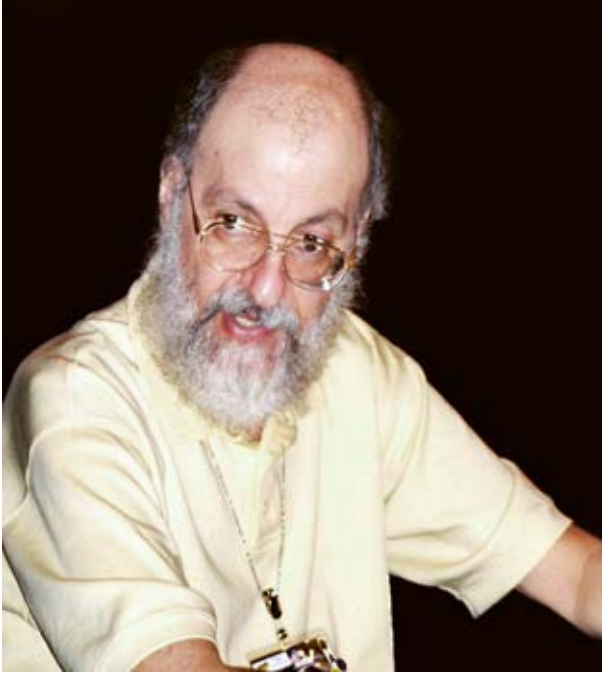


FIGURE 9.3 Ever since publishing, *Guns of the South* in 1992, Harry Turtledove has been the most prolific writer of alternate history novels. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

benefited from the increasing willingness of publishers to embrace alternate history. The most important in the U.S. were established science fiction and fantasy presses, such as Del Rey Books, Baen Books, and Tor Books, which saw the opportunity to transform alternate history into a profitable literary genre.¹⁶²⁵ New publishers also entered the field, such as British-based Sea Lion Press, which helped pioneer the eBook market for alternate history, publishing dozens of alternate history texts in the years after its founding in 2015.¹⁶²⁶

Equally important for the mainstreaming of alternate history was the appearance of crossover novels by well-known fiction writers. British author Robert Harris's novel *Fatherland* (1992), about the Nazis winning World War II, was an international bestseller that reignited public interest in alternate history. Soon thereafter, other well-known writers tried their hand at the genre, as was shown by Stephen Fry's novel *Making History* (1997), about Hitler never being born; Philip Roth's novel *The Plot Against America* (2004), about Charles Lindbergh being elected president of the U.S. in 1940; Michael Chabon's novel *The Yiddish Policemen's Union* (2007), about a Jewish state being established

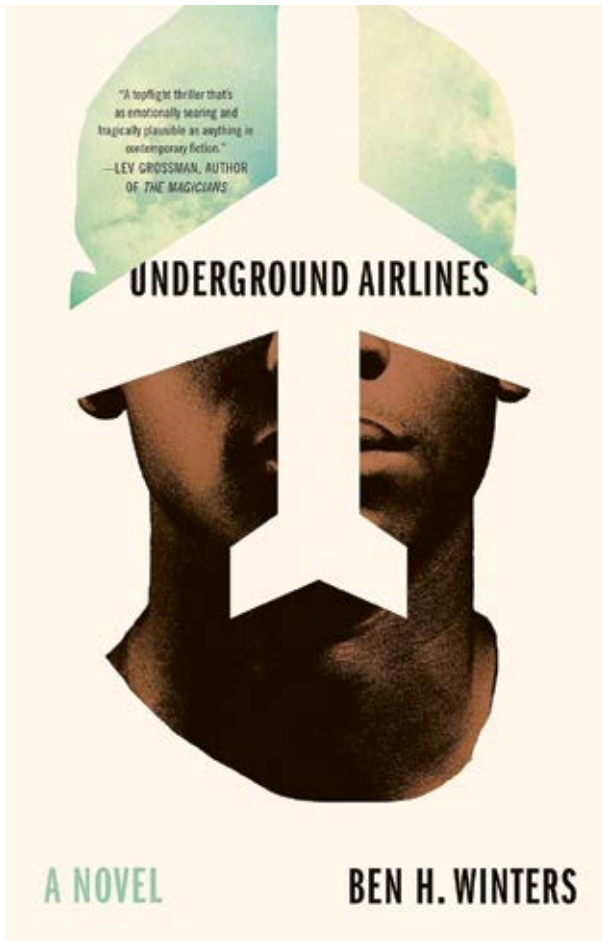


FIGURE 9.4 Ben Winters' novel, *Underground Airlines* (2016), was set in a present-day world where the Civil War never took place and slavery persists in portions of the U.S.

in Alaska in the early 1940s; Stephen King's novel *11/22/63* (2011), about JFK not being assassinated; Timur Vermes's 2012 novel *Er ist wieder da* (*Look Who's Back*), about Hitler becoming a talk-show host in present-day Berlin; Kate Atkinson's novel *Life After Life* (2013), about Hitler being killed in 1930; Colson Whitehead's novel *The Underground Railroad* (2016), about a more nightmarish antebellum South; Ben Winters' novel *Underground Airlines* (2016), about slavery persisting in an America where the Civil War never happened; and Curtis Sittenfeld's novel *Rodham* (2020), about Hillary Rodham never

marrying Bill Clinton (Figure 9.4). All these books introduced alternate history to readers who had never been exposed to the genre and enhanced its mainstream status.

Another notable growth area for alternate history after 1989 was film. As in the realm of literature, some works of cinema targeted aficionados of alternate history. This was true of films dealing with the Nazi era, such as Stephen Cornwell's *The Philadelphia Experiment II* (1993), Armin Mueller-Stahl's *Conversation with the Beast* (1996), and Barry Hershey's *The Empty Mirror* (1998); it was also true of films on other topics, such as Kevin Willmott's *CSA: The Confederate States of America* (2004), about the South winning the Civil War, and Koji Masutani's *Virtual JFK* (2008), about President Kennedy avoiding assassination in 1963. But in a sign of things to come, mass market films also appeared for the first time. In 1994, HBO released a cinematic adaptation of Robert Harris's novel, *Fatherland*, thereby becoming the first major American studio to produce a cinematic work of alternate history. Soon thereafter, established directors began to embrace counterfactual modes of narration, with Quentin Tarantino directing two films, *Inglourious Basterds* (2009), about Hitler being assassinated, and *Once Upon a Time in Hollywood* (2019), about Sharon Tate not being murdered by the Manson family.

Alternate histories proliferated even more on television. After 2015, the advent of internet streaming technology allowed new studios, such as Netflix, Amazon Prime, Hulu, and Apple TV+, to sponsor a range of alternate history shows. Some were based on alternate history novels, such as Amazon Prime's *The Man in the High Castle* (2015–2019), Hulu's *11.22.63* (2016), and HBO's *The Plot Against America* (2020). Others were based on alternate history comic books, such as HBO's *Watchmen* (2019), which altered Alan Moore's original 1980s narrative (which was set in a world in which the U.S. won the Vietnam War) by relocating it to a world in which the U.S. government paid reparations to Blacks for the Tulsa Race Massacre of 1921 (Figure 9.5). Other American shows were entirely original, such as Apple TV+'s *For All Mankind* (2019–22), about the U.S.—Soviet rivalry continuing in outer space, and Amazon Prime's *Hunters* (2020), about American Nazis in the 1970s plotting to establish a Fourth Reich in the U.S. Nearly all these series employed A-list movie stars (Al Pacino, Regina King, and James Franco, among others) and lavish budgets to produce high-end works of counterfactual entertainment. Prominent shows also appeared in other countries. In Great Britain, BBC Two dramatized Len Deighton's 1978 novel *SS-GB* (about the Nazi occupation of England) in 2017, while in 2020, BBC One aired a streaming series based on Malorie Blackman's novel, *Noughts + Crosses*, about a world in which Africans colonized Britain. In Germany, the television channel Phoenix produced a series of documentary



FIGURE 9.5 HBO's series, *Watchmen* (2019), was set in a world in which the U.S. government paid reparations to Black people as atonement for the Tulsa Race Massacre of 1921.

programs called “What If?” (*Was wäre, wenn ...*) in 2017; in Russia, a similar show called “Alternate History” (*Al'ternativnaya istoriya*) premiered in 2011; and in 2018, Netflix debuted the Polish language drama *1983* about a world in which communism never collapsed.¹⁶²⁷

Counterfactuals also appeared in other areas of western culture. In the realm of comic books and graphic novels, Marvel Comics launched a second iteration of its “What If ...?” series between 1989 and 2018, publishing hundreds of special issues depicting well-known superheroes interacting in counterfactual situations—for example, Captain America battling White Skull during the American Civil War (2006) and Daredevil growing up in medieval

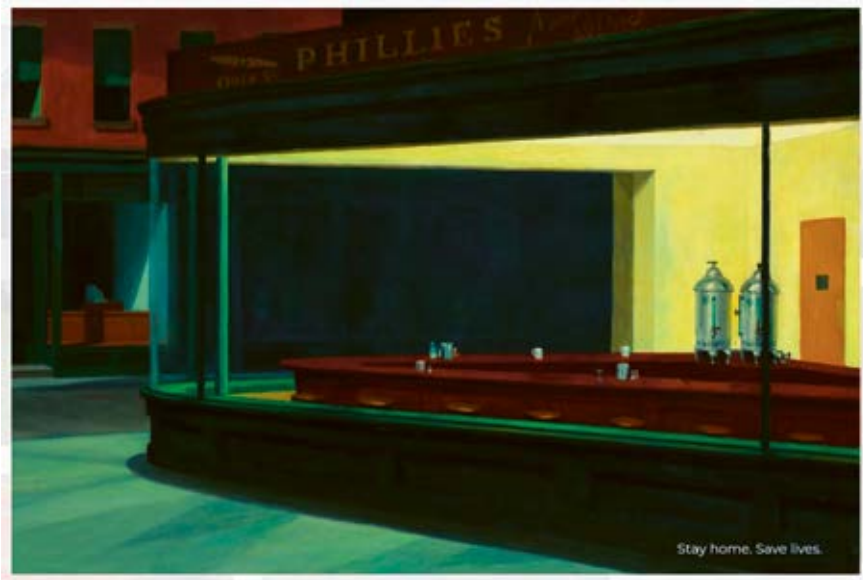


FIGURE 9.6 During the COVID-19 pandemic, Jeff Roy and Drake Paul produced a series of artworks that reimagined classic paintings with key figures removed. Here is their version of Edward Hopper's "Nighthawks" (1942) looking even emptier than the original.

Japan (2006).¹⁶²⁸ DC Comics also got into the act, producing a mini-series exploring how Superman would have developed had he landed in the Soviet Union.¹⁶²⁹ Counterfactuals were also explored in works of art. In 2013, the famed German painter Anselm Kiefer organized an exhibition of paintings, entitled "Morgenthau Plan," that depicted how Germany's landscape would have evolved if the U.S. had implemented the 1944 plan's call to deindustrialize the country after World War II.¹⁶³⁰ In 2020, artists Jeff Roy and Drake Paul created a series of fourteen paintings, entitled "Art of the Quarantine," that highlighted the effects of the COVID-19 pandemic by digitally removing key persons from famous works of art, such as Edward Hopper's "Night Hawks" (Figure 9.6).¹⁶³¹ "What ifs" also found expression in the field of architecture, with museum exhibitions, journal essays, and architectural competitions revisiting never-realized buildings and city planning schemes in cities like London, Los Angeles, and New York City.¹⁶³² Counterfactuals also inspired dozens of role-playing video games, such as *Freedom Fighters* (2003), about the Soviet Union invading the United States; *Damnation* (2009), about the American Civil War lasting several extra decades; and *Wolfenstein: The New Order* (2014), about the Nazis winning World War II.¹⁶³³

Counterfactual history also developed a robust presence on the Internet. One of the most notable milestones occurred in 1997 with the launching of the website Uchronia, which has since become the largest online database of alternate history narratives, comprising more than 3400 alternate history titles.¹⁶³⁴ Around the same time, the creation of Alternatehistory.com enabled users to pursue discussions about the genre and upload self-produced works of fiction, while alternate history magazines and blogs, such as *Never Was* and *The Counterfactual History Review*, offered reporting and analysis.¹⁶³⁵ With the advent of YouTube in the mid 2000s, alternate history assumed video form with the emergence of channels like Matt Mitrovich's *The Alternate Historian*, while Facebook hosted Newt Gingrich's video site, *What If? History That Could Have Been*.¹⁶³⁶ Alternate history has also shaped the creation of internet memes and, more recently, found expression in AI-generated images and videos (Figure 9.7).¹⁶³⁷ All these online developments gradually enabled the field of counterfactual history to assume more institutional form. In 1995, the creators of Uchronia established the Sidewise Awards for Alternate History (named after Murray Leinster's 1934 short story "Sidewise in Time") and have bestowed short-form and long-form awards to authors ever since.¹⁶³⁸ A few years later, in 1998, Del Rey Books declared October to be "alternate history month."¹⁶³⁹

The explosion of cultural counterfactuals was also supported by a surge in personal counterfactuals. Many works of film, television, and theater after 1989 depicted how the lives of fictional individuals were drastically shaped by chance events. Drawing on the tradition established by Frank Capra's classic movie *It's a Wonderful Life* (1946), a range of films used sequential or parallel narratives to illustrate how their protagonists' lives are drastically affected by minor points of divergence, including Alain Resnais' comedy *Smoking/No Smoking* (1993) and Peter Howitt's romantic comedy *Sliding Doors* (1998).¹⁶⁴⁰ Similar scenarios were explored in episodes of the hit television shows *Friends*, *The Big Bang Theory*, and *Community*, all of which imagined key characters experiencing different fates. They also appeared in Broadway musicals like *If/Then* (2014), which depicted its protagonist's life unfolding in two possible directions depending on whether she takes a phone call.¹⁶⁴¹

The surge of counterfactuals after 1989, finally, was also marked by a notable convergence between analytical and cultural counterfactuals. Historians and fiction writers increasingly cited one another's work in explaining their sources of inspiration. It was telling that the era's acknowledged master of alternate history, Harry Turtledove, earned a Ph.D. in history at UCLA and often credited his training as crucial for his literary success.¹⁶⁴² Working in the opposite direction, the historian Roger Ransom cited Ward Moore's famous novel *Bring the Jubilee* as the inspiration for his historical monograph, *The*



FIGURE 9.7 Artificial intelligence has made the production of alternate history images and videos easy. This image was created on the website, What If AI (w-if.ai.com), with the prompt, “What if England had defeated the American Revolution?”

Confederate States of America.¹⁶⁴³ In 2012, the creators of the architectural fantasy “Nieuw Amsterdam” cited the influence of Hendrik Willem van Loon’s 1930 essay “If the Dutch had kept Nieuw Amsterdam” (originally published in J.C. Squire’s volume *If It Had Happened Otherwise*) as the chief influence on their project.¹⁶⁴⁴ Robert Harris, finally, cited Len Deighton’s 1978 novel *SS-GB* as an inspiration for his blockbuster novel *Fatherland*.¹⁶⁴⁵

As analytical and cultural counterfactuals increasingly converged, they produced the growing belief in a transcendent phenomenon known as “counterfactualism.” Prior to 1989, no such word existed. But in the years that followed, the concept became increasingly used by scholars and other commentators. Starting with the work of historian Jeremy Black, who helped popularize the term in his book *What If? Counterfactualism and the Problem of History* (2008), scholars such as Peter Bowler and Catherine Gallagher employed the term in books, articles, and reviews.¹⁶⁴⁶ Although no single definition of the term emerged, the notion of counterfactualism was increasingly used after the turn of the millennium to encompass both analytical and cultural counterfactuals.

Speculative Trends

As in earlier eras, writers speculated about a wide range of topics ranging from the ancient world to the modern era. Anglo-American narratives covered a range of familiar topics, such as the eruption of World War II, World War I, and the Civil War, but they also addressed new events, including the end of the Cold War, the fall of communism, and the crimes of western imperialism. These narratives were diverse and spanned a range of nightmare, fantasy, and stasis scenarios. They also changed over time, in keeping with presentist concerns.

Nazism and World War II

As was true of the first four decades of the postwar period, the rise of Nazism and the eruption of World War II remained the most popular topic after 1989. Well over one hundred narratives—essays, novels, short stories, films, television programs—appeared, which was more than twice the number in the years 1945–1989.¹⁶⁴⁷ Once again, the majority imagined the nightmare scenario of the Nazis winning World War II.¹⁶⁴⁸

It is impossible to survey all these narratives comprehensively, but Anglo-American depictions of a Nazi wartime triumph are especially revealing. For the most part, British and American writers categorized the scenario as a nightmare, but they did so for different reasons having to do with shifting political trends. Between 1989 and 2001, American and British narratives were shaped by the end of the cold war. Most American texts returned to the triumphalistic tradition of the early postwar period and depicted a Nazi victory as a nightmare. As was seen in Leo Rutman's novel *Clash of Eagles* (1990), Stephen Cornwell's film *The Philadelphia Experiment II* (1993), Newt Gingrich and William Forstchen's novel *1945* (1995), Arthur Rhodes's 2001 novel *The Last Reich: America Strikes Back* (2001), and J. N. Stroyar's novel *The Children's War* (2001), American writers depicted the Nazis ruthlessly brutalizing the U.S., nuking American cities, and massacring American civilians. But as with future histories published in the 1940s, these tales ended redemptively by portraying the American people liberating their country from Nazi oppression. By contrast, British texts were more pessimistic. Adrian Gilbert's book *Britain Invaded* (1990), Craig Raine's play *1953* (1990), Robert Harris's novel *Fatherland* (1992), and Madeline Bunting's book *The Model Occupation* (1995) attacked the "finest hour" myth by depicting the British people collaborating with their Nazi occupiers. These downcast depictions by left-liberal writers reflected Britain's crisis of confidence after 1989. Despite the collapse of communism, British

writers experienced new fears of decline, especially following the emergence of a powerful unified Germany eager to accelerate the pace of European integration in the period surrounding the “Year of European Unity,” 1992.¹⁶⁴⁹

After 2001, however, Anglo-American narratives of a Nazi victory became more consistently pessimistic. British works, such as Owen Sheers’ novel *Resistance* (2007), C. J. Sansom’s novel *Dominion* (2012), Guy Saville’s novel *The Afrika Reich* (2011), Jo Walton’s trilogy *Farthing* (2006), *Ha’Penny* (2007), and *Half a Crown* (2008), and Tony Schumacher’s trilogy *The Darkest Hour* (2014), *The British Lion* (2015), and *An Army of One* (2017), depicted Britons not only collaborating with the Nazis but establishing their own domestic fascist government (Figure 9.8). Many of these narratives expressed the post-9/11 fear that the “War on Terror” could facilitate fascist political trends. A similar message was advanced by two American novels: Philip Roth’s *The Plot Against America* (2004), which depicted President Charles Lindbergh establishing a pro-fascist government in 1940, and Alan Glenn’s novel *Amerikan Eagle* (2011), which portrayed the notorious Louisiana Senator Huey Long becoming dictator of the United States in 1936. Both texts expressed concern that the Bush administration’s curtailment of civil liberties after 9/11 heralded a sharp rightwing turn.¹⁶⁵⁰

American and British fears of fascism became even more acute after 2016. In the United States, the election of Donald Trump lent new importance to four high-profile streaming series: *The Man in the High Castle*, *The Plot Against America*, *Hunters*, and *Watchmen*. Although the four shows examined different aspects of Nazism, they arrived at several conclusions about its significance for America’s political future. All the shows insisted that fascism posed a serious threat to the United States; they pessimistically depicted Americans actively collaborating with fascist rule; they urgently advised the targets of fascism—Jews, African Americans, and other minorities—to join forces to combat it; and they explored the vexing question of whether using violence against fascism was ethically permitted or was itself “fascist.”¹⁶⁵¹ In advancing these points, the shows’ creators shared the belief, articulated by *The Man in the High Castle*’s executive producer, David Zucker, that counterfactual histories about Nazism were “cautionary tale[s]” for present-day America. Their immense popularity among viewers further reinforced this belief.¹⁶⁵² In Great Britain, meanwhile, the BBC television adaptation of Len Deighton’s novel, *SS-GB* was interpreted against the backdrop of the country’s decision in the spring of 2016 to leave the European Union, with the show’s executive producer noting that the show’s “terrifying” premise resonated with people who feel that “we’re now living in an alternate world.”¹⁶⁵³

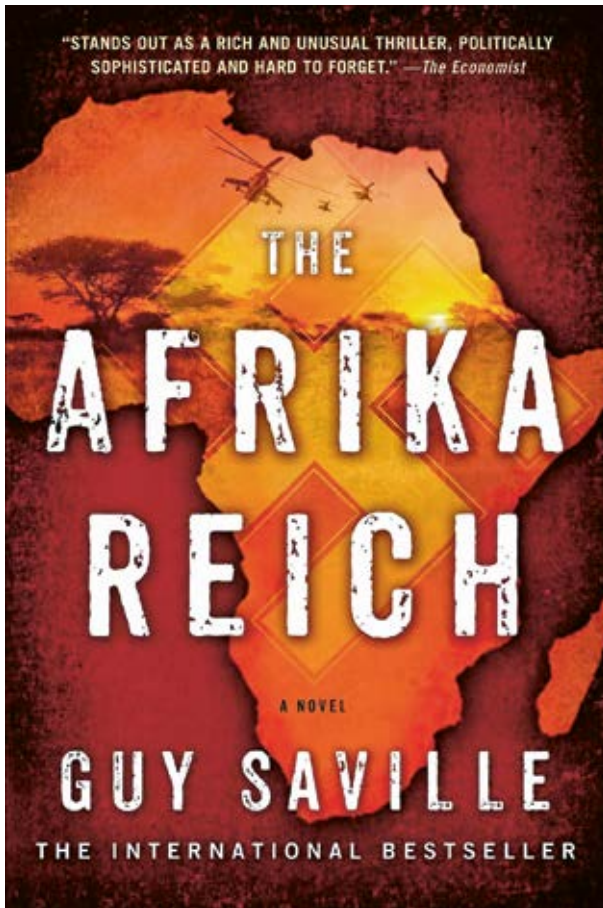


FIGURE 9.8 Guy Saville's novel, *The Afrika Reich* (2011) was one of many British alternate histories after the year 2000 that depicted Britain embracing fascism.

World War I

In the years after 1989, many people wondered “what if?” about the eruption of World War I. In contrast to the depiction of World War II, however, the Great War inspired a greater mix of fantasy, nightmare, and stasis scenarios.

Fantasy narratives came in a variety of forms. Some writers speculated that history would have been better if the war had never happened. Norman Stone's essay “Archduke Francis Ferdinand Survives Sarajevo” (2004), York Membery's essay “What If Franz Ferdinand's Assassin Had Missed in 1914?” (2006), Richard Ned Lebow's book *Archduke Francis Ferdinand Lives!* (2014), and Hannes Stein's



FIGURE 9.9 Richard Ned Lebow's book, *Archduke Francis Ferdinand Lives!* (2014) imagined ways in which World War I might have been prevented.

2013 novel *Der Komet* (*The Comet*) speculated that the Archduke's survival in 1914 would have prevented a broader European war, preserved Europe's waning Empires, and fostered a process of European unification that avoided the twentieth century's calamities (Figure 9.9).¹⁶⁵⁴ Other writers imagined history turning out better if Germany had won the war or suffered a milder defeat. This was true of Niall Ferguson's book *The Pity of War* (1999), which argued Britain would have remained a great power comfortably distanced from a German-ruled Europe, and Robert L. O'Connell's essay "The Great War Torpedoed" (2001), which imagined a German victory promoting the country's

post-1918 democratization.¹⁶⁵⁵ These fantasies reflected regrets about the course of twentieth-century history.

Other writers speculated about the Great War with nightmare and stasis scenarios. Harry Turtledove's novel *Curious Notions* (2004), Robert Conroy's novel *1920: America's Great War* (2013), and part two of Richard Ned Lebow's book *Archduke Franz Ferdinand Lives!* all imagined a victorious Germany becoming more aggressive and eventually attacking the United States (even employing nuclear weapons) at different dates between the 1920s and 1970s.¹⁶⁵⁶ Journalist David Frum, meanwhile, contended that a western defeat by the Germans in World War I would have torpedoed the cause of democracy.¹⁶⁵⁷ By contrast, stasis narratives, such as Harry Turtledove's short story "Uncle Alf" (2002), and Ian MacLeod's novel *The Summer Isles* (1998), speculated that while a German victory (or draw) in World War I would have spared the country a turn towards Nazism, it would have prompted the losing nations—France and Britain—to embrace fascism as a way to cope with military defeat.¹⁶⁵⁸ One way or the other, the war's losing nations would have had to cope with political extremism. Similarly, Jean-Jacques R gnier's short story "Des der des" (2003) suggested that if Francis Ferdinand had not been assassinated in 1914, a different European war would have broken out a few years later anyway, while Ben Elton's novel *Time and Time Again* (2014), showed how the effort of time travelers to prevent the Archduke's assassination fails to make history any better.¹⁶⁵⁹ As was true during the interwar era, in short, writers after 1989 remained divided about the consequences of the Great War having a different outcome.

The Civil War and Slavery

Another popular theme in counterfactual history after 1989 was the American Civil War. During this period, fluctuating race relations in the U.S. and other parts of the world directly shaped depictions of the topic. The surge of racial unrest during the Los Angeles riots of 1992, the alleged dawning of a "post-racial society" following the election of President Barack Obama in 2008, and the return of racial strife following the election of Donald Trump in 2016 all shaped whether the Civil War era was reimagined as a nightmare or fantasy.

During this period, many writers produced nightmares. The most prolific was Harry Turtledove, whose hit novel *Guns of the South* (1992) depicted a group of time travelling, Neo-Nazi mercenaries from South Africa using AK-47s to help the Confederacy triumph over the Union. In presenting this nightmare, Turtledove underscored the evils of South African apartheid, which was clinging to life in the early 1990s, while also commenting on American realities.

By ending the novel with the Confederacy turning against the Afrikaners and abolishing slavery in the CSA, Turtledove offered a hopeful perspective on American race relations at a time when they were in crisis.¹⁶⁶⁰ Turtledove took a similar approach a few years later in his eleven-volume *Great War* series (1997–2007), several volumes of which portrayed the Confederacy becoming an expansionist imperial power in the 1880s and embracing fascism in the 1930s.¹⁶⁶¹ In so doing, Turtledove, a longtime antifascist, called attention to the legacy of racism in the American South, while validating the real course of American history.¹⁶⁶²

Other writers produced nightmares on slavery. African American director Kevin Willmott's film *The Confederate States of America: C. S. A.* (2004) was a mock documentary that used bitter satire to depict slavery persisting into the present-day world after a Southern victory in the Civil War—going so far as to include advertisements for products like “The Shackle” for retrieving run-away enslaved persons (Figure 9.10). Roger Ransom's volume *The Confederate States of America: What Might Have Been* (2005) imagined that a victorious Confederacy would have approved a system of “compensated emancipation” in the 1880s, but thereafter would have denied Black people equal citizenship, trapping them “in a caste system based on race with no hope of escape.”¹⁶⁶³ In a 2011 *Wall Street Journal* op-ed, journalist Fergus Bordewich speculated that “had the Confederacy won its independence, it would have [led to] the ... institutionalized repression of ... blacks” and created “a model of [political] authoritarianism and racial oppression well into the twentieth century.”¹⁶⁶⁴ Several years later, African American writer Colson Whitehead's novel *The Underground Railroad* (2016) portrayed a nightmarish version of the antebellum Confederacy where certain states have institutionalized lynchings and genetic engineering projects for African Americans.¹⁶⁶⁵ Similarly, Ben Winters' novel *Underground Airlines* (2016) depicted a nightmarish present-day South, in which several states use enslaved persons and a genetically engineered race of non-human laborers to anchor the Southern economy.¹⁶⁶⁶ All these texts expressed their authors' liberal political belief that the nightmare of Confederate rule could illuminate America's history of racial injustice.

By contrast, other writers gravitated towards fantasies. Harry Harrison's *Stars and Stripes* trilogy, published between 1998 and 2002, imagined Great Britain allying with the Confederacy but overplaying its hand by launching attacks on the American mainland, thereby prompting the North and South to join forces, invade the British Isles, liberate Ireland from British rule, and ultimately reforge the United States of America.¹⁶⁶⁷ This happy ending was echoed by Newt Gingrich, William R. Forstchen, and Albert S. Hanser, in their Civil War trilogy, *Gettysburg* (2003), *Grant Comes East* (2004), and *Never Call Retreat* (2005),

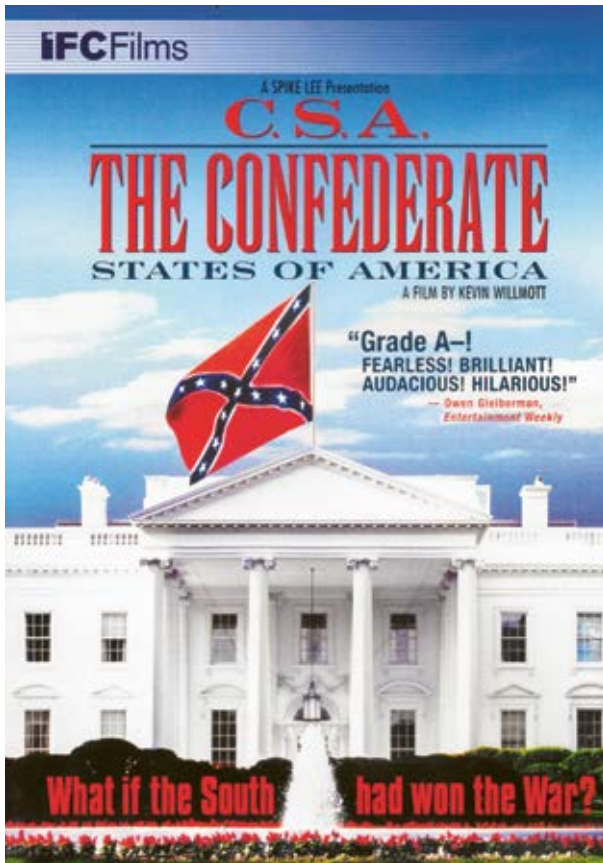


FIGURE 9.10 African American director, Kevin Willmott's film, *The Confederate States of America: C. S. A.* (2004), depicted slavery persisting in present-day America.

which burnished the legend of Confederate virtue by imagining how, after winning the Battle of Gettysburg, Robert E. Lee nobly rejects Jefferson Davis's order to continue fighting after recognizing the importance of national unity.¹⁶⁶⁸ Finally, Robert Conroy's novel *1862* (2006) showed British intervention on the side of the Confederacy leading to the latter's defeat and the end of the war two years earlier than in real history.¹⁶⁶⁹ Written by men spanning different political leanings—from Gingrich on the right to Harrison on the left—the novels reflected the patriotic mood of the post-Cold War and post-9/11 periods.¹⁶⁷⁰

By contrast, as the 2000s progressed, growing political tensions created more polarized views of a Southern victory. During the Bush administration, some discontented liberals came to view the scenario as a fantasy. In a 2006

New York Times editorial, “Disunited States of America,” journalist John Tierney expressed his frustration with GOP rule by fantasizing that “if the South were a separate country,” then “politics in both countries might be less partisan” since “Northern liberals wouldn’t be ranting at George W. Bush” and Southern conservatives “wouldn’t have to fight for moral values against godless Yankees.”¹⁶⁷¹ Under the Obama administration, meanwhile, right of center figures fantasized more intensely about a southern victory. In 2012, the rock musician and rightwing Tea Party activist Ted Nugent protested “big government” by endorsing states’ rights and proclaiming “it would have been best had the South won the Civil War.”¹⁶⁷² This rightwing sentiment reappeared during Trump era controversies over dismantling Civil War memorials, when the rightwing activist Jason Kessler proclaimed that “our entire country would be better off if the South had won the Civil War.”¹⁶⁷³ In response to such claims, liberal critics lamented that the South had, in fact, “won the civil war,” with journalist and writer Rebecca Solnit observing, “If the North had won the war ..., there would not be statues ... honoring the defeated leaders ... [and] the Confederate flag would be ... seen only in museums.”¹⁶⁷⁴

The End of the Cold War

The end of the Cold War and the collapse of the Soviet Union also generated a wave of counterfactual texts. Some were produced by writers in the U.S. and western Europe. But in a new development, many appeared in Eastern European countries, especially Russia and Poland. Writers in both nations not only explored how the collapse of communism might have unfolded differently but how it might have shaped their own national histories.

In the U.S. and Britain, writers examined whether the fall of the Soviet Union and the collapse of communism was avoidable or inevitable. In a 2004 issue of *Slavic Review* that was devoted to the question, “Was the Soviet System Reformable?,” the lead article, written by historian Steven F. Cohen, answered the question affirmatively, rejecting the deterministic claim of conservative scholars that communism was doomed to extinction and speculating that multiple events could have allowed it to survive—for instance, Mikhail Gorbachev “introduc[ing]... market reforms ... without democratization.”¹⁶⁷⁵ Around the same time, Mark Almond and Richard Ned Lebow published essays examining how the absence of Gorbachev could have allowed the Soviet regime to survive well into the 1990s.¹⁶⁷⁶ A similar premise informed Apple TV+’s hit series *For All Mankind* (2019–26), which depicted Gorbachev using new policies to spark a Soviet economic boom and help the country spread communism around the world.¹⁶⁷⁷

Writers in other western nations explored similar scenarios. German writers produced alternate histories about the East German communist regime surviving past 1989, including Reinhold Andert's fake commemorative book *Rote Wende: Wie die Ossis die Wessis besiegten* (1994), which "documented" the fifth anniversary of the GDR taking over the FRG, and Christian von Ditfurth's novel *Die Mauer Steht am Rhein* (1999), in which Gorbachev is overthrown and the two Germanys are forcibly unified in a technically "neutral"—but, in reality, Soviet-dominated—state called the Demokratische Republik Deutschland (DRD). Similar reversals of history marked Sebastian Knauer's novellas *Bitte nicht hinauslehnen* (1996) and *Erich Lebt* (1999), both of which depicted East Germany annexing West Germany, and Jörg Mehrwald's novel *Bloss gut, dass es uns noch gibt!* (2000), which portrayed ordinary East Germans eking out a meager existence in a world where East and West Germany never unified in 1990.¹⁶⁷⁸ All these narratives satirized the 1990s phenomenon of "Ostalgie"—East German "nostalgia for the east"—while prompting West Germans to consider how they would have reacted if their own state had vanished. In so doing, these texts validated history as it really transpired.

Russians also wondered "what if?" about the fall of communism. While scattered texts already appeared in the 1990s following the Soviet Union's collapse, the largest wave started after 2000 with the rise of time travel tales known as *Popadantsy*.¹⁶⁷⁹ Referring to people who become "accidental travelers," *Popadantsy* narratives featured Russian protagonists traveling through time to rectify the country's historical setbacks. As various scholars have argued, the narratives mirrored the nationalist agenda of Vladimir Putin by trying to undo Russia's historical traumas.¹⁶⁸⁰ Some of these tales directly addressed the collapse of the USSR—for instance Oleg Izmerov's *Imperiye* series (2012–13), one of whose volumes imagined *perestroika* being adopted already in the Brezhnev era—but the majority spanned the entirety of Russian history. Whether depicting the Tsarist monarchy becoming a global power in the early nineteenth century, the Bolshevik Revolution failing, or the Red Army defeating the Nazis even more handily in World War II, these narratives became enormously popular after the USSR's collapse in 1991. Critics have noted that such tales exploited the existence of a "loser's complex" among Russian readers by allowing them to achieve counterfactual victories denied them in real life.¹⁶⁸¹ Some of the narratives embraced aggressive nationalism, for example, German Romanov's book *A Comrade Führer* (2012), which depicted the USSR allying with Nazi Germany against the Soviet Union's "real" enemies, the UK and US, while other narratives allowed Russians to go back in time and defeat Ukrainian "Nazis."¹⁶⁸²

Writers in Poland also used alternate history to reimagine the nation's past. On the one hand, some Polish writers after 1989 produced patriotic fantasies—for instance, Maciej Lepianka's 1996 novel *And on the Next Day* (*I w następnym dniu*), which portrayed Hitler's assassination in Warsaw preventing the eruption of World War II and allowing Poland to become the wealthiest nation in Europe.¹⁶⁸³ These and other texts helped alternate history become a respected literary genre and gain official state support; indeed, in 2009, the Polish government's National Center for Culture organized a competition called "Time Switches" that deployed alternate history for nationalistic purposes.¹⁶⁸⁴ One of the competition's winners, Marcin Wolski, later became well-known for his conservative reinventions of Polish history, for example, in his novel *Wallenrod* (2009), which imagined a healthy Joseph Pilsudski forging a strategic alliance with Hitler in 1938, thereby enabling Poland to withstand the dual German/Soviet threat and become a great power.¹⁶⁸⁵ On the other hand, liberal writers rejected the fantasy of undoing Poland's historical tragedies. Marcin Ciszewski's *Major* trilogy of novels (2008–2010) refused to negate the German invasion of 1939, the Warsaw Uprising of 1944, and the Warsaw Ghetto Uprising of 1943, while Jacek Dukaj's novels *Xavras Wyzryn* (1997) and *Lod (Ice)* (2007) depicted Poland failing to free itself from Russian rule after 1918.¹⁶⁸⁶ The 2018 Netflix streaming series *1983* also explored a nightmare scenario in which Poland's communist dictatorship survived as an oppressive regime into the early 2000s.¹⁶⁸⁷

The West and the World

Other writers after 1989 explored the Janus-faced legacy of western imperialism. Some hailed the west's rise to global prominence by examining factors that might have prevented it from happening. Others indicted western imperialism by fantasizing about how the tables might have been turned between colonizer and colonized. Stimulated by the increasing pace of globalization, the memory boom's push to rectify historical injustices, and fears of civilizational conflict after 9/11, the writers who produced these analyses were divided into two camps: those who defended and those criticized the modern west. Not surprisingly, the debate often pitted writers of European descent against writers from African and Arab backgrounds.

Scholarship defending the rise of the west began in the late 1990s and continued into the new millennium. Philip Tetlock, Richard Ned Lebow, and Geoffrey Parker's 2006 anthology *Unmaking the West* featured a dozen essays on how the west's rise to dominance might have been forestalled, many of

which examined nightmares—for instance, Victor Davis Hanson’s reflections on a Persian defeat of the Greeks at Salamis and Jack Goldstone’s examination of a Stuart defeat of Britain’s Glorious Revolution, both of which imagined the stifling of western democracy (Figure 9.11).¹⁶⁸⁸ Around the same time, Niall Ferguson defended western imperialism in his book *Empire: The Rise and Demise of the British World Order and the Lessons for Global Power* (2002) by arguing that without the British Empire, the Nazis might have won the Second World War and India never would have become the world’s largest democracy.¹⁶⁸⁹ A different defense of western imperialism appeared at the outset of British classicist Ian Morris’s book *Why the West Rules—For Now* (2010), which reminded readers about the perils of the west not ruling by depicting Chinese naval forces invading, occupying, and subjugating mid-nineteenth century England.¹⁶⁹⁰ Finally, on the right wing of the political spectrum, political scientist Bruce Gilley’s controversial article “The Case for Colonialism” (2017) argued that “absent colonial rule,” parts of Africa and Asia would have been denied key economic benefits and might have experienced greater internal violence than they experienced under European control.¹⁶⁹¹

By contrast, more liberal writers employed “what ifs” to indict western imperialism. Many fiction writers used trading places counterfactuals to imagine the colonized switching roles with the colonizers. The African American writer Steven Barnes’s novels *Lion’s Blood* (2002) and *Zulu Heart* (2003) imagined Socrates’s death in 400 BCE leading Europe and North America to be colonized by an Egyptian-Abyssinian civilization and white people experiencing slavery at the hands of Africans.¹⁶⁹² The Black British writer Malorie Blackman employed a similar premise in her young adult novel series (and later BBC television show) *Noughts and Crosses* (2001–2021), which depicted dark-skinned “Crosses” ruling over lighter-skinned “Noughts” in twenty-second-century Britain.¹⁶⁹³ Christopher Evans’s novel *Aztec Century* (1993) imagined the Aztecs becoming a global power and conquering Britain in the twentieth century, while French writer Laurent Binet’s novel *Civilizations* (2019) depicted the Incas conquering Spain in the sixteenth century.¹⁶⁹⁴ Lebanese writer Raymond Khoury’s novel *Empire of Lies* (2019) showed a successful seventeenth-century Turkish defeat of Viennese forces producing a present-day world in which Muslims rule France and face an overseas threat from a religiously fundamentalist United States. Harry Turtledove’s *Through Darkest Europe* (2018) depicted a shift in medieval intellectual history leading Muslim civilization to surpass a religiously fanatical Europe in both learning and technological progress. Matt Ruff’s novel *The Mirage* (2012) imagined a united Arab world liberating itself earlier from Ottoman rule and overtaking a religiously fundamentalist and increasingly terroristic “Christian States of America.”

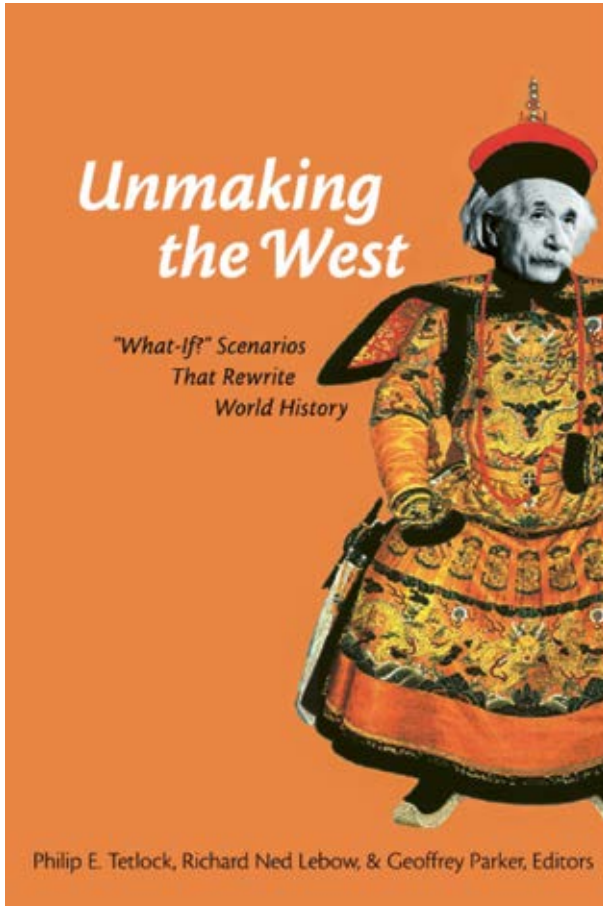


FIGURE 9.11 Philip Tetlock, Richard Ned Lebow, and Geoffrey Parker's 2006 anthology, *Unmaking the West*, featured a dozen essays on how the west's rise to dominance might have been forestalled.

Whether taking the form of fantasies or nightmares, these and other texts reflected the tense climate of the early twenty-first century.¹⁶⁹⁵ Reacting against the War on Terror and the growth of rightwing populism in Europe and North America, liberal writers used trading places counterfactuals to show how the western world could have easily experienced the same fate as Africa and the Middle East. As the producer of *Noughts and Crosses*, Kibwe Tavares, put it in 2022, by “allowing people to put themselves in the shoes of someone ... on the receiving end of racism,” alternate histories sought to make “white audiences think [and]... Black audiences feel empowered.”¹⁶⁹⁶

Other Topics

In the years after 1989, many other topics were reimagined in counterfactual fashion. Some were highly specialized, for example, the history of sports, as was seen in sportswriter Mike Pesca's 2018 anthology *Upon Further Review*, which explored different outcomes to famous sporting events.¹⁶⁹⁷ Other works, such as Joshua Hull's book *Underexposed: The 50 Greatest Films Never Made* (2021) and Archie Bland's book *Undelivered: The Never-Hard Speeches That Would Have Rewritten History* (2022), explored cultural artifacts and documents that never came to be.¹⁶⁹⁸

Major political events also inspired counterfactual speculation. The 100th anniversary of the Bolshevik Revolution sparked renewed questions about how it might have been avoided or had a different outcome, as was seen in Tony Brenton's volume *Was Revolution Inevitable? Turning Points of the Russian Revolution* (2017) and Philip Cunliffe's book *Lenin Lives! Reimagining the Russian Revolution, 1917–2017* (2017).¹⁶⁹⁹ The period between the fortieth and fiftieth anniversaries of John F. Kennedy's assassination in 1963 also sparked counterfactual reflection, as was seen in the film and book *Virtual JFK* (2008/09), Stephen King's novel (and later Hulu television series) *11/22/63*, and Jeff Greenfield's *If Kennedy Lived* (2013). The American Revolution continued to inspire imaginative retellings, as was seen in Harry Turtledove and Richard Dreyfuss's novel *The Two Georges* (1995), Robert Conroy's novel *Liberty: 1784, The Second War for Independence* (2014), and essays by prominent historians like David McCullough, all of which portrayed the revolution as failing or nearly failing.¹⁷⁰⁰ Finally, the fifth, tenth, and twentieth anniversaries of the 9/11 terrorist attacks sparked a wave of speculation, such as the *New York Magazine* special issue, "What If 9/11 Never Happened?" (2006).¹⁷⁰¹

All these narratives offered a range of conclusions about how history would have been altered. Some fantasized that history would have been improved—that Russia would have democratized without the Bolshevik Revolution; that JFK would have pulled the U.S. out of Vietnam had he not been killed; that a British-controlled U.S. after 1776 would have abolished slavery and avoided civil war; and that a President Gore would have prevented the 9/11 attacks. Others responded by saying that history would have been no better or actually worse—that Russia was destined to suffer authoritarian rule after its defeat in World War I; that Kennedy would have kept the U.S. involved in Vietnam; that a British-ruled U.S. would have merely experienced a worse Civil War led by an unrepentant South; and that a 9/11-style attack against the U.S. was merely a matter of time. These disagreements confirmed that speculating about the past was as popular and controversial as ever.



FIGURE 9.12 Michael Lösch's edited book, *Wäre Luther nicht gewesen* (2016), imagined German history without Martin Luther.

Writers in other countries also revisited pivotal events in their own histories. In the years after 1989, writers in France marked the 200th anniversary of the French Revolution and Napoleonic era by speculating about the French Monarchy surviving the crisis of 1789 and Napoleon Bonaparte triumphing at Waterloo.¹⁷⁰² Writers in Germany marked the 500th anniversary of the Protestant Reformation in 2017 by fantasizing about ways in which Luther's absence might have spared Germany many of its early modern nightmares, such as the Thirty Years War (Figure 9.12).¹⁷⁰³ Writers in Spain imagined fantasies and nightmares pertaining to the Spanish Civil War and subsequent Franco

dictatorship, especially ways in which both might have been avoided.¹⁷⁰⁴ And writers in Israel imagined the Jewish state being established in other parts the world, such as Uganda or upstate New York.¹⁷⁰⁵

Explaining Counterfactuals

Commentators across the west responded to the wave of “what ifs” with a flood of reviews, essays, and books trying to explain the new appeal of counterfactual history. Journalists and academics attributed the wave to a range of contemporary trends and events. In so doing, they began to sketch out the contours of a larger explanation.

Journalists were the first to notice the upsurge of counterfactuals. They gave significant attention to the publication of four texts in the 1990s: Robert Harris’s *Fatherland* (1992), Harry Turtledove’s *Guns of the South* (1992), Niall Ferguson’s *Virtual History* (1997), and Robert Cowley’s *What If?* (1999). Not long after Harris’s and Turtledove’s novels appeared, journalists wrote that alternate history was “establish[ing]... itself ... as a popular ... tributary of speculative fiction” and was being embraced by a “curious public.”¹⁷⁰⁶ Around the same time, other commentators reported that counterfactual history had become a “bustling new trend” and a “fashionable new discipline” in academia.¹⁷⁰⁷ Similar claims persisted after the turn of the millennium. In 2002, one writer called alternate history a “burgeoning book genre,” while another in 2006 said that “the genre has never been more popular.”¹⁷⁰⁸ In the years after 2010, other observers echoed the by-now familiar claim that “what ifs have become an entire genre of literature” and were part of a “growing field in historical studies.”¹⁷⁰⁹ As late as 2017, a journalist wrote that “alternate histories” were increasingly “in the air.”¹⁷¹⁰

Scholars also sought to explain the rise of counterfactual history. Some, such as Philip Tetlock, Aaron Belkin, Niall Ferguson, and Robert Cowley, ventured explanations in the introductions to their edited volumes.¹⁷¹¹ Other scholars devoted entire monographs to analyzing the trend. Geoffrey Hawthorne’s book *Plausible Worlds: Possibility and Understanding in History and the Social Sciences* (1991) was the first study after 1989 to show how “what ifs” shed light on causality.¹⁷¹² In 2001, Karen Hellekson’s book *The Alternate History* (2001) offered a narratological examination of cultural counterfactuals.¹⁷¹³ My own book, *The World Hitler Never Made* (2005), was the first in-depth study to examine counterfactual representations of a single topic—that of Nazism. Jeremy Black’s *Counterfactualism and the Problem of History* (2008) offered a more sweeping survey of the field, while Richard Ned Lebow’s collection of essays

Forbidden Fruit: Counterfactuals in International Relations (2010) proposed guidelines for creating plausible counterfactuals. After 2010, other important studies continued to appear, most notably Richard Evans's study *Altered Pasts: Counterfactuals in History* (2013), which offered a contrarian critique of counterfactual history, and Catherine Gallagher's more supportive volume *Telling It Like It Wasn't: The Counterfactual Imagination in History and Fiction* (2018). During this period, scholars also produced analytical anthologies and journal articles on counterfactual history.¹⁷¹⁴ They organized symposia, conference panels, and special journal issues on the topic.¹⁷¹⁵ They even produced manifestoes endorsing counterfactual reasoning as an analytical and pedagogical tool.¹⁷¹⁶ Outside of the English-speaking world, finally, scholars also contributed important studies, including Alexander Demandt, Michael Salewski, and Peter Burg in Germany, and Eric B. Henriot, Quentin Deluermoz, and Pierre Singaravélou in France.¹⁷¹⁷

Taken together, the works of journalists, writers, and scholars exhibited common features. Most stressed that counterfactual thinking dated back to the ancient Greeks and could be found in the writings of subsequent thinkers, whether the early modern reflections of Pascal and Gibbon, the modern writings of Nietzsche and Weber, or the twentieth-century analyses of Fogel and Trevor-Roper. Scholars also endeavored to create a canon of cultural counterfactuals, tracing the earliest examples of alternate history back to the pioneering nineteenth-century literary works of Geoffroy-Château and Renouvier, and going forward to the post-1945 novels of Dick, Amis, and Harris. Still other scholars drew on this evidence to analyze counterfactuals from a more theoretical perspective. They offered elaborate definitions of counterfactuals. They identified how they functioned rhetorically, narratologically, and typologically. They discussed the merits and drawbacks of counterfactual thinking for historical understanding. They suggested rules governing the plausibility of counterfactuals. And they applied their theories to concrete events in the form of analytical case studies.

In undertaking this work, writers posited several theories about the new popularity of counterfactual thought. One theory, first advanced by Ferguson, was that counterfactuals were inherently anti-deterministic and thus thrived in eras hostile to deterministic thinking (Figure 9.13).¹⁷¹⁸ Various observers in the 1990s noted that the demise of communism in the years 1989–91 had created precisely such a climate by liberating history from its deterministic, Cold War shackles. In a 1999 *American Heritage* forum on alternate history, Phil Patton noted that while “the relentless logic of the Cold War [had] carried with it the implication of a face-off lasting indefinitely,” the collapse of the Berlin Wall had “made history no longer look inevitable,” declaring that “the dizzying

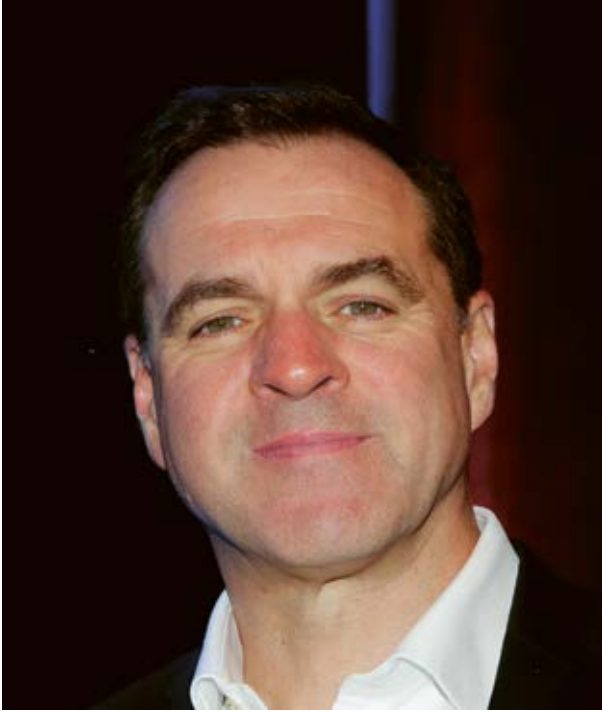


FIGURE 9.13 Niall Ferguson was one of the leading scholars to venture explanations for the upsurge in counterfactuals in the 1990s. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

pace of the changes that brought Lech Walesa from house arrest to power ... has suffused the world with a sense that anything's possible after the iron grip of the Cold War.¹⁷¹⁹ Such optimism about the future's open-endedness, however, did not last long. After the terror attacks of September 11, 2001, other critics sensed that it was not only communism but also liberalism that was in ideological decline. In his 2004 anthology *What Might Have Been*, the conservative historian Andrew Roberts rejected liberalism's "whiggish" faith in progress by concluding his anthology with an essay by the conservative intellectual David Frum, arguing that if Al Gore had been elected president over George W. Bush in the year 2000, he would have responded to 9/11 with a feckless diplomatic approach instead of vigorous military one.¹⁷²⁰ In presenting this nightmare, Frum and Roberts implied that present-day liberalism had not met the challenges of the post-9/11 world and needed to be replaced with a more assertive form of conservatism. After the world financial crash of 2008 further damaged liberalism's reputation, Roland Wenzlhuemer cited its decline in the shadow

of capitalism's possible "collapse" to explain "the renewed interest in counterfactual questions."¹⁷²¹ Subsequent observers cited the rightwing populist crusade against liberalism as another factor for the popularity of "what ifs."¹⁷²² If it was true, as philosopher Crispin Sartwell argued, that the rise to power of autocratic leaders like Donald Trump proved the bankruptcy of "all philosophies of history," it was easy to understand why, as novelist Ben Winters put it, many Americans viewed "life [under] the Trump presidency ... [as] an absurd ... counterfactual."¹⁷²³

Scholars also theorized that "what if" thinking was being promoted by postmodernism. Starting in the 1990s, scholars pointed to the ways in which postmodern literary conventions were dovetailing with counterfactualism. As the literature scholar Elizabeth Wesseling put it in 1991, the fact that postmodern literary fiction pursued the "malleability of historical reality" and blurred the binary distinction between "fact and fiction" explained why postmodernism was encouraging people to embrace "counterfactual conjecture" and imagine ways "in which events might have taken an entirely different course."¹⁷²⁴ A few years later in 1994, literature scholar Paul Alkon argued that Robert Harris's *Fatherland* and Harry Turtledove's *Guns of the South* had been shaped by postmodernism's goal of "abolishing historicity."¹⁷²⁵ After the turn of the millennium, literary scholars came to accept Kathleen Singles' view that "alternate histories reflect the postmodern tension between artificiality and authenticity."¹⁷²⁶ Journalists embraced these insights as well. In a review of Andrew Roberts's anthology, *What Might Have Been*, historian T.G. Otte observed that the postmodern "deconstruction of 'metanarratives'" had facilitated counterfactual thinking by eroding "established certainties."¹⁷²⁷ Historian Tristram Hunt added that the postmodern emphasis on "contingency and irony" created a world in which "one history is as good as another," adding that the "blurring of [the] factual [and] counter-factual" had made all history into "what if' history."¹⁷²⁸

A third theory held that new scientific developments were promoting counterfactual thought. In 1997, Niall Ferguson popularized this hypothesis by drawing on chaos and complexity theory to argue that history was the result not of predictable but stochastic forces. The consequence, he noted, was that history itself should be rechristened as "chaostory" and seen in contingent rather than deterministic terms.¹⁷²⁹ A few years later in their book *Unmaking the West*, Philip E. Tetlock and Geoffrey Parker applied insights from the related field of path dependency theory to examine whether (and when) small alterations to historical events actually led to major changes.¹⁷³⁰ Still other scholars cited "parallel worlds theory" and the idea of the "multiverse" to explain the popularity of counterfactual thinking.¹⁷³¹

Linking all these theories was the belief that rapid change was promoting counterfactual thought. Commenting in 1992 about the new popularity of alternate history, fiction writer Gregory Benford attributed it to “the uncertainty ... and angst that go along with modern times,” adding that the “zeitgeist” was defined by an awareness of “the fragility of events [and] the arbitrariness of history.”¹⁷³² More than two decades later, Jeremy Black made a similar claim, declaring that “the appeal of counterfactual history” reflected “a climate of cultural and political uncertainty.”¹⁷³³ Other scholars amplified these points, noting that change was the engine of speculation.¹⁷³⁴

Debating Counterfactuals

Scholars and journalists not only explained the rise of counterfactual history but debated its virtues and vices. While the field’s supporters tried to legitimize counterfactual history by bolstering its plausibility and utility, the field’s critics cited longstanding objections to prevent its entry into the mainstream.

The supporters of counterfactual history undertook new efforts to enhance its scholarly legitimacy. Aware of the fact that “frivolous counterfactuals” had long “given the question [of ‘what if?'] a bad name,” Robert Cowley emphasized that his anthology *What If* (1999) only featured counterfactuals that were “at all times plausible” and avoided scenarios in which “Napoleon ... [had] stealth bombers.”¹⁷³⁵ Around the same time, Niall Ferguson tried to lend new scientific credibility to counterfactuals by establishing guidelines governing their creation. To refute the common objection that “what ifs” depended on “facts which ... never existed,” Ferguson declared “we should consider as plausible or probable *only those alternatives which we can show on the basis of contemporary evidence that contemporaries actually considered.*” In doing so, Ferguson argued, historians could “narrow the scope for counterfactual analysis” and resist disreputable flights of fancy.¹⁷³⁶ Other scholars offered rules governing counterfactuals, arguing that they had to be marked by clarity (by ensuring that the variables in any scenario were clearly defined), simplicity (by changing as few variables as possible), consistency (by guaranteeing that the variables adhered to theoretical laws of cause and effect), and brevity (by resisting the urge to extrapolate the effects of a variable beyond a limited time span).¹⁷³⁷ Some scholars went even further and asserted that counterfactuals did not have to be plausible in order to be legitimate, claiming they could provide valuable insights even if they took the form of more “exuberant” thought experiments.¹⁷³⁸

Other commentators promoted counterfactual history by giving glowing reviews to the era’s many works. Journalists and scholars alike praised Ferguson’s

Virtual History for reminding people that counterfactual history was “a necessary part of historical explanation” and “reignit[ing]... the old debate about history that asks what if ...?”¹⁷³⁹ Writing in the flagship journal *The American Historical Review*, historian Walter A. McDougall lent academic credibility to Ferguson’s study by calling it both “persuasive and entertaining.”¹⁷⁴⁰ Robert Cowley’s *What If?* received similar praise for bridging the gap between elite and popular audiences. While the highbrow *The New York Times* called the volume “fascinating” and the *Chicago Tribune* praised it for featuring “headliner historians,” the mass market magazine *Entertainment Weekly* called it “great fun.”¹⁷⁴¹ Many subsequent works received similar accolades. Jeff Greenfield’s *Then Everything Changed* was applauded by the *New York Times*’s Michiko Kakutani as a “shrewdly written, often riveting” book.¹⁷⁴² Bowler’s *Darwin Deleted* was called a “daring book” that “venture[d] into ... risky ... scholarly territory,” while still being “fun.”¹⁷⁴³ And Richard Ned Lebow’s *Archduke Franz Ferdinand Lives!* was praised for getting people “to reflect in new and unexpected ways on the ... unpredictability of history.”¹⁷⁴⁴

Reviewers also praised the era’s cultural counterfactuals. Robert Harris’s *Fatherland* was hailed as a “stunning” work of literature and credited with helping alternate history secure an international readership.¹⁷⁴⁵ Harry Turtledove’s *Guns of the South* was called the “best alternate-history” novel since ... [Philip K.] Dick’s *The Man in the High Castle*.¹⁷⁴⁶ Philip Roth was praised for helping legitimize counterfactual history in his novel *The Plot Against America* by leaving his highbrow literary perch and “join[ing]... the ranks of alternate historians” like Harry Turtledove.¹⁷⁴⁷ Michael Chabon was also praised for embracing the field of alternate history in his “dazzling” and “wildly inventive” novel *The Yiddish Policemen’s Union*.¹⁷⁴⁸ Subsequent novels were lauded in similar terms. Stephen King’s *11/22/63* was commended for “mak[ing] alternative history work” in his “suspenseful” tale.¹⁷⁴⁹ Colson Whitehead’s *The Underground Railroad* was described as “thrilling.”¹⁷⁵⁰ And Curtis Sittenfeld’s *Rodham* was called “wildly compelling.”¹⁷⁵¹

Films and television series, meanwhile, were credited for their social and political relevance. In 2006, reviewers praised Kevin Willmott’s film *CSA* for offering a “chilling” revelation of “just how close to the surface the legacy of slavery is in American life.”¹⁷⁵² In 2018, *The Hollywood Reporter* called *The Man in the High Castle* “must-see TV,” because its premise was “so real” due to the “unmistakable parallels between its fictional dystopia and the real world” in the Trump era.¹⁷⁵³ In 2020, a reviewer of HBO’s *The Plot Against America* wrote that the show’s “alternate reality” felt “less like fiction and more like a well-crafted reminder of what’s going on in the world today.”¹⁷⁵⁴ *Watchmen* was also hailed for its political significance, a verdict that was confirmed in 2020 when the show won eleven Emmy Awards.¹⁷⁵⁵

Despite receiving critical acclaim, works of counterfactual history were often attacked. Certain critics responded skeptically to the surge of “what ifs” in the 1990s by predicting that its popularity would be short-lived. After the success of Harris’s *Fatherland*, one writer in 1995 offered a blanket dismissal of “alternate-past novels” by saying it was a “subgenre with many more forgettable entries than memorable ones.”¹⁷⁵⁶ Around the same time, another critic complained that alternate history was merely “the latest literary fad” and doubted that it had “a future.”¹⁷⁵⁷ Even after the success of Ferguson’s *Virtual History*, journalists declared there was “not a big market for the genre” and claimed that “what if” books were “difficult to sell.”¹⁷⁵⁸ In 2001, finally, a skeptical reviewer dismissed alternate history for the opposite reason, insisting that the market had become “super-saturated” with too many texts.¹⁷⁵⁹

Commentators also revived the claim that wondering “what if?” was a waste of time. A reviewer of Cowley’s book *What If?* critiqued it for engaging in “wild speculation instead of ‘sober calculation.’”¹⁷⁶⁰ A critic of Roger Ransom’s *Confederate States of America* faulted the author for basing his claims on a “fanciful foundation.”¹⁷⁶¹ And a reviewer of *Virtual History* dismissed it as pure “nonsense.”¹⁷⁶² Historians made similar claims. Reviewing Jeffrey Gurock’s book *The Holocaust Averted*, Hasia Diner said that “the problem with ... works that hinge on [the question], ‘what if,’ is that the ... counter-historian need not be troubled by evidence, and so any scenario can be considered as plausible as any other.”¹⁷⁶³ In reviewing Lebow’s *Archduke Franz Ferdinand Lives!*, Richard Evans claimed the author spun “so many contradictory counterfactuals out of a single event” that it revealed “the essential arbitrariness of the procedure he employs.”¹⁷⁶⁴ Some critics used polemical language to critique counterfactuals. One said that Lebow’s counterfactual narrative read like “a parlor game played by sauced tweeds at the faculty Christmas party.”¹⁷⁶⁵ A reviewer of Gurock’s book declared that “alternate historians ... use history the same way a drunk uses a lamppost—for support rather than illumination.”¹⁷⁶⁶ A critic of Greenfield’s volume *If Kennedy Lived* said that “the very plausibility of its fictions,... risks leaving readers knowing less than they did before they picked [the book]... up.”¹⁷⁶⁷ As one observer concluded: “counterfactual history is addictive [and]... like most addictions, tends to be bad for the brain.”¹⁷⁶⁸

Positioned between the supporters and critics of counterfactual history, finally, were scholars who remained ambivalent about it. Among the many scholars who fell into this camp, two were the famed English historians Eric Hobsbawm and Ian Kershaw. Neither scholar was able to make up his mind about whether the advantages of wondering “what if?” outweighed the disadvantages. In his 1997 book *On History*, Hobsbawm skeptically noted that historians had “not got[ten] very far” with counterfactual analysis, declaring that



FIGURE 9.14 Ian Kershaw is one of many historians who has taken an inconsistent stance on counterfactual history, endorsing it in some ways while rejecting it in others. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

“arguments about [what ifs]... cannot be settled by evidence, since evidence is about what happened and hypothetical situations did not happen.”¹⁷⁶⁹ Echoing E.H. Carr’s claim from a generation earlier, Hobsbawm asserted that “what ifs” properly “belong to politics or ideology and not to history.”¹⁷⁷⁰ At the same time, Hobsbawm conceded that “all history is full of implicit or explicit counterfactuals” and affirmed that “conjectural history has a place in our discipline.”¹⁷⁷¹ Indeed, Hobsbawm made good on his support for the “excursions [of historians] into the imaginary” by devoting an entire chapter of *On History* to exploring counterfactuals related to the Bolshevik Revolution.¹⁷⁷² Ian Kershaw also took an inconsistent stance on counterfactual history (Figure 9.14). In the introduction to his 2008 book *Fateful Choices*, he insisted that major twentieth-century leaders had routinely contemplated “alternatives” in deciding how to respond to pivotal events, adding that he himself was open to the

“question of what might have followed had [such]... alternative[s]... been taken up.”¹⁷⁷³ At the same time, Kershaw rejected the kind of “counter-factual or virtual history ... which makes an intellectual guessing-game of looking into some distant future and projecting what might have happened had some event not taken place.”¹⁷⁷⁴ While he conceded that “historians implicitly operate with short-range counterfactuals,” he noted in his epilogue that it was “pointless” to contemplate how alternatives could have “changed the course of history.”¹⁷⁷⁵ In so doing, Kershaw, like Hobsbawm, revealed that scholars remained divided about the merits of counterfactual history.

Politicizing Counterfactuals

Further illustrating this division was the frequent allegation that “what ifs” were being mobilized to serve political goals. While liberals often levelled this charge against conservatives, conservatives replied that liberals were primarily responsible for politicizing counterfactual thought.

Liberals first made this claim around the turn of the millennium in response to the fact that two of the most prominent editors of counterfactual anthologies—Niall Ferguson and Andrew Roberts—were outspoken political conservatives. In a 2004 essay, Richard Evans declared it was it is “no accident” that the members of what he called the “young fogey school” of conservative British historians “were located on the right wing of the political spectrum.”¹⁷⁷⁶ Claiming that their conservative political beliefs dovetailed with their methodological focus on the deeds of great men instead of structural factors, Evans argued that such biases made counterfactual speculation little more than a politically motivated form of “wishful thinking.” Evans reiterated the claim that counterfactual history was a “monopoly of the right” in his 2014 book *Altered Pasts*, and sharpened his dismissal of the field.¹⁷⁷⁷ Aware that counterfactual history was surging in popularity, Evans alleged that its “frivolity and whimsicality” was meant to entertain rather than educate. He added that “what ifs” were helping people indulge their desire to flee from the present into a past “unfettered by facts,” and concluded that counterfactuals were “of little real use in the serious study of the past.”¹⁷⁷⁸

Evans’s claims stimulated a decade-long debate among the opponents and supporters of counterfactual history. In 2004, Tristram Hunt agreed that counterfactual history was a “reactionary” movement committed to “pushing a dangerous rightwing agenda.”¹⁷⁷⁹ Subsequent scholars, such as Robert Gerwarth and Slavoj Žižek, also branded counterfactual history as conservative.¹⁷⁸⁰ Other scholars, however, objected to Evans’s arguments. Already in 2004, some

refuted his association of counterfactual thinking with conservatism, pointing out that because “what ifs” often found leftwing expression, they were politically neutral.¹⁷⁸¹ Other scholars amplified this point in subsequent responses, with Jeremy Black noting that counterfactualism was a scholarly “method,” not a “political issue,” and Cass Sunstein defending the causal importance of counterfactuals in research.¹⁷⁸² As late as 2020, however, Evans continued to argue that “counterfactual [history] has almost no use for serious historiography.”¹⁷⁸³

Liberal claims that counterfactuals were inherently conservative intensified after the election of Donald Trump. Trump encouraged such suspicions on multiple occasions by offering ill-considered counterfactual statements. Immediately after the 2016 election, he fraudulently declared he would have “won the popular vote if you deduct the millions of people who voted illegally.”¹⁷⁸⁴ In 2017, he used a fast-forward counterfactual in declaring that “[if]... Andrew Jackson [had] been a little later, you wouldn’t have had the Civil War.”¹⁷⁸⁵ In 2018, Trump attacked Democrats for opposing Brett Kavanaugh’s appointment to the Supreme Court with a transplant counterfactual, speculating that “if we brought George Washington here [to the Senate], the Democrats would vote against him.”¹⁷⁸⁶ And in his 2019 state of the union address, he floated the nightmare counterfactual that “If I had not been elected president of the United States, we would right now ... be in a major war with North Korea.”¹⁷⁸⁷

While countless observers mocked such claims, others saw them as part of a rightwing trend.¹⁷⁸⁸ Some critics associated alternate history with the extremist Alt-Right and the worrisome concept of “alternative facts.” In 2017, for example, one scholar claimed that “Trump’s birther movement against Obama was an alternate history.”¹⁷⁸⁹ Others equated Trump’s use of counterfactuals with outright lies. In 2021, President Joe Biden justified his decision to abolish Trump’s 1776 Commission (which had been entrusted with promoting “patriotic” history instruction) as both “offensive” and “counterfactual.”¹⁷⁹⁰ Around the same time, a *Los Angeles Times* journalist wrote that Trump’s claims about the “stolen” 2020 election amounted to a “delusional ... counterfactual history.”¹⁷⁹¹ Others pointed out that Trump was not the first conservative to abuse “what ifs,” with several citing Newt Gingrich’s conservative alternate history novels and Facebook site, “What If?” Upon hearing Trump disparage NATO’s peacekeeping achievements after 1949, for instance, journalist John Heilemann remarked that Trump had embraced “Newt Gingrich’s version of alternate history.”¹⁷⁹² The fact that rightwing autocrats elsewhere in the world also employed counterfactuals for nationalistic purposes added to liberal fears. The examples were numerous and included Polish Prime Minister Jaroslaw Kaczynski’s 2007 contention that Poland would have been a more populous

country deserving of greater EU voting rights “if [it] had not experienced the years between 1939 and 1945”; Vladimir Putin’s 2021 claim that Russia would have been a country “nearing 500 million people” in size if only “Russian statehood [had not] disintegrated twice during the 20th century”; and Victor Orban’s 2020 claim, on the 100th anniversary of Hungary’s signing the Treaty of Trianon, that “no other nation in the world ... *would have* survived a century like this.”¹⁷⁹³ All these claims validated liberal suspicions that conservatives were the most likely to wonder “what if?”

Further support for this belief appeared in 2017, when a bitter controversy erupted in the U.S. about the counterfactual legacy of the Civil War. In July of that year, HBO announced that the creators of *Game of Thrones*, David Benioff and D.B. Weiss, were planning a new alternate history series called “Confederate” about the South winning the Civil War. Before long, protests by left-liberal critics reached a fever pitch and eventually led to the program’s cancellation (Figure 9.15). Many critics feared that the producers’ track record on *Game of Thrones* (which featured abundant sexual violence and few minority characters) boded ill for a show that would focus squarely on the violent institution of slavery. But some critics focused on HBO’s decision to tackle the topic of slavery through the genre of counterfactual history. Writing in the *New York Times*, columnist Roxane Gay likened the show’s counterfactual premise to “slavery fan fiction” and feared it would promote a rightwing agenda, noting “there are people ... who will watch a show like *Confederate* and see it as inspiration, rather than a cautionary tale.” This comment and others like it reflected the liberal fear that “the racist right in the U.S.”—including some of Trump’s closest advisers like Steve Bannon—had “for decades consoled itself by reading crazed ‘alternate history’ novels” by writers like Newt Gingrich about the South winning the war.¹⁷⁹⁴ By contrast, other writers defended *Confederate* from the charge that its counterfactual premise served the political right, with some pointing out that the Black filmmaker Kevin Willmott’s alternate history film *CSA* had skillfully tackled the premise in critical fashion.¹⁷⁹⁵ Yet, even Willmott’s film had sparked controversy only a few years earlier in 2014, when administrators at New York City’s prestigious Dalton School had to apologize for screening the film after angry students and parents misunderstood its satirical portrayal of slavery thriving in the present-day U.S.¹⁷⁹⁶ Coming at a time of worsening race relations during the Trump administration, political sensitivities were too acute for liberal critics to tolerate depictions of slavery that allowed for misunderstandings.

Liberal fears about the right-wing use of counterfactual history were also illustrated by the controversy over Bruce Gilley’s 2017 essay “The Case for Colonialism.” Gilley’s article made national headlines when the journal where



FIGURE 9.15 Protests by left-liberal critics in 2017 led to the cancellation of HBO's proposed series, "Confederate," which was based on the premise of the South winning the Civil War. (Source: Alamy)

it originally appeared, *Third World Quarterly*, withdrew the essay after being subjected to withering attacks from left-liberal critics.¹⁷⁹⁷ More than a few critics focused their attack on Gilley's use of counterfactuals, claiming they were being used to rehabilitate colonialism. As the left-wing writer Nathan J. Robinson wrote, Gilley's claim that colonialism was "better than what would have happened in its absence," was "an argument frequently deployed by abusive ... individuals ... to justify their acts" and "a terrible way of evaluating colonialism."¹⁷⁹⁸ Other critics, such as the economists Yannick Dupraz and Valeria Rueda, refuted Gilley's claim that the costs and benefits of imperialism could be counterfactually determined by comparing countries that were subjected to European colonialism with countries that were spared European rule, writing that "European colonialism was so widespread that finding a counterfactual for colonization is quasi-absurd."¹⁷⁹⁹ In a long response, Gilley defended his use of counterfactuals and challenged his critics to speculate on such hypothetical cases as "Spanish rule of Ireland, Persian rule of India,... and PRC rule in Hong Kong."¹⁸⁰⁰ Scattered commentators defended Gilley, with some contending that his critics failed to disprove his argument that history would have been better with more colonialism.¹⁸⁰¹ Yet, Gilley damaged his claim of being a disinterested academic by accepting a 2019 invitation from

the rightwing AfD party in Germany to speak in front of the German parliament, where he used counterfactuals to relativize the severity of the Herero genocide of 1904–08.¹⁸⁰²

Like liberals, conservatives also viewed counterfactuals as politically suspect. Conservative critics often dismissed alternate histories of Nazism for allegorically attacking the present-day political right. In 1992, German conservatives claimed that Robert Harris's bestselling novel *Fatherland* had deliberately disseminated an ominous image of a victorious Nazi Germany to exploit what *Der Spiegel* said were the "fears and resentments of the Anglo-American public" about Germany's growing power in the EU.¹⁸⁰³ More than two decades later, conservatives in the United States objected to the narratives advanced by streaming series *The Plot Against America*, *The Man in the High Castle*, and *Watchmen*. One conservative critic said the HBO series was a "screech against the Republican Party" produced by "blinkered ideologues," while another likened its depiction of Lindbergh to "character assassination."¹⁸⁰⁴ A reviewer of *The Man in the High Castle*, meanwhile, contended that the show's Black-led, anti-Nazi resistance glorified "anti-American views" and "Antifa philosophy" while promoting "resistance to ... the Trump administration."¹⁸⁰⁵ Social media users, finally, lambasted *Watchmen* as "woke propaganda" created by "social justice warriors."¹⁸⁰⁶

Conclusion

Despite these debates, counterfactual history in the years after 1989 became more securely anchored in western life than ever before. This new security reflected not only the unprecedented production, but also the enthusiastic reception, of analytical and cultural counterfactuals. As historians, journalists, fiction writers, and filmmakers increasingly explored "what ifs" in books, op-eds, novels, films, and television shows, they found their works embraced by millions of readers and viewers across the western world. While the topics of focus varied widely from nation to nation, the spread of counterfactual history reflected shared political and psychological impulses. As western society developed a more flexible and subjective attitude towards history, people began to reimagine it in ways that suited a range of political fantasies and nightmares. This process of reworking the past inevitably sparked controversy. But as works of counterfactual and alternate history made headlines and became commercial and critical hits, the genre itself acquired unprecedented legitimacy. No longer was counterfactual history easily dismissed as a "parlour game."

Conclusion

If 'ifs' and 'ands' were pots and pans,
There would be no need for tinkers' hands.¹⁸⁰⁷ (English proverb)

If the little word 'if' did not exist,
Many a farmer would be a rich gentleman.¹⁸⁰⁸ (German proverb)

If my aunt had been a man,
She'd have been my uncle.¹⁸⁰⁹ (Russian Proverb)

Wondering “what if?” is inherently paradoxical. As the proverbs above indicate, Europeans have traditionally been suspicious about counterfactual speculation, viewing it as a nonsensical waste of time. Yet the ubiquity and venerability of such proverbs, which find equivalents in other European languages dating back to the Middle Ages, suggests that such speculation is a longstanding feature of European life.¹⁸¹⁰ Whether applied to the future, present, or past, wondering “what if?” is an activity that people across the western world have indulged in for centuries. So why have they done so despite the many warnings not to? And why have they speculated about the one area of human life that is unchangeable—namely, the past?

This study has tried to answer these and other questions by providing the first systematic analysis of counterfactual history in the western tradition from antiquity to the present. Drawing on a vast reservoir of well-known but untapped sources, it has documented the stunning extent to which western historians, theologians, philosophers, politicians, journalists, and other writers have speculated about the past over time. In so doing, the book has established an empirical foundation for constructing a general theory of counterfactualism. Although speculating about the past is a complex phenomenon that cannot be reduced to formulaic generalities, the historical record makes abundantly clear that people have used counterfactual reasoning in similar situations for similar reasons with similar effects. These patterns allow us to propose some answers to the question of why people wonder “what if?”

A General Theory of Counterfactualism

People use counterfactuals to assign meaning to historical events. They focus especially on questions of causality, morality, and memory, wondering “what

if?" to determine why events occur, how they should be judged, and how they should be remembered. In doing so, people focus on major rather than minor events, on pivotal moments when history's course suddenly shifts from one track onto another. Counterfactuals thus proliferate in periods of rapid change. Such periods confront people with new interpretive challenges. In periods of stability and continuity, historical events need little explanation and are viewed as confirming the natural order of things. The arrival of upheaval, however, forces people to confront new realities. The western world has experienced many eras when momentous political, military, and religious conflicts brought about radical change. Whenever such conflicts have erupted, people have wondered "what if" to make sense of the new world around them.

People are especially prone to speculate when they disagree about why their world has changed. As they wrestle with the meaning of historical events, people examine them not in isolation but in the context of broader—and often divisive—metahistorical questions. They debate whether specific events were caused by deterministic or contingent forces; whether events were inevitable or avoidable; whether events were justified or misguided in their origin; and whether they were positive or negative in their outcome. As people confront these and other thorny questions, they routinely employ counterfactuals to determine the origins and consequences of historical change.

This cycle of rupture and response, investigation and speculation, has defined more than three millennia of western history. Over this long period, counterfactual thought has been shaped by the shifting realities of time and space. The use of "what ifs" has surged in some eras and stagnated in others. Certain parts of the western world have gravitated to counterfactual thought, while others have abstained from it. One trend, however, is unmistakable: because counterfactual thought is a response to change, the accelerating pace of change in western life from antiquity to modernity has made people progressively more inclined to wonder "what if?" over time. If modernity is defined by constant change, it is also defined by constant speculation.

Although the precise moment of its birth is unknown, counterfactual thought first emerged in the ancient world. The first "what ifs" appeared in ancient Mesopotamia and Egypt, but they were relatively scarce because of the two civilizations' stability and longevity. By contrast, the comparative turbulence of the ancient Israelites' history—which was marked by the repeated experience of foreign invasion and subjugation by rival empires—led them to use counterfactuals more often than their Near Eastern predecessors. The Greeks and Romans surpassed all other ancient civilizations, however, in their tendency to speculate about the past. As the main imperial powers in the Mediterranean world for a thousand years, they were the central actors

in the western world's pivotal events and possessed the agency to determine their outcome. The Greeks and Romans were thus uniquely poised to speculate when interpreting the past. With the waning of the Roman Empire, early Christians became the next major group to wonder "what if," doing so while waging doctrinal battles with rival faiths. Medieval Europeans were guided by similar religious concerns in narrating the military clashes of the Crusades and debating the extent of God's power. Early modern Europeans thinkers were led by a mix of secular and religious motives in speculating about the rise and fall of Renaissance Florence, the Spanish conquest of the Americas, the eruption of the Protestant Reformation, and the onset of religious war. Soon thereafter, Europeans and their North American relatives were prompted to speculate about a series of political upheavals, including the English Civil War; the Glorious, American, and French Revolutions; the Napoleonic Wars; the unification of Germany; the American Civil War; the eruption of World War I and World War II; the onset of the Cold War; and the crises of the twenty-first century. All these events, by stimulating dramatic change, prompted people to speculate about how history might have unfolded differently.

Many factors, in turn, have affected how people have speculated about the past. One of the oldest is religion. As long as western life was securely rooted in religious faith, people were comparatively unlikely to wonder "what if?" in probing the causes of historical events. Viewing the existing order as divinely mandated, they saw the world in deterministic, especially providential, terms and were disinclined to imagine alternatives to it. This was true of the ancient Sumerians, Egyptians, and other polytheistic Near Eastern peoples. The ancient Israelites were somewhat different, for while they also viewed the world deterministically, their monotheistic belief that a single divinity was driving historical events in linear fashion toward a specific telos made them use deterministic counterfactuals to emphasize the inevitability of God's divine plan and the Israelites' need to trust in it. This was also the case for early Christian thinkers and later medieval theologians, many of whom supplemented their deterministic counterfactuals with missed opportunity counterfactuals to accuse pagans and heretics of failing to recognize Christianity's inescapable truth. Subsequent Europeans—whether medieval Crusaders, Spanish proselytizers, or Protestant rebels—also employed deterministic and missed opportunity counterfactuals to justify their actions by making them accord with divine providence. This religious impulse continued into the nineteenth century with the campaign of Catholic conservatives against the French Revolution and only faded at the dawn of the twentieth century. On balance, the historical record suggests that people with firm religious beliefs tend to employ a relatively narrow range of counterfactuals to validate their worldviews.

By contrast, the rise of secular modes of thinking in western life encouraged people to wonder “what if?” in new and diverse ways. If religious conviction promoted the belief in determinism, the rise of secularization fostered the belief in contingency. Understood as encompassing everything from the desires of individual agency to the accidents of pure chance, contingency was first identified by the ancient Greeks and Romans as a causal force in history. Although both civilizations were rooted in religious belief, their polytheistic orientation and non-teleological view of the gods’ role in history led them away from the determinism of Judaism and Christianity toward the comparatively secular belief that chance (*tyche* and *fortuna*) shaped history in unpredictable ways. In the process, the Greeks and Romans became more likely than prior civilizations to consider alternatives to the past. The belief in chance faded during the intensely religious Middle Ages, but it resurfaced in Renaissance Italy, where secular-oriented thinkers like Machiavelli and Guicciardini used “what ifs” to show the role of chance in Florence’s late fifteenth and early sixteenth century travails. Soon thereafter, skeptical thinkers in post-Reformation France, such as Montaigne and Bayle, wielded counterfactuals to show how chance could challenge the false certainties of religious fanaticism. During the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, English natural philosophers and Enlightenment thinkers like Bacon and Hume subjected chance to rational analysis in the effort to discover its underlying secular laws, while French *philosophes* like Montesquieu and Voltaire used reason to understand how chance and determinism interacted in secular historical causation. Interest in the topic of causation continued during the American and French revolutions, when contemporaries used counterfactuals to decide whether the two upheavals were inevitable or avoidable, the result of determinism or chance. The fascination with chance faded for a time during the nineteenth century, when liberal nationalists in England, France, Germany, and the United States triumphalistically employed deterministic and close call counterfactuals to portray their nations’ modern development as preordained events consonant with the era’s belief in progress. But with the onset of *fin-de-siècle* uncertainty and the eruption of World War I, western liberals once again confronted the unpredictable role of chance in human life. When the totalitarian movements of Communism and Nazism embraced secular forms of determinism after 1918, liberals viewed chance—and counterfactual thinking more broadly—as a democratic antidote. This belief continued during the Cold War years 1945 to 1989, through the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991, all the way up to the present. Thanks to these trends, counterfactual thought has understandably (though erroneously) become viewed as anti-deterministic.

Counterfactual history has also been shaped by broader intellectual trends. Eras that have embraced determinism have generally displayed a spirit of epistemological confidence. They have endorsed the optimistic belief that objective truth is attainable within established intellectual traditions. These eras have been disinclined to entertain alternate views of the past and have preferred to see it as preordained. If they used counterfactuals at all, they did so to confirm the status quo. This was true of Imperial Roman historians like Livy, early Christian writers like Eusebius, medieval theologians like Aquinas, early modern Protestants like Luther, nineteenth-century positivists like Comte, contemporaneous socialists like Marx, Whig historians like Buckle, and Bolshevik leaders like Lenin. By contrast, periods of skepticism have encouraged people to embrace epistemological doubt and to question worldviews rooted in certainty. In such periods, people have been more inclined to consider alternatives to the established historical record. This mindset helps explain the willingness to wonder “what if?” by sixteenth and seventeenth-century skeptics like Montaigne and Bayle; late-nineteenth-century scholars like Burckhardt and Nietzsche; early-twentieth-century historians like Bury and Berlin; and the myriad scholars who have been influenced by the postmodern critique of objective truth, ideological metanarratives, and deterministic philosophies of history. Skepticism, in short, has tended to foster speculation.

Counterfactual history has also been influenced by rhetorical factors. Rhetoric has been a feature of all human communication since the advent of speech itself, but in the western tradition, rhetoric was originally systematized in a secular context. First invented by the Greeks and later refined by the Romans, rhetoric originally emerged in the setting of the *polis*, where rival politicians developed increasingly sophisticated modes of oral argumentation to persuade the citizenry about the merits or drawbacks of their respective positions. As part of this process, classical orators, writers, and historians developed a rhetorically diverse range of counterfactuals to enhance the persuasiveness of their arguments. Applied to questions of causality and morality, these counterfactuals assumed many typological forms—from the temporal to the existential. They also became more daring, moving beyond mere subtractive cause and subtractive effect counterfactuals and taking the form of additive cause and additive effect counterfactuals. This diversity of usage grew out of the Greeks’ and Romans’ non-deterministic philosophy of history and their embrace of chance, both of which created vast space for counterfactual inventiveness. This rhetorical tradition further explains why the Greeks and Romans dramatically outpaced earlier, religiously rooted civilizations in wondering “what if?” The western willingness to speculate contracted during the Middle Ages, when the deterministic strictures of Christian belief once again limited

the spectrum of counterfactual expression in European life. But it expanded once again during the Renaissance, when humanists like Machiavelli revived the rhetorical practices of the classical world. During the early modern period, this rhetorical inventiveness remained somewhat constrained by the persistence of religious traditions, but by the eighteenth century, the growing secularization of European life paved the way for counterfactuals to fully realize their stylistic potential under such rhetorically minded and humanistic scholars like Burckhardt and Nietzsche. Our own counterfactual age, with all its rhetorical excess, is merely the latest iteration of this tradition.

Counterfactual thinking has also been shaped by the dynamics of human psychology. Because people use counterfactuals to cope with sudden change, wondering “what if?” has long been influenced by human emotions. Counterfactuals have long been associated with the degree of control that people have over their environment: where people feel they are at the mercy of deterministic forces, they view history fatalistically; where they feel a sense of agency, they are more inclined to speculate about whether alternative decisions would have been better or worse. For this reason, counterfactual thought has long been linked to the emotions of relief and regret. E.H. Carr was half-right when he said that the tendency of people to wonder “what if” was determined by whether they ranked among history’s winners or losers. While Carr was correct that the latter often speculated about history turning out differently, he failed to recognize that the former were equally inclined to do so. The historical record clearly shows that historical speculation is shaped by whether people view the past optimistically, from a triumphalistic perspective, or pessimistically, from a stance of regret. Historical success and historical failure foster different ways of wondering “what if?” Those who are blessed with the former tend to embrace deterministic and providential counterfactuals that confirm the inevitability of history’s course; they also use close call counterfactuals to explore nightmares of failure that thankfully never happened. Roman historians exhibited this mode of thought in chronicling the rise of the Empire, as did early Christian theologians chronicling their victory over paganism, Spanish explorers narrating the triumph over indigenous peoples, British parliamentarians explaining the defeat of absolutist monarchy, Enlightenment *philosophes* marking the rise of western global dominance, American revolutionaries celebrating the overthrow of British colonial rule, nineteenth-century Whig historians celebrating British imperial glory, and Bolshevik and Nazi leaders touting their rise to power. By contrast, those who have been cursed with failure have embraced missed opportunity counterfactuals to explore fantasies in which history turned out better. Thucydides displayed this pattern of speculation in coping with the defeat of the Peloponnesian War, as did Orderic

Vitalis in explaining the failures of the First Crusade, Machiavelli in reflecting on his exile during the Wars of Italy, Emperor Charles V in coping with Luther's rebellion, Lord Bolingbroke in dealing with Britain's setbacks in the War of the Spanish Succession, Chateaubriand in coming to terms with the Old Regime's destruction in the French Revolution, Napoleon in accepting his downfall at Waterloo, Trotsky in reflecting on his expulsion from the Bolshevik party, and a whole host of political leaders and military men who struggled to deal with the traumas of World War I, World War II, and the Cold War. All these patterns reflect the psychological desire of human beings to enhance and preserve their self-esteem in the face of success and failure.

Political factors have also shaped counterfactual thought. Since antiquity, countless rulers—along with their personal advisers, military staff, and court historians—have used counterfactuals to legitimize their decrees, policies, and ideologies. Just as Mesopotamian kings used aggrandization counterfactuals to tout their capacity for mercy, twentieth-century politicians employed deterministic counterfactuals to justify going to war. In so doing, rulers and their retinues have frequently addressed questions relating to causality and morality. They have contemplated whether historical decisions are the result of structure or agency; whether historical events are inevitable or avoidable; and whether historical policies should be viewed as “too hard” or “too soft.” All these questions have figured prominently in debates about key political events in the last several centuries, including the Glorious Revolution, the French Revolution, the Napoleonic Wars, the American Civil War, World War I, the Bolshevik Revolution, the rise of Nazism, the eruption of World War II, and the onset of the Cold War. In debating whether these events could have been prevented or were unavoidable, partisans on both sides have rushed to claim the moral and political advantages of historical innocence and saddle their opponents with the burdens of historical guilt. In most cases, the victors of political and military struggles—from George Washington to Vladimir Lenin—have employed close call and deterministic counterfactuals to legitimize their accomplishments. By contrast, the vanquished—from Napoleon Bonaparte to Kaiser Wilhelm II—have cited the vagaries of chance to shore up their sagging authority. The strength of political ideologies has also shaped the use of counterfactuals. In periods of stability and security, the supporters of different ideologies typically use deterministic counterfactuals to confirm the inevitability of their success, a trend visible in the “what ifs” used by 19th century liberals and interwar Bolsheviks. By contrast, in periods of insecurity, people question their ideological beliefs and speculate more actively about the past, a trend exemplified by the behavior of liberals in the years 1918–1939 and Soviet historians in the era of De-Stalinization. On balance, political systems

defined by authoritarian rule permit a narrower range of counterfactuals than liberal democratic systems, which permit diverse viewpoints on the past.

Historiographical developments have also guided the evolution of counterfactual thinking. Historians have wondered “what if?” ever since antiquity, but it took them millennia to admit they were doing so. Traditionally, historians embraced the fiction that counterfactuals had no part in historical writing. They condemned the activity even though they frequently speculated about the past themselves. Indeed, as far back as Plutarch, historians have hypocritically attacked their colleagues’ use of counterfactuals by employing counterfactuals of their own. This contradiction was rooted in denial and defined historical scholarship for centuries. It explains why the tradition of historical speculation during this time was mostly preserved passively through intertextual practice. Livy’s famed “Alexander digression,” for example, influenced a chain of historians including Plutarch, Machiavelli, Raleigh, Macaulay, and Burckhardt; Pascal’s remark about Cleopatra’s Nose, like Gibbon’s comment about the Battle of Tours, influenced countless historians from Disraeli to Ferguson. Yet while historians were generally familiar with such scattered “what ifs,” it took centuries before they recognized that historical speculation was a phenomenon unto itself. Only once the discipline of history became professionalized in the modern era and historians became methodologically self-reflexive did they grasp the idea that examining what never happened in the past was part of examining what did. Although Herodotus and Livy displayed glimpses of this recognition already in antiquity, it was only in the eighteenth century that scholars such as Bolingbroke, Hume, and Herder began to see historical speculation as a distinct activity. Full recognition of counterfactual thought did not emerge until the nineteenth century. After Disraeli first called attention to “events which have not happened” in 1824, support for “might have beens” progressively increased in the decades after 1850, especially among scholars opposed to the dominance of deterministic thought in western life. This support ultimately sparked a backlash from the supporters of determinism—both secular or religious—and unleashed the first debate about the merits and drawbacks of counterfactual speculation.

In many ways, the debate has never ceased. In the past one hundred and fifty years, there have been five waves of debate between the supporters and opponents of counterfactual history: from the 1850s to 1914; from 1918 to the early 1940s; from the late 1940s to the early 1960s; from the late 1960s to the early 1980s; and from the late 1990s up to the present. Each of these waves has seen the two camps advance similar arguments. Each of the waves has also failed to produce any consensus. Indeed, the repetitive features of the debates suggest that every generation needs to rediscover counterfactual history for

itself and wrestle with its benefits and drawbacks. That said, the cumulative effect of the debates has been to erode historians' longstanding resistance to wondering "what if?" The more that public discussion has made scholars aware of counterfactual history, the more they have utilized speculative methods in their work. Although opposition persists, counterfactual history enjoys greater acceptance today than ever before.

Counterfactual history has also been shaped by broader trends in western cultural life. While historical speculation was long confined to works of historiography, it gradually found expression in other realms of culture. Works of what later became known as "alternate history" first appeared in literature in the nineteenth century in the form of short stories and novels. After 1945, they increasingly appeared in theater, radio, film, television, graphic novels, and art. None of these developments would have taken place, however, had scholars and writers not first become aware of counterfactual history's existence after the mid-nineteenth century. Cognizance of historical speculation as an independent phenomenon was a precondition for the advent of alternate history. Small wonder that both emerged simultaneously in the mid-nineteenth century. For much of its existence, alternate history was a niche cultural phenomenon that appeared in distinct waves. It emerged first in France in a small batch of texts between the 1830s and 1850s; it was followed with a flurry of Anglo-American narratives between the 1870s and 1914; and it experienced a subsequent wave of European and North American narratives between 1914 and 1939. Each of these waves was modest in character, however, and failed to make alternate history known to the broader public. Only between 1945 and 1989 did alternate history begin to gain meaningful attention in western popular culture. Its full breakthrough into the cultural mainstream only took place after the turn of the millennium. Today, counterfactual novels, films, television shows, and comic books have become so ubiquitous that most people have arguably become aware of historical speculation through works of alternate history.

The evolution of counterfactual history has also been influenced by mnemonic forces. The ways people speculate about the past reflect how they wish to remember it. Both activities are shaped by objective and subjective factors. How people wonder "what if" depends on whether they are confronting positive or negative events; whether they wish to celebrate or critique them; and whether they approach them from a conservative or liberal political perspective. People who want to remember positive events in triumphalist fashion tend either to use deterministic counterfactuals to make them seem inevitable or nightmarish close calls to celebrate how events actually transpired. This strategy guided the historians of imperial Rome, the chroniclers of

early Christianity, the memoirists of medieval Crusades, the nationalistically minded Whig historians of nineteenth-century Great Britain, the totalitarian leaders of the early twentieth century, and the liberal historians of the post-1945 world. Those who seek to commemorate negative events more critically, by contrast, often employ missed opportunity counterfactuals to highlight sins of omission that might have improved history's course. This approach defined Renaissance critics of the Wars of Italy, Enlightenment critics of European imperialism, eighteenth-century American opponents of British colonial rule, Northern historians of the American Civil War, pacifist critics of World War I, revisionist historians of the Cold War, and present-day critics of western imperialism. These and other cases confirm that people use counterfactuals to transform history into memory.

A Dialectic of Counterfactualism

As outlined above, the general theory of counterfactualism reveals that people act subjectively, tendentiously, and instrumentally in speculating about the past. Counterfactual history is ultimately about advocacy. For millennia, people have used counterfactuals for their rhetorical power. Whether consciously or not, they have long sensed that "what ifs" can persuade, move, and convince people to adopt a particular viewpoint on a given issue. Because rhetoric thrives where people are divided, it is no surprise that counterfactuals do as well. As people debate the origins and consequences of wars, revolutions, and other dramatic events, they inevitably divide along political and historiographical lines into opposing camps—liberal and conservative, orthodox and revisionist—that argue about why history unfolded as it did. They also argue about how history might have been different, hatching nightmares and fantasies to cope with the competing emotions of relief and regret. The historical record makes one thing clear: the longer people engage in historical debate, the more they use counterfactuals. The longer that debates drag on without resolution, the more people become impatient for closure. As feelings of impatience intensify, people begin to supplement their empirical arguments with rhetorical ones in the hope of finally ending disagreement and forging a consensus about the past. Counterfactuals thus function as rhetorical trump cards that can be used by all sides in historiographical controversies. By appealing to our emotions, people use counterfactuals to break deadlocks that cannot be resolved through reason.

As people use "what ifs," however, they paradoxically produce the exact opposite of what they intend. As they speculate about the past, they generate a "dialectic of counterfactualism" that makes historiographical debates

more, rather than less, intractable. Whenever one camp levels a counterfactual charge, the other inevitably responds with a counterfactual countercharge of its own. Every time one camp advances a fantasy scenario claiming that history could have been better, for instance, the other responds with a stasis or nightmare scenario claiming that that history would have been the same or worse. What further sharpens the dialectic of counterfactualism is the fact that “what ifs,” by their very nature, cannot be disproved. Because no amount of empirical evidence can refute a speculative statement about the past, counterfactual debates usually drag on indefinitely without resolution. In the end, while counterfactual arguments are mobilized to settle debates, they end up prolonging them. The confirmation of this pattern over many centuries of western history helps explain why counterfactual history remains controversial to this day.

Patterns of Speculation: The West and Beyond

The diverse factors that have shaped counterfactual thought explain why some nations have wondered “what if?” more than others. While counterfactual history has been especially popular in the western world, the nations of Europe and North America have not speculated in equal measure. Wondering “what if” has been especially popular in Great Britain and the United States. Examining why these countries seem to have gravitated to counterfactual history more than others in the west is important in and of itself. It is also a precondition for addressing the history of counterfactual thought in non-western nations.

The U.K. and U.S.

The popularity of counterfactual history in Great Britain and the United States reflects the two countries’ pivotal roles in modern history. Given how historical speculation is prompted by the occurrence of momentous events—as well as by the degree of control people feel they have over those events—the nations that have driven history forward, for better or worse, have been the most likely to wonder “what if?” In the modern era, Britain and the U.S. have played disproportionate roles in shaping western and world history. To be sure, they have hardly been alone, being joined by other powers, such as France and Germany. These latter nations did not develop as robust a tradition of historical speculation, however. The British got an early start in speculating about the past thanks to their experience of domestic political upheaval in the seventeenth century and their rise to global influence in the centuries that followed. By way of comparison, France’s centrality in European affairs during the years 1789

to 1815 prompted French writers to speculate especially actively between the late eighteenth and mid-nineteenth centuries, a fact that was reflected in the pioneering role played by French writers in creating alternate history. Yet in the years after 1870, France fell behind Britain and the U.S. on the global stage and saw its counterfactual tradition stagnate. The reverse was true of Germany. As a belated nation that only shaped European and world affairs after unifying in 1871, Germany had less time to develop a counterfactual tradition as robust as its western neighbors. Still, both France and Germany continued to develop respectable traditions of counterfactual thought, especially after the eruption of World War I. For its part, the United States followed a similar path as Britain. As a former colony profoundly influenced by British ways, the U.S. became increasingly prone to wonder “what if?” as it gained influence on the world stage during the late nineteenth and early twentieth century.

Britain and the United States also embraced counterfactual history because of their distinctive political, religious, intellectual, and cultural traditions. The two countries may have been more inclined to speculate, to begin with, because of their early experience of democratization. Thanks to their seventeenth and eighteenth century political revolutions, Britain and the U.S. gradually became open societies that embraced—at least on a limited basis—liberal freedoms, such as free speech, a trait that in tandem with a vigorous print culture fostered counterfactual thought.¹⁸¹¹ To confirm this hypothesis, further research is needed on how other parts of Europe—for instance, France and the German speaking lands of Central Europe—evolved at the same time. But it is possible that their different political trajectories had an impact. France’s nearly century-and-a-half of repressive absolutist rule may have denied its population the freedom to fully wonder “what if,” while the Holy Roman Empire’s similar orientation—in addition to its political impotence on the European stage—may have had a similar effect on German speakers. Britain and the United States may also have embraced historical speculation thanks to their early experience of secularization. Having gradually embraced the principle of religious toleration after the late seventeenth century, Britons and Americans slowly loosened the limitations that Christianity had long placed on counterfactual speculation and developed a rhetorically diverse range of “what ifs.” By way of comparison, France’s absolutist fusion of church and state in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, and the Holy Roman Empire’s religious turmoil during the same period, may have reinforced Christian barriers to fully speculating about the past in both countries. Britain’s rich historiographical tradition, dating back to the Middle Ages, also allowed the country’s historians to take advantage of its comparatively open political and religious climate. The same was true for Britain’s fiction writers, who increasingly embraced

counterfactual speculation after the nineteenth century. For obvious reasons, the United States, as a much newer nation, took longer to develop the same degree of intellectual and cultural vitality; but after gaining independence, American historians and fiction writers gradually caught up to their British colleagues. Although scholars and writers also speculated in France and Germany, they were less active than their Anglo-American counterparts.

Further research is needed to fully document the extent to which other European countries have embraced counterfactual history. But it may eventually reveal that they have followed the patterns noted above. Future research will probably confirm that the absence or diminished presence of key political, religious, intellectual, and cultural traditions in other European countries explains their less pronounced embrace of counterfactual history. In Eastern Europe, the relatively small size of most nations (Russia excepted), combined with their relative lack of geopolitical agency and less developed traditions of secularization, democratization, and free expression, may account for their avoidance of "what ifs." The marginal role in global events played by the nations on Europe's southern and northern periphery may similarly explain their low rates of speculation. To be sure, future research may challenge these suppositions by locating abundant "what ifs" in these parts of Europe. In fact, it may reveal that counterfactual thought is common in nations that have been at the mercy of historical events unleashed by larger neighbors. There is suggestive evidence, for example, that people in Poland and Ireland have often wondered "what if?" (especially about missed opportunities) because of their long histories of suffering at the hands of the Russians and British.¹⁸¹² Moreover, countries on Europe's periphery that have experienced traumatic events like civil wars and population transfers, such as Spain and Greece, may also have wondered "what if?" at a meaningful rate. Only empirically grounded research will fully reveal how western nations have speculated about the past.

Beyond the West

Further research is also needed about the history of counterfactual thought in the non-western world. Given the challenges of comprehensively analyzing how western nations have wondered "what if?", it is difficult to say anything conclusive about the many civilizations that make up most of the globe. Comprehensively surveying the presence of counterfactual thinking in the historiographical and literary traditions of the Islamic world, the Indian subcontinent, East Asia, and Africa is too daunting a task for any one scholar to undertake. Yet, it is worth highlighting some trends that scholars may wish to explore.

Today, it is easy to find evidence of counterfactual thought in the non-western world. In the Middle East, Turkish writers have wondered how history might have been different if Mustafa Kemal Atatürk had lived during World War II, while Iraqi writers have reflected about the consequences of Saddam Hussein staying in power.¹⁸¹³ Indian journalists have wondered how history would have been different if Subhas Chandra Bose had become India's prime minister instead of Jawaharlal Nehru in 1947 (Figure 10.1).¹⁸¹⁴ South Korean writers have imagined Japan winning World War II and ruling the Korean peninsula.¹⁸¹⁵ And Kenyans have wondered how their nation would have developed if Prime Minister Jomo Kenyatta had buckled under pressure and ceded the lands of the Northern Frontier District to Somalia in 1962.¹⁸¹⁶ These non-western examples of counterfactual thought should not be surprising, given how the forces of globalization have spread western trends worldwide. What remains unclear is how longstanding a tradition of counterfactual speculation exists in the non-western world. Given the relative absence of literature on the subject, we simply do not know the answer. But the limited evidence suggests that while non-western peoples have certainly shown the capacity to wonder "what if?," they have not done so for as long as westerners.

If this is the case, the question is why. While counterfactual speculation is clearly a universal feature of human thought, it is also shaped by cultural differences.¹⁸¹⁷ Here, the general theory of counterfactualism provides a method for examining how people have wondered "what if?" in non-western countries. At the risk of oversimplification, one of the core issues involves the relationship between freedom and fatalism. While fatalism has complicated origins and has sparked controversy for its essentialist tendencies, it has importance for the general theory of counterfactualism.¹⁸¹⁸ The western experience suggests that fatalism is inversely related to speculation; the more people embrace the former, the less they gravitate to the latter. Conversely, when people feel a sense of control over their lives, the more they tend to speculate. In the history of the West, fatalistic modes of thought were common in the ancient and medieval worlds, largely due to the power of ecclesiastical and royal authorities. But this mental orientation gradually faded in the face of broader cultural, political, and social forces. The onset of secularization, the rise of democratization, and the growth of individualism, together with the emergence of western nations as imperial powers, gave people in the West a greater sense of agency in the world. In so doing, it gave them the capacity to speculate about how their lives and the historical trajectories of their countries might have unfolded differently. The extent to which secularization, democratization, individualism, and imperial influence have shaped non-western nations, in turn, may help us gauge how they have embraced counterfactual history. The less they



FIGURE 10.1 Indian journalists have wondered how history would have been different if Subhas Chandra Bose had become India's prime minister instead of Jawaharlal Nehru in 1947. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

have been influenced by these forces, it may be surmised, the less they have wondered “what if?”

Counterfactuals in the Islamic World

The Islamic world's relationship with counterfactual thought both dovetails with, and diverges from, the West's. On the one hand, Islam's monotheistic character has led Muslims to wonder “what if” in the same way as Jews and Christians; in fact, Islam's fatalistic dimensions also led early Muslim thinkers to use counterfactuals to reinforce religious faith. On the other hand, the Islamic world's belated modernization may have kept it from developing as robust a tradition of counterfactual thought as that which exists in the west.

From the very beginning, Islamic texts used “what ifs” to strengthen religious doctrine. Counterfactuals can be found in Islam's core texts, including the Qur'an (composed in the 7th century C.E.) and the Hadith (composed in the 8th and 9th centuries C.E.). The counterfactuals in these texts vary in focus:

some are historical in orientation and concentrate on the life and deeds of the Prophet Mohammed; others are personal and illustrate moral precepts. Predictably, many counterfactuals in the Qur'an emphasize Allah's wisdom and power. Some take the form of close call counterfactuals and show how humanity would have been impoverished without Allah's wisdom. Commenting on Allah's importance for human morality, the Qur'an declares in Surah 7:43, "we should not have been *rightly* directed, if God had not directed us."¹⁸¹⁹ In Surah 4:83, the Qur'an states that "if the favor of God and his mercy had not been upon you, ye had followed Satan except a few of you!"¹⁸²⁰ Other counterfactuals emphasize Allah's omnipotence. Anticipating the medieval European debate between intellectualists and voluntarists about the extent of God's power, the Qur'an notes in Surah 25:45 that Allah could have easily altered the physical laws of the universe, declaring "Does thou not consider the works of thy Lord, how he stretcheth forth the shadow before sunrise? If he had pleased, he would have made it immovable forever."¹⁸²¹ Similarly, Surah 5:48 states that "if thy Lord pleased, he would have made all men of one religion," before explaining that Allah chose to do otherwise to judge whether people lived up to the precepts of their respective faiths.¹⁸²²

Islamic texts also used to "what ifs" to mandate belief in Allah. Some passages reinforced this message by condemning unbelievers. One section of the Qur'an employed a missed opportunity counterfactual to predict that infidels would eventually regret their failure to accept Islam's truth, declaring in Surah 67:10 that "they shall say, 'Had we but hearkened or understood, we had not been among the dwellers in the flames [of hell].'"¹⁸²³ Another section of the Qur'an recounts how Mohammed sought to purge insincere Muslims from his military ranks, noting in Surah 4:73 that they were the people who, after missing out on the "bounty" won in battle against enemy forces, uttered the materialistic lament, "Oh, would that I had been with them,... I might have won a rich prize!"¹⁸²⁴ Certain passages in the Hadith, meanwhile, used counterfactuals to urge adherence to Islamic moral rules, with one reporting that when "Abdullah ibn Mas'ud went to visit a sick person with some other people ... [t]here was a woman in the room and one of the men began to look at her. Abdullah said to him, 'It would have been better for you if your eyes had been gouged out.'"¹⁸²⁵

Yet while Islamic texts often employed historical speculation, they also discouraged it. The Qur'an contains passages that clearly critique counterfactuals. In one of them, Mohammed condemned unbelievers for defending their failure to join his wars of conquest by their use of disingenuous counterfactual claims, such as "if we had been able, we had surely gone forth with you."¹⁸²⁶ Elsewhere, Mohammed admonished civilians not to pity soldiers who died

in holy war, telling them not to speculate that “if only [the soldiers]... had been ... [at home, they]... had not ... been slain.” For as he deterministically declared, “what befell them was so ordained [by]... God.”¹⁸²⁷ The best example of all appeared in a passage from the Hadith that declared: “The strong believer is better and more beloved to Allah than the weak believer ... If anything befalls you, do not say, ‘if only I had done such and such,’ rather say ... ‘Allah has decreed and whatever he wills, He does. ... For (saying) ‘If’ opens (the door) to the deeds of Satan.”¹⁸²⁸

Further research is needed to determine how counterfactuals evolved over time in the Islamic world. It is likely, on the one hand, that scholars will find evidence of historical speculation in the medieval and modern eras. It is significant that the great North African historian Ibn Khaldun (1332–1406) used scattered counterfactuals in his famous text, the *Muqaddimah* (1377), applying them to the origins of the Umayyad caliphate (Figure 10.2).¹⁸²⁹ Similarly, the famed early modern Turkish historian İbrahim Peçevi (1572–1650) speculated in his two-volume *History* of the Ottoman Empire how the Sultan’s army might have attained military victories over Hungarian forces in the late sixteenth century.¹⁸³⁰ It can be assumed that other Muslim historians speculated about similar events. On the other hand, scholars may also discover religiously based skepticism towards counterfactuals in Muslim histories. To cite merely one example, Ibn Khaldun himself discouraged speculation, writing in the *Muqaddimah* that, in seeking the causes of things, “we have been commanded completely to ... suppress any speculation ... and to direct ourselves to the Causer of all causes ... God.”¹⁸³¹

As scholars research the relationship between speculation and determinism in Islamic historiography, they will want to examine a range of questions: To what degree did the deterministic and fatalistic aspects of Islam shape how Muslims used counterfactuals? How did this use vary across space—from North Africa to the Middle East and Asia—and how did it shift over time? To what degree did the comparatively late arrival of modernity in the Islamic world make Muslims less likely to wonder “what if?” than westerners?¹⁸³² Have westernization and globalization promoted or impeded counterfactual thought in the contemporary Islamic world? Recent research on the reluctance of Arab Muslims to wonder “what if” (or “*lau lau*”) suggests the enduring importance of Islamic religious and cultural traditions.¹⁸³³ At the same time, recent scholarship on Arabic language alternate histories (a genre called *al tarikh al-badil*) suggests that the Islamic world is just as open to counterfactual speculation as the west.¹⁸³⁴ Only future research will determine how these competing trends relate to one another.



FIGURE 10.2 The North African historian, Ibn Khaldun, occasionally used counterfactuals in his famous text, the *Muqaddimah* (1377). (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

Asian Counterfactuals

Similar questions can be asked about Asia. Given the considerable size, diversity, and longevity of the continent's core civilizations, it is impossible to adequately survey the history of counterfactual thought in Asia. It is especially difficult given the relative lack of scholarly research on the topic.¹⁸³⁵ In examining how people in China, India, and other Asian countries have wondered "what if?", therefore, future scholars may again want to consider the general

theory of counterfactualism and employ some of the same comparisons used to analyze the Islamic world.

At first glance, the many differences between Asian civilizations and the West suggest an aversion to counterfactual thought. Western scholars have long postulated a tendency towards fatalistic thinking in Asian life. Whether attributing it to religious traditions, such as the polytheism and syncretism of Taoism, Buddhism, Hinduism, Jainism, and Shintoism; to philosophical concepts, such as the power of fate (expressed in the Chinese notion of *ming* and Hindu idea of *karma*) over human agency; to cultural traditions, such as the belief in cyclical time and reincarnation (*samsara*); to social traditions, such as the prioritization of the collective over the individual; or to political traditions, such as the prevalence of authoritarian centralism over popular sovereignty, scholars have identified a pattern of deterministic thought in Asia that would seem to restrict counterfactual speculation.¹⁸³⁶

And yet, this view does not withstand empirical investigation. Take the case of China. It is true that Chinese historiography was not very open to counterfactuals. Like ancient Mesopotamian and Egyptian historiography, Chinese historiography took longer to develop narrative forms of historical writing, remaining mostly annalistic until the Qin era (221–206 BCE).¹⁸³⁷ Chinese historiography was also long beholden to the ideological dictates of dynastic regimes and the deterministic, if not fatalistic, features of Taoism and Confucianism. Yet, while “what ifs” are scarce in ancient Chinese texts—for instance, in Confucianism’s “Five Classics” and “Four Books”—they are not entirely absent. They appear, for example, in the writings of Confucius’s disciple, Mencius (372–289 BCE), who occasionally used trading places counterfactuals to draw conclusions about legendary emperors and philosophers (Figure 10.3).¹⁸³⁸ Counterfactuals are also visible in texts written during the Han Dynasty (200 BCE–200 CE), which produced the father of Chinese historiography, Sima Qian (145—c. 86 BC), and his famous *Records of the Historian* (*Shi Ji*), which occasionally wondered “what if?” in employing a more analytical approach to the past.¹⁸³⁹ “What ifs” were even more common in the work of the rationalist natural philosopher, Wang Chong (27–c. 97 CE), whose collection of essays, known as *Lun-Heng*, utilized causal counterfactuals for a wide range of analytical purposes. Among other things, Wang used them to examine the causal relationship between moral degeneration and moral philosophy, speculating that Confucius’s fifth-century political treatise, the *Chūnqiū* (*The Spring and Autumn Annals*), “would not have been written” if “the ways of Chou [had] not degenerated” and “the people [had]... not been uncultured.”¹⁸⁴⁰ Wang also used temporal counterfactuals to critique philosophical snobbery,



FIGURE 10.3 The writings of the Chinese historian, Mencius (372–289 BCE), featured trading places counterfactuals. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

condemning the disdain displayed by the first-century CE philosopher, Chang Po Sun, toward the work of his contemporary, Yang Tse Yun, by noting that “[if the latter] had ... lived before [the former]..., Chang Po Sun would have looked upon him as a gold safe.”¹⁸⁴¹

Counterfactuals also appear in Indian texts. Certain western scholars have claimed that India lacks a significant historiographical tradition, attributing it to the culture’s cyclical view of time, the ritualistic features of Hinduism, and the region’s tradition of political decentralization.¹⁸⁴² Yet while India may have had less historiography than other civilizations, Indian culture was still marked by a strong sense of historical consciousness that permitted room for counterfactual thought. In the realm of literature, for example, the epic poem the *Mahabharata* (400 BCE–400 CE) features “what ifs” in which key characters



FIGURE 10.4 Scattered “what ifs” are found in the ancient Indian poem, the *Ramayana* (700 BCE–300 CE), as in this 17th century image, where King Dasharatha tries to prevent his son, Rama, from going into exile in the forest. (Source: Wikimedia Commons)

express regret for setbacks and gratitude for achievements. After suffering a shameful defeat in battle, for example, the warrior villain, Duryodhana, is described as thinking “it would have been far better if he had been killed by [his rival,] Chitrasena” before announcing his “wish to fast unto death.”¹⁸⁴³ In another passage, the poem employs a causal counterfactual to declare that “Bhima’s arrows would have killed Duryodhana then and there had it not been for his armor.”¹⁸⁴⁴ Similar “what ifs” are found in the epic poem the *Ramayana* (700 BCE–300 CE). In one of many passages devoted to underscoring the virtue of King Dasharatha, the King regrets his decision to banish his son, Rama, to the forest by declaring, “Had I died without inflicting this evil on Rama who does not merit it, I would have experienced joy in heaven” (Figure 10.4).¹⁸⁴⁵ These texts reveal that Indian culture possessed the same capacity for wondering “what if” that the Sumerians expressed in the *Epic of Gilgamesh* and the Greeks articulated in the *Iliad*. The fact that subsequent Indian historiography remained underdeveloped in a relative sense should not lead us to underestimate the existence of an Indian counterfactual tradition.

African Counterfactuals

The same is true of counterfactual thought in Africa. Unlike China and India, Africa is too geographically vast and culturally diverse to have a single

continuous civilizational tradition. While the northern parts of the African continent were shaped by a variety of religious and literary practices—from ancient Egypt, early Christianity, and Islam—sub-Saharan Africa remained rooted in indigenous traditions. This divergence profoundly influenced the continent's historiographical development. In the North, written history advanced thanks to the influence of Islamic practices, but south of the Sahara, historiography remained rooted in oral culture. While historical consciousness was widely preserved there through proverbs, songs, and sayings—and while it can be assumed that these traditions expressed their share of counterfactual impulses—the lack of written documentation makes it impossible to say how developed “what ifs” were in the central and southern parts of the African continent.

As a result, the oldest African counterfactuals hail from the North, specifically from the powerful early modern Mali and Songhai Empires. After embracing Islam in the late Middle Ages, both empires produced Arabic language texts.¹⁸⁴⁶ These texts mostly documented post-Islamic events, but they also addressed older occurrences that had originally been preserved in oral form. This was true of the nineteenth-century *Kano Chronicle*, which documented events dating back to the tenth century in the Hausa States in Northern Nigeria (Figure 10.5).¹⁸⁴⁷ Notably enough, this text and others like it contained scattered counterfactuals. The *Kano Chronicle* documented how the rulers (*Sarkis*) of the Hausa experienced close calls and missed opportunities in military conflicts dating back to the seventeenth century—for instance, when forces marshalled by the city of Katsina, Kano's trading rival, “would have entered and destroyed [Kano]” if it had not been “for the sake of the *mallams* [Muslim religious leaders].”¹⁸⁴⁸ Similarly, the seventeenth-century *Tarikh al fattash*, which documented events in the seventeenth-century Songhai empire, included counterfactuals showing how, but for specific circumstances, certain leaders (*askiyas*) would not have lost battles and certain judges (*qadis*) would not have been appointed to their positions.¹⁸⁴⁹ These texts, despite being small in number, suggest that counterfactual thought was a part of North African culture.

This all-too-brief survey of non-western counterfactuals is anything but comprehensive and is mostly meant to stimulate future scholarship. The good news is that the field is currently wide open and offers abundant opportunities for scholarly inquiry. Once historians and others decide to explore “what ifs” in the non-western world, they would do well to look for broader patterns of speculation. In doing so, they should address a variety of questions: Which historical events have inspired people to ask, “what if?” How have those events been depicted: as nightmare, fantasy, or stasis scenarios? What types of counterfactuals have been used to portray these scenarios? Scholars will also want

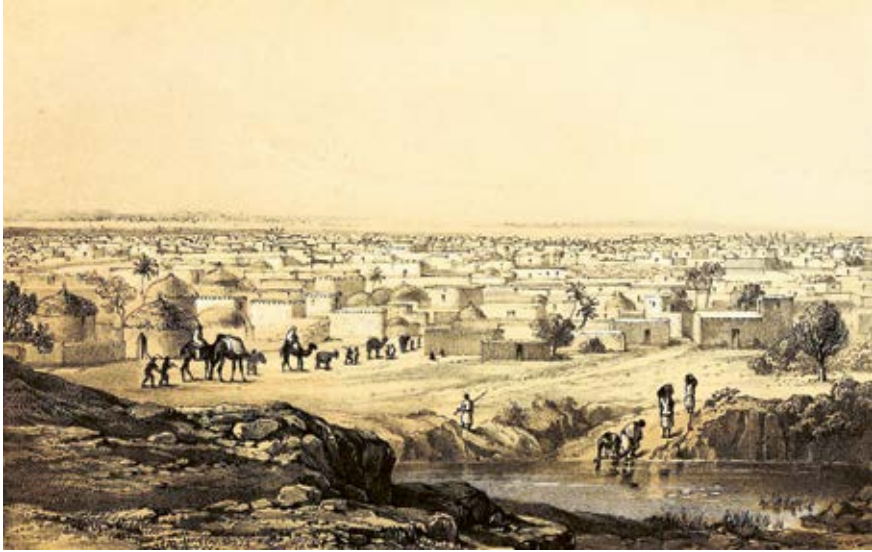


FIGURE 10.5 *The Kano Chronicle* included occasional counterfactuals depicting how the rulers (*Sarkis*) of the Hausa states experienced close calls and missed opportunities in military conflicts. (Source: “Kano from Mount Dala,” by Martin Bernatz (1857). Wikimedia Commons)

to diachronically examine how patterns of speculation have shifted over time. They will want to determine how different political, intellectual, cultural, and historiographical considerations have shaped the process of wondering “what if?” They will want to identify whether trends in speculation have been marked more by continuities or breaks. Scholars will especially want to consider how major ruptures in the history of the non-western world—for example, the arrival of new religions, such as Islam and Christianity, and the imposition of new power relations rooted in colonialism and imperialism—shaped how non-western nations wondered about the past. As scholars explore these and other questions, they will gradually be able to produce a global history of counterfactual history.

The Future of Counterfactual History

As they make headway, scholars will want to keep an eye on future developments in counterfactual thought. Although the western world is currently experiencing a surge of interest in historical “what ifs,” there is no reason to assume it will last. This book has demonstrated that historical speculation

surges and recedes over time in conjunction with broader forces. Whether they are religious, political, intellectual, rhetorical, historiographical, or mnemonic, these forces help generate the tensions, divisions, and conflicts among people that prompt them to speculate about the past. Reflecting on how these forces may develop down the line may help us predict how counterfactual thinking will develop in the future.

If present trends continue, counterfactual history is likely to thrive. The reason is simple: to an increasing degree, western society in the internet age is experiencing the kinds of tensions, divisions, and conflicts that stimulate counterfactual thought. The signs are everywhere. Religious tensions are intensifying between the proponents of fundamentalism and the supporters of secularism. Political divisions are deepening between rightwing radicals, liberal democrats, and leftwing socialists. Intellectual conflicts are growing between those who reject, and those who respect, objective truth. Rhetorical rivalries are surging between the supporters of reckless hyperbole and the advocates of measured discourse. Historiographical debates are erupting between the supporters of revisionism and the defenders of orthodoxy. Memory wars are raging between those who deny historical injustices and those who want to atone for them. These conflicts are diverse in expression, but they generally pit two groups against one another: those who embrace dogmatism and those who promote pluralism. History tells us that the latter are more likely to accept counterfactuals than the former. This being the case, the eventual outcome of present-day conflicts will decide whether historical speculation will increase or fade in the future. In the meantime, battles over counterfactual history will remain unresolved thanks to the dialectic of counterfactualism. Because counterfactuals are empirically unverifiable and lend themselves to rhetorical excess, they fail to break the interpretive deadlocks they are meant to resolve and perpetuate, rather than mitigate, disagreements about the past.

There is a chance, however, that future debates about counterfactual history may one day become less bitter than they have been in the past. At least this may be the case if this book achieves its main goals. From its original conception, *Predicting the Past* has pursued the dual goals of analysis and advocacy. It has sought to explain the origins and trace the evolution of counterfactual history over three thousand years of western history. But it has also sought to show that counterfactual history is a longstanding part of the western tradition and deserves to be acknowledged as such. If readers of this book are convinced that this is, in fact, the case, counterfactual history may continue to gain further acceptance in the years to come. Historical speculation may eventually cease to be controversial. Should this come to pass, counterfactual history will finally become legitimized in western intellectual and cultural life. At this point, we will no longer have to wonder whether it is acceptable to wonder "what if."

Notes

Chapter 1

- 1 Heinrich von Sybel, *Vorträge und Aufsätze* (Berlin, 1874), pp. 305–06.
- 2 This is the contention of Daniel Woolf's essay, "Concerning *Altered Pasts*," pp. 420–421.
- 3 Joseph de Maistre, *Considerations on France* (Cambridge, UK, 2003), pp. 4–5.
- 4 *Ibid.*, pp. 7–8.
- 5 *Ibid.*, p. 5.
- 6 *Ibid.*, p. 8.
- 7 *Ibid.*, p. 9.
- 8 *Ibid.*, p. 21.
- 9 *Ibid.*, p. 14.
- 10 *Ibid.*, p. 16.
- 11 *Ibid.*, p. 16.
- 12 *Ibid.*, p. 17.
- 13 F. A. de Chateaubriand, *Portrait of Bonaparte* (New York, 1814), pp. 13–14.
- 14 *Ibid.*, pp. 28–29.
- 15 *Ibid.*, p. 36.
- 16 *Memoirs of Chateaubriand, Written by Himself, Volume 1* (London, 1848), p. 187.
- 17 Chateaubriand, *Portrait of Bonaparte*, pp. 52–54.
- 18 Viscount de Chateaubriand, *The Genius of Christianity* (Baltimore, 1871), p. 457. He added that "[if] the writers of the eighteenth century ... had been more religious, they would have approached nearer to perfection."
- 19 *Ibid.*, p. 684.
- 20 *Ibid.*, pp. 674–76.
- 21 *Ibid.*, pp. 651–652.
- 22 *Ibid.*, p. 676. Chateaubriand said "the human race would have been reduced to a few individuals wandering among ruins." He added, "for this reason, Jesus Christ ... [was the] SAVIOUR OF THE WORLD ... A little earlier, his morality would not have been absolutely necessary, for the nations were still upheld by their ancient laws; a little later, that divine Messiah would have appeared after the general wreck of society." *Ibid.*, p. 678.
- 23 Joseph de Maistre, *The Pope* (London, 1850), pp. 150–51.
- 24 *Ibid.*, pp. 293–94.
- 25 *Ibid.*, p. 291.
- 26 Joseph de Maistre, *Letters on the Spanish Inquisition* (Boston, 1850), pp. 86–93, 96.
- 27 *Ibid.*, p. 60. Finally, de Maistre credited religion with enabling the Spanish people to overthrow Napoleon and regain their liberty, implying that they would not have "been willing to sacrifice their lives for the ... good of the nation ... had they not been guided by national feeling ... and ... what heretical calumny [calls]... Spanish superstition." *Ibid.*, p. 100.
- 28 De Maistre, *The Pope*, pp. xxii–xxiii.
- 29 *Ibid.*, pp. 192–93.
- 30 *Ibid.*, pp. 291–92.
- 31 Ceri Crossley, "History as a Principle of Legitimation in France, 1820–1848," in Stefan Berger, Mark Donovan, and Kevin Passmore (eds.), *Writing National Histories: Western Europe Since 1800* (London and New York: Routledge, 1999), pp. 49–56.

- 32 M. Guizot, *History of the Origin of Representative Government in Europe*, Volume 20 (London, 1861), p. vii; see also Breisach, p. 244. Taking the same view was the philosopher, Victor Cousin. Believing that history was "a manifestation of God," he believed that it had a "regular development" that was guided by "necessary laws." M. Victor Cousin, *Course of the History of Modern Philosophy*, Volume 1 (Edinburgh, 1852), p. 138. Providential forces, he declared, meant that "everything is in its ... place" and "is there for good."
- 33 M. F. Guizot, *General History of Civilisation in Europe, From the Fall of the Roman Empire Till the French Revolution* (Edinburgh, 1848), p. 114 (original, 1828).
- 34 Ibid., p. 176.
- 35 Ibid., p. 204.
- 36 Guizot, *General History of Civilisation in Europe*, p. 224.
- 37 Adolphe Thiers, *History of the French Revolution* (London, 1845), p. 25.
- 38 Ibid. Thiers added that in a less absolutist France, "the spirit of independence, awakened by the struggles of the Fronde, would not have been smothered; the inquiry into the true interests of humanity would not have been retarded." "The seventeenth century," he concluded, "might have been the age as well of reason as of genius."
- 39 Jules Michelet, *Historical View of the French Revolution* (London, 1888), p. 427. Orig. 1847–53.
- 40 Jules Michelet, *On History*, ed., Lionel Gossman (Cambridge, UK, 2013), pp. 54–61. The quotes come from his *Introduction to World History* (1831).
- 41 Jacques Nicolas Augustin Thierry, *The Formation and Progress of the Tiers État, Or Third Estate in France, Volume 1* (London, 1855), pp. 5–6.
- 42 Alphonse de Lamartine, *History of the Girondists*, Volume 1 (London, 1890), p. 41.
- 43 Ibid., p. 40.
- 44 F. A. Mignet, *History of the French Revolution from 1789 to 1814* (London, 1856), p. 2.
- 45 Ibid., p. 3.
- 46 Michelet, *Historical View of the French Revolution*, p. 486.
- 47 Ibid., p. 191.
- 48 Ibid., pp. 234–35.
- 49 Ibid., p. 421.
- 50 Quinet, *La Revolution*, Volume 2, pp. 42–43.
- 51 Quinet, *La Revolution*, p. 144.
- 52 Ibid., pp. 164–65.
- 53 Ibid., p. 56.
- 54 In the years after his death in 1821, Napoleon experienced a wave of admiration that culminated in King Louis Philippe's decision in 1840 to rebury the former Emperor's remains at the Invalides in Paris.
- 55 Madame de Staël, *Considerations on the Principal Events of the French Revolution*, Vol. II (London, 1818), pp. 243, 270.
- 56 Ibid., p. 413.
- 57 Ibid., p. 345.
- 58 Ibid., p. 398.
- 59 Ibid., p. 389.
- 60 Madame de Staël, *Considerations on the Principal Events of the French Revolution*, Vol. III (London, 1818), p. 324.
- 61 De Staël, *Considerations on the Principal Events of the French Revolution*, Vol. III, p. 328.
- 62 Ibid., pp. 394–95.
- 63 Ibid., p. 399.

- 64 Adolphe Thiers, *History of the Consulate and the Empire of France Under Napoleon*, Volume 5 (Philadelphia, 1865), p. 758.
- 65 Gooch, p. 202.
- 66 Adolphe Thiers, *History of the Consulate and the Empire of France Under Napoleon*, Volume 5 (London, 1845), p. 63.
- 67 Ibid., p. 63. In his *History of the French Revolution* (1823), Thiers ended his narrative by justifying Napoleon's coup on the 18th of Brumaire as "a necessary blow which terminated anarchy" and as a sign of Providence's intention to spread "liberty." Adolphe Thiers. *History of the French Revolution* (Edinburgh, 1859), p. 777.
- 68 So did Mignet, who, on discussing Napoleon's abdication in April of 1814, concluded: "thus fell this man ... [who was] the most gigantic being of modern times. That which would have rendered the destiny of another [man] extraordinary, scarcely counts in his." Mignet, p. 407.
- 69 Ibid., p. 739.
- 70 Adolphe Thiers, *History of the Consulate and the Empire of France Under Napoleon*, Volume 12 (Philadelphia, 1894), p. 434.
- 71 De Staël, *Considerations on the Principal Events of the French Revolution*, vol. 2, p. 303.
- 72 Ibid., pp. 336–37, 341.
- 73 Ibid., p. 323.
- 74 Adolphe Thiers, *History of the Consulate and the Empire of France Under Napoleon* (London, 1855), 656–57.
- 75 Mignet, p. 400.
- 76 Adolphe Thiers, *History of the Consulate and the Empire of France Under Napoleon*, Volume 12, pp. 289–90.
- 77 Pieter Geyl, *Napoleon, For and Against* (New Haven, 1949), p. 74.
- 78 The original edition by Emmanuel-Auguste-Dieudonné comte de Las Cases was published as *Le Mémorial de Sainte-Hélène*, 8 vols. (London, 1823).
- 79 *Memoirs of the Life, Exile, and Conversations of Emperor Napoleon by the Count de las Cases, Volume 2* (New York, 1879), pp. 132–33.
- 80 Ibid., p. 223.
- 81 Ibid., pp. 132, 145.
- 82 *Memoirs of the Life, Exile, and Conversations of Emperor Napoleon, Volume 2* (New York, 1855), p. 280.
- 83 For Austria, see *Memoirs of the Life, Exile, and Conversations of Emperor Napoleon by the Count de las Cases, Volume 2* (New York, 1879), pp. 104–110. For Spain, see *Memoirs of the Life, Exile, and Conversations of the Emperor Napoleon, Volume 2* (New York, 1855), p. 296.
- 84 *Memoirs of Napoleon Bonaparte* (London, 1836), Volume 1, p. 376.
- 85 Ibid., Volume 3, p. 134.
- 86 *Mémorial de Sainte Hélène: Journal of the Private Life and Conversations of the Emperor Napoleon at Saint Helena, Volume 3* (London, 1823), pp. 214–15.
- 87 *The Life, Exile, and Conversations of the Emperor Napoleon, Vol. III* (London, 1835), pp. 152–53. *Memoirs of Napoleon Bonaparte* (London, 1836), Volume 3, p. 166.
- 88 *Memoirs of Napoleon Bonaparte* (London, 1836), vol. 2, p. 171. "I should have been another William III," he declared, "but I would have acted with greater generosity ... My troops would have behaved in London just as they would in Paris. No sacrifices, not even contributions, would have been exacted from the English."
- 89 *The Life, Exile, and Conversations of the Emperor Napoleon, Vol. IV* (London, 1835), pp. 75–77.

- 90 *Memoirs of Napoleon Bonaparte* (London, 1836), Volume 1, p. 376.
- 91 *Memoirs of Napoleon Bonaparte* (London, 1836), Volume 3, p. 322.
- 92 *Mémorial de Sainte Hélène: Journal of the Private Life and Conversations of the Emperor Napoleon at Saint Helena, Volume 4* (London, 1823), p. 76.
- 93 *The Life, Exile, and Conversations of the Emperor Napoleon, Vol. IV* (London, 1835), p. 29.
- 94 *Memoirs of Napoleon Bonaparte* (London, 1836), Volume 2, p. 54.
- 95 *The Life, Exile, and Conversations of the Emperor Napoleon, Vol. IV* (London, 1835), pp. 263–67.
- 96 Herbert Butterfield, *The Whig Interpretation of History* (New York, 1965). The book was originally published in 1931.
- 97 As Macaulay famously put it in 1835, “the history of England is emphatically the history of progress.” Thomas Macaulay, *Critical and Historical Essays, Volume 1* (New York, 1907), p. 292.
- 98 Henry Thomas Buckle sought to discover the “great laws” that governed the “fortunes of mankind,” including the history of England. Henry Thomas Buckle, *History of Civilization in England, Volume 1* (New York, 1859), p. 171.
- 99 Buckle described the history of England as “more important than any other.” Buckle, p. 167.
- 100 Benedikt Stuchtey, “Literature, Liberty and Life of the Nation: British Historiography from Macaulay to Trevelyan,” in Berger, et al., pp. 30–47.
- 101 Steve Fuller, *The Knowledge Book: Key Concepts in Philosophy, Science, and Culture* (New York, 2007), p. 66.
- 102 E. A. Freeman, *The History of the Norman Conquest of England, Volume 5* (Oxford, 1876), p. 394.
- 103 Thomas Macaulay, *The History of England, Volume 1* (Boston, 1855), pp. 11–12.
- 104 *Ibid.*, p. 17. Freeman made a similar point about King John, saying “Under a better King, the formal confirmation of our national life and our national freedom might have been put off.” Freeman, p. 467.
- 105 *Ibid.*, p. 18.
- 106 William Stubbs, *The Constitutional History of England in Its Origin and Development, Volume 2* (Oxford, 1875), p. 101. Stubbs added that while King Henry III (r. 1216–1272) defeated the nobles’ leader, Simon de Montfort, the King’s ensuing “irresolution and impolicy” prevented him from pacifying the nobles for good, declaring that “had he been able to divide the national opposition ..., he might have created a lasting despotism.”
- 107 Stubbs, *The Constitutional History of England in Its Origin and Development, Volume 3* (Oxford, 1875), p. 611.
- 108 E. A. Freeman, *The Growth of the English Constitution* (London, 1872), p. 71.
- 109 Macaulay, *The History of England*, p. 24.
- 110 Stubbs, *The Constitutional History of England, Volume 3*, p. 294.
- 111 *Ibid.*, p. 522.
- 112 J. A. Froude, *History of England from the Fall of Wolsey to the Death of Elizabeth, Volume 1* (New York, 1881), p. 117.
- 113 Henry Hallam, *The Constitutional History of England, Volume 1* (London, 1876), p. 81. Hallam conceded that “the abolition of monastic institutions might have been conducted in a manner consonant to justice,” but he ultimately justified it by concluding that “Henry’s profuse alienation of the abbey lands, however illaudable in its motive, has proved upon the whole more beneficial to England than any other disposition would have turned out.” *Ibid.*, pp. 74–75.

- 114 Ibid., p. 79.
- 115 James Mackintosh, *The History of England, Volume 2* (London, 1838), p. 240.
- 116 Ibid., p. 188.
- 117 Froude, p. 167.
- 118 Macaulay, *The History of England*, p. 57.
- 119 Ibid., pp. 79–80.
- 120 Thomas Macaulay, *The History of England: From the Accession of James II*, Volume 1 (Philadelphia, 1855), p. 34
- 121 *Macaulay's History of England: From the Accession of James II* (London, 1953), p. 103.
- 122 Hallam, *The Constitutional History of England, Volume 1*, pp. 348, 256.
- 123 Ibid., p. 263.
- 124 Henry Hallam, *The Constitutional History of England, Volume 3* (London, 1878), p. 506.
- 125 Ibid., p. 176.
- 126 *Macaulay's History of England*, p. 116.
- 127 Henry Hallam, *The Constitutional History of England, Volume 1* (London, 1876), p. 384.
- 128 Henry Hallam, *The Constitutional History of England, Volume 1* (London, 1878), p. 644.
- 129 Mackintosh, *History of the Revolution in England in 1688, Volume 1* (Paris, 1834), p. 365.
- 130 Macaulay, *Critical and Historical Essays*, p. 315.
- 131 James Mackintosh, *The History of England*, Volume VIII (London, 1838), pp. 183–84.
- 132 Macaulay, *Critical and Historical Essays*, p. 316.
- 133 Ibid., pp. 315–16.
- 134 Henry Hallam, *The Constitutional History of England* (London, 1872), p. 470.
- 135 Ibid., p. 478.
- 136 Macaulay, *The History of England, Volume 3* (New York, 1861), p. 233.
- 137 Henry Thomas Buckle, *History of Civilization in England, Volume 1* (London, 1861), p. 400.
- 138 Markus Volkel, “German Historical Writing from the Reformation to the Enlightenment,” in Woolf, *The Oxford History of Historical Writing*, volume 3, pp. 326, 338–9.
- 139 Iggers, p. 64.
- 140 Barry Emslie, *Speculations on German History: Culture and the State* (Rochester, NY, 2015), pp. 136–37. Ranke rejected the idea of progress, saying in 1854 that “France was much more moral and cultured in the middle of the seventeenth century than at the end of the eighteenth.” *The Theory and Practice of History*, p. 23.
- 141 Cited in Leopold von Ranke’s preface to his *Geschichte der romanischen und germanischen Völker von 1494 bis 1514* (Leipzig, 1855), p. vii.
- 142 Leopold von Ranke, *The Theory and Practice of History*, edited by Georg G. Iggers (London, 2010), p. 21.
- 143 Iggers, *The German Conception of History*, p. 95.
- 144 Ficker rejected evaluating history according to “preexisting political and moral principles.” Julius Jung, Julius Ficker (1826–1902): Ein Beitrag zur deutschen Gelehrten-geschichte (Innsbruck, 1907), p. 320.
- 145 Wilhelm Giesebrecht, *Geschichte der Deutschen Kaiserzeit, Volume I* (Braunschweig, 1858), p. 54.
- 146 Wilhelm Giesebrecht, *Deutsche Reden* (Leipzig, 1871), p. 68.
- 147 Ficker, *Das deutsche Kaiserreich*, p. 20.
- 148 Ibid., pp. 125–26, 129.
- 149 Ibid., p. 134.
- 150 Ibid., pp. 87, 90.
- 151 Ibid., pp. 65–67.

- 152 Ibid., pp. 78–79.
- 153 Ibid., pp. 92–95.
- 154 *Geschichte der Deutschen Kaiserzeit, Volume 1* (Braunschweig, 1863), p. 295.
- 155 Ibid., p. 47. Ficker, *Das deutsche Kaiserreich*, p. 14.
- 156 Giesebrecht *Geschichte der Deutschen Kaiserzeit. Volume 1*, p. 447.
- 157 Giesebrecht, *Deutsche Reden*, pp. 100–102; Ficker, *Das deutsche Kaiserreich*, p. 112. Ficker added that imperial power further declined under the next Emperor, Frederick II (r. 1212–50) and his son Conrad IV (r. 1250–54), observing that “this development never would have happened if the acquisition of Sicily had not forced the Emperor to seek his base of support there instead of in Germany. Ibid., p. 115.
- 158 Ficker, *Das deutsche Kaiserreich*, pp. 76–77; 117–118.
- 159 Jung, p. 334.
- 160 Heinrich von Sybel, *Die Deutsche Nation und das Kaiserreich* (Düsseldorf, 1862), pp. 7–8, 44–46.
- 161 Ibid., pp. 15, 28.
- 162 Ibid., pp. 30–31.
- 163 Ibid., p. 60.
- 164 Ibid., pp. 19–20.
- 165 Ibid., p. 95.
- 166 Ibid., p. 50.
- 167 Some scholars regretted Germany’s failure to develop national institutions in the Middle Ages. Sybel, for example, praised Emperor Charles IV (r. 1346–78) for promulgating the famous Golden Bull of 1356, which created the college of electors responsible for choosing the Emperor, saying “it could have become the nucleus ... of a new imperial authority. *Die Deutsche Nation und das Kaiserreich*., p. 82. Unfortunately, it ended up merely enhancing the power of the nobles at the Empire’s expense. Droysen pointed to the hopes raised in 1495 when the Diet of Worms approved the creation of new centralized institutions, including a new Imperial Council (*Reichsregiment*), speculating that “if [only]... everyone had thought this way, the Empire would have become a peaceful state, founded on lawful freedom.” Gustav Droysen, *Geschichte der preußischen Politik, Zweiter Teil* (Leipzig, 1859), p. 15. However, Emperor Maximilian I (r. 1493–1519) abolished the council in 1502 and angered the nobles by going to war against the French in Italy in the pursuit of dynastic goals. This was especially tragic, according to Sybel, since “Germany at that time was economically and militarily superior to its western neighbor and would have only needed the Reich constitution, which the Emperor had destroyed, to repel a French attack by itself without Spanish protection.” Sybel, p. 91.
- 168 Heinrich von Sybel, *The Founding of the German Empire by William I, Volume 1* (New York, 1890), pp. 10–11.
- 169 Ranke, *History of the Reformation*, p. 468.
- 170 Ibid., p. 486.
- 171 Ibid., p. 189. Given that Frederick’s support of Lutheranism showed “national tendencies,” Ranke noted that “this certainly opened one of the grandest prospects for the destiny of Germany ... Had Frederick only been inspired by a more daring ambition! Had he not been of so cautious a nature, rendered still less enterprising by age!” Yet, as Ranke went on to note, “he had too long and too profound an acquaintance with the history of the empire, not to know that ... vast ... power was necessary to hold together in union and subordination these haughty ... princes and states, all striving for independence.”
- 172 Ibid., pp. 238–39.

- 173 Droysen, *Geschichte der preußischen Politik: Zweiter Teil* (Leipzig, 1870), p. 100. Despite being a member of the Prussian School, Droysen was a student of Leopold von Ranke.
- 174 Sybel, *Die Deutsche Nation und das Kaiserreich*, p. 92.
- 175 Discussing the reign of Emperor Ferdinand II (r. 1619–1637), who led Catholic League forces against Protestant rebels at the war's outset, Sybel speculated that "if [he] had triumphed" across the Empire as he did against Czech rebels at the Battle of White Mountain in 1619, Germany would have suffered the same fate as ... Bohemia," which was ruthlessly re-Catholicized in the wake of the state's defeat. *Ibid.*, pp. 122, 124.
- 176 Heinrich von Treitschke, *Germany, France, Russia, and Islam* (New York, 1915), p. 272.
- 177 Sybel, *Die Deutsche Nation und das Kaiserreich*, p. 124.
- 178 Both Droysen and Treitschke were deterministic, with the former proclaiming that "historical necessity" had "created, carried, and guided" the state of Prussia and the latter declaring that it was Prussia's destiny "to either rule Germany or perish." Gustav Droysen, *Geschichte der preußischen Politik Erster Teil* (Leipzig, 1868), p. 3. *Politics by Heinrich von Treitschke, Volume 2* (New York, 1916), pp. 361–62. Treitschke further made clear that narrating Prussia's rise to greatness had a presentist function—namely, to "appreciate the "blessing of ... unity" and "awaken ... a delight in the Fatherland." Gooch, p. 143. By way of comparison, Ranke was not nearly as deterministic or presentist in assessing Prussia's role in history—though he also appreciated the state's importance. Gooch, *History and Historians*, p. 195.
- 179 Leopold von Ranke, *Memoirs of the House of Brandenburg and History of Prussia, During the Seventeenth and Eighteenth Centuries, Volume III* (London, 1849), pp. 1–3.
- 180 Gustav Droysen, *Geschichte der preußischen Politik: Fünfter Teil* (Leipzig, 1878) pp. 150–51.
- 181 *Politics by Heinrich von Treitschke, Volume 2* (New York, 1916), p. 364.
- 182 *Treitschke's History of Germany in the Nineteenth Century, Volume 1* (New York, 1915), pp. 63–64. In this way, Treitschke added, "Germany could have effected ... by her own powers that necessary revolution which two generations later was shamefully forced upon her by the might of the foreigner."
- 183 *Politics by Heinrich von Treitschke*, p. 365.
- 184 *Treitschke's History of Germany*, p. 410.
- 185 Sybel, *Founding of the German Empire by William I*, pp. 131–32.
- 186 *Ibid.*, p. 162. Sybel mused: "Who can calculate the effect which the resolute action of a heroic and clear-sighted personality could have produced at this time of insecurity and upheaval. To be sure, it would have led to a rupture of the old Confederate fetters, but in such a way, that this would have marked the end of a revolution and not its beginning." *Ibid.*, p. 364.
- 187 *Ibid.*, p. 364.
- 188 *Ibid.*, p. 391.
- 189 *Ibid.*, p. 437.
- 190 *Politics by Heinrich von Treitschke, Volume 2* (New York, 1916), p. 62.
- 191 *Politics by Heinrich von Treitschke, Volume 1*, p. 130.
- 192 *Ibid.*, p. 141.
- 193 Cited in Adolf Hausrath, *Treitschke: His Doctrine of German Destiny and of International Relation* (New York, 1914), p. 56.
- 194 Otto von Bismarck, *The Memoirs, Being the Reflections and Reminiscences of Otto, Prince von Bismarck* (New York, 1966).
- 195 *Ibid.*, p. 85. Conversely, Bismarck justified using the stick with Hanover and Hesse, noting how he rejected King Wilhelm's proposal to permit the states to be ruled independently

by “partial princes” instead of being annexed by Prussia, arguing that this generous policy “would have given us [a] discontented [type of] confederation” marked by the desire to “win ... back lost territory.” Ibid., p. 81.

196 Ibid., p. 98.

197 Ibid., p. 167.

Chapter 2

198 Isaac Disraeli, “Of a History of Events Which Have Not Happened,” in *A Second Series of Curiosities of Literature* (London, 1824), p. 119.

199 Thomas Carlyle, *The French Revolution: A History, Volume 2* (London, 1837), p. 192.

200 On the crisis of faith, see Timothy Larsen, *Crisis of Doubt: Honest Faith in Nineteenth-Century England* (Oxford, UK, 2006); on the crisis of liberalism, see Carl Schorske, *Fin-de-Siècle Vienna: Politics and Culture* (New York, 1979); on the crisis of positivism, see H. Stuart Hughes, *Consciousness and Society* (New York, 1958); on the crisis of historicism, see Iggers, *The German Conception of History*.

201 Disraeli, pp. 99–119. Catherine Gallagher misdates the text as having been published in the 1790s, an impossibility given that Disraeli cited texts published in the first two decades of the nineteenth century. See Gallagher, pp. 25, 320 n15.

202 Disraeli, pp. 107–08, 102.

203 The works included Robert Southey’s *Life of Oliver Cromwell* (1821), William Roscoe’s *Illustrations, Historical and Critical, of the Life of Lorenzo de Medici* (London, 1822), Malcolm Laing, *The History of Scotland* (London, 1819), and John Whitaker’s *Mary Queen of Scots, Vindicated* (London, 1787).

204 Disraeli, pp. 110–112.

205 Ibid., p. 113.

206 Ibid., p. 112.

207 Gallagher, p. 25.

208 Disraeli, p. 119; Gallagher, p. 25.

209 Ibid., p. 99.

210 Disraeli’s opposition to religious intolerance may also have reflected his tensions with the London Jewish community, which he quit in 1813, after a dispute over his synagogue membership. James Picciotto, “Isaac Disraeli and His Family,” in *Sketches of Anglo-Jewish History* (London, 1875), p. 301.

211 Disraeli, p. 119.

212 Carlyle, p. 192.

213 David M. Epstein, “Mirabeau and the French Revolution: A Reappraisal,” *The Historian*, Vol. 32, No. 4, August 1970, pp. 576–594.

214 Carlyle, p. 188.

215 Ibid., pp. 191–192.

216 Ibid., p. 192.

217 Thomas Carlyle, *On Heroes, Hero-Worship, and the Heroic in History* (London, 1841).

218 *The Works of Thomas Carlyle, II: On Heroes, Hero-Worship, and the Heroic in History* (London, 1902), p. 13.

219 Ibid., p. 13.

- 220 Ibid., p. 13.
- 221 Joanna Malecka, "Thomas Carlyle's Calvinist Dialogue with the Nineteenth-Century Periodical Press," *History of European Ideas*, 2019, Nr. 1, p. 22. Claire A. Simmons, *Eyes Across the Channel: French Revolutions, Party History and British Writing, 1830–1882* (Amsteldijk, Netherlands, 2000), pp. 89, 21.
- 222 *The Works of Thomas Carlyle, II*, p. 13.
- 223 Ibid., p. 14.
- 224 Carlyle, *The French Revolution*, pp. 200, 203.
- 225 Ibid., p. 249.
- 226 Ibid., p. 249.
- 227 Victor Cousin, *The Course of the History of Modern Philosophy, Volume 1* (New York, 1852), p. 204.
- 228 Ibid., p. 201.
- 229 Ibid., p. 204.
- 230 Cousin believed that history was a "science" that should link "every fact ... [to] the general law which causes it to be." Ibid., pp. 165–66.
- 231 Ibid., pp. 199–201.
- 232 Cousin met Hegel in 1817. Terry Pinkard, *Hegel: A Biography* (Cambridge, UK, 2001), p. 381.
- 233 Hegel, *Lectures on the Philosophy of History* (London, 1884), pp. 31–33.
- 234 Ibid., pp. 32.
- 235 Hegel acknowledged the existence of chance and contingency but saw them as merely the manifestation of deterministic trends. As he put it, the job of philosophy was to "elicit the necessity concealed under the semblance of contingency." https://www.marxists.org/reference/archive/hegel/works/sl/slactual.htm#SL145n_2
- 236 Ibid., p. 90.
- 237 Karl Marx, *The 18th Brumaire of Louis Bonaparte* (Chicago, 1919), p. 139.
- 238 In his book, *The Civil War in France* (1871), Marx later responded to the eruption of the Paris Commune of 1870 by saying that while "it would have initiated the regeneration of France" had it succeeded, its constitution (which sought to decentralize the French state) "would have been an impossibility," since it retained a place for the French middle class. Cited in Paul Thomas, *Karl Marx and the Anarchists* (New York, 1980), p. 94.
- 239 Manfred B. Steger and Terrell Carver, eds., *Engels after Marx* (State College, PA, 1999), p. 127. As Engels noted, "the fact that ... a particular individual emerges ... is a pure accident. But if we would remove this man, a ... substitute would be found ... in the long run." Cited in Leo Yaresh, "The Role of the Individual in History," in C. E. Black, ed., *Rewriting Russian History* (New York, 1956), p. 80.
- 240 Breisach, p. 274.
- 241 Auguste Comte, *A General View of Positivism* (London, 1909), p. 344.
- 242 Breisach, p. 274.
- 243 As Buckle put it, "the movements of nations are perfectly regular" and follow a "doctrine of uniform sequence." Henry Thomas Buckle, *History of Civilization in England*, Volume II (London, 1864), p. 325.
- 244 Henry Thomas Buckle, *History of Civilization in England*, Volume I (New York, 1913), pp. 69, 71.
- 245 Ibid., p. 199.
- 246 In praising the secular philosophy of Bacon and Descartes, Buckle cautioned that they were merely its "exponents, [not its]... creators," declaring: "what would have been the effect produced by Bacon and Descartes, if, instead of living in the seventeenth century,

- they had lived in the seventh? Would their philosophy have been equally secular; or being equally secular, would it have been equally successful?" Buckle, *History of Civilization in England*, Volume 1, p. 238, n 30.
- 247 Herbert Spencer, *The Study of Sociology* (London, 1877), pp. 33–35.
- 248 Ibid., p. 36.
- 249 Frank Thilly, "The Individualism of John Stuart Mill," *The Philosophical Review*, Vol. 32, No. 1, January 1923, p. 5.
- 250 John Stuart Mill, *A System of Logic Ratiocinative and Inductive Part II* (New York, 1874), p. 648.
- 251 Robert Carr, "The Religious Thought of John Stuart Mill: A Study in Reluctant Scepticism," *Journal of the History of Ideas*, Vol. 23, No. 4, 1962, pp. 475–495.
- 252 Mill, *A System of Logic*, p. 570.
- 253 Ibid., p. 570.
- 254 Ibid., p. 649.
- 255 In his book, *On Liberty* (1859), Mill criticized Marcus Aurelius for persecuting early Christianity, writing "It is a bitter thought, how different a thing the Christianity of the world might have been, if the Christian faith had been adopted as the religion of the empire under the auspices of Marcus Aurelius instead of those of Constantine." In making this claim, Mill sought to defend the principle of free speech by showing that even the wisest of people can be wrong. As he put it, "Unless anyone who approves of punishment for the promulgation of opinions flatters himself that he is ... wiser ... than Marcus Aurelius ... let him abstain from that assumption of the joint infallibility of himself and the multitude." Stefan Collini, ed., *John Stuart Mill, On Liberty and Other Writings* (Cambridge, UK, 2003), p. 29. Jon Elster has described Mill as the first social science practitioner of counterfactual reasoning. Jon Elster, *Logic and Society, Contradictions and Possible Worlds* (Berkeley, 1978), p. 178.
- 256 Luthy, pp. 36–37, 42.
- 257 Ewa Domańska, "Hayden White: Beyond Irony," *History and Theory*, Volume 37, Nr. 2, May 1998, pp. 173–181.
- 258 Hayden White, *Metahistory*, p. 243.
- 259 Ibid., p. 238; Alberto Coll, "Foreword," in Harry Zohn, ed., Jacob Burckhardt, *Judgments on History and Historians* (Indianapolis, 1999), p. xvii.
- 260 See Jacob Burckhardt, *Force and Freedom: Reflections on History* (New York, 1964), p. 53.
- 261 As Burckhardt famously put it, history "is the record of what one age finds worthy of note in another." Coll, p. xiii.
- 262 White, pp. 232–38; Coll, p. xviii.
- 263 Coll, pp. xvii–xxii.
- 264 Coll, pp. xx–xxi.
- 265 Lionel Gossman, *Basel in the Age of Burckhardt* (Chicago, 2000), p. 271.
- 266 Gossman, p. 268.
- 267 As Burckhardt put it, "not everything is necessary by any means ... many things are accidental and personal doings." *Judgments on History and Historians*, p. 223.
- 268 See Jacob Burckhardt, "On Fortune and Misfortune in History," in Hans Meyerhoff, ed., *The Philosophy of History in Our Time* (New York, 1959), pp. 271–72.
- 269 White, p. 251; Gossman, p. 270.
- 270 Burckhardt, *Judgments*, pp. 68, 33.
- 271 Jacob Burckhardt, *The Civilisation of the Renaissance in Italy* (London, 1898), pp. 171–72.
- 272 Ibid., pp. 315–17.

- 273 Ibid., p. 117.
- 274 Burckhardt, *Judgments*, p. 112.
- 275 Ibid., pp. 193–94.
- 276 Ibid., pp. 193–94. In fact, Burckhardt insisted that it “would ... have been better” for German Protestantism without the Swedes, for it would have forced “the North German people ... to fight a national fight for their religion” without foreign support.
- 277 Ibid., p. 257.
- 278 Ibid. pp. 41–43. Burckhardt found a further benefit in the destructive impact wrought by medieval Islam, writing “If one imagines history without Islam, one must also eliminate the at least temporary rejuvenation which, as an opponent, it brought the Byzantine Empire and later, through the Crusades, to the West.” Ibid. p. 29.
- 279 Ibid., p. 246.
- 280 Ibid., p. 263.
- 281 Burckhardt, “On Fortune and Misfortune in History,” p. 274.
- 282 Ibid., p. 283.
- 283 Ibid., p. 287.
- 284 Ibid., p. 285.
- 285 Ibid., p. 289.
- 286 Burckhardt, *Judgments*, p. 29.
- 287 Ibid., p. 106.
- 288 Ibid., p. 158.
- 289 Ibid., p. 269.
- 290 Ibid., p. 82.
- 291 In the first scenario, Burckhardt imagined how the war would have unfolded without Cromwell, speculating that “the Presbyterians would have sought to make peace with Charles I,” but concluding that “the revolutionaries ... would have seized control.” In the second scenario, Burckhardt imagined that if Cromwell had “lived longer,” then “he would have been obliged to use the army for foreign wars ... in the spirit of a Protestant ... crusade” and his army “probably would have set out against the ‘idolaters’... and committed depredations ... against all sorts of Catholic peoples.” Ibid., pp. 200–203.
- 292 White, *Metahistory*, pp. 349–50.
- 293 Friedrich Nietzsche, “We Philologists,” in Oscar Levy, ed., *The Complete Works of Friedrich Nietzsche, Volume 8, The Case of Wagner* (New York, 1911).
- 294 Ibid., pp. 169–70.
- 295 Ibid., p. 170.
- 296 John Charles Evans “Nietzsche on Christ vs. Christianity,” *Soundings: An Interdisciplinary Journal*, Vol. 78, No. 3/4 (Fall/Winter 1995), pp. 571–588. Friedrich Nietzsche, *The Antichrist* (New York, 1920), pp. 99–100. It was also a universal message, whose original traits—as seen in “primitive Christianity”—were mere “accident[s] of environment.” Using a transplant counterfactual, Nietzsche speculated that “[if Jesus had been] set down among Hindus he would have made use of the concepts of Sankhya, and among Chinese he would have employed those of Lao-tse, and in neither case would it have made any difference to him.”
- 297 Evans, “Nietzsche on Christ vs. Christianity,” p. 571.
- 298 Oscar Levy, ed., *The Complete Works of Friedrich Nietzsche, Volume 11, Thus Spake Zarathustra* (New York, 1914), p. 84.
- 299 Nietzsche, *The Antichrist*, p. 119.

- 300 Ibid., p. 171. Daniel Conway, “‘The Milieu in Which He Moved as a Foreign Figure’: Nietzsche’s Revaluation of Epicurus,” in Vinod Acharya and Ryan J. Johnson, eds., *Nietzsche and Epicurus* (London, 2020), p. 218; Nietzsche, *The Antichrist*, p. 171.
- 301 Nietzsche, *The Antichrist*, p. 171.
- 302 Friedrich Nietzsche, *Twilight of the Idols*, in Walter Kaufmann, *The Portable Nietzsche* (New York, 1968), pp. 540, 653. Martin A. Ruehl, *The Italian Renaissance in the German Historical Imagination, 1860–1930* (Cambridge, UK, 2015), p. 95.
- 303 Giorgio Colli and Mazzino Montinari, *Nietzsche Werke: Kritische Gesamtausgabe, Siebente Abteilung, Dritter Band. Nachgelassene Fragmente, Herbst 1884 bis Herbst 1885* (New York, 1974), p. 191.
- 304 Ruehl, pp. 98–102.
- 305 Ruehl, p. 100.
- 306 Nietzsche, *The Antichrist*, p. 178.
- 307 Ibid., pp. 177–79.
- 308 Friedrich Nietzsche, *Human All Too Human*, in Anthony Uyl, *The Writings of Nietzsche, Volume III* (Woodstock, Ontario, 2017), p. 211.
- 309 Ibid., p. 62.
- 310 Ibid., p. 62.
- 311 Ibid., p. 62.
- 312 Ibid., p. 105.
- 313 Iggers, pp. 126, 134.
- 314 Edward Shils, ed., *Max Weber, On the Methodology of the Social Sciences* (Glencoe, IL, 1949), pp. 90–92.
- 315 Fritz Ringer, *Max Weber’s Methodology: The Unification of the Cultural and Social Sciences* (Cambridge, MA, 2009), introduction.
- 316 Eduard Meyer, *Zur Theorie und Methodik der Geschichte: Geschichtsphilosophische Untersuchungen* (Halle, 1902), pp. 49–50. Christopher Adair-Toteff, *Fundamental Concepts in Max Weber’s Sociology of Religion* (2015).
- 317 Eduard Meyer, *Geschichte des Altertums, Volume III* (Stuttgart, 1901), pp. 420, 445–46.
- 318 Eduard Meyer, *Zur Theorie und Methodik der Geschichte*, pp. 49–50.
- 319 Ibid., p. 16.
- 320 Ibid., p. 164.
- 321 Ibid., p. 47, n1. The context for Meyer’s remark was when he highlighted the significance of “events that never occurred but that could have been expected” by citing the failure of “Queen Mary of England to produce an heir with her husband, the King of Spain, Philip II,” while dismissing the related question of whether “England would have become Catholic” with the claim that such “speculation that did not belong in history.”
- 322 The observations appear in Weber’s essay, “The Logic of the Cultural Sciences,” in Shils, ed., *Max Weber*, p. 164.
- 323 Ibid., pp. 164–65. Weber further flagged Meyer’s inconsistent stance on counterfactuals by refuting his claim that it was “historically irrelevant” who fired the “two shots ... during the Berlin March days ... [that] provoked the outbreak of ... street fighting” during the Revolution of 1848 because “the situation was such that any accident whatsoever would have caused the conflict to break out.” According to Weber, Meyer did not realize that his comment was itself a counterfactual, a point that drove Weber to determine the utility of counterfactuals once and for all.
- 324 Ibid., p. 170.
- 325 Ibid., p. 173.

- 326 Ibid., pp. 175, 180.
- 327 Ibid., p. 181.
- 328 Ibid., p. 184.
- 329 Ibid., p. 166.
- 330 Ibid., p. 180, n. 39.
- 331 "Hypothetical History," *The Boston Globe*, March 25, 1883, p. 4. For "imaginary history," see "Mr. Asquith," *Carmarthen Journal*, December 14, 1894, p. 7. For "Historical 'Ifs,'" see "Archibald Campbell Tait," *The Sewanee Review*, Volume 15, October 1907, p. 393.
- 332 The first such instance of linguistic reification appeared in 1819 in an anonymously written book review of Joseph François Machaud's *Histoire des Croisades* in *The British Review and London Critical Journal*, Volume XIII, 1819, p. 52.
- 333 It is unknown how influential Carlyle's hyphenation of the phrase was for transforming it into a stand-alone concept. Carlyle's influence was visible in Justin Huntley McCarthy's book, *A Short History of the United States* (1898), which declared "It is one of the 'might-have-beens', which for the most part, are a vanity that if Governor Pickens had ... captured Fort Sumter early in February [1861], the Confederate States might have flourished for a time at least in peace." In Justin Huntley McCarthy, *A Short History of the United States* (London, 1898), p. 241. The phrase's first appearance in *The New York Times* was in the 1870s, in obituaries of writers who never reached their full potential. See "Henry Kingsley, The Novelist," *The New York Times*, July 2, 1876, p. 4.
- 334 Francis Jacox, "Historical Might, Could, Should, or Would Have Beens," *Colburn's New Monthly Magazine*, Volume 181, London, 1864, pp. 418–431.
- 335 Ibid., p. 418.
- 336 Ibid., p. 418.
- 337 Ibid., p. 421.
- 338 Ibid., p. 425.
- 339 Ibid., p. 421.
- 340 Ibid., p. 430.
- 341 John Timbs, *Historic Ninepins: A Book of Curiosities Where Old and Young May Read Strange Matters* (London, 1869), p. 3.
- 342 Ibid., pp. v–vi.
- 343 Ibid., p. 4.
- 344 Ibid., p. 67.
- 345 Timbs, p. 68.
- 346 Lecky was a disciple of Carlyle and began using counterfactuals around the same time as Burckhardt in the 1860s, as was shown in his volume, *History of the Rise and Influence of the Spirit of Rationalism in Europe* (1865). In this volume, Lecky used nightmare counterfactuals to highlight the detrimental impact of Spain on early modern European history as a foil to praise the rise of English liberty. For example, in condemning Spain's embrace of slavery and "centralised despotism," he argued that "Had she long continued to exercise the assimilating, absorbing, and controlling influence of a great Power, the advancement of Europe might have been indefinitely retarded." William Edward Hartpole Lecky, *History of the Rise and Influence of the Spirit of Rationalism in Europe* (New York, 1919), p. 321. More broadly, Lecky used "what ifs" to argue that "individual action and even mere accident have borne a very great part in modifying the direction of history." Lecky, "The Political Value of History," in William Edward Hartpole Lecky, *Historical and Political Essays* (London, 1909), pp. 31–32.

- 347 William Edward Hartpole Lecky, *A History of England in the Eighteenth Century*, Volume 1 (London, 1878), pp. 14–16.
- 348 “Events that Never Happened,” *Chamber’s Journal of Popular Literature, Science and Arts*, February 8, 1879, p. 91.
- 349 Review of Lecky’s *A History of England in the Eighteenth Century*, Volumes 1 and 2, *The Quarterly Review*, January and April 1878, p. 501. “Historic Accidents,” *Sheffield Independent*, September 26, 1895, p. 2.
- 350 “Modern Cheap Publications,” *Sunday Times*, September 2, 1866. See also “The Tory Manifesto,” *The Guardian*, May 30, 1865, p. 7; “What Might Have Been,” *All the Year Round*, April 19, 1862, pg. 128.
- 351 “Untitled,” *The Times*, February 12, 1859, p. 6.
- 352 Gail Hamilton, *A Battle of the Books* (New York, 1870), p. 119.
- 353 “Events That Never Happened,” *Chambers’s Journal*, Volume 56, Issue 1, 1879, pp. 91–93.
- 354 “Lucky Accidents,” *The Belfast News-Letter*, 1892, p. 6.
- 355 Some focused on the history of music. See Louis C. Elson’s many remarks, for instance, “If Martin Luther had not been a singer ... hymnology would be vastly different today,” in his book, *The Realm of Music* (Boston 1892), pp. 37–41.
- 356 Charles Larcom Graves, Edward Verrall Lucas, and George Morrow, *If—A Nightmare in the Conditional Mood* (London, 1908).
- 357 *Ibid.*, pp. 35, 6, 24, 54.
- 358 Charles Larcom Graves, Edward Verrall Lucas, and George Morrow, *Hustled History: Or, As It Might Have Been* (London, 1908), p. 50.
- 359 “Historical ‘ifs,’” in *Popular Electricity and Mechanics*, July 1914, p. 112.
- 360 M. P., *History of Orangeism: Its Origin, Its Rise and Its Decline* (Dublin, 1883), p. 9.
- 361 Frank H. Hill, “Home Rule and Home Rulers,” *The Contemporary Review*, January 1891. In 1888, an American writer in *Life Magazine* implied that counterfactual history was an established field, declaring that “history that never happened has always been an interesting study: ‘While There’s Life There’s Hope,’ *Life Magazine*, August 23, 1888.
- 362 Frederick William Bussell, *A New Government for the British Empire* (New York, 1912), p. 60.
- 363 “What Might Have Been,” *St. Albans Messenger* (Vermont), March 14, 1912, p. 1 “Three of Decisive Battles of History Fought June 14,” *Trenton Evening Times*, June 14, 1913, p. 7.
- 364 “1875,” *Sheffield and Rothertham Independent*, January 1, 1876, p. 6.
- 365 “The End Has Come,” *The Sunday Oregonian*, August 22, 1897, p. 4.
- 366 “The Ninth of Ab,” *The Jewish Exponent*, July 19, 1907, p. 4.
- 367 “The Dead Past,” *The Macon Daily Telegraph*, November 16, 1907, p. 4.
- 368 “China and the World,” *The Nation*, September 21, 1911, p. 264.
- 369 “The Flight of Years,” *The Crisis* (Columbus, Ohio), January 6, 1869, p. 400.
- 370 “Moral Hags,” *The Washington Post*, October 24, 1897, p. 28.
- 371 “Not Democracy, But a Disease,” *The New York Times*, July 15, 1900, p. 18. See also “Topics of the Times,” *The New York Times*, July 15, 1904.
- 372 “The Age of Reason,” *The Edinburgh Review*, January 1907, p. 11.
- 373 William Hickman Smith Aubrey, *The National and Domestic History of England*, Volume 3 (London, 1867), p. 235.
- 374 D. W. Faunce, “Paul, as an Argument for Christianity,” *The Baptist Quarterly*, October 1, 1873, p. 486.
- 375 “Shall We Celebrate the French Revolution?” *Radical Leader*, August 11, 1888, p. 4.
- 376 Frederick Greenwood, “Disraeli Vindicated,” *Blackwoods Edinburgh Magazine*, Volume 161, March 1897, p. 434.

- 377 *The Original Plymouth Pulpit: Sermons of Henry Ward Beecher in Plymouth Church, Brooklyn*, Volume 1 (New York, 1898), p. 348. One author in a small Iowa newspaper in 1883 blasted “might have-beens” as a “pagan” practice “utterly removed from a true Christian view of God’s providence,” saying “If we have failed to make the most of ourselves ... then surely it is [wrong]... to shift the blame upon ... ‘fortune,’ by which we virtually mean God himself.” “Might Have Been and May Be,” *Lyons Weekly Mirror* (Iowa), June 9, 1883.
- 378 “Uncrowned: A Page of Jewish History,” *The Sunday at Home*, May 5, 1877, p. 284.
- 379 Reverend E. Paxton Hood, “The King’s Sceptre,” *The Sunday at Home*, September 15, 1883, p. 581.
- 380 *Ibid.*, p. 582.
- 381 *Ibid.*, p. 581.
- 382 Shirley Gerard, “If Only --,” *Ladies Home Companion* (London, 1862), p. 203.
- 383 “Reflections by WJC,” *The Detroit News*, December 28, 1915, p. 4.
- 384 “It Might Have Been,” *The Aurora Daily Express*, October 31, 1896, p. 4.
- 385 “We Recommend White Bear Mine Shares,” *The Globe and Mail*, September 15, 1906, p. 21.
- 386 *The Jewish Exponent*, January 20, 1911, p. 14.
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- 588 Hamlin, p. 216. In discussing the possibility that Robert E. Lee might have replaced Davis as the Confederacy's leader, Pollard stopped short of fully exploring the scenario, noting: "we have no space here for an excursion on the speculation, interesting as it is." Pollard, *Life of Jefferson Davis*, p. 422.
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 731 Barnes, *The Genesis of the World War*, p. 434.

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- 749 Loreburn, pp. 17–19.
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- 752 Loreburn, p. 192.
- 753 Sazonov, p. 182.
- 754 Churchill, *The World Crisis*, pp. 203–04.
- 755 Headlam, pp. 306–07.
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- 761 Churchill, *The World Crisis*, p. 201.
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- 785 Barnes, *The Genesis of the World War*, pp. 530–31.
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- 790 Bausman, p. 71.
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- 792 There were only scattered references to the phrase in France, where the term “uchronia” was occasionally applied to Pascal’s aphorism. See “L’imprévu qui sauve,” *La Presse*, November 8, 1926, p. 1; “Fantasies uchronique,” *Maroc-Matin*, July 23, 1935.
- 793 He noted, for instance, that “if [King] George III had been ... a man of different character, the differences between the colonies and the mother country would have been amicably composed,” and “if ... a monarch of another mould than Constantine had emerged [as] the final victor [in the Roman Empire’s struggle for power], Christianity would ... have obtained toleration, but not privilege.” Harold Temperley, ed., *Selected Essays of J. B. Bury* (Cambridge, UK, 1930), pp. 63–64.
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- 812 “Let Us Talk It Over,” *The Pittsburgh Post*, December 3, 1919, p. 2; “If Cleopatra's Nose,” T. E. B. *Monthly Service Bulletin*, May 1922, p. 8; *New York Tribune*, December 4, 1919, p. 3.
- 813 Buchan, p. 44. See also Matthews, pp. 137–38, 141, 144. See also Newton Parke, “Hannibal, A Major ‘If’ of History,” *The Baltimore Sun*, February 2, 1930, p. 103.
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- 815 Bruce Barton, “It's a Great Little Word,” *Daily Boston Globe* (1928–1960); May 20, 1928, p. 14.
- 816 “Every-Day Poems by Anne Campbell,” *The Arizona Republic*, September 4, 1937, p. 18. “There is an enormous number of ‘iffers’ extant” in the U. S.; *The Hartford Courant*, February 8, 1932, p. 5.
- 817 R. G. Collingwood, *The Idea of History* (London, 1946), pp. 80–81.
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Chapter 5

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- 827 John Wheeler-Bennett, *The Treaty of Brest-Litovsk and Germany's Eastern Policy* (Oxford, 1940), pp. 15–16.

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- 896 Hitler's Table Talk, p. 346.
- 897 Hitler's Table Talk, p. 7.
- 898 Hitler's Table Talk, p. 50. In 1942, Hitler used an implied counterfactual to suggest that if the Bible had not "been translated into German" then "the whole of the German people [would not have been]... exposed to the whole of this Jewish mumbo-jumbo." *Hitler's Table Talk*, pp. 513–14.
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- 924 Purzelbaum published essays in Nazi journals; *Nationalsozialistische Monatshefte*, Bd. 3, 1932, p. 575, and *Der SA-Führer*, Bd. 1–45, Sonderdruck 36/37, 1939, p. 32.
- 925 *Ibid.*, p. 216.
- 926 One reviewer of an earlier text by Purzelbaum saw anti-Nazi proclivities. Review of Peter Purzelbaum, *Lausebums*, by: W. A. W., *Books Abroad*, Vol. 11, No. 3 (Summer, 1937), p. 346.
- 927 For instance, Purzelbaum cited a line spoken by the famed ancient Jewish thinker, Rabbi Akiva, from Karl Gutzkow’s 1846 play, *Uriel Acosta*, which supported Jewish emancipation.
- 928 Arkady Joseph Sack, *The Birth of the Russian Democracy* (New York, 1918), p. 138.
- 929 E. H. Wilcox, *Russia’s Ruin* (London 1920), p. 16.
- 930 Alexander Kerensky, *The Catastrophe* (New York, 1927), p. 80.
- 931 Edmund A. Walsh, *The Fall of the Russian Empire* (Boston, 1928), p. 260.
- 932 Edward A. Ross, *The Russian Bolshevik Revolution* (New York, 1921), p. 181.
- 933 Morgan Philips Price, *My Reminiscences of the Russian Revolution* (Westport, CT, 1981 (orig. 1921), p. 216.

- 934 *Conditions in Russia: Speech of Hon. William H. King* (Washington, DC, 1924), p. 7.
- 935 William Henry Chamberlin, *The Russian Revolution, 1917–1921, Volume 1* (New York, 1935), p. 139.
- 936 N. N. Sukhanov, *The Russian Revolution 1917. An Eyewitness Account. Vol. I* (New York, 1962), p. 293.
- 937 Chamberlin, *The Russian Revolution*, p. 294.
- 938 Ross, pp. v–vi.
- 939 William Henry Chamberlin, *A False Utopia: Collectivism in Theory and Practice* (London, 1937), p. 17.
- 940 Kerensky, p. 234.
- 941 Chamberlin, *The Russian Revolution*, pp. 411–412.
- 942 Wheeler-Bennett, p. 16.
- 943 “Lord Grey on Bolshevism,” *The Times* (London), July 16, 1920, p. 7.
- 944 Chamberlin, *The Russian Revolution*, p. 415.
- 945 Walsh, pp. ix–x.
- 946 Albert Rhys Williams, *Through the Russian Revolution* (New York, 1921), p. 286.
- 947 Kerensky, pp. 72–73.
- 948 “Thrilling First Hand Story of the Rise of the Bolsheviki,” *The New York Sun*, February 10, 1918, p. 60.
- 949 Some claimed there would have been no Nazism had the Bolshevik Revolution never occurred or had Germany triumphed in World War I. William Henry Chamberlin, *The World's Iron Age* (New York, 1941), p. 107. Oswald Garrison Villard, “Issues and Men,” *The Nation*, October 22, 1938, p. 411.
- 950 Frank Eyck, *G.P. Gooch: A Study in History and Politics* (London, 1982), p. 407.
- 951 W. H. Dawson, “The Urgency of Treaty Revision,” *The Contemporary Review*, July 1933, p. 16.
- 952 “Overplayed Hands,” “Without the Treaty of Versailles ... Hitler's rise to power would have been impossible.” *The Muscatine Journal* (Iowa), October 9, 1933, p. 3. Letter to the editor by Paul Schulz to *The Chicago Tribune*, March 22, 1939, p. 12. Letter by David Shnayerson, *The Kilgore Daily News* (Texas), August 8, 1937, p. 5. Letter by Friedrich Kuechle. “Defends Germany,” *The Pittsburgh Press*, April 9, 1933, p. 37.
- 953 “Flint is No War Call,” *The Kansas City Star* (Kansas City, Missouri), October 24, 1939, p. 1. See the remark of isolationist Minnesota Senator Henrik Shipstead in *Congressional Record*, vol. 85, part 1, October 16, 1939, p. 454; see also Alabama Senator J. Lister Hill's argument in *Congressional Record*, Volume 87, Part 1, February 5, 1941, p. 622.
- 954 *Congressional Record*, Volume 84, Part 5: April 24, 1939, to May 18, 1939 (Washington, D. C., 1939), p. 5436.
- 955 *National and English Review*, 1935, Volume 105, p. 333.
- 956 Egon Ranshofen-Wertheimer, *Victory is Not Enough* (New York, 1942), p. 98.
- 957 “Hitler and One of the Big Ifs of History,” *The Chattanooga News*, February 21, 1938, p. 4.
- 958 William Montgomery McGovern, *From Luther to Hitler: The History of Fascist-Nazi Political Philosophy* (London, 1941).
- 959 Harold Butler, *The Lost Peace* (New York, 1942), pp. 110–111.
- 960 Rohan D'O. Butler, *The Roots of National Socialism, 1783–1933* (London, 1941), pp. 283–84.
- 961 James Thomson Shotwell, *What Germany Forgot* (New York, 1940), pp. 80–81.
- 962 “Another Versailles?” *The Honolulu Star-Bulletin*, June 18, 1940, p. 6.
- 963 “War Won, Peace Lost,” *The Daily News* (New York), May 3, 1939, p. 637.
- 964 “Recuperative Power,” *Aberdeen Journal*, December 7, 1942, p. 2.
- 965 “Hitler's Inaugural,” *The Coshocton Tribune* (Ohio), February 3, 1937, p. 6.

- 966 Joseph J. Mathews, "The End of the Anglo-French Entente," *World Affairs*, September 1940, Vol. 103, No. 3, p. 151.
- 967 Aurel Kolnai, *The War Against the West* (New York, 1938), p. 13.
- 968 Benedetto Croce, *Philosophy, Poetry, History* (London, 1966), p. 548. The essay was devoted to determining the criteria that lent "quality" to historical writing.
- 969 In other words, Croce rejected combining a subtractive cause counterfactual with an additive effect counterfactual. That said, Croce allowed that it was sometimes reasonable to use "grammatical conditional[s]... [for] underlining the importance of certain decisive acts." Croce, p. 557.
- 970 Croce, p. 558. Croce also cited the implausibilities of Charles Renouvier's novel *Uchronie*, saying they were suitable for an "abstract philosopher," but not a professional historian.
- 971 Croce had explored the relationship between chance and determinism already before World War I in his essay *The Humanity of History* (originally written in 1912–13) where he criticized the growing emphasis among prewar historians on the role of "the absolutely extraneous, the capricious, [and] the accidental" in history and emphasized the role of rationality. Benedetto Croce, *Theory & History of Historiography* (London, 1921), p. 94.
- 972 Croce, *Philosophy, Poetry, History*, pp. 555–556.
- 973 Allan Nevins, *The Gateway to History* (New York, 1938), pp. 159, 38.
- 974 *Ibid.*, p. 247.
- 975 *Ibid.*, p. 35.
- 976 *Ibid.*, pp. 37–38.
- 977 Charles Oman, *On the Writing of History* (New York, 1939), p. ix.
- 978 *Ibid.*, pp. 132, 134, 146–47.
- 979 *Ibid.*, p. 166.
- 980 *Ibid.*, p. 9.
- 981 *Ibid.*, pp. 20, 180–81, 198, 126.
- 982 *Ibid.*, pp. 157–58.
- 983 Raymond Aron, *Introduction to the Philosophy of History: An Essay on the Limits of Historical Objectivity* (London, 1961), p. 10.
- 984 For background, see Iain Stewart, *Raymond Aron and Liberal Thought in the Twentieth Century* (Cambridge, UK, 2019), pp. 18–20, 50–54; Peter Breiner, "Raymond Aron's Engagement with Weber: Recovery or Retreat?" *Journal of Classical Sociology*, Vol. 11, No. 2, pp. 99–122.
- 985 Aron, pp. 179–80, 184–84.
- 986 *Ibid.*, pp. 160, 161–167.
- 987 *Ibid.*, p. 180.
- 988 *Ibid.*, p. 180.
- 989 *Ibid.*, p. 166.
- 990 *Ibid.*, p. 184.
- 991 *Ibid.*, p. 178.
- 992 *Ibid.*, p. 178.
- 993 *Ibid.*, p. 148.
- 994 *Ibid.*, pp. 183–84, 256.
- 995 *Ibid.*, pp. 254, 148, 149.
- 996 *Ibid.*, p. 333.
- 997 Marc Bloch, *The Historian's Craft* (New York, 1959), p. 190.
- 998 *Ibid.*, p. 191.
- 999 *Ibid.*, p. 193.

- 1000 Ibid., pp. 194–95.
- 1001 Ibid., p. xvi.
- 1002 Ibid., p. 125.
- 1003 Ibid., pp. 124–25.
- 1004 Bertrand Russell, *How to Read and Understand History* (Girard, KS, 1943), p. 9.
- 1005 Ibid., p. 16.
- 1006 Ibid., pp. 32–33.
- 1007 Ibid., pp. 32–33; p. 13.
- 1008 Bernard Berenson, *Rumor and Reflection* (New York, 1952), p. 110.
- 1009 Ibid., p. 287.
- 1010 Ibid., p. 289. Berenson also speculated that the advent of Julianism “might have saved the eastern world from the horrors ... [that] furnished squadristi or Stosstruppen to ferocious partisans like “Saint” Athanasius and “Saint” Cyril of Alexandria.” Ibid., p. 289.
- 1011 Ibid., p. 290.
- 1012 Ibid., p. 290.
- 1013 Sidney Hook, *The Hero in History* (New York, 2008), pp. 19–20.
- 1014 Ibid., pp. 6–7.
- 1015 Ibid., p. 117.
- 1016 Ibid., p. 28.
- 1017 Ibid., p. 116.
- 1018 Ibid., p. 123.
- 1019 Ibid., p. 114.
- 1020 Ibid., p. 123.
- 1021 Ibid., p. 16.
- 1022 Ibid., pp. 120, 131, 134.
- 1023 Ibid., p. 247.
- 1024 Ibid., p. 247.
- 1025 Ibid., p. 264.

Chapter 6

- 1026 This translation comes from Kenneth R. Berry’s edited volume from 1994: Louis-Napoléon Geoffroy-Château, *Napoléon and the Conquest of the World, 1812–1832* (Oklahoma City, 1994), pp. 410–411. The full title was *Napoléon and the Conquest of the World, 1812–1832: History of the Universal Monarchy* (*Napoléon et la conquête du monde, 1812–1832, Histoire de la monarchie universelle*).
- 1027 Many literary scholars have reflected on the narratological differences between alternate history and other genres of fiction—whether historical fiction, historiographical meta-fiction, science fiction, utopian fiction, secret histories, future histories, parahistories, and the like. Darko Suvin, “Victorian Science Fiction, 1871–85: The Rise of the Alternative History Sub-Genre,” *Science Fiction Studies*, July 1983, Vol. 10, No. 2, pp. 148–169; Jörg Helbig, *Der parahistorische Roman: Ein literarhistorischer und gattungstypologischer Beitrag zur Allotopieforschung* (Frankfurt, 1987); Gordon Chamberlain, “Afterword: Allohistory in Science Fiction,” in Charles G. Waugh and Martin H. Greenberg, *Alternative Histories: Eleven Stories of the World as it Might Have Been* (New York, 1986), pp. 281–300; Amy J. Ransom, “Alternate History and Uchronia: Some Questions of Terminology and Genre,”

- Foundation*, Spring 2003, p. 64; Geoffrey Winthrop-Young, "Fallacies and Thresholds: Notes on the Early Evolution of Alternate History," *Historical Social Research*, Nr. 2, 2009, pp. 99–117.
- 1028 For a classic discussion of historical fiction, see George Lukacks's study *The Historical Novel*, written in the 1930s and first published in 1955. For a recent discussion of nineteenth-century historical fiction, see Harry Shaw, *The Forms of Historical Fiction: Sir Walter Scott and His Successors* (Ithaca, NY, 2018).
- 1029 Darko Suvin, *Metamorphoses of Science Fiction: On the Poetics and History of a Literary Genre* (New Haven, 1979), pp. 7–8. While alternate history often overlaps with tales of science fiction and fantasy, in this study I exclude narratives that feature extreme celestial events, space aliens, monsters, magic, witchcraft, golems, wizards, dragons, and other supernatural phenomena. For example, I do not discuss such novels as Harry Turtledove's *World War* series (1994–2004), which features lizard-like space aliens invading planet Earth. In this study, I also largely avoid discussing young adult or juvenile fiction.
- 1030 The genre of secret history dates back to Procopius's *Secret History* (ca. 550 CE) and found its abundant early modern expression between the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries. During this period, and ever since, secret history has been loosely associated with historical revisionism, gossip, slander, and conspiracy mongering. Secret histories have also been seen as transitional texts that paved the way for the modern novel. Brian Cowan, "The History of Secret Histories," *Huntington Library Quarterly*, Volume 81, Number 1, Spring 2018, p. 133.
- 1031 *Perceforest: The Prehistory of Arthur's Britain* (Cambridge, 2011). Friedrich Wolfzettel, "Fictional History as Ideology: Functions of the Grail Legend from Robert de Boron to Roman de Perceforest," in Jon Whitman, ed., *Romance and Imagining Time from the Medieval to the Early Modern Period* (Cambridge, 2015), pp. 90–104.
- 1032 *Tirant lo Blanch* expressed the Christian fantasy of reversing the Ottoman Turkish conquest of Constantinople in 1453. Glyn Morgan and C. Palmer Patel, "Introduction," in Glyn Morgan and C. Palmer Patel, eds., *Sideways in Time: Critical Essays on Alternate History Fiction* (Liverpool, 2019), p. 12. Robert S. Rudder, *The White Knight: Tirant lo Blanc*, at <https://gutenberg.org/cache/epub/378/pg378.html>
- 1033 Unlike Martorell's fantasy, which expressed Catholic fears of Islam, Gott's text expressed the millenarian longings of a devout English Puritan who was deeply involved in the political upheavals of the English Civil War. See *Nova Solyma, the Ideal City*, Volume 1 (New York, 1902), p. 88 and chapter 1, *passim*. Adam Roberts, "Napoleon as Dynamite," in Morgan and Patel, eds., pp. 31–32.
- 1034 Johannes Dillinger, *Uchronie: Ungeschehene Geschichte von der Antike bis zum Steampunk* (Paderborn 2015), p. 99. On "embryonic" alternate histories, see Paul K. Alkon, *Origins of Futuristic Fiction* (Athens, GA, 2010), p 154.
- 1035 Damian Walford Davies, ed., *Counterfactual Romanticism* (Manchester, UK, 2019).
- 1036 Some scholars have argued that, over the course of the nineteenth century, the increasing success of European powers in mapping (and colonizing) the known world led the European imagination began to shift from alternate places to alternate times—from utopias to uchronias. See Dillinger, pp. 100–02. See also Darko Suvin's claim to this effect in Adam Roberts, *History of Science Fiction* (New York, 2006), p. 88.
- 1037 Gallagher, p. 49; Adam Roberts, *History of Science Fiction*, Second edition (New York, 2016), p. 143.
- 1038 The novel was originally published anonymously in 1836. It was reissued in 1841 under the title *Napoléon Apocryphe*, with the author's name listed as Louis Geoffroy. It was

- republished in 1896. Brian Stableford re-issued the book in 2016 under the title, *The Apocryphal Napoleon* (Los Angeles, 2016).
- 1039 Geoffroy-Château, p. 39.
- 1040 Ibid., p. 317.
- 1041 Ibid., p. 422.
- 1042 Dillinger, 108.
- 1043 Geoffroy-Château, pp. 282–285.
- 1044 See Brian Stableford's introduction to *The Apocryphal Napoleon*; Gallagher, p. 51.
- 1045 Geoffroy-Château, p. 10.
- 1046 Dillinger, p. 110.
- 1047 Ibid., p. 110.
- 1048 Gallagher, p. 53.
- 1049 Geoffroy-Château, pp. 319–22.
- 1050 Joseph Méry, *The Tower of Destiny and other Stories* (Encino, CA, 2012), p. 172.
- 1051 Ibid., p. 174.
- 1052 Ibid., p. 222.
- 1053 Ibid., p. 227.
- 1054 Ibid., p. 229.
- 1055 Ibid., p. 167.
- 1056 Gallagher, pp. 58–59.
- 1057 Ibid., pp. 60–61.
- 1058 Alkon, p. 130. Ben Carver, *Alternate Histories and Nineteenth-Century Literature: Untimely Meditations in Britain, France, and America* (London, 2017), pp. 81–83.
- 1059 Gallagher, p. 322, note 1. The journal was *La Revue philosophique et religieuse*. The original title was *Uchronie: Tableau historique apocryphe des revolutions de l'empire romain de de la foundation d'une fédération européenne*. Carver, p. 81.
- 1060 J. Alexander Gunn, *Modern French Philosophy: A Study of the Development since Comte* (London, 1922), pp. 188–93. Renouvier also rejected Comte's positivism as undemocratic and authoritarian. Warren Schmaus, *Liberty and the Pursuit of Knowledge: Charles Renouvier's Political Philosophy of Science* (Pittsburgh, 2018), pp. 5–6.
- 1061 Charles Renouvier, *Uchronie (l'Utopie dans l'histoire)* (Paris, 1876), p. v.
- 1062 Ibid., p. xiii.
- 1063 Ibid., p. xii.
- 1064 Ibid., pp. xiii–iv.
- 1065 Pietro Terzi, "Contingency, Freedom, and Uchronic Narratives: Charles Renouvier's Analytical Philosophy of History in Context," *Journal of the History of Ideas*, November 2019, pp. 257–278. Renouvier had to withdraw from political life after Louis Napoleon's coup of 1851 and only returned to Paris after the latter's fall in 1871. Carver, p. 81.
- 1066 Review of *Uchronia* in *Le Courrier Littéraire* Nr. 1, 1876, p. 282; Review of *Uchronia* in *Musée Universel*, 1876, p. 144; Félix Pécaut, "Une Hypothèse de Philosophie de l'histoire," *Les Temps*, August 25, 1878, p. 3.
- 1067 Robert Flint, *History of the Philosophy of History* (Edinburgh, 1893), p. 669. Emil Reich, "The Eightieth Anniversary of Theodor Mommsen," *Literature*, Volume 1, 1897, p. 213. "Review of *Uchronia* in the *Pall Mall Gazette*, November 28, 1876, pp. 11–12.
- 1068 "Zufall, Gesetzmässigkeit und Zweckmässigkeit," *Die feierliche Sitzung 1911: Vortrag des wirl. Mitgl. Jodl*, in *Almanach der kaiserlichen Akademie der Wissenschaften* (Vienna, 1911), p. 477.

- 1069 P. Gérin, Review of *Uchronie, Le Bien public*, August 24, 1876, p. 4; M. D. Nolen, "Les Récentes Théories en Morale," *La Revue politique et littéraire*, April 12, 1879, p. 13.
- 1070 Avrom Fleishman, *The English Historical Novel: Walter Scott to Virginia Woolf* (Baltimore, 1971). Anne Stephens, *British Historical Fiction Before Scott* (New York, 2010).
- 1071 Lee's *The Recess (Or, a Tale of Other Times)* portrayed the history of two "unknown" twin daughters of Mary Queen of Scots, Matilda and Ellinor. Paul Gordon, *The Practice of Quixotism: Postmodern Theory and Eighteenth-Century Women's Writing* (New York, 2006), chapter 5. Other examples of secret history include Sir Walter Scott's 1824 novel *Redgauntlet*, which depicted plans for another Jacobite rising in 1765, again featuring the Stuart pretender to the throne, Charles III (Bonnie Prince Charlie), which never ends up taking place. Elizabeth Moline Cuddy, *The Counterfactual History Novel in Nineteenth Century British Literature* (Ph.D. dissertation, Purdue University, 2015), pp. 17–18. Benjamin Disraeli's 1833 novel *The Wondrous Tale of Alroy* can also be seen as a secret history, insofar as the main character, the twelfth-century Jewish adventurer Alroy, does not seem to shift the course of history in any real way after initially conquering, and later losing, the city of Baghdad. See Ben Carver, chapter 3.
- 1072 Non-Anglophone poets also incorporated counterfactuals in their lyric verse. In Germany, Heinrich Heine's satirical poem, "Germany, A Winter's Tale" (1844) featured 16 stanzas exploring how German history would have been different if the forces of Hermann (Arminius) had not won the Battle of the Teutoberg Forest against Roman forces in the year 9 C. E. Among other things, Heine writes, "Had Hermann not won the battle ... we'd bow to Roman lords."
- 1073 Alfred Lord Tennyson, *In Memoriam A. H. H.* (New York, 1900), p. 75.
- 1074 *The Poetical Works of John Greenleaf Whittier, Volume 2* (Boston, 1873), p. 86.
- 1075 Dante Gabriel Rossetti, *The House of Life: A Sonnet Sequence* (Portland, ME, 1903), p. 100; *The Works of William Ernest Henley: Essays* (London, 1921), p. 136. See also Irish poet S. R. Lysaght's 1901 poem "The Unexplored," which evoked "Tidings of the might-have-been." John Cooke, *The Dublin Book of Irish Verse 1728–1909* (Dublin, 1909), p. 660.
- 1076 Mary Wyatt Candler, *Poems* (London, 1877), p. 23; Ellice Hopkins, *Autumn Swallows: A Book of Lyrics* (London, 1883), p. 71.
- 1077 Charles Dickens, *The Personal History of David Copperfield, Volume 2* (Boston, 1894), p. 267.
- 1078 Thomas Hardy, *A Pair of Blue Eyes* (Oxford, UK, 2005), p. 272.
- 1079 Eliza Tabor Stevenson, *St. Olave's* (New York, 1870), p. 120.
- 1080 James Payn, *Not Wooed, But Won* (Leipzig, 1871), p. 79.
- 1081 Valerie Purton, *Dickens and the Sentimental Tradition: Fielding, Richardson, Sterne, Goldsmith, Sheridan, Lamb* (London, 2012).
- 1082 Michael C. Cohen, "Whittier, Holmes, Lowell, and the New England Tradition," in Alfred Bendixen, ed., *The Cambridge History of American Poetry: Part II—A New Nation: Poetry from 1800 to 1900* (Cambridge, UK, 2014), pp. 259–281.
- 1083 Andrew Miller sees literary might-have-beens as a byproduct of nineteenth-century realist fiction, writing that just as "realism ... give[s] us stories about how things really were, a space naturally opens up within that mode to tell us how things might have been." Andrew Miller, "Lives Unlived in Realist Fiction," *Representations*, Spring 2007, p. 122.
- 1084 Hilary Dannenberg, *Coincidence and Counterfactuality: Plotting Time and Space in Narrative Fiction* (Lincoln, NE, 2008), pp. 4, 196.
- 1085 Joseph Hatton, "Chiefly About the Past," *The Rose, the Shamrock, and the Thistle*, November 1862, p. 34.

- 1086 Ailenroc, *Musings of a Middle-Aged Woman* (Philadelphia, 1872), pp. 71, 65.
- 1087 Mark Twain, "My Boyhood Dreams," *McClure's Magazine*, Jan 1900, Nr. 3, p. 286.
- 1088 W. P., "Might-Have-Beens," *Glasgow Herald*, June 13, 1914.
- 1089 One exception to this trend was the publication of a short story in the year 1900 by the Austrian-Jewish lawyer, writer, and Zionist luminary, Theodor Herzl, entitled "Bonaparte the Entrepreneur." For an English translation: <https://zeek.forward.com/articles/116672/>
- 1090 The story is narrated by a British war veteran looking back on the novella's key military events 50 years later.
- 1091 Edmund Lawrence, *It May Happen Yet: A Tale of Bonaparte's Invasion of England* (London, 1899), pp. 82–83; Gallagher, p. 89. Lawrence presented the events of Napoleon's invasion as having "passed away" from memory and become veiled in a "conspiracy of silence," apart from rumors and unreliable printed sources. Lawrence, pp. 82–83.
- 1092 Chamberlain, "Afterword," pp. 284–85.
- 1093 Castello Holford, *Aristopia: A Romance History of the New World* (Boston, 1895), p. 3.
- 1094 *The Westminster Gazette*, May 25, 1907, pp. 6–7. The contest's terms asked all competitors to imagine the "probable history" of the post-Waterloo world up until the year 1837.
- 1095 Suvin, "Victorian Science Fiction."
- 1096 A. Michael Matin, "Scrutinizing the 'Battle of Dorking,'" *Victorian Literature and Culture*, No. 2 (2011), pp. 385–407.
- 1097 George Tomkyns Chesney, *The Battle of Dorking: Reminiscences of a Volunteer* (Edinburgh, 1871), pp. 3–4.
- 1098 Chesney, p. 64.
- 1099 Lawrence, pp. 153, 241.
- 1100 Evans, *Altered Pasts*, pp. 8–9; John Vincent, "G. M. Trevelyan's Two Terrible Things," *London Review of Books*, June 1980.
- 1101 Lincoln Geraghty, *American Science Fiction Film and Television* (New York, 2009, p. 4; Edward James and Farah Mendlesohn, *The Cambridge Companion to Science Fiction* (Cambridge, UK, 2003). In surveying American texts, I have excluded Mark Twain's famous novel *A Connecticut Yankee in King Arthur's Court* (1889). Given that its plot is not set in real history (Camelot being mythical) and does not alter the course of history in any appreciable way, it is better regarded as a "secret history." That said, the novel resembled the era's alternate histories in reflecting the influence social reform movements. Twain was a social reformer and his novel expressed discontent with present-day American life by having a time traveler to Arthurian England modernize the country so as to dampen its courtly culture and prevent its later transmission to the colonial United States. Carver, p. 211.
- 1102 Edward Everett Hale, "Hands Off," *Harper's New Monthly Magazine*, 1881, pp. 582–588. Nathaniel Hawthorne's short story, "P's Correspondence" (1845) has sometimes been seen as an earlier alternate history. But while the story depicts the protagonist "P" discussing the alternate lives of historical figures, such as Napoleon Bonaparte (whom P "meets" in London, a shadow of his former self) and Lord Byron, it does not really depict any major alteration to the course of history. Moreover, since "P" tells of his "encounters" with historical figures without leaving his room, we are left to assume that his story is a reflection of a mental illness or what Hawthorne calls "disordered reason." See the text at Project Gutenberg, <https://www.gutenberg.org/files/9230/9230-h/9230-h.htm>
- 1103 Hale, "Hands Off," p. 588.
- 1104 *Ibid.*, p. 588. In the introduction to the volume in which "Hands Off" later appeared, Hale hoped that clergymen would discuss the tale's core "theological doctrine"—namely, the

- need to trust in God's providence. Edward Everett Hale, *The Works of Edward Everett Hale: In His Name, and Christmas Stories* (Boston, 1899). *Ibid.*, p. ix. Hale's conclusion also echoed that presented by the Church Father, Origen. See *Predicting the Past*, Volume 1, pp. 103–104.
- 1105 Annette Condello, *The Architecture of Luxury* (New York, 2014), pp. 117–120. C. Roland Marchand, *The American Peace Movement and Social Reform, 1889–1918* (Princeton, 2015), p. 36. Jean Holloway, *Edward Everett Hale: A Biography* (Austin, TX, 1956), pp. 215, 219–200.
- 1106 Edward Page Mitchell, “The Clock that Ran Backward,” in Peter Haining, *Time Travelers: Fiction in the Fourth Dimension* (New York, 1997), pp. 111–123.
- 1107 Mitchell, p. 116.
- 1108 *Ibid.*, p. 117.
- 1109 *Ibid.*, pp. 121, 123.
- 1110 *Ibid.*, p. 123.
- 1111 *Ibid.*, p. 123.
- 1112 Mitchell preceded H. G. Wells in imagining the concepts of time travel, teleportation, and invisibility. See the introduction to *Sci-Fi and Fantasy Stories From ‘The Sun’ Illustrated* (2020) and https://sf-encyclopedia.com/entry/mitchell_edward_page
- 1113 *Ibid.*, p. 118.
- 1114 Edward Page Mitchell, *Memoirs of an Editor* (New York, 1924), pp. 76–77.
- 1115 Castello Holford, *Aristopia: A Romance History of the New World* (Boston, 1895).
- 1116 *Ibid.*, pp. 69, 81, 86.
- 1117 *Ibid.*, p. 234.
- 1118 *Ibid.*, pp. 5–6. See the obituary in the *Grant County Herald* (Lancaster, WI), June 7, 1905, p. 1.
- 1119 *Ibid.*, p. 7.
- 1120 Frank Purdy Williams, *Hallie Marshall: A True Daughter of the South* (New York, 1900).
- 1121 *Ibid.*, pp. 25–26.
- 1122 *Ibid.*, p. 101.
- 1123 *Ibid.*, p. 102.
- 1124 *Ibid.*, p. 103.
- 1125 *Ibid.*, p. 183.
- 1126 Gallagher calls the novel “blatantly racist” but overlooks its social criticism. Gallagher, p. 95.
- 1127 Renee de Groot, “What If the Pen Was Mightier Than the Sword? Civil War Alternate History as Social Criticism,” *Aspeers*, Nr. 10 (2017), pp. 55–67.
- 1128 Williams, pp. 140–41.
- 1129 Charles Felton Pidgin, *The Climax: Or, What Might Have Been* (New York, 1902).
- 1130 *Ibid.*, pp. 97–98.
- 1131 *Ibid.*, pp. 97, 137.
- 1132 Pidgin wrote two novels about Burr, including *Blennerhasset, Or the Decrees of Fate* (1901) and *Little Burr* (1905). He also wrote a novel about Burr's daughter, entitled *Theodosia* (1907). After 1902, he led the Aaron Burr Legion.
- 1133 Pidgin, *The Climax*, n.p.
- 1134 Pidgin's 1902 novel, *Stephen Holton*, explicitly attacked “liquor saloons.” See Charles Felton Pidgin, *Stephen Holton* (Boston, 1902), p. ix.
- 1135 Joseph Edgar Chamberlin, *The Ifs of History* (New York, 1907). Chamberlin's volume was the first anthology of alternate histories ever published.
- 1136 *Ibid.*, p. 29.

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Chapter 7

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Chapter 8

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